She Ra: After The End (Final Draft)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33561388.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Epic, Post-Canon, Drama, Drama & Romance, Fluff and Angst, Angst, Angst and Feels, Humor, Action/Adventure, Action, Sequel, Science Fiction & Fantasy, Minor Character Death, Minor Original Character(s), Original Character(s), Canon-Typical Violence, Violence, Friends to Lovers, Enemies to Lovers, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow Is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak is Named Kadroh (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Characters from the original MotU Canon, POV Multiple

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of She Ra, Part 2

Stats:
Published: 2021-08-29 Completed: 2022-02-13 Words: 199,122 Chapters: 54/54

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She Ra: After The End (Final Draft)

by BesottedShoe

Summary

The Horde is gone. Prime has been destroyed. Etheria is finally free and at peace. But this is just the beginning of a new journey for Catra and Adora. Redemption is a long journey that Catra must walk, and new threats lurk in the shadows. Can they find peace despite the darkness still waiting in their past? Their mission to bring magic back to the universe seems impossible with so much left to do at home.

- Inspired by She-Ra: After the End (First Draft) by BesottedShoe

Introduction

Hello! I have too much to say in this introduction to put it in the notes, so instead I'm making this first chapter the introduction.

This is a reupload and edit of a previous fic with the same title I published last year.

Each chapter has some form of editing done. Some are simple grammatical improvements, others feature entirely new scenes or plotlines. I've even written two entirely new chapters.

The Biggest change is going to be in format. Each "Episode" has been broken up into 2-5 chapters, to avoid the problem my previous upload had, which was overly long chapters (The longest single upload was 16000 words, which is quite simply too long to upload as a single chapter on AO3). By breaking each chapter up, I hope to maintain the feeling of each one as a single episode of the show, while also making it more reader-friendly.

A few content notes:
- I tried to hew as close to the show as possible, but this fic is fairly serious. There is a lot of discussion and exploration of the character's psychological states and issues, and a hefty amount of angst. There are not going to be quick fixes to any of the character's internal problems. Catra isn't immediately happy and free of any psychological issues just because she's with Adora now. She still has a lot of work to do and a lot to go through.
- Catra is the definitive protagonist, but Adora, Glimmer, and Bow are still main characters in their own rights.
- There is violence in this fic. Action scenes are frequent, and characters do get injured. Injuries are not described graphically, and blood is not mentioned too frequently. It's still not graphic, but it's a more intense level of fantasy violence than we see in the show.
- This fic does not contain smut, though there is some light innuendo. I want it to be accessible to all readers, and I think that there are plenty of other authors who could do smut better than

me.
- While the main characters of the show are still the main characters, there are also several side characters promoted to the main cast, as well as original characters and characters adapted from the original She Ra/He Man universe.
- Overall I would say the tonal difference between this fic and the show is similar to that between Legend of Korra and Avatar The Last Airbender.

A Note on Formatting: I'll likely only include chapter notes at the beginning and end of each "Arc"

In terms of story, Season 1a is essentially Catra's Forgiveness Tour, acting as something of a mirror to the first half of the show's Season 1. Chapter 8 begins a new, plot heavy and antagonist driven arc.

Season 1a Chapter List:

1: The Shadow Cast Out - In the aftermath of Prime's defeat, Catra makes an unexpected friend in the Whispering Woods.
1: The Moments After
2: Catra's Run
3: In The Sunlight

2: The Head That Wears The Crown - The Best Friend Squad returns to Bright Moon, but Glimmer has a hard time assuming the mantle of Queen, and Catra makes a horrifying discovery.
1: Return to Bright Moon
2: Unpleasant Recollections
3: New Normal

3: Rose and Thorn - A trip to Plumeria has the Best Friend Squad working through their issues, and helping some friends to bond.
1: A Morning in Plumeria
2: Meditations and Conversations
3: Perfuma and Scorpia

4: Return to Salineas - Mermista does not take Catra's presence in Salineas very well. Catra discovers how much hard work is needed for true redemption.
1: Rage of the Sea
2: Walls
3: The Longest Road

5: Shadow Weaver - Adora and Catra work through the loss of Shadow Weaver with the help of Micah and Castaspella, her previous generation of protégés.
1: Journey to Mystacor
2: Legacy
3: A Day of Relaxation
4: The Book Closes

6: Snow Rest For the Weary - The Princess Alliance gathers in the Kingdom of Snows for a much-needed day of fun, but find that their hard-won peace must still be fought for.
1: Princess Party
2: Elemental Attack

7: The Odd Couple - A new threat rises, attacking Entrapta and Hordak. Catra comes to an important step in her journey to redemption: being able to forgive someone else.
1: The Battle of Dryl
2: The Enemy Within

8: Interlude - Catra's past comes back to haunt her in a horrifying and unexpected way.

My intended upload schedule is going to be 3 chapters (aka, most episodes) uploaded per week, on Monday, Wednesday, and Friday. This should be consistent, as I have the chapters prewritten this time, but as all things are, it may be subject to change. For example, I may choose to make it exactly 1 episode arc per week, meaning some weeks may have 3 uploads, others only 2, others up to 5. We will see.

As always, the best way to show your appreciation for this work is through comments! I love receiving comments, so if you like the work, consider telling me why, or asking questions or even giving constructive criticism! If you don't like commenting, you can also leave a kudos instead.

The Shadows Cast Out, Part 1: The Moments After

Chapter Summary

> Horde Prime is gone. Catra and Adora have confessed their love and finally begun their relationship. The Princesses talk about what needs to be done with Hordak. Scorpia is trepidatious at the prospect of ruling the Fright Zone. Catra goes on a run into the Whispering Woods and makes an unexpected friend, but her unexplained absence causes Adora some undue stress.

Chapter Notes

> This is one chapter that is relatively unchanged from the first draft save for being split into three parts.

Catra

To say that Catra had had a rough day would have been an understatement. She had tried to leave the woman she loved, nearly watched her home planet be destroyed by an extraterrestrial megalomaniac, gotten poisoned and nearly eaten by a giant worm, watched the only mother she ever had be consumed by flame (she was not going to think of what Shadow Weaver had said before that moment… not yet), and watched the love of her life slip closer and closer to death.

Of course, that had prompted her to confess her feelings to Adora, and hear the words she never thought she could.

"I love you too."

Now she's standing on a hill covered with strange, magical greenery, the air full of bobbing lights, arm in arm with her friends, looking up at a sky full of stars.

Catra decided that today started now, and it was the best day of her life.

*****

The next few hours were a blur. Most everyone was exhausted from the day before, be it magically, physically, or emotionally. Adora has been dragged in every direction by various princesses and princess-adjacents, so Catra has found a secluded overlook to sit with Melog and people-watch.

Scorpia is holding an ever growing bundle of plants, as Perfuma rushes every which way to admire the new wildlife She Ra had created. Catra smiles. She's happy for Scorpia, genuinely happy that she finally found someone who deserves her affections.

Her gaze wanders over towards the nearby Horde Spire, now covered in patchwork vegetation. She can't help but hear parts of the conversation going on at the base of it. The pirate one (Sea Hawk? She needed to ask Adora what his *actual* name is), is saying something about the new plants making the spire more flammable as he waves a torch around emphatically. *'Where did he get a torch?'* Catra hopes he wins the argument. She'd love to watch one of those spires go up in flames.

A camp is being set up at the back of the valley. Apparently Glimmer didn't have it in her to teleport everyone back to their kingdoms, so a handful of tents had been erected. Hordak was in one of them, in a magical holding cell. The Princesses were in a good mood, but they were trepidatious at the idea of letting their old arch enemy walk free based only on Entrapta being friends with him.

'Not like she's got very good taste in friends anyways.' Catra bites back the thought. It's in the past now. Hordak had been a better friend to Entrapta than Catra ever had, which was the only reason why she hadn't attacked him when she realized who the clone being dragged around was.

Besides, being stuck in a holding cell with only Entrapta and Wrong Hordak for company felt like enough punishment for the former warlord for now.

Glimmer and Bow had been sitting with Glimmer's dad for a while. They were having quite an in depth conversation.

'Catching up,' Catra thought. Glimmer's dad had been on Beast island for so many years. She pushes away the pang of guilt that comes unbidden from that thought. *'I could barely even talk back then. It's not my fault.'*

Adora was… wait, where is Adora? Catra stands up, somewhat panicked and scans the valley.

"Come on… where's that poof?" She mutters to herself.

"Catra?" Adora's voice comes suddenly from close behind her.

Catra yelps and turns around. Adora is standing behind her, with a slightly worried, mostly amused expression on her face. Catra smiles at her.

Stars, she's perfect.

"Hey, Adora. You finally free from the clutches of the princesses?" Catra drawls fondly as Adora walks up to her.

Adora gives her a light punch on the shoulder before sitting down. Catra joins her, leaning over and resting her head on Adora's shoulder. A low purr rises in her chest as Adora reaches her arm around and absently strokes her hair.

"What now?" Adora says quietly.

"Aren't we bringing magic back to the universe?"

Adora gives a small chuckle. "Eventually, but I think we have a lot to do on Etheria before we can worry about other planets."

“Well whatever you decide to do, I’ll be with you the whole way.” Catra pauses, then adds, more quietly, “I’m never going to leave you again.”

Adora looks down at her, and Catra turns up to meet her gaze. Catra blinks slowly. Adora smiles, her eyes watery, and leans down to kiss her.

Glimmer

“It’s decided then! When we get back to Bright Moon, we’ll throw a big party to celebrate the Rebellion’s victory.” Glimmer smiled. “Everyone’s invited of course, and the next day we’ll start planning rebuilding efforts.”

Scorpia raises a claw politely.

“Scorpia, you don’t have to be called on to speak” Glimmer says with a sigh

“Oh, sorry, okay. Uhh, when you say ‘rebuilding efforts’, you just mean for the real kingdoms right? We can just… not worry about the Fright Zone anymore right?” Scorpia is avoiding eye contact with the other princesses, and her tail is curled tightly to her.

Before Glimmer can speak, Entrapta cuts in, “Oh of course not!! There is so much tech hidden in every corner of the Fright Zone! We need to tear it apart panel by panel and get everything we can out of there!” At the looks from other princesses she adds, “Oh! And also you’re the Princess of Horror Hall, so we need to rebuild your kingdom too.”

Scorpia scratches the back of her head with a pincer. “Yeaaah… so about that. I know I’m a princess now and, boy that’s a lot to take in, I’m still not quite sure how to process it. Like I can make lightning! That’s not something I thought I’d be able to do, heheh. But, I mean, princesses don’t *have* to rule, right? I mean, look at Adora! She’s She Ra, and She Ra is a princess, but she doesn’t have to rule anywhere.”

Glimmer cuts off her rambling, “Scorpia. If you don’t want to take over, we can find someone else to. But I think you’re the right person for this. The Fright Zone needs to be dismantled, and I can’t think of anyone better to do the job than someone who really knows it. You know the Fright Zone and the people there better than any of us. They’ve lived their whole lives under the Horde. It’ll be best if they have a familiar face to guide them into the new world. Plus, we’ll help you every step of the way.” Glimmer looks around at the other princesses, who all nod and turn to smile at Scorpia.

Perfuma puts a gentle hand on Scorpia’s pincer, “I support you. Whatever you choose to do, I’ll be right beside you.”

Frosta summons ice fists, “Yeah! And who knows how many horde bots are still in the Fright Zone, just waiting to be punched!”

Mermista rolls her eyes at that, “I’ve got a few ideas about improving that dump, starting with the sewers.”

“Scorpia, you’ve got this. You’re strong, loyal, and kind. Etheria needs you, and the Fright Zone needs you. The people there have needed positive leadership for so long, and if anyone can give them that, it’s you.” Bow says, his voice soft, but strong.

Castaspella smiles and speaks authoritatively. “The Sorcerer’s Guild will lend their support to any efforts to rehabilitate the Fright Zone, and return it to its rightful rulers.”

Sea Hawk looks towards Scorpia, and speaks in a gentler tone than his normal bombast, “Taking up this mantle of responsibility would be a once in a lifetime adventure to cherish.”

Entrapta is on her hair now, squirming with excitement, “Ahhhhh! I’m so excited to work with you in the Fright Zone againnnnn!! I’m gonna go tell Hordak!!”

Glimmer’s heart skips a beat, “Entrapta, wait-” but the scientist is already gone. Glimmer lets out a groan before turning back to Scorpia, whose eyes are huge and watery, “The Princess Alliance

can handle anything together. We beat Horde Prime together. As long as we're together, I think this'll be a cakewalk!" She says confidently.

Scorpia sniffles, "You.. you guys.. Come here!!" She pulls Perfuma, Frosta, Sea Hawk, and Netossa into a huge hug, and everyone else closes in to join. The hug breaks apart and Scorpia shakes the tears off her face. "You're right. I need to be there for the Fright Zone. It's my home, and the Horde- whatever's left of it, those are my people. I need to be there to make it better."

There's some more affirmations that Glimmer kind of tunes out, lost in her own thoughts as she is. It's Spinnerella who finally brings up how badly everyone needs sleep, producing sounds of agreement from the gathered crowd. Bow starts to get up but Glimmer grabs his hand. He smiles gently and sits back down next to her, no explanation needed. She takes a deep breath.

"Dad?"

King Micah pauses and turns around, "What is it? What do you need?"

"I need your advice."

"Of course." Micah sits back down, facing Glimmer.

Glimmer sighs and puts her head in her hands, "I have no idea what to do about Hordak…" she groans.

Micah nods, "I think most of us are in the same boat on that.

Glimmer continues, building up steam, "I mean, I know how to start the rebuilding process, and I know what we all need to do, but he's just this blank spot in my plans. He seems like he's changed, and I know we gave Catra a second chance, and Hordak did pretty much the same thing, right? And Entrapta trusts him and adores him, and I know we need to be forgiving because we're the good guys, right? But should we forgive him?? He knew what he was doing, he tried to conquer Etheria for decades! He

wanted to bring Prime down on us, even if *I'm* the one who actually did it in the end," she barrels through Bow and Micah's immediate protests, "and Prime was a much bigger threat than Hordak ever was, and we lost so much fighting him, but we lost so much more from fighting against Hordak, right? We lost…" she knows she doesn't need to say it. *'We lost my mom'*. She sees Micah's saddened eyes at the thought. "I mean, the war against Prime only lasted a few months. We were fighting Hordak for decades! How can we just let him live however he wants to after all of that!?" She's breathing heavily, and she feels tears streaming down her face. Her voice was breaking, and she lets herself crumble into Bow's waiting arms and cry.

After what seems like an eternity, Bow speaks, "We can't let him not face any consequences for his actions." Glimmer looks up at him, surprised by the dark edge in his voice.

Micah nods, and his next words are tinged with the utter exhaustion everyone feels. She Ra's magic may have given a new energy, but they had still been fighting for weeks without any real pause. "Well," he says, "I don't think we should worry too much about it now. We're all tired. For now I say we just let him be with Entrapta until we can figure out what to do on a more permanent basis."

"That's it!" Bow exclaims, jolting upright so excitedly that Glimmer nearly rolls to the floor. Looking at his face, there's a twinkle in his eye. "If he's going to be free, he needs to actively atone for his crimes somehow. Glimmer, you were saying we can't just let him live however he wants, but maybe the solution *is* to let him live how he wants."

"WHAT!?" Glimmer shoots up. Bow is smiling now. *Smiling!*

"We let him live exactly how he wants."

Micah catches on, and clarifies, "We let him be beside Entrapta."

Glimmer looks between the two of them, realizing what they're getting at. A smile crosses her face.

Hordak

"And with Scorpia in charge I'm sure you'll be able to come with me and help salvage all the tech we can. We can make all of Etheria as advanced as the Fright Zone, or more! I haven't even gotten the chance to factor in how all this new magic will improve our technology! Just think of the possibilities!" Entrapta has been talking his ear off about the reconstruction of the Fright Zone. Hordak smiles fondly. How glad he is to have his Entrapta back. Many of his memories are foggy, but somehow she survived the mind wipes. When his emotions and his memories were taken from him, Entrapta remained. As she speaks, more memories come flooding back. Scorpia… the last remnant of the Scorpion Kingdom. A Force Captain, a princess. Glimmer, the current Queen, leader of the Princess Alliance. Leader of his enemies. Horror Hall, his first conquest, his first allies. The Fright Zone: his stronghold, his sanctum, his empire, his home. His sanctum, his lab… salvaging the remains… the ruins… what was left of his lab after…

"*Catra.*" He growls, cutting off Entrapta's babbling.

"Oh, I'm sure Catra and Adora would love to help tear that place apart too, and Catra probably knows more about its infrastructure than Scorpia or even you!" Entrapta responds offhand, only to look more closely at Hordak's face, the tears pricking at the corner of his green eyes, the clench of his jaw. "Oh. You… don't want to see Catra? Something… happened, between you."

Hordak looks away. He wipes away his tears and growled. "Catra lied to me. She manipulated me. She… she took you away and made me think…" He stops. Catra had made him think Entrapta betrayed him. Catra had sent Entrapta to die on Beast Island.

"Ohhhhh, is this about her betraying me and exiling me to Beast Island?" She pauses, and her tone drops. The next part comes out

muffled, and Hordak looks up to see her mask has dropped down. "Is that why you didn't come for me? She told you something else had happened to me… she knew that if you knew where I was, you'd… come for me?" The last part sounded hopeful, and a Hordak feels a pang of… guilt? at not being able to answer directly.

Hordak reaches out for her, but stops himself before hitting the magical wall. He clenches his fist. "Catra… told me that you had betrayed us. That your… friendship was a ruse." He's speaking through clenched teeth as the painful memories flood back in.

"Oh." She responds, her voice small. "I don't think I betrayed you, and the data suggests that our friendship was real." Hordak looks up and sees that she's on her tracker pad. She turns it towards him, showing a series of charts and graphs. A clump of hair lifts the mask off her face. "See? It shows our interactions and the increased positive outcomes of them over time! I don't think they would have continued to be so positive if our friendship wasn't real. At least I think. I'm not very good at friendships, but it seems like they're supposed to produce positive results." A strand of hair points to one of the graphs, "Look! This one shows how much being friends with you increased my happiness meter!"

Hordak is stunned. "My… friendship?" He chokes out. He knew how much Entrapta meant to him, but he had never dared to believe that he meant the same to her. How could he? A defect, a conquerer, a monster…

"Hey, Hordak"

He hisses, and turns towards the entrance to the tent, panicked. Entrapta turns, too, and her hair waves at the two figures standing there. "Hi Catra! Hi Adora!"

Adora smiles at Entrapta, but Catra is focused on Hordak. He can't read the series of emotions playing across her face, but her ears are back and her tail is stiff, showing a tension that belies her slinking movements and relaxed body language.

“Wow Hordak, they’ve really given you the deluxe package.” She drawls as she walks forward, running her claws along the magical wall. “You’ve got pillows and everything.” She stops and leans in. She’d be nose to nose with him were it not for the cell. “You thought you were the good guy Hordak. And you treated your closest allies worse than the princesses treat their *prisoners*” The final word gives way to true venom and injury that runs into his former second-in-command’s core.

Adora speaks, cutting off Hordak’s response, “Catra. This isn’t why we came.” Her voice is stern, but still soft.

Catra’s face slides back to a mocking smirk. “Awww, but I’m having so much fun with this.” The feline looks at the blonde, but her bravado falters and her face flushes. She backs away from the cage. “Fine. Go ahead.”

“Hordak.” His attention turns to her. The child he found from the portal. The object of Shadow Weaver’s machinations. The thorn in his side that grew more and more painful. The woman who saved him.

She Ra.

“Yes, Force Captain?” He says, without thinking. She winces at the title.

“My name is Adora. I want you to tell me right now. Is there any chance that Prime is still alive?” Her voice is firm and powerful. Her eyes hold no hatred or anger, and yet Hordak can feel the power within. Power to topple Horde Prime.

Hordak contemplates her question. He looks at Catra, who is now avoiding his gaze, her hand on her side of her neck.

She screamed when she realized where they were taking her. She fought and spat and cursed. She wanted to die, she didn’t want this. She struggled as she was forced into the pool. Hordak had been selected to hold her in. He wondered if it was a choice designed to hurt her, or him.

He finally responds. “Prime’s consciousness was as much a physical thing as a technological thing. His servers were his mind. You destroyed Prime, beyond any doubt. The fall of the Hive Mind proves that. His influence, however… that will be resilient. If you want to know if Prime is truly gone, you would have to find out if his servers are still functioning.”

Entrapta gasps, “Of course! That’s why the server on his flagship was so hard to hack! The server didn’t just replicate a mind, it WAS a mind! Oh he must have flash cloned his consciousness into the computer! That is sooo smart…”

Adora scoffs, but her expression is transparently worried. “Well I doubt much of anything is still functioning on his ship. I kinda, you know…” she pantomimes holding aloft her sword. “Psheeeeewww… turned it into a tree, heheh”

Hordak raises an eyebrow. “I’m aware. You would have to find a hub on one of his vassal worlds.” *‘Curious. Even when she wields all the power in the world, she is still so bizarrely human.’*

Entrapta cuts in, “And besides, we have no way of knowing how much tech is still intact aboard Prime’s flagship. We don’t even know if your magic affected the inside of it at all! We have to take a trip up there to find out!”

“WHAT!?” Catra screeches, her hackles raised and her claws out. “We are NOT going back there!”

Adora puts a hand on Catra. The feline flinches, but leans into the touch. “No one would make you go back there Catra.”

Hordak attempts to empathize with the cat. “You have… painful memories of the *Velvet Glove*. It would be… foolish for you to go back there.”

Catra hisses at him. “What do you know about it!?” Her glare softens slightly upon seeing his expression.

“I know more than most.” He says softly.

Catra backs away, then runs out of the tent.

“Catra!” Adora is after her in a flash.

There’s a pause before Entrapta turns back to Hordak, “I’m going to go to sleep now, I’m very tired from today.” Her voice is somewhat monotone, like she is having to remind herself of something she’d much rather ignore.

Hordak nods. “Today has been trying. Rest.” His tone is somewhat authoritative, and he winces. Entrapta smiles and waves at him.

“Goodnight, Hordak!”

“Um… good… night, Entrapta.” He turns away as she wanders out of the tent, sitting in the air and typing on her tracker pad as her hair walks for her. Hordak closes his eyes, and attempts to reach for the hivemind, not for the first time, and certainly not the last. He doesn’t know if the absence he feels is comforting, or terrifying.

The Shadows Cast Out, Part 2: Catra's Run

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra goes for a morning run that gets a little emotional, and Adora wonders what their new relationship means.

Catra

The sound of birds singing woke Catra up. Giving a squeaky yawn and a full body stretch, she sits up, and looked at the mess of frazzled blonde hair beside her. She reaches out and strokes the hair aside to brush a hand across Adora's cheek, eliciting a cute little snore, and a hand reaching up to scratch. Catra giggles, and breathes a sigh of relief.

Good. It wasn't some dream or illusion. She's real. We're *real. We won.*

Looking around the rest of the tent, she smiles at the sight of Bow and Glimmer cuddled up even closer than she and Adora. Melog stirs at the bottom of the bed, their mane a contented blue, as they look at Catra and emit an echoing 'mrow?'

Catra leans down and scratches their head gently before standing up. As quietly as possible, she squirms into her outfit, and stealthily exits the tent. Looking around outside, her suspicions were confirmed. It isn't quite sunrise yet, the stars are still out. Melog trots up beside her, their mane still blue, but frizzled out with potential energy.

They're right. Catra needs to run.

The camp is out of sight within minutes. She laughed as soon as she was out of earshot, loping across loamy terrain and soft grass, leaping across rocks and clambering over ridges. It has been so

long since she had run like this. Not running away from anything, just running, letting it all out.

Catra feels a yell swelling in her chest, and lets out a joyous "WHOOOO HOOOOOO!!!!"

She's free, finally *free!* Free from Prime, free from the Horde, free from the looming cloud of her feelings for Adora…

Free from Shadow Weaver.

Her foot slams into a root, and she goes sprawling, rolling across the grass and coming to rest at the base of a tree. Tears begin to prick at her eyes. She barely hears Melog's concerned queries.

The memory of Shadow Weaver creeps in on her mind like the old witch's magic.

You're gone! I'm happy! You can't take any more from me!!

"I'm so proud of you, Catra." The words ring in her skull. Catra clutches her temples.

"Get out of my head!" She sobs

"She distracts you." Shadow Weaver talking to Adora, Adora *listening*!

"No… Adora wants me. Adora wants me!" Catra's claws are digging into her arms, desperately trying to claw her way back to reality. But all she can see is a scarred face, a plume of flame, a shattered mask in an empty room.

"What are you doing? Running away? That's all you're good at!" The voice spits out, angry now.

"I'm not!"

"You are. You know you're not worthy of Adora. You know that you'll always end up here, alone… You know that you can't wipe

away who you are. You can't make them forget, any more than you can forget." Shadow Weaver is taunting her. The voice is getting closer, getting more real. Catra's head is swimming. She sees the ground beneath her, she sees shadows moving, encroaching on her. A singular shape approaching,

"Adora? Is that you?" Shadow Weaver's voice, but another one too, layered faintly under it. Catra doesn't dare look up. "Why are you on the ground silly?" Shadow Weaver's voice is far away now, a new one has taken its place, high and scratchy, with a strange accent.

Catra slowly looks up, only to find another face inches away from her own.

"Ah!" She squawks and tumbles backward, scrambling away. Melog leaps in front of her, their mane turning red as they growl.

"Oh hush Swift Wind! Adora has something important to do!" Melog's growl turns into a confused trill as they are batted aside by a broom.

Holding the broom is a strange looking woman. Somewhat pink tinted skin, eyes covered by gigantic thick glasses, a long, angular nose and small mouth. Her hair is a gigantic poof, nearly the size of her body, which is covered in layers of thick, tattered pink cloth. A swarm of small insects hover around her. She approaches Catra without hesitation and points the broom at her.

"Waaaaait… you're not Adora! Mara? No, that's not right. This isn't how the first time goes." She reaches a thin hand up and scratches her head.

"Who are you?" Catra says, the fear gone, replaced by confusion and curiosity.

"Oh! Catra, of course! You and Swift Wind need to come along. We've got ingredients to gather!" The old woman begins to shuffle away, towards the woods.

The Whispering Woods? How far did I run? I'm not even tired.

"Wait!!" Catra gets up and rushes after the shockingly speedy old woman.

"Come on dearie! Just follow Madame Razz's voice!"

With Melog on her tail, Catra rushes into the Whispering Woods.

Adora

The panic started when she woke up without feeling Catra's warmth beside her. Aside from being out of character for the feline to wake up early, Adora's paranoia quickly ran rampant. The fact that no one else in camp had seen her leave had sent Adora into a full on spiral. Bow and Glimmer had managed to talk her down from becoming She Ra and tearing across the countryside, so instead she has several maps of the area in front of her, with potential routes Catra could have taken marked out.

She marks one of the routes off and turns to the assembled people before her: Glimmer and Bow, obviously, Swift Wind, for his eyes in the sky, Entrapta, who had just wandered in, and Scorpia, who had been roused by the concern for Catra.

"Glimmer, could you ask Micah or Castaspella if they have any sort of tracking spell?" Adora asks, trying not to sound too stern or authoritative, not wanting to overstep with Glimmer.

Glimmer sighs and teleports out without answering.

"She's going." Bow assures her. "She doesn't like being up this early."

"Its not even early!" Adora says defensively, and is met with various sounds of disagreement from the gathered people.

Scorpia jumps in, "Oh! I bet Catra probably went somewhere high! Back in the Fright Zone she had this platform overlook that she always went to when she was sad or upset or lonely or

whenever I overwhelmed her. She was up there a lot actually! Boy was it hard for me to climb with these pincers!" She lets out a laugh.

'Of course I know that Scorpia! I showed her the platform! I dared her to climb it the first time. It's our *spot!'* Adora silently curses herself for being so harsh on Scorpia in her mind.

Swift Wind responds, "Yeah but the only place that's high up around here is the spire, and she definitely didn't climb that."

Glimmer teleports back in, Castaspella beside her.

Castaspella immediately rushes up and hugs Adora. "Ah! Adora. Glimmer told me what happened, and I'm so sorry I can't help more. I know a scrying spell but I don't have the components with me." She pulls away, her hands on Adora's shoulders. "Are you doing okay?"

Adora gives a strained smile, and even she knows how much it must show the stress she's feeling. "I'm fine. Thank you."

Casta raises an eyebrow and turns to the table, resting a hand on her chin contemplatively. "Why would Catra leave? She wouldn't have been kidnapped, so she must have left on her own. Do you think she needed to be alone to process what happened to Shadow Weaver? Or maybe she needs time to think about being with you now?"

There's a silence in the room for a moment. Bow was frantically trying to get Castaspella to stop as soon as she said "Shadow Weaver", Glimmer is deep in a facepalm, and Adora simply reels for a moment. Castaspella was right. Catra has probably needed some space to process everything that had happened. Glimmer's aunt may be blunt to a fault, but she was definitely right.

Before she can respond, a tall white figure bursts into the tent.

"Wonderful news brothers!" Wrong Hordak exclaims, his arms spread and his face split in a wide grin. "I have spoken to my

newly freed clone brothers, and one of them told me he saw Brother Catra and Brother Melog running away from the camp an hour before dawn!"

Adora immediately turns to the table, leaning over it and staring at the clone, "Running away? Why?? Where did they go? How fast were they going!?"

Wrong Hordak grabs a pencil off the table. "I will attempt to draw an arrow pointing where he said they ran." On the word 'arrow', he directs a wink at Bow, who looks confused. The clone leans over the table, and draws a straight line going somewhat Southwest from their camp.

"GASP! That goes towards the Whispering Woods." Swift Wind interjects.

"There's no way she could have gotten that far, right?" Glimmer says.

Adora, however, has gotten all she needs. "She's there. Glimmer?"

Glimmer sighs. "Ugh! If this becomes an everyday occurance I'm going to put a cell around her room!"

"Good luck! Be safe in the woods!" Castaspella says as Glimmer, Bow, Swift Wind, Adora, and Scorpia disappear in a shower of sparkles.

They reappear at the edge of the Whispering Woods, and Adora is already rushing forward the moment they arrive. She's vaguely cognizant of Glimmer calling her name exasperatedly behind her, but she's too focused, scanning every inch of terrain she can see for signs Catra had come through. She summons her sword without transforming, and begins slashing through a wall of vines ahead of her.

"She needs to think about being with you now." Why? What if she changes her mind? What if she doesn't want to be with me? I need to be there. I can't let her leave again.

“Adora!!” A hand grabs her wrist, and she turns around. Her friends are arrayed behind her, worry etched on their faces. Bow is holding her and speaking softly. “Adora. We need to work together. Running ahead and tearing through the woods isn’t going to find Catra faster.”

Adora realizes that tears are falling down her cheeks, and her breathing is ragged. She’s dimly aware that she can’t see the edge of the woods anymore. But it doesn’t matter.

“Why would she run away..?” She asks, her voice breaking. “I thought it would be different now! I thought this wouldn’t happen anymore! We’re together now! We have to stay together...” Bow pulls her into a hug, and Glimmer joins.

“We’ll ask her why when we find her.” Glimmer assures her. “For now, let's fan out and look. Keep in eyesight of each other, and Swift Wind will be in the skies. I’ll teleport ahead and shout for her. Let’s go!”

Adora gives her friends a squeeze, “Thank you.” She says, burying her face in Bow’s shoulder.

“Hey.” Bow pulls away, his hands on Adora’s shoulders, “We’ve got this. Catra’s part of the Best Friend Squad. We’re not gonna let her just disappear. Wherever she is, we’ll find her.”

He turns and pulls out his tracker pad. “Once I get close enough, this *might* be able to pick up her life signs.”

Glimmer giggles, “Might?”

Bow turns defensively, “What? The Whispering Woods messes with my tech! And I never got the chance to fine tune this individual tracking device.”

Adora smiles proudly. “I’m sure it’ll work, Bow. You made it.” Bow blushes and turns around. Adora turns stern again. “Alright everyone! Fan out, and be alert. We don’t know what kind of

creatures have woken up in the Woods. I'll take point. FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

The ShadowCast Out, Part 3: In The Sunlight

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra climbs a tree as a metaphor, and Adora has a bit of a breakdown.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Madame Razz's home is… quaint. She insisted on "tidying up" before Catra could come in, but the little hut was filthy when she walked in.

Catra looked at Melog before turning back to the old woman, who had her face buried in a cabinet, rooting around for 'the right spices'. She takes a deep breath in before speaking, "So… I have a few questions: who are you, how do you know Adora, and why am I here?"

Razz's response is muffled by the cabinet. "You're here because you need to help me make some tea! We are having a tea party tonight! Swift Wind can tell you about it." Her bony hand gestures vaguely towards Melog, who mewls in confusion.

"Uhhh, yeah… that's not Swift Wind, and I don't know how to make tea." A thought occurs to her, and she says in a slow, perhaps overly saccharine voice, "I could go get my friend Scorpia though! She makes amazing tea, and I'm sure she'll bring Adora with her."

Razz finally emerges, clutching three wooden canisters in her hand that she haphazardly tosses onto the counter before turning to Catra. "Oh nonsense Elana Dearie. You're the only one who can

get up high in the trees! And the Mupry leaves are what we need!"

'What is wrong with this lady? Who's Elana? And why did I follow her?? I don't even know where I am in the woods! Adora's probably worried sick… she probably thinks I ran away-'

That train of thought is interrupted by Melog pressing against her side and Razz shoving a wicker basket into her arms. The small old woman shuffles past her back outside.

"Come along Elana! I'll show you the Mupry trees!"

Catra looks at Melog, shrugs, and follows.

Catra's never met anyone who can outpace her, especially over terrain like this, but Razz moves inhumanly fast, and maneuvers through the tangled underbrush like it's not even there.

This is far from the first time Catra has moved through the Whispering Woods, but things are different now. With the magic returned to Etheria, everything is more alive. She finds herself banking to avoid a herd of green, three-eyed deer. New plants on tall stalks snap at her with fanged mouth-like leaves. Vines shiver and retract at her approach with strange hissing sounds. Things she assumes to be rocks instead turn out to be weird budding creatures that scoot away across the ground as she runs.

None of this seems to affect Madam Razz, who glides through the strange new plant life as if it were not there at all, and is allowed to pass without being accosted.

Catra finally catches up only because Razz has stopped, rustling through a bush and picking berries.

"Hey, old lady. I thought you were showing me a tree, not picking berries."

Razz turns, her eyes wide (*or maybe that's just her glasses?*), "What was that? Oh! Catra dear! The Mupry trees are right there!

Climb to the top and get the leaves that touch the sun."

Catra looks across the clearing, following Razz's pointing. The trees there are grey, with vertical white streaks. They're much straighter and taller than most trees in the Whispering Woods. She snorts. "Alright. Shouldn't be too hard." She strides across the clearing and unsheathes her claws. She pounces up, latching into the tree bark.

Catra quickly realizes that these trees are going to be harder to climb than she thought. The bark looks solid from a distance, but is thin and papery - difficult to get a clawhold in without the bark simply shredding and sending her sliding down. The branches are numerous, but brittle. The ones that snap when she trusts them with her weight outnumber those that don't. In five minutes, she's already fallen six times. Now she's finally managed to make it to the canopy, only to feel the branch she's standing on begin to crack and bend.

"Oh no! Nonononono!!" She screams as the branch snaps. She lunges forward and digs her claws into the tree, and slides down rather than falling, branches colliding with and snapping against her legs and backside as she winds up halfway down the tree. Her hair is on end, her tail straight as an arrow and poofed out. "Ugggggghhhh." She slams her forehead against the tree. "I hate thissss." She whines.

Something is pressing into her back, annoying her. She slaps it away with her tail, feeling a somewhat solid branch. She raises an eyebrow. "Wait a minute…" turning her head, she sees a branch from one of the nearby gnarled oaks poking into her. Inclining her head, she sees the tree reaches nearly to the top of the Mupry. A fanged grin stretches across her face. "Okay. That'll work."

She tenses her body, curling in carefully before leaping off backwards. She sails through the air for a moment before flipping over and landing on the branch. It's thin, and it groans, but it holds her.

“Finally, a proper tree. How hard is that to ask for?” She smirks, and looks upwards.

Okay. This I can do.

She gets to the top of the Oak tree easily, and the peak of the Mupry is in sight. One mighty leap later, and she’s clinging onto the tree trunk at its highest point. She snaps off three whole branches of leaves before clambering back down. The journey down is less graceful than she anticipated, due to her balance being thrown off by the branches.

Wow, who knew carrying branches covered in big bushy leaves would make climbing difficult?

When she reaches the ground, she is frazzled, her outfit is torn, there are branches and leaves sticking out of her fur, and she’s covered in dirt, but she triumphantly holds up the branches like she’s won a race.

Razz is sitting crosslegged on the ground, petting Melog with both hands.

“Hey, old lady! I’ve got your leaves!” She struts over to Razz, who is on her feet immediately.

“Excellent! No time to waste, we need to get back to make the tea!” And she’s off. “Come on Catra!” Her voice calls out.

Catra smirks. Melog trots up beside her and meows. “Oh yeah. Let’s go.” Catra says confidently, and she and Melog dart off through the woods.

She feels free, somehow. Rushing through the Whispering Woods alongside an alien shapeshifter, racing a crazy old woman to her house to make tea, it feels… right, somehow. It didn’t even a few minutes before but- now that she has the leaves, now that she has a goal…

It’s a stupid goal you know.

Maybe. But it doesn't matter.

When Razz reaches the clearing, Catra is already there, leaning against the wall of the hut and trying her best not to show how hard she exerted herself getting here.

"Oh good! Hurry, hurry inside! We have to get the kettle boiling!" Razz pushes aside the curtain and waddles inside, Catra following with a smile.

The smile gives way to jaw dropped shock as she watches Razz wave her hand and a fire lights on its own under the tea kettle. A stone bowl floats over and the spices she had grabbed earlier pour themselves in. Razz grabs one of the sticks from Catra's arms and, in one fluid motion, tears the leaves off and dumps them in the bowl, and uses the branch as a mortar to grind them down.

"Is that… magic?" Catra says, awestruck.

"Don't act so surprised, dearie! You are surrounded by magic every day! Etheria is magic. Madame Razz is not the first person you've seen with magic, eh?" She dumps the bowl of mashed leaves and spices into the kettle, which came to a boil remarkably fast. She then scuttles over to another counter and dumps out top boxes of different colored powders and starts mashing them together with the berries she picked.

Catra hops up on the counter nearest her and sits. "I guess so but… I've never seen magic like yours I guess." Razz doesn't respond, and another thought enters Catra's head. "Why were you at the edge of the woods anyways? How did you find me?"

Razz pulls the haphazard ball of dough she's managed to form and tossed it onto a pan. With a snap, the fireplace is roaring, and she places the pan on the bricks within. "I was at the edge of the woods because I needed your help of course! We are having a tea party you know! Swift Wind and Mara are coming soon."

"But… why me? You probably could have gotten those leaves faster than I did… I barely made it up the tree. I didn't make it up

the tree, I had to use the other tree to get to the top."

I cheated to win. Just like I always have.

Catra brings her legs up onto the counter and hugs her knees close to her chest. Melog leaps up and shifts down to housecat sized. They nuzzle against Catra, their mane a dark blue.

Razz puts a hand on Catra's shoulder.

"Sometimes you can't just climb a tree. It's hard and the branches you rely on break and you fall. And it only gets harder every time you fall. But it's only hard if you don't look at the other trees. There is a whole forest out there! When you accept help from the other trees in the forest, your own tree becomes much easier to climb." Catra looks at Razz's kindly face, and tears come unbidden to her eyes. Before she can say anything else, she hears a faint voice.

"Catra!?"

"Sparkles?" Catra says, her ears perking up.

"Oh! We'd better get ready if people are arriving!" Razz shuffles over to the counter. Catra jumps off and exits the hut.

Adora

"CATRA!!" She shouts

She's been shouting for the better part of an hour. Her throat is starting to hurt.

I didn't know She Ra's throat could *hurt*.

She hears the others shouting for Catra as well. Scorpia occasionally substitutes in a "Wildcat!?"

Why does she call her that? I don't have a different name for Catra, how come Scorpia gets to?

Focus, Adora! Catra needs you.

But what if she doesn't? What if she realizes that she never did?

She said she loves me. We kissed. Doesn't that mean we need each other?

And if not, what does *it mean? Does it mean anything..?*

"Adora!"

Bow's warning comes too late, and She Ra walks headlong into a tree, falling to the ground with a breathless "oof".

Bow rushes over and helps her up, looking up at her with concern in his eyes and asking, "Adora, are you okay? You've been kinda… spaced. Are you sure you got enough sleep?"

"I'm fine Bow. We need to find Catra." Adora says gruffly. She feels bad brushing Bow off like this, but none of it matters until they find her…

My what? My best friend? Partner? Girlfriend?

"Hnnnngh! CATRA!!" Adora shouts in frustration as she slices through a veritable net of vines. The vines shrivel back with a whining sound as she cuts into them.

She hears a sigh, and then Bow is in front of her, his arms outstretched.

"Okay. Enough. We're talking about this. Now." He says. He has a hard edge in his voice that Adora never would have imagined possible a few years ago.

"Bow!" She says, exasperated that he doesn't get the time pressure.

"Hey! Why aren't you guys calling for Catra? CATRA!" Scorpia calls over.

Bow opens his mouth to respond, but Adora cuts in with, "Because Bow thinks now is the best time to stop and talk about feelings."

Bow glares at her. "Because Adora clearly has something on her mind that she needs to work through before she explodes!"

They hear rustling as Scorpia starts making her way towards them. "Oh yeah, if you want to say something important to someone, sometimes it's good to let someone else hear it first." She emerges from a bush, smiling broadly and blushing a little, "Perfuma told me that. Gosh she is just so wise, and her wisdom definitely applies now!" She approaches Adora.

"Look guys, I appreciate that you're concerned, but we need to find Catra." She says, the annoyance growing.

Bow grabs her shoulders. "Adora. Catra ran off on her own. We're all worried about her, but she can handle herself. She has a magical cat that can turn her invisible. If she doesn't want to be found, we're not going to find her."

Adora sputters for a moment, but she knows that Bow is absolutely right. She sighs and hangs her head, letting She Ra fade. Before she can say anything, a shower of sparkles heralds Glimmer's arrival.

"I didn't find anyth-! Why are we all together?" She says, an eyebrow raised.

Bow turns and pulls her into the group. "Adora was about to tell us what's bothering her so much that she zoned out and ran into a tree."

"Oh, that makes sense." Glimmer responds. She takes Adora's hands and sits down, Scorpia and Bow following suit. "Adora. What's going on? Is it just that Catra's missing?"

Adora can't meet anyone's eyes, so she settles for looking at Glimmer's hands, still holding hers. "I dunno… probably. I mean

what else is there to be worried about right?" Everyone remains silent. Adora lets out a dry laugh and continues, "Heh, I guess I just don't understand why she'd run away. I mean, I figured that wasn't gonna happen now. I mean is that crazy? Is it crazy to think that because other things have changed that this thing has changed? She's always liked to be alone but I guess I thought that now she'd want to be alone… with me? Heh, I know that probably doesn't make sense but I just…" She feels her face heat up and she turns away, saying the next part quietly. "I mean we're… together now, right? Why would she want to be alone if we're together? Am I taking this whole…" she swallows nervously, "this whole… relationship thing too fast?" She finally looks up at her friends. Bow and Scorpia are watery eyed, with nearly identical looks of support on their faces. Glimmer is smiling proudly, and she gives Adora's hands a squeeze before responding.

"Adora. It's okay to be scared by something new. I think we're all scared about how our lives are going to change from now on." Here Glimmer turns and smiles at Bow, "Catra is always going to be Catra. She's always going to be your Catra. But she's still her Catra too. And she's always going to do things that may not make sense to us, just like you're going to do a lot of things that won't make sense to her," Adora is crying now, and lets out a choked laugh. Glimmer smiles, and Bow picks up.

"Adora. You're an amazing friend. And you're going to be an even better girlfriend." (Girlfriend. Hearing someone else say it is nice.) "So, let's find Catra, and you can talk about this with her yourself, okay? You don't have to be an instant expert at this. Relationships aren't effortless. You have to work at it, all the time." The last part has some jokingly exasperated emphasis, and Glimmer giggles. "But you also need to realize that you're part of the relationship too. You have to work with yourself just as much as you work with her."

Adora smiles. "I love you guys." She says through tears, and grabs Glimmer and Bow and pulls them into a hug. Pulling away, she turns to Scorpia, who has been silently crying, a pincer over her

mouth to avoid all our sobbing. "Hey… Scorpia?" Big shiny eyes meet hers. "Do you think you could help me… come up with a nickname for Catra? Like what you have?"

Scorpia immediately perks up. "Oh wow, really? Oh my gosh thank you! I don't know how much help I'll be, I mean, 'wildcat' took me months, but I am so honored to help." She pulls all three of them into a tight embrace, "you guys are the greatest at friendship!"

She puts them down and they all stand up. Adora wipes her face and smiles. "Alright. If Catra came through the woods, she wouldn't have left much of a trail, but it would be distinctive. Now that my head's a little clearer, I can-"

"DID SOMEONE SAY… SWIFT WIND!?"

Everyone jumps as the alicorn pushes his head into their midst. Scorpia physically restrains her startled stinger.

Glimmer yelps, "Swift Wind! How do you sneak up on us like that??"

The horse shrugs with his wings, "It's one of my many talents. Just like finding Catra."

"WHAT!?" Adora grabs Swift Wind's face. "Where is she. Describe the place exactly! No. Take us there! Take me there! Why are you not telling me where she is!?"

Swift Wind's response is muffled, "Becaush you're grabbing my mouf"

Adora lets go. "Oh! Hehe, sorry."

Swift Wind shakes his head, his mane flowing majestically as he does "pthah! You seriously need to wash your hands Adora. Oh, right, Catra. I saw her in a clearing about two miles deeper into the forest that way." He points with a rainbow colored wing, "She was on top of a tree, then she jumped into another tree, then she

took some branches off of that tree, and then she climbed down. To the ground." He adds disdainfully.

Adora meets everyone's gaze. Bizarre behavior, even for Catra.

Scorpia raises a claw, "Do you think you can lead us there… on foot? I don't think you can carry all of us and we won't be able to follow you from the ground."

Swift Wind tosses his mane and strikes a pose. "Never fear, Swift Wind can guide you through the woods! He has a perfect internal compass."

The horse trots off in the direction he pointed.

Catra

Catra pushes the curtain out of the way and steps outside Razz's hut, Melog on her heels.

"CATRAAAAAA!" Yep, that's definitely Glimmer.

"SPARKLES?" Catra shouts back, cupping her hands around her mouth.

"Catra!?" The sound is closer.

"Yeah, I'm over here!" Catra waves her hands in the air before realizing that the princess almost certainly can't see her.

There are a few more false starts before Glimmer arrives in a shower of pink.

"Catra!" She rushes in and pulls Catra into a hug.

"Heh, woah there Sparkles. Personal space?" But she returns the hug anyways.

It's nice to have friends.

Glimmer pulls away suddenly, and adopts a stern pose, hands on hips, neck to one side and head straight. "You have got a lot of explaining to do, missy!"

Catra scoffs, "Missy??"

"I'm gonna bring you back to Adora, and you're going to explain why you left, and then you two are gonna talk about what your new relationship means, and figure out- who is that?" Glimmer points behind Catra. The feline looks over her shoulder at where Razz has emerged from the house, broom in hand, and begun sweeping the dirt.

Catra turns back to Glimmer. "Oh that's, uh… Razz." She shrugs, "I'm not sure what her deal is."

"Wait, Razz?" Glimmer facepalms, "Of course! Now it makes sense!"

"Wait, you know Razz?" Catra asks, stunned.

Glimmer shrugs. "Well, Adora and Swift Wind know Razz, and I think Bow met her once. Hi Madame Razz!" She waves over Catra's shoulder.

"Huh? What was that?" Razz asks either her broom or the moths that flutter around her constantly.

"Okay. I'll go get everyone and we'll be right back!" Before Catra can say anything else, Glimmer is gone.

"Pft. Glad she didn't drag me along." She mutters. "Hey, Razz! Everyone's about to get here."

"Oh! Wonderful! I'll go pour our tea and get the bread ready!" She shuffles into the house, and Catra takes a seat on a root, one leg hanging down, her toes scraping the dirt, the other one up on the log.

Glimmer isn't gone long, but it's still long enough to leave Catra alone with her thoughts

I've been gone long enough to warrant a search party. I left for no reason and didn't tell anyone. What was I thinking? Adora is going to be furious! They're going to see that I'm not worth the effort.

She can see Melog's mane turn an anxious yellow as she pulls her knees into her chest.

Great. I'm upsetting Melog now. I've upset Melog, Adora, Glimmer, who knows who else! I bet Razz is probably sick of me already. Maybe I was right to run away. They're only looking for me cause Adora thinks she has to. They'd be better off without me.

I should leave.

She's getting up when the tinkle of teleportation startles her back to reality. In the middle of the clearing, facing away from her current position, are Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, Swift Wind, and Adora.

What are they all doing out here??

"Catra??" Adora swivels her head around rapidly, catching sight of Catra immediately. "Catra!" She sprints over and sweeps Catra off the root into a squeezing hug.

"Oof! Haha, Hey Adora." Catra says, the wind knocked out of her and a chuckle escaping on her name.

Adora pulls her head off of Catra's shoulders and puts her hands on Catra's cheeks. Catra doesn't have time to react before Adora has pressed their lips together frantically. "I love you Catra." She says, burying her face in Catra's shoulder. Catra gets a full view of the other three people's reactions: Bow with massive watery eyes and his arms pumped triumphantly, Scorpia beaming happily despite the restrained sadness in her eyes, Glimmer averting her gaze politely, and Swift Wind theatrically gagging silently. She manages to both scowl and blush ferociously.

"Okay. Adora? Crushing me." She says. The blonde immediately releases her.

"Catra. Why did you run away? Why didn't you tell me?? Are you mad at me? Were you chasing something? Was something chasing you?? Why come to the Woods? And how did you meet Razz?" Catra's head spins with the volley of questions Adora pelts her with, so she decides to go one at a time.

"Ummmm… I needed to run; you were sleeping really cutely; never again;" (Adora blushes when she realizes which question that answers. 'What a dork'), "no; I guess Melog; I lost track of how far I ran; and she found me." Catra smiles at Adora, and then turns to everyone else, "She said she was planning a tea party for everyone."

Swift Wind gasps. "That was today?? Ah, man! It is really easy to let your commitments slip when the world is ending and the person scheduling them has no concept of time."

"Swift Wind? Mara?" Razz's voice from within the hut heralds her exit, somehow balancing a pan, several teacups, a kettle, a loaf of berry bread, and a jug of milk on top of her broom. She takes everyone in and smiles. "Oh! You're all here! And right on time, too! Come come, sit!" She lets go of the broom, and Bow and Scorpia lunge to catch it, but they collide with each other and the broom stays standing in midair on its own.

Adora walks up to Razz, who is attempting to yank a root towards her house for some reason. "Razz, it's so good to see you!"

"Oh it's wonderful to see you too Mara! I'm so glad you brought Elana again, it's been so long since the last time it was her first time. Give me a hand with the table Mara dear."

Adora shakes her head and puts a hand on Razz's shoulder. "Razz, it's me, Adora. And that's Catra, not, umm, what was that name again? You've never said that one before." Razz looks at her, confused, and blinks.

Before? Is her messing up names common? Why is she calling Adora Mara? Why'd Swift Wind say she has no concept of time? "Uuggghhh" Catra grabs her head and sits down on the root. Scorpia and Bow immediately rush over to her

"Oh gosh, are you okay?? Did she poison you? Can you hear me Catra??" Scorpia asks.

"I'm fine!" Catra says, before feeling a piercing spear of guilt through her chest at how Scorpia flinches from the tone. She reaches up and puts her hands on Scorpia's pincers gently. "I'm just… confused, alright?"

"Overwhelmed?" Bow asks, "Razz has that effect."

Catra chuckles. She's not sure where Adora and Razz's conversation has gone while she's been distracted, but she immediately snaps her attention to Adora when she hears, "FOR THE HONOR OF GREYSKULL!"

Wow. She Ra is…

Catra whistles, louder than intended, and She Ra shoots her a smirk while Glimmer giggles.

Catra's eyes are glued to the Princess of Power as she walks to the edge of the clearing, raises her sword, and slices a large boulder cleanly in two. She cuts again, and picks up the large, flat slab she's created, hefting it over her head, (Gods, those arms…) and walking it to the clearing before gently setting it down on the ground, creating a perfect table for Razz's broom to lay out the tea and bread.

Everyone stands around awkwardly for a moment, before Scorpia's eyes go wide. "Ohhhh what is that cake thing?? That smells… SO GOOD." She rushes in and sits crosslegged on the grass in front of the table. Razz trundles up and starts pouring tea.

"Oh that's Madame Razz's world famous breckberry sweetbread! I've just made it today for the first time."

Scorpia speaks around a mouthful of sweetbread. "Hey, how can it be famous if you just made it for the first time?"

Bow and Glimmer sit at the end of the table, and Catra settles between Adora and Scorpia.

"See? This is how it should be! Either everyone gets a chair, or no one gets a chair." Swift Wind settles to the ground beside Adora, who pats his flank affectionately.

Glimmer is the first to drink the tea, and pulls a strange face while examining the cup. "Ummm… Madame Razz? What kind of tea is this? It tastes…"

"Weird." Bow finishes, "Not bad, but… weird."

Razz doesn't seem to hear them, so Catra answers, "Ummm, she called it a Mupry tree? So…"

Bow spits out his mouthful of tea and panics. "Wait?? Mupry?? Mupry leaves are poisonous! You can't make Mupry tea!!"

"Oh don't be silly child," Razz responds dismissively. She then turns and looks at Catra with a smile. "Mupry makes the best tea! The poison only thrives in darkness, but once the tree has grown tall, the sunlight purifies it. Burns away the toxins, leaving only the leaf's truest self."

Is she comparing me to a tree? And if so… why is it working so well?

Catra blushes and takes a sip. Bow and Glimmer were right, it tastes… weird. There are so many different flavors that come in and out of focus. But it's not bad. Catra nudges Scorpia lightly, "Not as good as yours." She says, grinning.

Scorpia blushes furiously and gives Catra a fearsome side hug. She gasps, "Oh! Did you guys know I actually got Hordak to drink my tea once!?"

"WHAT?!" Adora and Catra cry in unison.

"Yeah! Ah man it was wild. So this was when Entrapta had started working with him, and Emily was bringing them food…"

Catra listens attentively, laughing with everyone, and sweeping her eyes across the table. Her friends, together. Melog snoozing peacefully behind her, Adora pressing her shoulder to her, Scorpia animatedly talking about the antics of a bumbling robot and a paranoid shut in conquerer, Bow and Glimmer snuggling, Razz talking to her broom…

This is good. I feel… Catra looks at Razz, I feel like I'm in the sunlight.

Catra decides that today was the best day of her life.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry this one came a day late. I hope you've enjoyed the first "arc" of this story!

Kudos and comments are very much appreciated, and thank you for reading!

The Head That Wears The Crown, Part 1: Return to Bright Moon

Chapter Summary

> In Which Catra is introduced to life in Bright Moon, and the Princesses come to a decision about how to punish Hordak for his past transgressions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow

Bright Moon turned out to be in surprisingly good repair. The Rebellion had abandoned it when Prime's troops closed in, but it seems his forces left it alone for the most part afterwards. They took a few pieces of art, but little has to be done to make it livable again.

Glimmer had brought Bow, Adora, and Swift Wind to scout ahead while everyone else made their way via caravan (Catra had awoken with a stomachache and threatened murder if Glimmer teleported her). Now, the four of them are standing on the overlook outside of the throne room, gazing out over the sound and watching the haphazard caravan of princesses, refugees, soldiers, and citizens emerge from the Whispering Woods.

Adora has been in a state of complete disrepair leaving Catra on her own, but since the caravan had moved out at the same time as them, Glimmer convinced her that there was no way to know where they'd be in order to drop Adora off with Catra. Bow knew that Glimmer secretly wanted to grill Adora about their relationship, and give Catra some space, but Adora has been freaking out ever since.

As soon as the caravan emerges, Adora snatches the binoculars from Bow and scours over them. “Where is she?? I don’t see her!”

“See who?” Comes an amused sounding raspy voice from behind them.

They all jump and scream in unison. Adora strikes a fighting stance. Bow ducks behind Swift Wind and nocks an Arrow. Glimmer’s hands light up. Swift Wind flares out his wings and whinnies aggressively

Catra is leaning against a pillar with her arms crossed and an amused smirk on her face, Melog curled around her legs. “You know, I was thinking about how weird it is to be here without anyone trying to kill me but now it feels right.” She snarked good naturedly.

Bow puts away his bow and arrow and Glimmer’s glow dissipates. “Sorry… force of habit.” Bow says ruefully, but he is drowned out by Adora bellowing “CATRA!!” and sprinting across the room to sweep the cat girl into her arms and spin her around.

“Gah!!” Catra cries. “Ribs, Adora! I have them!”

Adora loosens the hug and sets Catra down.

“Sorry,” she says with a sheepish giggle.

Bow turns to Glimmer, his eyes sparkling and his hands on his cheeks. “They. Are. The. Cutest!!” He practically squeals.

Glimmer smirks and elbows him. “I guess we need to work a little harder then.” She wraps an arm around his midriff and pulls him to her side. He’s blushing harder than Catra now.

I need to talk to Glimmer about us later.

His train of thought is cut off when he notices what Catra is doing. Holding Adora’s hand and gazing silently around the throne room,

taking in the high ceilings, glossy floors, bright white pillars, ornate gilding, and the magnificent floating throne.

"Wow…" she says, and Bow can relate. It's been so many years, but he still remembers being a child and seeing Bright Moon's throne room for the first time. He smiles and wraps his arm around Glimmer as the two of them approach their friend.

"It's so… real…" Catra says, still awestruck.

"Real?" Glimmer asks, a very slight edge of teasing in her voice at the strange choice of adjective.

"I guess… The only throne rooms I've ever been in were Hordak's and…" *Prime's*. "But they felt… fake. Artificial. This feels… I dunno, genuine? And for so long I thought about being here as- as a-"

"A conquerer." Glimmer says, a little harshly, and Catra winces before continuing.

"Yeah. I imagined so many ways this place could look, so many different versions of me sitting on the throne of Bright Moon. But you know what?" Catra turns to Glimmer with a glint in her eye, "I never imagined the throne would actually be *floating*. I mean come on Sparkles, is this whole kingdom just as reliant on magic as you?"

Bow smiles as the melancholy tension in the room fades, giving way to laughter as Glimmer splutters a comeback, and Adora leaps to her girlfriend's defense.

Things are gonna be normal now…

He casts his eye to the empty throne, and then down to Glimmer at his side.

Not old normal, I guess. But new normal. New normal is good.

"Hey? Heyyy! Arrow Boy!" He snaps out of his reverie.

"What?? Do we need something? Who's broken??" He says, his voice high and panicked.

Catra lets out a short, squeaky cackle. "We're all broken, dummy. Glimmer wants to give me the 'grand tour' before everyone else gets here." She's leaning against Adora, with one arm up around the blonde's shoulders and the other on her opposite hip, popped out to the side. Bow smiles at Adora's goofy grin. He doesn't think he ever imagined Catra looking so at ease in Bright Moon.

"Sure! Where to first?" He says happily.

Yeah. I like new normal a lot.

Catra

Bright Moon exceeded all of Catra's expectations. The gorgeous, sweeping architecture that she once mocked as indefensible carries into the inside, with long, tall hallways and extravagantly decorated rooms. Bow and Glimmer talked excitedly about all sorts of details about the castle, pointing out what rooms had what, telling stories about Adora's first days in Bright Moon (*My dork had a hard time adjusting to Princess life. Go figure*), and generally being enthused. Catra smiles. She likes these two, whether it's Bow's friendliness and positivity or Glimmer's wit and drive that reminds her of herself.

"And this is my room! It's the biggest and nicest in the castle cuz, you know, Queen!" Glimmer says, her smile oozing into her chipper voice. Catra's jaw drops. It's the first bedroom she's seen in Bright Moon and it's massive. There are amenities and nooks in this room that she couldn't even begin to understand. The bed is suspended from the ceiling, with little floating stairs leading up to it (*I love that*). But her attention is drawn to the main source of noise in the room: a large sheet waterfall covering one of the walls, filling into a long pool level with the floor. Catra's hackles raise.

"Why." She breathes. "Would you want a *waterfall* in your room??"

Glimmer laughs, “For decoration and calming noises! It’s pretty standard.”

“I’ve got one too!” Adora offers, then she sees Catra’s state of startlement and stumbles over her words “A-bu-uh… but mine is a lot smaller and not as big…”

“Speaking of… let's go to your room!” Glimmer shouts, and before Catra can protest, she’s grabbed them and teleported them to another room. Catra pushes down the sensation of her stomach flipping as her entire world changes, smells, sights, sounds completely flipping in an instant. She thinks it’s her heightened senses that make teleporting so rough for her compared to everyone else.

Looking around the room, it’s similar to Glimmer’s, but smaller, more humble. There are still an excessive amount of cushions and crystals and water, but it feels more… home-y. The vanity has little pictures and diagrams done in a familiar style pinned up all over it, covering almost the whole mirror. The wardrobe door is ajar, revealing several identical white shirts and grey pants. The bed is a far cry from the hanging poof in Glimmer’s room, being instead a simple mattress with one blanket and one pillow.

Of course Adora can’t let herself be comfy. We’ll change that.

Catra chuckles at her dork of a girlfriend, and squeezes her hand before realizing something. She lets go of Adora’s hand and takes a step back, rubbing her upper arm and speaking to Glimmer while looking at the ground.

“So… um, Sparkles. Where’s… where’s my room?”

There’s a beat of silence, long enough for Catra to regret bringing it up. She looks up and sees Adora looking surprised and a little hurt, and a Glimmer looking at Bow.

“Well,” Glimmer starts, “If you want your own room we can definitely find you one, but since we’re going to be hosting a lot of

displaced people for a while… I thought maybe you could stay with Adora."

Catra immediately blushes. *'Why though? Adora and I slept together practically the whole time we were in the Horde? What's different now?'*

Of course, looking at her girlfriend and seeing the expression of reticent hopefulness and love tells Catra exactly what's different.

"It doesn't have to be permanent," Glimmer assures, sensing Catra's hesitation, "And we can bring in another bed-"

"No." Catra says, smiling at Adora and taking her hand, then gently swinging it back and forth. "No. That sounds perfect."

Adora's eyes go wide and sparkly as she wraps Catra up in a hug. Catra squeaks briefly, but then nuzzles into Adora's neck and shoulder with a soft purr.

Adora releases her, still grinning ear to ear. Catra strides up to the bed and pokes it. It's much softer than Fright Zone beds. *Wow this is nice.*

"Eh. I guess this'll do." Catra shrugs noncommittally. Then, something catches her eye. The bathtub in one side of the room. "Okay. That's gonna have to change."

Everyone looks over, confusedly. "The… bathtub?" Bow asks tentatively.

"One: There is no privacy there, and Two: I'm gonna need there to be a shower instead. Baths… don't agree with me." She says it light heartedly, but as soon as she does images of a green pool fill her mind. Clones holding her under, her hair being shorn, the sting of electricity…

She shivers at the memory. Adora puts a hand on her shoulder, clearly having noticed her train of thought. "Then we'll add a

shower.” Adora says simply, before adding, “I’ve wanted a shower this whole time too, I just… never wanted to ask.”

“Really??” Glimmer says, faux shocked. “Adora, I have never known you to not tell people what you want! I am shocked! Positively shocked!” She says in a mockingly scandalized tone. Before Adora can respond, Glimmer holds up a finger and cocks her head. There’s enough time for Catra to look to Bow, confused, and be met with a shrug before Glimmer looks back at them, her smile faded and her tone more businesslike. “They’re here, and they want to have a meeting with us to make some decisions.”

“All of us?” Catra asks nervously. She understood the princesses letting her in during the desperation of the war on Prime, but she didn’t expect to be included afterwards.

Glimmer nods, and her expression falls further into seriousness. “Yes. I think we should all be there to decide what happens to Hordak.”

Glimmer

Glimmer has her head in her hands. She knew this meeting would be difficult, but she didn’t anticipate just how many different opinions were going to be put forth.

“I think we should just all be able to punch him whenever we want!” Frosta’s idea. Juvenile, and admittedly appealing in its simplicity.

“We can’t just punch people we don’t like, Frosta. I think we should try to change him, make him a productive member of society. Maybe he just needs peace.” Of course Perfuma is advocating that they do basically nothing. As tempting as it is to simply let bygones be bygones, especially considering the precedent set by accepting Catra, it isn’t that simple.

“I’m really gung ho about community service, I think that’s the way to go.” Scorpia has been advocating that they make Hordak

do community service. A very good idea, except that Scorpia has only a vague knowledge of what community service is.

"Or, we could just execute him." Mermista had been advocating that, like, a *lot*, and it's really unsettling.

"No." Glimmer snaps, and the buzz of argument subsides. "We're not going to execute him, or torture him, or let him off scot free."

A muffled, relieved "yay" came from the corner of the room. Entrapta has been sitting there, facing the wall with her mask pulled down over her face since Mermista first proposed execution.

Glimmer continues. "I think we should hear the plan that Bow came up with."

We should have opened with his plan. Could have saved a lot of time.

It was Bow who had suggested letting the others give their ideas first, and Glimmer thinks it's been a disaster. The only person who hasn't spoken so far is Catra, who is clinging to Adora's side and trying to avoid looking at Entrapta or Mermista. Or anyone, really.

Understandable. Poor girl.

Bow clears his throat. "Thank you. The plan I came up with mixes a lot of your ideas. Except execution." Mermista sighs. "Hordak isn't going to walk free, but we have to be willing to give everyone a chance." He glances at Catra, who blanches and tries to make herself as small as possible. "We also have to keep in mind that Hordak is close friends with Entrapta. And Entrapta is one of us. She doesn't deserve to have her friend taken away from her." There are some grumbles of assent at that. If there's one thing the princesses can agree on, it's the power and importance of friendship. "I've been working with King Micah on a solution." Bow looks to the older man and nods.

Micah stands. His hair is pulled back into a bun, his beard is trimmed, and his outfit is clean. He looks kingly, but Glimmer is still having a hard time seeing him as King.

I still have a hard time seeing him as my dad.

"Scorpia has the right idea." Micah begins, "Hordak is too valuable a resource to go to waste, he's intelligent, driven, and has knowledge of technology and the wider universe that exceeds the rest of us put together. He can put that knowledge and capability to use. But the problem with simple community service is accountability. There's also the fact that he deserves punishment, not simply atonement. He fought us for decades, destroyed towns, tore families apart." His voice cracks at the last statement, and he takes a moment to compose himself. Most eyes go to the empty chair beside him, the tall throne that Glimmer has yet to claim. "He can atone for his actions, yes, but he also has to pay for them. So. How do we solve all of these problems in one fell swoop? Entrapta."

"What!?" The nasally voice comes. Entrapta turns around and raises her mask. "Do I finally get to give my recommendations! Oh yes!" She reaches for a data pad but Micah cuts her off.

"No, Entrapta. You are the solution."

Hordak

How did the Rebellion fight him to a stalemate for decades, weather constant bloodshed and violence, doubtless suffer so much at his hands… and yet still put him in a guest room instead of a prison cell? Hordak has been questioning this since his arrival to Bright Moon. They put him in another magical circle, and he is sitting on the floor of it, but still. They gave him a pillow.

After all these years I'm here, striding through the halls of my enemy's capital. In chains. Disgraced and alone.

Even Entrapta hasn't visited him here. It's for the best. The more time she spends away from him, the better chances she'll have.

Hordak looks up as the door opens. Queen Glimmer is the first one in, followed by the archer, then King Micah, then She Ra and Catra, then the remainder of the princesses. The room is quite full, except…

Where is Entrapta? His unasked question is answered though, as the flower princess looks around, gasps, ducks out of the room, and returns, leading Entrapta on a small leash made of vines.

"Oh! Sorry. Hi Hordak!! They came up with a solution for how to punish you and you're going to love itttt!" Entrapta says, her hair elevating her in an excited curl as the Queen sighs. Hordak turns to her, raising a confused eyebrow.

"And why," he begins, "would I 'love' my punishment?"

"Because it's probably the only thing you want anymore, since," the Queen chuckles, "I doubt you've got any more plans of world domination."

Hordak looks down at the floor. "I… do not."

Why would I. It was never anything more than a cry for attention. A cry that was stifled as soon as it was heard. There would be no point anymore. I never wanted to rule or be worshipped, I only wanted…

He is snapped out of his reverie as King Micah approaches. Hordak straightens so that he is kneeling before the king, rather than half lying prostrate. The small pink queen he may have a hard time respecting, but this man radiates power and authority.

"Hordak." He begins. "Before I pass my sentence, do you have anything to say before us?"

Hordak pauses, then stands, surveying the crowd. He hisses when his eyes pass over Catra, who sticks her tongue out in response.

He can’t help a sneer when the flower princess meets his gaze with a smile and a wave. He settles on Entrapta, who looks like she’s ready to burst with… excitement? That can be addressed later.

“Your world has been my prison for many years. Etheria was everything I hated, and if I could have wiped your Rebellion off of this pathetic world I would have.” He growls. Several princesses begin to speak at once, but Micah holds up a hand, stone faced. Hordak continues, “War and anger were all I knew. I lashed out, desperate to prove my worth to- to…” he can’t say the name. He looks away, ashamed that he can’t face him.

I threw you into the abyss. Why do you still haunt me?

He looks back to the princesses, hating the understanding and pity that fills the eyes of some of their number. A few of them have their hands on the backs of their necks. “I waged war against you for decades. I threw away my life and the lives of others in pursuit of a fruitless conquest. I accept whatever punishment you choose to give me.” He pauses, then, “But... I will not accept no punishment.”

Catra scoffs at that, and Glimmer smirks, “Oh trust us, it may not seem like a punishment, but it will be.”

Micah reaches into a pouch and pulls out magical ingredients. Hordak’s mind jumps to the sorceress. To Shadow Weaver. Micah begins to draw a large sigil on the ground. Entrapta moves forward on her hair, her hands behind her back.

“Can I explain this next part??” She asks Glimmer, sounding like a wave of excitement about to break.

“Ugh. Yes Entrapta, you can expla-”

“GREAT!!” She turns to Hordak, striding up on her hair. “Micah is going to use magic on both of us, he’s going to bind us together, and the magic will always know how far apart we are, so the Princesses will be able to keep tabs on us. The exciting part is

these!” She reaches her hands out and opens them, revealing two pieces of metal. One is large and circular, with a hinge and a clamp, like a collar or bracelet. The other is a pin, a badge, not unlike those worn by Horde Force Captains. “I wear the pin, and you wear the collar! You have to stay within 50 feet of me at all times, or you get a very minor electrical shock! Isn’t that great!! Now we can be lab partners again!” She says, reaching her hair through the magical cell wall and placing it on his shoulder.

“I… don’t understand.” Hordak says. “This is not punishment, this is… kindness?”

“Of course it’s kindness,” the archer says, stepping forward, “We’re the good guys, kindness is how we win, and even you deserve kindness Hordak.”

The flower princess continues the thought. “We have to believe that anyone can be better as long as they have people to help them. If Entrapta could help you be a better person, then of course we would want to enable that. But I can speak from personal experience to tell you that keeping her close to you is… a challenge.” Her fist closes and her eyes go wide at the last part, her lips pursing.

Hordak’s eyes widen as it settles in. How many times had he and Entrapta been working, only for her to haul herself into the vents with no warning or explanation, being gone in an instant. Micah has finished the rune on the ground. It’s a large circle, with two smaller circles inside side by side. Entrapta eagerly leaps into one, bouncing in place slightly. Micah waves a hand, and the magical cell around Hordak dissipates. Several of the princesses tense, with the ocean princess and the dark skinned princess taking outright fighting stances. Hordak scoffs at their paranoia and steps into the other circle, facing Entrapta. He smiles tentatively at her excitement.

Her excitement to be by my side. It’s a strange thought, someone choosing to be close to Hordak. He supposes she must have chosen this, since it would otherwise be a punishment for her, too.

It's a punishment for her regardless. I should be kept away from her. They should make her move on for her own good. What happens when she tires of me? When she realizes she can't fix me?

He was so wrapped up in his thoughts that he didn't even notice the circle flash with magic. He didn't know if the faint glow that surrounded Entrapta in that moment was magic, or simply a product of his affections playing with his mind.

"Ahhhh! Now that that's out of the way we can get this on you!" Entrapta unclamps the metal collar and lunges towards Hordak.

Hordak lets out a strangled cry and staggers back reflexively. "No! Wait!"

"What do you want Hordak? We're not going to postpone your punishment." The young Queen's voice, hard and harsh.

"I…" Hordak starts, and his hand goes to the back of his neck, to the sleek metal port there. The brand of Prime, marking Hordak as his own and leaving an open slot for his presence. "Might I… ask…" This is the hardest thing Hordak has ever done. He can't meet the queen's eye as he asks, nay, *begs*, "May I ask for… one… k-kindness, from you first..?" He can only see the Queen's feet as she takes a step back. He hears Catra scoff at that, and he closes his eyes, ready to be denied, to have this mercy of a punishment be revoked and to be locked in chains.

"What might that be?" Glimmer asks, her voice measured.

"I… understand that Entrapta was able to surgically remove an embedded chip." He finally looks up, and takes some satisfaction in seeing pain on Catra's face as she rubs the scar on the back of her neck. "Might you permit her to… try and remove my…" he hates to call it what it truly is, "the docking port in my neck. Please?" He finally meets Queen Glimmer's eyes, and is surprised to see sympathy there, then the sparkle of an idea. She smiles at him, not with warmth or affection, but it is genuine nonetheless.

“Of course.” She says, and Hordak can’t help his jaw going slack in surprise. “It must be a terrible reminder, and if she can do it for you, we might be able to help the other clones with the same problem.”

Of course. Her decision was to show kindness to them all. Not to me. The realization is somewhat relieving. He hates the thought of receiving special treatment from his victorious enemies.

“Great! I just need to go get my surgical tools. You wait right here Hordak!!” And Entrapta is gone, the other princesses ducking as she uses her hair to move over their heads and through the tall doorway.

“See?” Says the archer, looking at Hordak but speaking to the other princesses. “If he had the device on, he’d be receiving almost-painful low grade electric shocks already! It works as a punishment, too.”

The sea princess rolls her eyes and sighs, then shoots Hordak a glare before exiting. Most of the other princesses follow suit. King Micah murmurs something to the Queen before exiting. Hordak is left alone with Glimmer, the archer, Scorpia and the flower princess, and Adora and Catra. The latter two have him fixed with hard glares, while Scorpia simply awkwardly avoids his gaze. Hordak is very suddenly conscious that he is no longer in a cell.

The tension is broken when the flower princess steps forward, a smile on her face that doesn’t seem entirely forced. “Hello there, Hordak. My name is Perfuma, I’m the princess of Plumeria.”

Hordak nods, “I have read reports of you.” He says stiltedly. He is alarmed and put off by her openness and welcoming aura. “Plumeria has been deceptively well defended thanks to your powers.” He means it as a compliment, but he doubts she takes it as such.

She lets out a strange, strained humming sound and closes her eyes for a moment before letting her face resume its smile, which

looks even more genuine now, "Thank you. I wanted to tell you that if you would ever like to join me for guided meditations to work through your problems, you and Entrapta are welcome in Plumeria." Hordak doesn't miss the strain behind the word 'welcome', nor the stilted delivery of the invitation, but he cannot help the dark chuckle that escapes him.

"My problems will not be solved by meditating with my enemies." He spits out the words.

Surprisingly, the flower princess doesn't budge or flinch. "No, but your negative attitude might be." She turns on her heels and strides out of the room, leaving Hordak slack jawed with surprise.

She pauses in the doorway and looks over her shoulder at Hordak and waves a hand. Hordak sees a spark of magic around his wrist, and looks down to see a bracelet of living flowers there. He looks up in confusion as the flower princess, Perfuma, smiles and laughs a little before walking into the hallway.

Queen Glimmer and the archer look at the others in the room. Glimmer wraps her arm around the archer's. *Ah, he is her consort then*. "We'll be in earshot. Shout if you need us." She says.

"Trust me Sparkles. We won't." Catra responds, her eyes burning into Hordak with hate as she says it. Hordak believes her. He had lost to Catra while at the height of his power.

Glimmer nods, and vanishes along with the archer in a pop of energy, leaving Hordak and the three former Force Captains alone in silence.

He sees Catra's fists clench, watches Adora put a hand on her shoulder. The feline's face is clouded with too many emotions for Hordak to read. He remembers how she hurt him, but the memories of how he must have hurt her have not yet returned to him. Perhaps he hasn't allowed them to, wanting to keep her in his mind as a villain. Leave him with *something* to hate, someone worse than him.

Adora seems impassive, simply supporting Catra and sparing Hordak not a second thought.

Scorpia keeps opening her mouth like she wants to speak, only to close it again and turn away, thinking to herself. After the fourth time this happens, Hordak speaks.

"Yes, F- Princess Scorpia?" He says, giving her permission to speak despite her being the one in power here.

"Oh, what? I don't, I wasn't saying anything, I don't really have- I should go." She says, looking very nervous.

"There's something you wish to say to me. Say it." He says, earning a sharp, frightening glare from Adora. "Please." He adds tentatively.

"Oh. Well uh, I guess…" Scorpia bumbles, "I guess I just want to know the truth. You always told me that my family became your allies and gave up the Black Garnet willingly, but Shadow Weaver said that you conquered my kingdom and took the Black Garnet by force."

Hordak pauses as the memories come back. "I… I believe both are true." He sees the look of confusion on Scorpia's face.

"How can both be true, I mean, they're pretty mutually exclusive unless you conquered them *after* they allied with you, but that just seems, heh, pretty excessive, even for you."

"The memory is… difficult to recall" Hordak says. His eyes close as he attempts to push through the green fog that encompasses so much of his mind now. "I attacked your kingdom, desiring it as the heart of my empire. Before too much blood was spilled, your grandfather surrendered to me, and offered the Black Garnet and his loyalty. I accepted."

"So… what happened to my granddad?" Scorpia asks, her voice soft.

“I… don’t remember…” Hordak says honestly. “I believe the war claimed him.”

“Oh. That makes sense I guess.” Scorpia says. There's a pause. “Well that’s all I really needed to know so… I’m gonna go.” She awkwardly waves to Hordak before leaving. Hordak turns to Catra and Adora. He opens his mouth to speak, but at that moment Entrapta appears in the doorway.

“I got my tools!! Are you ready for surgery?” Entrapta’s hair is holding a variety of tools, many of which do not look suited for delicate surgery, and another tendril is dragging a wheeled cot behind her. She looks at the two women in the room. “Oh! Were you talking to Hordak? Should I wait?”

Adora opens her mouth, but Catra cuts her off. “No. I’ve got nothing to say to him. Go right ahead.” She stalks out of the room, and Adora follows, casting Hordak a lingering look as she goes.

Hordak turns to Entrapta, who pulls the cot into the room. “Alright lab partner! Let’s get *medical*!” She pulls her mask down and turns on several whirring instruments.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Kudos and comments are always appreciated, hope you enjoyed!

The Head That Wears The Crown, Part 2: An Unpleasant Revelation

Chapter Summary

In which Glimmer tells Catra a horrible truth, Bow has trouble making tech that isn't arrows, and Catra has a breakdown.

Chapter Notes

Content Warning: Unintentional self harm

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Even the echoes of her footsteps sound more pleasant and welcoming in Bright Moon than they did in the Fright Zone.

In the early morning, just as the sun is beginning to break over the horizon, Catra has decided to go on a walk through the corridors of Bright Moon. She's not sure where she's going, or how long this walk will take, but she knows that she feels safe for some reason.

'I shouldn't feel safe here,' She thinks as she passes another guard. The mask covering half the soldier's face makes it impossible to tell if they are glaring at Catra with pure hatred like they really should be, but Catra has decided not to worry about that.

She contemplates stopping in front of this guard and apologizing. Just spilling her heart for a stranger, explaining why she did everything she did, and how she would take it all back if she could. She wants to tell this guard that she would take all the pain she's inflicted on other people for herself a thousand times over if she could. She wants to sit down in this hallway and let the guard

mete out the judgement they deem most fitting for her, because she's ready to accept it.

But instead she keeps walking. She walks until the guard is out of sight, and then she walks some more. She paces through gardens and trophy rooms, through rubble-strewn halls and past shattered mosaics. Bright Moon had made it out relatively intact, but Prime had done some damage.

Prime did damage to all of us.

Catra stops and leans against the wall. Her hand presses to her temple to combat the sudden headache.

"All beings must suffer to become pure!"

"No…" She groans, trying to push the chorus of voices out of her head.

"All beings must suffer to become Pure!"

"Shut. Up." She growls. She pushes off the wall and opens her eyes, trying to keep walking.

Everything is so bright here. The light, the angles, the colors… it's all horribly familiar…

"ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE!!"

Catra stops dead, staring at a mosaic on the wall.

From the white and green relief, Horde Prime smiles down upon her. His hand reaches out towards her, the metal claw beckoning her towards his side.

She clenches her fist and scrunches her eyes shut. Every muscle in her body screams at her to leap up and slash through that smug, evil, condescending face, but she swallows hard and settles for a weak punch to the wall before turning around.

Catra looks up and down the wall to make sure no one else is coming. She evens out her breaths and steps away from the wall, sweeping her hair back over the top of her head with both hands. She straightens her back and turns to walk down the hallway, not checking to see what the mosaic she nearly clawed through actually represented.

After a few steps, she stops, her pupils dilating to take in the movement at the end of the hall. There, perched on a patch of moss amid a pile of rubble, is a small gray mouse.

Catra's heart is still pounding from the flashback she'd just had. *'I've got all this energy built up… might as well put it to use, right?* She crouches and readies to pounce. *'Yeah… I think this is what I needed.*

Glimmer

Glimmer keeps seeing her. She supposes that's inevitable, given that Angella ruled this Castle for over 800 years, and has dozens of murals and statues in her honor, but it doesn't make it any less unsettling.

And of course the statues all have to be life sized or larger. Why didn't I get any of those tall genes? Why does she always have to be looking down at me??

Glimmer's fists clench as she thinks it, looking up at a more recent statue of her mother, this one is built in the middle of a Koi pond in a topiary garden. The stone is a beautiful pink, and it shows her mother in a rare display of emotion, determination on her lifelike stone face. The statue is supposed to depict Queen Angella saving the Rune Stone during the Battle of Bright Moon. It had been completed a year before she…

'Before she what?? I can't even say she's dead, because she isn't! She's trapped in some weird alternate reality forever, and I'm best friends with the people who caused it!'

Her fists clench tighter and tears spring unbidden to her eyes. She looks up at the carven form of her mother, strong and powerful like Glimmer could never be. She opens her fists as she realizes they were starting to glow with magic. What was she going to do? Throw sparkles at her mom's statue to make her grief go away?

"Why?" She asks, her voice strangled from trying not to sob. "Why did it have to be you?" She says. She slowly sinks to her knees. "We were all there in that portal world? Why was it you who stayed behind?? Why-?" She cuts herself off, hating herself for still thinking this, but she forces it out. Maybe saying it will take it out of her brain. "Why couldn't Adora stay..? Why did you save her instead of yourself?" Glimmer isn't sure if the empty feeling that comes after saying that is a relief, or if it's terrifying.

She stands up, and wanders over to a nearby bench. She looks into the koi pond, studying the fish lazily wandering their small domain, and she weeps.

She hears Catra's approach briefly before she sees her, she hears the echoing screech or claws against marble and turns to see Catra tumble out into the lawn, breathing heavily and smiling with reckless abandon. Glimmer hastily brushes the tears away as the other girl stands up and orients herself.

"Hey Sparkles." She says, leaning against a bonsai tree and looking perfectly casual.

"Hey Catra." Glimmer says, dismayed by how soft her tone is. Seeing Catra's expression change, she adds, "Going for a run through the halls? Getting in your 'zoomies'?" That's what Scorpia called them, the times when Catra just pops with energy and needs to run and run until she's calmer. Perfuma could probably name some deep emotional reason for it, but Glimmer just thinks it's funny.

"Maybe." Catra says, clearly trying not to blush. Glimmer watches her eyes dart around the garden, and land over Glimmer's

shoulder on the statue. She pushes off the tree and takes a few steps forward.

"Is that..?" She asks softly.

Why would she bring this up?? "Queen Angella. My mom." Glimmer responds, turning to look as well. "Not my favorite statue of her."

"I keep seeing her around but I- I wasn't really sure." Catra says, her voice quiet. Glimmer hears a dry chuckle, and turns to look confused at the cat girl. "Those old Horde propaganda posters were pretty accurate after all." Glimmer smiles, but can't bring herself to laugh.

'Is she… working up to an apology? I don't think I can handle that right now.'

Catra hesitates. "Can… can I…" she motions to the bench.

Glimmer smiles. "Of course." Catra puts her upper arm in her hand and approaches the bench slowly. Seeing her hesitation, Glimmer turns so her back is to the middle of the seat. Catra smiles and does the same, and the two sit back to back in silence.

"Where's Melog?" Glimmer asks.

"Sleeping somewhere, I think. They've got a weird sleep schedule." Catra answers, "And that's coming from *me.*"

Glimmer hasn't known Catra for too long, but she definitely knows about her penchant for naps.

They chuckle, and then have a moment of peaceful silence before Catra speaks again.

"Um… this is gonna be weird but… what- what was she like?" Glimmer turns, and sees Catra is still looking at the statue.

Weird? Just weird? What is up with her??

“She was strong.” Glimmer begins. “Strong and smart and wise. She was an amazing leader, a perfect queen, and…” *and a great mom*. “She always tried to protect me. It was really annoying most of the time.” Glimmer giggles, and Catra hesitantly joins in. “She was so… motherly. She took in Bow and Adora so easily. She was the mom neither of them ever had, though both for very different reasons.” She giggles again, and Catra doesn’t join in this time. Glimmer worried that the indirect reference to Shadow Weaver may have upset her, but instead:

“Bow doesn’t have a mom?” She asks hesitantly.

“Oh! Oh not like that, he just has two dads.”

“Oh.” Glimmer hears a shuffle of movement behind her, and looks over her shoulder to see that Catra has curled her knees up to her chest and wrapped her arms around them. “I’m…” she pauses, and takes a deep breath. “How- how did… When did it- when did it happen?”

A chill runs down Glimmer’s spine. She stands up stiffly. “Why are you asking that?” She says, somewhat mechanically.

Is she taunting me? Does she really not know?

“I- Nevermind. You don’t have to answer! I’ll go!” Glimmer turns and locks Catra in place with her eyes.

“Why did you ask that?” She repeats.

“I just-” Catra pauses and screws her eyes shut. “I don’t know when in the war it happened, so- I wanted to know…” Her claws extend and dig into her arms as she curls into herself. “I wanted to know if it was me who ordered the battle that she-”

“Ha. The battle.” Glimmer says, her voice dry and furious. “My mother didn’t die in battle Catra.” Catra looks up at Glimmer, her eyes filled with confusion and tears. “My mother isn’t dead.”

Catra releases her arms and leans back. “Wait, what?”

"She's trapped. She sacrificed herself to save us all." Glimmer sees realization dawn on Catra right before she says it. "From the portal. From you. She's gone because of *you*."

Catra recoils as if Glimmer just blasted her with every ounce of magical power she has. She stands up, half falling off the bench, backing away from Glimmer frantically. Glimmer is just standing there staring at Catra, not sure what has come over her. Catra turns around and runs to the railing, leaping up and perching on the edge, and Glimmer finally comes to her senses.

"Catra, wait!" She reaches out a hand.

Catra pauses, and murmurs something that Glimmer can barely make out as, "I'm sorry," before leaping off. Glimmer teleports to the edge and looks down, terrified, and breathes a sigh of relief when she sees a lithe form leaping from rock to rock, scaling down the mountain. The sigh of relief catches in her throat and turns into a sob, and she sinks to the ground, her back to the railing, and lets her emotions flow.

Bow

'Okay, Bow. You can do this. It's just a simple communicator, smaller than a tracker pad, it can fit on your wrist.'

"Maybe I should get Entrapta…" He mutters, looking at the mess of parts in front of him.

'No! You are a tech master. You've built and fixed all sorts of things. You don't need Entrapta, this doesn't even involve alien tech! This is simple robotics.'

Bow braces himself and sets to work. It goes pretty well. He's reproduced and modified plenty of tracker pads, so he knows the inner workings well. Really all he's doing is miniaturizing and removing the actual tracking functions in order to make a more efficient communicator.

After about an hour, he laughs in triumph and holds up the finished product: A 2x3 inch screen with several buttons and a volume knob on the sides, a leather strap, adjustable to fit any arm, and a long shaft fletched with feathers so it can be fired from a-

"Ugggghhhhh" Bow groans, and tosses it into a pile of similarly failed creations. He flops back in his chair. "Why does everything I touch turn into arrows??" He puts his head in his hands and groans.

It makes no sense of course, but whenever he's crafting, the arrow just happens. It's like he falls into this creative trance, and when he emerges, whatever he was making turns into an arrow.

Bow is snapped out of his reverie by a knock at the door.

"It's unlocked." He calls, muffled by his hands.

"Hey have you seen- uhhhwwhat's happening?" Adora's voice asks, going from concerned to befuddled.

Bow emerges from his hands and gestures to the pile of discarded trick arrows. "Take a look."

Adora steps in and approaches the pile, picking one of them up and examining it with a look of puzzlement. "It's… a new sonic arrow?" She tries.

"No!" Bow cries, "It was supposed to just be a speaker! None of them were supposed to be trick arrows, it just happens, like I can't make anything else! My arrows are my curse!" He buries his head in his arms on the table. He feels Adora give two awkward backpats.

"It's okay Bow," She offers, her positive tone unable to hide her completely understandable confusion. "Maybe just try to make the arrow bits smaller and smaller until they don't affect the… thingie? The whatever you're making."

Bow's head shoots up. "Adora, you're a genius!" He stands up abruptly, the chair spinning across the room, Adora only barely dodging it. He wraps her in a hug. "Instead of trying to fight against the problem, just work with it until it's not a problem anymore! It's a part of the design! A quirk! All my tech can have tiny little arrows coming out of them! Like a cute little signature!" He does a little dance of joy before turning back to Adora. "What did you come here for though?"

Adora rubs the back of her neck self consciously, and her body language says that she's doing the thing where she doesn't want to burden anyone else with her troubles. Bow waits patiently, guessing what this is about and knowing that her paranoia will overcome her anxiety.

"Have you seen Catra? I haven't seen her for hours and I can't find her in the castle, and I also don't know where Glimmer is. Do you think they're together or did they have a fight or did I just upset both of them?" She's rambling, and Bow puts a hand on her shoulder to stop her.

"Hey, Adora? Come back to Etheria. We'll find them." He grabs his tracker pad and straps his bow and quiver to his back, just in case. "Glimmer probably has her pad with her, so we can start with her, then we'll find Catra. Maybe she's just with Razz again."

"Yeah… yeah! She probably just ran off again!" Adora says, but her smile fades quickly, "Away from me…"

"Hey." Bow grabs her shoulder. "If she ran away, she was probably running away from Bright Moon, not from you. You know she's still not one hundred percent comfortable around here. I'm sure she's fine."

Catra

Catra is not fine.

She is, in fact, curled up in a ball in a cave in the Whispering Woods, her fur damp and matted, her arms stinging from how much her claws have dug into them, and her eyes and stomach hurting from crying.

Melog is with her, having come to find her very soon after she fled Bright Moon, but they're not curled around her like they normally are. Instead they've taken up a position at the mouth of the small rocky cave, growling at any wildlife who come to investigate.

'It was me'. Catra has just kept thinking. She had managed to distance herself from wondering what had happened to Glimmer's mom, how she became queen, but now she wishes she could have stayed ignorant of it forever.

'It was me'. She didn't order a soldier to kill her, or just set the circumstances in motion, she did it, personally. She pulled a lever, and Glimmer lost her mom.

That must be why she activated the Heart… Of course. Glimmer had told her that she could forgive Catra because she had also made a mistake that nearly destroyed Etheria, but now… *that was my fault too…*

Why didn't she just kill me when she found me then? She let me live and now I'm going to drag the rest of them down forever.

"Why would you forgive me??" Catra croaks out, breathing her thoughts into the air. "How could you let me live with what I did?"

A voice echoes in her mind in response. "Because… you're *Catra*." Adora, in an intimate moment aboard the ship, right after they had saved Catra from Prime.

'What does that mean?' Even if it made sense, it only accounted for Adora. Why would Bow forgive her? *'I threw him off a cliff!'* Why would Glimmer? *'My mother is gone because of* you.'

"GAAHHHH" Catra screams into the air and takes her claws across the stone again and again. She's not sure how long she tears into

the cave wall, but when she comes away, there is a layer of stone dust at the foot of the wall and dozens of score marks. She looks at her hands. Several of her nails have cracked, and one of them - her right index, has snapped off entirely.

Great. Now Adora'll have to heal that. Can't even hurt a wall without being a burden.

A familiar voice enters her thoughts, a deep, condescending drawl. "You'll *never* be anything more than a burden to Adora, and you refuse to prove your worth to me!"

"Shut up!" Catra shouts at Shadow Weaver, but there is no response.

Because she's dead. She said she was proud of me, and then she died.

Catra assumes the next voice she hears is just another manifestation.

"Catra..? It's me…"

"Here to finish me off, Queen Sparkles?" She responds flatly without looking over her shoulder.

"What? Catra…" She looks over her shoulder at last to see Glimmer standing in the cave entrance, Melog blocking her from getting closer with bared teeth and a red mane. There are clear tear tracks down her soft cheeks, and Catra flinches at the markings of the pain she caused. They may not be as present as the various scars on Adora, but they serve the same purpose.

"If you're not here to get rid of me then what do you want?" Catra says, trying to conjure up some of that old venom her voice used to carry. Maybe she'll be able to drive Glimmer away.

Like Scorpia. Like Adora.

"Catra, can you call off Melog so I can come talk to you?"

What?

"What? Why do you want to talk to me?" She turns, looking at Glimmer with genuine confusion, and is met with an extraordinarily fed up expression.

"Because you're my friend, and I just scoured the Whispering Woods for three hours because you *jumped off a cliff*!!" She cocks her hip and puts a hand on it. "Seriously, Catra, did you think running away was going to save you from my love and support?"

"Pft. Arrow Boy's rubbing off on you." Catra chuckles, forgetting that she's supposed to be angry for a moment. Melog looks at her, and she cocks her head, gesturing for the nebulous shapeshifter to join her. Their angry demeanor vanishes and they shift down to a smaller size before wrapping around Catra's knees.

Glimmer walks up and kneels in front of her. Catra turns her head to the side. She can't meet those kind, sparkly eyes.

"I'm sorry." Catra mutters simply, and she is surprised to feel more tears welling up in her eyes.

Huh. I figured I was all out.

"Catra… please look at me." Glimmer's voice is strained, Catra can't discern the emotions , so she looks up, her eyebrows upturned and knit in a look of worry.

Glimmer takes a deep breath and closes her eyes. "Catra pulled that lever." *Why is she talking about me in third person?* "Adora told she you did it to spite her. She was so desperate to win that she almost destroyed all of Etheria." Glimmer opens her eyes. Her voice starts to waver as she continues. "The Catra who did that took my mother away from me. And I will *never* forgive her for that."

Catra instinctively starts to back away, starting to stand up. This is too much for her. She thought she wanted to hear this but now that she is, she just wants to go back to when she only *thought*

she was beyond forgiveness. She hates having this confirmation that her "friends" could never forgive her. As she stands, Glimmer stands too, and leans in, catching Catra's hand in two of hers and looking up into her eyes.

Just like she did on the ship. When she told me to do one good thing in my life. Catra's arm tenses, ready to thrash out of Glimmer's grip and escape.

"Catra." Glimmer pleads. "Don't run away. Please let me say this. That Catra is gone now! That Catra sacrificed herself to save her worst enemies! I can't forgive her, but I do forgive *you!*"

Catra blinks several times in shock, her mouth hanging open. "W-what..?"

Glimmer pulls her in and wraps her in a tight embrace. Catra can't even process it, she just lets herself collapse into Glimmer's soft, warm hug.

"I forgive you Catra. There are so many reasons I forgive you." Catra can hear the tears in Glimmer's voice. The two girls sink to the ground of the cave, and Catra awkwardly returns the embrace. Glimmer's tears turn to sobs, wracking her form under Catra's arms. Catra weeps too, but her body is too drained to manage anything more than silent teardrops from her eyes. She isn't sure what this makes her feel, but she's pretty sure it's good, in a weird way.

There's a moment there in the cave between the two. Catra's tears have stopped, and Glimmer's sadness has grown quieter. Catra just holds the other woman, one hand caressing her pink hair. Every so often she'll let out a "shh" or a weak purr to signal that everything will be okay. '*I'm really not good at this comforting thing…*' Catra thinks, but she continues nonetheless. Right now, her friend needs her.

"So…" Catra eventually says when Glimmer's sobs calm down. She awkwardly pats her on the back. "Do you think we can get back

before Adora and Arrow Boy notice we're gone? I could use a wash." Glimmer gives a laugh as she pulls away and smiles warmly at Catra. Catra gives a mischievous smirk. "Not to mention- people might talk if I emerge from the woods covered in glitter." She raises her eyebrows suggestively, and is rewarded with a brightly blushing Glimmer pushing a hand into her face.

"Nope! No more! Yes we're going back and you can get clean!" Catra licks Glimmer's hand, and the two collapse onto the floor in a pile of giggles, Melog prancing around them laughing in their own echoing chitters.

They roll up into a sitting position facing each other with smiles on their faces. Glimmer's expression turns from mirth to fondness, and she reaches out to touch Catra's cheek. Catra tenses, unfamiliar with this sort of intimacy from anyone but Adora. Glimmer just smiles and nods before pulling her hand away. Catra responds with a simple gesture of trust: a long, slow blink.

Glimmer breathes in and stands up. "Alright. I'm gonna teleport us back so… get ready."

"Nnnnngh." Catra growls and braces herself after standing up. "Do we have to??"

She reluctantly takes Glimmer's hand, and prepares for the world to flip.

Glimmer

Glimmer knew that Adora and Bow would have noticed their absence, so she's not necessarily surprised when she teleports into the hallway outside Adora's room and gets met by a very panicked blonde shouting and raising her fists.

"Aw, there goes the wash." Catra drawls.

"Catra! Glimmer!" Adora rushes in and scoops both of them off the ground in a big hug, earning squeaks of protest from both

women. She sets them down and turns over her shoulder, calling down the hallway, “BOW! BOW THEY'RE HERE!!”

Pattering footsteps echo down the hall, heralding Bow’s approach. Adora has already turned to Catra and started fussing with her hair, pulling twigs and bits of detritus out of her fur.

“Where were you! Catra you can’t keep running off like this. Last time you found Razz but what if Glimmer hadn’t gotten you! You could have gotten hurt!” Adora grabs Catra’s upper arms, provoking a wince and a slight hiss from the cat girl. Glimmer watches Adora go from frightened, to confused, to apologetic, to understanding, so sad in a second before Bow arrives and sweeps her into yet another airborne hug.

“GLIMMER!” He squeezes her tight before setting her down. “Are you alright? Did you run into anything dangerous? Or,” his tone changes, “did you see anything really cool?” Glimmer chuckles.

“You’re such a nerd.” She gets on tiptoes to kiss him, wrapping her arms around his neck and looking up into his sweet brown eyes. “I did see something really cool though. I saw a humanoid cat person and a shapeshifting alien!” Bow giggles, and she turns to smile at Catra and Adora, but sees that their mood is much less jovial. Adora looks crushed and Catra looks ashamed, trying to cover her arms and explain herself.

“-couldn’t help it… it just happens when I get upset.” She pleads.

“Catra… I know about that, I’m not upset about those… look at your hands…” Adora’s voice cracks as Catra looks at her hands. Glimmer saw them in the cave, but in the bright lighting of Bright Moon, the torn knuckles and ruined nails are highlighted.

“I know.” Catra says quietly. “I was hoping I could wash them off so you wouldn’t get upset.”

“What?? You don’t think that maybe hiding your injuries from me wouldn’t make me *more* upset??” Adora is starting to get worked up, and Glimmer sees Catra’s getting ready to retort.

Uh-uh. Today is not *the day for these two to fight.*

"Hey!" She says, her voice loud enough to echo slightly in the hallway. The two bickering lesbians turn to her, still looking angry. "Catra, Adora, come onnn. It's been a long day and I reeeeally just want to have a nice relaxing night with my best friends. Adora, Catra's sorry she ran away. It was my fault anyways." Catra opens her mouth to protest but Glimmer bulldozes over her. "And Catra, Adora is sorry for being angry, she just gets really worried when the people she cares about might be in trouble." She looks into Catra's eyes, trying to communicate nonverbally, 'I know it gets suffocating. She's working on it.'

Both of them look at each other and soften. Adora gently takes Catra's hand, carefully avoiding the raw areas at the tips of her fingers.

"Alright Glimmer. We're gonna go get Catra cleaned up, then we can have a sleepover tonight."

Glimmer smiles. "That would be nice…" Adora smiles back, and Catra grins.

Adora starts to leave, but Catra lingers a moment. "Hey, uh… thanks, Sparkles. It… what you said. What you did. Meant… a lot."

"Well, you mean a lot to me, Horde Scum." Glimmer says lovingly. Catra follows Adora, and Glimmer calls after them, "Don't mind the glitter Adora! It was nothing!"

"What!?" Adora practically squeaks, and Catra shoots a glare at Glimmer, her face bright red and angrier than she ever was when trying to kill them.

"I am going to kill you Sparkles!!" She shouts as Adora sees the telltale sparkles from Glimmer's cape and starts laughing uproariously. Catra huffs and stalks into their room, slamming the door behind her.

Glimmer grabs Bow, who is also blushing furiously from the interaction, and teleports to her room, leaving Adora cry laughing and begging Catra to let her in.

"So, what happened with Catra and you?" Bow asks after a moment's hesitation.

Glimmer sighs and teleports up to her old bed. They have a large bed on the floor now, since they're (*finally*) sharing a room, but the suspended one is just so much nicer for naps, or retreating to sulk when her responsibilities get too much. She lies on her stomach, with her arms and head dangling over the side looking down at Bow, who starts compulsively folding and putting away various sheets and clothes Glimmer has left strewn about. (Sometimes she does it just so he has something to do during conversations like this. She knows he appreciates it.)

"She found me in the koi garden," Glimmer starts, "and we talked for a bit, but then she asked about my mom. Turns out she didn't know what happened, and I kind of… blew up at her?" Glimmer sighs.

"Because of you." *I really said that, huh?*

"She ran off into the Woods, and I tried to find her… it took a while, but I caught up and talked to her about it. I told her I forgave her…" she pauses for a long while. Bow has sat down now, and is looking up at her, just waiting for her to let it out.

Stars, he's good. I lucked out with him.

"I said I forgive her and I know she deserves forgiveness, but what if I don't really forgive her? I think of bad Catra as a different person that I don't forgive, but doesn't that mean I don't actually forgive her?? I try to… rationalize, I guess, but Catra is still the person who did all those things, right? Hhhhhgh!" Glimmer flips over so she's sprawled on her back. "I don't know what to do…"

Bow breathes in and speaks. “Catra is a complicated person. So are you. So is Adora. We all are. Everyone is capable of great good and great evil. Just because you forgive someone doesn’t mean you have to forget what they did.” Glimmer hears the sound of Bow standing and walking up the floating platforms to join her. She turns her head miserably to look at him sit down beside her, and he speaks softly, but firmly. “I forgive you for activating the Heart,” (*uh oh. More tears*.) “and I forgive you for what you did before it. But I can’t forget it. I don’t *want* to forget it. It was something that led you to who you are now. If… If Catra hadn’t activated that portal. If there hadn’t been that massive terrible thing looming over her… do you think she ever would have changed? Or would she have just kept doing smaller bad things, never having a catalyst to really change?”

The question hangs above them for a while before they hear a knock on the door.

“Sparkles!! We’re gonna come in now!” The door swings open as first Catra, then Adora enter and look around the room.

“Hey, where are you?” Adora says, confused.

“We’re up here!” Bow calls out.

Catra smiles. “Awesome.” She hands a small box she was holding over to Adora and makes her way up, leaping from bedpost to cabinet to bookcase, then swinging on a crystal light fixture and landing on the opposite side of Glimmer from Bow, who gasps and sputters in protest at every movement. Glimmer giggles at his flustered expression, and sits up, scooting over so everyone will be able to occupy one corner of the bed.

Adora makes her way up the stairs, looking at Catra fondly, “You know there was no need for any of that.”

Catra licks the back of her hand casually. “Maybe, but I still beat you.” She responds smugly. Adora rolls her eyes and sets the box down in the middle of them. Opening it, Glimmer smiles at the

cake there. A glance at Catra's slightly blushing face and bashful smile confirms her suspicions.

The cake was Catra's idea. To make it my perfect day. Glimmer gives her a smile and a light punch to the upper arm. Catra gives an exaggerated groan. Glimmer laughs. "Thanks Catra."

"Whatever, Sparkles. Don't get a big head about it." Catra mutters, and Adora scoots closer to wrap an arm around her girlfriend.

Glimmer rests her head on Bow's shoulder and the four friends dig into the cake, chatting and joking happily.

'A really good end to a bad day.' Glimmer thinks, sharing a meaningful look with Catra.

Maybe I don't have to forgive her. But I still love her.

After a while, everyone drifts off to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Comments and kudos are always appreciated

The Head That Wears The Crown, Part 3: New Normal

Chapter Summary

In Which Bow and Glimmer discuss their relationship, and Glimmer begins a new chapter in her life.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow

Bow is the first to wake up, opening his eyes to greet the new day, and Glimmer, sprawled across the bed, with the covers tangled around her and an arm flopped haphazardly across his chest. He manages to excavate himself without waking her and stands beside the bed, stretching. Catra, Adora, and Melog had decided to sleep on the hanging bed last night (well, Catra decided to sleep on the hanging bed, and the other two followed), and Catra's tail is hanging off the edge, flicking back and forth adorably. Bow stifles a noise at the sight, and gets dressed. He heads out of the room and walks down the hall to get breakfast for everyone.

It's a beautiful morning. It rained during the night so the Whispering Woods are glittering with dew illuminated by the morning sun, like a reflection of the slowly fading stars above.

Man it's nice to have stars. It seems rather inconsequential compared to the other outcomes, but Bow has to be honest with himself; the return of the stars and the opening of a wider universe was a not insignificant reason why he could forgive Glimmer for activating the Heart of Etheria.

I forgave her because I love her. Bow hates that he has to remind himself of that. Of course he loves her. He's loved her for years.

But activating the Heart… and the way she acted leading up to it… *I wasn't sure if I could even be her friend anymore. Now we sleep in the same room and I still don't fully know what we are.*

Bow sighs as he enters the kitchens. The Best Friend Squad has grown so much more complicated, and he knows now that he isn't obligated to fix all their problems, but he still feels like he should.

I want to.

His thought is interrupted by a telltale twinkling behind him. He sees two guards startle to awkward attention and chuckles to himself.

"Hi, Glimmer." He says, turning around, holding a tray laden with breakfast food.

The Queen is quite a sight, wearing her pajamas, rumpled hair, half lidded eyes, and the most adorable possible scowl. She rubs one eye with a closed fist. "You left me." She pouts at him.

Bow immediately blushes furiously, and is grateful that no one but the guards seems to care about Glimmer's presence. "Ummm yes!" He says, a little loud and high, "I went to get breakfast for the four of us! For when Adora and Catra wake up from the slumber party! Ha." He looks around, a bead of sweat on his forehead. Glimmer looks tired and befuddled, the guards look at each other and shrug, and Netossa gives him a raised eyebrow. *Nobody suspects a thing.*

"Uggggh!" Glimmer growls and grabs Bow. He squeaks in dismay and keeps a death grip on the try to prevent anything from spilling when they return to the room.

Glimmer promptly returns to the bed and flops on her face, patting the empty spot beside her and growling. Bow smiles lovingly and places her meal on the bed beside her, and a glass of milk on the bedside table. He then ascends the floating stairs to the other bed, seeing Catra curled up against Adora's side, her

nose buried in Adora's neck and shoulder. Adora is stock still, her eyes wide open staring at the ceiling.

Bow cocks his head to the side, "Good morning Adora." He says quietly.

"Hey, Bow. I've been awake for an hour but Catra is still asleep." She says, explaining her current state. She raises her free arm and points towards the ceiling. "Did you know that those two archways intersect at a slightly different angle than those two?"

Bow looks up at the archways, which look identical to his eye. "Ummm, I know now! I brought breakfast." He hands the tray to Adora, who carefully grabs it and sets it on her torso and legs, before giving him a wide smile and a thumbs up.

Bow returns to his bed, where Glimmer is sitting up cross legged with a blanket wrapped around her, munching discontentedly on pancakes.

"Good morning beautiful." Bow says, smiling at her. Glimmer huffs in response. "Ready to greet the day?"

"Bowwwww" She groans, "I have meetings allll dayyyy. I'm so *not* ready to greet the day because the day is gonna be awfullllll."

Bow is unable to respond, on account of his insides absolutely melt upon hearing a little "mrrp?" from above him, followed by Adora whispering "wake up" and the sound of purrs.

He and Glimmer lock eyes and simultaneously squee at the sheer cuteness.

"Gah!" An exasperated shout comes from above them. "Adora! I am going to kill your friends."

"No! Don't! You're so warmmmmm" Adora cries.

There's a ruffling of fabric. "I may be warm but I'm not cute." Catra mutters mutinously.

Bow grins and turns back to Glimmer. Their friends' audible display of affection has brightened her spirits, and reminded Bow what he wanted to talk to her about. He speaks lowly, and is silently grateful to hear Adora and Catra start muttering and giggling at each other.

Not that I don't want them to hear, it just makes it easier to say.

"Hey, Glimmer?" She hums and looks up at him. He blushes and continues, "Are we, you know… dating? I mean I know we're together now but we haven't actually called it anything? Not that we have to put a label on it if you don't want to! It's only been a few days so… But, I mean, if you do…" He's started awkwardly rambling like Adora, and eventually Glimmer just puts a finger to his lips, her eyes filled with amusement and adoration.

"Yes, Bow. We're dating." She pecks him on the lips, then the chin, before burying her face in his chest and hugging him. "We're dating and you're my boyfriend and I love you."

Bow feelstears gather in his eyes as he wraps Glimmer in a big, warm hug. They hear the door open quietly, and he sees a tail vanishing through the exit. Adora and Catra let themselves out to give them some privacy.

Aww.. they didn't have to.

He looks back at Glimmer. *But it's definitely appreciated.*

Micah

King Micah watches as everyone filters out of the meeting hall.

Stars I miss war meetings. In war meetings, there was no bureaucracy, no tedium. Everyone was to the point and said what needed to be said. But these peacetime meetings drone on for hours longer than they should. He admires Glimmer's willingness to cut through it all. To impose her royal authority onto the

politicians. He tries to do that, settle into the role he played a lifetime ago, but he still doesn't feel entirely comfortable as king.

Why should they trust me? I nearly destroyed them all. Micah shivers at the thought. He still sometimes feels the pangs at the back of his neck from the chip, but it was worse for him than for many others. Prime had forced him to use dark magic. Glimmer had purged the poison from him, but he could still feel the intoxicating, draining power of it. Micah knows that if Prime had had him deployed on the front lines from the moment he was chipped, he likely could have wiped out the rebellion, maybe even She Ra.

I could have destroyed them all. The thought has been keeping him up for many nights.

He comes back to reality and looks around the room. It's mostly empty now. Glimmer has her head in her arms on the table, clearly exhausted. General Juliet is at the door, making sure everyone has left before closing it and turning back to the royals.

"Your Majesties." She says, formal as always. "We have an hour before Princess Scorpia and Princess Perfuma arrive. Are there any security concerns you would like me to address in the meantime?"

There's a pause, as Micah waits for Glimmer to speak, but she doesn't raise her head, so he goes ahead. "No, General, thank you. I think we could all use a break." He favors her with a smile, and although it's small, he sees her shoulders lose a bit of tension. *'She's of the same mind as me.'* He thinks, *'She misses the simplicity of wartime.'*

Juliet nods and exits the room. Micah sighs and allows himself to slouch back into his chair. He shoots up when he hears Glimmer speak, her voice muffled by her arms.

"Dad..?" She lifts her head and looks at him. "Was Chancellor Brannic always so awful?"

Micah practically guffaws at that. Brannic is the Chancellor of Bright Moon, a position akin to the mayors of smaller towns. He's well spoken to a fault, passive aggressive, and rather self important. He has a tendency to argue for the sake of arguing that doubles the length of any meeting he's in.

"Oh no." Micah says, still chuckling. "He used to be better in some ways, and much worse in others." Brannic had taken several steps back during the war, but now he's back full force. "Hah! He was way worse when he was trying to court your mother."

Glimmer shoots up and slams her hands on the table. "wHAT!?" She shouts, disbelief etched over every inch of her face. "That guy tried to get with *MOM*!?"

Micah laughs again. "Oh yes. They were together at some dance or other for an event. Watching Angie dance with *him* was the highlight of the evening." Micah remembers it fondly. Brannic has always been short, portly, and balding. Quite the contrast to Angella's towering elegance. Micah swooping in to 'save' Angella from her embarrassing date that night had been the beginning of their romance. "Brannic kept trying to convince her to 'bring the Royal and legislative branches closer together.'" Glimmer laughs at the impression of Brannic's deep, drawling voice. '*Gods, it's nice to make her laugh.*'"Of course, Angie never considered it for a moment."

"I'd hope not!" Glimmer says, still giggling. "Ughhh. I can't even imagine marrying a *politician. Blech*."

Micah gives a knowing smile, "Well I doubt you'll have to worry about that." Glimmer blushes and smiles sweetly. Micah breathes a small sigh of relief. He's had a hard time bonding with Glimmer, and he hasn't brought up her relationship yet, but that was a good reaction.

"No. I guess that's *one* problem with being Queen I won't have to worry about." She says, her energy deflating as she sinks into her hand, propped up on the table.

“Glimmer? What’s wrong?” Micah asks tentatively.

Glimmer sighs and looks at him, “I just… there’s so much to do! And I haven’t been Queen for long and I have to adjust to ruling, and lead Etheria out of war, and balance my personal life. I’m just one person. And I just…” Micah is dismayed to see tears starting to form. “I know I won’t be able to live up to mom…” She finishes quietly, wiping away the tears.

Micah pauses. “I know how you feel.” He smiles gently when Glimmer looks at him with a raised eyebrow of disbelief. “I do. I haven’t been King for 14 years, and even before that…” he chuckles sadly. “The bad part of having an immortal queen is that no one thinks to train the other members of the royal family how to rule.” He looks at the empty throne beside him, still stubbornly unclaimed by Glimmer. “We all thought she’d always be here. She was so strong, and she’s been such a constant throughout all of our lives. No one on Etheria can remember a time when she wasn’t on the throne of Bright Moon. We both have so much to live up to. But we don’t have to do it alone.” He reaches over and puts a hand in Glimmer’s shoulder. She smiles and rests a hand of her own. “We have each other. We have our friends. We have the Princess Alliance ready to jump in and help each other at every opportunity. And I know that if anyone can overcome this, it’s you Glimmer. I know I can’t be the father I wanted to be for you, but I need you to know that I am so very proud of you.” Glimmer starts crying now, and he leans across the chairs and hugs her father. Micah allows himself to push past the awkward barrier, and embrace his daughter.

He and Glimmer leave shortly after to get dinner. When the next meeting begins, they enter, and see everyone has taken their seats. The guards stand at attention as the two royals walk in. Micah sits in his tall throne, and sees Glimmer standing in the doorway, a conflict within showing in her eyes. He meets her gaze, and smiles.

Glimmer sets her jaw, and strides across the room, around the table, and takes her seat in the throne of the Queen.

“Alright. Let’s get started.” She says confidently.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, as always, kudos and comments with your reactions or questions are very much appreciated, I hope you enjoyed this arc, it focuses on Glimmer more than it does Catra, which I like about it.

Rose and Thorn, Part 1: A Morning in Plumeria

Chapter Summary

> In which the Best Friend Squad spends a day of relaxation in Plumeria, has some therapy with Perfuma, and everyone ships Scorfuma

Chapter Notes

> This arc has a bit extra for Bow compared to the original upload, as well as several other tweaks here and there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Perfuma

Perfuma's morning meditation goes uninterrupted. She's in her favorite sp0ot, a babbling, rocky creek that marks the divide between the Plumerian forest and the Whispering Woods. Every so often she will be interrupted by some magical beast, some more hostile than others, but she always sends them on their way peacefully.

Today is going to be good. Her friends are coming from Bright Moon, and Plumeria is going to have a festival to celebrate (Well, actually a festival to celebrate an obscure moon-phase-based harvest holiday from a hundred years ago, but who's asking?)

And Scorpia is coming too. She smiles. She likes Scorpia a lot. She's strong, kind, giving, considerate, good looking, and gives great hugs. There has, of course, been gossip about the two of them, but they're just friends.

For now.

Yes. For now. I did fight her during the war. Perhaps Adora may have some advice on dealing with that particular inner turmoil.

Perfuma smiles and shakes her head. She will deal with those thoughts when the time comes. In the meantime, she has a party to plan.

Catra

Catra is lounging against the doorway of the throne room, gazing out over the Bright Moon Lagoon. Melog is trotting around, their mane tinged slightly yellow, reflecting her own internalized anxiety about today. Glimmer said that they're going to go from kingdom to kingdom over the next few months to see if there's anything they can do to help. Catra knows that the real reason is that Glimmer wants to feel useful in person, instead of in a meeting room. She also knows from overheard conversations that they want to make Catra become friends with the other princesses.

Like that's ever gonna happen.

As her eyes scan the view ahead of her, she notices something. She takes a closer look and realizes what it is. She surprises herself by smiling slightly at it.

"Ready Horde Scum?"

"Bah!" Catra jumps as Glimmer teleports in behind her. The Queen giggles at the ruffled catgirl, and Catra grabs her tail to smooth it out. "Yes I'm ready, Sparkles. Ready as I'll ever be" She responds, muttering the last part.

"What were you looking at?" Glimmer asks, and Catra blanches.

She won't find it reassuring like you do. She'll yell at you and remember everything you did and kick you out. Just shut up.

She already remembers everything I did. She's my friend and I can talk to her.

"Just taking in the view, Sparkles." Catra says, adding on with fake begrudgement, "It's a nice one, I guess."

Not a lie, but not the whole truth.

Glimmer rolls her eyes at the obvious deflection. "Fine. Bow and Adora are waiting for us. Come on!" She holds out a hand.

"Wait, we're teleporting there??" Catra asks, her voice getting higher.

Glimmer laughs, "Of course we are. Why would we *walk* there? The walk to Plumeria *sucks*." The disgust in Glimmer's voice surprises Catra. She's clearly speaking from experience.

She did used to have to recharge her powers. Guess she didn't teleport as much back then.

"Ugh. Fine." Catra grabs Glimmer's hand, and braces as they teleport to a balcony where Adora and Bow are waiting. Adora rushes in to support Catra, but she waves her off. They're in Bright Moon still, so this one wasn't too bad.

Besides. I need to get used to it if we're gonna be going from kingdom to kingdom.

The next teleport is less pleasant. The sights and sounds and smells of Bright Moon vanish, and are replaced in an instant by earthy, natural smells and the sounds of a forest in the throes of waking up.

Catra lurches, and gladly leans into Adora's comforting embrace, reveling in her girlfriend's warmth and support for a bit longer than necessary, but who cares anyway? Straightening up, she steps away from Adora just a bit, brushing the back of Adora's knee with her tail as she does, and takes in the view.

Plumeria seems more like a camp than a city. Catra raises an eyebrow at the large number of tents, and the rather fragile look of the larger residences. There are no walls, or even

reinforcements, just trees and underbrush growing around the edges of the large clearing.

She wonders idly how the Horde never defeated Plumeria, and then remembers how absurdly powerful (and surprisingly violent) Perfuma is. Thinking back on what she's seen that woman do, she wonders if Scorpia's report of a building-sized plant golem a few years ago really was accurate.

She shakes the thought out of her mind and turns her eyes towards the largest tree, an ancient, gnarled mass of leaves and beautiful blooming flowers. At the massive base of the tree is the Heart Blossom, Plumeria's Rune Stone, wrapped up in the tree's roots like an embrace. The tree's roots spread out for dozens of feet beyond that, stretching even farther than its drooping canopy.

'*Wow*.' Is all Catra can think in response to the sight.

She realizes that people are starting to approach their group, and Glimmer and Bow start to walk forward. She anxiously takes a step behind Adora, not wanting to be recognized and accosted.

Glimmer and Bow are smiling and waving as they approach the crowd, and Catra sees them part as Perfuma rushes forward.

"Oh! Friends! Look everyone, the heroes of Etheria are here!" She cries, and closes the gap with her arms outstretched, embracing first Glimmer, then Bow. "It is a pleasure to welcome you back to Plumeria Queen Glimmer and Bow!" She steps away, all smiles and welcoming energy, and trots over to Adora. "And Adora! Everyone look! The She Ra is here!" She gives Adora a big hug.

Okay, getting a little handsy there, flower girl. Catra quickly gets possessive over Perfuma's hand quickly trailing up and down Adora's back before she breaks away. The thought is driven away by Perfuma closing in and pulling Catra into a hug as well. Catra stiffens, but leans into it. It's actually pretty nice to get this sort of affection from someone outside of her core friend group (*I am* not *calling us the 'Best Friend Squad'*).

“And Catra! We welcome you to Plumeria with open arms. I’ll have to give you a tour before we get to the festivities.” Perfuma says with an earnest smile.

“Festivities?” Catra and Adora say simultaneously with trepidation and excitement, respectively.

“Of course!” Perfuma says, with a giggly tone, “Festivities to celebrate the beginning of peace on Etheria! Now come on!” Perfuma spins around, her dress swooshing with her and the leaves on the ground stirring. Adora grabs Catra’s hand as the four of them follow Perfuma into the crowd. It’s pretty clear that the Perfuma’s desire to get a tour in ahead of the festivities isn’t going to happen. Gifts are immediately lavished upon them, Adora and Glimmer especially. Music starts to be played and the crowd drifts over to an area where tables are laden with all sorts of food. Perfuma crafts flower crowns for the four, and Catra gives her a grateful smile that hers is more conservative than those given to the other three. It’s certainly a sweet gesture, but flowers just aren’t Catra’s thing.

‘*Yet. Maybe I can change that*.’ She thinks with a smile as she watches Adora kneel down and let a faun child put a pretty blue flower behind her ear. Adora beams at the child, then, catching Catra’s eye, motions for her to come over.

Even earlier today Catra would have resisted, would have panicked and run away, not wanting to hurt anyone. But something about this place has put her more at ease than she has been in a long time. Maybe the calming freeform flute and drums, or maybe just the pleasantly earthy smells. Or maybe it’s just how at ease Adora is, and how welcoming everyone is. Catra walks over.

“This is Catra.” Adora tells the child with a smile. Catra gives a half cocked grin.

“Hey there. You having fun talking to the mighty She Ra?” Catra says, her heart racing way too much, worrying that she doesn’t

know how to talk to kids, worrying that she'll screw up and turn these criminally nice people against her.

But that doesn't happen. The child's face lights up. "Wait, this *is* the She Ra?? Wowwwww! I thought she just turned into the She Ra!" The child turns to Adora, "You are so cool!!! My name is Thurston, but my friends call me Thurby, so you can call me Thurby 'cause we're friends now." He nods affirmatively.

"Uhh, yeah! We're friends, heha. You get to tell everyone else that you're friends with the She Raa…" Adora says, clearly blustering. Catra bites her lip holding back a giggle.

Clearly I'm not the one who needs to worry about how to talk to kids.

"Hey, kid." She says, and Thurston turns to look at her, wide eyed. "Check this out." Melog senses her intent, and brushes up behind her. The coolness of their magic washes over her, rendering both of them invisible.

"Wooooooah!!" Catra revels in how wide Thurston's eyes get. She sneaks around him and uncloaks behind him.

"Boo."

"Ah!!" Thurston jumps a solid foot forward, tumbling into Adora, who catches him reflexively. Any fear immediately dissolves into an astonished gasp as Catra gives a mock bow.

"Ohmygosh that was soooo cooooool. Can you teach me how to do that?" He pushes out of Adora's arms and rushes to Catra.

"Sorry kid, can't go giving away my secrets to just anyone. Let's just say I've got a special friend who helps me out." Melog uncloaks behind her and walks around her legs to look Thurston in the eyes.

"Wow." Thurston is awed.

And sufficiently distracted.

"Psst. Hey Adora, wanna check out the food tables?"

Adora's face sparkles with utter delight. She lets out a long gasp before speaking. "You haven't had Plumerian festival food yet!! Come on let's go!!" She grabs Catra and yanks her to her feet. She lets out an alarmed squeak, but allows herself to be dragged to one of the tables.

Adora busies herself loading up a plate with all sorts of food, tossing on a bizarre mishmash of fruits and vegetables alongside pastries and candies. Catra smiles bemusedly.

Can't be all that different from the party food at Bright Moon.

It is very different from the party food at Bright Moon.

The pastries have a very husky, nutty undertaste to them. The candies are softer and all have a honeyed taste to them, compared to the more sugary sweets of Bright Moon. The fruits and veggies are fresher and come in a bit more narrow variety (*'No imported foods. They grow everything themselves.'*, thinks the logistical side of her).

And then there are the pies. Tiny personal fruit pies, about palm sized, in all different varieties. She and Adora sit down beneath a tree and spread out an array of about a dozen pies, dividing each of them in half to try.

Catra chooses apple pie as her favorite, while Adora goes back for seconds of the cherry pie (*too sweet for me*). Bow and Glimmer join them, soon followed by many other Plumerians.

Bow begins regaling the citizens with highly embellished tales of the heroics of She Ra and the Best Friend Squad. Catra blushes furiously when he tells them how she and Adora saved the universe with their love, though the Plumerians just give a collective "awwwww". She leans her head on Adora's shoulder and listens to Bow. He's a good storyteller. Even though she was there

for many of these stories, she's still drawn in by the many embellishments and straight up falsehoods woven in.

Scanning the crowd, she locks eyes with Perfuma, who is smiling altogether too sweetly at her and Adora, and blushes some more. She wills herself to push away from Adora, quelling the sad look that action provokes with a comforting brush of the tail against the back of the blonde's neck. She trots across the clearing to Perfuma, who smiles expectantly.

She's unexpectedly reticent to say what she came over to ask, so instead she asks, "Hey, uh, Perfuma. You wanna go ahead and give me that tour? I don't think Arrow Boy is gonna be done for a while yet." She adds with a sarcastic head tilt. Indeed, Bow has decided to go back to the beginning, and is telling his enraptured audience about when he and Glimmer first met Adora.

'Yeah. This isn't a part I want to stick around for anyways.' Catra's smile falters, but she's brought back to reality by Perfuma's response.

"Of course Catra! Follow me." She stands and turns.

Catra follows her away from the crowd and into a more central area. Perfuma speaks as she walks.

"We just left the aptly named celebration clearing, where most of our festivals are centered. I don't say our festivals are completely *contained* there because we have a tendency to… spread the party all over town." She lets out a strained hum after that, and then points to the sprawl of tents. "This is where people live. Most of our homesteads are simple yurts," (*so that's what they're called*) "because we like to live a simple life close to nature. The surrounding forest keeps us safe from most negative weather, and if we do get hit by a particularly bad storm, I can use my plant magic to shelter the dwellings under a dome."

Catra looks up, taking stock of what a large area that dome would have to cover. *'Stars she's powerful.'* She turns back to Perfuma.

Every new thing she learns makes her believe Scorpia's stories of giant plant golems more and more.

"What happens if you're not here?" Catra asks.

"The people of Plumeria are adaptable." Perfuma explains, "And we tend to keep relatively few worldly possessions. Most of our kingdom's population are nomadic. It's rare for this particular settlement to be so full."

Perfuma leads her to a small square in the midst of some yurts, and Catra stops dead upon entering it. In the middle of the clearing is a large statue, made entirely of plants, but shaped into pristine detail.

It's everyone. Adora as She Ra stands in front, proud and powerful, with her sword raised triumphantly in the air. Glimmer stands by her side, her hands ready and a big pink flower sprouting between them, clearly representing her magic. Frosta and Mermista are beside Glimmer, Frosta with her ice fists on. King Micah is behind his daughter, looking toward She Ra, and the pirate one (*Sea Hawk. Right? Is that really his actual name??*) is posing resplendently behind Mermista. To his side, Entrapta is held up on her massive pigtails, and a clear depiction of Wrong Hordak shadows her, carrying some bundles of cables trailing off the tech in her hands. Netossa and Spinnerella are embracing to their side. Bow is on She Ra's other side, an arrow nocked, ready for action. Scorpia is behind him, smiling and waving. Perfuma herself sits cross legged in front of Scorpia, and there, right to her side on the edge, Catra sees herself. She's half lounging, with her knee up and her tail wrapped around it, with a smirk on her face.

Perfuma turns to look at Catra, and smiles warmly at the open mouthed look of shock on her face. "It's a statue of Etheria's heroes." She says, "All the Princesses and their allies. I made it in our first celebration of the fall of Horde Prime."

Catra isn't sure why she's so moved by it, so she focuses on something else. "You made this? Like… from memory?"

Perfuma blushes and places a gentle hand on her mouth. "Well… yes! I have a good memory for faces, and an artistic mind."

Catra stars circling the statue, admiring the level of detail in each portrait, despite all being made of plants. "Wow… it's, um… it's good." She offers. Catra's not super solid on the whole compliment thing, being so used to sarcasm and undercutting people's achievements. It feels weird to just… tell someone that they did a good job. *'But good. Weird, but good.'*

Perfuma beams at the awkward complement, and surges forward to give Catra a warm embrace.

"Oh. Yup. Yeah…" Catra stammers awkwardly, and gives the taller woman a pat on the lower back. "So…" She says as Perfuma releases her. "Any other notable things?"

"Oh of course!"

Perfuma shows her many places around Plumeria, some genuinely impressive (a long tunnel made of plants grown in an archway, which Perfuma states has had no magical assistance, just very careful tending for decades), some eclectic (a waterfall going through a hole in a tree, which would be more impressive if the waterfall or the tree were larger), and some that Catra just doesn't get (a rock garden where people have just stacked rocks in different places). She follows Perfuma throughout and listens attentively.

Every so often they catch a glimpse of the party, and every time Catra attempts to catch Adora's eye. The first time, Adora is busy exasperatedly correcting Bow's storytelling. The second time, she sees Catra and excitedly smiles and waves, forgetting she's holding a glass and sending lemonade flying everywhere, provoking a guffaw from Catra.

Perfuma leads her to the massive Heart Blossom. Up close Catra gets a sense of how truly ancient and powerful this tree is. Her

tail drifts across one of the upraised roots and she gets a shiver from the Runestone's magic flowing through the wood.

"This is the Heart Blossom, the source of my magical powers." Perfuma is gesturing specifically to the glowing green Rune Stone embedded in the center of the tree, but Catra has a hard time looking at it without drifting off into…

"PRIME CASTS OUT ALL SHADOWS.
"PRIME CASTS OUT ALL SHADOWS.
"PRIME CASTS OUT ALL SHADOWS."

Spearing pain in the back of her neck. Shorn locks of hair falling to the white floor. Green lightning flowing through green water. Green eyes staring above a green grin.

Catra shivers. *'Green lights… guess that's another thing I'll have to avoid.'*

She instead turns her eyes to the branches of the tree. Up close she can see that they're covered in simplistic, but beautiful carvings. Carvings of history. Perfuma points out one that depicts the founding of Plumeria, and another that shows the first connection to the Heart Blossom.

"And this one depicts a prophecy, that the She Ra would return and save us from a great threat." Catra looks at it in awe.

"Huh. Guess that one came true in a lot of ways."

"Indeed it did. She saved us from ourselves."

"What?" Catra turns to Perfuma, utterly bewildered by that introspective statement. *Is this just how she always is?*

Perfume turns back, her voice somewhat soft. "We were apathetic because we had grown so reliant on other people to save us. The Horde was poisoning our land, poisoning the Heart Blossom. But Adora inspired us to fight for ourselves, and we joined the Rebellion. If she hadn't saved us from our own apathy, the Horde

would have destroyed Plumeria.” Her tone stays soft, and even at the last part it doesn’t fall into despair, still retaining that melodic joy in the back of everything she says.

She’d never admit it, but Catra finds Perfuma’s voice relaxing.

Speaking of…

“Hey… uh, Perfuma.” Catra takes her upper arm in her hand and looks towards the ground. Her tail is twitching, and she hopes Melog isn’t scaring someone by reflecting her emotions. “Um. You… said something about… meditations? Earlier?”

Perfuma instantly lights up. “Of course! After the party is done I’d love to have some guided meditations with all of you. Speaking of, we’re probably missed at the party.” She turns to walk back, but pauses first, giving the sweetest mischievous giggle, “I’m sure you are.” Before trotting away.

“Gah!” Catra says, trying to stifle the blush and the smile that crosses her face in response to that. She fast-walks back to the party, passing Perfuma with a playful shove.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! As always, I hope you enjoyed, and comments or kudos are appreciated.

Rose and Thorn, Part 2: Perfuma Therapy

Chapter Summary

In which Perfuma gives meditative therapy to the BFS

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

Adora loves Perfuma. Really, she does. Perfuma is sweet, considerate, kind, and funny. But meditation? Sitting still for hours on end with nothing to occupy her but her own breathing? Adora could think of few things worse than that.

Maybe there's like, a more punchy meditation. No… not with Perfuma. Maybe once Scorpia gets here I'll figure out something with her. I need sparring, not sitting.

Of course, she couldn't exactly say no (*why not, though?*), so now she's sitting on a flat stone in the middle of a clearing, several minutes early for her appointment with Perfuma.

Her nose is itchy.

Her leg is stiff.

There's a bug flying around her left ear.

A leaf just landed on her head.

There's a bump in the stone pressing right into her hip.

Adora is all over the place. She closes her eyes and hums loudly to try to drown out the thoughts, her tongue sticking partially out of her mouth.

“Adora?” An amused sounding voice comes from the opposite side of the clearing. Adora’s eyes snap open and she leaps to her feet, stumbling forward as she does.

“Perhuma!” Adora calls out, forgetting to put her tongue back in her mouth. Perfuma giggles.

“You’re early Adora. I see you were already trying some meditation techniques of your own.”

“Yes. Meditation. I was meditating and it felt…” Adora trails off before giving a strained smile and two thumbs up, “...So good… very… relaxing!” The word ‘relaxing’ comes out loud and strained.

Perfuma smiles and shakes her head, giving Adora a caring but ever so slightly condescending look.

“Adora. There are different techniques of meditation for different people. I didn’t think breathing exercises and introspection were going to work for you, so I brought an… alternate method.” Perfuma gestures behind her, and another figure emerges. It’s Cherrick, the buff blonde airhead guy. He’s carrying a large sack that Adora instantly recognizes as a punching bag.

“Punching meditation…” she whispers, awestruck. Cherrick slings the bag over a branch and ties it to the tree trunk before giving Adora an ‘OK’ gesture and walking off.

“Not *just* punching, but yes.” Perfuma says. “I know you’re most at ease when you’re active. I assumed that exercise would naturally be the most relaxing and focusing activity for you.”

Adora is bouncing up and down with excitement. She dives forward and wraps Perfuma in a hug, lifting the tall, slim woman off the ground. “Yes! Thank you! You were right, of course. You know me too well.” Adora rambles, laughing a little giddily before turning to the punching bag. Perfuma smiles wordlessly and holds out a pair of handwraps, which Adora takes and expertly tightens around her knuckles, enough to keep some mobility without

slipping off. She adopts a fighting stance, dancing from side to side, and starts to strike.

Perfuma got it right on the money. Once Adora gets in the swing of it, punching is indeed relaxing. Her thoughts weave into each other instead of cutting each other off. Her shoulders are tense not with worry, but just with readiness. She smiles.

"So, Adora," Perfuma speaks, and Adora pauses to listen, "You can keep on punching if you want, or, if there is anything you want to talk about, I am here to listen."

"Oh!" Adora thinks for a moment, "Well, um. I don't think I really have much that I need to talk about! Everything's going really great right now! The world is at peace, my friends are happy, Catra seems like she's doing great…" She's been interspersing her words with punches, but she falters now. "I mean… it feels kind of weird that she's doing so well. Like those first few days were really rough and now she keeps going back and forth between doing really good and doing really… not good." Adora scratches the back of her head self consciously. "I guess… I don't know. I'm worried about her. I'm always worried about her and- and I know it annoys her but… What if she's hiding how she's really feeling from me?? We grew up in the Fright Zone and we were always taught to hide our emotions and stuff and I know she's still in that mode but…" Adora lets out a slow 'pfffff' sound and sinks to the ground, turning towards Perfuma, who is sitting cross legged and patiently waiting for Adora to speak. Adora sighs heavily, then scoots over to one of the rocks to sit cross legged facing Perfuma. "Is it bad that I assume she's hiding it from me? I want her to be feeling just as good as she seems but… It feels too easy. I- I feel like I don't deserve it to be this easy." The last part comes out quietly, and it is followed by tears starting to fall from Adora's eyes.

Of all the things she expected to hear from the other side of the clearing, stifled, gentle laughter was not one of them. It snaps her out of crying as she looks up and wipes her face. "Are- are you

laughing at my insecurities?" She's too bewildered to even process it. Perfuma? Laughing at someone?

"No! No, I am sorry." Perfuma says, still smiling. '*She doesn't sound very sorry…*' "I just… That last sentence. Adora, who could possibly deserve ease more than you? You have saved the world how many times? Four? Was any of it easy? You gave up your way of life, turning away from the only world you ever knew because you found out it was wrong. You shouldered more responsibility in a few years than most people have in their entire lives. Adora. You deserve ease. Maybe Catra is hiding her feelings right now, or maybe not. But when the day comes where she isn't, where she's just as happy as she seems, you deserve to believe that. You deserve to enjoy that."

'*You deserve love too!*' Mara's voice echoes in Adora's head. She crosses the clearing and wraps Perfuma up in a more gentle hug, tears flowing again.

"Thank you." She whispers.

"You're welcome." Perfuma responds warmly. There's a slightly awkward pause after the two women part, and Perfuma rocks back and forth a bit before asking, "Adora?"

"Hmm?"

"I could use some advice from you, too. If that is alright."

Adora blinks in surprise, and quickly wipes the tears from her face. "Oh! Oh. You want- you need advice from *me?* Advice on what? Heh, advice on punching, cuz I can give you-"

"No, Adora. Not advice on punching. I suppose I misspoke saying advice, it's more… curiosity. How have you dealt with knowing you and Catra were once enemies?"

"Oh. Oh. Well I guess I- Waaaaait a minute." Adora folds her arms and raises an eyebrow, setting her face in a teasing smirk. "This is about Scorpia, isn't it?" She wiggles her eyebrows, and suppresses

a giggle at Perfuma's immediate blush. *I was crying in her arms a few seconds ago and now I'm teasing her? What a day.*

"No! Well, yes, but- not like that. We're just friends and I don't want it to be weird. She's staying in Plumeria and some people are not very happy about it, even if they know she's a princess now."

Adora's shoulders slump a little. *Clearly Perfuma's not ready to admit that yet.* "Yeah, I've got some advice for that." She starts pacing around the clearing and detailing ways she's been ingratiating the inhabitant of Bright Moon Castle to Catra's presence, and vice versa.

Bow

Bow is exhausted. The party was very nice, but it got much wilder and dragged on much longer than Perfuma anticipated, so several hours of what was supposed to be a nice, relaxing trip instead turned into a lot of energetic dancing and a lot of Bow telling stories.

'*I wish I brought my lute*' he thinks, not for the first time. He hasn't been able to practice for a while, and he's still way rougher on the lute than he is on the violin. But he's just been so busy trying to figure out ways to incorporate Prime's tech into Etheria… He and Entrapta came up with a system of teleporters between different kingdoms, but it's going to be very difficult to extract that tech from his ships.

Perfuma extended an offer for some one-on-one guided meditation with everyone, but Bow isn't sure what that will help. *I'm already pretty calm, and I'm happy with where I am right now. Then again, it's meditation, right? Not therapy. Just a chance to relax a little and let the world go by*. Bow nods. It does sound pretty nice. He checks on Glimmer, who is clocked out for a midday nap after eating too much at the party, and then steps out of their yurt and makes his way over to the meditation circle.

He looks around, admiring the natural beauty of this spot. The grass here is soft and springy, interspersed with moss in most places, and there are several flat rocks of different sizes in a circle around the center of the clearing. A rocky brook curves around half of it, and the trees provide nice shade. *This is probably my favorite spot in Plumeria.*

"Bow!" Perfuma enters the clearing and rushes forward, a big smile across her face. Bow matches her smile and energy instantly.

"Perfuma!" The pair embrace before pulling away, arms on each other's shoulders. "I feel like I haven't seen you at all today! We came to visit you in your kingdom and I've barely gotten to talk to you. How have you been?"

Perfuma smiles and moves to sit on one of the flat stones. Bow chooses one next to her and turns to face her. "I have been doing wonderfully, to be honest. A lot better than I expected given the circumstances of the past several months." She sighs, clearly thinking about the war against Horde Prime. "But the people of Plumeria are closer to each other than ever after all we've been through. And we've even gotten some new inhabitants!"

"Oh?" Bow asks, "Who are those?"

Perfuma smiles, looking quite pleased about the situation. "Some ex Horde soldiers to begin with, and some of the lost Horde Clones have made their way here as well. We're working on educating them. Wrong Hordak is a lot of help with that."

Bow nods. Wrong Hordak has been quite busy trying to rally his brothers into little communes across Etheria. After Prime's death, the clones had either gone completely insane, fled to parts unknown, or wandered around, impressionable blank slates like Wrong Hordak had been initially.

He looks at Perfuma, picking up that there's something she's leaving out. "And what about Scorpia?" He says, his voice

lowering conspiratorially.

Perfuma blushes. “What about her? She’s been a big help of course. She is staying here and making trips to the Fright Zone to try to figure out what the situation is over there. I’m helping her of course. The Fright Zone is *beautiful*.”

“Huh. Never thought I’d hear that.”

She giggles, “It really is. Whatever She Ra did to introduce all this new, magical plant life affected the Fright Zone too. All those jagged metal buildings are covered in beautiful plants.”

Bow smiles and shakes his head a little. “Weirdly, I can’t wait to visit the Fright Zone

After a few seconds, Perfuma turns towards him, clearly wanting to talk more. “What about you? How have you been, Bow?” She asks.

“I’ve been great!” Bow answers, “Glimmer and I are doing really well, and I’m so happy that we’ve finally taken this step in our relationship. I’m growing as a craftsman and I finally feel worthy of calling myself a tech master. Things are looking up for me.”

“What about your family?” Perfuma asks, “Are you spending more time with your parents?”

Bow’s heart sinks a little. He sighs and admits, “The truth is… I haven’t seen them in person since the war ended. I mean, we talk a lot more because I sent them both communicators but… I don’t know. We have a family event coming up and I know most of my brothers are going to be there but… I don’t know if I’m actually ready for that.”

“Why not?”

Bow shifts to a more comfortable position on his rock. “Well, the version of myself I’ve been presenting to my family for years… isn’t me. My dads know, and they’re so proud of me, but my

brothers… I just worry that they won't see me as their same little brother anymore."

Perfuma hums contemplatively, then posits, "But you are not. You have grown and matured in ways they cannot understand."

"Exactly!" Bow says, "But I don't know if I'm ready for them to see that."

"Well," Perfuma says evenly, "I think it's your decision to make. You do not have to show yourself if you are not yet ready to. But, on the other hand, I think it would be nice for you to see your family."

Bow nods, then stands up and walks over to Perfuma. He kneels down and gives her a warm hug. "Thanks, Perfuma, you're a true friend."

"You are too, Bow," Perfuma matches the hug. Bow breaks away and returns to his flat stone, "And hopefully this meditation can clear your mind and help you make those decisions. Now, close your eyes, and breathe in…"

Glimmer

Bow enters their shared yurt to be greeted by a gigantic yawn from the freshly awoken Glimmer. She had a bit too much candy and her stomach had been in a full scale revolt, but a nice nap has settled the internal conflict.

"Good afternoon sleepy-head." Bow says happily, going to one wall and unpinning the flap that covers a hole in the wall to serve as a window. Sunlight streams in and catches Glimmer right in the eyes.

"Bah!" She cries, and teleports to a different position. "Bowwwww! Watch where you're pointing that thing!"

Bow cocks his head and looks out the window. "You mean… The sun?"

"Yes!" She crosses her arms and pouts, her vision still spotty from the invasion of light.

"Alright, Alright. I'll be careful where I point… the sun." He stifles a laugh and walks over to Glimmer, sitting down and opening his arms. She gladly falls into a nice hug, letting out a contented hum. If she hadn't just woken up from one, she'd be happy to drift into a nice nap right now.

"How was your meditation with Perfuma?" She asks, closing her eyes and just listening to her boyfriend breathe and speak.

"It was great!" He responds. "We mostly just caught up and did some quiet meditation. She says that she and Scorpia are just friends, by the way."

Glimmer scoffs. "Pffft! Hyeah right!" She leans up into a sitting position. "Well *I'm* gonna go get the truth out of her." She stands up, dusting herself off. She leans down and kisses Bow on the forehead. "I love you." She says warmly.

Bow smiles. "Love you too. And go easy on her."

Glimmer rests a hand on her chest and feigns offense. "Bow! I am the picture of sensitivity and thoughtfulness. I wouldn't dream of pushing her on this sensitive subject!"

Bow rolls his eyes, "Of course." Glimmer huffs and teleports to the meditation clearing.

Perfuma, who was on the outskirts of the clearing, magically nurturing a small bent sapling, practically jumps out of her skin as the **POP tinkle** of Glimmer's magic is followed by a loud, "Hi Perfuma!!"

"Glimmer! Ha. It's good to see you. Are you ready for guided meditation?" She turns and walks to one of the stones, settling

into a meditative pose.

“Mayyyybe.” Glimmer says, her hands behind her back, bouncing on her heels. Perfuma opens an eye and looks at her in silence. Glimmer slouches. “Come onnnnn Perfuma! I never get to talk with anyone about stuff like this! Tell me about you and Scorpia!”

Perfuma’s eyes shoot open and she blushes. “Well- I- hmmmm. There’s not much to tell. We are good friends, she’s very nice and thoughtful, and I’ve been helping her in the Fright Zone.”

“Uggh!” Glimmer stomps over and plops down in front of Perfuma. “I know there’s more between you two. Scorpia obviously likes you! And no offense but you’re not doing a great job hiding that you like her too.” Perfuma smiles despite herself, before blushing furiously at the last sentence.

“Hmmmmm. I think we should get to our guided meditations.”

“Ugh.” Glimmer growls, but is secretly satisfied. She got all she needed, and Perfuma’s eagerness to change the subject is plenty telling on its own. She teleports to one of the flat stones near the brook and settles into a meditative stance. She can’t quite get the classic feet-on-knees pose, so she settles for simple criss cross applesauce.

Perfuma’s voice comes from across the clearing, warm and soft. She speaks slowly, “Now, breath in… and breathe out. Feel the energy of the world around you flow in and reinvigorate yourself. Let the barriers around you fall, and feel yourself become one with nature.”

Glimmer does so. It’s surprisingly easy to relax here. She doesn’t quite feel herself ‘become one with nature’, but she does feel more open.

“Now, let your thoughts flow freely. Break the dam within your mind. If you want to speak them aloud, I am here to listen. If you don’t want to say it aloud, that is fine too. If you want me to leave, I can leave.”

"No, I'm fine if you stay." Glimmer closes her eyes and concentrates on her thoughts. Thinking about her thoughts, there are a lot more of them than she thought, many of them less pleasant than she may like. '*But that's the point, isn't it?*'

"I guess I have a lot of thoughts…" She begins, "Right now they're pretty simple. It's a nice day, this meditation is nice, I hope you and Scorpia get together," She smiles at the somewhat strangled hum that elicits, "I'm really happy to be with Bow right now, and I'm happy Adorable and Capra have each other… Though I wish we could do more things as a group sometimes… I mean I know we're both couples now but, ugh. I miss Adora sometimes. And I- I'm still having a bit of a hard time with Catra. It feels like she can't decide whether she wants to only think about her past or just… I dunno, pretend it doesn't exist? I don't want to make her feel like she has to put on a facade for us, I guess."

"Hmmmm…" Perfuma ponders for a moment. "Adora was worried about the same thing with Catra. I think it might help her if you took the initiative and invited her to be herself more often."

"I try!" Glimmer protests, forgetting the meditation for a moment and looking over at Perfuma. "But I just feel like she's never comfortable around us, and I don't know where she would be comfortable. And she keeps talking about needing to 'make up for what she did', but I'm really worried that that won't go well…" Glimmer sighs. "We're going to Salineas next week and I know Mermista isn't nearly as forgiving as most of us are. And…" She swallows hard at this thought, "and some stupid, selfish part of me doesn't want to lose any friends because of Catra…"

Perfuma hums in acknowledgement. "I think your concerns about losing friends because of Catra are valid, but I also think that maybe if they're willing to drop your friendship over someone else, then maybe they don't deserve it to begin with."

"I guess so…" Glimmer says, a little doubtfully. '*If they stuck with me while I was listening to Shadow Weaver, they'd better stick by me with Catra.*' "Yeah. Yeah! You're right. My friends are my

friends, and they don't get to dictate that to me. I'm the *Queen*. I get to decide who my friends are." It feels good to say, though she does giggle at herself a little over the trivial assertation of her queenly authority.

Perfuma readies a response, but they both hear a distant, "HEY EVERYONE, I'M HERE!!"

Perfuma's eyes light up at hearing Scorpia's voice, and she stands up rather fast, stumbling out of her meditative sitting position. Glimmer gives her a knowing look and she waves a hand at her. "Oh hush, you." Perfuma says, and strides out of the clearing. Glimmer grins and teleports out, ready to catch up with Scorpia.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Comments and kudos are always appreciated, hope you enjoyed!

Rose and Thorn, Part 3: Scorpia and Perfuma

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra gets her therapy/meditation session with Perfuma and unloads about her past mistakes, and Scorfuma sails.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia

Scorpia arrives just after 4 in the afternoon, pulling her brightly painted skiff into its usual spot on the outskirts of Plumeria and hopping off, followed by Emily. She takes a nice, deep breath of that fresh Plumerian air and smiles broadly. It's a beautiful day, she's in a beautiful place, and she's about to see her best friends for the first time in weeks. *'Well, the first time that isn't in a board room because that doesn't count as hanging out.'*

And she'll get to hang out with Perfuma.

Not that she doesn't hang out with Perfuma a lot already but it's still nice. Especially after spending so much time in the Fright Zone… having to think about all the things that have to get done there… It'll be good to just unwind.

"Hey Scorpia!"

"Hey Cherrick! How's it goin'?" She calls back, pointing with her pincers.

"Oh you know… Takin life one life at a time." He nods and closes his eyes as if the thing he just said made any sense at all.

"Haha! Sure!" Scorpia just goes with it. Cherrick is just like that sometimes… most times. All the time.

Scorpia strides through the trees and yurts with a pep in her step.

Today will be a good day.

'Could have been a great day…' She pushes that thought down. With their friends over, it wasn't a good time. Emily bumps into her as she's stopped walking.

"Ope! Sorry there Emily, got lost in thought, you know?" Emily cocks her body and beeps in response.

"I know, I know. But plans change, right? I mean that's the whole point of plans. Honestly I think it's just not the right time, ya know? It's still pretty early, and our friends are here and I don't wanna make things weird while I'm still kinda living in Plumeria." Emily lets out a coo and pushes past Scorpia, walking onward. Scorpia sighs. Emily is weirdly emotive for a robot, and right now she's pretty clearly annoyed. '*Ah well, I'm sure she'll be happy to see everyone.'*

She enters the main square of Plumeria and finds it surprisingly empty, though the clear remains of a celebration are strewn about.

"Huh. Guess we missed the party." Scorpia looks at Emily, who pokes at a discarded conical paper hat and beeps sadly. "Ah it's okay girl, we can bring our own party." She takes a deep breath in and raises her pincers to her face, shouting, "HEY EVERYONE, I'M HERE!!" She puts her pincers on her hips and waits, then realizes, and raises them again to clarify, "IT'S SCORPIA BY THE WAY!"

"Hey Scorpia!" Bow is rushing out from between some yurts, and she charges to wrap him up in a big hug once he arrives.

"Bow!! How are you? How's Glimmer? Where are Catra and Adora? Are they here? Am I too late for the party? Oh yeah, Emily's here too." Emily pushes past Scorpia and nudges Bow. She's quite the affectionate bot.

“Scorpia!” Glimmer teleports into view, and then immediately teleports into a hug, clinging to Scorpia’s side. “Catra’s napping and Adora is waking her up.”

“Oh, it’s fine. How’s… uh… How’s queen-ing been going?”

“Ugh. What about you? How’s princess-ing been going?” Glimmer has dropped off and the three are now walking over to a picnic table.

“Oh, it’s been hit and miss, ya know? Some of the old Horde Soldiers aren’t really happy with all the changes we’re talking about with the Fright Zone, but Perfuma has been really helpful with it, as have you guys at Bright Moon. Oh! Please thank Castaspella for sending Fygan, he has been a great help with figuring out how to use the Black Garnet’s powers.”

Glimmer nods, “I’ll pass it along.”

“Hey, Scorpia.” A low, raspy voice comes from across the clearing, and Scorpia swivels her head around to see Adora and Catra striding forward, hand in hand.

‘They’re so happy together. I hope I didn’t stand in the way of that…’

As they get closer, Emily beeps and relocates to the other side of the table, away from Catra, and the feline woman stops in her tracks, eyes wide at the bot.

“Catra? Are you okay?” Adora immediately asks, her other hand resting on Catra’s now.

“I-“ Catra’s words are choked. Scorpia attempts to come to the rescue.

“Hey! It’s okay. Emily, come here. Catra won’t hurt you, she’s good now, okay? Why don’t you come out and actually meet her? I promise I’ll keep you safe.” She turns to look at Catra, whose

face is somewhat contorted. “Catra, is that okay with you?” Catra nods, and lets go of Adora’s hands and kneels to the ground.

Emily hesitates, and Bow, sitting in front of her, puts a hand on her dome. “It’s okay Emily. Catra’s our friend, and you’re our friend too.”

The robot hesitantly steps out from behind the table. Catra cringes as the score marks on her hull are exposed. Emily cautiously approaches Catra, who gently holds out a hand, palm up. Slowly, the robot lets itself walk into the hand.

Scorpia watches all of this with bated breath and twinkling eyes, and when the two touch, she can’t hold back the waterworks. “Oh you guys!!” She rushes in and grabs Emily in a hug, though she can’t quite wrap her arms around the spherical bot. Emily beeps happily, and upon being set down, nuzzles against Catra, who cautiously, and somewhat confusedly, reaches out a hand and rubs the top of the sphere.

“Uh, good girl?” She flounders, looking up at Scorpia and smiling before standing up. Scorpia’s instinct is to grab her in a hug, but she’s been working on not doing that to people who don’t want it. Catra clearly sees the internal struggle and smiles. “Oh just hug me you softie. I haven’t seen you in weeks.”

Scorpia needs no further encouragement, grabbing Catra in a big, warm hug. A distorted mewl catches her attention, and she sees Melog, Catra’s strange alien cat, pacing around her legs. She releases Catra and squats down. “Hey there little guy… uh, girl, uh…” She looks to Catra for clarification, but only receives an amused shrug.

“Your guess is as good as mine.” She says, “I think neither.” Melog mewls affirmatively.

“Alrighty then, hey there little Melog. Have you met Emily?” The robot bleeps, and the shapeshifter trots over, shifting their form until they are closer to Emily’s size. Their mane is mostly blue,

with shades of purple and yellow sparking occasionally. They nuzzle against Emily and let out an echoing purr.

"Oh good, our robot and alien have met." Catra remarks. "So, Scorpia, you torn apart the Fright Zone yet? Or are you leaving some for the rest of us?"

"Oh well, uh… Actually we're planning on leaving it mostly intact."

Bow blinks in surprise. "Really? Scorpia, you want your kingdom to look like… like *that?*"

"Yeah, I didn't think the Fright Zone was really your aesthetic." Glimmer adds.

Scorpia waves a pincer and scratches the back of her neck with the other one. "Oh well it's not really about that, it's more about practicality. It would take too long to take it all apart, so we're just remodeling instead. Ya know, taking away a lot of the more spiky bits, making it all cleaner, et cetera."

"I think it's going to look beautiful when we're done." Perfuma has arrived, striding lightly across the field. "I have been working on giving each building its own garden, since there is not much ground space for sustainable farming." She joins the five of them (Emily and Melog are playing a little ways off) and smiles at Scorpia.

"Hey, hi Perfuma! You look great. Did you uh… Did you do something with your hair?" '*It's okay. You talk to Perfuma all the time. It's fine. Don't make it weird. Not like you did with Catra.*' Bow and Glimmer quietly giggle at the awkwardness.

"No, I didn't do anything different, but thank you Scorpia." Perfuma is blushing, and holding herself a little awkwardly. As if to distract from it, she waves her hand, and flower crowns appear on everyone's heads.

Bow giggles at Catra's, but she's too busy looking at Adora, adjusting the crown on her head. "Hey Adora," She says, pointing

to it, "Does this make me a princess now?"

Adora giggles and nudges her with an elbow. '*How do they make it look so easy?*'

"Oh! Perfuma, I got you something!" Perfuma looks up at Scorpia with an expectant smile. Scorpia spins around, looking for it, then remembers, "Oh! It's at the skiff, I'll uh, I'll be right back. Don't go anywhere!" And she's off, vaguely cognizant of Perfuma saying she could come with, but Scorpia is too far off now.

"Come on Scorpia. It's just a gift for a friend. It's not even a big thing, just something you found that made you think of her. Not in a romantic way! Just reminded you of her." She mutters to herself as she fastwalks to the skiff. '*And when you give it to her you'll get to see her pretty face light up with a smile, and she'll probably hug you and give you flowers…*' "Focus!" She smacks herself with a pincer. She reaches the skiff and opens the cargo compartment, gingerly grabbing the little box inside, and turning back to the group. She stops, and breathes for a moment. "Yeah… I need to talk to someone about this…"

Catra

Catra's wandered off from the group, needing to stretch her legs a bit and wondering what's taken Scorpia so long. She passes a few trees when:

"Catra!"

"What? MREOP!" A deep red pincer emerges from the bushes, grabs her, and yanks her in. She sprawls into a small hollow between two trees where Scorpia is sitting cross legged, with her tail wrapped around her. Catra springs onto all fours, her hair poofed out, bouncing to the opposite side of the hollow as Scorpia. "Scorpia! A little warning, next time? What is it? What's taken you so long?" She's a little snappy, and instantly feels guilty given who she's talking to. '*But not too guilty. She did just grab me and practically hurl me into a bush*.'

“Catra. I need your help.” Those dark eyes are full of pleading, and an expression that makes Catra somewhat wary.

“Uh… With what? Finding a better hiding spot?” She tries to ease the (*mostly one sided*) tension with a joke.

“Aw man is this a bad one? Wait- no. That’s not it. It’s…” She blushes. “It’s about Perfuma.

‘*Oh no*.’ “Oh. Uhhhhh… yeah um Scorpia? I’m probably not the best person to get help from with this…” She curls in on herself. “I’m pretty sure I know what you need and, well… you saw what happened because I didn’t know how to tell Adora what I felt.” There’s a pregnant pause as Scorpia processes that, and Catra thinks it through. “Hey, Scorpia.” She starts again, trying to inject some Perfuma-style cheer into her voice. “I’m doing meditation with Perfuma soon, but I’ll think about it, and I’ll give you my very professional advice afterwards, ‘kay?”

“Oh! You’re doing meditations with Perfuma? Ha, that is great. She’s a really good listener.” Scorpia nods. “Alright, I’ll see and talk to you later, you’d better get to your meditation then, I’ll probably hang out with the others. I’m sure we could find something to occupy us.”

Catra chuckles. ‘*Knowing Adora, you’ll probably wind up saving something from some great threat*.’ “Alright. See you then.” She stands and exits the little nook, heading back to the clearing.

Perfuma is pacing by the time she gets back. *Not a good sign.* She turns excitedly, and her face falls upon seeing Catra is alone.

“Wow Perfuma, you look more excited to see me than Adora.” (*Patently untrue even if Perfuma didn’t look downcast. No one could conceivably be happier to see Catra than Adora. Even at that sarcastic comment her girlfriend looks disbelieving*.) “Don't worry. Scorpia’s still here. She just has a surprise for you that requires a bit of set up.” Catra swaggers to Adora and drags her tail across her wrist. She lets the smug, teasing air drop a bit.

“Hey. I’m ready to do that meditation now, if you want.” The last part is rushed. She doesn’t want Perfuma to say no, and is rewarded with a wide smile on that tan, freckled face.

“Of course Catra, follow me.” She motions for Catra to follow.

She places a quick peck on Adora’s cheek and winks at Bow, mouthing ‘Scorpia.’ And cocking her head towards Scorpia’s hiding spot. He smiles and gives a stiff armed thumbs up and starts side shuffling towards it.

The meditation clearing is a very pleasant place. Catra chooses a stone far enough away from the creek that instead of causing anxiety, the sound fades into the background. Perfuma chooses a spot on the opposite side of the clearing and sits, smiling at Catra, who awkwardly shuffles and gives a strange half smile.

“I am glad you decided to give this a try Catra, I think letting yourself be open is a very important step.”

“Yeah… let’s just get started before I change my mind.” She’s already starting to reconsider, despite herself. *This is a good thing. You need to do this. For Adora’s sake, alright?*

Perfuma gives an understanding nod. “Now, sit like me if you can, with your legs crossed and your feet settled on your knees, your back straight and your arms rested on your legs. This helps open your energy pathways and makes you a conduit for positive vibes to flow through you.”

Catra adjusts herself. The position is fairly easy for someone as flexible as her. She doesn’t feel any energy pathways open within her, but she didn’t really expect to. *Even if it’s real, I’m not gonna feel it like Perfuma does. I’m not good like her*.

“Now, the first step is to keep your breathing measured. You are going to breathe in for five counts, and out for eight counts. You get to decide how long each count is, but it is best to keep it slow. When you breathe in, you are bringing all the positive energy of the world around you inside. When you breathe out, you’re

releasing the negative energy you keep pent up inside you. Let's try just breathing for a few minutes. Close your eyes, and think of the good things you want, and let go of the bad things you have."

"Okay…" Catra closes her eyes and starts breathing slowly. For a little while, she doesn't really think of anything, but as it goes on, the peaceful, still air and ambient noise begins to bring some thoughts to the forefront.

Breathe in… *Adora.*

Breathe out… *The Horde.*

Breathe in… *Real friends.*

Breathe out… *Lies.*

Breathe in… *Kindness.*

Breathe out… *Hurting people.*

Breathe in… *Sunlight.*

Breathe out… *Shadow Weaver.*

She's faintly conscious of a presence behind her, Melog having joined them to keep a protective eye on her, but she keeps breathing.

Breathe in… *Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia.*

Breathe out… *Prime.*

Breathe in… *Plumeria, Bright Moon, comfort.*

Breathe out… *The Fright Zone.*

Breathe in… *Jokes.*

Breathe out… *Cruelty*

Breathe in… *Peace*.

Breathe out… *War.*

Catra isn't sure how much this could change things in the long run, but being forced to come up with one good thing for every bad thing is really helping. *I didn't realize how many good things I had.*

Perfuma speaks. "Now, Catra, would you like to talk about some of the things you've been thinking of? If not, you don't have to, but it is helpful to let people know what you are thinking."

Catra thinks for a beat before responding. "Yeah… yeah. It's okay, I- I can talk about it." She takes a deep breath, not meditative, just preparing herself to be open. "I guess it's nice to think of the nice things I have. Things I didn't even realize. I'm… grateful, I guess. I got a second chance, and I've got a nicer life now than I deserve." Perfuma lets out a noise in response, but doesn't try to argue. "I knew there were a lot of bad things… More than I could really think of. I mean… There's Shadow Weaver and Prime and Hordak… There's how awful I was… I dunno. I guess I'm just really glad I'm getting all these good things but." She sighs, and lets out a slight raspberry. "It doesn't feel real a lot of the time. I feel like any day I'm gonna wake up and I'll be back in the Horde, with Shadow Weaver looming over me. Ruining me." She adds quietly. Melog bumps against her side to steady her.

"Catra, I have a question for you, and this is a little off topic but I think it's important. Adora told me that she tried to get you to join the Rebellion a few times. Why didn't you?"

Catra thinks for a long while. Even now she still thinks of it as Adora leaving her, choosing the Rebellion over her. But Adora *did* give her so many chances to join. She rationalized for so long…

"There were a lot of reasons." She begins. "I guess…" She starts rubbing her arm, "I was jealous… and hurt. She left the Horde when she saw strangers getting hurt… So why didn't she leave

when she saw me getting hurt?" Her voice is quiet. She's never said that out loud. Not even to herself. Why'd she just open up to Perfuma about that? "Shadow Weaver treated everyone like crap… why didn't she realize it? Why would I go with her to help strangers when she…" She trails off, not wanting to finish the sentence. '*When she didn't want to help me?*'

"I see," Perfuma pauses, "And do you still feel that way?"

"No!" Catra's eyes snap open and she leans forward. "No, I know it's my fault I didn't go with her. I made my choices. I'm living with them. I accept that now." '*Do I?*'

"Saying that it was all your fault is just as damaging as saying it was all Adora's fault." Perfuma responds. "You have to take a step back from your guilt, and try to examine what happened from both sides."

Catra thinks on that for a while. "I guess…" She starts, then trails off. '*So many memories…*' She thinks, '*most of them bad…*' "Adora was Shadow Weaver's favorite." She begins, "Always was. But she acted like she wasn't. I guess… Adora was the only person in the Fright Zone who was ever kind or good to me, and she was so good to me almost all the time, right? But… She didn't really defend me much from Shadow Weaver. Or anyone, really. I fended for myself, and got rewarded with kindness. Whenever Shadow Weaver would call me lazy, Adora could come in and tell me to work harder. And I don't really hold that against her anymore. It's how she was pretty much molded to think, and she couldn't break free of her mold for a long long time. When she left to look for the sword… That night… I wanted to go with her. I tried to go with her, but she told me to stay! Said she, 'didn't want me to get in trouble on her behalf.' Ha! And then Shadow Weaver started punishing me when she found out Adora was missing.

"When I went to Thaymoor… when it all went down… I felt so messed up. I thought that, somehow, the princesses had stolen my best friend and- and ruined her! But then, over the next few months as I started taking on more and more responsibility, it felt

like a blessing in a messed up way. Hordak thought I was valuable, and I was doing a better job than Shadow Weaver, and all of it was because Adora wasn't there. I felt like I was free, like I was finally done being her sidekick. Then Adora and I got trapped inside the Beacon together. We worked together a bit and I really did think about just leaving it all behind for a bit. Then that... AI thing showed me a bunch of really messed up visions of our past. Things that… made me hate Adora even more." Catra pauses there, shivering at the memory of what she did next.

"Bye Adora! I really am going to miss you."

"After that… I just rode on the high of freedom for a long time. But it didn't really matter, because I was alone. And we were really enemies then. She didn't try to convert me, and I never even thought about leaving. And every time we'd fight, I'd lose, which just made me angrier and angrier. And then…" She trails off, and closes in on herself.

"And then?" Perfuma nudges gently. Her tone is clear, telling Catra that she doesn't have to say it if she really doesn't want to, but it will be good for her.

Catra gulps. She never talks about the portal, and it's gotten even harder now that she knows exactly what price it really took to stop it. "In the portal… everyone got to see their perfect world for a while. Mine… wasn't what I was expecting. Instead of ruling the world, I was just back in the Fright Zone. Back to playing second fiddle to Adora. But now: she defends me. I'm not her sidekick, I'm her partner! It didn't are sense to me that I could possibly want to just be happy with Adora, so when things broke down… so did I."

Catra sighs. "I never joined Adora because I felt free, which was all I ever wanted. But I couldn't have freedom and Adora, and that made me so, so *angry*. And I took that anger out on Adora, and Scorpia, and the Rebellion, and everyone." Catra lets her head hang back as she lets out a growling, exasperated breath to the

sky. “Stars, things would have been so much better if I had just gone with her.”

That smooth, calming voice from the other side of the clearing answers, “But you didn’t. And things are pretty good now, wouldn’t you say?”

Catra brings her head down, and thinks of how much fun she’s had in just the past month with Adora and her best friends. More unadulterated joy than she’d felt in her life, with no Shadow Weaver or Hordak or war looming over her.

“Yeah. Yeah they are.” Catra acknowledges, “And… thanks. It did help to kinda… lay it all out. It wasn’t all my fault, and it definitely wasn’t all Adora’s fault, but it did happen, and the best thing I can do is just keep going.”

Perfuma is smiling. She rises and crosses the circle to Catra and sits down in front of her, reaching out and taking her hands. “Thank you Catra. Thank you for being open with me. If you want to stay and continue with this meditation, you can. If not, you can go help Scorpia set up her ‘surprise’.” Catra smiles at Perfuma. “You’ve made so much progress in even these few weeks, and from what I’ve seen, you’ve made it on your own. I’m very proud to know you.”

Catra feels tears start to fall at that. “I haven’t done it all alone…” She responds, not meeting Perfuma’s eyes at first. “I’ve had Adora… and Sparkles and Arrow Boy… I’ve had Melog, who’s been amazing…” Now she meets Perfuma’s sparkling eyes. “I’ve had you…” Perfuma smiles with more warmth than Catra thought possible. She lets the moment sit for a minute before adding, “And I also had this crazy old lady in the woods who made me climb a tree as therapy. That helped a lot.” Perfuma giggles, and Catra smiles. ‘*It feels so nice to make people laugh…*’

Catra’s ears perk up. “Hey… Is- is that music?” Both of them stand up, and Perfuma smiles.

“I think they restarted the party without us, Catra.”

“I think they did!” Catra says with mock offense, and starts to walk out of the clearing.

“Catra, one last thing.” She turns to look at Perfuma. “Did this help? Do you feel like your mind and soul are in a more peaceful harmony?”

“Yeah… yeah. I do. Um… thanks, Perfuma. I think- I think I’d like to try this again. Maybe not always the talking but…”

“I understand.” Perfuma nods sagely, and holds her hand together, then she hums and starts vibrating excitedly before lunging in and hugging Catra. “I’m so happy to have helped, and I will be happier to continue! Next time we can start yoga lessons!”

Catra extricates herself from the flower princess’s grip “Oh-kay, one thing at a time, heheh. Let’s go crash their party.”

Catra runs ahead of Perfuma. She has to talk to Scorpia first.

Adora

Plumeria throws the best parties. It’s just a fact. Adora used to think that Elberon did but no. Definitely Plumeria. The Best Friend Squad decided to stay the night just to enjoy their time for a little longer. So the next day goes by in steady celebration. The highlight comes when all four of them are standing together, joking and laughing about Cherrick getting stuck in a tree, and Adora looks to her side and sees Perfuma guiding two Plumerian citizens in, holding…

“Us cake!!” Adora cries, dropping her drink and grabbing Bow’s face to turn him towards it. He gasps and grabs Adora’s hands, flattening them to his cheeks.

“US CAKE!!” He and Adora cry in unison. The cake is a flat, single layer cake, with raised portraits on top of each of the four of

them.

“Best. Party. Ever.” Bow proclaims. Catra and Glimmer look at each other. Catra rolls her eyes and gives a ‘pfft’ sound and Glimmer rolls her eyes.

Adora grabs Bow and Catra’s hands and makes a beeline for the cake, Glimmer dragging along by Bow.

“Ah! Adora. Would the She Ra do us the honor of cutting this celebratory cake?” Perfuma asks, certainly knowing the answer already.

Adora moves her mouth without sound for a moment.

“Breathe, Adora.” Catra says, chuckling at her disaster of a girlfriend.

Adora closes her mouth and grins. She raises a hand to the sky.

“For the honor… of GRAYSKULL!!”

After a few minutes, Adora bashfully backs away, accepting that a magical sword may not be the best cake cutting implement. She cringes at the grisly decapitation she inflicted upon Bow’s picture. *Ah well, it’ll still taste good*. Plus it’s always nice to give the people some She Ra attention. But looking around, she doesn’t immediately see Catra. She has to turn her gaze to the edge of the clearing, where she raises an eyebrow to see her girlfriend on all fours, nose in the air, heading towards a garden plot. She gets there, and finds a plant with triangular leaves that she immediately faceplants into. Adora puts a hand to her mouth to stifle a giggle, then walks over to examine the strange behavior.

Bow

“Catra!!” He calls out, sounding very tired, “Please come down!”

From the thick boughs of the tree comes a petulant, "No. Adora's mean to me!"

Bow facepalms. During the party Catra had gotten into a small garden that Perfuma informed them contained catnip, and had gone through several distinct phases. At first she just seemed a little loopy, very giggly and affectionate and distinctly unlike Catra. Rather quickly, that changed to hyperactivity, running at a million miles an hour around the square, heedless of who she ran over in the process. She even plowed through the remains of the cake. Adora's attempts to restrain her resulted in She Ra getting scratched up, and Catra running up a tree to pout about it. Now, he's trying to get her down before the lethargy sets in and she winds up falling.

"Adora's very sorry, and she wants you to come down so she can apologize."

Adora is off being consoled by Glimmer ("Why won't she let me love her??").

Melog seemed to have reacted to the catnip by proxy, but has gone through the phases in reverse. While Catra was rubbing her face against people, Melog was falling asleep on top of Emily. Now they are running laps around the Heart Blossom, phasing in and out of invisibility and yipping strangely. Several children are chasing them excitedly, catching the illusory flowers and stars they are unconsciously summoning in their wake.

"Humph!" Catra responds, actually pronouncing the word "Fine. But I can't get down anyways. I'm stuck."

"WhAt?" Bow calls, his voice cracking.

"I'm stuck! I'm stuckstuckstuckkkkk" Catra lets out a squeaky cackle that slowly trails off.

I'm gonna have to climb this tree, aren't I? Bow sighs, and sets to work.

It takes a while to get through the dense canopy, but eventually he finds the quickly relaxing Catra, and extricates her foot from between two branches. *It's a miracle she didn't break it.*

It is perhaps one of the worst cruelties of Bow's life that he is too busy focusing on getting them both safely down from the tree to fully appreciate how adorable Catra is once the lethargy sets in. She wraps her arms around his neck and starts purring, slowly rubbing her face against his shoulder.

He reaches the ground and gently hands Catra over to an anxiously waiting Adora, who takes her in her arms bridal style.

"Heyyyyyyyyyy 'Dora." Catra mutters. "You're pretty. Boop." She tries to bop Adora's nose, but misses and hits her lip instead, sending her into a fit of lazy giggles and purrs as she curls herself around Adora's torso, making it a little more difficult to carry her back to their yurt.

Bow smiles, and looks around, catching the eye of Scorpia, who was looking wistfully at Adora and Catra. Bow gives a subtle thumbs up, and nods meaningfully in Perfuma's direction.

Perfuma

Adora, Bow, Glimmer, and Catra left an hour ago, teleporting out while Catra was still sleeping off the catnip. Now, she and Scorpia are sitting together on a large, flat stone, gazing up at the stars and the moons. Gently, Perfuma reaches over and places a hand on Scorpia's pincer.

"So, Scorpia," She begins. "What was that surprise you had for me? I assume you wanted to give it to me at night, since you didn't do it at the party." Her voice is gentle and curious, because she's hiding her excitement and mild irritation. She really wants this surprise.

"Yeah… yeah. So…" Scorpia gets up and walks over towards one of the picnic tables, and emerges holding something behind her

back. “So it’s not that much… Nothing special or unique really, just… I was walking through the Fright Zone and I saw this and I thought of you so I took it to give to you.” She sits down on the rock with Perfuma and slowly reveals what’s behind her back. A tiny pot, with a little trefoil flower in it.

Perfuma smiles and takes it. “Oh Scorpia… it’s lovely.”

Scorpia is visibly blushing, even in the rather dark evening light. “I saw it growing in a little crack in the floor of the skiff hangar. I just thought that, since it was probably there before She Ra’s whole thing… I dunno. It just made me happy to think that it managed to thrive there and bloom. It made me think of you, and how you said that I can do anything and I just…” She pauses and breathes, then continues very quietly. “I wanted you to know how special you are to me.” She looks up, meeting Perfuma’s gaze bashfully. Despite being one of the largest and most outgoing people she’s ever met, Scorpia has a way of seeming small and shy.

Perfuma smiles and sets the pot to the side. She reaches up and cups Scorpia’s cheek with a slender hand. “Thank you Scorpia. I have a surprise for you, too.” Scorpia’s face lights up.

“Oh! What is it? Is it clothes? Oh man you better tell me fast cuz I am *terrible* with surprises.”

Perfuma giggles. “Close your eyes.” Scorpia does so, and Perfuma smiles for a moment, letting her thumb drift across the bit of cheekbone carapace. Slowly, gently, she leans in, and kisses Scorpia delicately on the lips.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Comments and kudos are always appreciated, and I hope you enjoyed!

Return to Salineas, Part 1: Fury of the Sea

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra returns to Salineas, but Mermista proves much less forgiving than the other princesses.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer

Queen Glimmer presses a button on her remote, and the image on the screen shifts to an overhead map of the Crimson Waste. Large patches of the map remain blank, pending cartography.

"This is the most complete map of the Waste we have access to. As you can see, it is not very complete. But, Hunters has sent us some details about some threats we should be aware of." She clears her throat, and starts shuffling through the stack of files in front of her, swallowing uncomfortably as the moment of silence drags on for more and more moments. The assembled party in the meeting room looks to each other as the young queen tries to get her things in order.

"Which one..?" She mutters, eventually grabbing one of the Crimson Waste files and opening it. "No! That's botany!" She tosses the file over her shoulder.

"Eh, Your Majesty-" General Juliet starts, but Glimmer cuts her off with a snapped, "Just a minute!"

The file isn't even here. You're embarrassing yourself. You've finally stepped up to be queen, and you're embarrassing yourself in your first big meeting.

Glimmer restrains herself from grunting in frustration as she emerges from her pile of files with a tight smile on her face. She

can see everyone's expressions. Micah is empathetically grimacing, Juliet is trying to stoickly avoid eye contact, and Bright Moon's Chancellor Brannic has his wide, pig-like nose tilted upwards in disdain.

"Well," Glimmer says, trying to regain control, "Huntara has told us that… there are a lot of… gangs! In the Waste! And they're dangerous!"

Chancellor Brannic raises an eyebrow. "So our alliance with Huntara has netted us the valuable information that… The Crimson Waste is dangerous? And we paid her for that information?"

Glimmer's eye twitches, "Well, not exactly. She- she gave us specifics but… You know what? The file with the information must be in my office I'll just- I'll be right back." Glimmer says cheerily, and teleports to her office. She starts tearing through her shelves and stacks of scrolls and files, but is still unable to find the file. She flops into her chair, looks as the amorphous mass of papers and documents, and just screams in frustration.

Catra

Catra wakes up to the disappointing reality that Adora's warm presence is no longer in the bed beside her. She opens her eyes, but snaps them shut with a hiss at the sunlight streaming in. She sits up, blinking slowly to get used to the light. It seems to be late morning. Melog is pacing a tight circle around the bed, and jumps up and mewls excitedly at her. Apparently they had bacon for the first time this morning, and they loved it.

"Bacon?" Catra responds, "Don't think Adora's given me that yet." After the first few times, Catra stopped eating anything that Adora didn't give her. Not that she didn't trust it, just that Adora got so upset when she didn't get to see Catra's reactions to new foods. So Catra patiently waited for her scatterbrained girlfriend to introduce her to new foods.

I'm sure I make it difficult by not leaving the castle… She feels the walls closing in, and makes the conscious choice to stand up, walking over to the balcony and stretching, letting out a mighty yawn. She settles in for some morning meditation. She wasn't fond of it, but the noise of the decorative waterfall did help her drift off into a more harmonious headspace.

She makes a face at how her subconscious sounds like Perfuma, then settles in for a ten minute meditation. She could probably go longer, but ten minutes was about the max amount of time she could usually get in before-

"Catra!" Bow's voice this time, and his worried tone immediately sets her on edge. She jumps up.

"What is it? Where's Adora??" She starts to walk forward but he raises his hands in a calming motion.

"Adora's fine, in the meeting room with Glimmer. I just wanted to check in with you. I wasn't sure if you remembered what we were doing today and I'm here to make sure you're still okay with it."

Today… Oh, right… great.

"Yeah, I remember, Arrow Boy." She says, closing herself off almost immediately, and turning around to hop onto the railing, looking out over the sound instead of at Bow. "And I'm fine, thanks." She uses the 'thanks' as a barb. "Just going to visit a kingdom I destroyed. What could be more fun?"

She hears Bow's footsteps approaching, and gets very angry very fast. '*Gods, just drop it already, idiot. Take a hint.*' She turns her head towards him and snaps at the kind, considerate, '*condescending*' look on his face, getting more agitated with each word. "Look. I'm fine. I'm gonna go, and I'll be fine. I don't need you hovering over me every hour of the day! So just, back off! Stop acting like you care." Melog steps in front of Bow, their mane spiked out and red. Bow takes an alarmed step back, his face

looking hurt for a moment, before he settles into resigned disappointment.

"Yeah. Okay Catra. If you change your mind… we're all here for you." He turns around and walks out, but pauses as he reaches the door, casting a glance over his shoulder at the still worked up Catra. "You don't have to go if you don't want to." He leaves.

"Of course I don't want to…" Catra mutters to herself. "That's why I have to go. But I don't need you to hold my hand." She sinks down to the floor, her back against the railing.

By the time Adora finds her, she's sobbing, digging her claws into her arms and thinking of nothing but that moment of hurt on Bow's face. A look she's seen before.

'You're a bad friend.'

Adora

Considering the shape she was in this morning, Catra was actually doing pretty well. Catra had apologized to Bow right before leaving, and she hasn't really talked much since. Sea Hawk had shown up unannounced to ferry them to Salineas, and Catra had said that, as much as she hates ships, she hates teleporting more. Now, she's huddled in the cargo hold, while Adora sits at the edge of the hatch, looking down at her with a beatific smile.

"Shut up." Catra mutters, full of adorable sickly rage.

"I didn't say anything." Adora responds, teasing and faux defensive. Catra responds by throwing a balled up biscuit wrapper that bonks Adora right in the eye. Catra cracks a laugh at that, but immediately closes her mouth and lets out a strangled 'hrrg-' and hunches over.

"Fear not, valiant savior of Etheria! I have just the cure for your affliction!" Comes their captain's jolly voice. *'Oh no…'* It was only a

matter of time before Sea Hawk and Catra officially met, but it could have been under better circumstances.

Catra, for her part, simply looks up at the sailor with half lidded eyes and a truly done expression.

"Is it adventure?" Adora says, her voice getting a little nasally and snide.

"Nay, friend Adora!" Sea Hawk dramatically reaches into his coat and pulls out a little brown flask. "It's this corund root infusion. Settles the stomach and helps the mind tune out the movement of the waves."

Catra stares at him for a beat, her eyes narrowing. She looks to Adora for guidance. All Adora can do is shrug, so Catra looks back to Sea Hawk and swipes the flask out of his hand in a flash, chugging the whole thing before handing it back. She then settles into her side, still swaddled in her blanket, and using a sack of grain as a pillow.

"Alright." She says. "I'm going to nap until we get to water kingdom. If you're not Adora, leave me be."

Adora sighs, simultaneously feeling a surge of love and a twinge of disappointment at Catra's ever fiery temperament. She looks at Sea Hawk and gives a rueful smile and shrug, then cocks her head, indicating they should go to the bow, leaving Catra to her nap.

Adora strides forward and takes a seat on the railing, while Sea Hawk contents himself to put one leg up and rest his arm on it.

"So, First Mate Adora," Sea Hawk begins, but Adora cuts him off with a chortle.

"First Mate? You didn't tell me I got promoted." She smirks. "Bow's gonna be jealous."

Sea Hawk grins, "Well I needed someone with someone with more leadership experience. Plus I already bought a 'She Ra is my co-captain' bumper sticker, so I was all in." Adora laughs, and Sea Hawk continues, "So, Adora. How did you come to the decision to be with Catra? I always saw some chemistry between you two when she was trying to kill us, and even moreso after she switched sides, but it still seems an odd choice."

Adora smiles sweetly and tucks a stray hair behind her ear. "Catra and I grew up together in the Horde. I guess it just took a long time for us to realize what we felt." Her face darkens and she turns her head to look over. The vast expanse of waves. "There's always been something standing in the way of it…" '*Always been someone standing in the way of it.*' Adora subconsciously puts a hand on her cheek and closes her eyes.

"I see." Sea Hawk says, with a tone that indicates he definitely does not see.

"Hey, Sea Hawk?"

"Hmm?"

"Can I ask you a favor?"

"Anything, Adora, I, along with all of Etheria, are forever in your debt." Sea Hawk bows deeply.

"Oh-key don't be dramatic, I just-" Adora casts a glance to the open cargo hatch and lowers her voice, "I just need you to make sure Catra's okay in Salineas. I know I may not be able to be by her side the whole time and… I don't want anything bad to happen to her." Adora's gaze is on the floorboards now, and she's rubbing her arm, feeling guilty for putting her protective responsibilities onto someone else.

Sea Hawk approaches and kneels in front of Adora, taking her hand and looking her in the eye with surprising respect and understanding. "Adora," he says, speaking rather softly, "I swear that I will keep your beloved safe during our time in Salineas."

Adora smiles and tears up. '*My beloved.*' She likes that. "Thank you." She stands up and pulls Sea Hawk into a hug, then heads to the cargo hold to join Catra.

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They are awoken by Sea Hawk's loud announcement that they've arrived. Adora shoots up, and clambers on deck, looking excitedly at Salineas. It's one of the more visually stunning kingdoms.

I wish this were Catra's first time here…

Her face falls a bit when she sees the state it's in. No fire and smoke like the last time she saw it, but there are still piles of rubble. Shattered statues. The Sea Gate is gone, and much of the city still looks sparsely inhabited.

Sea Hawk brings the *Dragon's Daughter 20* (he had lost count and rounded up) into port, and the crew is greeted by a familiar dark skinned herald/guard/butler, who bows deeply, and motions for them to follow.

Catra is gripping Adora's hand tightly and standing behind her and Bow. Her pupils are wide, and her ears are flattened against her head. Adora looks back and gives a reassuring smile. Catra's mouth twitches upward as they get off the ship.

"At least it's land." Adora offers, trying to get a laugh out of Catra.

No such luck, instead, the cat-girl grimaces. "Yeah, not exactly dry land though." She's stepping gingerly, and Adora realizes the wet, sandy pavement is probably not ideal on mostly bare feet.

The palace is fairly intact, as per Horde guidelines. *Destroy defenses, but if there is not a princess, leave important structures intact to minimize reconstruction work.* Adora registers some dull surprise that they bothered to follow that. They weren't very stringent with many of their other so-called 'rules of engagement'.

The herald opens the large, seashell patterned doors, and announces, "The party from Bright Moon, and the Royal Consort are here."

From the end of the hall, a bored drone of a voice emanates. "Ummmm he is *not* the Royal Consort. He is just my boyfriend."

Glimmer giggles, and the herald amends, "The party from Bright Moon and the Royal Boyfriend are here."

The group walks across the hall, and Sea Hawk struts forward before kneeling before the throne, stretching a hand towards the Princess. "My dearest Mermista! Too long it has been… an eternity it seems since I last saw my Ocean Jewel."

Mermista rolls her eyes while Bow, Glimmer, and Adora stifle laughter. She grabs Sea Hawk's hand and drags him up into her lap, with his legs hanging over the armrest. "You've been gone like, a day. Bright Moon isn't that far."

She finally turns her attention to the group. She gives her version of a smile, but it fades when she sees Catra behind Bow and Adora. "Ummmm, you didn't tell me *she* was coming."

Before Adora can leap to her girlfriend's defense, Glimmer has leaned in. "Yes, we did. I asked if you didn't want her here and you didn't respond."

Mermista rolls her eyes. "Yeah but you should have known I wouldn't *read* that part. Anyway, yeah, I don't want her here so…" She makes a shooing motion with her hand.

Adora feels Catra's grip tighten on her hand, whether out of anger or fear, she can't tell. She steps forward, her own anger clear on her face.

"That's not fair! She deserves a chance to make up for it!"

"Adora…" Catra says.

Mermista scoffs, "Um… I don't think my people are gonna like her 'making up for it'. Can't she make up for it by just- staying away?" Mermista stands up, heedless of the fact that the action sends Sea Hawk sprawling. She starts speaking with more emotion in her voice than normal, sounding full of cold fury. "She did more than enough last time she was here. Do you think I'm letting Hordak come over for hangouts? She blew up my chair!" Glimmer looks at the intact throne behind her and Mermista waves a hand, "Not this one, *obviously.*"

Adora surges forward before anyone else can stop her. "It's different! Hordak was waging war for decades! Catra was just as much a victim as you, or anyone! It's not like we blame you for what you did when you were chipped! She's a different person now!" She's moved far enough forward that Catra has let go of her hand, though Adora didn't notice.

"Adora…" Catra's voice, soft and pleading. Adora starts to turn her head, but Mermista brings her back into the conversation.

"She got a haircut. That does *not* mean she's a different person. I'm like, dating Sea Hawk now, but that doesn't make me a different person."

Glimmer chimes in. "Mermista, I almost destroyed all Etheria. If I got a second chance, Catra deserves one too."

Bow adds on. "Catra almost destroyed Bright Moon a long time ago. If we gave her a second chance, why can't you?"

Adora rejoins, defensively saying, "She's not a better person just because we're together! That's backwards."

Even Sea Hawk speaks up, softly and gently. "Mermista. You nearly killed me when you were chipped. But I never gave up on you, and I never thought for a second that I wouldn't forgive you."

Mermista snaps, craning her head back with a titanic "UGHHHHH!" She levels a glare at everyone. "Stop comparing that. It's not the

same. I don’t remember most of what I did then, but Catra remembers everything. Don’t you?” She’s glaring at Catra now. Adora starts to move in between them, as if to shield Catra from that baleful stare.

Before anyone else can leap to her defense, Catra finally retaliates, stepping forward and practically spitting the words, “I remember you weren’t there!” Everyone goes stock still, Mermista’s eyes widen in utter shock. Catra doesn’t seem to register it in her pissed off state and adds, “Ha! We almost won the war because you Princesses had to go out and do everything yourselves, leaving your homes defenseless!”

The moment of silence that follows is one of the worst moment’s of Adora’s life, as she watches Mermista go from shock to rage, and sees Catra gasp, taking a step back, her ears falling.

Mermista opens her mouth to speak, but Catra beats her to it, turning around and shoving Bow and Adora out of the way to get out of the throne hall.

“Catra!” Adora shouts, and rushes after her.

She reaches the door by the time she hears the butler return, announcing, “The hors d’ouevres are ready!”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! If you enjoyed, please leave a kudo or comment, they are always appreciated.

Return to Salineas, Part 2: Walls

Chapter Summary

> In Which Catra has some therapy-via-construction and forges a friendship with Sea Hawk, Bow advises Adora to stop trying to brute-force forgiveness, and Glimmer helps Mermista with her daddy issues.

Chapter Notes

> CW: Heat exhaustion

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow

Bow is pacing in front of Adora and Glimmer in a sitting room while Sea Hawk talks to Mermista. "So the introduction could have gone better. That's fine! These things happen. All they need is to get Catra and Mermista together in a more casual setting, and the two will realize how similar they are, and they'll bond, and everyone can be best friends again!"

Adora raises a hand. "First we have to find Catra, which I could have done if you hadn't *locked me in this room!*"

So Adora is a little upset.

Glimmer chimes in. "Adora, Catra doesn't need someone telling her that she's blameless. She did some really bad things here, and she needs to come to terms with that on her own." She puts a hand on Adora's shoulder, and her frown deepens at the immediate flinch Adora gives.

Wow she is really wound up.

Bow smiles and sits on the table in front of Adora. "Hey. There's nothing we can't do. Everyone else gave Catra a chance. Mermista

may just need to give her a few chances. It's natural." Adora opens her mouth, but Bow talks first, putting a reassuring hand on her knee (on the same side Glimmer is on. He wants to leave her other side open - she doesn't like being boxed in). "Catra won't be far. I'm sure she didn't go into the city. She's probably somewhere around the ship. If you want to go find her right now, you can go. But please consider that she may want to process this on her own first."

Adora's gaze drifts to the floor. She squints her eyes closed, and a tear falls out of one of them. She wordlessly reaches up, pulling Bow into a tight hug, which Glimmer joins.

Bow looks at Glimmer, not sure what to say or do, and sees that same frustrated confusion on her face. '*I'm supposed to be the friendship guy, but I don't know what to say or do here. This is such an impossible situation.*'

Glimmer breaks the hug, and looks at Adora. "I'm gonna go talk some sense into Mermista, okay?" She vanishes in a shower of sparks.

Adora turns to Bow, who smiles. "And while she's doing that, we can go see what sort of vendors are on the streets."

Adora's face instantly brightens, and she jumps up, proclaiming, "STREET FOOD!"

Mermista

"UGGGGGHH!!" Mermista exclaims, half-heartedly tossing another goblet across the room. Her dutiful guard/herald/servant wordlessly sweeps up the broken goblet and scurries over with another one, which she immediately throws with another "UGH!"

He goes to sweep this one up, but Mermista just says, "Leave it. Just… go outside, okay? You are like, all up in my personal space right now."

The man simply nods and walks outside, shutting the door behind him. Mermista flops back into the water of her sulking tub and watches her tail swish back and forth.

"If they aren't going to respect my wishes, then they should leave." She mutters.

'They are my friends, and I didn't actually tell them not to bring her.' Her thoughts respond.

"Ugh. What-ever. I shouldn't have had to tell them. It's puh-retty obvious that I don't want the girl who blew up my kingdom coming back to my kingdom."

'She did the same thing to all of them and they forgave her. It would be pretty lame if I were the only one who didn't.'

"More like pretty sane." Mermista mutters, but she admits her thoughts make a pretty good point. If she doesn't give on this, then she'll probably end up as the odd one out of the group, not Catra.

'*Not like I've made much of an effort to be close to any of them…*'

Mermista sighs and sinks down below the water, looking up at the glittering ceiling through the water's surface.

She thinks, as she too-often does in times like these, about how her father would have handled a situation like this.

She wishes she could just go visit her dad in his retirement cottage, way down on the Southern coast, and ask his advice. She hadn't done that for years.

'Because his advice was always that I needed to "be my own princess". Ugh.'

Instead, she simply imagines how her father, Prince of Salineas, would have reacted to this situation.

Prince Aquarus would have officially and publically forgiven Catra of course. The move would shore up the alliance with Bright Moon and be good PR. In principle, though, he wouldn't have actually pardoned her, meaning she'd be unable to return to Salineas without an escort from Bright Moon. He'd avoid alienating any allies while still making sure his people wouldn't have to think about the one who destroyed their homes.

'That's what my dad, the Prince, would do. What about my dad, the Person, though?' Mermista ponders for a while before accepting that she simply doesn't know.

She doesn't know how her dad, the best leader she's ever known, would have handled this. And she doesn't know how she is going to handle this.

Catra

If she's honest, Catra doesn't really know how she wound up where she is right now.

Well she knows *how*, but not really *why*.

After the argument in the palace, she had run away. She ran and ran through the streets of Salineas, panicking and hiding whenever she saw someone, and eventually she got to the outskirts of town, where a large construction site rebuilding a part of the 'sea wall' was. A foreman had spotted her, fortunately not recognized her, and assumed she was a volunteer. She'd been given a bright vest, a helmet, and a toolbox, and now she's laying mortar and bricks on a section of a dilapidated wall.

Perhaps the strangest thing about her current predicament is now *good* it feels. It's nothing grand, no numbers of exchange of money, she's just using her own hands and her own body to help fix her mistakes. Help undo the damage she caused. It's almost enough to drown out the blazing heat.

Almost.

'Stars it really is hot.' She thinks as she pats a damp kerchief on her forehead. Her thin body fur is matted, and she doesn't want to think about the state of her head hair under the helmet. Her dark clothing soaking up the sun's warmth isnt helping either. Nor is the lightweight vest she was given, which, while an easy, breathable material, is still one more layer.

Still, she labors away. Lather mortar, place brick, knock into place with a hammer, shave off overflow.

Lather mortar, place brick, knock into place with a hammer, shave off overflow.

Lather mortar, place brick, knock into place with a hammer, shave off overflow.

Lather mortar, place brick, knock into place with a hammer, shave off overflow.

I shouldn't be here.

Shut up.

Am I wrong?

No, but shut up anyways.

You're the reason this wall needs rebuilding.

Yeah, doesn't matter. Shut up.

You've ruined everything. You've ruined these friendships before you even started them.

Shut up. Too hot.

Catra blinks the sweat out of her eyes, but the spots in her vision that are forming remain. She should stop, take a breath, drink some water.

She doesn't.

Lather mortar, place brick, knock into place with a hammer, shave off overflow.

Lather mortar, place brick, knock into place with a hammer, shave off overflow.

Lather mortar, place brick, drop hammer, pass out.

*****

She wakes up shortly afterwards, finding herself in a very unexpected place: tenderly curled up in the strong embrace of… Sea Hawk?

"Bah!!" She cries, starting to thrash to be let down.

"Fear not Catra, I'm here on behalf of your beloved. I swore to keep you safe." He does not let go, so Catra calms down and lets herself be carried. She'd put up more of a fight if she weren't utterly exhausted.

And this is kind of nice… It reminds her of Scorpia's embraces that she never let herself enjoy.

After a light jog, Sea Hawk sets her down. They're on a bench overlooking an empty bay, lined with docks. She looks around, confused.

"Where's Adora?" She asks Sea Hawk, who has taken a seat beside her.

"As far as I know, she and Bow are perusing the market for street food." He responds, fixing some imperfection in his mustache. "I assumed you might want a moment to breathe after your fainting spell." He holds out a flask.

"It wasn't a 'fainting spell'," Catra grumbles, taking the proffered flask and taking a long drink of the (thankfully) water within.

Gods, my throat's dry. She gasps in a breath before taking another long drink. She rips the stupid helmet and vest off and tosses them to the side. She leans back in the bench, crossing her arms and not looking at Sea Hawk when she says, "Thanks. For… ya know."

"Of course." He responds, as if helping people is just… natural. Expected. Totally ordinary.

A moment of silence follows that. Not awkward, as Catra curiously feels no tension with Sea Hawk. Instead, they sit on this bench in a comfortable silence, listening to the waves and the seagulls and the distant sounds of construction. Catra scans the horizon, and notices something on an outlying sandbar that catches her attention. She lets out a dry chuckle and elbows Sea Hawk, then points.

"See that ship? I sank that one." There's a bitterness to her voice. The Salinean navy had put up a fierce, but brief fight, unable to match the Horde's battleships and firepower.

Sea Hawk chuckles, and points a little ways to the right, where a more dilapidated husk of a ship hull emerges from the sand and waves. "I sunk that one." He responds.

Catra turns and gives a curious look, raising an eyebrow. "Ha, what's that story?" She remembers the things she's heard about Sea Hawk, and his excitement over burning Prime's spires, and adds drily, "Doesn't look burnt."

Sea Hawk guffaws. "Oh no! That's someone else's boat. I sunk it due to a terrible and tragic misunderstanding regarding a boat race." He pauses, chuckling at the memory. "Pirate races allow many more tricks than normal sailor races."

"Wait", Catra holds up a hand, "you used to be a pirate? Like an actual pirate?"

"Of course!" Sea Hawk looks almost offended. "My adventures on the high seas are the stuff of legend!! Have you not heard the tale

of the Great Fire of the SS *Primrose*? Or the Blaze of the *Blue Ballad?*"

"Sounds like you set a lot of ships on fire."

"Yes! I was an infamous pirate!" He pauses, and some of his bravado fades, "Though not a very successful one. Most of my pirate friends don't like me anymore. I set a lot of their boats on fire." He huffs, leaning his chin in his hands, and his elbows on his knees. "I had good times with those people. I was friends with them! But then I ruined it. Sometimes I think my ship burning habit may cause more harm than good."

Catra thinks on that, unsure of what to say to the suddenly despondent rogue. "Hey…" she starts, and just lets her mouth take over. "I don't know much about burning ships, but I know a bit about burning bridges. You know, like, not actual bridges but- connections. It's- it's not your fault if you can't reconnect. Both people have to work on fixing a burnt bridge. Or- ship, I guess." Sea Hawk is looking at her now, though she's looking at the ground, tracing a pattern with her right toe claw. "I don't really know what I'm saying here but… I guess just that it's not all your fault. If you made the effort to apologize, you can't do anything if they don't want to forgive you. Just gotta… live with it." She gets quieter on the last part, and she feels a rough hand on her shoulder. She slowly, hesitantly, reaches her own hand up and lays it on his.

They stay there for a moment, looking out at the slowly rising tide, before Catra asks, "is your name really 'Sea Hawk?' Kinda… on the nose, isn't it?"

He pulls away, "Of course! Sea Hawk is the only name I've ever known, and being a Sea Hawk is the only life over ever known!" He strikes a pose, standing up on the bench with one leg up on the armrail, pointing out to the waves. "Adventure calls to me, like the Sea calls to a Hawk!"

Catra scrunches her nose in confusion, “That… doesn’t make sense.”

Sea Hawk shrugs and sits. “I suppose not, but my parents really did name me Sea Hawk. My career choice was obvious from there. Though I did want to be a cook at one point.”

“Pfft.” Catra scoffs, trying to imagine Sea Hawk in Bright Moon’s kitchen, brandishing a skillet like a sword, surrounded by far more fire than should be in a kitchen. The scoff turns into a high pitched guffaw as both Glimmer and Mermista enter her mindscape, trying to quench the fires. Sea Hawk laughs with her.

“Ahhh…” he sighs as they stop laughing. “I can’t imagine myself as anything but the roguishly handsome sailor I am now.”

“Yeah…” Catra pauses, “Hey, Sea Hawk?”

“Yes?”

“How’d you fall in with the Princesses?”

“A remarkable story, that.” He goes into storytelling mode, and Catra leans back in the bench and watches as he gets up, gesturing emphatically while recalling the tale of how he was recruited by She Ra to help save Salineas from the evil Horde, and how he daringly saved the day just as all seemed lost by destroying their battleship.

Catra cringes when she realizes what battle he’s talking about. Her first attempt to destroy Salineas. Her first meeting with Scorpia. Her fight fight against She Ra.

Wasn’t much of a fight. She was helpless and I pummeled her.

Familiar pants of guilt flare up, like they always do when she hears stories of the war. Sea Hawk is better than the others though. They always try to tiptoe around the fact that Catra was their enemy, but Sea Hawk is far too busy exaggerating his role in

the tale to even remember hers. *Is it weird to feel good about being forgotten?*

Probably. Don't care.

As he finishes his tale, she gives a sarcastic slow clap at his bow.

"Wowwwww. Great story. Loved the part where you singlehandedly boarded the enemy ship and fought off the whole crew of- how many was it?"

"Fifty guys!" It had been 30 the first time.

"Riiiiiight… definitely not three cadets and one force captain." She smirks at him, and his eyes go wide.

"Oh no! That was- um… a different mission. Ahem."

Catra's ears perk up and her head swivels as she hears a familiar voice cry out her name. Her face crumples into a smile as she sees Adora rushing towards her, Bow not far behind.

"Hey, Adora." Catra says casually, bracing herself for the incoming hug.

She doesn't brace enough, since she didn't expect Adora to literally leap over the back of the bench and tackle her to the ground.

The wind is knocked out of her, and Adora's tight embrace doesn't help her catch her breath. Fortunately it doesn't last too long, as Adora releases her and pulls her into a sitting position.

"Heh, sorry." Adora says, one hand rubbing the back of her neck. "I got excited. Are you okay?"

"I'm fine, dummy," Catra responds, her voice threatening to burst with affection, "I've had worse falls than that."

Adora's brow furrows and she responds, "I mean about Mermista, and Salineas. Where'd you go??"

"Umm, I ran through town and wound up helping rebuild a wall? Then I passed out from the heat and Sea Hawk brought me here." She looks up at Adora, whose mouth has gone small in surprise from that answer. Catra takes her hands and smiles. "I'd like to go talk to Mermista now. As long as you're with me.

Glimmer

Glimmer teleports into a disconcertingly familiar scene.

A princess, standing alone in the room, staring up at a mural of their kingdom's previous rule.

"Hey Glimmer," Mermista acknowledges her flatly, without looking away from the picture of Prince Aquarus.

"Heyyy…" Glimmer says, feeling more than a little awkward at the similarities. She pushes those feelings down and walks up beside Mermista. "You're asking yourself what he would do in this situation, aren't you?"

"Maybe," Mermista sighs, "Hhhhhhuuuhhh. Whatever. It's stupid anyways." She turns and walks away from Glimmer and the painting, flopping down on a couch facing away.

"I don't think so." Glimmer responds quietly. She walks over to the couch and pushed Mermista's feet off to sit down. Mermista gasps affrontedly. "Okay." Glimmer starts, "Let's talk. Because you and Catra are both my friends, and I am not about to lose either one of you."

Mermista scoffs and gets up, walking away with her arms crossed.

"Come onnnn Mermista!" Glimmer pleads, "Why can't you just let this go?"

“Let this *go*??” Mermista says acidly, turning with anger and shock on her face, “How have you ‘let this go’ so easily?? I feel like I’m the only sane person around here! You let Hordak off with a slap on the wrist, you’re letting Prime’s clones wander across Etheria, and now you’re best friends with *Catra!!* The same Catra who tried to kill you how many times??”

“No!” Glimmer says, standing up, “Not the same Catra. She has gone through so much Mermista. So much more than any of us! And she’s changed. She’s a different person now. A better person!”

“Doesn’t seem like it to me.” Mermista retorts, “Seems like she’s more than willing to slide back into old habits when she gets upset.”

Glimmer rolls her eyes, “You provoked her into that! I mean, we all kinda did but you did most!”

“She destroyed my home!”

“I know!” Glimmer shouts back, “And you were there for the aftermath of it! You think you’re the only one who remembers that? You think you’re the only one who cared? Do you not remember what happened because the Horde destroyed Salineas? What-“ She falters before forcing out, “What *I* did?” Mermista glares at her. “Catra did a lot of terrible things. She- she took my mother away from me.” Glimmer gestures up at the mural of Prince Aquarus, saying, “You can stand here all sad and wonder what he’d do, but you know what? At least he’s still here! He’s what, a week’s boat trip away in some quiet little cottage? I can never see my mother again! I look at her every day, in every other room of Bright Moon. And every time I see Catra I’m reminded of why I’ll never see her again. But I’ve forgiven her. I’ve moved on.” Glimmer is breathing heavily, her voice shaking. She’s shocked she hasn’t started crying, but also glad. Mermista wouldn’t respect tears.

Mermista looks down and sighs. “It’s not just about me not forgiving her.” She mutters. “I have to think of my position as ruler of Salineas. If I give out a pardon to the person who destroyed my kingdom, I look weak. I cannot afford to look weak to my people or anyone else!”

Glimmer walks up, taking one of Mermista’s hands with both of hers. “Yes you can! That’s the point of the Princess Alliance. You don’t have to put on this ‘strong, confident ruler’ front. We’re here to help.”

Mermista pulls away. “Yeah, that’s nice for now, but we don’t know if the Alliance will last forever.”

Glimmer is taken aback, and asks, “Why wouldn’t it?”

“Ugh! I don’t know why, but that’s not the point!” Mermista presses her hands to her temples. “Ugggghhh. I *have* to make the right decision here. My dad was one of the best rulers Salineas has ever had. My people are still comparing me to him. I can’t let them down, and I can’t let him down.”

“You’re talking a lot about your people, and your dad,” Glimmer says, “But what about you? What do you want?”

Mermista turns. “I… want things to be easy. The way they used to be. Before I had to worry about rebuilding my kingdom and balancing being a princess and being a person. I just don’t want to worry so much.”

Glimmer smiles and walks forward. She takes Mermista’s hands, and the other princess does not pull away. “Then don’t.” Glimmer says, “Make whatever decision your heart says. If you decide to forgive her, that’s perfect. If not, then it’s ours to worry about, not yours.”

Mermista sighs. “Okay. Thank you.” She squeezes Glimmer’s hands, then begins to walk out of the room, before pausing and looking back to say, “Just- pretend I hugged you right there, okay?”

Glimmer raises an eyebrow, and teleports into a big bear hug around the water princess despite her protests.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, as always, comments and kudos are most appreciated, hope you enjoyed!

Return to Salineas, Part 3: The Longest Road

Chapter Summary

In Which Mermista buries the hatchet

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

For the second time today, Adora finds herself standing tensely between Mermista and Catra. But this time, she takes a deep breath, and steps aside, relinquishing her control over the situation.

Catra can talk for herself.

"Princess Mermista," she starts, and kneels, looking up at Mermista, whose face is surprisingly impassive, though her lips are pursed. "I know there's nothing I could ever do to… make up for what I did to you and your kingdom. All I can do is tell you that… I'm sorry. I was a horrible person, who did horrible things. I know I've changed, but you don't have to accept that. If you want to hate me… that's fine, seriously. I'm sure a lot of people do. But… it's up to you. If you want me to never come back here, I won't." Catra looks up, and the room waits with bated breath for Mermista's response.

"Ugggggghhhh…" Mermista's head knocks against the back of the throne as she groans. "Well, obviously I'm not gonna kick you out now. You're fine to stay in Salineas as long as you don't cause any trouble. Also if anyone attacks you in the street, I'll like, have your back, or whatever." Catra stands up in surprise, but Mermista raises a hand, "Don't make a big thing about it. It's gonna be way cooler to have you as a friend than an enemy."

Mermista stands, and looks at everyone else. “Anyways, are we gonna go shopping now or what?” She looks at Adora, “You need like, a million new outfits.”

“I- uph, I’m fine with-“ Adora starts, but Glimmer and Catra both put their hands on her shoulders, gently shaking their heads. Adora pouts, “But I like it.”

Catra smiles. “And you’ll like whatever we get you. Plus I’m ready to shred that stupid red jacket.”

Glimmer leans around Adora to look at Catra with a teasing smile. “Don’t think you’re getting off easy either, Horde Scum. We’re getting you new clothes too.”

Adora turns a smug grin on Catra, who laughs, “Ha! You wish, Sparkles.”

Catra

About three hours into the shopping trip, with Catra loaded up with more clothes than she’s ever owned in her life, the decision is made to see what options there are for restaurants.

“Hey.” Mermista says to Catra as they are walking towards the place Sea Hawk picked for them. “Can we talk?”

The whole group pauses. Adora shoots Catra a worried, protective glance.

I’ll accept whatever is thrown at me.

“Sure,” Catra says, giving Adora a nod and saying to the group, “Go on ahead, we’ll catch up.”

Bow gently squeezes Catra’s upper arm, and Glimmer gives a supportive smile. Sea Hawk gives both Catra and Mermista two thumbs up as he walks away backwards, and Adora can’t resist hugging and kissing Catra as if it’s the last time they’ll ever see each other.

“Ugh.” Mermista says, “It’s not like it’s the last time she’ll ever see you.”

“You sure?” Catra remarks wryly, testing the waters for what’s okay to say.

“Mmmmmprobably.”

“So…” Catra says, following Mermista to a small park off the side of the street. Little water sprites leap about in the fountain, flanked by palm trees.

Mermista crosses her arms and leans against one of the trees. “Look,” She starts, “I really wish I hated you. That would make things a lot easier. But I don’t. You’re a pretty cool person, and I kinda think we could have been good friends if things were different.” Catra stays silent, waiting to see where this is going. “But I don’t think that’s going to happen.” Mermista continues, “You like, seriously sucked for years. And I can let you be better, but I can’t just let it all slide like everyone else. I’m gonna keep my word. You’re welcome in Salineas and I’m not going to bring you to trial or anything. I mean you’re already a good way towards becoming my friend for real. But I *will* hold what you did against you. And if you mess up again, if you slip back into those old ways, I’m gonna put you down.”

Catra gulps and nods. “That’s… kinda refreshing.” She admits, “Almost what I feel like everyone else should be saying. I… don’t deserve to walk free. After everything I’ve done… I shouldn’t be allowed to be here. I should be behind bars or in- AIY!!” She is cut off as Mermista sends a small squirt of water from the fountain at her face. Catra yelps and springs away backwards.

“What was that for??” She screeches at Mermista.

Mermista answers, “You were wallowing in self loathing which like, totally takes away from my whole thing and made me feel bad, so just like, be cool okay? Next time just like, grovel or something.

Ugh. Let's just go eat." And Mermista walks out like she hadn't just implicitly threatened Catra's life.

I will never, as long as I live, understand how that woman's mind works.

Bow

They wound up spending the night in Salineas to cast off the following morning. ("When the winds will be more favorable!" Sea Hawk had claimed, though it was obvious he just wanted more time with all his friends together.)

When they had arrived at the restaurant of choice, the owner had recognized Catra. He'd threatened her and nearly had the rest of the patrons attacking poor Catra. But before Adora could turn into She Ra and escalate the situation further, Mermista had actually stepped in, true to her word, and informed everyone present in no uncertain terms that, "Catra is under my protection. You got a problem with her, you take it up with *me.*" The owner was properly mortified, and the people who had nearly formed a mob were shamed into silence.

Their meals wound up being free, which was good since Catra discovered her appetite for seafood rival's Adora's appetite for… well, everything else.

Bow knows that the situation between Catra and Mermista isn't solved, and probably won't be for a long time. But even after less than a day, the atmosphere in the group is more relaxed than even he could have expected.

When the time comes to leave, everyone gathers by the *Dragon's Daughter 20*.

"And you're suuuure you don't want to ride the waves back to Bright Moon?" Sea Hawk tries one last time, sounding a little dejected, "The only way to get through seasickness is experience you know."

Catra rolls her eyes and bops him on the arm, "I know. And I will okay? Just… maybe a few weeks between each time okay?"

Sea Hawk unabashedly mopes at that. "Oh alright…" He perks himself up a bit to say, "I'll make a fearsome scalawag of you yet Catra!"

Catra grins. "You can start by coming up with a pirate name for me. Ooh! And get me a hat. A big fancy hat with feathers!"

Sea Hawk's eyes sparkle! "Haaaaahhhhh! That would go perfectly with that long coat you bought yesterday!! Yes! We will be the perfect adventuring buddies on the high seas!!" He wraps Catra in one arm and squeezes her to his side, lifting her partially off the ground while gesturing grandly with his other hand.

Bow chuckles at the two unlikely friends before turning towards Mermista.

"Hey," He starts.

"Mmm-are you gonna talk about friendship stuff to me?" She deadpans.

"Actually I was just going to tell you I'm proud of you." Bow responds. "I… know it couldn't have been easy to make the decision you did, and I know that it's been kinda hard to rationalize how crazy the world has gotten, but I'm glad you did what you did."

Mermista nods, "Yeah… I guess… part of me was imagining her as being 'The Horde', you know? Like, holding her responsible for everything. But, she's not the Horde. She's a weird anxious cat girl who thrives on chaos and loves Adora." Bow looks over to where Adora and Catra are cuddled together, watching Glimmer berate Sea Hawk for some comment.

"She's Catra." Bow says simply. And for him and Mermista, that's enough.

Glimmer

Not long after they landed back in Bright Moon, Glimmer is in her office, toiling away at various bits of legislation and paperwork.

'*Mom never talked about this part of being Queen.*' Glimmer snorts at that thought, bitterly muttering, "She didn't talk about any parts of being Queen."

She sighs heavily. The gust of air is enough to send a stack of papers collapsing to the ground. Now visible on the desk is a dossier sent by Huntara detailing the hostile gangs throughout the Crimson Waste.

"AGH!" Glimmer cries, letting her head flop down onto her desk. She closes her eyes and decides to stress nap, only to hear a knock at the door.

"Come in." She groans, expecting more paperwork to be delivered.

Instead, the door opens, and a husky voice drawls out, "Wow Sparkles. This place is a mess."

"Catra!" Glimmer teleports out of her chair and wraps Catra in a hug, "Please tell me you're here to save me from this."

"Wasn't necessarily my intention, but…" Catra walks up to the desk, and her eyes scan the scattered papers and scrolls. She then looks at the alleged filing system, and her mouth twists in confusion. "How do you make sense of any of this? Nothing's organized right."

Glimmer sighs. "It's color coded… I've got so many things to worry about I just- hhhhh. I went with what was easiest."

"Easiest? Nuh-uh. We're fixing this."

The two get to work, and Glimmer is surprised by how efficient Catra is when it comes to organizing and sorting all the files and

dossiers. Catra cites her experience running the Horde, which makes sense. Regardless of the reason, the task is done in less than an hour, and Glimmer feels so much better. Both girls lean back in their chairs, and breathe satisfied sighs of relief.

"So," Glimmer starts, "Why did you actually come to see me?"

Catra averts her eyes. "I… I wanted to talk about something."

Glimmer smiles, and turns her chair around. Catra does the same, and they're back to back.

Catra starts talking again. "Remember… Before we went to Plumeria? I was looking out of the throne room, and you asked me what I was looking at?"

Glimmer laughs, "And you gave me a vague non-answer? Yeah."

"Yeah… I was looking at the Runestone tower." There's a pause. Glimmer can tell Catra's gathering herself.

"Why?" She prompts.

"There's a part of it that's… Different. A big patch of different colored stone. That's… That's the repaired part, isn't it? From the Battle of Bright Moon? When I shot it with a tank?"

Glimmer nods, "You and a few other people, but yeah, it is. Why were you looking at that?"

Catra sighs. "Because it made me feel… good, in a weird way. To see that the damage I did got fixed in the end. It's nice to know that the things I did won't last forever."

Glimmer turns around, and wraps Catra in a hug from behind. "Nothing lasts forever. But I think good things tend to overwrite the bad pretty quickly."

Chapter End Notes

A shorter chapter this time, but I still hope you enjoyed!
Comments and kudos are always appreciated!

Shadow Weaver, Part 1: Journey to Mystacor

Chapter Summary

> In Which the Best Friend Squad readies to travel to Mystacor, where a memorial service for Light Spinner is being held.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra may not be as hyperactive as Adora, but sparring is still one of her favorite pastimes, especially now that the war is over. Keeping her combat skills sharp is always important, and it helps clear her head almost as much as meditation.

Mostly she spars with Adora. Adora is the only person who can physically match Catra, but they both have a frustrating tendency to hold back. Sometimes she spars with Bow, helping him hone his melee combat skills, but she runs into the same problem.

She wishes she were sparring with one of them as she slams into the dirt for the fifth time in as many minutes, her limbs pinned to her body by a glowing net.

"Ha! That's 5 to 2!"

Netossa does *not* hold back at all, and she encourages Catra to do the same. Adora is always on standby, chewing her nails nervously, ready to She Ra it up and heal any injuries.

Catra growls and cuts through the net, leaping to her feet and spinning to face the cocky net-tossing princess. The training room is outfitted with walls and handholds for her to take full advantage of her agility. Netossa, meanwhile, is employing a strategy of energy conservation, moving as little as possible until Catra closes the distance.

Catra pauses for a moment, planning her attack. She lets her eyes chart a course, and then looks at Netossa and matches her smirk. Catra tenses, and springs forward, going in a different direction than her eyes indicated.

She leaps to the right, grabbing onto the back of a dummy. The dummy leans forward, and Catra springs upward as a net wraps around it. She grabs one of the swinging gymnastics bars, and flips up to balance on it, dodging a net-ball as she does. The next jump carries her to the top of the wall on Netossa's right, and she runs forward on all fours, batting aside another net-ball. She dives in, and lands with her hands on Netossa's shoulders. The other woman lets her momentum carry both of them to the ground. Catra rolls off, and gets to her feet just as Netossa summons a net, pulling it down on top of her. Catra rolls out a millisecond before its too late, and lunges in, grabbing Netossa again, and placing a single clawed finger in the center of her forehead.

"3 to 4." Catra says, panting. Netossa opens her mouth to protest, but Catra cuts her off with, "No, you knocking me over when I was warming up does not count."

Netossa scoffs. "Alright. I still win though."

"Fine." Catra says, willing herself to be fine with it. Her muscles are aching too much for her not to be fine with it.

She walks over to the side of the room, and grabs a towel and a water bottle. She wipes her face and underarms with the towel, and then beckons with her fingers.

Adora, who was watching from the sidelines, takes the token of permission and charges in, wrapping Catra in her arms and lifting her up.

"Agck! Okay, Princess. Still sore." Catra groans, not really upset.

"Sorry." Adora says. "It's just nice to see you getting along with people!"

“Well she’s the one princess who I don’t really have to change anything to get along with.” Catra jokes in response. Netossa is strange. She treats everything, *everything*, as a competition, so being her friend isn’t that different from being her enemy. Catra is secretly a little glad she never fought Netossa during the war. The other princesses tended to hold back even in battle, but Netossa does everything she can to get under her opponent’s skin. It’s a little upsetting sometimes.

“Catra?”

“Hmm!?” Catra startles back with a squeak. Adora giggles.

“Normally I’m the one who spaces out. Guess I’m rubbing off on you.” She teases.

“Ugh, shut up.” Catra puts her hand on Adora’s dumb face and pushes her away. She turns to Netossa and smiles sheepishly. “Hey, Netossa.” The dark skinned princess looks up and cocks her head. “Rematch when I get back?”

“You’re on!” Netossa clenches a challenging fist in front of her face, but then Spinnerella puts a hand on her shoulder. One brief nonverbal exchange later, Netossa turns back to Catra. “Right, Spinny and I are going on vacation for a while, sorry.”

She doesn’t sound too sorry, but she is going on vacation with her wife, so that’s fair.

“Oh. Alright.” Catra says, trying to hide her disappointment. “Have fun!” She says, pushing her voice to show her happiness for them instead of her sadness. She quickly turns and hurries out of the room.

Adora shrugs at the two of them before following hot on Catra’s heels.

*****

“Adora, just drop it, alright?” Catra bites. She’s sitting on the railing of their balcony, looking anywhere but the caring face of her loving girlfriend.

“Catra I know it’s hard to think about her, but you have to tell me if you don’t want to go.” Adora puts a hand on Catra’s raised knee.

Catra sighs. She puts a hand on Adora’s, but still doesn’t look at her. “Look. I want to go to Mystacor. It’s really cool and I want to see it when we’re not on a stealth mission. But I’m not gonna go to some dumb memorial service. I don’t want to think about her at all.”

“Do you want me to stay with you?” Catra looks at Adora in confusion. Adora pulls her hand away and clasps it with her other one. It’s her turn to avoid her girlfriend’s gaze. “I… I was gonna go to the service, but if you don’t want to, I mean, if you want me not to want to. Like if you want me to be with you while you don’t go, I’ll be there.” There’s a pause as Catra tries to wrap her head around Adora’s word mess, and Adora adds, “Not there as in… *there*, there as in with you!”

“Yeah, I get it.” Catra chuckles. “I- I’ll let you know when we get there, okay?” She gets off the railing and takes both of Adora’s hands. “Thank you.”

Adora looks into her eyes and smiles. “Okay.” Catra leans in and kisses her. “Now are you going to pack at all, or…?”

Glimmer

Glimmer and Micah are in the War Room, talking with General Juliet over Tracker Pad.

“We’ve located the cache and have almost dealt with the bots,” The General reports. “It seems like they’re under the command of a pair of clones.”

“Any hints to a larger operation?” Glimmer asks.

“Not yet your Majesty, but I’ll have more information for you once this battle is over.” Juliet’s viewport shakes as an explosion lands near her. “We got a report from Dryl that some of the bots over there started acting erratically once this batch was activated, but no hostility.”

Glimmer sighs and rubs her temples. This has been the way of it recently. Hints of organization across these scattered uprisings, but nothing concrete.

“Keep up the offensive.” Micah says. “If we can stamp out these pockets, we may be able to cut off any larger union before it happens.”

The general nods, and starts to say something, but another blast cuts off her feed.

Glimmer sighs and leans back in her chair, closing her eyes. She hears footsteps entering the room, and smiles, aware of who it is.

Two hands wrap around the chair and cover her face. “Guess whoooo?” Comes a familiar, exuberant voice.

“Hmmm, let me think…” She ponders for a moment, “Catra?”

“Gross.” Another voice says from across the room, followed by an adjacent giggle.

“No! It’s Bow!” The hands come off her face, and Glimmer turns in her chair, grabbing Bow’s shoulder to bring him down in a sideways/backwards hug.

“Hi Bow.” She chirps, looking over at Catra and Adora. “We all ready to go?”

“Yep!” Adora says, patting the suitcase she has packed. Catra is just wearing a backpack, and Melog has an adorable little travel pack on their back.

“Alright!” Glimmer stands up, taking Bow’s hand. Bow takes Micah’s hand, and Adora and Catra come to Glimmer’s other side. Glimmer looks at Catra and nods. Catra braces herself, and Bright Moon vanishes around them.

They arrive at the cliff overlooking Mystacor.

“Ummmm… Where is it?” Catra asks. “Last time we came here we just teleported right to it.”

“The protection spell is back up,” Micah answers, “So teleporting straight to Mystacor doesn’t work.”

“Instead, we have to take the normal way!” Bow says, and he, Glimmer, and Micah leap off the cliff, vanishing into the clouds.

“WHAT!??” Catra’s panicked shout echoes from above. The island slowly floats up, revealing Adora comforting Catra, and Melog with a spiked out red mane that slowly fades as Bow waves at them.

Catra and Adora leap down. “Why is this the normal way?” Catra asks incredulously.

*****

The ride to Mystacor is uneventful, and they see the greeting party. Castaspella at the head of course, and a group of other sorcerers behind her.

“Greetings, Heroes of Etheria!” She calls out. “King Micah (my favorite brother). Queen Glimmer (my darling niece). Bow (Glimmer’s sweet new boyfriend)!”

“Aunt Casta!” Glimmer says, her teeth gritted and blush spreading across her face. Bow waves awkwardly, and Catra guffaws.

“Adora, She Ra of Etheria! (You may remember the time she almost destroyed Mystacor and then saved it).” Adora laughs and rubs the back of her neck. “And Catra! (You may remember the time she almost destroyed all Etheria and then saved it).” Catra

goes stiff, Melog growls protectively and turns orange. Casta waves a dismissive hand as she approaches, hugging each of them one by one, including a reluctant Catra.

“Aunt Casta,” Glimmer starts, “Do we have a plan?”

“Oh, Ha! Classic Glimmer! So eager to move on from your beloved Aunt! Ahaha, only teasing. We’ve got a celebratory feast planned, then that pesky memorial for Shadow Weaver, then another feast, and then tomorrow is the eclipse ceremony. But first, let’s show your new friend Catra around!”

“She knows I’ve been here before, right?” Catra mutters to Adora.

Before Adora can respond, Casta cuts in with, “Oh please. That wasn’t a proper introduction. We were invisible the whole time! Speaking of, how would you feel about Melog getting some time to be pampered and studied by some of our sorcerers? They’ve been fascinated by their magic, and we’d love to figure out some differences and similarities to Etheria’s magic.”

Catra stiffens, and Melog’s mane goes orange. “It’s fine with me, but-“ She leans down to Melog. “Is it okay with you?” Melog rubs their face against Catra’s cheek and meows.

Glimmer smiles. Those two are so cute. Bow’s quiet squeaks echo her sentiment. *Thank the stars for Melog.*

“I’ll be fine. I’m not even going.” Catra says, “And remember, this goes two ways. I feel just how much you want pampering.” Melog nods, and trots over to Castaspella and rubs against her legs.

“Wonderful!” The sorceress says. “Let’s go!”

Glimmer looks back at Catra, who looks small and confused without Melog by her side. Falling back, she takes one of the cat girl’s hands, and Adora takes the other. Catra blushes, but smiles in gratitude as they head into Mystacor.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! If so, kudos and comments are always appreciated.

Shadow Weaver, Part 2: Legacy

Chapter Summary

> In which Shadow Weaver's memorial service is skipped by Catra, the BFS relaxes in Mystacor's spa, and Catra and Adora consult with Casta and Micah about their lingering feelings and traumas about Shadow Weaver.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

The memorial service is brief. Castaspella gives a short summary of Shadow Weaver's life and deeds, most of which are bad, before opening the floor to anyone who wishes to speak. One of her old students, Fygan, a green skinned humanoid who reminds Adora of Double Trouble, gets up and gives a small speech going more in depth into Shadow Weaver's accomplishments as Light Spinner.

"What she lacked in social skills, she made up for in insight. She knew how to make the magic of this world bend to her will in ways the Guild wouldn't dare to dream of. Ultimately with disastrous results."

That's the line that sticks out to Adora.

No one else says anything on her behalf. Most people leave after that. Micah walks up to the small shrine and mutters something before Casta puts a hand on his shoulder and leads him out. Adora's alone in the room now. Slowly she stands and walks to the shrine. She places a hand on the cool stone table, and looks at the memorabilia. A few paintings, a couple scrolls of spells she had created, a Sorcerer's Guild badge.

And a shattered mask.

Catra had brought the mask. Adora didn't even know she had it, but apparently she had delved back beneath the surface to retrieve it at some point in the past few weeks. Before the service had started, Catra had wordlessly emptied the shards onto the table and walked out without saying a word. Adora had arranged them to resemble the intact mask.

Now she's staring into those eyes, replaying the moment in her head.

Shadow Weaver raises a hand, and takes off her mask. For the first time, Adora sees the face of the woman who raised her. The cracked, grey face smiles, almost beatifically.

"You're welcome."

The mask falls, and Shadow Weaver dissolves into a massive pillar of flame, taking the Heart Guardian with her.

Adora looks at the mask and reaches out a finger. She doesn't touch it, instead letting it fall back to her side.

"You're welcome."

Adora clenches her fist. Tightens her jaw. Shadow Weaver ruined her and Catra. She had no right to ask gratitude. No right to redeem herself. No right to be respected. No right to die so easily.

"You're welcome."

Adora closes her eyes, and breathes. In and out. One of the exercises Perfuma had taught her on a day she was actually able to sit still.

"You're welcome."

Breathe in Catra. Breathe out Shadow Weaver.

"You're welcome."

Adora opens her eyes and looks at the mask.

“Thank you.” She whispers, and turns away.

*****

She keeps getting drawn back to the statue.

There are so many interesting places to see and interesting things to do in Mystacor. So why does she keep coming back here? She never even met “Light Spinner”. She only ever knew Shadow Weaver. The darkened statue may as well be of a stranger.

But it’s not. It’s her. The outfit is different, even the build is different, but it’s still her.

The woman who raised Adora. The woman who ruined Adora. Who tortured Catra and corrupted Glimmer.

The woman who sacrificed herself to save the world.

‘She’s probably so satisfied with this, wherever she is.’ Adora thinks, *‘She always wanted me to love her. I bet she’s happy to see me so conflicted now that she’s gone.’*

“Even though I shouldn’t be conflicted.” Adora growls aloud to the statue.

The statue just looks at her, as statues are wont to do.

“You really shouldn’t.” Comes a voice from down the hall.

“GLAH!!” Adora spins around and jumps into a readied stance, only to see Castaspella walking towards her, an amused smile on her face.

“Sorry to eavesdrop, dear but it is a well traversed hallway, not the best place to have emotional moments.” Casta stops next to Adora, who is still frozen in her fight ready stance. “Trust me, I

speak from experience." She looks at Adora. "Um, at ease?" She laughs at her own joke.

"Oh! Uh, sorry." Adora straightens up, and both of them look at the statue.

"You know, she was Micah's teacher." Casta says.

"Yeah, I know. Hard to imagine."

"Well she was a rather different person back then." Casta pauses. "Wore less red. Didn't cover her whole face. Had normal hair. Not as evil. Still a manipulative jerk, but less evil."

"Miss, um… Princess? What do I call you?" Adora says, tripping over herself like usual.

"Just Casta's fine dear." She waves a dismissive hand. Adora pauses for a moment.

Just Casta is not fine.

Picking up on her discomfort, Casta rolls her eyes. "Archmage Casta if you want to get proper. Miss is fine as well."

"Archmage Casta, did Shadow Weaver train you?"

"No. I was too young. So was Micah but… he was *special.*" She waves her hands and makes a face. "We were both ahead of our classes in talent and power. We both tried to get her to teach us, but she only accepted Micah. He was the golden child." She turns with surprising earnestness to Adora, and puts a hand on the blond woman's shoulder. "If you want someone with whom to talk to about this, he's the one. He knows a bit more of what you're going through than I do."

Adora nods silently. "Thank you." She says. On an impulse, she grabs Casta in a hug before leaving, not sparing that statue another glance.

Glimmer

Glimmer finds herself in front of Light Spinner's statue soon after Adora left. She's pacing back and forth, trying to collect her thoughts, until she finally stops and looks up at the statue.

"What I don't understand is *why.*" She begins. "You said you wanted to take down the Horde, but why did that include manipulating me? What did you gain from it? Did you just want a new pupil? Did you want to be in charge? It felt like you never had a real reason to do what you did and I just don't understand."

The statue does not respond.

"Yeah, figures." She says, looking away and huffing. "You're about as open now as you were then."

She starts to walk away, but pauses, and turns back to the statue.

I need to say this. I need to get this out, even if it's dumb.

"You are not responsible for the things I did. Good or bad. I made my own decisions, and I'm done blaming you for them." She pauses, then adds, "But thank you for teaching me magic. And not all of your advice was terrible. You were smart, even if you were evil." She chuckles a little on the last sentence before walking away.

Catra

Catra knew it was going to go poorly as soon as she stepped into the large natural chamber and saw the many pools of water.

"Nope" she says, and instantly turns around, only to have Glimmer grab her shoulders and spin her around. Catra crosses her arms and pouts as she is pushed on her heels into the room.

"You don't have to get in the water." Glimmer says. "The steam does almost as good a job on its own. We can be in the water,

and you can just lie down beside us and we can all relax."

Catra scoffs at the last sentence and casts a meaningful look at Adora. "Somehow I doubt that, Sparkles."

Bow speaks up, "Last time we did this, Adora actually fell *asleep* in one of the hot springs." Bow lays out his towel and places his clothes on it, then lowers himself into the nearest pool with a satisfied sigh. "If that doesn't convince you of the magically relaxing properties of these waters, I don't know what will."

Glimmer follows into the pool, and Adora excitedly goes after them, after giving Catra a smile and a peck on the cheek.

Catra grins at her idiot getting in the water and immediately starting a splashing fight with Glimmer and Bow, then lays out her own towel, safely away from the splash zone, and sprawls out across it.

She closes her eyes, and lets the warmth wash over her. The air is moist, and her fur and hair does get a little wet, but it's not too bad. It reminds her of her shower back in the Horde. She had always hated the shower heads, so she knocked it off one day. It turned the spray into a heavy mist instead of concentrated streams, and it was a little easier to tolerate. This sensation, on the other hand, is much more pleasant. She feels herself drifting into half slumber as a low purr escapes.

She knows it was heard by the clamor of giggles from the pool, and she opens one eye to cast a baleful gaze at the three of them, who immediately spin around to pretend they weren't looking.

"Ugh. Losers." She says, and closes her eyes again to let herself drift off.

*****

Catra's eyes open to see Adora's eyes closed in front of her. She smiles. Sometime during the nap, Adora got out and set her own

towel next to Catra to lie down.

Catra stretches out, grateful for once that Adora didn't try to snuggle. *She's too wet for that.*

Slowly she gets to her feet, and steps away from the group. Glimmer and Bow are still in the pool. Glimmer snoozing on Bow's shoulder, and Bow totally zoned out, probably thinking about arrows.

Catra shakes herself thoroughly before strolling out of the cave.

She wanders the grounds of Mystacor for a while. She passes a hedge maze with a balcony overlooking it, a statuary garden, and an upside down fountain.

'Sparkles was right. Mystacor is awesome.' She thinks as she looks into the gravity defying trickles of water flowing up the inverted feature. She starts as a chittering sound enters her ears. She looks around and sees three flying rodent-like creatures float down to hover near the fountain. They have bulbous, glowing blue eyes and two long furred tendrils ending in similar glowing orbs. These are one of the new creatures reintroduced when She Ra brought the magic back. Most people call them Pixies.

One of the Pixies hovers up to her and chirps before alighting on her head. Catra tenses slightly, not being a big fan of small furry creatures, but she simply shakes her head slightly to dislodge instead of swiping it away as she once would have.

She wanders further, and comes to a parapet overlooking a large clearing. Though it's much more ornate and less tech heavy than she's used to, she knows a training ground when she sees it.

In the little arena, two students are staring each other down while a handful of other sorcerers watch. The first, a scrawny but tall satyr with a mop of curly black hair, frantically scrawls a rune in the air, sending a torrent of wind at his opponent. But his enemy, a shorter, blonde haired human, simply raises a barrier with ease, before dancing to the side and drawing her own rune. The ground

beneath the satyr's left foot suddenly raises, sending him sprawling.

The onlooking sorcerers applaud. The blonde bows, then walks over and offers the satyr a hand, which he begrudgingly accepts.

The satyr walks off, and a new opponent enters the ring, a lithe, wolf like woman with gray fur.

Catra watches with interest as the two duke it out. They're much more evenly matched than the last fight, but one move the wolf pulls takes her out of it.

Without drawing a rune, the wolf stretches out a hand and grabs at nothing. The human instantly freezes, surrounded by a yellow aura. It's only temporary, a move designed to disorient and knock her off balance, but Catra's breath stops and she's thrown into a memory.

"Impudent child."

The air suddenly tightens around Catra's body like a vice. Only her eyes can move, and she frantically looks out into the hallway, praying for Adora to come to her rescue.

"I've told you again and again not to come in here, and yet you continue to be impertinent."

Catra is lifted off the ground and spun around to face Shadow Weaver.

The sorceress is seething with rage, and the Black Garnet pulsates behind her.

"You jeopardize both Adora's and your own future with your continued obnoxiousness." The sorceress seethes. Catra feels a sting of electricity dance around her, not to the level of actual pain, just a reminder that it could come any moment.

Shadow Weaver glares for a moment longer, before sighing theatrically and dropping her grip on Catra.

"I suppose it's just your nature, isn't it." She drawls. "Adora is good and obedient, and you are lazy and ungrateful." Shadow Weaver slides forward and kneels down in front of Catra, putting a hand gently on the young girl's face. Catra looks up at that mask with tears in her eyes. "It's alright, child. I know it's not your fault." The hand drifts down to the chin, and Shadow Weaver pinches it between her fingers and thumb. "You are a wild animal. It's just your nature." Shadow Weaver stands. "You will never be what I want you to be." She waves her hand, and Catra, tears now flowing freely, scrambles out of that accursed room on all fours. She hears Shadow Weaver's derisive laughter echoing through the halls as she runs.

"Are you alright dear??"

Catra snaps back to reality, dimly aware that she's on the ground, and hyper aware of Castaspella looming over her looking concerned.

"FINE" she snaps, scrambling backwards and to her feet. "I'm fine, don't worry. I don't need help, I just… bye." She turns to walk away, her face flushed.

She'd have expected some concerned speech, but she doesn't expect the high, clear laughter that rings out from behind her. She turns, an eyebrow raised.

"Oh come now dear you don't have to hide things from me." Casta says casually, walking up to Catra. "Here, walk and talk with me."

Catra pads after her, still a little confused.

"If you think passing out is going to attract a lot of attention in Mystacor, you must not know much about Mystacor. Students pass out from trying spells all the time. I once passed out for a day and a half trying to copy a spell Micah had cast. It was years ahead of his class, so I definitely didn't have a chance of casting it." They're

back at the fountain now, and Catra is walking with open mouthed confusion, wondering where this story is going.

She's weirder than Micah.

"Really I just wanted to show my teacher that she was wrong about me not being as strong as Micah. She wasn't wrong, but I didn't realize that for a while yet." She shrugs and laughs.

Her laugh sounds forced but I can't tell if it is.

"Jokes on her, I'm head sorceress, and look where she is! Hahahahaha… oh! Sorry dear, hope that's not a sore spot."

"Umm… no? Who was your teacher?"

"Oh! So sorry, I thought I said. I was trying to learn under Light Spinner, who, of course, later became Shadow Weaver."

Catra stops in her tracks, her breath hitching.

"You will never be what I want you to be."

"I'm so proud of you Catra."

"Oh." Catra chokes out.

"Oh don't worry about her anymore dear. She's gone. She did horrible things while she was alive, and now she's gone." Casta puts a hand in Catra's shoulder, and Catra flinches away with a slight hiss.

"She didn't just do horrible things. She was *evil*. And just because she's gone doesn't mean *anything.* You have no *idea* what she did to me. I can't just forget her. What? Just because she…"
'Sacrificed herself for me she gets a pass? Because she saved Etheria she gets to be fine? No!' "No!" Catra realizes she's backed against a cliff wall, her claws out and her hackles raised.

Casta's lips are pursed and her eyes are widened, but she doesn't look surprised or scared, or even disappointed.

"Well of course I don't know what she did to you." She says. Catra's tense expression falters, her eyebrows tilting up. "She didn't raise me. She taught me, but she didn't raise me. I think I know *some* of what she did to you, though." She walks a little ways away and sits down on a stone bench, patting the seat beside her. Cautiously, Catra approaches, and sits down on the ground, looking up as Casta speaks.

"When Shadow Weaver was Light Spinner, she was better. Oh she was always manipulative and she always played favorites, but she knew good from evil. It was fear that drove her to the Spell of Obtainment more than a lust for power, really, though I admit it's easier to think the latter."

"She loved having power." Catra offers, her voice small.

Castaspella nods and continues. "She was Micah's tutor. He was ahead of his classes so he came under her wing earlier than most aspiring sorcerers. She was the head sorcerer of Mystacor for a long time you see, but she stepped down in order to take a more active role in teaching. It's ironic how truly terrible she was with children, because she adored them. She wanted to be loved by them, but she never really cared enough to earn it." She pauses, as if ruminating on that. Catra ponders all the times she was called *'ungrateful'*, realizing that Shadow Weaver really believed she deserved Catra's love from her dark, twisted perspective.

"Anyway. She was Micah's teacher, and she put him on such a pedestal. I eventually aged into her areas of studies but she would always put me down. Sometimes more subtly than others. It was always Micah for her. He was the golden child. He was powerful, special. She could mould him into her perfect little successor. She nearly succeeded in corrupting him. She pushed the two of us apart as she promised him greater and greater things; helped him realize what he was truly capable of. I 'distracted him', she said," Catra's hackles rise at the familiar

phrasing, "and he spent less and less time with me. Eventually, he helped her use the spell of obtainment. But his last minute realization of how wrong it was made the spell backfire, as it is wont to do. It corrupted her even more. Light Spinner was a real piece of work but Shadow Weaver was evil. Even when she was supposedly on our side she was evil." Castaspella pauses again, and continues a little quieter. "Even after so many years I was still so desperate for her acceptance, her approval. It was only when she finally spoke to me as an equal that I felt her role in my life was over."

Both women let that statement hang for a while. Catra draws her knees up to her chest and stares at the ground. *Is her role in my life over? Am I ready for it to be over? I want her out of my head forever.*

"And then of course she died, so her role in anyone's lives is over. Ahahaha!" Castaspella adds, waving a dismissive hand.

"Is it though?" Catra asks softly, not looking up at the sorceress.

She feels a hand on her shoulder, and looks up to see Casta kneeling in front of her. "Yes." She says simply. "Now, follow me. We need to get your mind off Shadow Weaver and I think I have just the thing!"

She gets up, pulling Catra with her, and walks off towards the castle.

Micah

Not all sorcerers believe in the power of meditation. They scoff at the need for a clear mind, believing instead that the mind must always be on the move, coming up with new combinations of spells and remembering rune forms. And perhaps that works for them.

But for Micah, those things have always simply come naturally, so having a clear mind allows him to focus his power.

Fortunately, he's not the only sorcerer who thinks that, so Mystacor has several prime locations for meditation. His preferred spot is the cloud beach; something about the warm sands and gentle noise of waves relaxes him so much.

His peace is interrupted by the sounds of footsteps approaching. He suppressed the urge to leap to a defensive stance, and instead just opens his eyes and slowly turns to look towards the incoming sound. He smiles as he sees Adora come down the winding ramp to the beach. She waves at him, and he raises a hand back.

She approaches closer, and bows stiffly. "King Micah." She addresses him formally, and he chuckles.

"Adora. What's on your mind? Come, sit." He gestured to the sand beside him and she, almost mechanically, takes a seat next to him. Her posture is stiff, her back straight. "Are you alright? Did Casta upset you?"

"No! No, she told me to find you, actually. I'm…" she trails off, and bites her top lip.

"It's about Shadow Weaver, isn't it?" Micah asks softly.

Adora sighs, and her shoulders relax into a slump. "Yeah. Guess it's pretty easy to tell, huh?"

"A little," he admits, "but I mostly know because I feel it too. The conflict between mourning her and rejoicing. It's... tough to grieve someone who nearly ruined your life."

"Yeah, yeah it is." Adora changes her posture, laying one leg in front of her and pulling the other one up so she can rest her elbow on her knee and her chin on her hand. "I feel relieved, but I also feel wrong for that. I know she was awful, and I know what she did wasn't real redemption but… She did save me. She saved all of us, in the end. And she wasn't always bad. I mean, sometimes she showed that tiny bit of good in her. Ya know… buried really, *really* deep down."

"Ha, yes, she wasn't all bad. She was better when she was Light Spinner, but even then she did horrible things without a second thought. She never truly cared for other people, just herself." Micah pauses for a moment, letting that sit before adding, "I think she was changing a tiny bit towards the end. She truly wanted to save Etheria. I think it was less about wanting to be better and more her realizing she would never get what she wanted. No one would ever trust her again. And in the end… she made the right decision."

"She did one good thing in her life…" Adora says quietly, almost too quietly to hear.

"Hmm?" Micah asks, not sure what the significance is.

"It's- it's something Glimmer and Catra told me. When… when they were on Prime's ship, the thing that finally pushed Catra to… um, turn good, I guess? Was Glimmer telling her to do one good thing in her life. I dunno, I guess it doesn't really mean that much but… Shadow Weaver did one good thing. I don't know if she really meant to, but she did. She sacrificed herself for us. And she was horrible and selfish and, and abusive… but she saved the world."

Micah lets out a silent chuckle. "You saved the world, Adora. Shadow Weaver saved you. Give credit where it's due."

Adora blushes a bit. "Well, yeah, huh, I guess… Catra did too though. She also saved- uh me and the world. You know." She makes a grand exploding gesture with her hands, "The power of love, hehe."

Micah smiles and looks out over the clouds. *The power of love… I miss her.* For a moment he imagines her, soaring through the clouds on her beautiful wings. He sighs, sad, but also content.

"Um… King Micah?"

"Yes, Adora?"

“Shadow Weaver was your teacher, right? What was she like back then? I know bits and pieces but I don’t know the full story.”

Micah sighs. “Well the full story is quite a long one… and not one I’m particularly proud of. All the students idolized Light Spinner, and for good reason. She was smart, the best sorcerer Mystacor had ever seen, and she was a very good teacher. Oh yes, she was very harsh on mistakes, but only so that you wouldn’t make the same mistake twice. But she also rewarded good work. She had her favorites, it’s true, and since I was chief among them I didn’t bear the brunt of her criticisms like others did. She saw greatness in me, and sought to draw it out. Eventually though, that turned into her trying to use my power to further her own ends. I may not have seen the worst of her as Shadow Weaver, but I saw how it started.” Micah stands, and paces back and forth. “I always wonder: what would have happened if I had held my ground in those last moments? When we were casting the spell of obtainment, it went wrong because I backed out, and the spell wreaked havoc on Light Spinner as a result. It’s partially my fault she became Shadow Weaver, in the end. I can’t help but blame myself for all the harm she did to you kids in the Horde.”

He feels a hand on his shoulder, and sees Adora behind him, her expression firm and her eyes bright. “Shadow Weaver did the same things to me that she did to you. She just… had more time. But we both became great. She had a hand in that, but she’s not responsible for our greatness. I think we can both take the lessons she taught us and be better for it.”

Micah smiles and looks out over the clouds. “You know you kids surprise me every day. You’re strong and wise and brave beyond anything I’ve seen. I’m so proud of all of you.” He turns back to Adora. “I’m going to head inside. But I wanted to say: thank you, Adora. Thank you for all the good you’ve done for Etheria. And all the good you’ve done for me. You gave me a second chance at life, and your strength inspires me every day to make that chance worthwhile. Thank you.”

Adora smiles, and wipes away a tear. “I, heh, I dunno about all that, I mean… you survived Beast Island on your own for years.”

“Adora, do you know how many bugs I ate? Because I don’t.” Micah grabs her shoulders, his voice getting a little more unhinged. “But I still miss the bugs. No one serves bugs anywhere, and I wish they would.”

“Ohhhh-keeeeeyyyy. Ummm. Let’s… go inside. Maybe we can ask the chefs to make you some nice… bugs…”

Micah laughs as she guides him back to the castle. “I’m only joking! Mostly. Bugs do sound nice right now though.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Comments and kudos are the best way to show your appreciation.

Shadow Weaver, Part 3: A Day of Peace

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra learns that reading is fun and Glimmer teaches her friends magic

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow

Bow has had a very relaxing day so far. Everyone else has seemed on edge ever since the memorial, which makes sense. Pretty much everyone but Bow has a very complicated and messy history with Shadow Weaver. But he's had time to take in Mystacor's sights and sounds, and relax in all sorts of places. It's really helped relieve some of the stress he's had recently. His project with Entrapta to rig a network of teleporters has hit a wall, several walls actually, so the rest and relaxation is what he needs to get his brain juices flowing again.

He's done enough regular relaxation though. Now it's time for his guilty pleasure…

"Book relaxation!" He declares as he throws open the door to Mystacor's massive library. The largest repository of knowledge on Etheria, dwarfing even his dads' library.

While he didn't want to be a librarian, a love of reading runs in his family far too strongly for him to ignore it. He practically prances through the library, taking joy in the beautifully ordered shelves and logically labeled sections. He plucks a novella at random from the historical fiction section, and traipses over to the nearest reading nook, only to find…

“Catra??” He exclaims. The feline looks up, her eyes wide and hair proofed out like she’s just been caught doing something illicit. In actuality, she’s curled up on a poofy chair with a thick looking book in her hands.

Castaspella leans into view from the nearby armchair, “Oh, hello Bow! So happy you could join us. Could you hold this for me?”

Bow walks up, still gawking at Catra, who is glaring and trying to hide the book she was very obviously enraptured by. “Not. A word.” She says, her eyes darting to Castaspella. Bow sees what Casta is making and understands immediately.

There’s a sweater in the works here, and several different balls of yarn. A few balls lay partially unraveled on the floor, and one sits in a state of disarray in Catra’s lap. Bow takes the sweater from Casta, and she shoots up, drifting over to Catra and grabbing her by the shoulders, eliciting a startled “Mrrp!” from the cat. She conjures a tape measure and runs it along Catra’s collarbone before nodding thoughtfully, and returning to her work without another word.

Bow sits down on the couch opposite the two of them. Catra is avoiding eye contact. “Sooooo… Catra.” She glares at him. “I didn’t know you were a big reader. That’s cool.”

“I’m not!” She says, “Ugh, just don’t even-“

Casta cuts in, “Oh, nonsense! She needed a bit of an introduction to the idea of reading for fun, but she’s taken to it like a fish to water! She’s burned through half of *The Lament of Ladarius* in just a few hours!”

“Wow.” Bow says, looking at Catra with genuine excitement. “That’s amazing! Oh you have to meet my dads now!”

“Wait, what?” She responds, her embarrassment subsiding a bit. “Whatever, fine, just… not a word to Sparkles, okay?”

“My lips are sealed.” Bow says with a conspiratorial wink. *They’re not. Glimmer has to know, this is too cute.*

Glimmer

“Alright.” She begins, “Adora, you should have an easy enough time with this. You’re good at memorization, and you already have magic. Catra, you’re probably going to have to rely on your components.”

Glimmer’s two pupils are arrayed before her in the vacant training room. Adora is sitting dutifully behind a desk, with many different textbooks and charts arrayed in front of her, and sketches of runes already drawn up. Catra is lounging on top of her desk, picking through a sack on ingredients Glimmer provided. As Glimmer watches, she pulls one of them out, a large dead beetle, and sniffs it. Her ears twitch a bit as she rolls the insect between her fingers.

“Question!” Adora raises a hand.

“Hahhhh. Adora, you don’t need to raise your hand.” Glimmer sighs exasperatedly.

“Sorry. If I already have my She Ra magic, why do I need to learn sorcerer magic?” She asks, cocking her head to one side.

Glimmer sighs. *If you don’t want to learn it, why are you so prepared?* “You don’t need it, but it’s handy to have other tricks up your sleeve. You don’t even need to use them in combat, they’re just nice to have.”

Catra has her hand up now.

“HUUUUGH. Yes, Catra?”

“This is dumb.”

“That’s not a question.

"I know." Catra smiles smugly. Adora giggles. *'I shouldn't have let them do this together."*

"HOKAY! Glimmer says, slicing her hands through the air. "No more messing around. We're gonna start with a simple spark spell." She snaps her fingers, and a tiny lick of flame appears. Catra's ears perking up betrays her mask of disinterest. "This is useful for all sorts of things. You can start fires, make some light…" She trails off. "Okay not actually that many things, but it's still useful." She turns to Adora. "The rune is really simple." She traces a line in the air, followed by a half teardrop on one side. The rune glows, and a small flame appears in her hand.

"Okay." Adora says. She grabs the magical chalks, and slowly draws the rune on a note card. The rune finishes, and the page dissolves in a flash, leaving a small flickering flame at the end of the chalk. Adora's eyes go wide. "Aaaaaaa!" She exclaims. She pokes the fire, and immediately pulls her finger back, shaking it in pain. Catra cackles.

"Alright Catra, you next. You'll need a pinch of sulfur, which should be in a little yellow pouch."

Catra rolls her eyes and roots through her sack of components, eventually pulling out a tiny yellow pouch. She opens it, and pulls out a pinch of sulfur, rolling it between her fingers. She looks back at Glimmer. "What now Sparkles?"

"Now, you say the magic word, *Ig*, and trace the rune in the air. It may not work the first-"

"Ig." She traces the rune in the air, and a spark of flame ignites in front of her. She makes an ecstatic face.

Catra starts laughing wildly, "Adora! Adora! Look at this!" Adora gasps, leaning in close. Catra closes her hand, snuffing out the flame, then declares, "Ig" again. The flame bursts up in her palm, and she and Adora both go nuts over it like kids with a cool new toy.

“Wow.” Glimmer says. “You’re a natural, Catra!”

Adora claps while looking at her girlfriend like the feline is the most amazing person to ever live. *As if she can’t summon a 7 foot tall warrior goddess at will.* Glimmer rolls her eyes.

The teaching goes on for a while, with Casta and Micah coming in to help, and Bow coming in to learn a bit. After spending the entire afternoon and evening, they came to a few discoveries.

Adora is very good at memorizing the runes, but the spells she conjures tend to be either way too strong or way too weak. By the end of the day, she’s learned the light spell, a spell for conjuring water, and a spell for detecting poisons.

Catra really is a natural. Though she doesn’t have any inherent magic, meaning she’s limited by what ingredients she can carry on hand. By the end of the day, she’s learned the light spell, a spell to conjure a short lived energy whip, a spell to pick up small objects from a distance, and a spell to blow a small gust of wind (she only learned that one upon hearing that it can help dry her off faster when she gets wet). She of course covered up her obvious childlike enthusiasm with sarcastic comments the whole time about how she could just have Melog do all of this for her, and Melog, who had spent most of the trip being pampered and studied by sorcerers, mewled in agreement from under the table. However, whenever Glimmer turned away from her, she could Catra ducking under the table to show off her new tricks to a delighted Melog. Though no matter how hard she tried, even with help from Castaspella, Catra could not cast one spell she’d specifically requested to learn: a simple telepathic message sending.

Bow has very little magical aptitude, but he seems fine with it. He managed to figure out a simple healing spell that would help with his finger blisters from the bow, and he’s happy with that.

Glimmer smiles as she watches Adora and Catra in the sparring circle in the evening light. Seeing Catra bust out the energy whip

to yank Adora's staff out of her hands is a delight, but not as much as Catra immediately whooping and giggling over it.

"I'm so proud of them." She says, looking up at Micah, sitting beside her.

"I know. Catra really picked magic up fast. You should keep teaching her when we get back to Bright Moon."

"I should? What about you?"

Micah rubs the back of his neck. "I don't know Catra very well. She's comfortable around you. Besides, you're a much better teacher than me."

Glimmer smiles, and leans her head against his shoulder. "I love you dad."

"I love you too, baby girl."

They watch Catra and Adora spar for a little while longer before the pair goes off to bed, arm in arm. Glimmer and Micah stay as the last bits of the sun fall beneath the clouds, and the light of the moons illuminates Mystacor. They're almost aligned together, with tomorrow being the eclipse ceremony, but they're nothing compared to the still mind boggling novelty of the stars.

"Dad?"

"What is it?"

"I know I've said this before but- thank you. Thank you for being the King. I'm sure it's hard having to adjust to life and have that responsibility but… I don't know if I could do it without you."

Micah chuckles, no amusement, just affection. "Baby girl, I know you could do it without me. You're stronger and wiser than I have ever been. I don't know if I'm the King I should be, but I do know that you are every bit the Queen you can be, and you'll only grow into it more as the years go on."

Glimmer pulls away and sighs. “I don’t know. I made some bad decisions before you came back… I trusted the wrong people.”

“I know a bit about that, and I can tell you this: I’m glad you went through that. And, in a way, I’m glad I was on Beast Island. Our hardships, our mistakes, those are what make us grow.” He looks up at the sky, and Glimmer does too. “And, you know, most people’s mistakes don’t bring stars back to the world.”

Glimmer chuckles a little. *‘Most people’s mistakes don’t bring galactic warlords to the world either.’* She pushes the thought aside. “Hey dad, wanna do a bit of sparring? I bet your old age has slowed you down enough for me to beat you.”

Micah jumps up. “Hah! You’re on Glimmer. Let’s see how much you’ve really learned.”

The two duke it out in the practice grounds until an irate satyr shows up telling them to go to bed- their light show is keeping everyone else up.

Micah of course won. After all, Light Spinner was a better teacher than Shadow Weaver.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! If you enjoyed, feel free to leave a kudo or comment.

Because this chapter is a four parter, I’ll be uploading the final chapter on Saturday

Shadow Weaver, Part 4: Closure

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra has a dream vision that sets her up against the specter of Shadow Weaver, allowing her some closure.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra knows something is wrong when she awakens alone in a completely black void, instead of in Adora's guest room at Mystacor. Looking around, she can see that she's already standing, and there is a ground beneath her feet, though there's nothing to differentiate it from the black air around her.

"Oh-kayyyy…" She says slowly, her voice echoing briefly before being swallowed by the darkness. On instinct, she steps forward. As her foot hits the ground, the scenery changes. And she changes.

She's back in the Fright Zone, specifically the training room. She's younger, wearing her old Horde uniform. She looks down at the quarterstaff in her hands, and then up at her opponent. Adora. Catra smiles a relieved smile, and is perturbed to see an all too malevolent smirk cross Adora's face.

"Come on, Catra. Gonna start this, or just laze around?" Adora taunts. *It's unlike Adora to taunt during battle. That's a habit she only picked up from me. Whatever. Like I'm gonna let her get away with it now.*

Catra leaps forward, shoving the staff ahead of her with both arms to knock Adora off balance. Adora moves her own staff perpendicular to catch it, and the metal clangs, sending

unpleasant reverberations up Catra's arms. Before Catra can react, Adora has turned her move against her, shoving her onto her back foot, and following up with a swing towards the head. Catra ducks, and swings her leg outward to sweep Adora's out from under her. She makes contact, but nothing happens. She looks up in confusion as Adora just stands tall, that same smirk on her face.

She lets out another taunt, and this time there's a faint reverberation to her voice. "Ha! You think you can knock me down?"

She raises the quarterstaff up, and brings it down on Catra's leg. Catra pulls back just in time, but the metal still smashes into her toes, and she cries out in pain. Her foot hits the ground, sending another flare of pain through her toes, and she looks up just in time to see the butt of Adora's staff slam into her chest, knocking the wind out of her. She staggers back, one arm windmilling while the other readies her staff. Adora moves forward with a flurry of blows, each strike sending out clangs that echo in the room. Catra's staff is denting under the attacks, and she's barely holding on.

Adora's too strong to defend against, and too fast to counterattack. Catra lets one hand off of her staff, and readies herself. On Adora's next blow, she lunges, grabbing the staff between Adora's hands, stopping the onslaught.

"Adora! Stop. What's gotten into you?" Catra pleads.

"Into me?" Adora laughs, and the reverberation is louder now. "I'm just better than you. I've always been better than you Catra. I don't need you slowing me down any more." Catra recognizes the second voice. "You're nothing, and now, I'm going to finish you off!" The staff suddenly spins, and Catra's wrist screams in pain. She falls back, dropping the staff and falling to her knees. The teenage Adora looms above her and pulls the staff back. "You're weak." She spits, and Shadow Weaver's voice is dominant

now. Adora swings the staff in an uppercut, striking Catra in the chin and sending her flying onto her back.

She lands not on the training room floor, but in the cold snow. She looks around. *The Northern Reach. Right, when…*

"HYEH HEHEH!!!" The lilting, almost drunken-sounding laughter warns of the incoming attack. Catra yelps and rolls to the side, just in time to avoid a massive strike from the infected She Ra. The red eyes and veins glow, and the sword is pulsing with energy.

Catra scrabbles backwards, remembering this day. The only time she had ever truly been scared of Adora. She had barely survived, and this isn't the first nightmare she'd had of that day.

Catra rolls back to her feet, and pounces, slashing her claws at She Ra's face. She hits, but her blow glances off, knocking her trajectory off course and sending her sprawling to the ground. Looking up, she sees the demented eyes of She Ra, and the red lightning sparking off her sword. Catra looks around frantically, dimly aware that Entrapta and Scorpia should be nearby. She sees where they had been on the original day, but the two of the are only fuzzy, vaguely discernible outlines behind the third figure standing there. A dark form in red robes, with black hair flowing behind her and white eyes narrowed behind a mask.

Shadow Weaver points at Catra and calls out, "Annihilate her."

She Ra giggles again, and takes the sword in both hands, inverts the grip, and plunges it down towards Catra's heart.

Catra screams and closes her eyes.

When she opens them, she's somewhere else.

The Crimson Waste. Specifically, the valley where she defeated Tung Lashor. She looks around, but the massive rib cage hollow is empty save one figure.

“Hey kitten, didn’t expect to see you here.”

Catra growls as she sees Double Trouble standing in front of her, their very presence a mockery. “Oh come on! You’re not even a part of this.”

“Oh come on, kitten. I’m a part of you. I always have been, even if you didn’t know it. The thrill you’ve gotten from every bad thing you’ve done, that’s me.” They strut forward, and Catra readies herself. “Your rebelliousness. It’s always been your downfall, hasn’t it? Rebelling against Prime, against Hordak, against Shadow Weaver. You did everything but actually join the Rebellion. You were always your own worst enemy. Your greatest achievements were never your own. The Battle of Bright Moon? Entrapta. Salineas? Hordak. You only came close to winning the war because of me. And let’s not even start on the portal fiasco.” They transform into Catra’s corrupted form and laugh before turning back. “It’s not like you actually stood a chance of leading the Horde to victory once Shadow Weaver was gone. No one trusted you. You didn’t know how to lead. You only ever knew how to rebel against her.” They’re right in front of her now, and she can’t work up the energy to swing at them, instead just staring at them. They lean down, smirking at her. “Face it. You wasted so many years trying to be bad, just because you wanted to prove that she was wrong about you. Your whole life has revolved around her. Everything special about you comes from her. If she were really gone, what use would you be?”

Catra’s breath catches. “No,” She says, her voice cracking. “No! You’re wrong! I’m my own person! I saw her die! She’s gone!”

Double Trouble simply laughs, and transforms into Shadow Weaver. “Dead doesn’t mean gone, foolish child.” She reaches out and puts a hand on Catra’s cheek. “You’ve always been so much like me. I live on… in you.”

She laughs, and turns back into Double Trouble as she does. The shapeshifter shoves Catra back, and she falls into the quicksand, and the vision changes again.

She’s wearing her old Horde uniform, with the sleeve on the right. She’s in a cave filled with Horde Tech, where Catra ran the Pulse Bot operation. Where she fought Glimmer.

Where Glimmer almost killed me, more like.

“Catra!” *Speaking of the Princess.*

Catra spins around, and sees Glimmer. The princess (*queen*) has pink flames radiating around her, but as they burn out, they turn black and purple. “This ends here.”

Catra readies a fighting stance, and grabs the whip she knows is at her side. “Well good, because this dream is getting really,” She lashes the whip towards Glimmer, “ANNOYING!!”

Glimmer raises a magical shield, and the whip bounces off, but Catra’s already on the move, leaping from crate to crate, avoiding the magical blasts of energy that come searing towards her, pink and black and purple. She leaps up to one of the overhanging catwalks.

“So, how do you fit into all this, Sparkles?” She calls down. There’s a tinkle of teleportation, and she looks up to see Glimmer appear on the catwalk in front of her. Catra rises to her feet. Glimmer’s hair is changing, getting longer and darker and flaring out behind her.

“How do *I* fit in? You took my mother from me Catra. I’m the result of your worst decisions. What I did with the Heart is all. Your. Fault.” She sends out a blast of energy. Catra leaps to the side, grappling onto the railing and swinging around to land a kick to Glimmer’s side, sending the princess staggering back.

“I know the real Glimmer doesn’t think that,” Catra growls, “She’s almost as guilty as me.”

Glimmer stands up and snarls, “Let’s try something new.” She traces a rune in the air, dark purple and glowing. Catra yelps as the metal railings to either side start writhing and changing,

transforming into long snakes that turn towards her and hiss. Catra bats one away, but the other sinks its fangs into her leg.

"GAH!!" Catra kicks it away and limps back, cracking her whip to keep the reptiles at bay as Glimmer strides forward. Her hair is entirely black now, and flowing like Shadow Weaver's. Her outfit has changed color to shades of red.

"You ruined me, Catra. If it weren't for you, I never would have turned to Shadow Weaver." She traces another rune, and Catra feels herself back into an invisible wall. "Nowhere left to run. Any last words?"

Catra smirks. "I didn't make you do anything Sparkles. Shadow Weaver taught you some neat tricks. Here's one she taught me!" Catra lashes the whip forward, wrapping it around Glimmer's wrist. She leaps off the catwalk, the snakes snapping at the air where she once was. She swings to the ground, and Glimmer screams as she's dragged along with her. Catra lands on her feet, ignoring the pain flaring from the snake bite. She dives to a crate, and grabs hold of the contents. She hears the twinkle of teleportation behind her, and spins around.

Glimmer's right behind her, glowing red and purple, her eyes alight. Catra jabs the stun baton into her stomach and unloads the full energy. Glimmer screams as green lightning courses through her. She collapses to the ground, and the scene changes again.

Bright Moon. The garden that had once been Shadow Weaver's. She stands slowly, taking stock of her surroundings. She'd only been here a handful of times, but she didn't remember it being so overgrown. The hedges are taller than her head, everything is wild and covered in thorns. Looking in front of her, the hedges seem to stretch on far longer than the size of the terrace should permit. The greenhouse is in the distance, the glass broken and massive thorn covered roots emerging from it. It's radiating darkness. Catra takes a step towards it, and quickly finds her ankle wrapped in a bramble. She hisses as it tears her skin.

“Foolish girl. Have you learned nothing??” Shadow Weaver’s voice is everywhere here. “When has the direct path ever worked for you?” Catra rips her leg free, only to feel a vine wrap around her arm. The plants around her are coming to life, animated by a dark red aura, like some nightmarish mockery of Perfuma’s power.

“You are an agent of subterfuge. That is what I *made* you. You subvert the enemy’s expectations with your movements *and* your attacks. I expected so much better from you than to simply charge forward and flail about like a wild *animal.*”

Catra claws her way out, and looks around. *Subverting expectations, huh?* She looks at the hedge to her right and smirks. Remembering her training bout with Netossa, she clenches, ready to spring. The vines anticipate her move, and encroach on the right hand hedge, but she’s not there, instead leaping to her left and grabbing onto a floating boulder. A beam of red lightning streaks out of the greenhouse, shattering the boulder under her, but she’s already leaped to the top of the hedge below. She sprints forward, batting aside encroaching brambles. Another beam of lightning strikes the hedge, blasting leaves and shattered wood everywhere. Catra screams in pain as she is flung to the ground onto a bed of thorns. Her body is covered in cuts, and the injuries she sustained in the other visions still ache. She hasn’t hurt this bad in a long time.

It’s exhilarating.

She leaps to her feet out of the thorns. The steps to the greenhouse are in sight. The sky is getting dark as shadows spread from the greenhouse.

“You’re getting tired, aren’t you Catra?” Shadow Weaver’s voice creeps in. It’s softer, almost inviting. “You can’t keep fighting this forever. You know you can never win.”

“Shut up.” Catra growls. She grabs onto an encroaching vine and tears it in half. “I already won. I beat you, I beat the Rebellion, I beat Horde Prime, and I got Adora. I have everything I want.

You," She lunges forward, grappling onto one of the biggest vines and scrambling up it to the Greenhouse. She looks in through the shattered pane of glass. The interior is filled with thorny plants, and Shadow Weaver is looming over a basin in the center. "You're the one who can never!" Catra lunges down. Shadow Weaver looks up just in time, "WIN!" Just as she did all those years ago, Catra carves a jagged line down the center of Shadow Weaver's mask, and the witch falls.

As they both hit the ground, the scene changes again. They're in the Black Garnet Chamber. Shadow Weaver is sprawled on the ground, her mask damaged, her magic gone.

Catra's back in her old Horde uniform, panting heavily, her claws extended. "Who's the disappointment now, old woman?"

Shadow Weaver looks up at her and speaks, her voice broken. "You always disappointed me Catra. You were everything I molded you to be, and still you disappointed me."

Catra steps back, tears stinging her eyes, infuriating her. "But *why?* If I was what you wanted me to be, then why did you hate me so much?"

The witch stands, and Catra hears footsteps from the door behind her. Turning around, she doesn't see the hallway beyond, just blackness.

And Adora walking in.

"Adora?" Catra says, hopeful, but worried.

Adora casts her a dismissive glance before walking over to Shadow Weaver and standing by her side. "Because you weren't me." She says smugly.

"Because you got in the way." Shadow Weaver adds. "Adora's affection for you is what ruined my plans. If you had just stayed away from her, we could have had everything. You could have been so much more." Shadow Weaver extends a hand. "And it's

not too late Catra. You can still prove yourself to *meee*. Rule by my side."

Adora holds out a hand, and speaks in a chillingly soft tone. "Come with us Catra. We can rule Etheria together. The three of us, as it was always meant to be. Stop fighting Shadow Weaver. Give in."

The room is being swallowed by darkness.

Catra stares at the hands, then at Shadow Weaver's mask. The sorceress's eyes are narrowed.

"NO!" She yells, taking a step back. Adora's face twists into a mask of rage.

"NO??" She screams. In a flash, the form of She Ra is back in the room, covered in red and blacktendrils of corruption, her eyes glowing purple and filled with rage. "Who do you think you are?" She Ra swings clumsily, and Catra leaps up, sending both feet slamming into her chest. She Ra stumbles back.

Shadow Weaver surges forward, purple magical runes sparkling around her hands. "You were nothing before I took you in, Catra, and now you are floundering, without purpose, without *meeee!*"

Catra backflips over the blast of magic. The room has changed again, this time into the chamber of the Heart Guardian. Where everything ended.

"You're wrong!" Catra cries, leaping forward and slashing Shadow Weaver across the chest. Her form vanishes into black smoke. A warbling cry echoes across the chamber, and Catra turns in time to dodge a swing of She Ra's sword. Shadow Weaver reforms on the other side of the chamber.

"Give up, Catra! You will never be rid of me! As long as there is darkness in your heart, I will be there! You can *never triumph!*" She says, launching blast after blast of purple and black energy.

Catra's never fought so hard in her life, keeping the crazed She Ra at bay while also dodging Shadow Weaver's magic, but that statement triggers something within her to snap.

"How many times do I have to tell you, you old hag?" She growls, backhanding She Ra to the side. "I," a kick to She Ra's gut. "Already," a fist to She Ra's knee. "HAVE!!!" Catra swings her fist in just as She Ra readies her sword for a counterattack. Catra's knuckles connect with the blade, and against all logic, instead of cleaving her hand in half, the Sword of Protection shatters.

The shards of the blade dissipate into shadow, and She Ra's form follows with a scream, half Adora and half Shadow Weaver.

Catra dives through the smoke and tackles Shadow Weaver. The mask is gone, and she's looking at Shadow Weaver's scarred, deformed face for one of the only times in her life. The room is still.

"Go ahead, Catra." Shadow Weaver says, her voice tender, like it was in her final moments. "You've won. You've made me *proud*."

Catra grits her teeth and clenches her fist. "I don't care." She spits, and brings her fist down. Just as it's about to connect with Shadow Weaver, the vision changes back to that dark void.

"You're gone!" Catra yells into the darkness. "You're dead, and more than that! I'm done letting you control me. You are gone."

The darkness doesn't respond.

Catra grits her teeth. "What? Do you want me to say thank you?? No! You did nothing for me! Nothing! You may have made me, but I'm more than you! I'm better than you! You're gone, and I'm done letting you control me!"

"Catra?" A weak voice. Catra spins around to see child Adora behind her, only a child looking confused and frightened. "Catra? Why do you fight Shadow Weaver? Why can't we all just be friends?"

Catra takes a step forward, and finds herself turned into a child too. She walks up to the young Adora and takes her hand. "Shadow Weaver never wanted to be our friend, Adora. You and I are all we have. We don't have to worry about her ever again."

She wraps Adora up in a hug.

"I'm never going to let her or anyone tear us apart again, Adora. Never."

The dream ends.

Adora

"Adora!!"

"Huh? Wha-, CATRA! *For the Honor of Grayskull!*"

Crack! Thud.

Where am I?

Adora shakes her head and takes stock of her situation. The room is lit up by her divine She Ra form. She's on the ground, one of the legs of her bed has snapped, and Catra is leaning over the bed looking at her, her mouth quirked to one side and an eyebrow raised.

"Sooo… that wasn't what I expected." Catra drawls. "Are you okay dummy?"

"I's fine!" Adora says, shooting up into a sitting position and nearly cracking into Catra's head. "Are you okay?? You woke up shouting my name, what happened?"

"I just…" Catra leans back in the bed, wrapping her arms around her knees. "I… I had a dream. I think. About… Shadow Weaver." Her eyes are brimming with tears. Melog hops up onto the bed behind her, their mane a dark blue, and starts purring.

Adora lets She Ra fade, and climbs into bed, holding out her arms. After a beat, Catra crawls into them, her head resting snugly against Adora's chest. Slowly, Adore starts stroking Catra's hair. "It's okay. She's gone now. She can't hurt us anymore."

"No, I know. That's… That's what the dream was…" Catra sighs, and her shoulders shake as she starts crying. "I know she's gone. I beat her. In real life, and in the dream. I beat her over and over and she's gone."

You beat her? What does that mean? "Okay, so what's wrong?"

Catra swallows hard. "I… I wanted so many things from her for so long, and I didn't get any of them. And when she said she was proud of me at the end…" She sighs, "I still don't know what to think of that. Was she just trying to hurt me one last time? Was she trying to make me feel better? I want her to not be dead, and I hate it! For so long I wanted her gone, out of our lives, and now-..."

Adora tentatively cups Catra's face and brings it around to look up at her. She lays a gentle kiss on her lips. "She *is* gone. She *is* out of our lives. We're better for it, too, don't you think?"

Catra smiles and laughs, hiccuping a bit. "Yeah, I do. It's just… weird. She'd hate that we're together." She changes her face to look stern, which looks strangely adorable with her tear matted cheeks. "Adora," She drawls in a Shadow Weaver impression, "Catra is distracting you. She's waking you up in the middle of the night, demanding cuddles at all hours of the day." Adora guffaws (*hearing even a bad impression of Shadow Weaver say the word 'cuddles' is strange*), and Catra collapses into giggles, pushing Adora down on the bed and settling on her torso. The laughter slowly transitions into purrs.

Adora looks up at the room around her, and stares into a corner that is lost in dark shadows. She blinks, thinking back to a time, many years ago, when the shadows of Mystacor held a very real danger. Looking closely into the corner, she swears she sees a

dark form sitting there, glaring at her. She wraps her arms tightly around Catra.

“She’s mine.” Adora whispers. “You’re never going to keep us apart again.”

Adora could swear she sees the shadow recoil and disperse at that. She sighs and closes her eyes, letting Catra’s purrs lull her to sleep. The last thing she hears is a sleepy sounding, “Love you ‘Dora.”

“Love you too Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! If you can’t tell, I love elaborate dream sequences, so I hope you enjoyed reading this chapter as much as I enjoyed writing it. Kudos and comments are always appreciated!

Snow Rest for the Weary, Part 1: Princess Party

Chapter Summary

> In Which the Princesses have a party at Frosta's Palace, Catra gives another apology, and Melog tells a story.

Chapter Notes

> This and the next arc are both two parters, and will be releasing on Tuesday and Friday

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"No." Catra grumbles, grabbing Adora and pulling her back down to the bed, nuzzling into her side.

"Catraaaa." Adora says. "It's time to get up."

"Never. Continue to sleep forever." The feline says petulantly.

Adora smiles in utter adoration, but still… "Catra. I've let you sleep in two hours. Come on. We've gotta be there on time. Frosta's a stickler for rules."

"Mmmmm… she punched me." Catra responds.

"You blew up her castle." Adora retorts.

Catra finally lifts her face out of the pillow and growls at Adora petulantly. "Hey. That was actually Scorpia's idea."

Adora rolls her eyes, then double takes, "Wait, really?"

"Yeah. She came up with using the heat bombs as a distraction." Adora smiles, hoping to lure Catra into a wakeful mood with

conversation. Unfortunately, Catra knows her tells. “Nope.” She says, poking Adora’s cheek and plopping back onto the bed.

Melog leaps onto the bed and curls up in Adora’s lap, looking up and mewling for pets. Adora obliges with one hand, and gives Catra pets with the other. Pretty soon both cats are purring contentedly.

Adora sighs lovingly. *I’ll give them a little more time then.*

Thirty minutes later, Glimmer teleports into the room with an annoyed expression on her face.

“Get up!” She barks, spraying Catra with a squirt bottle.

Catra screams and springs out of bed and hides behind it. “Avenge me Adora!!” She cries.

Adora is just laughing. *Stars I love them.*

Catra

As they arrive at the Kingdom of Snows, and Catra’s body adjusts to the dramatically different climate, her mind starts racing. She’s going over all the weird rules she was drilled about before leaving, but also dealing with memories of the last time she was here. The party, the dance, taunting Adora, kidnapping Bow and Glimmer, blowing up part of the castle… But she’s also dealing with her strange lack of guilt over it. It was so long ago by now, and back then she was able to have so much fun with it. It wasn’t like Salineas, where she was already hating herself as she was doing it. It had all felt like a game back then. And it helps that there are no visual reminders of her transgressions. No rubble or destroyed lives left in her wake. Just a ruined party.

And now she’s here to attend another, far more personal party.

The first thing she notices outside of her own head is how different everything looks. The return of magic to Etheria has

affected the Kingdom of Snows just as much as everywhere else, but in different ways. Instead of just becoming overgrown, the materials themselves have changed.

The massive icicles now contain dancing streams of light shining and multiplying through the fractals, like auroras contained in a prism. Semi-corporeal magical creatures float around, interacting with the citizens of the kingdom amiably, some of them even carrying heavy items for construction crews. Plant life has sprung up too, strange fungal trees rising tens of feet into the air and containing massive translucent pods filled with some sort of liquid that workers are harvesting.

The Kingdom seems much more alive than it did last time she came here, and it relaxes her somewhat, making her feel a little less like she's marching to a lonely, frightening citadel.

The walk into the throne hall was just as strict as it was at the Prom all those years ago. She's not sure why. She knows that they're technically here to celebrate some obscure festival day, but she also knows that it's just an excuse for Frosta to see her friends. So why do they have to go through all the pomp and circumstance?

Arriving at the throne itself is just as surreal as the walk up. Frosta has grown, and fills out the seat much more than she used to, but she wears the same ceremonial outfit, and hasn't changed her hair or anything.

The four give a bow, and Glimmer says, "It's an honor to be welcomed by you, Princess Frosta."

Frosta raises a hand, and they stand up out of the bows. Catra is so confused by the disconnect between this Frosta and the one she had gotten used to in the war that she almost doesn't realize that eyes have turned to her.

"Oh! Right." She says, and steps forward, clearing her throat and remembering the rehearsed apology. "I, Catra of Brightmoon,

um… denounce all allegiances I owed to the Horde of Etheria… ummm… renounce the actions I took while I served them…" She starts to sweat, forgetting her lines, but she feels a hand grab her own, and looks back to see Adora. She hears a rumble at her legs, and sees Melog there to reassure her. She closes her eyes and takes a deep breath. "And I humbly apologize for the damage I did to your kingdom during the All Princess Ball. I place myself at your mercy, Princess Frosta." She bows her head and bends her knees.

"You may rise, Catra of Bright Moon." Frosta declares. "I pardon you, on one condition."

Catra's head snaps up. She looks briefly to Glimmer in a panic. *There wasn't supposed to be a condition!*

But Frosta's voice loses its imperiousness as she says, "Can I ride Melog??"

"What? Uh… sure." Catra says, looking down to Melog, who mews their assent.

"Awesome!" Frosta says, jumping out of the throne and bounding to tackle hug Glimmer, who catches her with a shout of alarm. Frosta moves down the line, hugging each of them in turn, ending with Melog.

When she reaches Adora, she asks, "Where's Swift Wind?"

Adora shrugs. "He's been off on his own a lot recently. Leading his glorious horse revolution is a bit harder than he thought." Frosta seems a bit disappointed, but she's content with riding Melog for the time being.

After the somewhat tense introduction, Frosta insists on giving the BFS a proper tour of her castle, all while aboard Melog's back. The Centerpiece of the Kingdom of Snows is breathtaking in many ways, Catra rates it second to Bright Moon among the castles she's seen. The Fractal Fortress is chilly, but not nearly as frigid as

the outside, so clearly there's some sort of temperature control. Still, Catra's not a fan of the cold.

The tour eventually brings them to the Great Hall's roof. Catra shares a rueful glance with Adora, remembering their battle here.

It ended with us falling off. Catra thinks, shuddering and taking a nervous step away from the edge. Her vision tunnels, and she's overwhelmed with vertigo. Adora rushes up and grabs her shoulders.

"Hey, you okay?" She asks, her voice full of love and concern.

Catra snaps back to reality and gives a weak smile. "Yeah, just… need a minute."

Adora turns and waves to the rest of the party, "You guys go set up the party! We'll catch up." She turns back to Catra and pulls them both to sit down on the floor. "Alright. Spill." She says, crossing her arms and crooking her mouth in a hot smirk.

Catra blushes. *Someone's confident today.* "It's just… It's weird being back here. It was all so long ago… I was expecting to feel like I did with Salineas but, I don't feel as guilty. And then I feel guilty for not feeling guilty… ughhh!" Catra sighs and flops onto her back, spreadeagled. Snowflakes gently drift around, some landing on her. "Adora…"

"Yeah?"

"I'm sorry. I know I'm difficult and I don't make sense and I've got *so much baggage* and-"

"Catra! Hey. Back to me."

Catra leans her head up and looks at Adora, who has adjusted to be kneeling right next to her. Adora gently takes her hand. Catra unclenches, and then winces. She hadn't even realized she'd been digging into her palms.

“Catra… I love you. You don’t have to apologize for having complicated emotions. I’ve got complicated emotions all the time. You’re perfect.” Adora pulls her up into a hug, and Catra leans into it, breathing in Adora’s scent.

“You’re a dork.” She says quietly.

“Says the one sniffing my shoulder.” Adora quips back with a snort. Catra gasps in mock affrontement and shoves Adora onto her back.

“Shut up!” She squeaks, and darts to the stairs.

Adora and Catra’s laughs echo through the halls of the Fractal Fortress as they pass bewildered blue cloaked guards in an adorable race through the halls, ending when Catra collides with Bow just outside Frosta’s living room.

“There you are!” The archer says, extricating himself from the tangle of limbs that is Catra. Melog bounds out of the room and nuzzles Catra’s face. “Come on, everyone else is here. We’ve got games and snacks!” He motions for them to follow as he walks in.

Adora helps Catra up, and takes her hand as the two walk in.

Scorpia

“Alright!” Scorpia says, setting down the stack of board games on the table. Everyone’s eyes widen. “We got Magopoly, Ignorance is Bliss, Fightship, Scribble, Chance, Limbo, Connect 5, Who is it? Can You Guess?, Surgery, and Uno.”

Catra raises an eyebrow from where she is lounging on one of the couches, her legs lain across Adora and Bow. “I like Fightship.”

Mermista rolls her eyes from her armchair, “Uhh, you know we’ve only got like, an afternoon, right? Some of those games take hours to finish.”

Scorpia smiles and chuckles nervously. “Yeah, but I just figured that different people would want to play different games, ya know, cuz there’s lots of us and all.”

“Okay, first things first.” Mermista points to Scorpia and Perfuma. “Are you two finally dating now?”

Scorpia blushes ferociously and turns to Perfuma, whose lips have thinned to near non existence.

“If you must know,” Perfuma begins, “Scorpia and I are together now, yes.” She casts a warm smile to Scorpia, who blinks and smiles back.

“Finally!” Glimmer exclaims, and teleports herself over to hug both of them, “Watching you two be awkward around each other was *painfullllll*.”

“Awwww, I’m so happy for you two…” Bow says, his eyes watery and massive. Adora nods beside him with similar tearful joy.

Catra smiles and looks at Scorpia with genuine glee. “Good. You guys are cute together.”

Scorpia meets her smile. *Man, there was a time I wanted that with Catra. But looking at her and Adora, and me and Perfuma… Yeah, things are perfect now.*

“Hey,” Catra adds, “At least you weren’t as dramatic about it as me and Adora.”

Scorpia laughs, and Mermista raises her glass. “Hear Hear!”

Frosta jumps to her feet in her chair and points at the table. “ALRIGHT!” She exclaims, “We’re gonna break off into groups! Each group will be playing a different game! BEGIN!”

There’s a pregnant pause before Catra leans in and extricates Fightship from the pile. “Sparkles, you ever played this?”

Glimmer smiles and nods. “You’re going down.”

Adora pouts, and Catra notices, telling her, “No way Adora, you’re *terrible* at Fightship.”

“Ah, am not!”

“Are too! You get guilty whenever you sink the ships!”

Adora raises a finger and huff in protest, but then folds her arms and resigns herself to sulking. “It represents a big waste of resources,” She mutters. Catra cackles and leaps over the back of the couch to set up on the floor behind it. Glimmer teleports with her.

Bow and Adora choose Connect 5. Sea Hawk, Mermista, and Frosta open up the Magopoly Board. Scorpia and Perfuma settle in for some Limbo.

And Game Night begins.

Adora

Okay. Maybe Connect 5 wasn’t her strongest game. Adora’s a big enough person to admit that after her fifth loss to Bow.

Glimmer and Catra are spectating them. The Fightship game had gotten destroyed by a simultaneous storm of claws and blast of magic that neither girl claims responsibility for.

It’s Bow who suggests Scribble for the four of them.

That one also doesn’t last too long, devolving into an argument about whether some words are actual words, or just Horde words. (*“Horde words are words too!” Catra had protested. “Bow got to put ‘pew’! That’s not a word that’s a sound!” Glimmer had responded with, “Acronyms aren’t words. It’s in the rules!” She held up a rulebook, which Catra grabbed and shredded.*)

Up next was Uno. Catra won, because Bow was too nice to make her draw extra cards.

The Magopoly game had ended by then, and everyone has gotten a little tired of board games, so people kind of just split up into groups to start mingling and chatting.

Catra

Catra is lounging on a cushioned windowsill across from Scorpia, who is curled up on a stool far too small for her towering frame.

They've been chatting about nothing in particular, largely their significant others or how much the Fright Zone has changed, when Catra is struck with a sudden desire to discuss something hugely important to herself.

"Hey, Scorpia?" Catra says, unintentionally cutting off a story about a sentient mushroom infestation.

"Yeah?" Scorpia asks, seeming not to mind the interruption when she sees Catra's sudden intensity.

"I- I wanna tell you something. Something exciting that happened but- but you've gotta promise not to tell anyone okay?"

"Oooh!" Scorpia bounces and claps her pincers, "Yes! I'm great with secrets! What's up Wildcat?"

Catra smiles. She feels weird, excited in an almost childish way. "Well, it's not really a 'secret', you know? Just… something that happened that…" She bites her lip and leans in, saying in a quieter voice, "I made a friend!"

Scorpia looks confused for a moment, then realization strikes. "Wait, like-"

"Like outside the Princesses!"

Scorpia gasps and scoots her stool closer, asking, "How?"

Catra grins, feeling enthusiasm the likes of which she usually only experiences vicariously through Adora. She says, "So I was taking a walk through Bright Moon city, and I was invisible because I was with Melog, right? And I was sort of on the outskirts of this big marketplace, and I was trying out some of my new magic to snag a snack (because magic is *awesome*), and I saw this woman in the middle of the road, and she was engrossed in a shopping list or something, and I saw someone lose control of their carriage while it was turning and it was hurtling towards her!"

"What did you do?"

"I saved her!!" Catra says ecstatically, "I used magic to save her! I gotta say I don't know if I've ever felt more like one of the good guys than I did right then!"

"So how'd you make her your friend?" Scorpia asks.

"Well she kinda did that, actually," Catra responds, "Once she saw me she thanked me a bunch and asked me to join her for lunch. I was so overwhelmed and glad she didn't recognize me that I just... agreed. Turns out she's really cool. I've never really… bonded with someone like that before, you know?"

"What do you mean?" Scorpia asks.

Catra ponders what she means for a moment before saying, "Well most of my friendships were made out of necessity or convenience. At first," She adds, noticing a flicker of hurt on the other woman's face, "But this was just… spontaneous connection with another person. I dunno. It's a big step for me, that's all."

Scorpia smiles broadly and scoops Catra into a huge hug. "I am so proud of you Catraaa! You are so wonderful and deserve all the good things." She sets Catra down, who managed to stifle a purr.

"Yeah," Catra says, "And we've made a schedule to meet up once a week. I'm gonna tell Adora next time but I just… wanted to start with someone who'd know how it feels a bit better."

Scorpia blushes and nods.

Bow

"I guess the thing that freaks me out the most is my brothers," Bow admits. He's been talking to Perfuma for a little while and the subject has (*unfortunately*) turned to the fact that he's been avoiding his family. Perfuma nods understandingly as he continues.

"It's not that I'm scared of their reaction or that I'm not proud of being a Rebellion fighter, it's more that… I haven't seen them in so long, you know? And this big reunion… Really I'm worried that I'll finally see them again, and they'll have changed just as much as me."

"Well," Perfuma says, "The only way to find out is to go. The longer you put off meeting your family again, the more all of you are going to change. Maybe this can also be a doorway for you to grow closer to your brothers."

"Well… we weren't super close to begin with. I mean, I'm the youngest and I was the last one to leave. I was never super close to any of my brothers… Glimmer was the first real friend I ever had. And that adds a whole new question of whether or not I should bring her." Bow sighs, looking across the room to where Glimmer is talking about some Crimson Waste stuff with Adora.

'*She never lets herself take a break*.' He thinks, noting simultaneously that Adora doesn't either. Not the healthiest of combinations at times.

"Do you want to bring her?" Perfuma asks.

"Of course!" Bow says, "But… Is it weird that I think I'd have been more comfortable bringing her back before we were together?"

Perfuma giggles a bit, "That is a little weird, but I understand it. The best advice I can give is this: It's a family gathering. So bring

your family. The one you've made away from home. Glimmer and Adora and Swift Wind."

"And Catra," Bow decides, "I think my dads would love Catra. She's adorable and she likes reading."

Perfuma smiles, seemingly overjoyed at the thought of Catra being included. "Good," is all she says.

Bow sinks back, looking over to where Catra has joined Adora and Glimmer in order to gently steer the conversation away from work. Adora catches his eye and waves him over.

Bow smiles and stands up, turning to Perfuma to say, "Thanks a bunch Perfuma," before walking over to his family.

Frosta

Frosta is so happy that the party has gone well. Her attendants have made sure that a steady supply of snacks and drinks have been provided, and everyone is in good spirits. The memory of the last party she had hosted for all of these people nags at the back of her mind like a persistent chillbug, but it doesn't really bother her.

Her friends are here, and they are happy.

Night falls outside, and as the sky is plunged into a temporary darkness before the moon Avendia rises, Melog calls everyone to attention.

"What's happening?" Frosta stage whispers to Catra as she sits down beside her on the couch, looking towards Melog.

"Just strap in," Catra says, "'cause this is gonna be awesome."

Melog vanishes, and a fantastical 3D illusory show appears before them. It is like an animated puppet show made out of stained glass.

It tells the tale of two Krytians from warring tribes who used their magic to build a secret cave system to be together. Their union eventually brought an end to the war, and produced a child.

They watch as Melog shows the growth of the child through events in its life. When it was young and fell down a waterfall, clinging onto a branch to survive until its parents rescued it. The child grows, and leaves its parents behind to travel the world. It discovers natural splendor and danger in equal measure.

A dread silence falls over the room when the illusion shows the now-adult child looking up at the sky and seeing flared triangular vessels blocking out the stars. Melog tells the tale of Prime's invasion. His devastation of the Krytian people; a vicious war with countless casualties on both sides. Through this war, the child returns home, and stands with their people: the two tribes become one.

One by one, the Krytians vanish from the tableau. Last to vanish are the child's parents.

The child, now alone, retreats into the tunnel its parents had built so long ago. It uses its magic to craft a fortress of spikes and fear around itself. And no matter how hard the invaders try, no matter how many identical white soldiers march into the caves, they cannot penetrate this last bastion of Krytis. One child, standing alone against the might of an Empire that had conquered galaxies.

The invaders leave, but the child never emerges from that labyrinth beneath the surface. Never dares to venture outside and see the ruination of their home.

Not until six strangers come to its home. One tall, golden, and radiant. One short, pink, and sparkling. Another who joins those two together with a heart on his chest. One figure small, with a wrench in hand and two huge pink pigtails. Another comes wearing the face of the invaders, but with a wobbling in its walk and a smile on its face.

And the last is lithe and red, with feline ears and features. Melog's illusion shrinks as they find this figure and see a kindred spirit. One who knows what it is to be alone. One who needs Melog almost as much as Melog needs her. A bond is forged between Melog and Catra, and the story ends as Melog boards the newcomers' craft and departs into the stars, leaving Krytis, and the cave those two lovers had built so long ago, behind.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and Kudos are always appreciated.

Snow Rest For The Weary, Part 2: Elemental Attack!

Chapter Summary

> In Which a powerful fire elemental attacks the Kingdom of Snows, and the Princesses realize a new threat has risen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

Melog's story had left not one dry eye in the party, and the awed, solemn mood had taken a while to shake off, but once the moon came out and the auroras began dancing within the ice of the palace, the festivities had restarted.

Sea Hawk challenged everyone to an arm wrestling contest. Catra laughed him off until he bested Scorpia.

"Wait, *what!?*" Catra and Adora cry out in unison.

"Scorpia can lift tanks!" Adora says.

Sea Hawk leans back in his chair, his hands behind his head and his boots up on the table. "What can I say? I've got the technique."

Scorpia is looking at her claws in horror. "Am I not strong anymore..?" Perfuma rubs her back.

"You're very strong sweetie." She says encouragingly.

"Alright. Let's finish this." Adora says firmly, sitting down in front of Sea Hawk and outstretching her arm in challenge.

Sea Hawk immediately blanches. “Ummm, I think that… I mean I’m tired from all the others…”

“FIGHT!” Frosta shouts, forming ice fists.

“Come on Sea Hawk, don’t be scared of Adora.” Catra teases.

Sea Hawk blusters, “Scared? Me? I’m not scared! I back down from *no challenge*!” He slams his arm down on the table and grasps Adora’s hand.

Adora smirks, and the game is on. She’s surprised to find it more difficult than her previous matches with Sea Hawk. *Guess he’s actually been working out.* But eventually, she makes one last push, and slams his hand down.

As his hand hits, the entire fortress shakes. Adora looks at her arm, while everyone else looks around in alarm.

A guard rushes into the chamber. “Princess Frosta! We’re under attack!”

Frosta spins around. “What is it? Horde Remnants?”

“No Your Majesty, some kind of fire monster!”

Mermista grabs her trident and spins it to the ready. “It picked the wrong day to come here.” She boasts. The other princesses stand and ready for battle. Bow grabs his bow and quiver. Catra flexes her claws and smiles at Adora before Melog vanishes her.

Adora reaches out a hand and summons her sword.

“For the honor… of GRAYSKULL!!”

Glimmer

The Princesses were gathered around a large hole in the ground. The guards had managed to push the creature back before it could cause too much damage, but one of the Fractal Fortress’s

outer towers was half melted. The creature had burrowed into the ice, and now the team was spreading out, looking for the telltale glow of flame beneath the surface.

Bow has set up on one of the battlements, with a line of guards wielding crossbows.

Adora is sending blasts of magic into the hillside, hoping to shock the creature out.

Mermista melted a large patch of snow, and is holding a massive ball of water above her head, ready to strike whenever the monster shows itself. Sea Hawk is by her side, his Sun Sword in hand.

Perfuma is hanging back. Since she's unable to connect to the fungi that have sprouted, her plant magic is not of much use in this glacial land. At her request, a guard emerges from the castle carrying one of the decorative potted plants. She holds out a hand, ready to use it.

Glimmer summons her staff, and scrawls a rune in the air. Her staff hums to life, and she hops on, soaring into the air to get a birds eye view of the field.

"There!" She calls, pointing to a disturbance on the opposite side of the hill from Adora.

She Ra tenses, and leaps over there, sending out an arc of destructive magic into the hillside. An explosion of ice and snow showers the land as the creature emerges.

As soon as it is out of the snow, flame engulfs its form. It's a massive Elemental, easily the size of the ones they'd fought in the Northern Reach. Its body is long and serpentine, with several segmented metal forms wrapped around each other like a rope, and gouts of flame bursting from the seams.

As soon as Adora lands, the Elemental is on her. Its mouth opens, and two jets of flame sear towards her. Her shield rises to block it.

Catra's voice rings out from an unknown location. "Mermista! Push it towards the fortress!"

The water princess is already moving. Her hovering ball of water floats over the creature, letting a drizzle fall and steam onto it. The Elemental hisses and flinches, its flame jet faltering. The water ball falls to the ground, forming a slow tidal wave pushing against it. The creature shrieks and slithers back.

"Frosta! Ice the ground under it!" Catra calls again.

"On it!" Frosta shouts. She slams her hands into the ground, and the snow beneath the creature hardens into a sheet of ice. The Elemental loses traction and begins to slide towards the fortress.

"Glimmer, Scorpia! Hit it!" Catra commands. Glimmer unleashes two massive lasers of magical energy that detonate on the creature's back. Waves of Red Lightning wash across the field below and wrack the Elemental's metal body.

This thing's taking more punishment than most Elementals. Glimmer thinks.

The creature's tail rises in the air, and points towards the ground. The end of its tail spins like a drill and slams into the ice sheet, piercing through and anchoring it to the spot. Turning, it unleashes a blast of fire breath into the tidal wave, evaporating a portion of it.

"Don't let up!" Catra shouts. "Bow! Shoot it! Draw it's attention! Adora, lasso its mouth shut!"

"Fire!" Bow calls, and he and his line of archers lets loose a volley. The arrows bounce harmlessly off, but Bow's trick arrow douses the creature in green slime, stifling some of the fire on its body.

Frosta raises her hand, and ice creeps up its body from where its tail is anchored in the ground. The creature's flames begin to melt the ice, but Frosta is much more powerful.

“Mermista!” Frosta shouts. “Bring the wave down!”

“I’m trying!” Mermista responds. The creature’s fire breath is still pushing her wave back.

She Ra leaps in, her sword transformed into a lasso. She swings it around and wraps it around the creature’s jaws. The mouth snaps shut, and Mermista’s wave crashes down.

As soon as it does, Frosta’s at work, freezing the wave into a massive icy prison for the Elemental. It’s flames are doused, and it thrashes around in its cage.

She Ra’s body glows gold, and she walks across the battlefield to the creature’s head. The noise dies down, and it turns to her. It’s strange, pyramid shaped head looks at her, an array of eight red eyes blinking. She Ra places a hand on its snout, and gold magic radiates between them.

“Be at peace.” She says softly. The creature retracts its head and lets out a rumble. Frosta slowly lowers the ice shield around it. Glimmer readies her magic as she sees the creature’s body shake. Flames reemerge, but not as ferociously as before. There’s a series of clicking and grinding sounds, and the Elemental splits from the head down. Four smaller serpentine forms slither out. All four of them look at She Ra.

The moment is ruined as a flash of green lightning wracks across the Elementals’ bodies. They let out four simultaneous shrieks. One of them rears up and headbutts She Ra, sending her flying backwards.

The chaos of battle retakes the field. One of the Elementals burrows into the ice. Another darts towards Scorpia and rams into her. Scorpia grabs onto its head with her pincers and unleashes a torrent of lightning. It screams and flinches back, dropping her and shaking its head disoriented.

The third turns and belches out a fireball that crashes to the ground at Mermista’s feet. She and Sea Hawk go sprawling. The

Elemental turns and slithers towards Frosta, and gets its head frozen in a pillar of ice, temporarily immobilizing it.

The fourth lets out a scream and launches a fireball at the battlement.

"Bow!" Glimmer calls. She writes a glyph in the air and the fireball washes over a wall of force. Dismounting her staff, she teleports down into the fray.

Alright, you're tough. Let's see how tough.

A blast of energy blinds the beast. She conjures a spectral lash, wrapping around its tail. She sends a shock of pink lightning into the lash, then teleports out of the way as its head slams down on her. In midair, she launches a laser blast that detonates on its flank, provoking a shriek of pain. She teleports again, summoning another wall that it slams face first into. Another magic blast leaves a smoking crater in the side of its head. It turns and launches a jet of fire towards Glimmer. She opens a portal, and then another one. The fire enters the first portal, and exits the second one, redirected into the beast. The flames wash harmlessly over its face, but the move buys Glimmer time to rake the creature's body with a series of concussive blasts. It slides across the icy ground and hits the base of the wall with a thud. It shudders, and then collapses still.

"One down!" Glimmer shouts, and turns to the rest of the battlefield.

Mermista has trapped one of them in a gargantuan swirling ball of water in the air. The serpentine form is swirling around, being battered by chunks of ice that Frosta is launching into the sphere. Glimmer watches as Mermista heaves downward, and slams it into the ground. The explosion of water douses the field, and the creature lays defeated and extinguished.

"Two down!" She calls, as Sea Hawk slices the elemental's snout when it starts to rise.

She Ra blasts back onto the battlefield, leaping into the final elemental and grabbing its snout, wrestling it to the ground. With it pinned, Glimmer watches a wall of water rise above it.

"It's an illusion!" Catra calls out, and Glimmer sees she and Melog have appeared nearby. "Bow, shoot through it!"

Bow calls for his crossbowmen to fire, and Glimmer realizes why they haven't been firing. Bow had distributed his trick arrows among them, so when the volley passes through the illusory wall of water, the creature is covered in an array of slime and nets, pinning it to the ground and extinguishing its fire.

There's little time to breathe, as Perfuma calls out, "Look!"

Glimmer snaps around, and sees the fourth Elemental has emerged from within the Fractal Fortress, and slithers to the roof of the Throne Room. It lets out a shriek, and launches a series of fireballs down onto the battlefield.

"Scatter!" Catra shouts.

Glimmer teleports frantically, grabbing Catra, Frosta, and Sea Hawk out from under fireballs, and taking all of them with her as she teleports up to the roof.

The creature spins around to confront the four of them, but they're already moving.

"Eat this!" Sea Hawk cries, and tosses a small black sphere through the air. The Elemental obliges, snapping its jaws shut on it. An explosion of black smoke emerges, clouding the creature's head.

Catra is next. Glimmer sees her close her eyes and concentrate, then trace a shaky glyph in the air, summoning a spectral red whip. She grins, and wraps the whip around the creature's neck, dragging it out of the smoke cloud with all her might before leaping in and shattering one of its crystalling eyes with a strike of

her claws. She rolls to the side as the creature blasts flame in retaliation.

It's side exposed, Sea Hawk swings his sword up and shatters the other eye. The Elemental slams its head into his torso, sending him flying. Glimmer teleports to him, preventing him from falling off the roof. She sends a blast of energy into the creature as she deposits him to the ground.

"Thank you!" He says shakily.

Frosta steps forward. "Get. Off. My. Castle!!" She shouts, and raises her hands. The roof under the Elemental raises into a ramp, and it slides down with a panicked shriek, falling off the side of the building and crashing in front of the doors below.

Glimmer teleports down to check that it's out, then brings Catra, Frosta, and Sea Hawk back down to the battlefield.

Adora

Adora spent some time in She Ra form herding the four elementals back together and sending them on their way peacefully, healing their damage as she did. After that first shock, they didn't turn bad again. Then, she turned her attention to the group. Most of them had burns of varying degrees, and Sea Hawk had broken a rib, but a good dose of She Ra's healing magic got everyone back to normal pretty quickly.

They're back inside now, discussing the events of the day.

"From what I can tell, that Elemental isn't native to this area." Bow is saying, scouring through notes and books. "Its called a Salamander, its from the northern area of the Crimson Waste."

"How'd it even get all the way out here then?" Scorpia says. "We're on the other side of the world."

“And why’d it keep attacking after you calmed it?” Mermista says, looking to Adora.

“I’ve got a theory on that.” Adora begins, “When it got aggressive again, there was this flash of green lightning. When Horde Prime infected the planet, he somehow gained control of the Elementals. One of the Guardians nearly killed us at the Heart.” Catra inches closer to Adora and wraps her tail around Adora’s midriff. “I think his virus may still be dormant within some of them.”

“Which means someone must have activated it in this one.” Bow finishes.

“But then why here?” Frosta asks, “Why now? Who’d send it here thinking it could actually challenge all of us together?”

There’s a pause, interrupted by Glimmer’s track pad ringing. She pulls it out and opens the communication to General Juliet.

“What’s the situation General?”

Juliet’s voice comes through clear and calm. “Peaceful, your Majesty. We found the Horde camp that was reported but it looks like its been deserted for a while. Tracks seem to lead towards the Crimson Waste.”

Glimmer looks up at everyone. Adora leans in. “General, we’re in the Kingdom of Snows and we were just attacked by an Elemental from the Crimson Waste. There may be a connection.”

Glimmer speaks, “Keep vigilant for reports of any Horde activity outside of the Waste. I’ll try to contact Huntara when we get back to Bright Moon.”

Her tracker pad begins buzzing with another transmission, this one from Dryl.

“Thank you General Juliet.” Glimmer says. Juliet salutes as the call ends. Glimmer accepts the second call, and a staticy screen shows up, with Entrapta’s enthusiastic face filling it.

“PRINCESSES!” She shrieks, and Adora winces from the high pitch. “WHAT A RELIEF! We need your help!”

“Entrapta?” Bow says, leaning in, “What’s going on?”

A voice comes from off screen, Hordak’s by the sound, “Entrapta! The doors!”

“Oh, right!” Entrapta moves away from the screen, working at a console and chattering at the same time. “Dryl is under attack. Bots from both the Etherian and Galactic Hordes along with several Elementals. My own robots are being infected by some kind of virus transmitted by them. We’re holed up in my Castle but I don’t know how long we can hold out.” Her tone varies from frank and scholarly to giddy, but does not show the appropriate amount of fear.

“Just hold on Entrapta! We’re coming.” Adora says, and stands up, looking to Glimmer.

“Thank you!” Entrapta chirps, and hangs up the call.

Mermista stands up. “You guys save Geek Princess. We need to get back to our kingdoms to make sure we’re not under attack too.”

“Smart” Catra says, and stands up and takes Adora’s hand.

“I need to stay here and repair the castle, but call me if you need help.” Frosta says.

Glimmer grabs Catra’s hand, and Bow completes the circle.

“You guys ready to get back into it?” She asks.

Adora sets her brows in determination and nods, and the Best Friend Squad vanishes from the Kingdom of Snows, and arrives at the besieged Dryl.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! This chapter sets the stage for the much more action-heavy second half of this story. I hope you enjoyed, comments and kudos are always appreciated.

The Odd Couple, Part 1: The Battle of Dryl

Chapter Summary

> In which Entrapta and Hordak come under attack, and the Best Friend Squad fight off hordes of bots and elementals.

Chapter Notes

> I could not find a satisfactory way to split this chapter up, so instead this episode is split into two very long chapters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta

Click

E: "Edit to Log, day 27.

E: "I've discovered that Hordak seems to have relatively little trouble navigating my castle, nor do any of the other clones. I remember Wrong Hordak mentioned something about Horde Prime's ship being similarly designed as a labyrinth, only navigable by those connected to the hive mind. But obviously they're no longer connected to the hive mind, so… THEORY TIME!!

E: "I believe it's likely that whatever species the clones are simply has a genetic predisposition towards navigation, perhaps an advanced directional memory, or maybe an innate sixth sense for directions. The large ears may be another clue, maybe they have some subconscious echolocation ability! Ohhh this opens up all sorts of new possibilities regarding their homeworld! Perhaps the entire planet is one massive labyrinth of caves! That could explain so much about their biology! Oh this is exciting! I'll have to ask Hordak about this."

muffled sounds of Wrong Hordak distress

E: “Oh! That reminds me: not all of the clones have as easy a time with my maze as others. In particular, it seems those who were more roughly disconnected from the hive mind aren’t so good at navigation. Welp, guess I’d better go get him!”

H: “No, wait-“ *zap* “Gah! EntraptAAAAAA!”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log, day 34. I am bored. My bots are working on retrofitting the vent system in Dryl so that Hordak will have an easier time staying close to me, but in the meantime I’m stuck here.”

H: “You could simply use the hallways and go about your business as normal.”

E: “Agh! I *could* but that just doesn’t feel right.”

H: “I… see.”

E: “Hmmmm… Oh! I have an idea! I can spend the day working on Darla! Construction on the interior has gone quite well. We’ve upped the number of bedrooms and bathrooms and made sure some of the quarters are atmosphere adjustable for our alien friends. I’m also working on a solution to the thullite problem, but so far it seems to be the only material the ship will accept. We’d need to make some major modifications in order for her to accommodate any other fuel source, and I don’t know if that would be right.”

H: “What of organic matter? Horde industry is powered by coal and oil. Perhaps something similar could be appropriated to fuel the First Ones’ craft.”

E: “Hmmmm… I’ve considered that. The problem is that the engines are too attached to the ship’s superstructure. We’d have to deconstruct the whole thing in order to really change the power source, and I don’t know if we’d be able to reconstruct it properly.”

H: “So keep the engines rigged to the thullite, but route the other power systems to a new system. The thullite’s lifespan will stretch longer, and we will require less of it.”

E: “HAH! That’s perfect!” *muffled Entrapta hugging noises* “LET’S GO!”

Click

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Click

E: “Edit to Log, day 40. Wrong Hordak is improving on the front of gift giving. Today he gave me a flower! The flower was just a dandelion flower that he found, and he didn’t seem to have any sentiment or reason behind it, but still! Progress.”

Click

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Click

E: “Edit to Log, day 56. Two of Prime’s clones in the camp below seem to have established some sort of mental link with each other. Hordak believes they’re attempting to recreate the hivemind. For the sake of caution, we’ve imprisoned them in separate areas, but the distance doesn’t appear to stop their communication. I’m going to go down and see if I can discover anything about this limited hivemind they’ve managed to recreate.”

Click

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Click

E: “Edit to Log, day 58. After surgical removal of the neural implant at the base of the neck, the mind link between the two Clones has been severed. Their dismay at this turn of events does confuse me.”

WH: “They are fools for wanting to remain under the thrall of Prime.”

E: “Exactly! We just want them to have some individuality, why is that wrong to them?” *sigh, then upbeat* “In other clone related news, six more clones have joined our little community, and over half the population has chosen names! We are getting closer to integrating them into society every day!”

H: “But those who resist are just as dangerous as ever. If more of them were able to form a hive mind, they could pose a threat to all Etheria.”

E: “Don’t worry! None of them could be as big a threat as you were! Not with how much more vigilant and technologically advanced we are.”

WH: “Yes brother Hordak, you should not fear.”

H: “I *don’t*. I simply recommend caution.”

E: “Scientific progress isn’t made with *caution!* Scientific progress is made with recklessness and electricity!”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log, day 73. Wrong Hordak has fully mastered the art of gift giving, and gave me, Hordak, and all of the named clones personalized presents. He’s also given himself a birthday. Despite Hordak’s urging (and growls), Wrong Hordak refuses to change his name.”

H: “Of all the clones, he is by far the most grating.”

E: “Hordak!” **hair smack** “He is a very good boy and a great lab assistant.”

WH: “Thank you Brother Entrapta! I do hope the new mask suits your needs.”

E: “Of course it does! I’d gotten so used to doing science through pink lenses, it’ll be good to do it through green ones. It gives me a new perspective.”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log, day 88. Hordak has taken up cooking in an attempt to one up Wrong Hordak.”

H: *Distant* “That is *not* the reason!”

E: “As an impartial observer, I can say that Hordak has a long way to go, but he does have a knack for meat, particularly bacon.” *crunch* “Perfectly cooked, and chopped to be appropriately tiny.”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log, day… 90? No! 91. I haven’t slept for some time, but how could I with all that’s been going on??

E: “After extensive tinkering, I’ve discovered a link between Prime’s neural network and the control mechanisms of his bots. I knew the motherboard looked familiar, but a visit to one of his spires confirmed my suspicions. The bots were linked to his hive mind, but they had dampeners installed to prevent them from developing a consciousness. I believe if we were able to remove these dampeners without damaging the motherboard, we may be able to grant these robots a level of intelligence on par with First Ones AI. Maybe even as much sentience as the clones!! HAA! A robot that truly thinks at a human level of intelligence? I got close with Emily, but her bugs have always held her back. This could be a breakthrough unlike anything I’ve ever accomplished.”

Click

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Click

E: *disappointed* “Edit to Log, day 99. Unfortunately, my first test of removing the dampeners from one of the Galactic Horde’s bots was a colossal failure. When the dampener was removed, it sent out a pulse that fried the brains of all the bots within several hundred feet. Several of the clones also reported a backlash in their neural implants. Any further experiments on this subject will have to be performed far away from any bots or clones.”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log! Day something! We’re under attack by bots from both Hordes, and Elementals who appear to be under the influence of some sort of virus! This is incredibly interesting! It seems to be quite a bit more potent than the virus I encountered twice before! This is faaaascinating!”

H: “Entrapta! We need to call for help, not update the log!”

E: “Hey! Logging information is a vital part of the scientific pro-“ *Explosion* “-ceaauughhh! Okay! Calling for help!” *beep beep click beep* “PRINCESSES!”

Click

Adora

The moment the Squad sets down, the sounds of battle fill Adora’s ears. Fortunately they’re not right in the middle of the enemy force, but they aren’t too far away. Rolling to one side, Adora, Catra, and Melog take cover behind a ridge of rocks. Glimmer grabs Bow and teleports him behind a boulder on the other side.

The scene playing out in front of them doesn’t look good. A mass of bots, both the Etheria Horde’s spherical turrets, and the Galactic Horde’s mechanical footsoldiers. Weaving throughout them are the massive shapes of Elementals, seemingly from all corners of Etheria. There’s a storm of green and red lasers pouring into the walls of Dryl, which are nearly crumbled. Visible around the castle are a series of shapes firing back. Some are grey and metallic, others are white, firing from arm mounted cannons.

Adora blinks in surprise. *The clones are fighting back. Guess Entrapta got to them after all*. She turns to the group. “Okay. We need a game plan.” She pulls out her staff handle and begins sketching the terrain on the ground.

“Catra, Melog and I will be the vanguard. We’ll push forward invisibly and then engage the bots from there.”

Glimmer chimes in, “I’ll get my staff flying so I can rain magic on them from above.”

Adora nods. “Bow, you’ll stay back here, giving the rest of us some cover fire. Move up with us so you can get better angles whenever you need to.” The archer nods, and pulls out a trick

arrow. “Once we punch through, we’ll link up with whatever forces are still defending Dryl, and try to contact Entrapta.”

The ground shakes as a particularly large explosion rocks the other side of the castle.

“We’re out of time! Let’s go!” Catra says with urgency.

Adora closes her eyes and holds out her hand. “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

The sword manifests in her hand, and she feels the warmth and power of She Ra settle into her form. She opens her eyes with a flash of blue and smiles down at Catra, who wipes her wide eyed wonder off her face with a confident smirk. Adora’s vision suddenly goes hazy blue as Melog’s invisibility cloak settles over them. The three step out of cover and rush forward.

It’s a quick sprint to the enemy, and Catra makes first contact, diving out of invisibility and ripping open a Galactic Horde bot’s back, sending sparks and wires flying as she tears into it.

Adora’s vision clarifies, as the bots turn to see the beacon of energy behind them. She gathers that energy into her blade, and sends a sweeping arc through the bots, causing a wave of explosions to tear through their ranks.

A Galactic Horde bot rushes forward, its arms glowing with plasma blades, but it trips over the invisible Melog and goes sprawling before it reaches Adora. She finishes it off with a quick slash, then dives into the fray. She punches through and crumples one of the Etherian bots, then a slash of her blade knocks a small bestial elemental flying.

Pain flares in her left shoulder and she swings around, blade ready, only for another blast of green to strike her dead in the face. She lets out a scream and collapses to her knees, hand over her tender, steaming face.

“Adora!!” Catra’s voice. Adora hears a shattering of metal, and then a protective force over her. She feels her face slowly returning to normal, and she tentatively opens her eyes. They sting, and she sees spots, but nothing too bad.

‘*Thank the stars for She Ra’s healing,’*Adora thinks, not for the first time.

She gets to her feet and nods reassuringly at Catra. Catra grimaces. “We’ll talk later.” The feline says, and leaps back into the fray.

Adora is unsure of what that means, but there’s no time. In a flash, her sword becomes a shield, and she deflects a purple laser blast, refracting the beam into several destructive blasts that take out another squad of bots.

She has a moment to breathe and examine the terrain. The back flank of the bot army has collapsed, and pink and purple explosions are raining down onto the center group from the sky.

“SHE RA!!!” A chill runs down her spine. She whips her head towards the sound. A clone is standing there. He’s wearing a tattered uniform, augmented by armor made of Bot parts. He raises his arm cannon and launches a laser towards her. Adora raises her shield and holds it up, the laser washing off of it. Lowering her shield, she sprints forward, switching to a spear. The clone lets out a barking war cry, and dives in to meet her, a plasma blade swinging out of his gauntlet. His blade meets hers with a scattering of green energy. Her strength sends him staggering back, but a bot’s laser blast strikes her chest before she can take advantage. She wheels around, sending an arc of rainbow energy into the army, shattering the bot that shot her. A large scorpion shaped elemental lunges towards her, only to be stuck to the ground by a sudden explosion of green goop from an arrow.

Adora hears a shout of pain, and turns to see Catra engaging the Horde clone. She watches as her girlfriend kicks his knee, dodges

his blade, slashes his chest, and finishes off with a solid elbow to the chin.

Adora snaps out of her trance of admiration and rushes forward. Before the clone can recover, she's decked him across the face and sent him sprawling. The tip of her spear is at his throat.

"Stand down and call off your bots or else." She growls.

The clone simply laughs. "They are not mine to call off. Tick Tock She Ra! Soon this vile experiment to domesticate my brothers shall come to an end! Wahahaha-!" His unhinged villainous laughter is cut off by Adora knocking him out with the haft of her spear.

She turns to Catra. "We have to get to Entrapta."

"Duh." Catra says, and turns to face the rest of the oncoming bots.

Adora turns, and glows with energy as she prepares for the push to Dryl.

Hordak

Hordak stands in one of Dryl's long corridors, his exosuit thrumming with power and his arm cannon primed. A smoking pile of wreckage lies at the end of the hall, where he just destroyed several of Entrapta's bots, turned against their masters by some strange virus. Entrapta is hunched behind him, with several devices held in her hands and hair, scanning for a source that is ordering these bots.

"This is fascinating." She mutters. Hordak swings his cannon around a side hallway, and blasts a Galactic Horde bot to smithereens. "It's like they're all ordering each other. It's this continuous feedback loop that's cloaking the source. I've never seen anything like it, it's incredible. It's also very, very bad for us though."

Hordak wipes sweat off his forehead. The battle is getting to him.

"Why?" Comes the voice of Wrong Hordak, who is covering Entrapta's back with a long metal rebar.

"Unless we get some sort of beacon, I'm going to have to check each signal individually until I find one strong enough to be the source, but there are hundreds of them out there, and it takes too long to focus in on one signal to get a measurement. Now maybe if I could link to the antenna at the top of Dryl I could boost my signal enough to speed up the process…" Her diatribe is cut off as the castle rumbles again.

"Entrapta!" Hordak barks, "Lead us to the top of the castle!"

"Right! Follow me!" She surges forward, and both Hordak and Wrong Hordak take off after her. "Gagk!" She squeaks as they round a corner. Hordak lunges forward as she ducks. His gauntleted fist crashes into the bot, which goes flying backward and crushes another one against the wall. He helps Entrapta back to her feet, and the other clone cries out.

"Brothers, what is that!?"

Hordak looks up to see a section of the stone wall ahead is changing color to orange, and beginning to melt.

Of course. The temperature. He had been a fool to assume that the rising temperature had simply been a figment of stress.

The melting wall explodes in a blast of fire, and a massive, flaming metal serpent slithers through. Hordak grits his teeth. A Salamander elemental.

"Together!" He shouts. Wrong Hordak steps forward, and pulls a laser cannon from his side, holding it under arm. Green and Red energy flies down the hall and connects with the Salamander in a giant explosion. The creature bellows in pain, and Hordak springs forward. *We don't stand a chance of destroying it, but we can slow it.* He grabs one of the metal arches, and pulls on it. The exo

suit provides him the strength he needs, and the metal warps, pulling down into the center of the hallway with a mighty groan. He grabs the arch on the other side of the hall and does the same, covering the hall in a massive metal X. He rolls backward as a jet of flame flies towards him. The stone partially caves in as the arches supporting it have been bent away.

"Come on! Through the painting!" Entrapta yells. He spins in time to see Entrapta's purple hair vanishing behind a large painting of a cat.

Hordak runs to catch up with her. "Slow down Entrapta!" *I can't protect you if you're far from me.*

A crash of metal rings out below. His barrier is holding for now, but the Salamander will break through soon.

The trio rushes up a set of stairs, and Entrapta throws open a doorway. Light streams through, and Hordak hisses in pain from the sudden adjustment. He follows after the high pitched laughter and comes out to a high balcony.

"Ba! They're here! Look, it's She Ra!" Entrapta says, jumping up and down in excitement.

Hordak scans the battlefield. A mismatched horde of bots and Elementals is in utter chaos, as a beacon of multicolored light seems to have smashed through their back flank. Indeed, She Ra and her allies have arrived.

'How ironic that this sight brings relief where once it would have inspired rage and dread,' Hordak thinks.

"TRAITORS!" A voice bellows. Hordak spins and looks down the balcony. Another clone is standing there, wearing a tattered Horde uniform. The clone flexes his arm, and a green plasma blade extends.

"Brother, there is no need for violence!" Wrong Hordak calls out in his sickeningly optimistic way.

Hordak simply raises his arm and charges the cannon. “Step. Aside. Worm.” He growls.

The other clone laughs, and flourishes the blade before charging forward.

Hordak’s beam strikes him in the chest and lifts him off his feet, sending him sailing off the balcony towards the ground below. He looks back at his compatriots. Entrapta is deep in her screen, while Wrong Hordak stares at him, horrified.

“Brother… how could you?” He asks.

Hordak simply sneers at the naive fool, then grabs Entrapta’s hand and rushes towards the stairs up to the summit of the castle.

Bow

This flank of the bot army has almost entirely collapsed against She Ra and Glimmer’s onslaught.

Catra and Bow are behind a boulder. Catra’s dragged the unconscious body of the armored Horde Clone back so the two of them can interrogate him.

Bow pulls out an arrow and pushes on it, sending a spray of water into the clone’s face, startling him awake. He ignores the incredulous look Catra gives him as he replaces the arrow back in his quiver.

“Alright. Talk.” Bow starts. “Who are you?”

The clone sneers at him. “I am nought but an extension of Horde Prime’s will.”

Catra scoffs. “Okay, well Prime is dead, so you’re acting on your own here. Next question: Why are you attacking Dryl?”

“Prime reigns eternal, Etherian fool!”

Catra flexes her claws in front of his face. “The question.”

The clone’s eyes widen, and he gulps in fear. “We lay siege to this castle because we are honor bound to put an end to the heretical experiments they perform. Tearing clones from the comfort of the hive mind, giving them *names*?? It is an abomination, and so must be purified!” The end of his sentence is punctuated by an explosion from the battlefield.

Catra looks at Bow with concern. Bow puts a hand on her shoulder. “They’ll be okay.” He turns back to the clone. “How do you have control over these bots?”

The clone smiles wildly. “They are but tools. Means to an end. We have control over them because we have control over all!”

“We?” Bow asks, and the clone’s mouth snaps shut. *He let something slip*. Bow smiles. He reaches into his pack and pulls out his tracker pad. He types in the right number and waits. *Come on Entrapta…*

“Hi Bow!!” Comes the excited voice from the other end. There’s no visual, so she must be doing something else.

“Entrapta! The clones are in control of the bots! We’re not sure how, but if you can find the source, we can neutralize the clones and hopefully take care of this virus.”

“Thank you! You’ve narrowed my search significantly. Hordak! Start a scan for life forms!” Bow faintly hears a response on the other end, but he’s gotten what he needs. He turns and nods to Catra, who clenches her fist and punches the clone in the head, knocking him back unconscious.

Bow pokes out with an arrow nocked, and Catra leaps over the boulder to rejoin the fray.

Hordak

Scanning for life forms is not quite as easy as Entrapta had assumed. Hordak's eyes rake across the screen, and then he looks out over the battlefield. He makes a connection between screen and reality, and swipes that form aside. Elementals register as life forms, but he is sure none of them are behind this. There's a cluster of life forms on one side of the field that he's managed to identify as She Ra and her allies. He's finally narrowing it down. Pressing on one of the dots to find extra details, the readout is familiar, as is the energy reading connecting to two other life forms.

Hordak lets out a low growl. *'I should have guessed.'*

"What is it? Have you found it??" Entrapta asks.

"Yes." Hordak responds, his teeth gritted. "And there's a powerful signal coming off of it."

"Excellent!" Entrapta pulls out her tracker pad and calls the archer.

"Entrapta!" The boy calls, "Any luck?"

"Yes!!" Entrapta cries. "Hordak and I have discovered the source of the signal that's guiding the bots! Tell him Hordak!"

"The signal is coming from a trio of clones. One of them is on your side of the battle, one is on the other flank, and the third…" Hordak looks at his screen to make sure. "The third is in the camp below."

Wrong Hordak turns and looks at Hordak with wide, shocked eyes, and Hordak turns to face Entrapta. "We've a traitor in our midst."

Catra

Catra grins. She hadn't realized just how much she'd missed being in the heat of combat. Sparring with Netossa was fun, but this… The tension, the chaos, the heat, the smells… It's horrific and terrifying. But so incredibly thrilling.

She pulls out a length of string and carves a rune in the air, summoning her red spectral whip. She lashes it out, wrapping it around a Galactic Horde bot and yanking it into the path of another bot's laser. She takes a second to look around the battlefield. This flank has almost completely collapsed. She watches as Glimmer teleports down, grabs She Ra, and vanishes.

'Huh. Guess she's off to the other side. Thanks for telling us,' She thinks bitterly.

She's snapped back to reality by a metal stamping sound behind her. She spins on her heels and bends her knees, tearing through the metal with her claws.

The spherical Etherian Horde bot staggers a step back to regain its balance, and Catra freezes, her eyes wide.

She's not sure if she's ever really frozen in battle before, but seeing this bot, the exact location of those four scratch marks in its armor plating… The memories flash too fast for her to comprehend any of them. She's dimly aware of the bot's cannon revving up, and someone shouting "CATRA!!"

She's back in reality, but it's just as blurred. To one side, a shower of pink sparkles. A hand grabbing her upper arm. She's thrown off balance, and the bot fires. There's a scream of pain beside her, and she goes sprawling.

She's on her feet in an instant. An arrow slams into the bot, arcing electricity through it. It thuds to the ground, smoking. Catra whips her head to the side, and sees what she feared.

Glimmer is curled up on the ground, smoke rising from her form. There are scorch marks around her.

"NO!" Catra cries, and dives forward, skidding along the rocks and grabbing the queen and laying her on her back. Catra puts her hand on the back of Glimmer's head. Glimmer's eyes are scrunched closed. The fabric of her outfit has been burned away at the stomach, and the skin is marred by a fresh burn. "No no no

no no.” Catra says. “Come on.” She gently rattles Glimmer’s head, and is rewarded with a grunt. Catra lets out a breath of relief, and is almost surprised when tears start flowing. Melog appears beside her, mewling frantic questions. “Melog. Go get Bow. Hurry!” The Krytian hesitates, then nods and vanishes. Catra turns back to Glimmer, whose eyes are flickering open. “Glimmer? Glimmer!” Glimmer blinks and her eyes focus on Catra’s face. “Just focus on me, okay? Bow’s on his way. You’ll be okay.” Her voice is hoarse, and she can’t stop the tears from falling.

Don’t be hurt. Don’t die. I can’t live with that.

“Catra?” Glimmer says weakly. “What happened?” Glimmer tries to sit up, and immediately cries out in pain and falls back. Her hand moves to her stomach instinctually. Catra reacts in time and grabs the hand before it can slap down on the exposed wound.

“Don’t-! Glimmer. You got hurt. Bow’s on his way, and he’ll get you out of here. Just don’t touch your stomach, okay? You’re gonna be okay.” Her voice is cracking.

You’ll be okay. You have to be okay.

“C-Catra…” Glimmer says, coughing lightly. “I need to tell you something.”

“Hey… Don’t talk like that. Tell me later, okay?” Catra says, desperately trying to get her breathing in check, and avoid looking at Glimmer’s wound. She looks around. There are bots closing in on them. *Where’s Bow??* She grabs Glimmer’s shoulder and pulls the queen up onto her lap.

“Catra… You called me Glimmer.”

“What?” Catra says, looking at Glimmer in confusion. There’s a mischievous smile on the other woman’s face.

“You called me Glimmer instead of Sparkles. I think you’re starting to like me.”

Catra guffaws despite herself. *She's in stars know how much pain, and* that's *where her mind goes!? Pft. Princesses.* "Yeah. I like you, *Glimmer*. Now do me a favor and don't die." *Please.* Catra sets Glimmer down and rises, looking at the line of bots circling around them. She flexes her arms and winces. Her right arm has a nasty looking burn on it, but she ignores the pain and conjures her whip, ready to defend her wounded friend.

Bow

Three arrows are fired in rapid succession. The first one detonates in a concussive blast that sends three bots flying. The second tangles two more in a net. The third fries a bot with electricity.

Bow doesn't break his stride as another arrow bathes an Etherian bot in a wave of fire. His face is set in determination. Catra looks over her shoulder and sees him sprinting forward, Melog snarling, red maned at his side.

"Bow!" She shouts, and immediately turns and crouches over Glimmer's small, prone form.

"Glimmer!" He shouts, and arrives, falling to his knees next to her and grabbing her, scooping her into his lap and putting a hand on the side of her head. His thumb rubs her cheek gently as her eyes open, meeting his.

She smiles, and a tear falls from one eye. "Hi Bow." She says weakly.

Bow immediately gathers her in his arms and stands up. He turns and begins rushing back to cover. Glimmer winces as the position he's carrying her causes her stomach to bunch up, but Bow pushes through his immediate panic and worry. *Need to get her to safety, then find out how serious it is.*

They make it back to the rock, and Bow puts her down. A set of footsteps following him clues him into the fact that Catra has followed them back.

The feline rushes up, looming over them. “Is she okay? She’s okay right?”

“I don’t know! Give me some space!” Bow says firmly. He doesn’t mean it to come out as harshly as it does, and he winces when Catra stumbles back like he’s struck her. “I need some time.” He says softly, turning his head to give Catra a reassuring look.

“Oh. Right, yeah, sorry.” Catra says. She nods to herself, and rushes off into battle.

Bow notices a large mark on her upper arm, and calls out, “Catra, wait!” But she’s already rushed off to join Melog in finishing off the bots. *She’s gonna get herself hurt.*

Bow shakes his head. He only needs to worry about Glimmer right now. He turns to look at her. She’s laid out flat on her back. He finally looks at the wound fully. It’s not good, but it could be worse. The blast hit her while she was moving, so it’s more of a glancing blow, distributed across the surface of the skin instead of causing a deeper, potentially life threatening wound.

“Okay.” Bow says to himself. He pulls out an arrow and a small towel. He empties the arrow’s water supply into the washcloth, and gently begins dabbing around the wound. Glimmer winces and whines in pain.

“Stop it.” She says, sounding somewhat groggy.

She’s still in shock. Bow thinks to himself as he sets about cleaning the wound.

He sets the cloth aside as Catra returns.

“Is she okay?” She asks. Melog trots up beside her, their mane swirling orange with worry.

“She’ll be okay. It’s mostly on the surface. She’s in shock, but once that wears off she’ll be in a lot of pain. I’m gonna stay back

here with her. You have to find Hordak and Entrapta and take down that clone."

Catra nods, but her eyes are firmly on Glimmer.

"Hey." Bow stands up and puts gentle hands on her shoulders. "She'll be okay."

"Yeah, yeah..." Catra says, her voice unfocused. Tears begin to well up in her eyes as she finally looks up at Bow. "It was my fault…" She says, her voice heartbreakingly small. "I froze, and she pushed me out of the way and now she's hurt and it's *my fault.*"

"Hey." Bow says. Catra crumples to the ground, and he follows, kneeling in front of her and wrapping his arms around her. "It's not your fault. If she hadn't saved you, you'd be the one hurt. And you'd be in worse shape than she's in."

"But-"

"No." Bow squeezes her and pulls away, looking her in the eye. His voice is soft, but firm. "We all take risks to save the people we love. You've done it for Adora, and Glimmer did it for you. She'll be fine. Frankly the worst that'll happen is she's definitely going to lord this over you for a while." Catra chokes out a laugh through her tears. "Once this is over, Adora can heal her. Right now we need you to get into Dryl, and help Entrapta find that clone, before this happens to somewhere else." He looks back over to the other rock, where their clone prisoner is tied up and gagged. "Once I've helped Glimmer I'll do what I can from here."

"Okay." Catra says. She sniffs and wipes her face. "Okay." Her voice firms up, and she rises to her feet. Melog's mane shifts to a more normal blue. "Take care of her."

"That's the plan." Bow responds with a smile. "You can do this Catra."

Catra sets her jaw with determination, and Melog turns them both invisible. Bow hears their retreating footsteps, and he breathes in relief before turning back to Glimmer.

Glimmer's eyes are wide, and she's crying. "That was so beautiful Bow." She says, her voice wavering.

Bow sniffs and blinks back tears of his own. *Do not get distracted by how cute she is. She's loopy from the shock.* He huffs, and gets out his first aid kit, ready to start the process.

Adora

The fighting on the other side of Dryl is much fiercer. She Ra's power flattens waves of bots and elementals at once, but without Bow, Glimmer, Catra, and Melog backing her up, Adora is beginning to feel the fatigue of battle. Her form is holding, but she's dodging fewer hits, and the pain is getting more intense each time she takes a blast from a laser.

She grits her teeth as a beam sings past her head, leaving her ear ringing. She whips her blade around and points it at the bot that fired it, and casts out a bolt of jagged blue energy that dismantles the bot. She spins around, and carves through one that had been closing in behind her. Breathing heavily, she looks around. The bots are adjusting. They're halting their advance on Dryl and turning instead towards her, forming a circular wall around her.

Adora smirks. "Looks like I got your attention, huh?" She grabs her blade in both hands and readies to charge, but then she notices a rumble in the ground. The ranks of the bots split, and the earth cracks and exploded outward.

Crawling out of the hole is a massive elemental, one Adora's never seen before. It's made of interlocking, large metal plates. Its face is angular and pointed, and its four stocky legs are tipped with three thick, spade-like claws. The beast opens its mouth and lets out a guttural bellow before turning to her. Translucent eyelids close above its crystalline eyes. *'Great, there goes that weak spot.'*

The elemental paws the ground as it faces her, and she watches as a form rises from its back. A clone, wearing a suit of thick plate armor with a glass face covering. Salvaged from old Etherian Horde outfits and beefed up significantly with what looks like a Galactic Horde bot's chassis

"She Ra." The clone says. This one is much less bombastic than the one she faced on the other side. His voice is calm and cool, reminding her too much of Prime. She prefers the ones that sound angrier. "I must say I am delighted that you have come. I was worried that I would not get the honor of facing you in combat." The beast begins to stalk around the circle, and Adora turns to match its rotation. "Your performance exceeds even the most concerning of reports. But I digress." The clone reaches to the side, and lifts up a long metal lance, pointing it at her. His other arm, clutching the reins of this elemental, lights up with an energy shield emerging from the gauntlet. "The time has come to pay for your heresy. When Lord Prime returns, he will be most pleased to hear that I have avenged him."

"In your dreams." Adora says with a smirk. "Let's just start. I'll let you go first."

The clone smiles, and the visor changes color to hide his face. The Elemental makes the first move. Adora watches it shudder, and then open its mouth. A massive, condensed boulder rockets across the field towards her. She swings her sword and bisects the rock, then fixes her stance to set against the beast's charge. Letting the sword dissipate, she steps to one side of the elemental's head, and slams her palms into its face, knocking it skidding off course. It grinds to a halt, and spins around, opening its mouth to launch another boulder. This time, Adora moves with the rock's momentum, catching it and spinning a full 360 degrees before letting go, sending the boulder crashing into the Elemental's head plate. The creature steps back, stunned, and Adora charges. Her blade materializes in her hand, and she leaps, slashing across the creature's nose and landing on its back, looking down at the clone.

“Hi.” She says, feeling rather cocky.

The clone doesn’t respond, he simply sweeps his lance to the side, knocking Adora’s legs out from under her. She yelps and slides down the creature’s side, crumpling to the ground upside down. She opens her eyes, and immediately yelps again and instinctively curls into a fetal position. The Elemental surges forward, catching her underfoot and trampling her as it moves. She spins across the ground, her body thoroughly battered by those thick claws. Eventually, she emerges behind it, her head getting knocked by its tail. She uncurls and stands up, wincing. Her vision is blurry from the pain she’s in. She Ra is tough, but a beating like that is enough to stun Adora for a solid minute.

She does not have a minute. The beast opens its mouth again, and Adora prepares to dodge another boulder, but instead a storm of smaller rocks and dirt spew out. Adora shouts, and is blinded by the spray. Panicking, she begins blinking rapidly, but as she’s distracted, the Elemental slams into her side. The pointed nose lifts her off her feet and sends her flying across the makeshift arena. She skids to a halt against the crater where the pair first emerged.

The voice of Prime echoes across the battlefield. *No. Not Prime. Just a clone.* “She Ra. Tsk tsk. I expected more of a fight. Are you just going to lie down and die so easily?”

She Ra rises to her feet, gritting her teeth and slowly opening her eyes. Her rage and determination fuels her power. Light radiates from her form and her eyes glow solid blue. “No.” She says. She summons her blade, and multicolored energy begins to wash off of it. “This ends now.” The blade swings in a downward arc, and a massive wave of power surges across the battlefield. The Elemental digs its claws in and skids 10… 20… 30 feet backwards. The clone lies down flush on the creature’s back. The wave continues. The metal plating begins to warm and crack. The wave is narrowing down, turning into a concentrated blast targeting her foes.

Suddenly, a searing pain strikes into her side, and her concentration drops. She spins, facing the bot that just shot her, only for another blast to hit her shoulder. Adora lets out a battle cry, raking her blade through the air, unleashing the energy into the line of bots. Explosions rip through their ranks.

"I quite agree!" The clone calls out.

Adora turns to look at him, and then hears a grinding of metal and stone behind her. She spins around, and sees an Etherian bot of very distinctive make: Spherical, with long strut like legs that clamp onto the ground, and a massive drill on the bottom that has plunged into the rocky soil to anchor it. Adora's eyes widen as the red light blinks its short countdown, and she has just enough time to think, *'I thought we destroyed all of these!'* before a pulse blasts out from it, ripping across the battlefield and ripping into her body. She's sent flying, rolling across the battlefield, the pain overwhelming her senses. She's stunned for several seconds, and she feels the vibrations of something large standing over her.

She opens her eyes, and is first conscious of the fact that She Ra's form has dropped. She's just Adora, wounded and stunned, lying in the middle of the battlefield, with a massive elemental looming over her. The clone brings the lance forward, and the pointed tip presses into Adora's throat.

"Now, it ends." He says coolly, and begins to press down on the weapon.

Adora panics, so many thoughts going through her mind in these milliseconds. *'This can't be it. I'm She Ra! There's so much more I have to do. I won't die here. I can't. Catra… I love you. I'm sorry for everything.'*

'Someone… anyone… help me.'

'Please…'

"HhhyyyyyyeaAAAAGH!!!" A battle cry rings across the field. The clone's head whips around, and a large shape sweeps over him. A

long limb lashes out, and there's a ring of metal as he takes the strike directly to the face. His visor cracks, and he goes flying out of the saddle.

Adora's savior spins around and lands in the ring, his wings spread wide, his hair flowing majestically in the wind.

"Did someone say… SWIFT WIND!?" The alicorn says triumphantly.

Adora leaps to her feet, and sprints towards her companion, tears in her eyes, ignoring the pain wracking her body. She leaps up and wraps her arms around Swift Wind's neck, burning her face in his side.

"Thank you Swifty!" She says, her voice full of relief and gratitude.

The horse brings his head down to pat her back. "Awww, you're welcome. What kind of noble steed would I be if I didn't come to your rescue in your time of need?"

Adora chuckles, and turns around. The clone is rising to his hands and knees, and the Elemental is at his side. He growls and tosses the damaged helmet aside. A trickle of green blood is running down his face from a cut on his forehead. He leaps back onto the Elemental. His lance lies in the dirt, but he draws a long, white sword from the other side of the saddle, and a green plasma blade ignites on one side.

Adora sets her brows, and cracks her knuckles. "Let's go Swifty." She says with a confident grin. She flexes her arm and re-summons her sword. "For the honor… of Grayskull." She says, her voice full of tranquil fury as she looks at this clone who came so close to robbing her of her future. Her future as She Ra, her future as Adora, her future with Catra.

The strength and power of She Ra washes over her, and she leaps onto Swift Wind's back.

The Elemental bellows. The horse neighs, and both charge.

Swift Wind rises into the air and banks to the side. Adora leans down and slashes towards the clone, her blade meeting his in a shower of magic and plasma. Swift Wind arcs around in the air, turning faster than the Elemental does. He makes a curved line through the air, flying low to strike it in the head with all four hooves. Adora swings her blade with her left hand, bringing it down on the clone's shield. There's a pulse of magic, and the shield shatters. The Elemental groans in pain, and looks up, opening its mouth and sending a stream of stones and dirt towards them. Swift Wind turns as fast as lightning, and beats his wings. The force of the air knocks the stream of earth aside. The pair surges through the cloud of debris to face their opponents. Swift Wind lowers his head, and the horn smashes into the clone's chest plate, carrying him back and off the end of the Elemental. He lands on his back in the dirt, and Adora leaps off Swift Wind's back, landing above him and pointing her sword down at him.

"Enough." She says softly. "You're done. Prime is gone, and now, it's time for you to give this up."

The clone looks up at her with surprising calm. "Strike me down then She Ra. I have failed, but more will come. Your days are numbered. Prime shall reign again eternal across the stars."

Swift Wind's hoof comes down on his head, knocking him out cold.

"Anybody got a problem with that?" He says, looking around at the gathered bots.

The clone's elemental grumbles in pain, and then turns around and burrows back underground.

Adora leaps onto Swift Wind's back. "Alright, Swifty. Let's go." She says, a smile alighting across her face as the bots ready their weapons.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! The Odd Couple is my personal favorite chapter in the fic, so I hope you enjoyed. Feel free to leave comments or kudos to show your appreciation.

The Odd Couple, Part 2: The Enemy Within

Chapter Summary

> In Which Entrapta and Hordak hunt a traitor, and Catra comes to an important milestone in her journey towards forgiveness.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Wrong Hordak

They had managed to get out of Dryl safely, and they got down the path to the camp with only minimal harassment from some of Prime's drones, which Brother Hordak had dealt with swiftly.

"Alright!" Brother Entrapta begins, "Now that we're down here it should be a simple matter of tracing the signal to its source. The connection is a little fuzzy because all the clones have almost identical technical and organic readings."

"Almost?" The Wrong Hordak queries. "Are we not completely identical?"

"Fortunately, no!" Entrapta responds. "You all have slightly different signatures because of your different ages."

"Yes…" Brother Hordak picks up her sentence, "Each batch would have slightly different rates of degradation."

"And some clones have mutations or defects that make them stand out a lot more! You two both have very unique signatures, Hordak because of his birth defects," Hordak grunts and turns his head away from Brother Entrapta, "And Wrong Hordak because he was yanked out of the hivemind while directly connected, and his brains got a liiiiiittle fried by Bow's arrow." Wrong Hordak smiles, and winks.

“You.” Hordak says, turning and pointing to The Wrong Hordak. “Go from tent to tent, see which ones even have equipment capable of broadcasting this signal. Send Entrapta a message each time you eliminate a potential source. We’ll narrow it down until we find them.”

“Of course!” The Wrong Hordak exclaims, happy to be given such an important mission. He turns and strides into the camp, ready to assist his brothers.

*****

So far, he has been able to cross five tents off the list. The homes of Darton, Hogra, Bob, Sandstone, and D1-0015. He is sad whenever he passes by an empty tent, and knows that the occupant could well be fighting in the battle above, could well have already fallen.

He feels a ping at his communication device, and pulls it up. Entrapta’s jubilant face fills the screen. “GREAT JOB WRONG HORDAK!!! We’ve narrowed it down to the source!”

“Wonderful!” The Wrong Hordak says with a wide smile. “Where is it?”

“It’s coming from the 3rd barracks!” She says exuberantly.

Wrong Hordak’s face falls. Some of the clones had insisted on having a proper military. The third barracks would be full, for it’s where the security force for the camp lived. He rushes there, and arrives at the door at the same time as Brothers Hordak and Entrapta. He opens the door, and his heart falls.

Sixteen clones look up in unison as they enter. *It could be any one of them. And they are all my brothers*. He had known that it was a traitor, but being confronted with the evidence hurts all the more.

Hordak

The commander in charge stands up, and walks to the door.

“Brothers.” He says. Hordak sneers at the term. This clone has a strange twist to his voice, likely an affectation he puts on to heighten his sense of individuality. “How can I help you? Are we needed in the battle above?”

Wrong Hordak opens his mouth to speak, but Hordak cuts him off. “I’ll not mince words, Commander…”

“Bones.”

Hordak raises an eyebrow at the strange name. “Commander… Bones. One of your men is a traitor. And we are going to find out which one.”

Bones blinks in shock, but collects himself quickly. “Of course. I shall brief them on the situation.”

“No time.” Hordak says. “We shall interrogate each of them. Entrapta?”

“Weh?”

“What questions must we ask to weed out the traitor?”

“I’ve been working on that.” Her fingers scramble across her screen, pulling up several graphs and assorted scraps of data and script. “Whoever did this must have had access to my tower in the last two days. That’s the only place they could have had enough power to send out a signal that spans all of Etheria.”

Hordak nods. “We will start there.” He walks up to the first clone, Entrapta, Wrong Hordak, and Bones following him. “What is your name?”

“I have no name. I am D2-1200.” The clone says. His voice is less developed than many others. He sounds no different than one of Prime’s clones before the fall.

Good. That means he will not lie. “Have you been in the main castle of Dryl in the last two days?”

“No I have not. I spend my time in the barracks, the feeding hall, and the battlements.”

“Very good.” Hordak turns to the next one. “What is your name?”

“I am Rustling Wind!” The clone responds. Hordak grits his teeth. This one has the same obnoxiously positive ring to his voice as Wrong Hordak.

“And have you been in the main castle of Dryl in the last two days?”

“Not inside, but I walk up to the gate to retrieve pastries from the kitchen staff that I then distribute to those soldiers who have need of them.” The clone beams. Hordak rolls his eyes and moves to the next one while Wrong Hordak congratulates Rustling Wind on his kindness.

The next clone is sitting on his bed, one leg up. His head has been shaved, and there are tattoos on his bare arms.

“And you are?”

The clone doesn’t look up, but another clone chimes in. “That’s Daren, bro- uh, sir. You need not worry about him. He has been in the infirmary for the past four days.”

Hordak does not move his gaze from Daren. “Is this true?”

Daren finally looks up, and pulls up his loose-fitting pant leg, revealing a leg wrapped in gauze. “Hunting accident.” He grunts. Hordak narrows his eyes, then turns to the clone who spoke up to defend Daren.

“What of you?”

“I am Number One. I’ve been with Daren for the past several days, aiding him in moving about the camp.” A few other clones nod in affirmation.

The next four clones all deny having gone to the castle, and others back them up. Finally, he comes to a clone lurking in the back of the room, avoiding eye contact and lying on his bed.

“Who are you?” Hordak says, his voice low and commanding.

“That’s Chopper.” Bones says. “He’s… somewhat difficult.”

Hordak takes a closer look at Chopper, and his eyes widen when he notices something. A dark discoloration at the base of the neck, a sign of degradation like Hordak himself has suffered from.

“Have you been to the main castle of Dryl in the last two days, Chopper?” Hordak asks.

“No.” The clone responds bluntly without looking up. “I’ve been in camp.”

“No you haven’t!” Number One blurts out. Hordak’s head snaps towards him.

“What’s that?”

Number One blanches, and begins fidgeting. “I just- I saw him going up into the castle. I assumed he had business there so I didn’t question it.”

Hordak levels a glare at Chopper, who turns his head the other way. He leans in and grabs the other clone’s chin, turning his head to face him.

“Where. Were. You?” Hordak’s growls.

Chopper grits his teeth and smacks Hordak’s hand away. “Alright. I went up to the castle yesterday evening.”

Bones steps forward. “Why? You weren’t given leave.”

“I was there because… That’s where they keep the bot wrecks. And I didn’t want anyone to see me string these together.” He reaches to his side and pulls up a necklace made of the Galactic Horde Bot’s green eye panes.

A gasp goes up around the room. One of the clones Hordak hasn’t interviewed yet scoffs and says, “I shoulda known it’d be you,” in a disdainful drawl.

Chopper folds his arms and looks at the necklace. “I suppose it’s because I felt like Prime… *owed* me. So I took my reward.”

Wrong Hordak speaks. “Brother, this does not look good. You lied to us about your location, and you’re making contraband items? We don’t use the tools of Prime’s oppression to create.”

Chopper looks around, his face turning to defiance. “Now, wait! Hold on! I’m no traitor.”

Hordak leans in with a growl. “You will pay for this.”

Bones steps in between them as Chopper jumps to his feet, facing down Hordak. He holds his hands up, signaling for peace. “Okay, hold on. Hordak, it’s possible Chopper did it without realizing.” He turns to Chopper. “Don’t worry Chopper. We won’t hurt you. We’re just gonna hold you here until She Ra and the Queen come down and can determine the absolute truth.”

Chopper blusters, but Hordak raises a hand and puts it on Bones’s shoulder. “‘Until She Ra and the Queen come down?’ How did you know they were here?”

Bones meets Hordak’s gaze, and a dead silence falls over the room. Bones sighs. The affected accent vanishes as he says, “I really wish you hadn’t noticed that, sir.” In a flash, he flexes his wrist, and a knife flies out of his sleeve into his hand. He plunges the blade into Hordak’s exposed side, and the former warlord cries out in pain and falls to his knees. Bones kicks Hordak back,

knocking him into Chopper's legs, sending both clones toppling to the ground. He leaps up and drives his knee into Wrong Hordak's face. He sprints out of the barracks, grabbing Entrapta by the hair and dragging her with him as he shoves another clone out of the way.

"Hordak!" Entrapta squeaks in pain.

"Entrapta!" Hordak growls as he rises to his feet, wincing at the pain in his side. He pulls the knife out and races after the traitor.

Catra

Catra punches the wall hard enough to crack it. *Scorpia wasn't kidding. This castle really is a maze. Why would you make your castle a maze??* She turns around and rushes down another corridor. There's a rumbling sound from above her. *And why is it so hot?* She hears a meow echo down the hall and in her mind. She rushes towards it, and sees Melog pointing their tail to a staircase they discovered hidden behind a support beam.

"It's something." Catra says, and rewards Melog with a scratch behind the ear before racing up the stairs. "Entrapta should be at the top of the castle, right? That's where she's got those antennas. So if we move upwards, we should eventually get…" She trails off when she sees what's ahead of her. The hallway is ruined, partially collapsed. A pile of warped, melted metal lies in the middle of it. Catra unsheathes her claws and widens her stance. Melog rushes up and cloaks them both.

"Something's here. Above us." They say in her mind. Catra"s head whips around, looking for stairs. She smiles when she sees the scorched remains of a painting, with a passageway leading to stairs behind it. As she ascends, she sees a light at the top. She and Melog rush out onto a large balcony, about halfway up the castle's structure. She freezes when she looks at the other side of the balcony. Curled up there is a familiar, serpentine metal form - one of the smaller versions of that fire elemental they fought earlier.

It's sitting between her and the stairs upward. Slowly, Catra stalks towards it. Slowly, she flattens herself against the wall and inches beside it. There's just enough room to sneak past this thing. As she gets closer, the head grows more intense. *I'm gonna burn to a crisp if I sneak past it.* An idea forms in her head. She reaches down, and picks up a scrap of rubble. Heaving with all her might, she throws it behind her. The Salamander perks up at the noise, but doesn't move yet. Catra curses silently, and adjusts her plan. She tenses her legs, and takes off. Running straight towards it, she leaps onto the wall, managing to run along the slightly slanted slope long enough to get past the Elemental and rush up the stairs.

A few more staircases and balconies, and she's at the top. The wind whips by her as she scans desperately. It's a large circular platform with a series of antennae emerging from the center, but no Entrapta.

"You've gotta be kidding me." She mutters, and looks around, searching for that distinct purple hair.

Once again, Melog sees what she could not. Following their chirp of alarm, she looks down, and sees it. On the path between the castle and the Clone camp below, the distinct lavender hair rushing up the path… and a white humanoid form yanking on it. Catra feels her soul burning with rage as she sees Entrapta being pulled along like that. She flexes her claws, and leaps.

Hordak

Slowed as he is by his injury, and struggling to beat Bones's head start, Hordak moves up the path. He can hear the sounds of Entrapta struggling, but she is not a fighter, and this clone is particularly vicious.

Hordak feels the pulsing in his side getting worse. *It feels like fire in my blood. Is it poison? Or simply pain?* He grits his teeth and continues. *I will not let some pathetic sycophant of a dead tyrant be the end of me.*

He reaches the top of the path and falls to his knees. Looking ahead, the nearest door into the castle is ajar. He puts a hand on his side, and winces at the flare of pain. He stands and stalks towards the door.

A crunch of gravel turns his attention to the side. His eyes widen, and then narrow.

Catra straightens up and regards him from head to toe, smirking at his wound. *Smirking.* "Hey Hordak. You don't look too good."

"Catra." He snarls, and takes a step forward, only to cry out in pain. His legs feel… fuzzy.

"Woah." The feline says, and she takes a step back, her hands raising to her sides, palms outward. "You're hurt. Like, really hurt."

"Nggg. It matters not." Hordak stands again. "The traitor has Entrapta. He's fled into the castle."

Catra walks up to him and looks him in the eye. "You're not okay. I don't know how you made it up the hill but you're bleeding a lot. You need to stay here. Melog and I can find her."

Hordak bares his teeth, "You think I'd leave Entrapta's fate in your hands? I made that mistake once, *Force Captain.* Don't you remember?"

Catra takes a step back, her face betraying the pain his words caused. He relishes in it for a moment, before mentally remonstrating himself. *She is your ally for now.*

"I'm sorry." Catra says after a long moment, "I betrayed you. I took away your only friend, and I used that to hurt you for months. I've got more than my share of problems with you, but that was cruel. But you have to stay here. You're too hurt to do her any good, and you'll just get in my way."

Hordak does not back down. "You need me. I can navigate the maze."

Catra opens her mouth to protest, then closes it, and brings her palm up to her face. “Unnnngggg! I forgot her castle is a maze!” She complains, her voice muffled. “Fine. But first:” She reaches to her back and pulls out a small pouch. Reaching in, she pulls out a tiny golden leaf. She rubs it between her fingers, crushing it into a pulp. Hordak regards her warily. “It’s a healing spell. Not powerful, but it should stop the bleeding at least.” Hordak pauses, and moves his hand. Catra places her hand out, and a golden spell glyph appears and moves onto the wound. Hordak feels a tingling sensation, and he looks down to see a fresh scab over the wound. Catra whistles slightly. “Wow. I didn’t think that’d actually work. I’m pretty good at magic, huh?” She says jovially, looking up at Hordak as if for commiseration. He simply grunts and walks forward.

She used me as a guinea pig.

She helped me. She’ll save Entrapta.

Hordak swallows his hatred for the cat girl and walks into Dryl.

Catra

Melog’s swirling orange mane reflects the discomfort Catra feels following Hordak’s lead. *For Entrapta*. She keeps telling herself, but every time she looks at the tyrant, thoughts flash through her mind.

Her breath taken from her lungs. Hordak telling her she failed.

Hordak reprimanding Shadow Weaver, who turns around and torments Catra because of it.

Hordak sending her to die in the Crimson Waste.

As a child, Hordak bellowing in rage at her when she mistakenly stumbled into his sanctum.

Hordak stalking her through the Fright Zone, each blast of his cannon nearly destroying her.

Being held underwater, surrounded by clones wearing Hordak's face.

She finds herself glaring daggers at him, her claws fully extended. She shakes her head and blinks. *For Entrapta.*

Hordak does seem to know where he's going in this maze. Every so often he'll notice something: a discarded glove, an oil smear on the wall, a clump of hair. Clues Entrapta is leaving for them to follow her. They're leading upwards.

Something is making the castle rumble, and Catra notices the temperature rising. A chill runs down her spine.

"Hey Hordak. We've gotta hurry it up before that fire snake brings the whole castle down around us."

Hordak looks around, noticing the same things. "Indeed." He mutters, and picks up the pace. At one point, they stop, and hide under Melog's cloaking as they see the flame elemental burrow through the hallway in front of them, taking out one of the metal support beams.

Catra's theory is right. For some reason or another, they're trying to destroy Dryl.

After a while, they get into familiar territory, and Catra takes the lead, rushing through the destroyed painting, up the stairs onto the balcony. Hordak emerges behind her. The wind is picking up, and her hair lashes around her. She thinks idly about how it's getting longer, and a little more inconvenient, but the sight of the grounds below shakes her out of that.

The air is growing darker, and she sees flames licking out of windows and holes in the castle. Another Salamander is slithering around the castle grounds, leaving fire in its wake. *Pretty soon this whole place'll be slag.* "We need to find that clone." She says.

She looks to Hordak, who is looking up. Following his gaze, she sees the lip of the uppermost platform, and a thick tendril of purple hair waving over it. “Come on.” Catra says. “Let’s end this.”

The three of them race to the top. Catra hears Hordak’s breath getting labored, but she knows that he won’t stop, so she says nothing.

As they reach the top of the spire, they slow down, Catra holding up a hand. Hordak fortunately gets what she’s doing, and moves slowly towards the ladder. Catra thinks of how loud his old suit had been, and silently thanks Entrapta for this slick new one.

Hordak climbs the ladder, and she circles around and climbs the wall, Melog by her side cloaking her. She can hear Entrapta talking to the clone.

“You’re just like Prime! You don’t understand what makes us strong! You’re always going to fail because of that.”

“Silence.” Comes a voice. It’s not as refined as Prime’s, but not as gravelly as Hordak. “Soon this monument of depravity shall fall, and you with it. You will be an example to those who would domesticate my brethren.”

“We’re trying to set you free!”

Catra slowly climbs up the lip of the balcony. She sees the scene laid out before her: A clone working with a strange device, plugging it into wires attached to the tower. Entrapta, wrapped in a cable, lying on the ground, her hair still waving over the side trying to get attention. She ascends silently, creeping forward on all fours. If she can reach the clone first…

The plan goes out the window as Hordak comes thundering around the other side of the antenna, blindsiding the clone with a tackle. Catra curses, and arcs around to Entrapta. She appears over the princess.

“Catra! Oh it’s so good to see you.”

Catra snorts at the casualness of it. “Yeah, good to see you too.” She grabs the cable and begins cutting it with her claws. She stops when she hears a scream of pain. She whips around and sees Hordak stagger into the antenna. The other clone has what appears to be an old Horde stun baton, modified into a handheld device. She sees him jab the pointed head into Hordak’s side and shock him again. Hordak screams and staggers backwards.

“NO!” Entrapta cries. Her hair begins to lift her up, but the cable sends a shock through her, immobilizing her.

Hordak staggers backwards another step, and his foot hits air. The former warlord falls backwards, and Catra lunges in. She slams onto her chest, arm outstretched, and catches Hordak’s arm. The clone swings and crashes into the side.

Catra’s arm feels like its being wrenched out of its socket from holding up the armored clone.

“Gahhh!” She cries, looking down as Hordak looks up to meet her eyes. She can hear growls and shouts from behind her, and realizes somewhere in her mind that Melog is occupying the clone. But her focus is on Hordak.

“Come on…” She says, pulling with all her might. It’s no use. His wrist is slipping.

“Catra.” He says, strained. “Let go.”

“No!” She shouts, opening her eyes. This side of the castle is steeper than the other. The fall would kill him, and if not, the Salamander waiting at the bottom would. “Not on your life.” She says breathlessly.

“Let. Go!” Hordak says. “Save her!”

Catra strains with all her might. She looks over her shoulder sees the clone kick Melog to the ground and shock them. She turns back to Hordak. Tears are stinging her eyes. “I’m not letting go.” She says, and pulls. His arm falls down to just the hand.

“Save her!” He calls.

She opens her eyes and looks at him.

“Aaaaaauuggggghhhhh!!!!” She screams as she feels the stun baton jab into her back and unleash electricity through her body. But she holds on.

“Let go!” Both clones say, with very different tones.

She closes her eyes.

Her breath taken from her lungs. Hordak telling her she failed.

Hordak reprimanding Shadow Weaver, who turns around and torments Catra because of it.

Hordak sending her to die in the Crimson Waste.

As a child, Hordak bellowing in rage at her when she mistakenly stumbled into his sanctum.

Hordak stalking her through the Fright Zone, each blast of his cannon nearly destroying her.

Being held underwater, surrounded by clones wearing Hordak’s face.

Her body is overcome with pain, almost more than she’s ever felt. As her consciousness begins to fade, she opens her eyes, meeting Hordak’s. There’s fear and desperation there.

None of that matters anymore. It’s over. Entrapta needs him. Not just now. She needs him like I need Adora. Put it all aside.

“Do it for her.” She whispers. She has no idea if he can even hear her. Every muscle in her body screams in pain. Her vision is consumed in darkness, and she pulls. Her back arches. Her knees come forward. She lifts Hordak up.

“Impossible...” The clone says above her.

'I've done crazier,' She thinks, as the once-tormentor of her life grabs onto the lip and heaves himself up. She topples to her side, and unconsciousness takes her.

Adora

Combat has always felt right to Adora. It's the aftermath, the cleanup, that feels intolerable. As she was fighting off the last group of bots, a pulse went out from the top of Dryl's spire, sending a wave of green lightning surging across the enemy and suddenly, the bots stood down. Some of them wandered around, some of them immediately rushed away, and some of them simply stopped dead where they were standing.

Adora leans down and puts a hand on Swift Wind's flank, looking up at the spire. "Come on Swifty, let's find out what happened."

Swift Wind takes off, carrying her up there with great speed. When she sees the scene laid out before her, her heart nearly stops.

There are three prone forms on the platform. A clone, unconscious and tied up. Hordak, leaned against the spire with Entrapta desperately trying to get him to respond. And Catra, collapsed on her side near the edge.

"Catra." Adora breathes in panic, and leaps off Swift Wind without a second thought, landing next to her girlfriend and gathering her up into her arms. "Come on Catra…" Adora feels life in Catra's form, and there's slow, but steady breathing.

"She Ra!" Entrapta's voice, and Adora feels hair arms grab her forearm. "Hordak's hurt! Really bad. He needs healing, please!" There's a desperate pleading in Entrapta's voice that sounds so foreign that Adora is almost compelled to move over. She carries Catra with her, and gently sets her down.

Hordak does not look good. He's unconscious, and his side is covered in green blood. There's a substantial wound there.

Adora closes her eyes, and feels a hum of energy surround her. She puts one hand on Hordak, and one on Catra, and lets the healing magic of She Ra flow into them. Light consumes the top of the tower, and as it fades, so too does She Ra. Adora is left kneeling in front of the former leaders of the Horde. Entrapta is holding her breath, waiting for something to happen.

Catra regains consciousness first, starting with her tail gravitating towards and wrapping limply around Adora's wrist, then slowly stirring to life with a pained groan.

"Nnnnnngg. Everything hurts." She says, slowly blinking her eyes open. She sees Adora, and her pupils dilate. Adora gently brings her up into a tender embrace, then pulls away to look her in the eyes.

"What happened?" She asks.

Catra breathes in to speak, but another voice cuts in, deep and gravelly. "Catra saved me." Adora looks at Hordak, who is regarding Catra with curiosity.

"*Hordak!!*" Entrapta shouts, and lunges forward to glomp onto Hordak, who winces, then smiles at the contact. "I'm so glad you're okay. I was so worried about you."

Hordak hesitantly curls one arm around her, and pats her on the back. Adora suppresses a chortle at the sheer absurd awkwardness of the sight.

Hordak turns back to Catra and Adora. "I do not know why you saved me, but… I-" He swallows and blinks before finally getting out, "I thank you."

Catra lets out a light exhale through her nose, then responds. "I saved you for her." She points to Entrapta.

"Me?" The scientist says.

“Yeah. You two are obviously meant for each other.” (Adora must be light headed from the healing because there’s no way she’s seeing Hordak blush). “Hordak. I saw what it was like for you when Entrapta was gone. And I don’t want to think about how much it would hurt Entrapta for you to be gone. She needs you.” Catra turns and smiles at Entrapta. “Just like I need Adora.”

Entrapta takes a moment, processing that, then speaks, more quietly than usual. “I think you’re right, Catra.” She turns and looks at Hordak. “I’ve gotten so used to having a lab partner around, I don’t know how I’d be able to go back. When I was on Beast Island, I was able to make more scientific progress in a few months than I had in my entire life! But it didn’t feel as worthwhile because… I wasn’t doing it… with you.” She turns her gaze down, and Adora watches her hair move up above her head to pull her mask down, only to realize she’d lost her mask in the fighting. There’s a quiet, sheepish smile on her face.

Adora smiles at the two, then at Catra. *It may not look like us, but they love each other.* She stands up, helping a wincing Catra to her feet.

“We’re gonna go check on the others.” She says. “You guys should get down soon. Hordak, you should be alright to walk around, but take breaks. You lost a lot of blood.” *You shouldn’t have survived*. She thinks, but looking at the two of them, she knows how he made it.

“Oh no!” Catra suddenly exclaims. “Glimmer!”

Adora turns to look at her. “What?”

“Glimmer got hurt! We need to get down there.”

Adora and Catra leap onto Swift Wind, Melog shrinking down to the size of a rat and leaping onto Catra’s back.

“To Glimmer!” Swift Wind calls as he takes off and descends.

The flight is short, as the team alights on the ground back where they first arrived at Dryl.

Adora leaps off and rushes over to where she sees Glimmer lying down in front of a rock, Bow crouched over her. Glimmer stomach is bandaged a little haphazardly, and she looks over at Adora.

“Hi Adora.” She says, forced chipperness in her voice. “Is the battle over?”

Adora nods, then looks at Bow. “How is she?”

Glimmer rolls her eyes. “I’m right here.”

Bow looks tired as he says, “She’s hurt pretty bad, but not life threatening.”

Adora turns back to Glimmer, and closes her eyes. “For the Honor of Grayskull.” She says with quiet, heartfelt resolve.

She Ra reaches out and lays hands on her friend’s stomach, pouring healing magic into her. Adora is dimly conscious of how weary it makes her feel, and decides to give She Ra a break for the next few days.

One light show later, and Glimmer experimentally sits up.

“Ha, ha!” She says, and wraps Adora in a hug. “I can move my stomach again!” She reaches down and pinches it through the bandages, only to wince and immediately regret that decision. “Ohhhh that still hurts.”

“Yeah.” Adora chuckles, “It’s healed but your body still needs some recovery time.” She stands up and lets the form of She Ra fall. She looks to the castle, and her friends fall in beside her. “Let’s find out why all of this happened.”

*****

A few trips around the castle later, and they have all three horde clones gathered in one of the castle's more intact courtyards. The first one is babbling some mantra about the glory of Prime to himself. The one that nearly killed Adora sits perfectly still, his eyes closed, as if meditating. And the one who was beaten by Hordak simply slumps, staring off into the middle distance.

Glimmer walks forward and summons the rune for the truth spell. She casts it on the first one, who turns to look up at them, a wild grin on his face.

"What was your role in this plan?" Glimmer asks.

"I am all I have ever been!" The clone begins to rant, "One of many in service to Prime! There is no individual, there is only service to the collective!"

They all groan as they realize where he's going with this.

"I live to serve Prime! Holy One of a Thousand Suns, Overlord of the Known Universe, Bane of Disorder, He-Who-Shall-Reign-Eter-" He suddenly cuts off, and Adora, Glimmer, Catra, and Bow turn to look at him again. There's confusion and panic on his face. "He-Who-Shall-Reign-Eter- Etern-" He begins to breathe faster. "Prime shall reign fore- He liv-" He turns to Glimmer, horror in his eyes. "What have you done to me!?" He screams in terror.

Glimmer knits her brows, but Catra chuckles. She walks around Glimmer and kneels down in front of the clone, who is desperately trying to say what he's thinking. "Awwwww, look at you." She drawls, in a tone that is chillingly familiar to Adora. "Go ahead. Say that Prime's still alive. Just try it."

"Prime is still al- ali- Aaaaaaeuuuggggghhhh" The clone screams, and tears have begun flowing down his face. He's writhing against his binds. Catra reaches out and grabs his chin, her claws digging in just a bit. She lets out a malicious cackle

Catra, stop. Adora thinks. This is kind of scary to watch.

"You can't say it. She cast a truth spell on you, and you know, deep down, that Prime is gone." Her voice is coy, teasing, but it gets suddenly harsh as she says, "He's *dead.* And you're wasting your time trying to deny it." She releases his chin with a yank of her wrist, flicking his head to the side.

He continues to ramble. "Prime casts out all shadows. This is nothing but a lie. A trick. Prime li- Prime rules forev- Prime *shall ret-*" He collapses to the ground, sobbing. "No. *No no,* no no!" He glares up at Glimmer. "WHAT HAVE YOU DONE TO MEEEEE!!??" His scream echoes through the courtyard.

Adora looks at her friends. Glimmer's face is impassive. Bow looks as horrified as she feels. Hordak is standing a ways back and sneering in utter disgust and contempt. Entrapta is muttering something about science and typing rapidly on her tracker pad.

And Catra… Catra is looking down at that clone with a terrifying smile on her face. She's *delighted* to watch him break down like this.

This isn't right. Adora thinks. She kneels down in front of the clone, and takes his chin. He goes limp in her grip, and looks up at her with glassy eyes.

"He… is gone?" He says, sounding even more pathetic than Wrong Hordak had when they had first found him.

"He is." Adora says softly. "I'm sorry. It's time for you to move on."

The clone simply collapses back to the ground, utterly shell shocked. Adora stands up, and looks at Glimmer. "Let's try the next one. Maybe watching that will have made him feel cooperative." Adora looks at Catra, and Catra looks at her. Adora watches Catra's face go from sadistic glee, to concerned curiosity, to realization, to horror at the sight of Adora's face. Adora lets her glare drop, and she walks up to Catra. Catra takes a step back in fear, but Adora takes her hand gently. "Can we talk?" She says.

Catra's eyes widen, but she deflates a bit, and nods. Adora turns to Glimmer. "You guys handle this from here, okay?"

"With pleasure." Glimmer says, and walks towards the next one. Adora considers bringing Glimmer with them for this talk, but, *'Nope. That is not up to me. I'm not gonna force what I want onto Glimmer. Never again.'* She takes Catra's hand, and walks away from the interrogation.

Once they're out of earshot, Adora starts talking. "Catra…"

Catra pulls her hand away and brings her arms up, her hands wrapping around her upper arms. "I know. I'm sorry."

Adora speeds up and walks in front of Catra, reaching up and grabbing her hands again. She winces as she feels the nails digging into Catra's skin. "Catra. I'm not disappointed in you."

"Yes you are." Catra's still not meeting her eyes.

"Catra…" Adora thinks. *How can I get through to her… Oh!* "Hey, do you need to do that thing you and Glimmer do? The sitting back to back thing?"

Catra looks at her quizzically, then actually laughs a little. "Stars you're good." Adora beams. "But no. That's me and Sparkles's thing. Stop trying to steal our thing."

Adora pouts a little, then snaps back to the subject. "Okay, but I need you to talk to me and listen to me here, okay?" Catra closes her eyes, breathes in, and out. *Just like Perfuma taught her.* She opens her eyes and looks at Adora. She nods wordlessly.

Adora begins. "I know where you were coming from. I want to rub it in the faces of every one of those clones that Prime is gone. But that's not what we do. We're the good guys. Being the good guys doesn't just mean doing good things, it means we resist those urges, and," She takes a step closer to Catra, "We stop our friends when they give in to those urges. I know how tempting it

can be to want to just… hurt them. They did so much wrong to us, to you more than anyone."

"But we shouldn't hurt them back." Catra says quietly. "Because that'll just make them want to hurt us, and it starts a cycle." Adora is taken aback, and Catra grins bashfully. "Perfuma said that."

Adora smiles. "I love you, and I know you've made so much progress. I just… It was kind of scary. It made me think of things I've been trying to forget."

Catra reaches a hand up and cups Adora's cheek, wiping away a tear she didn't even know was forming. "I'm sorry. When I saw your face… I'm trying to be better. But… It's hard. It was really hard to choose to save Hordak."

Adora thinks on that. "I don't know if I could have done that." She says quietly.

Catra scoffs. "Shut up. Of course you could. You're Adora. You always want to save everyone." Her face drops when she sees the severity of Adora's expression, and she stops teasing.

"I would have gone after the clone. I would have just… assumed Hordak would survive the fall. But you…" She looks up at Catra and smiles. "You put everything on the line for Entrapta. I'm so proud of you."

Tears well up in Catra's eyes, and she grabs Adora and pulls her into a kiss and a hug. The two stand there, hugging, swaying, and purring (one of them, at least), for a while.

Glimmer

The next clone looks at Glimmer and Bow with a fairly smug smile. "You may ask your questions, but you'll get nothing from me." A chill runs down Glimmer's spine. She's always known that all the clones have the same voice, but this one sounds *exactly* like Prime. For a moment, she's on his ship again, his cold hands

on her cheek, her life about to be snuffed out, along with her home. She blinks, and hardens her expression. She raises her hands, and sends a truth spell into this clone.

"What was your role in this attack?" She says.

"Hm." The clone says. "Magic, how… quaint. I'm sure it works of course, so I'll not lie. I led one half of the army. My presence was necessary to keep the machines engaged."

"How were you controlling them?" Bow asks.

The clone shrugs. "I do not know, exactly. It felt no different from controlling them before the fall of the hive mind."

Entrapta butts in. "But then how did you take control of the Etherian bots? And what about the Elementals? They're partially organic."

The clone looks at her and smiles. "I cannot answer your questions. The bots used by my brother's imitation empire were no different from the footsoldiers of the true Horde. As for the elementals, they were somewhat more volatile to control, but their wills are weak, and they crumbled before us, just as their masters did all those centuries ago. If you want more details, I'd suggest asking 'Commander Bones'" He gives a heavy emphasis on the last two words, and almost chuckles, as if mocking his co-conspirator's name.

"Alright." Glimmer says, and walks up to the third and final clone conspirator. She casts the truth spell on him, and he slowly looks up at her. "Talk. Tell us everything about this attack."

The clone speaks freely, his voice sounding hollow. "My brothers have flocked to this place, seeking individuality. I came here and tried to dissuade them peacefully at first, to tell them not to lose hope in Prime. But they did not listen. I watched them fall into depravity, taking names, forging identities separate from the pure whole that we all once shared. I knew I had to act. I had to save them. I did what needed to be done. I reforged a rudimentary

hivemind with two brothers from the same birthing batch, and I tapped into Prime's virus that he invaded this planet through. Using it, I was able to send out a signal and rally the machines across this world here. I sent token forces to the other kingdoms as well, hoping to prevent any interference, but it seems that was my undoing. When the battle began, I relied on my brothers to lead the attack. When I was discovered, however, the plan changed. I decided to send out a self destruct wave to the machines. If I failed, I would take you all with me." He looks past Glimmer to Hordak. "But I failed at that as well." He hangs his head in shame. "You may do what you will with me. My life has run its course."

Another voice enters the conversation. "No, brother." Glimmer looks over to see Wrong Hordak emerge from where he had been standing behind Hordak. "It is never too late for one to see the light. We can still help you."

The clone shakes his head despondently. "Do what you will."

Glimmer stands up and turns. "Well. Now that we know that, we know that it won't be a continuous threat. And now…" She says as Adora and Catra walk back. "We can relax a bit, because today has been… *a lot.*"

Murmurs of agreement go up around them, and Entrapta cries out, "I'll get the kitchen staff to make us all tiny pastries!!!" She turns and rushes into the castle, Hordak hot on her heels.

"Wait." Catra says as they begin to follow the two. Glimmer turns and looks at her. The feline's eyes are focused on the door where Hordak just rushed in. "Doesn't he have a thing that keeps him closer to Entrapta?" Glimmer nods. "He was away from Entrapta during that battle."

There's a hush before Bow says, awed, "So not only was he bleeding out, but he was getting shocked the whole time. And he kept going for her."

Everyone lets that statement sink in for a moment. Glimmer turns and looks at the castle.

He really does love her. She thinks.

Entrapta

Click

E: "Edit to Log. With the help of the Princess Alliance, we won the Battle of Dryl, staving off an army of bots and foiling a plot to overturn our clone rehabilitation program." *to Bow* "What do you think, did that sound dramatic enough? Oh! Hordak saved me from a clone!"

G: "An evil clone!"

B: "A crazy clone."

E: "Well I don't know if I'd call him crazy or evil, just misinformed."

A: "That's a good way of looking at it."

E: "Thank you! I'm trying to be more understanding of people thoughts."

C: "Eh, I think they're all crazy. No offense."

WH: "None taken br- Catra!"

H: "Hm."

E: "On a scientific front, I've discovered that many of the clones share Hordak's resourcefulness and scientific cunning, I'll have to recruit more of their aid in my endeavors. With a lot of them helping, we should be able to solve the teleported problem!"

B: "That's a great idea! They'll know Horde tech better than anyone!"

E: “Exactly! We’ll have to work on convincing the other Princesses though.”

B: “I’m sure we’ll work it out!”

E: “Hurray!!”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log. The clone formerly known as Wrong Hordak has chosen a new name for himself after sufficient complaints from Hordak. His new name issssssss…”

silence

E: *whispering* “You can say it now.”

K: “Oh. Kadroh!”

E: “EEEEE! It’s wonderful because it retains the spirit of the original name. He’s still Wrong Hordak, because Kadroh is just Hordak spelled backwards! Isn’t it amazing!”

H: “Yes. Delightful.”

E: “Tiny pastries for everyone!”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log: One of the clones who attacked us a few weeks back has officially chosen a name now that his existential crisis about Prime being gone has resolved. His name is now: Hordeprimeisdead! All one word.”

H: *amused* “It’s better than some of their names at least.”

E: “Hey! Don’t be mean. All of their names are special and unique and beautiful.”

H: “What about Rock and Rock 2?”

E: “Well- Ab- I don’t- Okay yeah, Rock 2 is not a very original or creative name. But! It is still valid, and we have to respect it.”

H: “Of course d- Entrapta.”

Click

*****

Click

E: “Edit to Log!! Hordak gave me a gift!! I’m so exciteeeeed. It’s a pair of gauntlets with all sorts of cool gadgets built in.” *assorted mechanical sounds as Entrapta activates each gadget.* “They have tools like screwdrivers and pliers and an automatic hammer, it’s got a welding torch and a series of plugs that I can plug into computers. The right gauntlet has a miniature tracker pad built in, and the left one has a low power laser and an energy shield. Now I can actually fight! Ahahahahaaa!” *a laser fires, and Kadroh yelps in surprise.* “Ope, Sorry! Okay maybe not *fight*, but at least defend myself more. Oh! But that’s not even the best part of it. Look! Hordak made little insets in each gauntlet. They’re made out of the eye plates of Galactic Horde bots, but there’s First One’s writing carved into them! The same letters that are in Hordak’s power crystal! Isn’t that soo sweet?? I have to think of something to make for him!”

H: “Entrapta you’ve already done enough for-“

E: “Can’t hear you! Already brainstorming!”

Click

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Fun fact: this is the longest chapter in this draft of the story. If you enjoyed, leave a comment or kudo! They’re always appreciated.

Interlude: The Flower

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra's meeting with her new friend unearths a memory she may wish had stayed buried.

Chapter Notes

> The first entirely new piece of content in this draft, and one I'm quite proud of to boot.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"And then what?" Lila asks excitedly. The older woman's eyes sparkle as Catra wraps up her tale.

Catra is in a small tavern in Bright Moon City with her friend Lila, a middle-aged human woman with hip-length braided brown hair and grey eyes like storm clouds. She's been meeting with Lila once a week to hang out and talk. The things Catra has slowly learned that friends do.

Lila doesn't know who Catra really is, of course. She goes by the name Cyra, and Melog's illusion magic makes both of her eyes blue to hide her distinctive heterochromia.

Catra has told a few stories to Lila. Never the full picture, but also never really lying. Whether they're edited versions of her actual adventures or just exaggerations of old training scenarios, they always seem to delight.

In this story, Catra is fighting against a great beast in a cave. It's based on an actual escapade Catra had had when she was younger and stumbled upon a tunnel beneath the Fright Zone, only to encounter a strange, vicious creature she would later be able to identify as an Elemental.

In this version of the tale, she's in Bright Moon, but pretty much every other aspect is true.

Catra grins and says, "Not much actually. I smashed one of its eyes, then wrapped its legs up with the climbing rope I'd brought along. I didn't wait around or try to finish it off, I just ran. I figured: if it's not hurting anyone, may as well get away and leave it be, right?"

Lila nods sagely and raises her cup slightly. "Smart girl," She says before taking a sip.

Catra grins and takes a drink.

"Have you ever seen She Ra?"

Catra almost chokes at the suddenness of Lila's question.

"What?" She splutters, "What do you mean?"

"Sorry," Lila says bashfully, "I don't mean like, on a stage or through stories, I mean… You fought with the Rebellion against Prime. Did you ever see She Ra on the battlefield?"

'Oh, if only I could say the half of it…'

"Uh- yeah." Catra says evasively, "A couple of times. We never talked though." Weirdly that's one of the most complete lies she's told so far.

"Wow…" Lila says. "I wish I could have seen her."

"You still can," Catra says, "She lives up in the castle."

"I mean on the battlefield," Lila explains. She looks off into the middle distance a bit and grows more serious in tone and expression. "Tekla saw her once. In the first Whispering Woods campaign. She was holding a ridge against bots until the Princesses could arrive. They were almost overrun when She Ra got there and wiped the bots out."

“Who’s Tekla?” Catra asks tentatively, sensing the change in the air.

Lila starts at her voice and looks back, then explains, “Tekla was my wife. She was a Rebellion fighter.”

“Was…?” Catra asks.

Lila gives a smile that doesn’t lessen the obvious sadness in her eyes. As she speaks, she drifts back off into the middle distance, gazing into memory. She speaks with an almost detached air. “Yes. She died in the last part of the war, when the fighting really got fierce. She went off to fight for Tenfields and never came back. Her whole squad was captured or killed.”

“I- I’m so sorry…” Catra whispers.

She tries to remember Tenfields. She knows vaguely that it’s one of the small towns on the wrong side of the Whispering Woods - the ones The Horde had targeted to lure princesses into open engagements.

‘Did I order that battle? Am I the reason Tekla’s gone?’ Catra feels sick. *‘Of course. Of course this has happened. Of course this one anchor of normalcy, this one non-princess friend, has a wife who died because of me. Why wouldn’t she? After all, good things don't happen to me. Suffering always comes with them.’*

Catra grimaces and finishes her drink. The rest of their time is a blur. Lila apologizes for souring the mood, and they agree to meet again next week, but all she can think about is Tenfields. The name sounds so familiar but she can’t remember why. She’s pretty sure she didn’t order an attack on it…

She sighs as she walks back to Bright Moon Castle. *‘Maybe it’s time to tell Adora about Lila…*

*****

“Does the town Tenfields mean anything to you?” Catra asks.

“Tenfields?” Adora quirks an eyebrow and chews on her lip contemplatively. “Tenfields… hold on.” She hops off the bed and walks over to a bookcase that’s covered with blueprints and tactical drawings of Bright Moon Castle. She opens it and rifles through the contents.

“I think…” She mutters, pulling out one of her “logbooks” that Catra knows is just a wartime journal. She spends a few minutes sitting on the floor, flipping through pages.

Catra lounges on the bed looking at her partner and allows her mind to drift to how beautiful Adora looks. Cross legged on the floor next to a sunbeam, chewing on a pencil, her beautiful blonde hair pulled into a messy ponytail. So focused on-

“B-hAH!!” Adora exclaims giddily, breaking the spell. “Tenfields!” She starts to read the entry. “‘The Horde is targeting the small villages on the outskirts of the Whispering Woods. We intercepted a plan to attack Tenfields but-‘“ Here she pauses before continuing in the sort of guilty, half-apologetic, half-bitter tone that usually indicated Catra being brought up. “‘-but Glimmer refused to let me go. Even though the intel said Catra could be there herself, Glimmer seems to think that it’s just a ploy to lure us into a trap. She keeps lording what happened at Elberon over my head, as if I don’t know what happened there way better than she does anyway-‘ Okay I just rant about Glimmer for a good portion here,” Adora says ruefully.

“You two really had it out for each other for a while there, huh?” Catra observes, trying to contain the mass of panic roiling in her belly.

”Catra could be there herself.” Could it be? Could Catra really not remember a town she herself had been to? Was it just a trap? Or had she just repressed the memory? And if so- why?

“Here we go,” Adora says, finding where the page’s useful information continued, “‘We sent a squad of fighters to Tenfields to counter the Horde. No Princesses to help. They didn’t come

back.’” Adora looks up, “That’s the only mention of it.” She closes the book and walks over. She kneels on the floor next to the bed and looks into Catra’s eyes.

Catra averts her gaze, hoping desperately that Adora won’t see the struggle held within her eyes.

Unfortunately, her girlfriend is amazing.

“Catra, what’s wrong? You’ve been quiet ever since you got back, then you ask me about some random farming village apropos of nothing, and now you look more upset than I’ve seen you since Salineas.” Adora pauses, waiting for a response. When none comes, she continues. “Catra. Whatever you’re going through, let me in. You don’t have to-”

“I think I hurt someone,” Catra whispers.

“What?”

Catra takes a deep breath in through her nose and exhales before saying, “I was at Tenfields.”

Adora can’t help herself, and jumps up to proclaim, “I knew it!! Suck it Glimmer!” She balks at the twin stink eyes that earns her from Catra and Melog. She sits down, thoroughly embarrassed and guilty. “I’m sorry. Not the time at all.”

Catra sighs and continues. “I’m just… gonna start from the beginning. And no more interruptions,” She adds sharply. Adora nods, her expression serious again. “I made a friend,” Catra says, “Like, on my own, down in Bright Moon City. I haven't told you because I kinda liked having this to myself. It’s someone I actually befriended, like, outside the Princesses or the Horde. Not someone I was forced to be around or allied with out of convenience or met through someone else. Just someone I met and clicked with. When I leave the castle, it’s usually to go hang out with her. But when I visited her for lunch earlier today… I learned…” Catra swallows hard and closes her eyes. “She used to

have a wife. A wife that fought for the Rebellion and- and died at Tenfields. And I remember Tenfields but I don't know why."

Adora puts a gentle hand on Catra's, and she opens her eyes. She speaks gently, saying, "Catra, I understand why you're worried. But if you only kind of remember Tenfields, it probably means it wasn't very important to you. You probably just… saw it on a map once or read a report or-"

"No!" Catra snaps, yanking her hand out of Adora's and leaping up. She paces around the room as Melog spikes out orange. "No! It's not that I don't remember Tenfields. I remember *around* it. And I *know* something's missing!"

Adora stands up, agitated by this change in behavior. "What does that mean?"

"It means I don't remember! And I should!" Catra rounds on her girlfriend. "There's a hole in my memory! Something big happened at Tenfields and I can't remember it and I don't know why!"

"But what could have happened there? And how could you not remember it?"

"Gahh! I don't know!" Catra roars, reaching her hand against the wall and raking her claws across it. "I think it's my fault that Lila's wife is dead Adora!"

The room falls silent, save for the ever present whisper of the waterfall.

"Catra…" Adora says, taking a step forward.

Catra shakes her head and backs away. "You don't believe me."

"Of course I believe you." Adora says softly, "But how could something that big just be missing from your memory? It doesn't make sense."

"I don't…" Catra's face falls as it clicks. "Shadow Weaver."

“Shadow Weaver?”

“She had a spell that could erase memories. It, it must be something like that!”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “Okay, but done by whom?”

“By-...” Catra trails off, the brief wind gone from her sails. “I don’t know…” She says sadly.

There’s another silence before Adora says, “Okay. Game plan. We’re gonna figure this out tomorrow. I’ll talk to Castaspella about that memory magic. And you’re going to go to Plumeria.”

Catra looks at her, confusion written all over her face. “Plumeria?” She asks, “Why would I go to Plumeria?”

Adora smiles. “If it’s not magic, then it’s something in your own psyche. And if that’s the case, Perfuma is the best possible person to help you through it.”

*****

Catra lies on a padded plank of wood, fidgeting uncomfortably as Perfuma gathers materials.

“Are you sure we can’t do like, normal meditation?” Catra asks again. She’s really not thrilled at the prospect of Perfuma’s idea.

Perfuma breathes out a laugh and says, “Of course I’m sure. If you’re searching for repressed memories, we need to dig deeper into your spiritual self than simple meditation can accomplish. You have a blockage of energy, and need a spiritual realignment. Acupuncture is a perfectly safe way to access such repressed memories.”

Catra grimaces as Perfuma lights the last candle and turns towards the small side table holding the many fine needles. `*Well at least it smells nice,’* she thinks.

Perfuma smiles warmly at her, and against her better judgement, Catra feels some of her apprehension melt away.

I'm glad I left Melog in Bright Moon. Who knows what this sort of thing would be like through the connection.

"Pheeww… Okay princess," Catra sighs, "stab away."

She lies back and closes her eyes.

Perfuma speaks gently as Catra feels the sting of the first few needles. "Keep your mind focused on the gap in your memories. Don't let your emotions cloud you or push you back. Accept the reality of whatever happened and let it through."

At this point Catra has so many needles sticking out of her that she barely even feels them. There's no more pain from them, just pressure. She imagines she can hear her own heart beating. Something is stirring within her. Maybe it's her spiritual energy… or maybe it's just her organs disagreeing with her decisions.

Perfuma's voice comes into her awareness, "I'm going to insert the final needle now. This will open your third eye, and initiate the journey of energy through your body."

Catra feels a tiny prick on the center of her forehead.

Images flood her mind, too fast to make out.

Fields of crops burn bright.

A line of wooden houses crashes down like dominoes as a massive tank drives through them.

Civilians are rounded up by armored figures brandishing glowing green whips.

Rebellion fighters break the cover of the Whispering Woods to crash against the Horde's forces.

The fighting is fierce. The ragtag bunch of Rebels put up a much better fight than anticipated. Catra barely pays attention, instead scanning around, wondering where the princesses are.

The few survivors kneel, save one, who tackles a Horde soldier and sprints into the woods.

Trees and foliage blur together. Catra is running.

The roar of some beast.

Blood dripping from Catra's hands.

A strange plant with a tall, thick stem and a large red flower, like two hands joined at the heels.

Catra sucks in air desperately and her eyes snap open. "Plant." She gasps. Looking down at herself, she feels panic overtake her as she sees the needles protruding from her form. "Get them out!" She chokes.

Perfuma raises her hands, "Catra calm down, it could be dangerous to-"

"OUT!" Catra roars in desperation. She begins grabbing needles and pulling them out of her, heedless of the renewed pain or wells of blood.

"Catra stop!" Vines come up from below and tie around Catra's flailing limbs, lashing them to the bed. A final one loops around her forehead and pulls her head down before she can yank a needle from her collarbone with her teeth.

"Get them out!" Catra sobs.

Perfuma grimaces, and raises her hands. A web of vines hover over Catra, and begin to pop the needles out in rapid succession. After what feels like an eternity to Catra's panicking mind, her restraints fall.

She bolts upright and moves towards the door, heedless of the fact that she's in her underwear and there are little spots of blood all over her.

Perfuma steps forward, a pleading arm outstretched. "Catra, what are you doing??" She cries.

"It's a plant!" Catra says, "there was a plant! I don't- it's important!" She shoves the door open and staggers outside, blinking against the sudden orange glow in her eyes.

Fields of crops burning bright, the glare of the fire overwhelming the tepid glow of the cloud-covered sun.

"No!" Catra shades her eyes and runs forward. She can hear the slapping of Perfuma's sandals as the princess runs after her.

"Catra! What plant?" She calls.

Catra stops, her chest heaving. She's run away from the secluded hut and into a flower garden. She scans for the unusual angry red coloration. A few gardeners are staring at her, wondering why a half-naked, crazed looking cat woman is accosting their flowers.

"Catra!" Perfuma says, panting, "Please stop and talk to me."

Catra spins to look at her, still shaking and panicked. "There's a plant," she explains, "a red one. Tall stem. Red flower. Looked like-" She puts her hands together and spreads her fingers, "clawed hands."

Perfuma steps forward, "And why is this plant so important?"

Catra growls slightly, annoyed at the princess's calming tone and posture. "It's at the center of this!" She says, "I think that's why I lost my memories. I think-" '*I think I killed someone because of it.*' She swallows hard, trying to un-think that grim possibility. "We need to find it."

Perfuma nods, and Catra breathes a sigh of relief as the princess begins thinking. '*At least she's not being patronizing or trying to calm me.*'

"I think I know the plant you're talking about," Perfuma finally says, "Go back to the healing hut and wait for me there."

"No way," Catra protests, "I'm coming with yo-"

Perfuma cuts her off. "Catra. If this plant had an adverse effect on you before, I'm not going to risk it happening again."

"But-"

"Catra." Perfuma draws herself up to her full height. "It's not a request. Go."

Catra's ears flatten and she shrinks back. She chooses not to argue anymore and instead slinks back to the yurt.

To avoid thinking, she sets about cleaning up the mess. Tools and needles lie about haphazardly, knocked over in Catra's flailing and Perfuma's hasty removal. She collects the needles and sets them on the side table. She walks around the edge of the hut and puts out each of the candles, sending dozens of distinct smoke smells into the air. Finally, she sits on the table and waits.

She waits for a wave of horrible thoughts that never quite come. Her mind is almost blank, as if unable to create the images and words that the situation would call for.

Perfuma walks in the door, carrying a small potted plant. Catra regards it. The shape of the stem and leaves is familiar, though it lacks the distinctive flower.

"I believe this is the plant you were talking about," Perfuma says, setting it down on one of the counters.

"What is it?" Catra asks, her gaze still fixed on the plant.

“It’s called clawmint,” Perfuma says, her voice quiet and level, “Because of the distinctive shape of its flower.”

“But-”

“Another commonly used name,” Perfuma continues, “Is the Rage Flower. The plant has an unusual defensive mechanism when in bloom. It sprays pheromones over its attacker. These pheromones provoke a large array of reactions depending on the species. Most herbivores experience sudden drowsiness. Small predators tend to become afraid or hyperactive. Humans,” Her expression has become rather grim, “Become enraged for a short period of time. It’s a very dangerous plant.”

“Then why,” Catra rasps, “do you have it?”

Perfuma turns to look at Catra, who is breathing heavily and staring at the plant with slitted eyes.

“Because it’s harmless when not flowering,” Perfuma explains, “And is a vital ingredient in some of Plumeria’s most effective behavioral medicines. Anti-depressants, energy stimulants, even caffeine substitutes. But when it’s flowering, and especially when it’s in the wild…”

“It’s like evil catnip.” Catra whispers.

“Yes.” Perfuma says, “And if you suffered memory loss from it… I’m afraid you had a particularly adverse reaction.”

Catra shivers and looks down at her hands, remembering the blood she saw dripping from them in those flashes of memory.

“It was me…” She chokes out, “I need to-”

‘*Need to what? Tell Lila? Lose the one real friend you have? Think about this, Catra. What if she attacks you? What if she turns you in. You’ve only gotten this far because of Adora. What if Adora finds out about this? You think she’ll let you touch her when she knows you’ve used those hands to kill? What about Glimmer? If*

the people turn against you, how long until they turn against her? How long until Brannic convinces her to revoke your pardon?

'I don't care,' Catra thinks, `*Telling Lila is the right thing to do. And I won't be able to sleep until I've done it.'*

She stands up, and Perfuma starts. Evidently she had been talking while Catra had her little internal debate.

"Thank you so much Perfuma," Catra says, "But I have to go now. There's… something I have to do."

*****

Catra closes her eyes and braces herself before knocking on the door.

crack crack crack

After a few seconds, the door squeaks open. Lila pokes her head out. She's in a night gown and is carrying a mug.

"Cyra?" She asks, puzzled, "What are you doing here? Are you alright? Are you hurt?" She immediately begins scanning Catra's body for injuries.

"I'm okay." Catra responds. She's surprised that her voice comes out clear and steady, not as a shaky whisper like she expected. "Can I come in? I have to talk to you."

Lila looks concerned, but admits Catra, leading her into a small sitting room. Catra's eyes are drawn to the mantle, where a small framed painting depicts Lila with another woman: dark skinned with green eyes and a mop of shaggy black-and-blonde hair.

The soldier who ran into the woods.

"So what's wrong Cyra?" Lila asks.

Catra cannot meet her gaze. “I’m not who you think I am. My name isn’t Cyra,” She closes her eyes, dispelling Melog’s illusion, “It’s Catra.” She opens them and looks at Lila. Recognition flashes across her face. “And I know that you're probably thinking a lot of things right now but please just listen.

“When you told me your story, I started to remember something. It took a lot but now I finally know. I know why the name Tenfields was so familiar. Lila… it was me.” She looks into Lila’s face and sees a dawning horror. “It was me…” Catra chokes out as she suppresses a sob with everything she has. ‘*These aren’t my tears to shed tonight.*’

After the realization hits, Lila just whispers, “Why?”

“I didn’t have a choice,” Catra explains, “She ran, I chased, and I hit this plant and… It took my free will… made me just an animal… I’m so sorry.”

Lila falls back into her chair, speechless. Tears flow in steady rivulets down her cheeks.

Catra stands up, unable to prevent her own tears any longer.

“I’m so sorry…” She whispers again, and turns to leave.

Before she can get out the door, Lila speaks. “Catra?” Catra turns towards her, “Thank you for the closure. Please don’t come back.”

Catra feels those four words slam into her chest. She feels like she’s falling, and everything she reaches for to catch herself just turns to dust.

“Yeah.” She says, “I know.”

She turns and walks out the door. The last words Lila says come to her as if she were underwater, and they don’t seem to make any sense.

It’s only later, when Catra has returned to Bright Moon and collapsed into her bed that she finally processes those last three words.

“I’m sorry Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, kudos and comments are always appreciated!

A Day in The Fright Zone, Part 1: Demolition Decisions

Chapter Summary

> In which the Best Friend Squad returns to the Fright Zone and discusses which parts of the Horde's war machine are worth keeping.

Chapter Notes

> After a week and a day (the week was an intentional break, the day was forgotten) we are back! Season 1b begins with chapter 8, which old readers may remember as the one where everything changes. Hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora (Six Years Ago)

SHHHHHKRRRRRRIIIIIIIIIIIINNNGGGG!!

Adora is jarred awake at the sound of the alarm. Catra's on all fours at the foot of the bed, her tail puffed out in alarm as she looks around.

"Come onnnn." Lonnie moans, shoving a pillow over her face, muffling her next words. "Now?" Lonnie is generally professional and competent, almost as much as Adora. But not when sleeping. As she puts it, "*My dreams belong to me. Not the Horde*."

Adora is out of bed immediately, and rushes to the corner, grabbing the fire extinguisher and waiting for the rest of her squad to assemble. 7 and a half seconds later, she's leading an ordered march down the hall, moving outside to their designated spot. The other nine squads of their hall arrive soon after. Adora smiles proudly. Efficiency is important in a crisis, even if it is a drill.

“Squad Four!” Sergeant Cobalt is marching towards them, anger in his voice.

“Sir!” Adora steps forward and salutes.

Cobalt stands in front of her. “I’ll give you a chance to tell me what you think you did wrong.”

“Umm… didn’t assemble fast enough?” Adora says. She feels a claw tap on her shoulder, and turns to look at Catra.

Her friend steps up and leans an arm on Adora’s shoulder, looking up at Cobalt. “We left Kyle.”

Adora and Lonnie facepalm. Rogelio growls. *‘Seriously Kyle?’*

Cobalt grunts. “You left. Kyle. If anything, Squad Leader, you moved too fast. Efficiency isn’t just speed, it’s awareness too.”

“Yes sir!” Adora salutes again, “won’t happen again sir!”

“No it won’t.” He says. Kyle steps out from behind him and joins the rest of the squad, earning stink eyes from Catra and Lonnie. “Squad Seven! Where is your extinguisher?” Cobalt barks as he walks away.

Adora groans and bangs the extinguisher against her forehead, much harder than she had intended to. She staggers a bit, and feels Catra catch her.

“Hey, watch it. You’ll knock yourself out with that thing. And then you’ll fall and knock *me* out with it.” She says, teasingly.

Adora straightens up and smiles. Catra looks around and leans in, whispering, “Don’t beat yourself up, okay? This wasn’t your fault.”

Adora sighs, “But I should have done a head count.”

“No, actually. The leader doesn’t do head counts, the second in line does.” Catra sticks a thumb into her own chest. “I thought I

saw Kyle's skinny butt behind Rogelio. This one's on me."

Adora raises an eyebrow. "Catra, are you… claiming responsibility for something?"

The feline's eyes widen. "Oh stars, I'm turning into *you!*" She takes several steps back, mock horror on her face.

Adora laughs.

Catra (Present Day)

'Huh. The Fright Zone is… pretty'. Catra thinks, her mouth slightly ajar as she stares at the spires and arcs of the Fright Zone, now covered in vines and flowers. The jagged spikes of the surrounding crater are still fairly rocky and barren, but the actual industrial sprawl of the former Horde complex is covered in vegetation. '*Life, blooming in a factory of destruction'*. Catra sticks her tongue out and shudders. '*It was a mistake letting Mermista introduce me to poetry*'. Melog trots up to her side and butts against her thigh. Their mane is swirling green as they take in the sight.

"You never saw this place in its glory." Catra says, her hand drifting through their spectral mane. "You didn't miss much. There was a lot of smoke. The sky was red most of the time. Not a very good place to grow up."

The crunch of boots alerts her to another person's presence, and Adora stands beside her, lacing her fingers through Catra's own as the three of them look out over the Fright Zone.

"It's weird, isn't it?" Adora says, her voice hushed. "It looks like a whole new place at first but…" she trails off, and Catra picks up the thought.

"It's just a layer of niceness over a whole lot of bad."

Adora nods, and the rest of the party catches up, pulling their skiffs into spots near where Adora and Catra's had been parked.

Bow hops off his skiff, and helps Glimmer down with a slightly exaggerated bow. The queen of Brightmoon thanks him in the most pompous voice imaginable before the pair walks up to join Adora and Catra.

"Wow…" Glimmer says. "So much has changed since the first time I was here… Like I'm not tied up, for example." She shoots Catra a narrow-eyed look.

Catra chuckles bashfully and rubs the back of her head, "Yeah… Sorry about that Q."

"Q?" Glimmer says, her face scrunching up with amusement and confusion.

"Sure." Catra shrugs. "Sparkles is getting a bit stale. I'm trying new things."

General Juliet interrupts, walking up and bowing before Glimmer. "Your Majesty. The emissary from Mystacor has arrived, and Princess Scorpia is on her way to meet us."

Catra looks over towards the newest arrival. A single man who just landed on a staff. He wipes what appears to be a series of bugs out of his hair. He turns, and Catra's hackles raise.

Another Shapeshifter?

This sorcerer has the same green skin and pointed ears as Double Trouble, but is otherwise quite different. He has a fuller build and he's a tad shorter. His dirty blonde hair is dyed light blue at the roots, and he's wearing a fairly normal outfit: loose trousers and a poofy shirt with a distinctively fancy red vest. His nose is a little crooked and he has pronounced smile lines on his right side. As he turns to look at the group, that right side flashes a grin.

“Sorry for my tardiness Your Majesty. Took a wrong turn.” He bows.

How do you take a wrong turn in the sky?

“It’s okay Fygan. We only just got here.” Glimmer says with a forgiving wave.

Fygan straightens and nods to Bow, then turns to look at Catra and Adora. “I don’t believe we’ve been formally introduced. My name is Fygan, former head of Mystacor’s illusionists, and current ambassador to Horror Hall. And you, I presume, are Adora and Catra. May I just say that it is the honor of a lifetime to meet-“

“The memorial!!” Adora blurts out, loud enough to startle Catra. Catra gives her a ‘*what the heck?*’ look, and Adora gets sheepish. “Sorry, I just knew I recognized you from somewhere. You spoke at Sh- Light Spinner’s memorial, right?”

Fygan nods somberly. “I did. I know she’s a… complicated figure, but I felt like I owed her some measure of respect.”

No one owes that witch anything Catra cuts him off to ask, “Former head of illusions?”

Fygan nods. “That’s right. I resigned my station to serve as official ambassador here not long after I started work in the Fright Zone. I thought I could do more good here.”

Catra scoffs and turns away, looking at where Scorpia is approaching while Fygan and Adora carry on the conversation.

It’s both Scorpia and Perfuma, as well as four guards outfitted in spiffy modified Horde outfits.

Something’s wrong. Scorpia and Perfuma both look worried, and are talking to each other in hushed tones. Catra can make out Perfuma’s lips saying, ‘Should tell them. Maybe not lead with it though.’

Huh. I can read lips. That's pretty cool.

"Hey guys!" Scorpia calls out as they approach.

"Hi Scorpia!" Bow calls in response, "Hi Perfuma!"

The groups meet each other. Scorpia moves to give everyone hugs as they arrive. Introductions are exchanged, but Catra isn't paying attention. Her eyes have drifted back to the Fright Zone. To those walls and towers that trapped her for her whole life.

"What's wrong?" Glimmer's voice brings Catra back to the present. "You guys seem on edge."

Scorpia sighs. "There have been some disappearances recently. We're not sure if people are just deserting, but they're vanishing."

Perfuma glides over to Scorpia and wraps her hands around Scorpia's bicep. "This is the third one this month. They're getting more frequent."

Catra looks at Adora, who is already deep in thought, doubtlessly trying to think of ways she can help save the day.

Scorpia adds, "This time it was an officer. That old drill sergeant, remember?"

Catra nods. Cobalt. Not the nicest guy. She wouldn't be surprised if he'd deserted to seek out one of the Horde Remnant cells. "When did they start?" She asks.

"About two months after the war." Perfuma says.

"Anyways," Scorpia continues, "That's not why you guys are here. We need some help deciding what parts of the Fright Zone to demolish and what parts to keep. We got Entrapta and Hordak's perspectives a few days ago, but we figured having a less…"

Perfuma chimes in, "Analytical."

Scorpia smiles and continues. “Yeah, a less analytical perspective might help us make a decision.”

Catra raises her eyebrows. She’s impressed at how much Scorpia has grown into her new role as a leader. Even as a Force Captain she was never particularly good at managing people and thinking of solutions as a commander.

“Aaaaannnnddd…” Scorpia adds, “There’s all sorts of fun stuff we can do while we’re here! Ah man it’s like a reunion. I wish Lonnie and Kyle and Rogelio were here. Then we could really have to gang back together!”

There she is. Catra grins and bumps Adora’s shoulder. The blonde snaps out of her trance and looks down at Catra, who points her head over to the Fright Zone.

“Race you to the Foundry?” Catra says.

Adora breaks into a radiant smile. “Oh you are so on.”

The two are off immediately, ignoring Glimmer’s shouted protests.

Glimmer

Once everyone had gotten back together, the first area of debate was the training rooms.

“If the Fright Zone isn’t producing an army any more, there’s no need for it!” Glimmer argues.

Catra’s been the fiercest proponent of leaving it unchanged. “It’s not about an army. Horde soldiers were better trained than any of the other kingdom’s fighters.” General Juliet scoffs at that, but Catra continues, “And these training rooms are perfect for heightening teamwork and keeping you on your toes.”

“And,” Perfuma says, “being very offensive to princesses.” Scorpia shuffles awkwardly behind her.

Catra pinches the bridge of her nose. “That can be changed. The point is that it’s too valuable a resource to lose. I haven’t seen training grounds this useful anywhere but Mystacor. If anything, all the kingdoms should have these!”

“Why?” Glimmer says irately, “We aren’t at war anymore.”

Adora gives a hollow laugh, “So we’re just supposed to let our fighting skills die away? What about when the next threat comes? The Horde can’t have been the only enemy out there in the galaxy. Now that Etheria isn’t alone, we need to be ready for anything.” Catra nods in agreement, folding her arms against her chest.

“Guys,” Bow says, “how about we go through the training course, and make our decision based on that? That way we’ll be able to see first hand how useful they are from a, no offense, less biased perspective.”

“Biased?” Adora says, affronted.

“Every soldier thinks the place where they trained is the best,” Bow says.

Glimmer sighs, annoyed that she doesn’t seem to be on the winning side here. *‘I know they’re right. We need to be ready. But we don’t need to rely on Horde technology to do that, and we don’t need to keep these facilities open. It sends a bad message.’*

“I think that’s a wonderful idea Bow.” Perfuma says, her chipper attitude coming back to her, “Scorpia, what simulations do we have?”

Scorpia walks over to the command board and scrolls through a list. “Let’s see… Northern Reach, Whispering Woods, Crimson Waste, Meadowlands, Plumeria, Salineas, Kingdom of Snows, and The Fright Zone.”

“And are any of them *not* super offensive?” Glimmer asks drily.

“Hoo boy…” Scorpia scrolls through again. “Oh! The Crimson Waste! Enemies there are just raiders and animals, not princesses.”

“Fine. Let’s do it.” Glimmer says.

Bow

Bow’s visor comes down, and he nocks an arrow as the environment materializes on the glass pane in front of him. Spires of rock, canyons, massive skeletons, and cacti all provide ample cover, and he hears the grinding sound of the various plates rising to simulate the terrain.

“Alright,” Scorpia says, “The Crimson Waste is especially tricky. There aren’t too many enemies, but they hide, like-” She’s cut off as a laser blast flies into the group. Glimmer teleports up to a nearby rock to avoid it, while Catra leaps to the side and skids along the ground. “Like that!” Scorpia shouts.

Adora’s authoritative voice finds everyone to order, “Fan out, don’t stick too close to each other, but keep each other in sight!”

And it begins. Bow keeps his eyes peeled, and fires every time he sees a holographic raider show up on his mask. Perfuma uses a pair of potted plants as ammunition, firing off vines to restrain the training bots whenever she sees one. Scorpia is going powers free, charging in to engage the more powerful enemies with her pincers, and taking hits for those who can’t. Catra and Glimmer are working in tandem, both of them darting around the field, with Catra calling out targets, and Glimmer teleporting in to eliminate them.

Adora leads the charge, no She Ra, just her and her old staff.

“Bow, look out!” Scorpia dives in and shoves him down, and her chestpiece flares red as she gets hit by one of the bots’ carefully aimed blast. “Aw man.” Her shoulders slump as she sadly walks

back to the starting zone, having taken one too many hits for her friends.

They're nearly to the end. Perfuma got out soon after Scorpia, falling into a surprise pit of "quicksand". Bow rushes forward and ducks behind a raised platform representing some massive animal skull. Catra is nowhere to be seen, and Adora and Glimmer move forward together as the final bot rises out of a large hole. On the screen, the image of a massive snake monster looms, all teeth and red eyes. Bow fires several shots in quick succession. Adora leaps up, slamming it with her staff like a bat. Glimmer fires off a blast of energy into one of its legs. The bot groans, firing off several bursts that light up the ground panels. Adora leaps out of the way as one of the panels gives way, but her foot catches on the lip and she goes sprawling. Catra darts in, leaping over Adora and flipping around in the air to strike the bot with both feet. It stumbles and collapses into the hole it came out of, barely holding on with one leg, which Bow quickly dispatches with a well placed arrow.

"Whoo!" Glimmer teleports in and smooches him on the cheek.

Catra helps Adora up and cocks a hip as the room resets and Perfuma and Scorpia join them. "Not bad Princesses." She teases. "So. Whaddaya think?"

Bow looks to Glimmer, who slowly nods. "I think it can stay." She says, "You guys are right. We need to be ready for whatever the next threat is. And this is as good a way as any. As soon as the visuals are updated."

Catra

Catra and Melog had managed to slip away from the group. Walking through those halls made her feel trapped. She knew she had to get away. *But now what?* She's still wandering through the Fright Zone, but now she doesn't have Adora's comforting presence. There's no debate to keep her away from her own

thoughts, she's just walking around, her fur standing on end, waiting for something bad to happen.

She jumps out of her skin and wheels around as she hears a piercing groan. Looking around frantically, she rushes to a nearby window and exhales as she sees a team disassembling a tower nearby. *'It was just the metal creaking.'*

She spins around again, swearing she hears a familiar hissing voice. "Catra…" It drifts away.

"Shut up." Catra growls to the air. There's a moment of silence before she stands up. She wipes her hair out of her face and grabs her upper arm. "I shouldn't have come, should I?" She mutters.

'You don't belong here.' Catra gasps. The voice she hears in her head sounds like Shadow Weaver, but also like herself. *'You don't belong anywhere.'*

No, NO! Catra falls to her knees and clutches her head. It's been months since this has happened. She hasn't thought about Shadow Weaver since Mystacor.

"I beat you." Catra says, her voice cracking.

Foolish child. You beat nothing.

"I beat you!" Catra repeats, her voice growing into a shout. She stands up, and races through the halls, Melog hot on her heels, meowing questions that she doesn't have the time or brainpower to answer.

The pair dashes through the Fright Zone onto a balcony, then up a series of landings and precarious handholds to a platform overlooking it all. Catra breathes heavily, and glares out over this land. The place where she was raised, where she nearly broke the world. Where she took charge and proved herself. Where she defeated Shadow Weaver.

“I BEAT YOU!!” She shouts at the top of her lungs. It echoes through the buildings, and she breathes for a moment, before slowly sinking to the floor and letting the tears overtake her. But not tears of sadness or fear. Tears of relief.

I’m doing better. She looks down at her hands, remembering that time in the cave, where she had torn them apart in a fury. No more losing control. She smiles. Melog rubs against her, their mane light blue and yellow with happiness. Catra breathes in, and smiles.

Catra (Four Years Ago)

Catra grins triumphantly. Everyone else on the team got zapped by the bots, but she had bided her time, snuck around, and taken out the “queen” all by herself. She flips her mane of hair as Adora stalks over to her, an adorably pouty glare on her face.

“Catra! You’re supposed to be on the team, not on your own!” She shouts as she approaches.

Catra scoffs and struts over to Adora. “Clearly I do better when you’re not weighing me down. She walks past Adora, swiping her tail over the blonde’s bicep, and then squeaks in surprise and anger when a hand grabs that tail. “HeY! Let go!” She turns and smacks Adora’s hand away, and glares up at that dumb face, which is now full of concern.

“Catraa… that’s not what I’m saying. The assignment was about how well you could work with a team.”

“And you, as usual, failed.” Catra’s hackles raise and she suppresses a hiss at that hateful voice. She turns around, trying her best to look casual and unimpressed as Shadow Weaver glides towards her. She can see Sergeant Cobalt briefing the rest of the squad behind her.

“Really?” Catra says, “Cuz I thought I knocked it out of the park.” She cocks her head behind her, where the massive final bot is still

smoking.

"You left your more *valuable* team mates to be destroyed, including your team leader!" Shadow Weaver snarls. "Were this a real battle, you would have been caught and killed because of your little hide and seek game, and the Horde would have lost nearly a full squad of its most valuable soldiers."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "And Kyle."

The white eyes behind the mask widen. If it weren't Shadow Weaver, Catra could have possibly mistaken the intake of breath for an attempt to suppress a laugh. But instead…

"Insolent child. Why must you try so hard to disappoint me!?" The shadows writhe out from her form, and Catra takes an instinctive step back.

Not in the mood for lightning today. Catra grits her teeth. "Sorry, Shadow Weaver. Won't happen again." She can tell the tone isn't believable, but Shadow Weaver's form shrinks down regardless.

"Oh Catra." The witch slides forward, and places a hand on Catra's cheek. "I only want what's best for you. If you learned to work with your teammates, perhaps they might think better of you."

Catra lowers her gaze to the floor, thinking of the dirty looks, the hurtful comments thrown by the other recruits. The snide rumours about her and Adora…

Shadow Weaver turns to talk to Adora, commending her as usual, and Catra stalks away, right past the rest of the squad and out of the room. She suppresses the beginning of a sob, and blinks to get the tears out of her eyes.

"Cadet!" A gruff voice follows her.

"Ugh!" She pushes her hand against the wall, grinding her claws in. "What!?" She spins around, seeing Sergeant Cobalt's large frame walking towards her.

He raises what passes for an eyebrow, but doesn't tell her to watch her mouth. *Guess he knows Shadow Weaver's got a monopoly on punishing me.*

"Your review." He hands her a sheet of paper. She looks at it, and her eyes widen.

Top marks across the sheet, even in teamwork. She looks up at Cobalt in confusion.

"You performed admirably." He says, and turns.

"Wait!" She calls, and he stops. "What about teamwork? I left them behind so I'd have the glory to myself. Why would that get me top marks?"

He turns around. "Is that what happened? I saw a talented soldier who knows her own strength allow her teammates to distract the enemy while she snuck around to cut the head off the snake." Catra's eyes widen. Cobalt nods to her. "It's not your fault they couldn't defeat the enemy without you. And remember," He looks over his shoulder back at the entrance to the training room, then speaks more softly. "I'm the combat instructor. My feedback is more important than hers. You may be something of a slacker, but you have more potential than almost any other soldier I've trained. You're a leader. I've put in a request for you to be promoted to Force Captain." He straightens up and turns around to walk away, leaving Catra standing in the middle of the hall, mouth agape.

She goes through the rest of her day in a giddy haze. Someone in the Horde besides Adora had been nice to her. Someone stood up to Shadow Weaver, albeit indirectly. As she recalls the conversation to Adora on their platform, she's so overcome with happiness that she almost loses control, almost gets too close. But she disguises her movement by pretending she had just seen something on the blonde's cheek. The two sit side by side and watch the sun set behind the caldera walls.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, comments and kudos are always appreciated. Hope you enjoyed.

A Day in The Fright Zone, Part 2: Catching Up

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra and Adora spend some time together and make a troubling discovery.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia (Present Day)

Scorpia and Adora are pacing opposite cycles around the room.

"Come on guys," Glimmer groans. "This is what Catra has literally *always* been like. She'll turn up just fine."

Adora stops and huffs indignantly. "Um first of all, don't tell me what *my girlfriend* who I've known my whole life has always been like. Second of all!" She pauses, and lowers her finger, then sighs, "You're a hundred percent right." Glimmer humphs smugly.

Scorpia continues pacing. "Oh but what if she gets hurt? There's a lot of construction and destruction and other types of struction going on… She could be trapped under a crane! Or… trapped under a beam! Or trapped under a-"

"Sweetie." Perfuma steps in front of her and grabs her pincers away from the sides of her head. "Catra's not trapped under anything. Even if she was, she's with Melog, who can move things with their mind. It'll be fine."

Scorpia breathes a long exhale to calm herself.

"Hey guys. Woahhh… why's everyone so tense?" Catra's voice comes from the door.

“Catra!!” Adora barrels across the room and leaps onto Catra, sending them both to the ground with an ‘oof’.

Once her breath is back, Catra busts out laughing. “Geez. I guess I really do have to start giving notice when I wander off, huh? In case you wind up killing me with one of these.”

“Hey,” Adora says sternly, “Don’t say that.”

Catra’s giggles trail off as she and Adora get to their feet. “So, what did I miss?”

“Not much.” Scorpia responds, “We’ve mostly just been going over lists of buildings to demolish and ones to stay. And I’m gonna give you a tour of the newly refurbished Horror Hall!” Scorpia accents that last part with jazz pincers.

“Sounds fun.” Catra replies.

Scorpia turns to address the room, but she notices that Glimmer and General Juliet are apart from everyone else, talking quietly but animatedly. Juliet seems to be holding a small communication pad. The pair turn and Juliet addresses the room.

“I’m afraid we will have to leave after that tour Princess Scorpia.”

“What’s going on?” Scorpia asks, “Is someone in trouble?”

Glimmer looks concerned. “We just got word from Huntara. Apparently that old Fire kingdom at the edge of the Crimson Waste is crawling with ex Horde soldiers. We need to get back to Bright Moon to coordinate a response.”

Scorpia nods. “If it’s okay, I’d like to come with you.” Glimmer cocks her head, and Scorpia second guesses herself. ‘*Scorpia, just let them handle it. You’ve got your claws full already, and you’d only get in the way.’* Scorpia closes her eyes and takes a breath before saying, “I want to help plan a response. The Fright Zone is the closest kingdom, meaning it’s in my jurisdiction. Plus, I think it may have something to do with the disappearances too.”

Glimmer smiles warmly. “We’ll be glad to have you.”

“So…” Scorpia turns to look at Catra, who is leaning on Adora and has twirled some blonde hair around her finger. “Should we go ahead and get to that tour?”

Bow

“And here it is!” Scorpia says, “Good ol Scorpion HQ.”

Horror Hall is fairly simple in build, a large monolith of a castle with tiered defenses, made of massive slabs of sandstone, freshly cleaned and refurbished. Scorpia leads the way through the massive double doors, which open automatically.

“One of the perks of rebuilding with Fright Zone tech.” Scorpia explains. “And this is the throne room!”

Bow looks around with great interest as they enter the large hall. It’s much darker than the likes of Salineas or Bright Moon, but no less grand and adorned, especially now that it’s been restored. The paintings on the walls, detailing important moments in the Scorpion Kingdom’s history, have been repainted, and pop out vibrantly. The painting behind the throne has been updated, depicting the classical five spires, with the central one behind the throne featuring a stylized image of Scorpia herself. The other four are blank.

‘Room for more’. Bow thinks, casting a smile in the direction of Scorpia and Perfuma.

He wanders around the room, taking in the many paintings.

“Hey Glimmer, check out this one!” He calls. His girlfriend appears beside him.

“What’s up?” She looks up at the painting, and gasps lightly.

The top half of the painting depicts Horror Hall, flanked by the distinctive spires of the Fright Zone Caldera. The second half

shows two figures: One, a purple and brown Scorpion woman with a mane of grey hair down to her waist. The other: a tall pink clad slim form with angelic wings.

"Oh." Glimmer says quietly.

"This must be the founding of The Fright Zone." Bow says. "I didn't know Bright Moon was there. I thought we've always been enemies."

"Not always!" A nasally voice pipes up, Bow jumps and spins around, seeing one of the attendants who have been wandering the room, pointing other members of their group towards interesting areas of the castle. "Sorry to startle. You're mostly right. The Fright Zone and Bright Moon have always been rivals, often coming to blows over their conflicting ideologies. But it was Queen Angella who helped free what would become The Fright Zone from a warlord in ancient times. She was the one who realized the Scorpion peoples' connection to the Black Garnet. The Fright Zone has much to owe Bright Moon, as do many of the other kingdoms."

Bow turns back to the painting as the clerk drifts off. "Before we go off to space, we have got to take my dads here." He says.

Glimmer takes his hand. "I think we can make a day of that. Although… I worry about George and Scorpia being in the same place. Add in Swift Wind and the positive vibes may overload the planet."

Bow chuckles, and the group moves on to other parts of the castle.

Adora (Seven Years Ago)

Adora's tongue is stuck out. One eye is closed. This has to be perfect. She has to get this just right before-

"Adora? What are you doing?" Catra's voice.

Adora yelps in alarm and frantically shoves her pillow to the side to cover her work. “Nothing! Don’t worry about it.”

Catra’s skinny teenage form walks over and crawls into bed next to Adora, immediately moving the pillow out of the way to look at what Adora’s been doing. Adora blushes furiously as the feline cocks her head, seeing the little doodles of the two of them.

“You’re such an idiot.” Catra says, her voice soft and full of fondness. “One thing though.” Adora looks up, and Catra snatches the chalk without making eye contact. She quickly adds angry eyebrows to both faces, then tosses the chalk back. “There.” She says, “That’s better.” Adora smiles at Catra, who is still looking away. Catra sniffs, and pads down to the end of the bed before curling up for sleep.

Adora smiles and pats Catra’s head before lying down for sleep, facing the drawings. She closes her eyes and falls asleep to the sound of her best friend’s soft snoozes at the foot of the bed.

Adora (Present Day)

Adora sits cross legged on her old bed, looking sadly at the old drawing. It’s mostly faded, but the claw marks rending through her visage are unmistakable. She reaches out and runs her fingers across the scarred metal.

Catra is behind her, her arms crossed, leaning against the door frame, looking away. Melog is pacing the length of the room, mewling anxiously, shifting in and out of invisibility.

“When was this?” Adora asks softly.

“Right after you left…” Catra responds. “I… never really saw it after that cause I got promoted out of this dump. I’d… kind of forgotten I did that.”

Adora nods. She looks over at Catra. “Come here.” Catra’s eyes widen, and her breath hitches, but she obliges, crawling into the

bed that is too small for both of them now. Adora reaches into her pocket, and pulls out some chalk she keeps on hand for drawing battle plants. Catra looks at the chalk, looks at the wall, then looks at Adora and smiles. Adora leans in and draws something new. Both of their faces, just like before. Adora with the gold stud she's taken to wearing on her right ear, Catra with the shorter hair and without the mask. When she's done, Catra grabs the chalk, and adds the trademark angry eyebrows. She lets her hand fall to the bed, and Adora leans in and kisses her, softly and tenderly, placing her hand on top of Catra's.

Adora exhales softly. It's weirdly exhilarating to kiss her here. Here where they spent their childhood, where their feelings for each other developed. Adora remembers all the times their little sleepovers had left her feeling hollow, left her wanting so much more with the girl she was so close to, yet so far away from.

"Always wanted to do that here." Catra says, with a smirk.

"Me too." Adora says breathlessly. '*Stars she's beautiful*.'

Catra leans in for another, deeper kiss, pushing Adora's head down onto the pillow and leaning over her with a devious smile. "And always wanted to do this here."

Adora's face flushes ferociously, but before anything else happens, a mrowl from Melog at the door causes Catra to perk up. The feline groans and rolls her eyes. "Someone's coming." She says, annoyed. She leans down and kisses Adora on the nose. "To be continued." She says with a wink, and rolls out of the bed.

Adora is still lying there stunned when the person arrives.

"I… hope I'm not interrupting anything." Comes the voice of Fygan.

"NOTHING!" Adora shouts, bolting up and banging her head on the metal rim of the bed. She springs to her feet, rubbing her forehead. Catra snorts. Fygan's eyes are wide, and he's clearly

trying not to join the feline in raucous laughter. “Shut up.” Adora mutters to Catra.

“Not a chance.” Catra says, her tail wrapping around Adora’s calf. She turns to Fygan. “What’s up? Thought you’d be leaving with everyone else.”

“Oh, they haven’t left yet. And anyways, there’s something I wanted to show you two.”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “You know we’ve probably seen it.”

“No no, not what you’ve s- ah.” He pauses as his words make the journey from brain to mouth.

Can relate.

“You haven’t seen it,” He responds, “Because it’s something I’ve made in my spare time here. Sort of an… art project.”

“Sounds neat!” Adora says, and looks at Catra.

The feline shrugs. “Whatever. Let’s go.”

Catra

Fygan leads them away from the cadet halls, and towards the Force Captain barracks.

“I found a hidden chamber in one of the old force captain’s rooms about a month after I came here.” He begins. “It was an elevator that led pretty deep under the area to what I can only describe as a meat locker. From what I gathered, the captain it belonged to was a carnivore, so the ration bars didn’t really… work for him.”

I get that.

“He had this installed so he could have some, ah,” He raises his hands in finger quotes, “‘proper food’ every once in a while. When I saw it, I had the perfect idea for a little… gallery.”

“A gallery of what? Steaks? Fish maybe?” Catra snarks.

“Not quite.” Fygan responds, “See, I do sculptures. Ice sculptures. I’m pretty good at it if I do say so myself. But the problem with ice sculptures-”

“Is that they melt,” Adora chimes in. “Yeah… Frosta’s ice sculptures usually leave a big puddle in Bright Moon after a few hours.”

Fygan chuckles. “Exactly. But this room is totally temperature controlled. It goes colder than the Northern Reach down there. The perfect place to set up a little studio where I can create in the same area I work.”

“Huh,” Catra says, “Pretty clever. One problem though: I’ve been to the Northern Reach. Not really my style.”

“Oh don’t worry.” Fygan responds. “I’ll turn the temperature up when we get in, and we won’t be there long enough to cause any harm.”

“So there’s a possibility of harm? Awesome.” Catra adds sardonically, earning a light elbow from Adora.

“Be nice.” Adora whispers.

Fygan, however, simply turns to look at Catra as they reach the old force captain’s room, “Would it really be art if there weren’t a possibility of harm?” He flashes a toothy grin, and reminds Catra of Double Trouble.

As they enter, the remaining trappings of the room clue Catra in as to the identity of the force captain. Grizzlor, artillery division. *He did have a thing for hunting trips*. Fygan walks over to the wall and presses a raised panel. The wall slides aside, revealing another door, which opens into an elevator.

They enter, and Fygan presses another button. The car lurches, and they start going down.

“So,” Catra says, “How did you know good old Shadow Weaver?” Fygan opens his mouth, and Adora shoots her a look, “I know you probably told Adora when we met you, but I wasn’t listening.”

Fygan smiles, “Understandable. Shadow Weaver, or, as I knew her, Light Spinner, was my teacher at Mystacor. She taught me everything I needed to know about magic. Illusions, transmutations, conjurings. She was the most skilled sorceress to walk the halls of Mystacor.” His face darkens, “But she pursued dark magics that corrupted her, and you saw what that turned her into.”

The elevator comes to a stop. Fygan puts a finger on the button, but hesitates. “Brace for the cold.” He presses it, and the elevator door opens with a hiss, letting in a blast of frigid air. Melog yowls in displeasure, and Catra hisses subconsciously.

Adora doesn’t seem too perturbed as she walks into the room, Catra at her side and Fygan behind them. Fygan flips a switch, and the lights come up on a gallery of life sized, life-like statues of ice. The back part of the room is less illuminated, and is partially covered by a white sheet.

And they’re all covered in old Horde memorabilia.

“Woah.” Catra says, walking up to the closest one. It looks like a clone, chest puffed out, fists clenched, and its wearing what looks an awful lot like… “Hordak’s old armor?” Catra puts a finger on the cold metal. “How’d you get this?”

“Found it.” Fygan says, “In Hordak’s old sanctum. Pieced it back together for this guy.”

“Woah…” Adora says, walking up to another figure, this one appears to be a lizardman like Rogelio, only taller and thinner. He’s wearing what Catra remembers to be an experimental exosuit, designed to enhance battlefield strength and mobility. The project had been a failure, but it certainly looks striking on that sculpted mannequin, bent down with mouth agape in a roar.

Catra wanders around the gallery. The more she's in here, the creepier it gets. The sculptures are very lifelike, so she supposes she can congratulate Fygan on his skill. She walks past a few wearing various iterations of standard Horde outfits and suits of armor, then pauses, shocked. "I'm sorry, what?" She says, looking over at Fygan, who is still standing by the entryway.

"Oh!" He says, "I'd forgotten about that one."

Catra looks back. The mannequin is humanoid, in a crouched position. The outfit is hers. Specifically, a replica of what she wore when she was leader of the Horde.

Catra shakes her head. "I had more hair back then," She calls back, and turns towards the back of the room.

"Noted!" Fygan says.

Catra notices something. Behind the curtain are a few more sculptures. Some of them look more completed than others. Clearly this is the workshop portion. Shivering from the cold, trying hard to keep her teeth from chattering, she looks over her shoulder to see if Fygan is looking. His back is turned. *Probably fiddling with the temperature*. She pulls the curtain to the side and looks at the first figure.

It's masculine. Tall, with very broad shoulders and thick arms. The face is flat, and the form is covered in small spines. Catra regards it for a moment, then the blood drains from her face as she realizes what really makes this one stand out.

Color. Faintly, she can see the red and grey of the outfit, the blue of the skin.

And the shock of recognition.

"Adora," She whispers, her voice thin and tense. Adora, not far off, walks over beside her, and looks at the statue. A similar pall of realization falls over her.

“Cobalt?” Adora whispers. She pulls the curtain further to the side, and another humanoid form is revealed. This one is partially frozen in a block of ice, but the features are visible. One of Lonnie’s old friends from another squad. Shiva.

Both of them turn slowly, staring towards the entrance of the room at Fygan.

“You.” Adora breathes, her voice filled with rage.

Gone is his pleasant air. His face has dropped into a smirk. “Guilty.” He says, his voice sounding smugly amused.

“What did you do to them?” Adora says, walking to the middle of the room, Catra stalking by her side, her tail flexing back and forth in anger.

“Is it not obvious?” He responds, sounding confused. “Uh-I *killed* them. I took my sweet *vengeance* upon them. And I gotta say, it felt, *so. Good.*” He sounds smug, and his grin is turning more evil by the second. “But this? You two? Feels way better.”

“Well.” Catra says. “It’s over now you monster. If it’s a fight you want-“

“Then I think we can oblige.” Adora summons her blade and grabs it with both hands. Catra spreads her legs apart and flexes her claws, ready to pounce.

Fygan raises a placating hand, “Oh no no no! I’m not here to fight. I’d never win that one. Besides, don’t they say that revenge is a dish best served,” He spins his hand, and a blue glyph appears before him, spinning and flashing as the magic is activated. “*Frozen?*”

Beneath Catra and Adora’s feet, two circles hidden beneath the ice on the floor flash blue, and blue magic encompasses the two of them. Melog appears beside Catra, meowing in alarm as they are consumed by the energy as well.

“Adora?” Catra says, terrified. “I can’t move!”

“I can’t move either!” Adora responds, the light of her blade flickering and vanishing. They can barely move their lips to speak.

“Like I said,” Fygan strides forward, “Shadow Weaver taught me everything I needed to know about magic. Including an immobilization spell. And with my adjustments, it’s indefinite.”

Catra’s heart sinks into her stomach. The room is getting colder.

“Why?” Adora hisses. “Why are you doing this?”

Fygan’s grin fades, replaced by a grimace of rage. “Because of what you did to us.” (*‘us??’*) He cocks his head towards Catra. “For what she did most of all!” He turns around and walks towards the elevator. “The record for staying alive in this room, locked in place, unable to eat, freezing to death, is four days and two hours. I know you two have always been very competitive, so do *try* and do better for me.”

“The Princesses will find us.” Catra snarls.

“The other Princesses will be gone before they even miss you.” Fygan says, entering the elevator and turning to face them. “Goodbye Catra.”

“NOOOOOOOOOOO!!!” Adora screams, tears freezing in the corners of her eyes.

“Goodbye, Adora.”

The elevator doors close.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading. Comments and kudos are always appreciated!

A Day in The Fright Zone, Part 3: Frozen Hearts

Chapter Summary

> In which time is running out for Catra and Adora, and their friends realize the new threat facing them.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia

Fygan walks into the room with a bashful grin.

"Sorry everyone," He says, "I don't think they're going to come out to say goodbye."

"And why is that?" Glimmer responds tersely. Scorpia just slumps in her chair. She'd hoped to see them again before getting thrust into what might be a long series of war meetings.

Fygan inhales awkwardly and rubs the back of his neck. "I kind of… interrupted a moment? Catra said something about 'getting back to it'... I didn't ask for details."

"Ugh. Those two are insufferable." Glimmer says. "Well, I guess we should get going then."

A guard rushes into the room, and salutes Scorpia. "Princess Scorpia."

There's a hush. *Oh, that's me!* Scorpia realizes. "Um, yes! What is it? Speak."

"There was an accident at the skiff lodge sir." The guard says. "The skiff's engines got overloaded by faulty charging cables."

“So we’re stuck here?” Bow asks.

The guard nods. “My apologies.”

“It’s fine.” Glimmer says. “I’ll just teleport us back to Bright Moon!”

“Glimmer,” Bow says, “We have a lot of people and quite a bit of stuff to bring.”

“So I’ll make multiple trips!”

“OH!” Scorpia raises a pincer. “I have an idea!” Everyone looks to her. “The Crimson Waste is closer to the Fright Zone than it is to Bright Moon. I say we spend the time waiting for the skiffs to get repaired by sending out some recon drones.”

Bow nods, “I’m guessing you guys have some then?”

“Oh yeah, tons. Prime’s occupation here was mostly done with drones. Come on, they’re stored in that Spire he left here.”

She stands up, and motions for everyone to follow her.

Fygan speaks up. “If it’s all the same to you, I’m going to check on the skiffs. That short circuit seems a little too… convenient. It seems like someone’s trying to keep you here.”

“I agree.” General Juliet adds.

Glimmer pauses to consider this. “Alright.” she says. “Bow and Scorpia, can you guys get the drones prepped?”

“On it!” Scorpia says, giving a wink and a salute. “You can count on us boss.”

Glimmer teleports the others to the skiff bay, and Perfuma, Scorpia and Bow head down the hall

Maybe we’ll find Adora and Catra on the way. Scorpia thinks as they make their way towards the Horde Spire.

Juliet

No overt signs of sabotage. Juliet stands up, dropping this cable. All of them seemed perfectly in order. They all connected to the same junction box, and that seemed to be where the problem was. Juliet walks over and pries open that box. She takes a look inside, then at the top. She sighs.

"I'm not an expert on tech," She says, "But I know enough to figure out what happened."

Queen Glimmer teleports over, bringing Fygan with her. Fygan stumbles. Like Lady Catra, he does not seem to take teleporting all that well.

"What is it?" Glimmer asks. One of the Horde (*ex-Horde*) mechanics walks over to join them. Juliet points towards the top of the junction box, where it attaches to the wall. There's a rust eaten hole in the metal there. Looking at the wall, there's a clear path of water leakage from the roof.

The Horde engineer buries their face in their hands. "Of course." They say. They walk up and poke at the inside of the junction box, and their blue skinned finger comes away with moisture on it. They turn bashfully, blushing purple. "I'm sorry. This one's on me. Our tech didn't used to need to be water resistant, but now that the magic's back it rains more here. I didn't think to update it." They pinch the bridge of their nose and shake their head.

Or you wanted to prevent us from getting the drop on your Horde friends.

"Hey," Queen Glimmer puts a hand on their shoulder. "It's okay. Everyone makes mistakes. How long until we can fix it?"

"Give me a couple hours." They say. "I'm going to go get a replacement junction box. All the wires seem to be fine, I just need to get a new connector. There's a waiting room just inside the hall." They rush off.

Glimmer shrugs and walks over to the waiting room. Juliet walks in with her, Fygan following. The other Bright Moon guards assume posts at the door and out in the bay. Juliet takes a seat on a stool, and rubs her chin. *Something doesn't feel right.*

"General?" Juliet looks up at Glimmer. "Is something wrong?"

"Ah-no, Your Majesty. Just… an uneasy feeling. I think the location just has me on edge but…"

Glimmer cocks her head. "But..?"

"I agree with Fygan. The timing seems too convenient. And the fact that we haven't heard back from Huntara…" She shakes her head. *It's not much of a delay. Seems like a move designed to keep us here. But if it is sabotage, why? They'd know Queen Glimmer could teleport us all if necessary*. She sighs. "Things aren't adding up in a way that I like."

Her communicator begins to beep. She answers it. Queen Glimmer walks over, while Fygan steeples his fingers in front of his face and begins to pace.

Bow's face appears on the screen, and Glimmer snatches the pad. "Bow! Did you launch the drones?"

"Yeah," Bow says, he looks concerned. "But we can't find Catra and Adora anywhere. And they're not answering their comms."

"Fygan said they were trying to get some privacy…" Glimmer says thoughtfully.

Perfuma interjects on the other side of the comm. "Yes, but it's been almost three hours."

Scorpia speaks from off screen. "Yeah, plus, I know all Wildcat's hiding spots, and she's not at any of them. Something's wrong. I think this time they actually are missing."

That's it. That's the missing piece. Juliet spins around, drawing her curved longsword and pointing it towards Fygan. "Where are they?"

Glimmer stands beside her, glowing with energy. "You're the last one who saw them," the Queen says in a tranquil fury, "Where are they?"

Fygan raises his hands in a placating gesture. "Okay. Let's all chill out. I already told you. They're just spending some time together."

"So where's Melog?" Glimmer says.

Fygan raises a quizzical eyebrow, "Who?"

Juliet raises her blade to his chin. "If Catra and Adora are alone together, then where is Catra's familiar?"

"Big alien cat?" Glimmer says. "Really pretty noticeable when they aren't invisible."

"I don't know where they are." Fygan says, his tone getting more agitated.

"Tell. The truth." Juliet threatens. Glimmer begins to summon a truth glyph in front of her.

Fygan looks between the two women, then at the blade to his throat, then the glyph. He closes his eyes and sighs. "So. It's gonna be like that, huh?" There's a flash of light as he leaps backwards. Once her eyes adjust, Juliet sees three Fygans standing against the wall. All of them raise a hand and summon a glyph in the air, conjuring three tendrils of energy, two of which wrap around Glimmer, and the third moves towards Juliet.

Her instincts kick in. She slashes her blade through the air, slicing the tendril in two. She rolls forward towards the trio of traitors and swings her blade horizontally.

There's a cry of pain, and the center and left most copies vanish in another blinding flash, leaving only the one on the right, clutching a shallow gash across his torso. He staggers back and falls against the wall. The restraints around Glimmer fade, and she walks up and coldly summons the truth glyph before pushing it forward, letting it wash over the shapeshifter.

"Where are Catra and Adora?" She growls, her voice and face filled with rage.

Fygan looks up at them both with a sneer. "They're in the Fright Zone. And I assure you. They have all the privacy in the world."

They hear footsteps from the entrance as Bow, Scorpia, and Perfuma rush in.

"Is everything okay?" Bow asks.

"You guys dropped comms and-" Scorpia trails off as she sees the scene before them.

Fygan chuckles. "Well well well. The gang's all here."

Juliet puts her blade at the side of his neck. "Tell us where they are. Now. You have no more reason to deceive. It's over."

"Over?" The man leans up, his face turning into a smug, manic grin. "Over? Hahahahaaa. No. It's not over Princesses. I'm only just getting started. Once Catra and Adora are dead, I'm going to be coming for all of you." His gaze rakes across the room. "There's nothing you can do to stop me. Your walls will not keep you safe. Your guards cannot keep me out. Your blades cannot kill me. I am the past come back to haunt you, and you will all *burn* for what you did to me." He leans his head back and cackles. Juliet raises her blade and thrusts through his chest. He freezes for a moment, then his form turns white, and crumbles into a pile of snow and water.

What?? Juliet steps back, horrified.

“It’s a simulacrum.” Glimmer says. “An illusion. He got away.” She turns to the rest of the group. “Catra and Adora are in trouble. We need to search the whole Fright Zone before...” Everyone nods gravely. Bow pulls out his tracker pad and begins inputting codes. Juliet sheathes her blade and stands beside Glimmer, ready to defend her against any other threats.

Adora

“C-... C-Catra..?”

“Hhhhhh… Yeah? Adora?”

“I… c-can’t feel my fingers.”

“H-heh. Talk to me w-when… when it’s your whole a-arm.”

“Everywhere else just… itches?”

“Pft. At least you. Didn’t get stuck in, in… in a f-fricking *yoga pose.*”

“*Growp.*”

“I know… b-buddy.”

Adora stares at the elevator door. It’s all she’s been able to do for the past… well, she has no idea how long it’s been. She managed to keep track for an hour but after that… who knows?

It’s beyond cold. She can’t feel her extremities, her entire body aches from shivering. The warmth of She Ra is barely holding on within her. But the worst part is that she can’t turn her head. *I’m going to die next to the love of my life… and I can’t even look at her. I can’t hold her and tell her it’ll be okay.*

No. This is not it. We’re going to get out of here.

No one is coming for you. They’ve left already, and by the time they get back it’ll be too late.

The breathing next to her is growing shallower.

“Stay with me Catra.” She says.

“I am! I just… I need… I’ll just… rest for a b-bit.”

Adora’s eyes widen, the frost on her eyelids cracking. “No! No!!” She strains every muscle in her body. “Catra! Stay with me. Don’t go to sleep.”

“Mmmm… It’s fine ‘Dora.”

“No! Catra! Don’t give up!” Her voice is cracking in desperation. Her eyes are in pain from the tears freezing against them. “Please… We’ll get out.”

Adora hears Melog give a plaintive mewl, and sees a faint glow. But nothing happens. Like her, the cold is too much for them. They can’t focus enough to use their magic.

“It’s okay.” Catra’s voice says. “Don’t worry Adora… I’ll be back before you know it…”

“CATRA!!” No response.

“CAT-Catra…” No response.

“Catra…” No response.

Adora’s breathing is slowing. Her eyes are dragging themselves closed.

‘Take care of each other.’ Her vision is going dark.

‘You’re welcome.’ She doesn’t feel the cold anymore.

‘You’ve never given up on anything in your life! Not even on me. So don’t you dare *start now!’* She forces her eyes open. She can feel She Ra trying to surface, trying to free her. But no. It’s too little, too late.

The memories are flashing around her.

'She was brave, my Mara.'

'Adora you will be more powerful than they ever planned!'

'Now, it ends.'

'Goodbye, my oldest enemy.'

Her eyes drift close. But then…

Light. Not warm and holy, like She Ra. Cold. White. Industrial.

Her eyes come open, and she hears Catra groan.

The elevator is open, and a figure is standing there. It's fuzzy, but she can make out a Horde engineer's uniform. Blue skin. Their hand on one hip as they chuckle.

"Mmhmhm. Well aren't you two in a sorry state."

The figure walks forward, and loses color, turning black and amorphous before crystallizing into a tall, lithe form in a tight black outfit. The shapeshifter tosses their hair as they look at the room control and raise the temperature dramatically. They turn, and strut up to Adora and Catra, standing in front of the two of them.

Double Trouble bends down and smirks. "Did you miss me?"

Glimmer

Glimmer hasn't stopped hugging them since they were retrieved. Double Trouble had come to get them, announcing that they had saved Adora and Catra, but they were still trapped. Glimmer had dispelled the glyphs, and both women had collapsed to the now puddle of a floor. They were rushed to an infirmary, and, once Adora was conscious, She Ra returned to her, and she healed both of them to the best of her ability. Now, Glimmer is sitting in

between their infirmary beds, holding both of their hands, which are slowly getting less cold.

"So." Bow says, his arms folded. "How did you know where they were?"

Double Trouble smiles. "Oh. That sorcerer tried to hire me to do that bit of dirty work for him. I turned him down of course. No amount of money is going to get me to turn on my friends."

"You mean no amount of money is enough to get you to make an enemy of She Ra?" Bow responds drily.

"Exactly!" Double Trouble pushes off the cot they were leaning on. "Once I realized Fygan was going to go ahead with his insane plan, I realized I had to stop him. I failed at that part, but I did manage to sabotage his exit strategy."

General Juliet quietly exclaims, "I knew it!"

Double Trouble looks at her with something of an annoyed pout before continuing. "Then it was just a matter of finding them, which took a good deal longer than I'd hoped." They snicker. "The Fright Zone is a real maze."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. *It seems pretty well laid out to me.*

"Annnn-yways. You're welcome. I accept my payment in cash." They hold out their hand and blink.

Glimmer scoffs and stands up. She approaches the mercenary, who is grinning expectantly. "Tell you what. Let's just say you did this out of the goodness of your heart."

They gasp, laying a hand on their breast. "How dare you! I mean you're basically right but still! *How dare you!?*" they straighten up. "Well, I'd better be going if you're not going to pay me. I'm pretty sure Kitten wants to kill me."

Glimmer looks over at Catra, who has been silently glaring daggers at Double Trouble ever since she woke up.

"Alright." She says, "You're free to go." She walks over to Catra's bed and takes a seat, putting a gentle hand on the feline's cheek. "It's over now."

Fygan

Fygan crashes to a halt outside the ragged shack. He slams the door open and stumbles in. He looks around. His little hiding place. An old farm house on the edge of the Whispering Woods. Abandoned, unassuming, perfect.

He walks over to his drafting table, covered with clutter. He leans over it for a second.

"GAHHH!" He screams in rage, and swings his hands across the table, sending beakers and plans and components flying. He rampages around the room, smashing everything he can find as tears stream down his face.

I failed. He crumples to his knees, and looks up at the wall. The pictures there stare back at him, disappointed.

"No." He says slowly, walking up and taking a picture. "This is just the beginning. I promise you."

Fygan sits down on his bed and begins to formulate a new plan. Nothing so flashy, just something simple, something innocuous. A way to kill her without being caught. The details of his plan begin to come together, and he walks over to his drafting table and begins to write it out.

He knows where to get everything he will need, and how to infiltrate Bright Moon. All that's missing is the right costume.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! I hope you enjoyed. Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

The Bright Zone, Part 1: Catra's Affliction

Chapter Summary

> In which being frozen for several hours seems to have had adverse effects on Catra's health, and she has some interesting dreams

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for the upload schedule getting messed up, life is crazy right now. That said, welcome to Episode Nine, which was once my least favorite chapter, being literally just filler, but has now been expanded into a major 5-part storyline that I'm actually happy with.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Catra walks through the endless, empty halls of Bright Moon. Every so often, she'll look into rooms and see little vignettes playing out, some she remembers, others she's never seen, but all familiar.

In the spare room-turned-prison, she sees Glimmer lowering a magical barrier, and handing a large sack of coins to a certain shapeshifter, who looks confused at first, then deviously delighted.

Off one of the balconies, she sees the terrible hedge maze and the overgrown greenhouse where she'd fought Shadow Weaver in her dream-vision at Mystacor.

She looks into another room and sees Force Captain Octavia, looking up at a young Catra and Adora, the latter of whom shouts down, "Hey Octavia! You're a dumb-face!" while the former falls in love just a little bit.

She looks into another room that contains the three crystalline columns of Arxia, and Adora within them, the failsafe being magically branded onto her chest. Every so often Catra swears she can see the failsafe on Adora, even now so many months later. Not as a physical scar on her chest, no. This scar marks Adora's soul. A symbol of the destiny she tried so hard and gave so much to fulfill.

Another doorway opens into a tent, where the Princesses sit around a low table playing with dolls, planning a strategy for an assault on a fortress. Adora looks stressed, and snaps at Mermista that, "You can't transform into She-Ra!"

Catra walks forward. The halls of Bright Moon glow, and she blinks against the glare. When her eyes open, she is greeted by a long corridor of white and grey and green. The familiar halls of the *Velvet Hand*, leading to a single room at the end. She slowly walks towards it, and can hear the echoing cry.

"ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE"
"ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE"
"ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE"

At the door, she can see the large pool of green liquid, the lightning ripping across its surface. The barest silhouette of a humanoid form in the water, curled up in a fetal position, held down by two clones as Prime watches all with a beatific smile. The alien emperor turns to look at Catra and smiles.

"There you are, little sister. Welcome home."

Adora

Catra's sick.

She has been for four days, ever since they survived being frozen. She's hiding it, just like she always had. Couldn't show weakness in the Horde. But Adora knows. Catra is warmer than ever, she's shedding like crazy, she's sleeping even more than usual and

jolting awake with nightmares. She's avoiding touching Adora, and, most tellingly, Melog has been acting very erratically, mimicking her sneezes when none occur, wandering around and breathing heavily, with their mane swirling brown and yellow.

Adora walks down the hall to Bow's workshop. She doesn't want to bring Glimmer into this, the queen has been working herself to the bone trying to deal with the uprising in the Crimson Waste, but Bow could help.

She pushes the door open. "Hey BowwwwwWOAH!" She puts her weight on her back foot and flails her arms for a second. "What is *that*?" she asks, mouth agape and pointing.

"Adora!" Bow says excitedly, emerging from a pile of cables. "This is the beginning of a portal!"

The item in the center of the room does resemble the machine that had caused such a mess a few years ago. A large, circular apparatus within an archway. This one is made mostly out of the stark white and green metal and crystals that Horde Prime's empire was forged of, but there are also clear elements of First Ones tech integrated. There are wires leading off of it everywhere, and Adora knows just enough about tech to recognize the four humming devices on the balcony to be small generators. A Horde Clone whose head is shaved bald is currently tapping away at a mounted screen that shows an image of the portal, along with various readouts.

"Entrapta and Hordak made a huge breakthrough in our teleportation project! Once both portals are finished, we should be able to establish a link between them!" Bow swings his hands enthusiastically. "Come on, let me show you!" He grabs Adora and scoots her up to the control center, where the clone is working.

"Balder, if I may." Bow says politely. The clone looks at the two of them and nods wordlessly, before stepping back. Bow walks up to the screen. "Balder's my assistant. He's quiet, but man is he good at tech. Anyways," He presses a few buttons, and the text on

screen switches to standard Etherian. “We’ve run a super long cable from the nearest Horde Spire in order to get enough power to run this thing. There’s a lot of calibration that needs to be done in order to establish a link between the two gateways.”

“Wait,” Adora says, “Couldn’t Prime teleport stuff anywhere? I mean, when Catra saved Glimmer, she could send her into the middle of space.”

Bow nods. “Hordak’s theory is that the teleporters as they used to function were connected to Prime’s servers. Once Prime got…” Bow looks at Balder, then makes a silent finger across the throat gesture, “The teleportation network went with him. Maybe one day we’ll figure out how to get it working like that, but in the meantime, portal gateways between kingdoms is a pretty good start.” Bow puts in a few more codes, and Adora hears the machine thrum to life.

Balder walks over to a holographic control display, and inputs a few codes. The platform in the middle of the gateway glows green, and Balder picks up a large piece of scrap metal, too warped to be any use. The clone places the metal on the central platform, then slides a panel on the display board up. The portal flashes green, and the metal is gone.

“Woooooah!” Adora says, her eyes wide and sparkling. “Ha! That’s awesome! But, uhhhh where’d it go?”

Bow laughs nervously, “Weeee’re not sure about that, actually. Balder says it’s probably ending up in one of Prime’s other spires, somewhere in the universe.”

Adora giggles at the mental image of loyalist Horde clones getting increasingly dismayed as items from a far off world keep appearing in their teleporter room at random.

Balder deactivates the machine, and Bow turns to Adora. “So. What’s up?”

Adroa sighs. *Oh, right. The reason I'm here*. "Catra's sick, and she's hiding it from me. I think something happened when she was…" She trails off, and Bow nods, understanding without her needing to finish the thought.

No one really talked about what had happened at the Fright Zone. What Fygan had done there left everyone pretty shaken. Not just what had almost happened to Adora and Catra, but the fact that he'd killed over a dozen people in such a horrible way. Adora shivers subconsciously.

"Yeah. She's sick, and she's hiding it because she doesn't want to show weakness and I need some help." Adora speaks quickly, yanking her mind away from the unpleasant memory.

"Ohhhh, I see." Bow puts a hand to his chin and scratches his growing stubble thoughtfully. "She'll just get upset if we try to force her into getting some medical care." His eyes widen, and he exclaims, "We need to trick her!"

"Uh-say wha?" Adora's head lurches forward in confusion.

"Yeah!" Bow says, "We say we're there to hang out, but then, we lock the doors and start the process of nurturing her back to health!"

"That's..." Adora ponders for a moment, "A terrible idea. Catra's gonna hate it!"

"Okayyyy," Bow raises a finger, "Buuuut, can you think of a plan that Catra *wouldn't* hate?"

Adora inhales, then deflates. "No… Alright. Let's do it."

*****

When they reach Adora and Catra's room, the door is locked. Adora jiggles the handle, then knocks.

"B-gah!" Catra's voice squeaks out from within, "Uh, one second!" Adora looks at Bow and shrugs as they hear muffled grunts and curses, combined with occasional alien mewls. "Ugh! Get off!" *Who or what is she talking to*? "How did that even happen??" There's some hissing, and some growls, then quiet.

"Catra?" Adora calls tentatively, "I'm gonna come in now."

"Whatever." Her girlfriend says in a scratchy voice from within the room, "I've resigned myself to my fate."

Adora pulls out her key and unlocks the door, and she and Bow step in. The bed and the surrounding area are in disarray, pillows and blankets strewn everywhere, curtains ripped, and Catra plopped on the floor upside down, her limbs a tangled mess within the surprisingly intact sweater made by Castaspella for her. Catra looks up at them through half lidded eyes.

"Hey." She says, then sniffles noisily. "What's up?"

Adora giggles and walks forward. "You've been down lately, so I brought Bow over to help cheer you up." *Nailed it. Not totally lying makes it way easier.*

With much effort, they remove Adora's girlfriend from the indestructible sweater. Catra crawls into the bed and wraps herself in the blanket to replace it. She looks suspiciously at her two friends, who are now standing at the foot of the bed. Her eyes look somewhat puffy, and she's sniffling quite a bit. From their little cove in one corner of the room, Melog lets out a Catra sneeze.

"Awe!" Bow squees at the noise.

"Could you no-" Catra cuts herself off with a pair of tiny sneezes of her own. Seeing how the two are looking at her, she sighs in resignation, then speaks, her voice hoarse and stuffy, "Alright. I guess I should have seen this coming." She looks away, blushing in embarrassment a bit. "Yes. I'm sick. Go ahead and do…

whatever you princesses do with your *infirm*." She puts a mocking spin on the last word, then groans with discomfort.

"Well," Bow says cautiously. "We usually start with a bath, but I know that's not…"

"Do it." Catra says firmly.

What??? Adora gasps. Catra has never in her life volunteered to be in water. *She must be really sick. Or…* There's an unmistakable glint of mischief in the feline's eyes. *Oh no.*

Catra

Catra sits in the nearly empty bathtub with the smuggest of smiles on her face. Bow and Adora are covered in water and bubbles, with horrified and resigned expressions on their faces. Catra feigns innocence and licks her hand nonchalantly, only to instantly spit and hiss at the taste of the bubbles. The hiss quickly turns into a coughing fit, and her smug satisfaction turns to sick misery.

"Are you willing to cooperate now?" Adora says, her arms folded.

"No!" Catra shouts. "Never!" She leaps out of the tub and dives back into the bed, not bothering to grab a towel on the way.

"Catra!" Adora whines as Bow walks over to a small closet and retrieves a mop. "Come onnnnn. I want you to get better."

"Yeah, and I'm fi-" Catra sneezes adorably, which results in a fit of very not adorable hacking coughs. "Fine." She growls. From their hut, Melog sneezes.

"You aren't." Adora pleads, and Catra looks away from that oh-so-caring face. "You can barely make it through a sentence at this point. Please let us help you."

"Adora," Bow says, Catra hears his footsteps walking up to her girlfriend, "Why don't you go ask the healers where some Dwelerberry Syrup is."

“No, I don’t want to-” Catra hears a pause, then Adora’s voice comes back knowingly. “Aaaooooohhhh I see.”

See what?? Oh no. Catra spins around, and Adora shoots her a wink before hastening to the door.

“Hey! Don’t you dare-” Catra calls, but Adora is out the door. Catra sighs, and a light cough results. She wipes her runny nose on the sheets. She turns to look at Bow. “Alright Arrow Boy, just you and me now,” She challenges.

But Bow, perfect, angelic Bow, does not rise to her bait like Adora. Bow simply drags a chair over from the vanity and sits down, facing her.

“Wha- what is this?” Catra asks, suspiciously.

“It’s a conversation.” Bow responds gently. “I’m gonna ask questions, and you’re going to answer them.”

“Sounds like an interrogation to me.” Catra mutters.

“No,” Bow responds, “It’s a conversation because we’re friends.”

Catra softens a little at that. *We are friends.*

“You are sick Catra. Everyone knows at this point. So why are you trying to hide it from us?”

“Because!” Catra raises her voice, which prompts more coughs. This fit sends her slumping back onto the bed. Melog rushes out of their hut and leaps onto the bed, curing around her as she shivers. *Why is it so cold*? “Because I don’t need anyone’s help.” She finishes. “I can do fine on my own. I always have. It’ll run its course, and I’ll be okay again. I’m okay now!”

Bow chuckles. “Okay, first of all, you being ‘okay on your own’ meant trying to conquer Etheria. You threw me off a cliff! So that argument is right out. And just because you may not *need* someone’s help doesn’t mean you try to prevent them from giving

it. When people help you, it's because they want to. You're not a burden to anyone here Catra." (*Wow, just… expose me, I guess*.) "Yeah, it'll probably be fine. You're sick, but I don't think it's too bad right now. But you could be doing a lot better if you'd just let people help you."

Catra sighs. "Fine… I'll let you guys help. I guess… In the Horde we were trained to not show weakness. I suppose I'm just… slow to adjust. I'm sorry."

"Hey," Bow reaches out and puts a hand on her shoulder, "It's all okay. There is nothing for you to apologize for. You've made some really big changes and gone through a lot. It would be insane to not expect some difficulties adjusting."

Catra slowly raises a hand and squeezes his. "Alright." She says, "I'm gonna sleep now because everything hurts."

Bow nods. "We'll be here if you need us."

Catra smiles at that before drifting off to sleep.

*****

After an interruption by Adora making her take some Dwelerberry Syrup, which tastes foul enough initially that she almost pukes, but then fades to a rather pleasantly tart aftertaste, Catra drifts into a fitful sleep. Dreams plague her. Some of them are utter nonsense, but some of them are more disconcerting.

She comes to in the middle of a battle. Screams and crashes surround her. An explosion goes off, jarring her. She leaps into action, scanning the surroundings. She's in a walled town, Erelandia, she thinks. But there's no fighting. The sounds are not those of battle, they're those of a party. She can see confetti in the air. She herself is alone in a quiet alleyway.

"Catra?" A voice calls.

“Adora?” Catra responds. She sees the light first, and knows her girlfriend is in She Ra form. ‘*People pleaser*’. She thinks fondly. She looks over to the entrance, but her heart skips a beat when she sees who rounds the corner. It’s She Ra, alright, but not *her* She Ra. It’s the one she fought so many times, with the shorts and the flowing hair and cape and that stupid tiara.

“You alright?” She Ra asks with concern, “You’ve been gone a while.”

“Yeah, just needed a minute, you know?” Catra responds instinctually.

“I get it,” She Ra says with an understanding smile, “Can you come back now? Glimmer’s just about to give her speech.”

“Nice.” Catra says. She walks up beside She Ra. She wants to reach out and take her hand, but something stops her. *That’s not right. Not here, not now*.

She wanders out into the crowd. She’s suddenly conscious of her appearance. She feels younger. Her hair is back to its old mane, and she has her mask. Looking down, her outfit is different though, a red crop top with some gold embroidery on it, and dark burgundy leggings. She walks through the throngs of people, many of whom congratulate her or swoon. She chuckles. *Typical hero stuff*. She walks up to the stags and hops up to sit on the edge, leaning back to look at the podium, where Glimmer walks forward, She Ra at her side.

“Thank you, Erelandia!” Glimmer begins. Catra notes she’s in her queenly outfit. *Even though her mom shouldn’t be gone. How do I know that?* “Thanks to your help today, we’re one step closer to wiping out the Horde once and for all! With Shadow Weaver captured and their forces broken, there’s nothing left to stop us from launching a full scale assault on The Fright Zone!” The crowd cheers and Catra chuckles. *No way they could have gotten this far against the Horde if I was in charge*. Catra’s gaze drifts over to where She Ra is looking at Glimmer, pride and adoration in her

eyes, along with… something else. Her eyes narrow. *That's not right.*

"So, Erelandia, I come to ask you for one more favor!" Glimmer says, "We need soldiers for the push to the Fright Zone! If any of you would like to volunteer to save Etheria! Now is the time!"

Since when do the Princesses recruit militia? No wonder they're winning.

The crowd cheers, and around two dozen people step forward, offering various weapons to Queen Glimmer's service.

"Thank you Erelandia!" Glimmer says, "The Rebellion thanks you!" She turns and says something to She Ra, who beams in response. Catra's smile falters, then falls at what happens next. Glimmer wraps her arms around She Ra's neck, leans up towards her lips, and She Ra leans down to meet her…

Catra looks away, feeling sick to her stomach as the crowd cheers. She hops off the stage and walks away, breaking into a sprint once she's free of the crowd. Tears are falling down her face as she sprints into the Whispering Woods.

How could this have happened??

I went with her. I went with Adora at Thaymoor, and I never stopped playing second fiddle. I never got what I wanted.

Catra collapses to her knees and weeps.

The dream ends.

*****

The next dream sees Catra walk through the overgrown and abandoned halls of Bright Moon. Her soft footsteps echo gently as she walks forward, her eyes on the ground. She arrives at the throne hall and looks around. The murals, cracked and faded as they are, are beautiful. The swooping arches and curving metal

wings are gorgeous. Catra walks towards the throne, which has fallen onto the floor from where it once floated. She reaches out a hand and runs her fingers across the cold surface. Turning around, she can see right out to the Whispering Woods. From the doorway, her gaze is drawn to the wreckage of the Moonstone tower, and the shattered gem itself visible just beneath the surface of the lagoon. Looking into the Whispering Woods, she can see one of Prime's spires looming there. She leans against the edge of the doorway, staring out over the silent vista.

"Beautiful, isn't it?" Asks the smooth, resonant voice of Horde Prime from behind her.

Catra looks up at the tall figure, who is standing alone behind her, his hands crossed behind his back. "I've seen better." She turns away.

"Ah but surely even you can appreciate this. The silence, the peace, the hard-won order. All of it thanks to you."

Catra stands up and crosses to the other side of the doorway, then walks into the room, her arms folded across each other. "I never wanted this."

"Oh but you did, didn't you?" She looks up to see the throne has somehow regained its spot floating off the edge of the floor, and Prime's imposing form is filling it, legs crossed and gazing down at her. "You've always dreamed of a world to yourself. Ever your darkest, secret heart has longed to be truly alone, to have utter dominion over all that you see."

"Not much to have dominion over here."

"No? Is desolation not a complete enough rule for you?" Prime waves a hand, and a group of clones appear around her. Her hackles raise, but the clones immediately fall to their knees and bow before her. "You wish for subjects? Is it simply that you want to rule over people, not land?"

Catra simply sneers. “I don’t want to rule over anything anymore.” She turns and walks out the door of the throne room.

“You may deceive yourself, little sister, but Prime sees all. Prime *knows all*.” The voice echoes in her mind as the dream ends, the features of Bright Moon melting and warping around her, turning into the halls of Prime’s ship before vanishing into white.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading! Next chapter delves into the changes to this arc, so I hope you enjoy! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

The Bright Zone, Part 2: She Ra, P.I.

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra's condition worsens, and Adora suspects foul play. Meanwhile, Glimmer works herself to the bone over a potential new threat rising in the Crimson Waste.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

"Catra!" Adora calls as she maneuvers the door to their room open with her foot and elbow, "I brought something that I think you'll really liiiike." She says the last word with a slight sing-songy intonation. She looks over at the bed, expecting to see a bundled up Catra rousing herself for her.

But the bed is empty. The covers are half off and the blanket seems to have been pulled across the floor.

Adora sets the tray down on the floor and descends the two steps into the room.

Okay. Stay calm. She's probably just in the bathroom.

Adora's gaze turns to the bathroom, but there's no bathroom to look at. She does a double take, scanning the entire wall, and the others for good measure, but sees no doorway. Which of course makes no sense, as there should be a doorway into a bathroom there.

'Wait a minute…' Adora looks towards Melog's corner, and sees it is in a similar state of disarray and emptiness to the bed.

They must be concealing the door to the bathroom for some reason. But why would they do that?

Unless something's really wrong… Catra's in trouble!

Adora rushes towards the span of wall where she knows the bathroom door to be, and pushes. After one false start (*Oops*) she feels the wooden door beneath her hands. She fumbles about until she finds the handle, her heartbeat growing faster and faster with each passing second.

She finally finds it, only for it not to turn.

"Gah!" She steps back and kicks the door down, stepping through Melog's illusion into the bathroom.

"Catra!" She says urgently, "are you ok-" she cuts herself off with a little strangled noise as she sees the state of things.

Catra is curled up on the bathroom floor in front of the toilet, clearly having passed out. Melog is curled around her protectively, and immediately turns red and spiky to hiss at Adora.

"Catra!" Adora kneels down and pulls Catra into her arms, instinctively (and rather rudely) shoving Melog out of the way.

The alien stumbles backwards before shaking their head. Their mane shifts from red to a swirling greenish-yellow, and they sit down hard, clearly feeling some measure of the sickness their bond-mate suffers from.

"Catra, come on." Adora gently shakes the limp, but mercifully still breathing, feline form in her arms.

"Gnnnnn…" Catra stirs awake, grimacing. Before opening her eyes, she smacks her lips a few times, then sticks out her tongue and grimaces. "Blaehhh…" She whines in displeasure, then weakly opens her eyes to look up at Adora. "Mmmhey Adora…" she croaks, "don't marry Glimmer…"

Adora just smiles confusedly, and lifts Catra into her arms to carry her back to the bed.

Catra's whole body is burning and damp with sweat. Her eyes are bloodshot and her breath carries a dangerous sounding rattle.

"It's okay," Adora assured her as she replaces the blanket over her body. "I brought you chicken soup."

"Behhhh…" Catra groans, turning over and pulling the covers tightly.

'She's gotten worse,' Adora thinks. She looks over to the now visible bathroom door, which Melog walks out of rather limply. *'Much worse.'*

Glimmer

"Our forces are stretched thin enough as is." Chancellor Brannic says, his voice finally beginning to show emotion. "If we commit to a campaign in the Crimson Waste, it means relocating guards, leaving our homes vulnerable."

"Vulnerable to what?" Glimmer retorts, "This is the Horde we're talking about here. This could be the decisive blow to prevent any future conflicts. We could win for real this time!"

"And lose how many?" Brannic asks, "The Crimson Waste is a dead zone. People don't just walk into the Waste. There are monsters and warlords and bandits. Huntara can only do so much to keep our people safe. You are sending them to their deaths!"

"Brannic!" Micah rises from his chair, and Brannic goes quiet. "I don't intend to overrule your voice, but you will show respect to Queen Glimmer."

Brannic closes his eyes and exhales through his nostrils. "Very well. I apologize, Your Majesty. We simply do not have the numbers to mount a full scale assault like you're suggesting. And even if we did, it would be unprovoked."

“Unprovoked?” Glimmer says through gritted teeth. She stands from her chair. “The Horde has been provoking us for thirty years. They’ve destroyed countless towns and villages, taken so many people from us. My mother believed in keeping people safe above striking back, but I am not my mother. I will not risk everything we have worked so hard to rebuild if there’s something I can do about it!”

“But this cell hasn’t attacked!” Brannic replies. “As far as we know, they just want a home!”

“Do you really think that’s it? These remnants are just as dangerous as the real Hordes were.” Glimmer says, “I almost died fighting them at Dryl.”

“An isolated incident, whose source was discovered and captured.”

“Glimmer.” Micah puts a hand on her shoulder. She looks down at him. “I hate to say it but… he’s right. We have to act as though everyone deserves a chance at a better life. I suggest we move to establish diplomatic ties with this bastion.”

Glimmer sighs and slumps back into her chair. “I don’t like it, but… fine. We have to be better. But I don’t trust it. If someone comes to rally them, they could pose a real threat!” She turns to General Juliet, “We need to set up outposts at the edge of the Waste and the Valley of the Lost to be ready for the worst.” Juliet nods.

Brannic raises an eyebrow. “And where are the forces for these outposts coming from?”

“We’ll empty the outposts at the edges of the Whispering Woods. We don’t need to watch The Fright Zone anymore, so we don’t need them.”

Brannic barks out a guffaw. “Ah yes. You advocate caution against the Horde but propose leaving the Woods undefended from The Fright Zone.”

“Princess Scorpia controls the Fright Zone now Brannic.” Micah says, “We are allies with the Scorpion Kingdom.”

“Yes,” Brannic says, “Princess Scorpia, the *ex-Horde captain*. And I’m sure Bright Moon’s historians would *love* to tell you how alliances with the Scorpion Kingdom have ended in the past.”

“Silence.” Glimmer says coldly. “It’s decided. Two outposts will be emptied, and two new ones will be established. This meeting is over.”

Brannic stands and bows, then walks out, muttering discontentedly to a colleague.

Micah puts a reassuring hand on her shoulder as Glimmer slumps onto the table.

“I hate politiiiiiiiiiics” She whines.

“Hey Glimmer,” Adora’s voice comes from the doorway, and Glimmer perks up.

“Adora!” She says, and teleports over to her friend for a hug. Despite the fact that they live in the same building, Glimmer has barely seen Adora in days. “What’s up? Have you come to free me?”

“Free you? Ah-no…” Adora rubs the back of her neck awkwardly, “Actually, I… need your help.”

“Help with what?”

Adora sighs, “Catra’s gotten worse. Like, a lot worse.”

Glimmer nods, but a tiny part of her gets annoyed. *‘So you came to bother me about this?’* She immediately bats away that thought.

“I think she’s being poisoned.” Adora finishes.

“Poisoned??” Glimmer exclaims, “By who?”

Adora’s face darkens before she says, “Fygan.”

Glimmer swallows hard. Across the room, Micah and General Juliet cut off their whispered conversation and look over.

“What’s this about Fygan?” Micah asks.

“I believe he’s infiltrated the castle sir.” Adora says, turning to address Micah.

Once again, a spark of annoyance pricks at the back of Glimmer’s mind. *‘Why does everyone give him more respect than me? Even Adora!’*

“So what do you want me to do?” Glimmer asks evenly.

Adora turns to look at her, clearly slightly bemused by the question. “What do I want you to do?” She repeats, “Maybe start an investigation? Or, or scan the castle? Put up wards? One of the most dangerous people we’ve ever met could be in the castle right-”

“*Could be.*” Glimmer says, “Adora. I’m sorry but you have a hunch that someone dangerous might be in the castle based only on the fact that Catra’s gotten sicker.”

Adora looks offended and counters with, “Okay but you know I’ve been right about this sort of thing in the past. Isn’t it worth looking into?”

“With what people??” Glimmer says, her voice getting louder as she grows more agitated, “And what time? Adora, I have another meeting in less than ten minutes. It’s not as easy to run the full castle through an investigation than you seem to think, and even if we had real evidence that indicated Fygan was here, a full-scale sweep of the castle would only alert him! Just take a moment to calm down and think about it.”

Adora takes a step back, her face darkening. “You don’t believe me.”

“Adora-”

“No, it’s fine.” Adora’s brow sets and she clenches her jaw, “I get it. If you can’t help me, then I’ll just find him myself.”

Glimmer raises a hand as Adora strides out of the room. “Adora, wait! I don’t-” She teleports into her chair and flops backwards. “UGGGHHHH!! She is *infuriating* when she’s like this!”

Catra

Fever dreams may be bad, but what’s worse is the fact that everything is so… bright in Bright Moon. The walls and floors and ceilings are all white and gold and immaculately polished. Every time she opens her eyes it’s like the sun has come down into her room to give her its well wishes personally. The shine of Bright Moon is easily her least favorite part of the place. The flowing, curved architecture combined with the light reminds her far too much of the *Velvet Glove*, and actually makes her miss the sparse, industrial lighting and dull colors of the Fright Zone.

She extricates herself from the bed, wincing from the aches in her bones, and walks over to the washroom. She knows she’s getting worse. Dizziness and aches have supplanted coughing and nausea as her primary concerns, and she sways a bit as she walks. She enters the small room, closing the door and taking in the comparative darkness. She turns the knob on the recently installed sink (Horde plumbing had spread to the rest of the kingdoms in short order), and gathers the cold water in her hands before splashing it on her face to cool down a bit. She closes her eyes and breathes in deeply, bracing herself for the upcoming journey before turning and walking back to the bed. As she exits, she notices the room is darker, and sees a large, plain grey wall has been erected in front of the open windows and balcony. She casts a tired glance over at Melog, who is glowing faintly from

putting up the illusion, but sends a telepathic, "*You're welcome.*" her way. Catra sighs thickly, and climbs back in bed.

*****

The first dream is rather similar to the events she had just walked through. Catra blinks her eyes and looks around. Bright Moon is different. The walls are broken up by pipes sticking out, and clearly Horde infrastructure built in. She stretches out and stands up, looking over at the massive Horde tapestry that serves as a curtain for her room.

She walks over to the bathroom, and cups water in her hands to splash on her face, just to wake her up. She sighs, grabs a towel, wipes her face, and looks in the mirror.

"Bah!" She yelps as she looks at the reflection of Adora. But not her Adora. This one has the sides of her head shaved, her hair dyed dark, and a series of scars across her cheekbone.

Adora -no, wait- Catra staggers back, turning out of the washroom, her head spinning. She screws her eyes closed, and the dream ends.

Adora

Adora creaks open the door to their room gently.

"Catra?" She says quietly.

"Mmm?" comes the response from the mound of blankets and pillows on their bed.

Adora walks up. She notices that Melog has created a large illusory wall in front of the open balcony to provide shade to the room. "Hey Catra," she begins softly as she sits down on the bottom corner.

The pile of fabric shifts and a tiny face pokes out of a hole. Catra's nose is red and her eyes are puffy. "Bleh." She says,

acknowledging Adora's presence before sticking two hands out and beckoning, as if demanding cuddles.

"No cuddles Catra, I'm sorry." Adora says. Catra narrows her eyes and hisses pathetically in anger. "Catra, I'm gonna be…" Adora trails off, wondering if she should tell Catra her full suspicions, "Busy," She decides, "So I won't be able to play nurse for you."

"You've betrayed me." Catra croaks out.

"Buuut!" Adora says cheerily, getting off the bed and backing up towards the door, "I'm putting my best man in charge of your care and security."

Catra emerges a little further, showing an expression of equal-parts curiosity and suspicion. "Your best man?" She says, her voice thick and ragged. "And who might that-"

"DID SOMEONE SAY: SWIFT WIND!?"

Catra's face drops as the alicorn makes his grand entrance, diving through the illusory wall to showboat across the room.

"Adora, don't you worry," Swift Wind says, "I will guard and care for Catra with my very life!"

"Just let me die." Catra says with an expression of utter despair.

"Absolutely not!" Adora chirps, "Love you baiiiiii!"

She closes the door just as Swift Wind begins issuing orders to her sick girlfriend.

'*Okay,*' she thinks, '*Time to get to work.*'

*****

Adora set off with a singular goal: find out who is poisoning Catra, and how.

Of course, she has now run into a problem. Namely, that she has no idea where to start. Fortunately, though, help does not take too long to arrive in the form of General Juliet.

"General?" Adora asks, stopping the pacing she's been doing for the past thirteen minutes.

"Adora, I understand you're going to be investigating your hunch about Catra being poisoned, correct?"

"Heh, well technically I'm investigating right now." Adora says meekly.

Juliet raises an eyebrow and looks around the empty sitting room. "I… see," She says diplomatically. "Well, I thought you could use some help, and it seems I thought correctly."

"Really?" Adora mutters, "I thought Glimmer didn't believe me."

"Her Majesty is very busy, however the topic of the meetings for the remainder of the week is no longer military, so I am no longer required there." Juliet walks over to the couch and sits down, retaining her prim, military bearing as usual. Adora always finds that being around Juliet makes her revert to that stiff, officious body language too. "So," the general says, "What have we got?"

"Well," Adora says slowly, "Nothing so far. I was going to go investigate some of the storerooms to see if anything is amiss. Maybe while I do that you could find some people worth questioning?"

Juliet considers that before saying, "I say you do the questioning while I investigate the storerooms." She raises a hand and stands up to cut off Adora's counterargument, "All due respect, Adora, but I'm not helping you because I'm invested in Catra's wellbeing. I'm helping you because if Fygan is here, I want to bring him down."

Of course she doesn't care about Catra. Heck, out of everyone in the castle she might hate her the most.

“Well,” Adora says calmly, “If that’s the case, then I’d like to start the questioning with you.”

Juliet is initially taken aback by that, but then she smiles. “Smart.” She comments before sitting down for the interrogation.

“Do you have a reason to want Catra dead?” Adora starts.

“Don’t start with that question.” Juliet responds, “If anyone here answers no, they’re lying.”

Adora winces at the harsh truth in that statement. “Oh-kay, fair point,” She concedes. “Uhhhh…”

“If you’re going to question anybody about anything, you need to first think about how this alleged poisoning has happened. Was it through her food? Her water? Her medicine? Or was it delivered through an injury while she slept?”

“Not the latter,” Adora says. “Between me, Melog, and Swift Wind guarding it, no one could have gotten into our room.”

“And the full force of Bright Moon’s guards.” Juliet adds.

“Sure, them too.” Adora says absently. “Hold on.”

Adora sits down in a meditative pose and concentrates, projecting her thoughts through her mystical sacred bond with Swift Wind.

”Hey Swifty, I’m gonna need you to taste test everything Catra eats or drinks, okay?”

The horse’s voice is quick to respond in the affirmative. “*Of course Adora! Ehhrrmm… does that include the medicine?”*

“Sorry but, yes. And if you haven’t tasted any of them before, find a fresh sample to check them against. Do you understand?”

“Of course! I will not let you down!”

Adora sighs and stands up again. “Okay,” She says, “I’m going to start interviewing the guards. General, I think the medicine storeroom is a good place for you to investigate first.

Catra

Catra isn’t sure which is the real nightmare: her nightmares, or listening to Swift Wind.

No, the real nightmare is what she’s currently dreaming: a vividly colored fever dream that is playing out like a stage production of her life, but it’s a one horse show where everyone she knows is played by Swift Wind.

“No Shadow Weaver! I’m tired of you!” Swift Wind, playing Catra, shouts. He then scampers to the other side of the stage and swaps Catra’s mask out for Shadow Weaver’s.

“If you’re not with me, then you will dieeeeee!” He drawls in an admittedly spot-on impression of Catra’s deceased pseudo-mother/arch enemy. He then waves his wings around and red lightning zaps out of his feathers, only to turn into pitch black snakes that fly over to the other side of the stage, where he has somehow teleported to and now wears Catra’s mask again.

The snakes wrap around Swift Wind, and he cries out, “These snakes can’t hold me back any more than your bad parenting could, Shadow Weaver!”

He raises a hoof and stomps on Shadow Weaver’s mask, snapping it in two. The snakes vanish, and he hurries to the other side of the stage, where he falls onto his horse knees and holds the snapped mask in his wings.

“NooOOO!!” He cries in despair, “You’ve taken my power! I can feel my magic leeeaving meeeee! Magic! Power, power, power… magicpowerpowermagiiiiiccccccc…” He trails off as he sinks into the ground and promptly dies.

From her place as the sole member of the audience, Catra finds herself compelled to give a standing ovation.

Yeah, this is definitely the most terrifying thing that's ever happened to her.

Bow

Bow is finishing up a translation from a First One's artifact when he hears the twinkle of Glimmer teleporting into his workshop. He spins around with a smile to greet his girlfriend, but she cuts him off by immediately flopping face first into his chest, nearly sending him tumbling backwards out of his chair.

"Hnnnnnnnnnggggg" Glimmer complains.

"That bad, huh?" Bow asks, adjusting to be more comfortable and running a hand through Glimmer's hair.

"There's a faction of old Horde members who've taken over that old Fire Princess castle on the edge of the Crimson Waste. They haven't made any moves yet but I don't trust them."

"Glimmer, you've told me about them already." Bow reminds her gently.

She looks up at his face searchingly, "I have? Unnnnghhhh!" She buries her face back into his chest. "I have. I'm just so tired. I've been working on this for days. I've been studying maps and contacting allies and attending non-stop meetings. And every time I think I have a solution, someone comes in and tells me I'm wrong."

Bow tenses ever so slightly, "Well sometimes you need that. Come on babe, you know that." *Babe? That's new. I mean, we are together now, and it feels natural enough.*

Glimmer sighs, not seeming to notice the new term of endearment, "I know, I know…" She's silent for a moment, clearly

lost in thought, then pushes up to her feet. Now pacing, she continues, "I appreciate it when people tell me I'm wrong. I've… grown in that regard. But some days I feel like 'you're wrong' is literally all people tell me."

"I guess that's what it's like to be queen." Bow offers neutrally, "You told your mom that all the time."

Glimmer smiles fondly, "I did, didn't I? Hhhhhha. I think it would be easier if so much of it didn't come from Brannic."

Bow scoffs, "Ugh. Even *I* don't like Brannic. He mistook me for a waiter the first time I met him. While I was posing for a sketch, *with She-Ra*."

Glimmer chuckles, "He's not the most… observant, or the most well-mannered, but…" She gulps as she forces herself to say, "I value his experience."

Both of them laugh, and Bow smiles. "You've gotten so wise."

"Are you calling me old?" Glimmer asks, her eyes narrowing comedically. Bow just laughs.

"So," Glimmer says, "Has Adora got you in on her little project?"

"No?" Bow responds confusedly, "Maybe? What project?"

Glimmer sighs. "Catra's illness has gotten worse, and Adora is convinced she's been poisoned. So she's recruited General Juliet to scour the castle in search of Fygan."

"You sound like you think she's wrong."

"I do," Glimmer admits, "But I'm too busy to do anything about it even if I did fully believe her."

Bow hesitates to ask his next question, as he knows how much Glimmer hates it when the other side of an issue is brought up, but he forges ahead anyways. "What if she is right though?"

Glimmer groans and teleports over to the couch and sweeps a pile of schematics off of it to flop down dramatically. “If she’s right, then I have faith she’ll figure it out herself. But I don’t believe Fygan has infiltrated the castle. We’ve been on high alert all week since we learned about him, but we’ve heard absolutely nothing. He’s probably gone into hiding, and we won’t have to worry about him again.”

“I dunno…” Bow says ambivalently, “You and I both heard his rant. Those didn’t sound like the words of a guy who’s gonna give up after one defeat.”

“Mmm!” Glimmer grunts in frustration, “It doesn’t matter. Get over here and cuddle me befor-”

The door slams open and a guard stands there, breathing heavily. “Your Majesty! The meeting with the emissary from New Thaymoor has already begun!”

Glimmer pops over to the guard and shoots a look at Bow.

“I’ll help out with the Adora situation,” Bow assures her, “You just focus on getting through these meetings okay? Then we can have a nice break tonight. I love you.”

“Mm. Love you too.” Glimmer pouts before grabbing the guard and teleporting to the meeting room.

Bow smiles fondly before turning to get back to work. *Glimmer really needs to figure out a better balance. Or get someone to share the load.*

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, comments and kudos are always appreciated!

The Bright Zone, Part 3: Part Time Princess

Chapter Summary

> In which Adora and General Juliet's investigation into Catra's illness intensifies, and Glimmer has to sit through some worldbuilding

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

"Any luck?" Adora asks for the third time today as General Juliet walks into the room. What had once been a sitting room now looks like the lair of an insane person. Furniture has been shoved into corners, bulletin boards coat the walls, covered in notes taken of each interrogation, inventory of each storeroom, shipping lanes of the various medicines and foods Catra has eaten, pictures of medicines and ingredients, and many different colored strings connecting them all.

"The opposite of luck." Juliet says, her voice reflects the exhaustion that Adora feels. "The warehouse manager kept the inventory sheet in his pocket, and it got eaten by his dog."

Adora groans and bangs her head against the interrogation table. She'd questioned the kitchen staff, the guards, and most of the servants and discovered that the only thing out of the ordinary was that there were weird green lights coming out of Bow and Balder's workshop *('Because of course there are! They're working on a teleporter!'*), and that one of the Horde Clones had been chased out of the kitchen, apparently because he'd been eating handfuls of salt straight from the box.

"I can't help but feel like we're missing something huge…" Juliet muses as she paces the wall, looking at the myriad of notes

pinned there. “What’s this?” she asks, pulling off a paper that Adora has circled in red.

Adora gets up and walks over to check. “Xandiri.” She says, “It’s a medicine Catra took this morning. As far as I can tell it’s the only thing she’s ingested that’s different from the last few days.”

Juliet scans the information with interest. “It says here that it came from the Castle’s emergency medical supplies.” She says with dawning realization in her voice.

Adora shrugs her shoulders, not catching on to the revelation happening in her acquaintance’s mind. “Yeah, Glimmer got it for us.”

“She’d have to!” Juliet exclaims, “Only four people in Bright Moon have the key to those supplies!”

Adora’s eyes widen, “So it has to have been one of them!” Juliet nods. “So who has access?” Adora asks excitedly.

“Queen Glimmer and King Micah,” Juliet says, “Myself, and…” She trails off before saying in a lower, darker tone, “And Chancellor Brannic.”

Juliet

“Let me get this straight,” Brannic drawls over steepled fingers. The rotund man is now leaning over his desk, glaring at Juliet and Adora through eyes that seem intensely alert despite being half-lidded at almost all times. “You are wasting my precious little free time to accuse me of poisoning your little Hordeling girlfriend?”

“I didn’t say that.” Adora growls through gritted teeth, “And do not *ever* call her that again.”

Brannic chortles and leans back in his luxuriously upholstered armchair. “My apologies. I had assumed you two were a pair. Very well, I shall no longer call the Hordeling your girlfriend.”

“That’s not what I meant and you know it, you greasy, pompous, self-absorbed-!”

“Adora.” Juliet says, giving Adora a sharp glance. *‘He’s just trying to get a rise out of you,’* She tries to say with her eyes.

Juliet casts a glance to the corners of the room behind them on the wall with the doorway, where two guards stand sentinel. Not her soldiers, Brannic has always demanded his own private security force. It’s one of the biggest reasons Juliet does not trust him.

“I wouldn’t have suspected this kind of time wastage from you, General,” Brannic remarks, “Though from what I’ve heard, this is entirely in character for, uhh…” He points to Adora, “How am I supposed to address you exactly? Lady Adora? Miss Adora? How does one give proper respect to a, ah, part-time Princess?”

“Just Adora is fine.” Adora seethes.

“Lovely,” Brannic says, “Regardless. I have nothing to do with any ailments that Catra may be suffering.” Even when he says her actual name, he emphasizes the word “Catra” as if it were an insult.

“This poison was administered via a medicine that was taken from the emergency medical supplies,” Juliet says, “and you have a key to those supplies, as well as motive and the requisite lack of moral scruples.” Adora gives her a half-shocked, half-approving look.

Brannic grins widely. “You impress me, General Juliet. But, am I mistaken in saying that you also possess one of these keys? And have even more reason to hate Catra than I do?”

“General Juliet is not a suspect,” Adora responds, “You are.”

“Tell me my girl, did the General actually answer your little interrogation, or did she dodge the questions and automatically render herself above suspicion?” Brannic’s grin has grown wider.

“Don’t try to turn us against each other, Brannic!” Juliet says. Now it’s her turn to get annoyed at her old colleague’s conniving ways.

Brannic simply chuckles. “My dear General. I’m not turning you against each other. I’m simply telling Adora that there may never have been an alliance to begin with.”

“He’s right.” Adora realizes quietly. “You didn’t answer the questions.”

“Neither has he!” Juliet protests, turning towards the younger woman. “Adora, Brannic is trying to manipulate you. This is how he gets his kicks. Talking people in circles and turning them against each other.”

“Not true.” Brannic scoffs, “I have fun in plenty of other ways.”

“Answer the questions Brannic!” Juliet says, turning away from Adora, whose face has gone stony. “Where were you last night and this morning, and where are your keys to the emergency medica-”

Juliet is cut off by Adora standing out of her chair and proclaiming, “For the Honor of Grayskull!!”

There’s a flash of brilliant yellow light, and She Ra stands in the middle of the room, glaring down at both Juliet and Brannic. She has not summoned her sword, but her fists are clenched.

“Enough!” She Ra shouts. “Catra is in danger, and both of you are equally capable of having put her there.”

Brannic’s guards exchange a glance, clearly weighing their options.

Juliet gulps. She’s never been on this side of the wrath of a warrior goddess, and it is truly terrifying. Brannic, of course, maintains his unfazed, smug demeanor

“Adora,” Juliet placates in a measured voice, “You and I aren’t exactly close, but I give you my word, I swear upon the safety of Bright Moon, her King and Queen, and all her citizens this: If I were to bring any harm upon Catra, I would do it with a blade, not a poison.”

She Ra meets her gaze, those glowing, brilliantly blue eyes seem to burn straight through Juliet’s eyes into her very soul. There’s an impossibly long moment before Adora simply says, “I believe you,” before turning towards Brannic.

“I cannot be the culprit.” Brannic states calmly.

“And why is that?” Adora says, taking a step forward and leaning over Brannic’s desk so she’s looming over the short, balding man even more.

Even with a 7 foot tall glowing warrior goddess who possesses immense magical power looming over him, Brannic retains his composure completely.

‘Storms, I may hate the man but he has a power of his own.’ Juliet realizes.

Brannic opens a drawer and pulls out a key ring. He lets it clink onto the table and slides it over towards Juliet.

“My key is missing.” He says.

“What?!” Juliet cries, grabbing the key ring to search. “Why did you not tell me immediately?”

“I did not know immediately.” Brannic explicates, “I only discovered the anomaly when my people told me that you two were working your way through the castle. I immediately came to the conclusion that you believed Catra had been poisoned, and tried to find my key to begin my own investigation. However, when I searched my key ring, I discovered it was missing.”

“That’s a very serious problem.” Adora says. “Why did you keep this to yourself?”

“I did not,” Brannic answers, “I immediately sent for a locksmith to have the emergency medical supply closet lock changed. The King, Queen, and General should be receiving replacements tomorrow. I didn’t issue a public decree because I had no desire to cause a general panic, something the two of you could learn from.”

“What are you talking about?” Adora demands.

Brannic stands up. He is not a tall man, but there is such conviction in his stance and voice that his presence nearly matches She Ra. “The two of you haven’t exactly been subtle,” He states, “And I have had my people running around like maniacs trying to clean up the mess you’ve made. To ease the concerns caused by Bright Moon’s most famous hero and its foremost general wandering around saying that our food and medicine has been poisoned!” Adora takes a step back, looking somewhat cowed. “Oh, and let’s not forget the rainbow-colored horse prancing into the kitchens demanding to taste test everything that is sent to your *girlfriend*,” Brannic adds. She Ra rubs the back of her neck bashfully.

Brannic takes a deep breath. “I admit to being willfully obtuse at the beginning of this little conversation, because yes, I was having fun with it. But I will not be accosted in my own office.” He sits back down and gestures towards one of his guards. “Darius,” The guard steps forward, “Tell them what you told me.”

The guard, Darius, clears his throat before lifting the face-concealing visor. He has something of a scrunched face, with a flat nose and close together eyes. “I believe I may have an idea of who the key thief is.”

“Who?” Juliet and Adora ask in unison.

“This morning, I saw one of the Bright Moon guards leaving the Chancellor’s office. I reminded her that it wasn’t her domain, but she rushed off.”

“Who was it?” Juliet says. *If this is coming from one of my own men, there will be dire consequences.*

“Dunno,” Darius says honestly, “I don’t bother to learn any of you lots’ names.”

Adora growls in frustration, “Any defining features?”

“Oh, sure.” Darius nods, scratching his chin and dislodging a bit of dandruff from his scraggly beard, “Another cat woman, like yours,” He gestures to Adora, “tan fur with orange stripes. Average build.”

Adora looks to Juliet and asks, “Does that ring any bells?”

“It does…” Juliet contemplates, “That description matches Fenndra, but that doesn’t make much sense. She’s not a Palace guard, she ought to be in the city.”

“Well wherever she is,” Adora says grimly, “We’re going to find her.”

Glimmer

Glimmer has taken to using a tiny spark of magical fire on one of her fingers to burn doodles into the side of the table in front of her to pass the time during these meetings.

“And that settles the matter of grain seed imports from Alwyn to Tenfields,” States a tiny, bespectacled old woman, who, despite standing up in her chair, barely keeps her head and shoulders above the table.

“Our next order of business should be to discuss what is to be done with the abandoned fortress in Chiawick Pass.” Growls a gray-skinned man with an enormous mustache and an impressive set of walrus-like tusks.

“That fortress,” A squeaky-voiced faun answers, “Is currently home to a flock of harpies that were displaced by a hurricane.”

“Exactly,” the walrus man grunts, “And they’ve been attacking Deorstead’s livestock.”

“I thought Deorstead was a fishing hamlet,” The tiny old woman asks. Glimmer can only see the top of her elaborate multi-tiered bun bobbing as she speaks.

“We are,” The walrus-man responds, “But we don’t survive on fish alone, do we?”

“Regardless,” The faun squeaks, “Harpies are a protected species. With the return of Etheria’s magic also came the return of their natural predator: the cockatrice.”

“So move ‘em to a wildlife sanctuary.” Grunts the walrus.

The faun bristles, “They are a sapient species, and I hope you don’t speak about them like this to their faces, for your sake.”

The walrus man sticks out his tongue at the faun, then turns to Glimmer. “Your Majesty,” He rumbles, “What is your suggestion?”

Glimmer starts. This is the first time she’s been addressed since three issues ago. She forgets to put out the fire coming out of her finger, and burns her hand when she tries to clasp her hands officiously.

“Ow!” She hisses, shaking both hands. Micah chuckles beside her. “I think,” She recovers, “That your village should reach out to the harpies and try to establish peace. Maybe you can open trade with them and forge an alliance.”

The walrus-man snorts and mutters, “Yeah, like an alliance with some birds is gonna be fruitful.”

“What was that?” Glimmer says sharply.

"Nothin' Your Majesty." He blusters, "I just think that we ought to drive them out and garrison the fortress."

"Garrison it against what?" Micah asks. "The only thing on the other side of Chiawick Pass is The Hive." He then adds with an air of incredulity, "Are you afraid Princess Sweet Bee is going to attack you?"

"No!" The walrus-man protests (*What was his name again?*) "But we should be ready, shouldn't we?"

Glimmer sighs. "If you establish an alliance with the harpies, they may be able to serve as the garrison you want. Just get over your prejudice and your problems will be solved."

She goes back to idly drawing as the walrus-faced emissary from Deorstead falls into malcontented splutters and murmurs, and the conversation turns to an argument over how best to farm the numerous new crops created by the return of Etheria's magic.

She Ra bringing the magic back has brought more problems than it's worth.

She finds herself burning in a picture of the fortress at Mount Chandrila with a Horde banner flying over it. No matter how many hours of mind-numbing politics or boring paperwork she sits through, nothing can take her mind off of that. *I know that's the next big threat. That's what we should be discussing. Why can't anyone else see that??*

Adora

Fenndra was not on patrol, nor did her Captain even see her today. Now, Adora and Juliet are standing outside of a small, disheveled looking house on the outskirts of town. The yard is overgrown and one of the windows on the cramped looking second floor is covered by a sheet of plywood.

“One of Bright Moon’s guards lives here?” Adora remarks incredulously. She and Juliet have made their way onto the porch, which has thick dark curtains draped over it to partially enclose the space.

“Don’t be judgemental,” Juliet responds, “We don’t know her situation.”

“Wha- I’m not being judgemental!” Adora protests weakly as Juliet reaches out and takes hold of the door knocker.

There’s a disturbance inside after the three metallic raps, and the sound of at least three locks being undone is heard before the door creaks open.

A dark-skinned muscular man stands there, wearing a surprisingly clean and luxurious bathrobe and fuzzy slippers and holding a cup of coffee. *‘Why’s he drinking coffee? It’s dusk.’*

“Can I help -” He begins, but when he registers who the two women standing on his porch are, he stops and almost drops his coffee. “General? An-and are you really?” He reaches out a hand and pokes Adora’s shoulder to make sure she’s real.

“Adora, She Ra, saviour of Etheria and hero of the Rebellion,” Adora confirms with a smile and a wink. She gently extricates his finger from her shoulder and shakes his hand. Juliet sighs and rolls her eyes next to her.

“Is this the house of Fenndra Short?” Juliet asks brusquely.

“Oh! Uh, yeah? Why, what’s up with Fen?” The man asks.

“Can you get her for us?” Adora requests. “We have some questions for her.”

The man scratches the back of his neck, “Uh sure. Fair warning though, she’s been feeling pretty sick recently so she may ask you guys to come in.” He looks over his shoulder up the stairs behind him. From what Adora can see, the inside of the house is much

better kept than the outside. “Fen!” He calls, “General Juliet and Princess Adora are at the door, they wanna talk to you!”

“Sure they are!” A scratchy, squeaky voice calls down, “Well you can tell them to suck it! I’m sick!” This declaration is followed by a bout of coughing.

“Officer Fenndra!” Juliet calls up, “This is not a trick. This is a serious investigation.”

“Oh stars!” Fenndra’s voice squeaks, “Uh, one moment!”

Adora can hear sounds of shuffling from upstairs. The man smiles awkwardly before starting. “Oh,” He says, “My name’s Marcus, I’m Fenndra’s housemate. Sorry about the mess outside, Fen isn’t home much and I don’t really go outside.”

That explains why the interior looks so nice then.

Fenndra, a cat woman with tan fur and orange stripes down her arms, walks down the steps, leaning rather heavily on the railing and looking where she steps. She’s wearing simple grey pants and a tank top. Marcus quickly steps back to give her support until she shoos him away.

“Thanks Marc, I’ve got this.” She assures him, “Go to the living room.”

“But-”

“Private convo my man.” She rasps, “I’m fine. Just go wait.”

Marcus nods and walks down the hall, casting a worried look over his shoulder as Fenndra closes the door.

“General.” She says, raising a shaky arm in a salute, “Princess. How can I help you?”

“At ease soldier,” Juliet says.

“And take a seat,” Adora adds, gesturing to the pair of dusty chairs sitting beside them on the porch, “You’re shaking worse than one of Entrapta’s inventions.”

“That bad huh?” Fenndra says ruefully, but she looks exceedingly grateful as she sinks into the chair.

“So,” Adora begins, “I think you probably know why we’re here.”

Fenndra nods. “The medicine cabinet key, I know.”

“You understand that you stole one of the most valuable objects in the kingdom, right?” Juliet says sternly. Adora can tell that she wants to arrest Fenndra on the spot.

“I do, but it’s more complicated than that!” Fenndra says, only to fall into a fit of coughs from raising her voice.

“How?” Adora asks, her curiosity immediately piqued.

“Look, I- I’ve been sick for a few days. I think I caught something when I got some vendor food on my break. I knew about the emergency medical supplies and went up to the castle to find you General. I… I’ve been doing the best I can but I don’t really know how I was staying on my feet. I was going to ask if anything in the emergency supplies could maybe help.”

“So why didn’t you ask me?” General Juliet presses.

“I… don’t know,” Fenndra replies, “Somehow my brain went from, ‘ask the General for access’ to, ‘steal the Chancellor’s key’. I have no idea what happened. I was gonna tell you everything once I got better, I swear.”

“Do you think you might have been enchanted?” Adora asks.

“Maybe?” Fenndra says, “But I dunno who’d do that, or… why they’d target me. I mean, I’m not gonna say I didn’t do it. I remember doing it. But… I don’t remember why I did it.”

Adora turns to General Juliet, hoping she'll be reasonable. To her surprise, she sees a very sad look of recognition on the General's face.

"I understand," Juliet says, "That's how it felt when I was chipped." She kneels down and looks up at Fenndra with shocking softness in her face and voice. "Can you remember anything else? Any people of interest? Any… anomalies apart from the obvious?"

Fenndra closes her eyes and thinks for a long moment. "Yeah…" She says finally, "I remember passing the kitchens and seeing a clone around there. I don't know why but he felt… familiar?" She opens her eyes, "Sorry, I don't remember much about him. I think he was bald."

A chill runs down Adora's spine. '*Bald? Oh no…*'

Juliet stands up. "Well. You stay here and rest. I want you better by tomorrow so you can give a full statement on this incident. I assume you don't still have the key?"

"No, sir," Fenndra confirms, "Think it's in the supply room."

"Thank you for your cooperation," Juliet says. She turns towards Adora. "Any other ques...tions… Adora? Are you okay?"

Adora just swallows hard and reaches for her communicator. "I know who it is. We have to warn Bow."

Juliet's head moves back in surprise. "Bow? Why?"

"Because," Adora pulls up the screen, and presses on Bow's icon to call him, "It's his assistant, Balder."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, feel free to kudo and comment if you enjoyed!

The Bright Zone, Part 4: A Desperate Chase

Chapter Summary

> In which Adora uncovers the truth, leading to a frantic chase through the Whispering Woods, and a moment of reckoning that could have drastic consequences.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra's dreams are inconsistent. No longer can she follow a single narrative or ideological thread, now she's just hurtling through random scenarios and images with no sense or reason.

She sees Shadow Weaver spinning like a top, and every time she rotates, her mask changes into a different face. Adora, Bow, Hordak, King Micah, Netossa, Kadroh, Glimmer, until eventually she comes to a stop facing Catra, and it's Catra's own face she sees adorning Shadow Weaver's mask.

She stands on a tiny platform, floating through a void. In front of her, a hundred-story tall vision of Force Captain Octavia glares down at her.

"You little welp!" The massive cephalopodian woman roars down at her. One of her humanoid arms is clutched over a damaged eye, and her four tentacles are slamming down towards Catra. "I'll kill you for that!"

Catra sees a spear lying on the platform beside her, and she rolls towards it as Octavia's tentacle smashes down onto the ground where she had been. She snatches the spear and hurls it into Octavia's one remaining eye.

The titanic vision of Octavia falls forward as she screams, and her massive mouth filled with rows of shark-like teeth encompasses Catra wholesale.

She finds herself falling through a jungle made of wires and metal, covered in dark plant life. Vines snap around her as she falls. She smashes into the dirt below her, and it immediately begins to come alive and swallow her. Before her vision goes dark, she sees a pair of glowing red eyes looking at her from the jungle.

She snaps awake in the Crimson Waste. She's standing in a long, rough divet in the ground, looking up at the massive crashed vessel that she knows to be Darla. She can see a trapezoid of light gleaming at the ship's base, and a lone figure standing there, ready to go in.

"Adora!!" Catra calls out, but it's too late. Adora steps into the ship, which immediately explodes in a plume of green flame. Catra is knocked onto her butt, and looks at the fireball in despair. As she stares, the flames twist and stop, and, against all logic, Catra sees frost creep over the fire, then out and across the Crimson Waste.

Everything goes cold, even the sun freezes into a ball of ice above her, and Catra hears the voice of Fygan echo across this now-frozen wasteland.

"I'm going to destroy her."

The shapeshifter steps out of the frozen explosion, right where Adora had stepped in.

Catra gasps, her breath forming a cloud of mist in front of her. "NO!" She tries to scream, but the word lodges in her throat like an ice cube.

Fygan cackles like a madman, and frost covers Catra's eyes. The dream ends.

Adora

Adora and Juliet arrive back at Bright Moon Castle out of breath and sweating. Bow is there to greet them, with a grim look on his face.

"So Adora, can you explain the situation now?" He asks.

"Yeah…" Adora pants, "Balder… poisoned Catra… Heh… working with… Fygan… Whoo! We ran a long way… Heh… I'm fit I swear…" Adora leans against one side of the gateway to catch her breath.

Juliet straightens up and begins to walk into the castle. "I believe Balder put a poison specific to Catra's species into the Castle's salt supply. He tested it on one of my Guards and then used her to steal Chancellor Brannic's key and throw us off the scent."

How am I so tired but she isn't?? I'm in really good shape!

Bow looks at her as she straightens up and starts to follow Juliet. "And you think this is connected to Fygan?"

Adora nods. "I think Balder probably *is* Fygan. He's a shapeshifter and an illusionist, remember?"

Bow shakes his head. He looks a little horrified. "No, that can't be right. Balder and I have been working together since before Fygan did his thing in the Fright Zone. We're friends."

"I'm sorry, Bow," Adora says, putting a gentle hand on her friend's shoulder, "But I think Balder may be gone."

Bow tears up and just falls into Adora's hug. Adora just holds him close. "I hope I'm wrong, Bow, I really do."

"I know," Bow sniffs, "I do too but you're just being realistic…"

Juliet coughs politely. "I'm sorry but we can mourn later. If Brannic caught on to us, Fygan likely has too, and we need to catch him before he can escape.

“Okay,” Bow says, sniffing and pulling away from Adora. He gives her upper arm a gentle squeeze of thanks. “So,” He asks, “what’s the plan?”

Juliet looks at Adora expectantly.

“Well,” Adora says, “I think I have an idea about how to trap him, but we’re gonna need some help.”

“Help from who?” Bow asks.

“From the only person in this castle who can beat Fygan at his own game.”

Balder

Balder’s work is disrupted by the sound of hinges creaking open. The clone sets down his tools and turns to see Adora walking slowly into the room.

Balder simply grunts in lieu of asking why the Princess of Power is here, and why she has her staff at the ready pointed at him.

“The game’s up, Fygan.” She says coldly, advancing on Balder’s position.

Balder slowly raises his hands above his head, backing up and beginning to circle around the room. Adora counters his movement, on the alert for any hostile movements.

Balder’s eyes flit towards the door, and he has to suppress a smile at what he sees waiting for him outside.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.” Balder tells Adora carefully.

“The real Balder doesn’t talk,” Adora responds icily, her eyes narrowed.

But now the careful track he's led her on has her right where he wants her. A blue spell glyph appears around one of Balder's hands, and a matching sigil hums to life in the center of the room.

"Ohhhohohooh MAN!" Balder gloats, dropping the act altogether, "I mean I knew I was good but really?? The same trick twice in a row Adora?? Come ON!" His physical form under the clothes warps and shimmers black and green before adjusting into his true form.

"Okay, admit it," Fygan says smugly, "I had all of you fooled." He begins to pace around the room triumphantly. "Even Bow!" He declares, pointing at the still-ajar door, "Who, right now, is wondering where on earth General Juliet could be. Isn't that right?"

There's a beat before Bow steps into view, an arrow nocked and pointed at Fygan. "What have you done with the real Balder?" He says.

"Oho! Always concerned about your friends, aren't you?" Fygan sneers, leaning over and cocking his head to one side with his hands behind his back. "It's very noble of you, but rather stupid I'm afraid. And it's a weakness I'm all too willing to exploit." He turns away from Bow, fully confident that the archer's good heart will prevent him from firing. "I'm kind of disappointed that you're not more concerned about General Juliet, who is currently in a rather precarious position because of your little plan to capture me."

"What are you talking about?" Bow asks through clenched teeth.

"Right now she's immobilized on the roof. I planted a spell glyph up there to prevent her from dropping down onto the balcony and boxing me in. I imagine an especially strong wind will blow her right off into the lagoon, and," He pauses as a rumble of thunder echoes through the halls, "Would you look at that? Sounds like a storm is rolling in." He turns back towards Bow, a victorious and sinister smirk on his face, "You may want to be ready to catch her."

Bow's eyes are wide as he realizes Fygan is not bluffing. He begins inching towards the balcony, keeping his bow trained on the shapeshifter, who could not look more relaxed and in control.

"I'm kind of shocked by how easy it was to infiltrate Bright Moon," Fygan confesses, "I mean, haven't you guys had this happen once already? You'd think you'd be better prep-"

"ah-PTHEW!"

Fygan and Bow both stop dead.

"I'm sorry," Fygan says, turning towards the paralyzed Adora, who he'd all but forgotten about, "Did you just adorably sneeze while I'm laying out my master plan?"

Adora does not respond, she just looks ashamed. Fygan steps towards her and glares into her eyes. "You know," He remarks over his shoulder to Bow, not breaking eye contact, "I've been a lot of different people, and there's always one thing that gives it away to anyone close to the individual I'm impersonating. Do you know what that is?" He turns towards Bow. "The *eyes*. The windows to the soul. Because no matter how visually perfect an illusion is, you can't. Impersonate. A soul."

In a flash of black, Fygan shifts back into the larger, burlier form of Balder, rounds on Adora, and grabs her by the throat. The paralysis spell breaks, and Bow shouts in protest. Fygan spins around, hefting Adora by the throat as she struggles and claws at his hand.

"NO!" A voice from the hallway shouts. "For the Honor of Grayskull!!"

There's a flash of golden light and a bang as She Ra kicks down the door, her sword blazing with a white-hot rage that is reflected in her eyes.

In Fygan's hand, the fake Adora melts away to reveal a blank, grayish-brown humanoid with a bubble of swirling orange energy

around their head, and two round, orange eyes.

Fygan performs a simple incantation to conjure a knife and holds it up to Melog's throat.

Adora glares at him, seething with hatred. Fygan backs up towards the balcony.

"Do not ever try to outsmart me, Adora." Fygan rasps, "Do not *ever* think you are capable of that."

"Let. Them. Go." Adora demands, "*Now*."

Fygan cocks his head, "And I suppose you expect me to surrender as well, don't you?" Fygan feels the first few raindrops of the storm splattering against his back and on the top of Balder's head. He clenches his hand on Melog's throat, and the alien's struggles begin to weaken. Their mane is beginning to show spots of gray as they start to lose consciousness.

"Tell you what," Fygan says, turning towards Bow, who is giving a nervous glance outside, where the Whispering Woods are coming alive from the storm. "I'll give you a free shot at me, right… *NOW*!" And he spins around, heaves Melog over the railing, and hurls them off the balcony.

Adora

Bow acts first, dropping the arrow he had loaded, grabbing one from his quiver and firing a lasso out towards Melog, who has vanished from sight, hurtling towards their doom on the rocky cliffs below.

Fygan turns around, but hesitates for the first time when he sees Adora. A tiny flicker of satisfaction crosses her mind when she sees the fear in his eyes before she swings her blade in a downward arc through the air.

A wave of energy rips through the room. Wires snap and spark, a metal shelf collapses, the lights shatter, the balcony explodes outward, and Fygan goes flying out above the lagoon.

Fygan hangs in the air for a moment, looking like a great white bat in the form of Balder, before he begins to fall. But Adora's elation at this victory is short-lived, as he twists in the air and casts a spell, conjuring a cloud beneath himself that he lands on and immediately begins to fly away.

"NO!" Adora screams, leaping to the balcony and sending a wave of rainbow-colored magic towards the retreating spellcaster.

"Adora!" Bow groans, "Help me!"

Adora looks over towards him, and guilt washes over her. Bow was also buffeted by her strike, and is barely holding on to the lasso, where Melog hangs, semi-conscious, partway down the cliff.

"Bow! I'm so sorry!" She says as she grabs the rope and, with the strength of She Ra, hoists Melog up with one hand. "I'm going-"

A deafening crack and a blinding light snaps through her words as a bolt of lightning shears into the roof above them. Instinct pulls Adora's arms outward and, by some miracle, she catches General Juliet as she falls off the roof.

Adora pulls the still-paralyzed soldier away from the balcony and lays her on the couch. Bow follows suit carrying Melog.

"Can you heal them?" Bow asks.

"Later." Adora responds, standing up and moving towards the door, "I'm not letting Fygan get away again."

"Adora!" Bow's voice echoes after her, but Adora is already racing down the hallways.

Fygan can't get far on his little cloud. He's gonna be going to the skiffs to get away.

Adora vaults over a startled looking janitor and her cart and continues running at a dead sprint towards the recently built skiff hangar. Thunder shakes the castle, and the sound of rain roars against the roof above her.

"Move!" She roars as she sees a pair of guards in the way ahead of her. Both guards start, and flatten themselves against the walls on either side. "Thank you!" Adora calls as she moves past them, barely a blur. Even accounting for She Ra's long legs, Adora feels magic lending speed to her winged boots.

"Adora? What's going on?" Glimmer's voice, barely audible over the rain and the sound of Adora's own heart racing in her chest, almost as fast as she is.

"Fygan!" Is all Adora can say before she's left her friend behind.

At last, she sees the door to the skiff bay ahead of her. Without pausing, she swings her blade with abandon, shearing through the metal and barrelling into the room.

She skids to a halt, and makes eye contact with Fygan. The shapeshifter has dropped the guise of Balder, and Adora watches as the skiff hums to life underneath him, and he slams down on the throttle, rocketing off into the storm.

Adora leaps across the bay, landing on the other skiff. She lets She Ra fade from her and ignores the enormous wave of exhaustion that brings. *I need precision right now.*

"Adora!" Bow's voice calls out, and Adora looks over to see that he and Glimmer have teleported into the doorway. "Wait!" He calls, panting desperately.

Adora looks at him, then out to where Fygan's skiff is already sending up a wake as he speeds across the lagoon. Rage fills her head, and she squeezes the throttle. Her skiff roars to life beneath her, and she shoots out of the hangar like a bullet after him.

Bow

"WhAT is HAPPENING!?" Glimmer shrieks.

"Adora was right!" Bow shouts back as he runs down towards the other skiffs. *Dang it! Either out of fuel or damaged!* "Fygan was poisoning Catra! Now she's chasing him into the storm! Is she insane?! No-one could survive that on a skiff!"

"Fygan could." Glimmer responds grimly. "I'm going to try to get her out!"

"Wait, no- Glimmer!" Bow turns and reaches out towards her, but she's already vanished. *I have to catch up to them. But without a skiff, how am I going to keep up?*

The answer hits him in the chest. "Swift Wind!"

Bow takes off, running towards Catra and Adora's room.

Adora

Fygan's skiff has already broken through the curtain of the Whispering Woods by the time Adora crosses the lagoon. *He may have a headstart, but I've got more experience with these things.* Adora lets off the throttle and lets the ferocious winds carry her into the woods.

She has not been in the Whispering Woods during a storm, especially not since Etheria's magic returned. She sees that the trees are alive, dancing and swaying in the wind as if they were performing some occult ritual. Lightning cracks down beside her, splitting a massive oak, whose old wood belches fire like a dragon.

Adora banks around a massive, many-boughed willow. Fygan's skiff is dead ahead. He looks over his shoulder at Adora and lowers his skiff.

The ski at the bottom of the vehicle pierces the ground, slowing his progress, but sending up a plume of dirt and rocks that Adora has to swerve to escape. A tree branch slices across her face, and she can feel blood trickling down her cheek.

Another bolt of lightning streaks down beside her. It hits a strange rock and fractures into a dozen smaller bolts, a few of which lance into her skiff and scatter across the surface. Adora is glad that this skiff has a cloth wrapping around the tiller. If not, she thinks she probably would have gotten a nasty shock.

Fortunately, Fygan does not appear to be having a much better time of it. As she catches sight of him again, he only has one hand on the tiller, the other is flailing around, trying to bat away a small, metallic rodent-like creature that is clinging to his head.

Fygan

"Get off!" Fygan growls as he finally gets hold of the little pest that leaped onto him. He chucks it over his shoulder, hoping it finds purchase on Adora, whose skiff is gaining on him again. He weaves in between glowing, writhing trees as the forest closes in on itself.

Something to distract her… He brings up a spell glyph with one hand, and projects a massive illusion just ahead of him, which he slams onto the throttle and drives into.

Adora

Horde Prime looms above her like a totem of evil. Adora feels a stab of fear at her heart as the tyrant's green eyes gaze down at her.

She blinks and looks back down, but the illusion distracts her enough for her skiff to suffer a collision against a large, jagged rock. She yanks the tiller up in time to keep going, but smoke is

belching out of the wound on the underside of the vehicle's hull, and she hears it creaking ominously.

She can see Fygan's skiff ahead of her. His maneuver slowed her, but now he's having to zigzag through a dense thicket of trees, and she's gaining again.

She takes one hand off the tiller, and summons her magical weapon in the form of a lasso.

Bow

"I can't see anything through the trees!" Swift Wind calls.

"There!" Bow shouts, pointing at a flash of green visible on the ground below.

"OH NOOO!" Swift Wind cries as a massive humanoid figure appears in front of them. Horde Prime, smiling beatifically down into the forest. Swift Wind banks to the right, but lightning strikes, shearing through the air right beside them. The alicorn plummets towards the ground, but kicks off of the canopy and regains composure.

"Swift Wind!" Bow shouts over the storm, "Stay low!" He pulls out his bow and nocks an arrow. He can see the skiffs now, and his eyes are trained on the one in front.

"Adora!!" Swift Wind shouts out, and Bow looks back to see the second skiff is now trailing smoke and sparks.

Adora

Adora and Fygan are neck and neck, racing along a river in the midst of the Woods. Adora slams her skiff into Fygan's causing it to scrape along the riverbank. Adora can feel her skiff sputtering beneath her, struggling to stay active despite the damage it's sustained.

Ahead of them, a massive tree snaps from the wind and crashes into the river, sending a spray of water into the air. Fygan yanks his tiller up, and his skiff flies into the air off to the side. Adora tries to follow suit, but her skiff groans in protest.

This isn't good… Adora pushes on the tiller with all her might, but isn't able to pull up in time. The ski slams into the tree, sending her skiff into a spin. "NOO!" Adora cries, yanking up on the tiller desperately.

Fygan's skiff reappears, buffeted by the winds towards hers. Adora makes eye contact with the shapeshifter, who is trying to regain control of his vehicle. As he veers towards her, Adora makes a split second decision and leaps towards him.

Bow

Bow watches Adora jump onto Fygan's skiff, and he sees both of them ready for a fight. His heart drops into his stomach, because he can see what they cannot: The massive crystalline spire of the Beacon poking out of the trees ahead of them.

If they're fighting, they won't be able to stop in time and they'll crash. I have to stop them!

"Swift Wind!" He calls, "Stay low!"

Bow draws his bow and aims. He knows it's an impossible shot. The wind alone would prevent even the greatest archer in the world from landing it, but add on the fact that he's aiming at a fast moving, zig-zagging target through a thick tree canopy while astride a flying horse, *and* he has to avoid hitting Adora. There's no way even he could make this shot successfully.

Don't think. Just feel.

Bow takes a deep breath. They're almost at the Beacon clearing. He's out of time.

He looses the arrow.

Fygan

Adora lands on his skiff and rounds on him. Fygan fires a jet of green flame in her direction. She ducks out of the way, and he dives in, letting go of the tiller.

She swings a fist towards his head, and he brings up an arm to block it. He cries out in pain, now realizing just how vast the strength disparity is between the two of them. Undeterred, he delivers a sharp kick to her shin that causes her to wince.

“What’s wrong??” He asks, “Having trouble glowing?”

Adora grabs his arm and spins him around into a standing half nelson. “I don’t need She Ra to end you.” She growls into his ear.

He stamps hard on her foot, and is grateful for the fact that he’s still wearing Balder’s heavy work boots. She flinches, and he swings his head back to crack against her nose and mouth. She releases him, and he stumbles and falls forward just in time to see an arrow thunk into the engine housing and release a massive electrical charge.

The engine shorts out, then bursts open with a shower of sparks. The skiff glides through the air for a second before skidding into the ground, breaking through the trees into a large rectangular clearing. Adora grabs the back of Fygan’s shirt and hurls him bodily through the air before leaping free of the skidding wreck of the skiff.

Fygan slams into hard rock and rolls several times before coming to a stop. He groans and rolls over onto his back. When he opens his eyes, he sees Adora walking over to him. There is a flash of light in her hand as she summons She Ra’s sword.

Catra

Catra sees Adora.

She stands at the foot of a massive crystalline tower in the heart of the Whispering Woods. The Beacon.

Adora has her sword drawn and held in both hands, pointed downwards. One hand is on the pommel of the sword, ready to ram the blade downwards into the heart of the figure she is standing over.

Prostrate on the ground beneath her is Fygan, unarmed, subdued, helpless.

And Adora is going to kill him.

"Stop! Adora, stop!" Catra shouts, but as soon as she opens her mouth, her consciousness shifts. She rockets backwards, across the Whispering Woods, through a vicious storm, into her room in Bright Moon. She is standing at the balcony in the rain, one hand outstretched.

A voice calls out to her from the other side of the room, low and slurred. "You're not strong enough." Catra spins around and, against all logic, sees Shadow Weaver, sitting on the wardrobe, her legs crossed, with a goblet of wine in her hand.

"I need to get to her!" Catra says, "I have to stop her!"

"Why?" Shadow Weaver drawls, "Isn't this outcome precisely what you want? Fygan tried to destroy you in the Fright Zone. He's an obstacle in the way of your happily ever after with Adora. Why shouldn't she remove him?"

Catra's vision suddenly flashes with dozens of images.

She sees Adora standing over Fygan's corpse, Bow and Swift Wind looking horrified behind her.

Adora slamming her palms down on the war table, shouting at a committee of scared looking politicians.

Adora as She Ra at the head of a column of soldiers, marching across the Crimson Waste. One soldier nearby collapses from the heat, but Adora orders their companion to carry them rather than slow the march.

Adora stands in the midst of a ruined castle. A torn Horde flag flutters to the ground at her feet. She is surrounded by flames and bodies. Octavia kneels before her, offering surrender. Adora raises her sword.

She Ra and Glimmer face off in Bright Moon's throne room, both of them thrumming with magic. Bow and Catra stand between them, trying to prevent a fight. Adora sends both of them flying with a blast of magic and charges towards Glimmer.

Adora sits on the throne of Bright Moon. She Ra's armor is different, darker. This She Ra is not a hero, she is a conqueror.

The final image is stranger. It shows a woman, not Adora, sitting in a dark void. This woman is lithe and muscular, with long blonde hair flowing behind her. She has a thin, beautiful face, with sharp cheekbones and full lips. She looks like some strange alternate version of Adora. She opens her eyes, which flash with light before settling into a deep blue, and looks at Catra. "She's mine now." She mouths.

And then Catra is back in her room, looking at Shadow Weaver, the storm raging behind her. "If Adora kills Fygan, she'll lose herself." Catra says, "I have to send her a message."

"So do it," Shadow Weaver responds offhandedly, "You know the spell."

Catra pauses, "I… can't cast it." Shadow Weaver chuckles, and Catra gets defensive. "I don't know why! I just…"

Shadow Weaver sighs and sets her goblet on the wardrobe beside her. She pushes off, sways a little, then glides over to Catra, her fingers pressed together in front of her.

“Just cast it.” She says.

“I can’t!” Catra repeats, “I- I don’t have the components.”

Shadow Weaver laughs, “Did you ever see *me* using spell components for my work? You don’t need them.”

“But I don’t have magic within me.” Catra protests.

“And who told you that? Glimmer? Casta? They’re talented to be sure, but they haven’t even scratched the surface.” Shadow Weaver glides out towards the balcony. Through the storm, a small mote of magical light drifts down into her open hand. “Etheria *is* magic, Catra, and every living thing on it has that magic within them. You just have to reach out and take it.” She beckons Catra forward. Catra hesitantly walks out to the balcony, feeling the rain soak into her.

“Reach out your hand,” Shadow Weaver instructs, “And grasp the magic that is rightfully yours.”

Catra reaches out a hand and holds it in the rain for a long moment. Nothing happens.

“I don’t think-” She is cut off by a crack and a flash of yellow light. A bolt of lighting strikes her palm, and, without thinking, she closes her hand, grabbing hold of the electricity and pulling it into herself.

“Good!” Shadow Weaver says, “Now, cast the message spell.”

“But… How?” Catra asks. “Even if I have the magic, I still can’t do it.”

“The essence of the message spell,” Shadow Weaver begins to lecture, “Is that you are twisting the fabric of reality, tricking it into ignoring the distance between you and your intended target. But if you want to convince the universe that you can send this message, you must first convince yourself. Now, Adora can hear you.”

"No she can-"

"Convince yourself!" Shadow Weaver snaps. "Close your eyes and change your mind."

Catra closes her eyes. "Adora can hear me."

'No she can't.'

"Adora can hear me."

'*She's in the middle of the Whispering Woods.'*

"And she can hear me."

'*She's miles away*.'

"She can still hear me."

'Even if that were true, the storm drowns you out.'

"No. She can hear me. Adora can hear me."

'No she can't.'

"Yes she can."

'*No, she can't.'*

"Yes she can."

'*Nuh-uh.'*

"Adora can hear me."

'*Adora can… No! She can't! That makes no sense.'*

"Adora can hear me."

'*No she can't!*'

"Adora. Can. Hear me."

'You're right. She can.'

"Adora can hear me."

'Adora can hear me.'

"*Adora can hear me!*"

Catra opens her eyes, laughing. "Adora can hear me!" She exclaims, turning towards Shadow Weaver.

The sorceress nods. "Well done, Catra. Now go. Use what I have taught you. Save Adora from herself."

Catra has so many things she wants to say, so many grievances to air out, so many words unspoken to Shadow Weaver. Instead, she just nods, and walks over to the bed. She lies down, pulls the blankets around herself…

And wakes up.

Adora

Adora stalks forwards towards Fygan. Rage and hatred clouds her judgement. Fygan scrambles backwards, trying to get up, but the ground is too slick, and he falls back into a puddle. He raises a hand, and a spell glyph sparks to life, but Adora cuts off the spell with a vicious kick to that hand. She stands over her downed opponent, her sword held in one hand. She raises the sword up to her head, one hand on the pommel, ready to drive it down into Fygan's heart.

The shapeshifter looks up at her and says, "I win. Welcome to my leve-agck!" She cuts off whatever smug rant he was about to embark on with a swift kick to the chin.

Adora raises her sword. Behind her, there is a clattering of hooves as Bow and Swift Wind land. She can hear both of them shouting at her to stop, but it's as if they're talking to her through a curtain

of molasses. All there is in this moment is the man beneath her, every horrible thing he's done, and her sword.

Catra

Though her body screams in pain and exhaustion, Catra rises. She crosses the room and raises a hand. A blood red spell glyph appears there.

Adora can hear me.

Catra spins her hand and speaks. One word. That's all she has the energy for.

Adora

Adora raises her blade and brings it down with murderous intent.

"STOP!"

The point freezes in midair, millimeters from Fygan's chest. Somehow, Catra's voice just entered Adora's mind, as if she was standing right beside her.

And in that instant, all the adrenaline and hatred drains out of Adora. She realizes what she is doing and stops. She staggers backwards, tossing the sword away in disgust. The back of her foot hits a rock and she falls backwards, but Bow rushes in and grabs her.

Fygan slowly, painfully, flips over and sits up on his knees.

He spits out a mouthful of blood from where she kicked him. "I knew it." He pants, "You're a coward."

"No," Adora says, "I'll just never fall down to your level, Fygan. Do you know why?" She looks to Bow, who still has his hands on her shoulders, and to Swift Wind, who is glaring at Fygan and cracking his neck. She looks off into the storm in the direction she

knows Bright Moon to be, where Catra was somehow able to stop her from. “Because I have my friends. And you are *alone*.”

Fygan’s breath hitches, and Adora wonders why she sees tears welling in his eyes.

“You- I-” Fygan pants, “You-... GNAAAAIIIIIEEEGHHHHHHH!!!” He screams an unearthly, animalistic scream and slams his hands into the ground. A spell glyph roars to life beneath him, and a massive cloud of smoke erupts from beneath him, filling the entire clearing.

Adora brings out her shield and ducks behind it. After a minute or so, the winds of the dwindling storm clear away the smoke, revealing an empty clearing, with Fygan nowhere to be found.

“He got away.” Swift Wind says, stamping a hoof in anger.

Adora simply sinks to her knees, tears welling in her eyes. She looks up at Bow, who pulls her into a hug.

Swift Wind walks over and wraps his wings around them, and the three of them just stay there for a time, heedless of the rain and wind, just holding each other at the foot of the Beacon.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading, comments and kudos are always appreciated. Hope you enjoy!

The Bright Zone, Part 5: The Nightmare is Over

Chapter Summary

> In which Adora, Glimmer, and Catra deal with the traumas and ramifications of Fygan's second attempt on Catra's life.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

When Adora walks into the room, Catra immediately realizes that something is very wrong. She looks more exhausted and miserable than Catra feels right now, and Catra had passed out after casting the fateful message spell.

"Adora?" Catra croaks, lifting herself to sit up with some effort, "What's wrong?"

Adora looks up at her. Aside from the exhaustion evident in the lines on her face, she is also drenched and filthy. There's a deep cut on one cheek, her nose is discolored, and her upper lip is slightly swollen. *Why hasn't she just gone She Ra and healed all that? And, more importantly, how did she get all of that?*

Adora sighs and walks over to the bed, flopping down next to Catra, who scoots over to make room.

"Today," Adora says, "Has sucked."

And Adora delves into a recounting of her day. How she suspected poisoning when Catra's condition worsened, how she and Juliet had investigated and discovered Fygan's plot, how Fygan had outmaneuvered them and nearly killed Juliet and Melog, (Here Catra freaks out a little until Adora assures her that Melog is fine

now), and how she had chased Fygan on a skiff through the Whispering Woods.

“And then, when the skiff crashed, I had Fygan on the ground and… I almost…”

Catra pokes a hand out of her blanket bundle and rests it on Adora’s forehead for a moment before pushing up to stroke her hair. “You almost killed him.” Catra says, “I know. I… saw it, in a dream.”

Adora looks up at her. “But you stopped me. I heard you tell me to stop. How did you do that?”

Catra shrugs, “Simple message spell.”

Adora’s brow furrows, “But I thought you couldn’t figure that one out?”

“Ahhh…” Catra chews her lip a bit before admitting, “I kinda… dreamt that Shadow Weaver taught me?”

Adora’s face goes long and perplexed. “Shadow Weaver?” She asks, her voice high and nasally.

“Yeah.” Catra responds.

“Huh,” Is all Adora can say to that. “Well,” She says after a long beat, “Glad she was good for something at least, huh?”

Catra chuckles, and is shocked when it doesn’t provoke a coughing fit. “Yeah,” She reflects, “I guess she was.”

After a while, Adora gets up and changes into pajamas, and joins Catra to cuddle up and go to sleep.

*****

Catra sits on the throne of Bright Moon, looking out over what seems to be all of Etheria. She feels like she could stretch out her

hand and take it all. The whole world, hers to rule. She could have all that she desires on a whim. She reaches out, but then a sound outside the dream disturbs her.

In her sleep, Adora rolls over and drapes an arm over Catra. She squeezes Catra's shoulder and murmurs, "Love you Catra…" before letting out a soft snore. Catra smiles and closes her eyes, returning to her dream and casting aside her vision of rulership.

I already have everything I need.

Glimmer

Glimmer sits on a soaking wet bench, looking up at a statue of her mother carved of pink granite. She feels useless. She hadn't believed Adora when she had confided her suspicions, and worse, she'd actually gotten angry at her for being concerned. She'd spent the whole day wrapped up in dumb meetings without accomplishing anything useful, and then when the chips were down, she'd failed to teleport to Adora's skiff, and failed to provide any help to her friends when it really mattered.

"I'm the most useless queen ever," She mopes aloud, picking up a rock and tossing it into the nearby fountain.

"Not true." Comes a voice from behind her, making her jump. She spins around and sees Bow standing there smiling at her.

"Is that so?" Glimmer challenges, "So you're saying my *mom* was the most useless queen ever? Because there's only two options."

Bow flushes a little, "No, neither of you are useless at all." He says, walking over and joining her on the bench. She sinks into him, letting her head rest against his broad chest.

"I was totally useless today," Glimmer says, "If I had been there we could have stopped Fygan. Why didn't you guys tell me you were moving against him?"

“Glimmer,” Bow begins, “You know we all think the work you do as queen is more important than anything we’ll ever accomplish, right?”

Glimmer snorts, “Well that’s ridiculous. You’re one of the foremost inventors of our time. Adora can turn into a goddess who vanquishes galactic evils and heals whole planets. Melog held off a planetary invasion for decades. My dad is an experienced sorcerer, ruler, and diplomat who survived on Beast Island for 14 years, Catra is… also there. Why would you guys think me sitting through discussions about *grain trading* is more important!?”

“Glimmer, by making a decision about grain trading, you’ve changed dozens, maybe hundreds of lives. I know it’s not as exciting as chasing a bad guy through a storm, but the decisions you make save or improve so many more lives.”

Glimmer sinks down a little. “Not always. Sometimes there’s no right answer, and no matter what I decide, people’s lives will be worse.”

“Okay,” Bow acknowledges, “But that’s still important. Because if it weren’t for you, those bad situations would never get better. Sure you can’t always make the right decision immediately, but once you know about the problem I know you’re going to fix it, because that’s just how you are.” He puts a hand under her chin and pulls her up to look him in the eyes. “Glimmer, you’re *way* too stubborn to let people’s lives be worse for very long, and I know that I, and everyone else, trust you to make the right call, even when that’s hard. Even when it keeps you away from your friends or your boyfriend, I know it’s worth it because with one sentence in one of those really boring meetings, you do more to improve the world than Adora does by punching a hundred bad guys.”

Glimmer feels so many emotions well up within her, and all she can do to express them is to kiss the brilliant, wonderful, wise, beautiful genius in front of her.

“Thank you Bow,” She says.

Bow smiles. “Hey, we all have off days. Try this: Every time you make a decision that could improve someone’s life, make a tally of it. Even if it seems small or boring. I think that might help.”

Glimmer smiles and nestles into his arms, “Okay, I’ll try that.” She says, “And I promise that next time I’m too busy to come on an adventure with you guys, I won’t be too upset about it.”

“Good.”

“I love you, Bow.”

“I love you too.”

*****

Glimmer doesn’t see Adora at all the next day, and, once her duties as Queen are over, she teleports all over the castle looking for her.

poof The training room. “Adora!?” No response. *poof*

poof The library. “Adora!?” The librarian shushes her harshly, heedless of her royal status. “Ugh!” *poof*

poof The Moonstone Tower. “AdoRA!?” The Moonstone does not respond. *poof*

poof Adora’s bedroom. “Adora!?”

Catra squeals and yells, “KNOCK!” before throwing a pillow that Glimmer teleports away from before it makes contact.

“Is Adora in here?” Glimmer asks, “Also: how are you feeling?”

Catra gives Glimmer a serious stink-eye before saying, her voice still hoarse, “Adora’s not here, and I’m fine.”

“Where is she?”

“I dunno, I’m not her keeper.”

“UGH! You kind of are, you know.” *poof*

poof Shadow Weaver’s old garden. “ADORA!” There’s no response, but Glimmer sees movement in the greenhouse. She teleports in and breathes a sigh of relief when she sees Adora sitting on one of the benches. “Finally!” She pants, “I was worried…” She trails off as she notices something is wrong.

Adora is sitting on the bench, mechanically tracing a spell glyph in the air over and over. The glyph flashes red onto a plant in front of her.

I don’t think I’ve ever seen Adora practicing sorcery.

“Hey, Glimmer.” Adora says mutely.

“Hey, Adora.” Glimmer responds, approaching with a touch of caution, “What’s that spell?”

Adora turns to look at her. Glimmer can see dried tear tracks down her cheeks. The hand that isn't casting the same spell over and over is clenched, white-knuckled, on her leg. “Oh this ol’ thing?” Adora says, “It’s a spell you taught me that I forgot until a few hours ago.”

“What does it do?” Glimmer asks, sitting down on the bench beside Adora.

“It detects poisons.” Adora says, a rage-touched chipper overtone to her somewhat hollow voice.

“Ohhhh…” Glimmer says, immediately understanding.

“Yup.” Adora says bitterly, “I wasted all those hours playing detective with Juliet trying to figure out how Catra was poisoned, when I should have just been doing this from the beginning.”

“Adora, it’s okay.” Adora looks up at Glimmer, tears in her eyes. Glimmer guides the blonde down into a hug, her head resting on Glimmer’s chest. “It isn’t your fault. I’ve been casting spells way

longer than you and I still forget I have them. When you have innate power, you have less reason to think of your learned power. And everything worked out alright in the end. We beat Fygan and saved Catra."

"I know," Adora says tearfully, "I just feel so stupid."

"Well," Glimmer says, "You're one of the smartest people I know, and you're smarter now for having learned from this mistake."

Glimmer remains there, comforting Adora, for the next few hours. It's clear that Adora hasn't allowed herself a moment of catharsis since their first encounter with Fygan in the Fright Zone, and by the end of the night, Glimmer goes to bed happier, because she knows that just by being there for her friend, she helped.

Fygan

Fygan, ragged and beaten, but alive, limps to his shack and opens the door. He cannot even process the events that transpired or the things that were said, all he can do is plot his next move.

He walks over to the drafting table, and notices something on the floor. A blueprint, salvaged from the Horde's weapon's factories. He looks over it, and his face lights up.

"Yes… This will do nicely." He sets the blueprint down, and gets to work. He has all the materials he needs. He pauses, and looks at the picture frame sitting on the corner of the desk.

"I swear to you," He says, "Everyone who stands, or has stood in my way is going to pay." He pulls out a drafting pencil and begins to lay out plans. "They will *pay*"

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated. The next arc is much lower

stakes than this one, and is also entirely new to this draft of the story.

Reunions and Refreshments, part 1: A Brotherly Woe

Chapter Summary

> In Which Bright Moon gains (and loses) a new ally, and Bow reunites with one of his brothers, who he can't quite connect with.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

"HA! Okay, okay," Catra ends her cackling fit from Sea Hawk's last remark. "Okayokayokay. I've got one. Never have I ever… stolen a man's boots while he was wearing them?" She looks at Sea Hawk intently as he thinks.

"Ah!" The pirate remembers, and takes a drink. "And I'll do you one better," he adds with a trademark roguish smile. "I did it while he was standing up, too."

"*What!?*" Catra sits up, "No way. You are lying. 'M callin your bluff, waterboy."

"Waterboy!?" He repeats indignantly, "It's true. It was our first mate at the time. We were being approached by pirates, about to be boarded, and the fool tried to give the crew an inspiring speech. But he was prone to nerves and kept shuffling his feet. Sooo, I got behind him and did my work. It was a very delicate job, but I got the crew cheering by the end."

"Wow. Catra chuckles, leaning back in her chair, "I thought that one was too wild even for you."

"Nothing. Is too wild for me." Sea Hawk brags.

The two are sitting in a booth in Sea Hawk's favored bar in Seaworthy, playing a game of Never Have I Ever. The trip was at Glimmer's insistence, as Catra and Adora had gotten especially lovey and insufferable after Fygan's escape and once Catra had recovered from her illness a few weeks ago. So Glimmer teleported Catra here and ordered her to hang out with Sea Hawk for a while. Not that Catra's going to complain. Despite his seeming incompetence and pyromaniacal tendencies, Sea Hawk is *awesome*, and gives her that taste of normal person friendship she's been missing for months.

"All right," Sea Hawk says, getting focused. "Let's see…" He ponders, then remarks, "I'm having a hard time thinking of things I haven't done myself, heha." Catra chuckles with him. "Okay…" He says, looking at her. Then his eyes spark, "Never have I ever clawed someone's eye bad enough to blind it."

"Oh come on!" Catra protests, taking a drink begrudgingly. "Did Adora tell you that? I stand by that decision. Octavia's a dumbface."

"Actually," Sea Hawk grins, "Octavia told me when she had me, Bow, and Swift Wind held captive this one time."

"Ha! Yeah she never got over it." Catra giggles.

"Well, to be fair, you did scratch her eye out." Sea Hawk says.

"Bah," Catra waves a hand, "She could have probably gotten it fixed. Or gotten a replacement. She liked having an eye patch."

"Understandable. It really completed her whole look."

"Ha! Ain't that the truth." Catra lets herself sprawl out on the cushioned booth seat.

Her ears twitch as she hears heavy bootfalls approaching their table. She sits back up as a deep voiced man clears his throat at them. She sees a tall, dark skinned man with striking features. He

has a chestnut-colored mullet and a scar across one cheek, plus several more scars on his well-built arms.

"Sea Hawk," He begins with a faux affable tone that barely hides his malice, "Old chum. Fancy seeing you here."

"Ah- D- Admiral Scurvy??" Sea Hawk stammers, "Why, I- uh- to what do I owe the pleasure?"

"Admiral?" Catra mutters, "Of what?"

Three more tough-looking pirates emerge from the shadows, glaring at Sea Hawk and Catra.

Scurvy chuckles darkly. "We have got to stop meeting like this, Sea Hawk."

Catra looks over to Sea Hawk, who winks confidently at her. Below the table, Melog awakens from their nap and readies to pounce.

Bow

"Love you, dads," Bow says into the communicator he's got propped up on his knees. He's sitting on the couch in his workshop, taking a break from working on the teleporter to give his dads a call.

"Oh! Lance! How could we forget??" George exclaims, "Bow, your brother is coming to visit you!"

Bow's heart leaps in joy. *It's been so long since I've seen any of my brothers! Especially just, like, one on one!* "Which one?" He asks excitedly.

"Andrew." Lance says.

Bow's heart comes down from its leap and splashes into his stomach. "Oh." He says, feeling bad for how obviously let down he is. *Of all my brothers… it has to be the one I just don't get at all.* "Well that's… exciting!" Bow tries to feign enthusiasm.

“Isn’t it?? George says obliviously, “Okay. Make sure you two take lots of pictures, and try to give us a call together, okay?”

“Okay,” Bow agrees, his voice sounding rather glum.

“Hey, Bow.” Lance gets his attention, “I know Andrew can be… a little hard for you to get along with, but just give it your best shot. I think spending some time with you is going to help him, and it means a lot to us, okay?”

Yeah, maybe it’ll help him*, but what about* me?

“Okay dads,” Bow acquiesces, “I love you. Do you know when he’s planning on arriving?”

“Oh he’s on his way from the library,” George says, “He should only be a few more hours.”

Not much time to prepare, then. “Alright. Thanks for the heads up. Love you, bye.

“TTYL! Love you!” George exclaims. Lance chuckles at his husband’s use of the acronym and says, more calmly and normally, “Bye, Bow. Love you.”

The communication channel closes, and Bow sighs, letting his head fall down onto the grime-covered pillow below him. He scrolls through the channels and opens one.

In no time at all, the video channel springs open, and Adora’s chin fills the screen. “Bow? Is that you??” She asks.

“Yes, it’s me. Ad-Adora, you’ve gotta hold the tablet up in front of your face.”

“What? But I can see you fine.”

Bow pinches his nose. “Yeah, but all I can see of you is your chin.”

“Oooohhhh… Hold on.” Adora adjusts her trackerpad to hold it out in front of her face, holding it with both arms fully rigid and stiffly set perpendicular to her body. “Is that better?” She asks.

“Yes,” Bow says, trying not to laugh at how goofy she looks. “Hey, Adora, I… need your help. Could you come down to the workshop?”

“Yes!!” She exclaims excitedly, leaping up from her bed, keeping her arms totally rigid, “How can I be helpful??” She says brightly.

“I’ll explain when you get here.” Bow says, “And don’t worry, it’s nothing dangerous or bad. It’s just about my brother coming over.”

“HHHHHAAAAAAHAHHH!!” Adora gasps for altogether too long. “I get to meet a Bow-*brother*?? Onmyway!” She hangs up, and it’s not very long before Bow hears rapidly approaching footfalls echoing through the hallway, and Adora slides into the workshop, only to trip on a thick wire and almost tumble to the floor. “Where’s the brother??” She asks, her head swinging back and forth as if Bow’s brother were hiding somewhere.

“He’s not here yet.” Bow explains, “I… need help with how to deal with him.”

Adora calms down and bit and cocks her head, “What do you mean?”

“He’s… a lot different from me,” Bow explains, “And I’ve never really understood or been able to connect with him like I can with most of my siblings.”

“Okay…” Adora says, putting her thumb and forefinger to her chin, clearly already in problem-solver mode, “So… what sort of things does he like? Why can’t you connect to him?”

“Well,” Bow struggles to explain, “He likes… black.”

“Like… the color?”

“Yeah… And he acts kind of like Mermista, but more…” Bow trails off.

Adora looks almost frightened as she says, “Disinterested?”

“Yeah…” Bow says. “As for what he’s interested in, I’m not really sure. You know, besides pictures of dead animals.”

“Eeg.” Adora grimaces, “Okay… Catra went through a phase like that when we were teenagers.”

“And?”

“Annnnnnd she… didn’t really talk to me for a while then. Said my soul was ‘too light’ for her.”

Bow chokes back a laugh, imagining teenage Catra with her mane of hair covering half of her face giving Adora a vibe check like that. “Well,” He says, “That does sound like the sort of thing Andrew would say.”

“Okay.” Adora says, “We need to make a plan. I’ll go get the posterboard.” And she runs off down the hallway before Bow can stop her.

“Hnnnnn…” Bow sighs and flops back into the couch. His tracker pad rings out, and he answers the call, seeing General Juliet on the other side.

“Bow? There’s someone here for you, shall I send him to the workshop?” The screen shows an image of a young man who would look strikingly similar to Bow were it not for the hunched posture, dark clothes that cover almost his entire body except where they’ve been artfully ripped, long, straightened black hair with red tips that is swept over one half of his face, red tinted sunglasses (Bow knows that at least that part of the ensemble is medically prescribed), and, most strangely of all, white lipstick.

“Yes, General,” Bow says, “It’s just my brother.”

“Very well,” The general says, and hangs up. Bow lifts the pillow out from under his head and places it on top of his head to yell into it.

Glimmer

Glimmer spends so much time in Bright Moon’s various conference rooms that she sometimes forgets that her real throne is here, in Bright Moon’s glorious throne room, hovering in front of and above one of the kingdom’s larger waterfalls.

Granted, her duty today isn’t too much more interesting than her standard fare. Today, she’s taking audience from the citizens of the Upper City of Bright Moon: The tall towers and districts built into the mountain that brush up against the Castle proper. What that means is that she is sitting in the throne room pretending to care about the menial complaints of rich people, while she could be hanging out with her friends or going on adventures.

“So you see,” One of her subjects is saying, “Children really have no place in our neighborhood.”

“I… don’t even know where to start with that one.” Glimmer admits with full candor for once. “Kids are annoying you by being kids, and your solution is to get rid of the kids? Make sure only childless families live in a whole neighborhood? No.”

“But, Your Majesty-”

“Get out! And buy some earmuffs if it bothers you so much.” Glimmer snaps. The man huffs and scuttles out of the throne room. “Anyone else have complaints like that?” Glimmer calls out to the remaining people awaiting an audience. There’s a murmur, but no one leaves. “Good.” She says.

Micah leans up from his own throne, set beside and below the throne of the Queen. “Don’t be too hard on them baby girl. Be happy that the problems you have to deal with are the problems of peacetime.”

Glimmer sighs, and is about to respond when she sees General Juliet walking into the throne room, holding a box and looking thoroughly gobsmacked.

"Your Majesty," The general says, "We, um, have a… foreign dignitary who wishes to speak to you."

"Okay?" Glimmer says, looking at the threshold, eager to have a break in hearing about unwaxed or overwaxed apartment hallways, "Where are they?"

"Uh, he's… right here." Juliet rotates the box in her hands, revealing one side is missing and the interior is lined with dark green velvet, making it look like a little theater.

And sitting in that box on literal toadstools are a trio of tiny mushroom people.

"Whaaaaat…?" Glimmer breathes.

"They're back. The ones from the dreams." Micah gasps, in the hollow voice that means he's momentarily lapsed into his Beast Island memories. "Stay back! My fingernails are mine!"

One of the mushroom pixies stands up. He has thick stumpy legs, a belly that makes the stalk of his torso look very lopsided, and a long beard made up of something that looks like very stringy hair. Atop his head is a porous morel mushroom cap that looks like a hole-filled pine cone. Atop that cap is an ornate crown crafted of tiny woven gold.

"Yer Majesty," he begins in a thick accent, "beggin yer pardon if we've come before ye on the wrong day, but the journey for us is quite long and harsh."

"Beca- Yes of course. You're not interrupting." Glimmer says, narrowly stopping herself from saying, '*Because your legs are so short,*' in response to his statement.

“Well tha’s good ta hear, yer Majesty.” The mushroom king says, “Ah suppose introductions are in order then. I, am King Mycinscus Lipimblistic V, sovereign ruler of the kingdom of Lilifungia. This,” He gestures to the mushroom pixie to his left, “Is my Royal Advisor, Pimbles Van Cordicep.” This pixie has a gray coloration to the speckled, domed cap on his head, and his stem body is streaked with green. He wears a set of matching mossy silver bracelets.

“And this,” The king continues, gesturing to the pixie on his right, “Is ma darling daughter, Princess Tabini Lipimblistic.” The princess is short and round, with a similar morel cap to her father, but rounder facial features and a thicker stem body.

“Lovely to meet you,” Glimmer says, actively trying not to act like she’s talking to a child, “I am Queen Glimmer, and this is my father, King Micah. Holding your box is our trusted General Juliet, and sitting over there,” She gestures to a smaller chair, flanked by guards wearing grey armor distinct from Bright Moon’s soldiers, “Is where Bright Moon City’s Chancellor, Torol Brannic, will sit when he returns.

“So, how can Bright Moon help Lilifungia?”

“Actually, Yer Majesty,” King Myciniscus says, “We seek to enter into an alliance with yer people, and we have brought a gift to show our sincerity.” The advisor, Pimples, looks up at General Juliet, who grumbles irritably for a moment before checking in with Glimmer, who nods.

She calls out, “Alright, the Queen says you can bring it in!” and a pair of guards comes in, each holding a small crate.

“Our gift to you,” Pimples explains, taking over for the king. Pimples has a lighter accent compared to the King’s thick brogue. “Is a delicacy from Lilifungia.” One of the guards pulls out a small barrel, about half the size of one of the pixies’ entire body. “We call it Spritz! It’s a delicious, sugary, fizzy beverage suitable for all ages, and perfectly enjoyable by all types of creatures.”

"Go ahead," Princess Tabini adds in an unexpectedly squeaky voice, "Try one! They're delicious!"

Glimmer nods to one of the guards to bring up a sample. While the guard is standing in front of her, obscuring the view of the Lilifungians, she casts a quick spell to detect poison. Fortunately, she finds none, so she opens the barrel and takes a sip of the foaming brew inside.

Her eyes widen. *It's delicious!* It has the sugary sweetness of a fruit punch, but a darker color and flavor, with a hint of vanilla.

"Oh my stars," Glimmer exclaims, looking down at Micah, who is taking his own first sip. She looks over at the thoroughly bemused Chancellor Brannic, freshly returned from the bathroom and looking supremely confused as one of his men fills him in on everything. After a moment, he takes a drink from the small barrel placed in front of him. While it's still not a smile, Glimmer doesn't think she's ever seen a more positive expression on that man's ruddy, bejowled face.

"I think," Micah says, "That the gift is very much appreciated, and Bright Moon would love to count the kingdom of Lilifungia amongst its allies."

King Lipimblistic bows deeply, "Ah appreciate yer words, and yer kindness. I hope we can one day return the favor. May this be the beginning of a long and bounteous friendship!"

Glimmer raises her almost-empty cup, "To Lilifungia!" She says, and takes another deep drink of the delicious soda.

Bow

"Sooo…" Bow says at long last, breaking the awkward silence that has pervaded through the space since Andrew entered the workshop. "Uhh… have you, done anything cool lately, Andre-?"

"Name's not Andrew anymore." Andrew huffs, "I go by Woe now."

‘*Woe? Really? Not only ridiculous, but also derivative of MY ACtUaL NaME!*’ is what Bow thinks.

“Oh, well that’s, uhh, cool for you?” Is what Bow says. He looks over at Adora, sitting in the corner of the room side-eying Woe with knit brows and a concerned expression.

“*Any ideas?*” He mouths to her.

“*Just… be normal?*” Adora mouths back, shrugging.

Like normal is going to work with him.

“So, uh… Woe,” Bow cringes when he says the name aloud. “It’s been a while since we’ve seen each other?”

“Yeah, what of it?” Woe responds, getting defensive for some reason.

“Well, I… guess we could catch up a bit?” Bow suggests, earning a sigh and an eye roll from Woe.

“Catch what up?” Woe says, “You’re like, famous now. Everyone on Etheria knows who you are.”

“Not really,” Bow responds, a little irked by that, “Just because they know my face and my name doesn’t mean they know me. I mean, I know your face and your name, and we even grew up together. But that doesn’t mean I know you at all.”

Woe’s eyes widen a bit before he snorts softly and turns away, idly twanging a tightly wound steel coil. “Whatever.” He mutters.

“So…” Bow tries again. Against his better judgement, he continues trying to connect with his brother. “What have you been up to since the war ended?”

“Same stuff I was up to before it ended.” Woe responds cagily. “Just living my own life, not worrying about anyone else.”

“O-kayyy,” Bow says, pinching the bridge of his nose, “But *what* have you been doing? Do you have a job? Or… hobbies?”

Woe just snorts, “Yeah. Doesn’t everyone?”

Bow is thrown for a loop by that response. *What does he mean? Doesn’t everyone have hobbies? Or a job? Or… what??*

“I don’t get it,” Adora says abruptly, “If you don’t want to talk to Bow, then why did you come here?”

“What?” Woe looks over to her, clearly a little startled.

“You came here of your own volition to see your brother, and now you won’t give him the time of day!” Adora exclaims indignantly.

“Pft. What do you know about it?” Woe snipes at her.

Adora raises her eyebrows and puts her hands on her hips. “I know basic manners, and I’ve met your parents, so I *know* you know them too. So why are you being so blah!? He’s your brother! You haven’t seen him in years, and the two of you obviously have a lot to learn about each other. Bow’s trying to reach out to you, so why not meet him half way?”

Woe turns to her with a somewhat petulant frown on his face. “Don’t talk to me that way! You- you don’t know me! You don’t know what I’m going through! So- so don’t act like you want what’s best for me, okay?”

Adora looks bemused and confused by that, but she takes a moment, closes her eyes, takes a deep breath, and steps back.

“Okay.” She says, “You’re right. That was rude. Uh- how about we start over. Hi, my name’s Adora.”

Woe scorns the proffered hand and just turns to look out the balcony, walking over towards the tarp-covered section that is still being rebuilt from Adora’s fight with Fygan.

“Yeah,” He says after a beat, “I know who you are. You’re She Ra. The most important person on the planet. Eeeveryone loves you, and you’re Bow’s best friend.”

Adora looks to Bow, seeming just as confused as he is. Bow looks back to Woe and asks, “What are you talking about? What do you have against Adora?”

Woe snorts. “She’s here. I don’t want her to be.”

Adora looks extremely hurt by that, and Bow feels defensive anger welling up at that. “If you didn’t want her here,” He begins, “You should have just asked to speak privately, instead of being so standoffish and mean.”

“It’s okay.” Adora says quietly. Bow looks over at her, and immediately stands up to go comfort her when he sees tears welling in her eyes. She looks at him and shakes her head. “I’ll leave you two alone.” She walks over to the door and hesitates before leaving. “I really would like to get to know you too, Andrew.” She says quietly before leaving the room.

The door swings shut with a soft thud, and Bow turns to look at his brother, who quickly turns to hide the fact that he was glancing at the door.

“Happy now?” Bow says confrontationally, “Are you going to talk to me now? Or just keep deflecting?”

Woe chews his lip before asking, “Can you give me a tour of the castle?”

Bow screams internally, and sighs externally. “Yeah,” He says, “I can do that.”

Adora

Adora tentatively steps into the meeting room. She knows that she technically has a right to attend any of Bright Moon’s

meetings, but she never does. Her brain can't handle the hours of proceedings and technicalities and debates the way Glimmer's can (just one of many reasons why Adora admires her). But that knowledge doesn't mean she doesn't feel out of place as she bashfully walks around the large table, feeling the focus of the room shift away from whoever is talking towards her.

"'Scuse me," She whispers to Chancellor Brannic as she squeezes past the rotund man's chair to take her own seat on the other side of Glimmer.

"Adora!" Glimmer whispers thinly as Adora's chair screeches when she scoots in, "What are you doing here?"

"I don't know!" Adora admits, "Catra's gone and Bow's with Woe and I don't have anything else to do!"

"Bow's with Woe?" Glimmer asks, clearly confused.

"His brother Andrew, says his name is 'Woe'." Adora says with a bit of a huff.

Glimmer's eyes widen as she says, "WHAT!?" at full volume, prompting stares and a not-so-subtle scoff from the Chancellor. "Sorry," She says, then turns back to Adora. "Bow's brother is here?? Why does nobody ever tell me anything!?"

"I'm sorry! I thought you'd know!" Adora responds bashfully.

"Ugh!" Glimmer flips her head back. "This is not fair. Bow can't keep keeping me away from his family."

King Micah leans in on Glimmer's opposite side. "What's this about Bow's family?"

"Bow's brother is here and he didn't even tell me!" Glimmer whispers, "But he told *Adora*."

"Hey!" Adora cuts in, "I'm right here."

“Your Majesties?” Chancellor Brannic cuts in smugly, “The delegates from Lilifungia were hoping for an introduction to our new guest.”

Adora looks out over the table to see everyone looking at the King, Queen, and her. The delegates from Lilifungia seem to be the trio of 6-inch tall mushroom people sitting in their own little elevated theatre on one of the seats.

“What the…” Adora mouths as she sees the Lilifungians for the first time. *Did I make those?*

“Of course!” Glimmer says, “Apologies for our rudeness. This,” She gestures to Adora, who jumps a little, “Is Princess Adora,” (Adora shuffles uncomfortably at the title) “Otherwise known as She Ra, Princess of Power.”

The mushroom people gasp in awe. The younger one on the right goes starry eyed.

“She Ra!” The one in the middle, seemingly the king, says. “What an honour it is ta meet ya. We’d heard tales of yer power and magnificence, but it is a privilege to be in yer presence.”

“Oh. I’d- I mean, No… It’s, like- whaaaat? I mean I guess it’s kind of a privilege.” Adora says, taking the flattery about as well as she always does. Glimmer elbows her, and she clears her throat. “I mean- thank you. It’s an honor to meet you as well. And you are..?”

“I,” Says the one in the middle with the intricate crown, “Am King Myciniscus Lipimplistic V. This is ma darling daughter, Princess Tabini Lipimblistic,” The plump girl on the King’s right gives a star-struck curtsy, “And this is ma Royal Advisor, Pimples Van Cordicep.” The gray-skinned mushroom man with the bright ruby necklace on the king’s left gives a bow.

Why do I get such a bad vibe from Pimbles??

“Adora,” Glimmer says, “You have got to try their Sprit!”

“I’ve gotta what-now?” Adora asks, clearly mis-hearing.

“Sprit!” The King repeats, “A gift from us ta you, a delicious beverage for yer enjoyment.”

Adora is bewildered as a small barrel is placed in front of her. She opens it to find a brown beverage that rapidly foams up and over the lip of the cup.

“Ope, oh no.” Adora says as she desperately tries to scoop the foam back into the cup. “Sorry,” She adds on. People are stifling giggles, it’s an embarrassing experience for all involved.

Once the foam dies down, she lifts it to her lips and takes a sip.

She can’t help the tiny grimace that comes next, and she hopes the cup hides it. She sets it down and swallows hard. “Its… nice.” She says, with effort.

The King’s eyes narrow, “Are… you sayin ye don’t like it?”

“No! No!” Adora says, “It’s just… uhhh, maybe it’s not for me?”

“We painstakingly crafted this brew to appeal to all types of humanoids,” King Lipimblistic replies haughtily. “Take another drink.”

“Uhmmm O-keeyyy…” Adora says, a tiny bit of sass in her voice as she takes another sip. As before, the mix of sweet and citrus just feels unpleasant in her mouth. “Mmmm!” She says as she swallows, “Delicious.” Even she can hear the odd cadence in her voice as she says it. *Why must he ask me to lie??*

“Hmph.” The King grumbles, “Well I suppose there’s no accounting for taste.”

“Hey!” Adora protests.

“Adora,” Glimmer growls through gritted teeth. “Just suck it up. They’re our allies.”

Lipimblistic is already pretending Adora isn't there, and addresses Glimmer. "So we thought," He says haughtily.

"Now hang on a minute!" Adora says, quite annoyed by the sudden obnoxious turn. "Don't you threaten Glimmer just because *one person* doesn't like your weird drink!"

The king glares at her, huffing and turning somewhat brown with indignation. To his right, Princess Tabini looks mortified. "Apologize." He seethes to Adora.

Adora looks to her left towards Glimmer, who has been glaring at her until she hears that word from the king. Now it's Glimmer's turn to get angry.

"No!" She says, "Adora has nothing to apologize for. She's absolutely right! You've started a ridiculous argument and gotten uppity because one person doesn't like your stupid drink. The rest of us love it, so what's your problem?"

"It's tha principle of the thing!" King Lipimblistic declares, ignoring his daughter's quiet pleas of "Be reasonable,"

"The principle of what?" Glimmer shouts.

"Guys, stop!" Adora exclaims, putting out her hands for peace. "Look, King Limpbizkit, Your Majesty, I'm sorry I don't like your drink, but you have to admit you overreacted."

The King ponders this for a moment as the advisor, Pimbles, stands up. Adora narrows her eyes. *'I don't like that guy… Why don't I like that guy?'* "Eh-His Majesty was merely expressing a shrewd judgement of character. If Princess Adora does not like our drink, it would have been more tasteful for her to say so, rather than making such an extended farce of the matter."

"Sooo-rry!" Adora says, "I was *trying* to be *nice*! That's something we do here that maybe the mushroom pixie people don't!"

King Micah buries his head in his hands. Princess Tabini gasps loudly and looks to her father, who has turned a shade of purple. His mustache is quivering with rage.

"Mmmmushroom?? *PIXIES??* How *DARE* you!? How DARE you!?" He bellows, his little voice echoing rather impressively.

Adora shies back, not out of fear, but out of shock. *But… That's what Juliet called them!* "I'm sorry!" She tries quietly.

"Yer Majesty," Lipimblistic turns to Glimmer, who looks just as confused and upset as Adora, "If ye've any respect for us as a people, or place any value upon our admittedly fresh alliance, ye'll have this… impudent boor removed from this meeting, and make an apology posthaste for her insult."

Glimmer's face goes stony, and Adora's stomach drops as she realizes what's coming next. "Wait, Glimmer. It's okay, I'll leave!"

"No." Glimmer stands, her eyes filled with cold fire. "I will not be ordered about or manipulated in my own palace. And if your alliance is conditional upon everyone liking your drinks, then I do not value it. I recognize your authority as leader of a sovereign nation, but you are in *my* court now, and you will stand down or be removed."

A silence fills the room. The king looks to Pimbles, who nods wordlessly.

"Very well," He says, "Our brief alliance is over. Ye'll be receiving correspondence soon on whether or not this will mean war." He sits down on his tiny throne, and presses a button. The little box theatre the trio are in shudders, and four spindly wooden mechanical legs pop out of the bottom and begin to stalk out of the room.

"They had those the whole time?" Juliet exclaims indignantly.

Brannic gives a smug look to both Adora and Glimmer. "Well," He drawls, "That may be a new record on Bright Moon's shortest

alliance ever.”

Adora looks to Glimmer, who meets her gaze with an equal amount of bashful regret. As the Lilifungians leave, a low, condescending voice comes from the door, where Bow and Woe are standing, the former looking shocked.

“Nice going, A-dork-a,” Is what Woe chooses to taunt her.

There’s a pregnant pause before Adora looks around the room and gives a tiny, “... sorry.”

Chapter End Notes

> Hope you enjoy part 1 of this all-new chapter! It’s a Catra-lite one. Comments and kudos are always appreciated!

Reunions and Refreshments, part 2: The Princess and the Politician

Chapter Summary

In which Brannic teaches Glimmer a lesson about politics, and Bow finds solace in building.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer

"Hnnnngggg whyyyy did I do that???" Glimmer groans into her desk, which her head is currently planted on.

"It's okay," Adora responds, who is pacing about the cramped, cluttered office that the two women are both recovering from their respective terrible decisions last night.

Bright Moon has not gotten word yet on whether the Lilifungians view Adora's dislike of their Sprit as worth going to war over, but given their general weirdness, Glimmer wouldn't be surprised.

'*There was something up with the king during that meeting.'* She can't shake that thought. Even before Adora had entered the room, he'd been ill-tempered in a way he hadn't been earlier that same day.

'*I already have enough on my plate with Fygan and this new Horde base in the Waste, now I have to worry about whether my kingdom is going to be attacked by little mushroom people??*' "ughhh!" Glimmer bangs her head on the desk.

"Do you think- Nooo no. It's too crazy." Adora says.

Glimmer's eye twitches. "If it's too crazy, then why'd you bring it up?" She hisses.

"Just thinking out loud!" Adora says defensively, "Sorry." There's a pause before she continues, "And where does that guy get off blowing up like that over nothing?"

"Why couldn't you just apologize?" Glimmer snipes.

"I did!"

"Well, then- why couldn't you just like the Sprit?" Glimmer turns to look at Adora, who purses her lips to one side and folds her arms. Glimmer snorts a little at herself. "Okay, I'll take that one back. No one handled the situation very well. Except my dad," She spins back around in her chair before teleporting over to her little day bed, sending a stack of form copies tumbling to the ground. "My dad knows what he's doing. I really need to hand the reins over to him. I know I'd be happier."

Adora walks over and lifts Glimmers legs up to sit down, before replacing her legs on her lap. "Glimmer," She begins genuinely, "You are the Queen of Bright Moon. Micah only has authority because you've chosen to let him keep it. And he didn't handle the situation very well either! He didn't say a word, just buried his head in his hands! I don't know that much about being a ruler, but I know you have to at least present a front of unity." Glimmer lifts her head to meet Adora's earnest, brilliantly blue eyes as she continues, "Glimmer, I'm really sorry. I messed things up in there. I could never do the things you do, and I'm so proud of you for doing them. And…" She goes suddenly pale and trails off.

"What is it?" Glimmer asks.

Adora gulps and squeezes her eyes shut as she says, "I think Angella would be proud of you too."

Glimmer understands why Adora hesitated to say that. She thinks back to that moment in the fallout of the attack on Salineas, when she and Adora were at each other's throats and, in a moment of

weakness, she'd said *"Well maybe your best isn't good enough, if it was, my mother would still be here!!*" She still remembers the look of utmost pain on Adora's face after she'd said it, and she imagines Adora remembers it just as well. Glimmer hoists herself up and wraps Adora up into a hug.

"Thank you," She whispers, "And you know what," She adds, almost conspiratorially, "I think you're right."

Adora smiles and lets out a teary laugh.

Suddenly, the door bursts open, and Glimmer spins around, aware that she was sitting in Adora's lap with her arms wrapped around her.

A guard is standing there, seemingly startled by how violently the door swung open.

"Faulty hinge," Glimmer explains, "What is it?"

The guard straightens up to stand at attention. "Your Majesty, Princess Adora. Chancellor Brannic wishes to see you. He says it's about the situation with Lilifungia."

What could Brannic know of it? "Thank you," She says, then grabs Adora, yanks her to her feet, and teleports both of them to Brannic's office.

Chancellor Brannic's office within the Castle, which he always refers to as his "auxiliary office", is one of the darkest rooms in the Castle. It's appointed with deep red upholstery and curtains, and the lighting crystals have beaded shades hung on them.

"Ah, your Majesty," says the balding, squat man on the opposite side of the rich mahogany desk, "And Adora, back here so soon." Adora looks around the room and grimaces.

"Well, what do you have for me Chancellor?" Glimmer asks.

Brannic motions for them to take a seat, and one of his personal guards pours three drinks. Adora looks at hers but does not drink, while Brannic takes a sip before saying, "I've a request to make of you, your Highness. I've drafted up a declaration of war for you to sign."

Glimmer chokes on her drink and sputters out, "Ephth-acgk! Ex*cuse* me!? A declaration of war? Against who?? Did the Horde make a move?"

Adora turns to her and says, "The Horde?" At the same time Brannic responds, "What? No. Lilifungia."

Both Glimmer and Adora look at him in slack-jawed disbelief for a moment before Glimmer asks, "You want me to approve an unprovoked declaration of war against Lilifungia?? Are you out of your mind, Brannic?"

Brannic raises an eyebrow. "Unprovoked? Your Majesty, have you not heard?"

Glimmer's expression drops, and she leans forward in her seat. "Heard what, exactly?"

Brannic takes another sip of his drink. "A shipment of Sprit arrived in the lower city earlier today. Upon distribution, it was discovered that the shipment was… tainted. It caused sickness and panic throughout the citizenry. Compounded with the fiasco last night, and many are calling for something to be done."

"The mushroom people poisoned us?" Adora says, instantly tensing. Glimmer thinks of Catra's sickness a few weeks ago.

"We don't know that for sure," Glimmer mediates.

"Oh I'm afraid we do," Brannic says, "We've had samples tested both physically and magically. There was poison in those barrels. It was a preemptive strike. We're fortunate that they must have messed up the dosage, and no one was truly harmed. Now, the task falls to you to decide how Bright Moon responds."

A chill runs down Glimmer's spine. "So if I don't declare war, my people see me as weak, and see you as their best representative! You want this war! You just want to get re-elected!"

Adora stands up in outrage as Brannic grins. "Your Majesty, please. My re-election campaign doesn't start for a few years yet. I'm actually thinking of you. A good, easily won war is a wonderful way to establish strength from a newly appointed monarch. My dear girl, do you really think your mother's early years of rule are not stained? There are whispers in the streets, and all you have to do to quell them is sign one little declaration, win this splendid little war, and put King Liplistic in his place."

Glimmer goes pale. Adora glares daggers at Brannic. Glimmer looks down at the sheet on his desk. "Thank you, Chancellor Brannic," she says as she reaches for the proffered quill. Adora gasps as Glimmer begins to sign off on the declaration. She looks Brannic in the eye the whole time, not caring if she misses the dotted line. "You've given me a valuable lesson today." She says coldly.

Brannic just smiles the most sinister yet earnest smile she's ever seen on his face. "Good. These are the lessons all great leaders must learn. You've made the right decision." He pulls the paper across the desk towards him. "I'll tell the people."

"Yeah, Glimmer hisses, "You do that." She finishes her drink, reaches up, grabs Adora's hand, and teleports them away.

Bow

"So…" Bow tries once more to break the awkward silence between himself and his brother, Woe. "Seen any… dead… animals lately?" He attempts, cringing at himself as he says it.

Woe actually seems to perk up slightly at that. "Yeah, actually," He says in the brightest tone Bow has heard him use since arriving at Bright Moon. "On my way here I found a goose's keel and both

wing bones, with flight feathers still attached! Once I get home I can clean it and hang it somewhere."

"Oh." Bow says, trying to prevent his fragile constitution from getting upset at that. His dads have all sorts of similar trophies that they've found, including fossils. This is just like a fossil! Only more… recent. "That's cool."

Woe's eyes widen, and then narrow suspiciously as he sinks back into his chair, folding his arms and looking away. "Yeah, whatever. Like you care."

Bow sighs. The two brothers are in one of Bright Moon's smaller lounge rooms, sitting in opposite armchairs looking at the fireplace. "Okay," Bow sighs, "I give up. I guess we can just sit in silence until you leave."

"Pff." Woe snorts, "Way to be hospitable, little guy."

Bow's eye twitches. *Little guy?? I've done so much more with my life than you could imagine. Three years younger, but decades more mature.*

"You know," Bow says as he stands up, "I wish I understood you. I really do. It makes me sad that I don't get you, because I want to be your friend, but you're not willing to meet me in the middle. And, I'm sorry, but if you're just going to sulk and not talk to me, then maybe you should go."

Woe looks up at him, wide eyed and dismayed. He sighs, and shrinks in on himself. He mutters something indistinct.

"What?" Bow asks.

"Fine." Woe repeats, "Whatever, I'll go." Bow recognizes that that isn't what he initially said, but he's too exasperated to push the matter.

"Okay." Bow says, "I'll let you pack up. How'd you get here? Is there a carriage waiting for you?"

"Yeah," Woe responds morosely.

Bow turns around. "Okay," He says sadly, "I guess that's that. Bye, I love you."

"Sure." Woe snaps.

Bow sighs and walks out of the room.

"Hey!" Woe calls down the hallway after him. Bow stops, and turns around to look at him. "It's not exactly easy for me either." He says. "You know, I leave home to do my own thing, don't see you for years, and then I see you for the first time being projected all across the world, and I find out you're some… hero of the Rebellion! You're best friends with She Ra, you're dating the Queen. You've been to the Fright Zone and the Crimson Waste and Beast Island… How am I supposed to not feel small around you. You've been to space! You're one of the foremost members of the Etherian Makers community. What have I done that can compare to that, huh? You think I'm just a weirdo, but…" Woe sighs and flips his hair, turning away from Bow. "This," He gestures to his dark, punkish appearance, "Is the only way I can feel like myself. You don't know how surreal it is to look up to your *younger* brother like that. Sorry I don't meet your expectations."

Bow stands there, eyes wide and watery, unable to formulate sentences. Woe sighs and walks back into the lounge, slamming the door behind him.

A nearby guard whistles. "Yiiikes." Bow glares at her. "Sorry," She says, shrugging. "That was the most entertainment I've had in weeks."

*****

Bow intended to go to his bedroom and talk about Woe with Glimmer, but instead his feet carried him to his workshop, where he is now tinkering idly with a new crossbow design for the Bright Moon guards. His trademark little fletching pole comes out of the back of the stock, and the crossbow itself has a compound design

with a built in nocking lever. It's a very powerful piece of equipment, though it needs some refining before it can be reproduced to roll out to the guards.

The door hinges squeak, and Bow looks up to one of the finely polished pieces of white metal that makes up the semi-functional teleporter taking up much of the room. Reflected in the metal is not Glimmer or Woe, but Adora.

"Hey, Bow," She says, "Where's An- uh, Woe?"

Bow sighs, "I think he's on his way out. We… had an argument."

Adora walks over and proffers a hand. Bow gives her the crossbow and she immediately begins hefting it, feeling the weight and balance, testing the speed of the lever and the amount of strength necessary to wield it. "An argument? What about?"

"The fact that we both want to be friends but neither of us understands each other."

"If you both want to be friends then why argue?" She pulls on the lever and frowns. "It cranks up and back easily enough but gets stuck going back down," She observes. With her foot, she pulls over a small wheeled table, grabs a notepad and makes a note of that defect for him.

"Thanks," Bow says, then continues, "Well, because neither of us can communicate with the other. I don't understand why he's so negative on everything and everyone, and he's… I don't know… the way he talked made it seem like I intimidate him."

K-THANG!! An arrow punches a small hole in a scrap of sheet metal in the corner of the room. Adora examines the crossbow's trigger. "You intimidate him?" She looks over at Bow, "How? Your intellect? Ingenuity? Bravery? Skill?"

"All of the above," Bow confirms with utmost humility.

“Huh. Well I get that,” Adora says, “Even before I was She Ra I was still the highest scoring cadet in my group in the Horde. I didn’t have any friends outside of Catra, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. I tried, but people always shied away.”

“Sure,” Bow says as Adora takes another note, “But I don’t have Catra being jealous around me or Shadow Weaver breathing down my neck.”

“Fair,” Adora concedes as she walks over to the corner, grabs a plank of wood, and sets it up as a target. “But you are dating the queen, and your best friend is She Ra,” She flexes her arm, and her bicep radiates golden energy.

Bow rolls his eyes, then pauses. “That’s exactly what he said.” He mutters.

“If you guys both want to be friends, you will be, eventually. As long as you both keep trying to find common ground, you’ll figure it out. I think it’s less you than it is the space,” Adora says, firing the crossbow at the wood. The plank partially splits from the impact, but she frowns. “The trigger has the same problem as the lever. Gets stuck if you pull it too hard.” She makes another note.

“What do you mean the space?” Bow asks.

“I think you need to get out of Bright Moon.” Adora clarifies, “Maybe go to the Library, or… Seaworthy. Somewhere where Andr- Dang it! Where *Woe* won’t be intimidated.”

Bow thinks about that for a moment, bringing his forefinger and thumb up to his chin, mirroring something Adora does all the time.

“Hey, Bow?” Adora says, putting the crossbow down and turning towards him, “Do you have any advice for me? I kinda started a war.”

“You st- I- WHAT!?” Bow squeaks.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and Kudos are always appreciated.

Reunions and Refreshments, Part 3: A Splendid Little War

Chapter Summary

> In which the Mushroom Kingdom of Lilifungia and Bright Moon prepare to make war, and there's only one chance to stop the violence.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

Adora, Bow, and Glimmer stand on the parapet in front of the entrance to Bright Moon's Throne Room, looking out over the lagoon to the edge of the Whispering Woods. Where once Catra had staged a Horde Invasion, now the slopes and crags are host to a massive army of tiny soldiers, clearly thousands strong, but still less than a foot tall each.

"Your Majesty," General Juliet says from behind them, where she, Micah, Brannic, and Woe are also assembled. "Do you… want to assemble the guard?"

"No," Glimmer says, "We'll handle this."

Glimmer grabs Adora and Bow to teleport out. At the last second, Adora sees Bow flinch, and they teleport to the end of the bridge across the lagoon.

"What are you doing!?" Bow whispers. Adora turns to see that the flinch was Woe grabbing him.

"Getting a head start on leaving," Woe responds snarkily, "What, do you want me to run and hide?"

“That would be smarter!” Bow snaps.

“Shush!” Glimmer says sternly, as a large crab-like creature with luminescent fungal growths across its shell stalks onto the bridge. Seated on a platform on its back are King Myciniscus, Princess Tabini, Pimbles, and a fourth figure, a significantly taller (8 inches) Lilifungian woman wearing a suit of chitinous armor. Her mushroom cap is bright red with white splotches, and is somewhat torn on one side, as if a small creature had tried to eat it.

The crab stops about twelve paces away from them, and Myciniscus stands proudly. He is wearing a clearly ornamental suit of tiny, ornate metal armor.

“Queen Glimmer,” He expectorates, “Where is yer army? Are we ta march on yer kingdom unopposed? Ah won’t do such a dishonourable thing lightly, but ah’ll do it all the same.”

Glimmer smiles and puts a hand on her cocked hip. “I wouldn’t exactly say unopposed…” She holds out one hand and summons her staff.

Taking that as her cue, Adora holds a single hand aloft and cries, “For the Honor of Grayskull!!”

There’s a flash of gold light that the Lilifungian delegation has to avert their eyes from, and She Ra stands tall over the bridge. Princess Tabini looks at her with wide, sparkling eyes. Adora winks at her, and the little mushroom girl faints a little.

The Lilifungian advisor, Pimbles, stands up next to his king. “You think a single warrior can defeat our entire army?”

“A *single* warrior!?” Glimmer says indignantly, “Hellooo!” She waves her staff, “I’m as powerful as She Ra, if not more!”

Wellllll…

“And Bow can certainly hold his own as well!” She adds, less passionately.

“Gee, thanks,” Bow says, clearly in a mood and currently trying to stand in front of his irate brother.

The king huffs, and raises a tiny fist, “Ye have left us no choice, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon. General!” The taller woman looks down at him, “Order the attack.” She reaches down to her side and pulls out a war horn and presses it to her lips.

“Stop!!” An unexpectedly loud voice rings out to Adora’s left. She looks down to see Woe has pushed Glimmer and Bow aside and has a hand outstretched towards the Lilifungians.

“What??” Pimbles and Myciniscus say in unison.

“Who is this??” The king says to Glimmer, “Does he speak for you?”

“My name is Andrew,” Bow’s brother says, pushing the partially dyed lock of hair out of his face, “And I speak for myself. Look, I only saw part of the argument, but come on. You know as well as I do that, honor or not, throwing away the lives of thousands of your own citizens over something so petty is stupid.”

“Wha-! Huff! How dare you!” The king blusters.

“Pretty easily,” Andrew responds, “Because apparently I’m the only one here who still sees the small picture.” He walks out into the middle ground between both delegations. He looks at Glimmer and Adora. “You guys were seriously ready to fight them? Yeah, they’re small, but they’re still people! Doesn’t that mean something to you anymore?”

Adora looks at Glimmer, ashamed. *I was ready to just waste an entire army… why? Just to feel strong again? Like the old days?*

Andrew turns to the Lilifungian delegation. “And you, your Majesty, why are you so determined to have war? Didn’t you come

to Bright Moon seeking peace?”

“And they spat in mah face!” the king answers.

“They accepted your gifts, but not everyone has the same tastes in drinks. Just like not everyone has the same tastes in anything. Look at your daughter. She idolizes She Ra, and you’re trying to make your whole country her enemy!” The king looks to his daughter, his face softening. She goes purple and turns away shyly. “If your daughter didn’t like Sprit, would you declare war on her?”

“Of course not!” The king says, “B- but that’s different. We’re family.”

Andrew looks to Princess Tabini. “Do you like Sprit?” He asks.

The princess pauses, then squeaks, “N-no… I think it’s kinda dull.” The king gasps.

“See!” Andrew points to Adora, “When Adora didn’t like it, you turned it into a huge deal! But everyone likes different things. People like different drinks, different foods, different clothes and books. People like different kinds of music and different hairstyles. Some people like making art, some people don’t. But that’s not what matters. What matters is that we’re all people. We all have our own lives. And if you’re willing to throw away the lives of your people over a petty difference in taste, then you’re not just a bad king… you’re a bad *person*.” King Myciniscus recoils at that, falling into his seat. “So,” Andrew pushes, “Do you really want to be a bad person? Or do you want to accept that everyone is different, and just let it be water under the bridge.” On his last point, he gestures to the literal swelling current of water passing beneath them.

The king thinks for a long moment, many emotions and thoughts that Adora can barely parse dancing across his tiny face. Pimbles is looking to the king intently and fingering a ruby necklace he’s wearing. She can hear muffled sniffles coming from Bow to one

side of her, and she understands why. '*I wonder if Andrew meant for that speech to target him, too,*' She thinks, but her question is answered by the furtive glance Andrew gives Bow over his shoulder.

"Yer right." King Myciniscus says quietly. "Ah thought that, if we went to war, it would make ye respect us more. Make the world respect us more. But we are a wee people, and it was foolish of me to try to force us into being something we're not. General, order the troops ta stand down."

The general nods, but Pimbles suddenly lunges at the king. "NO!" The advisor cries, "No! You mustn't! We must prove our strength! Why have you stopped heeding my commands!"

Tahini and the general gasp as Pimbles pauses, and looks at Andrew. "Uh… was that out loud?" He says. Andrew nods. "Oh… poop." Pimbles says. "Welp, time for plan B!" He shrugs and pulls out a knife, then lunges at the King's throat.

Myciniscus topples backwards over his chair, and the Lilifungian general tackles Pimbles, tossing the knife aside and pinning him to the ground.

"Wait a minute," Adora says, taking a step forward, "You were magically influencing his decisions? So you're the one who made him take it so personally! You started the whole weird war!"

"Of course I did!" Pimbles spits as the General hefts him to his feet and puts a pair of tiny handcuffs on his equally tiny wrists.

"I KNEW IT!" Adora says, leaping in the air and pumping her fist triumphantly, "I *knew* something was off about you!!" She turns for a high five from Bow, only to see both he and Glimmer giving her scathing looks. "Oh, sorry," She says meekly, "Timing."

"But… Pimbles," The king says shakily, emerging from behind his toppled throne. "Why?"

Pimbles cackles mirthlessly. “Why?? Why, my lord, I did it for you! Your whole rule you’ve been *weak*. I was trying to make you show our people that we are strong. To prove we have a place as part of this world! Not just hiding beneath it.”

“Well,” Glimmer says, walking forward and kneeling in front of the crab bearing the Lilifungian delegation, “You’re right about one thing. The kingdom of Lilifungia *does* have a place in this world. Your Majesty,” She extends a hand out towards King Myciniscus, “If you’re still willing, Bright Moon would be honored to restore our alliance.”

Myciniscus stands, brushing himself off and straightening his crown. “Aye,” He says, reaching out both hands to firmly grasp Glimmer’s index finger, “The honour is ours.”

The two monarchs shake hands, and the Lilifungian General signals her troops to stand down. A massive sigh of relief goes up among the army.

The crab bearing the royal delegation turns around, and begins to scuttle away, but Adora calls out, “Princess Tabini!” The Lilifgungian princess turns around, her eyes wide. Adora smiles. “I love your dress,” She says earnestly, earning a face of bright violet blush and a deep curtsy from the princess.

“Thank you!” She squeaks, “Ah love your crown!”

“Thank you!” Adora smiles.

The Lilifungian army begins to file into the Whispering Woods, and Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Andrew watch King and Princess Lipimblistic vanish into the woods, returning to their kingdom to share the news of peace.

‘*Peace won by Andrew,’* Adora thinks, turning to thank Bow’s brother. But he’s already walking back across the bridge, a black hood raised over his head and his bearing downcast.

Bow looks after him, clearly conflicted. Adora puts a hand on his shoulder and lets She Ra fade. “Go to him,” She says. He meets her gaze, then looks to Glimmer, who gives an encouraging nod. His eyebrows set in determination, and he turns to catch up to his brother.

Bow

“Andrew! Woe! Wait! Stop!” Bow calls out to his shockingly fast-walking brother.

Andrew finally pauses his long stride and holds there, not looking over his shoulder to where Bow is practically running to catch up.

“Wait… Wheew… why do you walk so fast??” Bow says, panting from the unexpected exertion.

“What?” Andrew (*Or Woe? I’m not really sure right now*) says bluntly.

“Can we talk?” Bow says, “What you did back there, what you said-“

“Forget it.” Andrew says, and starts walking again.

“Wait!” Bow calls out, reflexively grabbing Andrew’s wrist.

“Let go of me!” Andrew says, trying to pull away. Even though he’s not even trying that hard to hold Andrew back, Bow has significantly more strength than his brother. He lets go, and Woe staggers back, glaring at him, the flop of his bangs once more covering half his face. “Gah! What do you want!? First you wanna get rid of me, then I save your butts, and now what? You wanna be friends??”

“I always wanted to be friends!!” Bow shouts back. Woe’s visible eye widens in shock. Bow realizes that his eyeliner is heavily smudged from recently wiped tears. “Andrew, or… Woe, or whatever you want me to call you,”

“Andrew’s fine…” He mutters.

“Okay. I want to be friends with you. I miss my brothers so much, and I know you and I were never especially close but… That makes me want to get to know you more, not less.”

Andrew has his arms crossed and is looking at the ground. “Really? I was… not great to you. When we were kids…”

Bow shrugs, “I remember, but you didn’t do any permanent damage, and… I’m a pretty forgiving person. My girlfriend almost destroyed the world, and I couldn’t even hold *that* against her.” Andrew snorts a little, clearly suppressing a smile. Bow smiles and pushes forward, “I do want to know you better, but… I can’t do that unless you let me.”

Andrew shuffles on his feet, rocks back and forth, turns his head to look out over the water, rubs his arm, and takes a deep breath before saying, “Dad kicked me out.”

Bow recoils, shocked and confused. “You were living with them??”

“I lost my place when everyone got chipped. I… moved into the library but… Lance… told me that if I was gonna live there… I’d… have to pay rent and…”

“And you don’t have a job.” Bow finishes sadly. Woe closes his eyes and flips his hair.

“Yeah,” He affirms, “Haven’t been able to get one.”

“And Dad...”

Andrew shrugs, “You know how he gets about laziness… We got in a big fight because I… accidentally let slip that I wasn’t actively looking for a job.”

“Do you think he really meant it?” Bow asks gently, “When I talked to them he seemed fine.”

Andrew shrugs, “I dunno, but I don’t think I’m gonna go back there even if I am welcome.” He turns and sits down on the stone railing of the bridge. The sun is beginning to set, and the two of them watch the colors begin to dance across the lagoon as night begins to fall and the sky comes alive with motes of light, both magical and celestial.

“Where will you go?” Bow says, sitting down beside him.

Andrew just shrugs noncommittally.

“Well…” Bow thinks for a moment, “What are your skills?”

“Hm.” Andrew lets a breath out through his nose, “I guess I’m a good artist… I’m good with animals… I was a masseuse for a little while… I don’t know what I want to do or where I want to go.”

“Well…” Bow ponders, “You proved to be quite a natural at conflict mediation back there. What if you lived here?”

Andrew turns to regard him, weighing whether he’s serious, which, of course, he is. “Here, like, Bright Moon?”

“Yeah, I don’t know if we have any positions open like… in the castle, but there are always jobs in the City, and if need be I *may* be able to pull a few strings for you. Don’t tell anyone but I’ve got some pretty powerful connections.”

Andrew snorts and genuinely laughs at that before he can stop himself. He lightly punches Bow’s shoulder.

“Thanks,” He says, “I’ll… I’ll think about that.”

“Well, you’re welcome to stay here as long as you need,” Bow assures him, “We have quite a lovely prison cell.”

“What??”

“It’s an inside joke, our prison is a guest room.”

Glimmer

Glimmer has spent days with minimal sleep. With the situation concerning Lilifungia stabilized, she's changed tack, and worked herself to the bone trying to discover everything she can about this potential threat in the Crimson Waste, but she's come up empty over and over. She's been without her friends, and has had to suffer politics and bickering. Her eyes hurt from long hours pouring over records and maps with nothing but her pink light orbs to see by.

But now, she finally gets a break. She's playing a board game with her friends. Magopoly stretched on for hours, but Andrew, freshly appointed Cultural Ambassador to Lilifungia, pulled off a late game victory. Next they played a goofy card game that had them all in hysterics until Andrew headed off to properly unpack into his new apartment. Glimmer, Bow, and Adora then spent the rest of the night lying on the grass of one of the garden balconies, looking up at the stars and nibbling from the remainder of the cake they'd brought in for game night.

The three lie head to head in a triangle, holding each others' hands and talking about nothing in particular.

Heavy is the head that wears the crown, but it feels a lot lighter when Glimmer has her friends around to help bear it.

Mermista

Mermista can't get her right eye to stop twitching.

This is understandable, of course, as her second favorite Yacht is currently smouldering atop a cliffside just outside Salineas.

"Honestly, not even mad," Mermista lies to the sheepish-looking pair of ne'er do wells standing side to side, their hands clasped behind their backs. "Really just more concerned as to how you got it up there."

"Well, *we* didn't," Sea Hawk explains, "That was the work of the Sea Serpent."

"Riiiiiight." Mermista drawls, "And why was a Sea Serpent so far out of its natural hunting grounds?"

"We tossed our ship's cargo to escape from Scurvy," Catra chimes in, "And we didn't know our cargo was… Sea Serpent musk."

Mermista pinches her nose and points at Catra with her other hand, "I thought you hated the water."

"Oh I do!" Catra confirms enthusiastically, then adds with a wicked grin, "Scurvy's janitor can attest to that!" She turns and high-fives Sea Hawk.

"Mmmmthanks, hate that." Mermista snarks, "Alright. The two of you are too chaotic to stay together. I'm calling Glimmer."

"Booo!" Catra says.

"Hey!" Mermista snaps as she pulls out a communicator, "You're on thin ice young lady. Wait, what? I'm not your mother! UGGGHHH!!" She groans as Catra sticks out her tongue and high fives Sea Hawk again. "Stop high fiving her!" She orders.

"Whyy?" Sea Hawk wines, "I haven't had a friend who matches my exuberance in so long!"

"You are lucky I love you!" Mermista says.

"It's a shame you're sending Catra away…" Sea Hawk remarks coyly, leaning over to his right side "She took note of a rather fine cask of brandy in Scurvy's hold."

"And I stashed it on a sandbar not too far away…" Catra finishes, popping out from Sea Hawk's left.

I do like fine brandy… Mermista thinks on this proposition.

“Hello?” A very tired Glimmer answers the call, “Mermista?”

Mermista says, “Alright, I’ll bite.” And hangs up the call.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! After this the upload schedule should return to normal. Comments and kudos are always appreciated! Hope you enjoyed!

Baking With She Ra, Part 1: Discovery of the Gift

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra discovers she has a special talent, and Glimmer works herself to the bone while Bow worries about her.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra awakens from a rumbling stomach. She extricates herself from Adora's arm, places a gentle kiss on the blonde, and stands from the bed and stretches. Melog remains asleep. She puts on a shirt, pads to the door, and walks out. Her footsteps barely register in the hallways of Bright Moon as she walks towards the kitchen. She yawns as she rounds a corner, stretching out her arms above her head and closing her eyes. She immediately regrets this decision as she walks right into someone else, who jumps a little.

"Bah!" She staggers back, shaking her head, and immediately widening her eyes.

She'd walked right into King Micah of Bright Moon.

"Oh! Uh, hi. I mean, sorry. Sir. Uh, Your Majesty?" She cycles through a couple different salutes, then settles on a half bow, half salute that she knows leaves her looking just like the sort of mess Adora tends to be.

Micah simply nods, "Hello Catra." His mood is somber, and he turns back to the wall, which he is looking at.

Catra looks up at the wall, and a chill runs through her. Micah is gazing at a large stylized mural of himself and Queen Angella. *Oh no. Nonononono I shouldn't be here.*

"Sorry for bothering you, I was just…" She slowly, awkwardly scoots around him and begins to speed up her footsteps.

"No, please. Stay a moment." Micah calls. Catra freezes, and slowly turns around. The king gestures for her to join him. Reluctantly, she does, and he begins to speak. "You never would have met Angella, would you? Glimmer tells me that Angie had long since stopped fighting in person by the time you came around."

"Uh… no." Catra says awkwardly. "Aside from our training holograms, I only ever saw her once."

"Really? When was that?"

Catra chuckles nervously and scratches the back of her head, "Uh, at the Battle of Bright Moon. When I… tried to destroy the Moon Stone."

"Ah." Micah says. He doesn't sound angry though.

"Yeah. She was at the top of the tower, keeping the Runestone safe all by herself. It was… impressive." Catra says, looking up at the mural. "She must have been a force to be reckoned with back when she did fight."

Micah laughs, "You have no idea."

Catra thinks back to the thorough thrashing she'd received from Glimmer when she'd inherited the full might of the Moon Stone. '*I think I might.*'

There's a pause, before Micah quietly says, "I forgive you."

Catra's heart rate goes up, and she takes a step back, "W-what?"

"For what you did. For activating the portal. I remember bits and pieces of it, and your friends have told me a few other details. I was angry, at first, but now…" He turns to her, "I don't blame you. You may have activated that portal, but Angie made her own decision." He closes his eyes and sighs, "Just like I made mine. No one is to blame for her sacrifice."

Catra's eyes are stinging with tears, and she turns and speedwalks down the hall without another word. She's also suddenly aware that she just had that emotional conversation with Micah while wearing one of Adora's shirts and her underwear.

Hunger overwhelms whatever feelings she was having from that talk by the time she reaches the kitchen, and she walks in, looking around for anyone there. Feeling safe, she turns on the lights, which slowly brighten, giving her eyes time to adjust. She wanders around, checking drawers for any snacks. She munches on a few crackers, but the salt isn't what she's going for.

Something sweet… She opens the pantry, and pulls down a small box with pictures of cookies on it. She uses a claw to rip open the top, and is surprised to find not cookies, but a back of powder inside. Confused, she looks at the back of the box, and sees instructions for baking the cookies using the mix.

"Huh." She shrugs, and walks over to one of the cabinets to retrieve a bowl. Some more searching yields a measuring cup, and she grabs a few eggs to complete what she needs.

The process begins as she tears through the bag and pours it into the bowl with a puff of powder that she waves away from her face. She cracks in the eggs, adds roughly the right amount of water, and dumps in the little packet of cinnamon, and begins stirring until it starts to form a mostly solid ball of cookie goop. She ransacks the kitchen some more until she finds a baking sheet, and begins to form the little balls the box says to make. She plops them down on the sheet, not bothering to measure out the "proper" distance between them, and then turns on the oven. She waits until it's hot enough (the oven is one brought over from

the Fright Zone that actually displays the temperature on a gauge), then slides the tray in and sits down in front of the oven, watching the cookies bake.

When they look ready, she grabs a mitt and pulls them out, filling the room with the delicious scent of cinnamon and cookie. She places them on the counter, and goes starry eyed looking at them. Most of them have glomped together as a result of her haphazard placement, but they look *delicious*. After a few minutes, she grabs one and gingerly takes a bite.

Catra melts into a puddle of happy kitty on the floor. *It's incredible. One of the best things I've ever eaten. And I made it myself!*

She chows down on several more, then grabs the tray and rushes out of the room.

Micah, still at his post, looks at her curiously as she spins past him.

"Want a cookie?" She asks breathlessly, then shoves two into his hands without waiting for a response.

She kicks open the door to her room. "Adora? Wake up!"

"Bah!" Adora leaps to her feet, pulling a knife from under her pillow and looking for intruders. "Catra?" She looks to the door as the feline jumps onto the bed and jabs a cookie into her open mouth. "Wha- mmmmmm" Adora melts into smiles as she devours the treat. "Where'd you get theshe?" She asks, mouth already full of her next cookie.

"I made them!" Catra announces happily, and Adora's eyes go wide.

"YOu wHAT??" Adora gapes at her, surreptitiously grabbing one of the lumps of congealed cookie mass.

Catra nods happily. She hasn't felt this excited in… well, ever. She's *good* at something! Not something that relates to war, or leading people, or anything. It's how she felt when she turned out to be a natural at sorcery, only better, because being good at this means cinnamon cookies with her girlfriend at 3 in the morning.

Adora gasps and grabs Catra into a tight hug. "Iloveyousomuchrightnow!" She squees.

Melog trots up and grabs a cookie, leaning back and biting it, then turning a happy green and waving their head back and forth, sending Catra telepathic messages of delight and approval.

Catra smiles, looking at the two of them be so happy from the cookies. '*This is amazing. I wanna do more of this.'*

Glimmer

Glimmer kicks the footstool, which slides across the floor, causing Bow to wince. "*Why* does Brannic have to be *right* all the time!?!?" She falls face first onto the bed and shouts into the covers.

"Ummmm…" Bow begins, "Because he's been Bright Moon's chancellor for like, 36 years?"

"Rhetorical question Bow!" Glimmer says, muffled.

"Sorry."

"Hhhh." She teleports up to her old bed and sits with her legs dangling off the edge. "I know what I want to say, and I know what's going on, but whenever I'm in those meetings with him and the others, even my dad! I just- Ughhhhhh." *I'm not making sense.*

"Why don't you get some help?" Bow asks.

"From who?" She scoffs in response.

Bow paces the room, "I don't know. Someone who's a lot like you and can pick up on your cues. That way Brannic and the others wouldn't be able to shut you down so easily. Like… like a second head!" He holds his hands beside his face in a rough head-shape.

Someone a lot like me… "Catra!"

Adora

"Alright." Catra begins. The two of them are in their room, with Adora and Melog sitting on the bed, and Catra pacing in front of them like an officer briefing her soldiers. "The kitchen is empty after supper, but any other times we can't be sure the staff aren't gonna be there, and I don't know if we're actually allowed to use it."

"Uh- we?" Adora asks, holding up a finger.

"Duh. If I'm gonna get more skilled at this, and start making my *own* recipes, I'm gonna need an assistant, and if nothing else, you're good at following orders."

"Heyyyyyy. That's rude."

"I'm sorry, I love you. But am I wrong?"

Adora raises a finger of protest and sputters, "Pft. Ab-tha-I'mna… No…"

"Exactly." Catra resumes pacing, "So. Here's the plan. We sneak in after nightfall, Melog can keep us invisible and cloak our sound once we're in. Then, we get to work. I'm gonna start baking everything I can find to get a better understanding of what I'm working with, and you are going to be my beautiful and loyal assistant."

"Awe, you think I'm beautiful?" Adora asks fawningly.

Catra rolls her eyes, "Obviously. I also think you're an idiot." Adora pouts. "Pay attention, this is important. We need to be prepared

for anything. This mission *has* to go off without a hitch, and definitely without Glimmer or Bow finding out because they will be un*bearable* if they learn about this."

Bow

Bow is walking back to his room late in the evening after having a solid streak of work getting done when he hears sounds of distress coming from the kitchen. Raising an eyebrow, he sneaks to the door, hearing a muffled exchange between two familiar voices.

"Well then turn on the faucet!"

"Adora! That'll flood the kitchen!"

"Well water is better than *fire*!"

"You know that's not true! Melog, get down from there!"

"*Mreeeeoooullllhr*."

With that, Bow opens the door and takes in the disastrous tableau before him. Catra is perched on the counter, surrounded by bowls and boxes, one of which has some puffy white substance that has exploded out like a cloud and takes up several cubic feet. Adora, in She Ra form, is frozen in place staring at him, standing in front of one of the ovens, which is wide open and very much on fire. Melog is in miniature form, clinging onto one of the hanging crystal lights with their claws. There's a moment of complete silence before one of the cabinet doors falls off its hinges with a clatter.

"Ummmmm…" Bow holds his hands up, "I'll just… go…"

He takes a step back, and Catra jabs a finger towards him, shouting, "Don't let him leave! Get him!"

Bow spins around and bumps into an illusion of a wall behind him, and Melog pounces on him, bringing him to the floor.

“Melog, keep him there. Adora! Put out the fire.”

“Oh! I forgot! I know a spell to do that now!”

From his vantage point pinned to the floor, Bow sees Catra hop down from the counter and walk towards him. Melog hops up, and he gets to his feet.

“Not a word about this to anyone, got it Arrow Boy?” Catra hisses.

“What even is ‘this’?” Bow asks, his voice cracking a tiny bit.

“Catra and I were baking!” Adora says excitedly as she experimentally summons a rune. She lets out an adorable gasp as a spray of water douses the flames in the oven, releasing a load of steam that begins to fill the room. Catra shoots her a stink-eye, and She Ra fades away into Adora. “Whaaat? Come on, he was gonna find out eventually.”

Catra baking?? Catra baking with Adora? Sneaking into the kitchen in the dead of night to… bake? Bow feels himself beginning to swell with excitement. Catra looks at him and her face twists into bemusement, “Ohhhh no. Don’t say it. Don’t say it!”

“That,” Bow says with surprising restraint, “Is the cutest thing I’ve ever heard.” Catra blushes, and inhales to shout at him, but he cuts her off with, “Now I’m going to help you clean up and get back to it.”

Catra moves her jaw for a moment, at a loss for words, then huffs and rolls her eyes. “Fine. Just… Don’t be weird about it.”

The four of them get to work fixing the kitchen. Bow uses it as a chance to bust out the second spell he learned, a very small-scale repair spell. Not nearly powerful enough to fix the scorched oven or even the cabinet, but enough to mend a few broken bowls. After cleaning up completely, they leave, adjourning to a nearby balcony to get some fresh air.

“So,” Bow begins, looking at Catra, “baking, huh?”

Catra blushes, "Yeah. I guess I just finally found something I'm good at. At least… something that doesn't…" She trails off, but Bow knows the sentence ends with *'doesn't involve hurting people*.' Adora takes her hand and smiles.

"Well. I have to go talk to Glimmer, but I look forward to experiencing more of your work." Bow smiles, and squeezes Catra's shoulder. She looks up at him with a tender, adorable smile, and he stands and leaves.

*****

His next task that night is not nearly so fun. Glimmer isn't in their room, so he heads over to her office and opens the door. It's dark, as usual, lit with various orbs of pink sparkles. Glimmer is passed out on her desk, a wide variety of documents laid out in front of her. Bow walks up and takes a look. There are maps and descriptions of the area surrounding the old castle at Mount Candila. Picking one of the maps up, his brows raise.

"That's not good…" He mutters, looking at where the large First Ones ruin is marked, only a tiny bit deeper into the mountains than the castle. If those Horde Remnants do wind up being hostile, that place probably contains enough First Ones tech to let them pose a serious threat using Entrapta's old designs.

He picks up a book open on Glimmer's desk. It's a list of known First Ones ruins and their purposes, compiled by Bow's dad Lance. Skimming through, he comes upon a page with a very similar location.

He reads over the document. This one is mostly bullet points and notes, just like most of the ruins his dads hadn't been to in person.

Referred to in some writings as the 'Temple of Creativity', or possibly 'Creation'. Believed to be home to the First One's experiments with the Rune Stones.

Also found a piece of writing referring to this location as 'The Forge', in relation to the She Ra legend. This is likely where her legendary Sword would have been created. Scrawled in the margins is a secondary note. *Now that we know She Ra's sword was a Runestone, this theory seems even more likely.*

New information about Mount Candila and the princess who once lived there indicates that earlier theories were correct. This facility is almost certainly where the First Ones created the artificial Spirit Ember rune stone, and could be home to untold other experiments and knowledge related to Rune Stones and the princesses.

Location is known, but the ruin is inaccessible, any paths through the mountains are long gone, and the Forge is likely long since buried, if it is even still intact.

Bow places the book down, and taps Glimmer on the shoulder. She does not rouse, so he gently lifts her out of the chair and into his arms. She stirs, and he knows she's woken up, but she allows herself to enjoy being carried back to their room.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, comments and kudos are always appreciated! Hope you enjoyed.

Baking With She Ra, Part 2: Giving of the Gifts

Chapter Summary

In which Adora has a birthday and Catra hones her talents.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer

Glimmer has a lot on her plate. Attempts to contact the Horde Remnants at Mount Candila had yielded no results, and Chancellor Brannic continues to protest the abandoning of outposts near the Fright Zone. On top of that, she has to deal with preparations for her upcoming trip to outer space, relations with the other kingdoms, a rise in piracy, and various other issues. But her most important task right now is planning for Adora's birthday party. Per the blonde's wishes, they're having two parties. One will be open to everyone and will be more of a celebration of She Ra, while the other will just be Adora and her close friends.

Glimmer teleports around the castle, making sure all the decorations are in order for the big party. Meals and snacks are being planned, and the big reveal is almost complete.

Now, to worry about the smaller party. She teleports to Catra's room, startling the drowsing catgirl.

"Is Adora here?" Glimmer asks.

"Next time, knock." Catra says, "For your own good." She stands up and stretches, "And no, she isn't. Why, what's up?"

"Good. I have a job for you. As you know Adora's birthday is coming up,"

"Still not sure what that is."

"And there are gonna be two parties. I want you to make the cake for Adora's personal party."

"Wait what?" Catra's ears stand up, "Like… make a cake for other people??"

Glimmer giggles, "Not a lot of people, just the Princesses and a few others."

Catra bounds over and grabs Glimmer by the shoulders, "Noooo nonono Glimmer you don't understand! I- I'm not ready for this. Make someone else do it."

Glimmer takes Catra's hands, "The kitchen staff are gonna need the day off after the big party. And besides, we don't need anyone else. We've got you. The stuff you've been making recently has been *amazing*. You got this Catra. I believe in you."

Catra's expression softens. "Okay, fine. Don't get all soft on me. I'll do it."

"Yes!" Glimmer pumps her fist and embraces the feline. "Thank you! It'll be great!" She teleports away before Catra can respond.

Catra

Catra is alone in the kitchen this time. It's mid afternoon, but it's also a holiday so the kitchen staff have the day off.

"Cake…" She ponders. One of the chefs had left out a baking recipe book, '*On Glimmer's orders no doubt,'* which she is now flipping through, looking at various cakes.

She settles on one that looks fairly easy, a simple chocolate cake. She gets out the ingredients and sets to work. She places it in the oven and hops up onto the counter to wait.

She's examining her nails when she hears footsteps approaching the kitchen. She hops down and turns to look at the door as General Juliet walks in. The caramel skinned elf looks at her with narrowed eyes.

"Oh, uhhh… h-hi, General." Catra gives a wave that transforms into a salute halfway through. Juliet rolls her eyes and walks over to the pantry, grabbing an apple and examining it.

"Catra." She says with the necessary amount of politeness.

She hates me. Catra withdraws into herself, turning back to the oven. "I'm sorry." She mutters quietly.

"What was that?" Juliet asks evenly.

"I'm sorry. For… everything. I don't think I've apologized to you yet."

Juliet pauses. "I know you are. I don't forgive you, but I also don't hold it against you." Catra looks up at the general, who meets her gaze with steely eyes. "As much as I think you belong in a cell," Catra cringes at that, "I also respect you. I think your tactics were effective, and humane."

"Humane?"

"After you took over we saw a marked increase in use of bots rather than soldiers on the front line. You spared a lot of your soldier's lives."

Catra thinks about that. *I guess so. I never really thought about it like that but yeah. Entrapta's tech let us put fewer people in harm's way.*

"Of course you cost a lot of our soldiers their lives too." Juliet adds, and Catra looks down at the floor. "But if you're honestly trying to change, then who am I to stop you?" She turns and starts walking out of the kitchen.

“Wait!” Catra reaches out a hand, and Juliet turns. “Um… are you on break?” The general nods, “Do you… want some cake?” Juliet looks her up and down suspiciously, but sees no reason to mistrust her.

“I suppose so.” The general walks back in and waits as Catra pulls the cake out and frosts it, then slices two pieces off.

Both women eat the cake in satisfied silence.

“It’s delicious.” Juliet says after finishing. “You have a real gift.” She stands up, grabs her staff, and leaves. Catra blushes and smiles to herself as she finishes her slice.

Adora

The party is in full swing. Adora has received so many presents, many of which are extravagant and meaningless. She gives everyone a similar smile and thank you, but she knows that most of these gifts aren’t going to be kept, and that does make her sad. But she’s only one person, and most of these gifts are for She Ra, not Adora.

After the last present is given, she excuses herself for a moment, plucking a few children off her limbs and striding off into a quiet hallway before letting her She Ra form fade with a sigh. She sinks down to a sitting position and wraps her hands around her knees.

“You okay?” She looks up, and sees Bow standing above her, drink in hand. He walks up and sits down across from her. She looks around for Catra and Glimmer but they aren’t there.

“Yeah.” She says, her voice betraying her exhaustion.

“Hey, what’s going on?” Bow asks with such genuine concern and love.

Adora smiles, thanking the stars for her luck with friends. “It’s just… It hasn’t gotten easier, over the years. Even now, now that I

know it's not just a sword, that she's… inside me, she *is* me! It's still hard not to think of her as a different person. And all these people, they love her so much, and she means so much to them…" She sighs, and rests her chin on her knees, "It's just intimidating, and overwhelming, and I don't feel like I deserve it."

Bow slides over next to her. "Adora, no one deserves fame or adoration or love. Because it's not your decision to make. If someone decides they want to give you something nice, it's not up to you to say if you deserve it or not. They decide if you deserve it. And you know what? You do deserve all the love the universe can give you. You saved Etheria! It wasn't She Ra who made that decision. You did, Adora did." Bow puts a hand on her shoulder. "You're one of the most amazing people I've ever met, and you've gone through so much and grown so much since I first captured you," Adora chuckles, "So, take all the time you need. But don't doubt yourself, okay?"

She leans in and embraces him, "Thanks Bow."

"Anytime. By the way," He adds, "You may want to hurry up, because Catra and Melog are entertaining children, and it's pretty much the cutest thing that's ever happened."

"They're *what??*" Adora shoots to her feet, sending Bow sprawling, and walking back into the party without bothering to transform back into She Ra.

She walks over slowly and leans against a pillar, watching Catra and Melog give an awesome illusory presentation of what seems to be a children's story. Adora wonders where Catra even got the details. It features a heroine who Adora later realizes is She Ra fighting against an evil dragon to save a village, only to discover the dragon was not what it seems, and telling the villagers that the beast is just hungry, thus bringing peace between the two sides. The kids cheer at the ending, and beg 'Miss Catra' to tell them another.

“That’s all I’ve got for now.” Catra says sweetly, looking up and seeing Adora. The kids groan in despair, and she gently lifts the smallest one out of her lap and stands up. “But Melog’s got more for you.” The space cat mewls in agreement and sits down. “You’ll have to pay very close attention though because their story’s got no words.” The kids nod and sit ready to watch. Catra walks over and takes Adora’s hand. “Not. A word.” She mutters in the same sweet tone she was using with the kids.

“I didn’t… I didn’t say anything.” Adora replies smugly as the two rejoin the larger party.

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“Ladies, gentlemen, and others!” Glimmer’s voice rings clear across the hall, “please follow me to the grand unveiling of our newest feature of Bright Moon Palace!”

‘Huh? This wasn’t part of the party plan!’ Adora looks at Bow in confusion, and he gives her a meaningful smile whose meaning she cannot for the life of her decipher. She walks with the crowd through the halls to a nearby courtyard, home to many statues of great heroes of Bright Moon. Adora walks through the door into the open air, and sees a large structure covered in a tarp, obviously a new statue.

Glimmer steps up on a little stage set up in front of the podium. “For a long time, Etheria has lived in darkness! But then, She Ra came and brought back the light. Adora, come here.” Adora breathes in, and steps forward as scattered applause erupts. She steps onto the platform with Glimmer and wordlessly tries to communicate her confusion. The queen simply smiles and continues, “This, is Adora. She was a Horde soldier for most of her life, but then, she found the Sword of Protection, and became She Ra. And she *chose* to be a hero from that moment on. She’s saved Etheria so many times in so many ways. So today, I am proud to unveil this monument in her honor.” Adora turns around and watches the tarp fall to reveal a gleaming statue of herself.

There are three forms in the statue. On the left is her true She Ra form, tall and armored, with the ponytail flowing back and the sword pointed down at the ground, held in one hand. Powerful and stoic. On the right is the original She Ra form, Sword of Protection held at the ready in two hands, hair and cape billowing behind her, a resplendent icon of heroism. And in the middle is Adora. Standing up straight between the two goddesses, staff in one hand, staring into the middle distance with an expression of determination on her face.

The crowd goes wild, and Glimmer wraps Adora up in a hug. Adora feels tears falling from her eyes. The noise dims.

"You are worth more than what you can give to other people. You deserve love too!" Mara's words echo in her mind as she gazes up at the three images of herself.

Micah

Micah is drawn to the kitchen by the catlike yowl of frustration and pain. He opens the door and looks in, seeing the form of Catra sprawled out on the floor, a large bowl overturned by her feet, and half mixed dough all over her and the floor.

"Am I… interrupting something?" He asks with a hint of amusement.

"No! Come on in." Catra drawls without looking over, "Don't mine me, just… bein' a failure."

Micah's brows knit. *That's no way to talk about yourself.* He walks over and takes a seat on the floor beside her. "What happened?"

"Third attempt at a cake." She explains, gesturing to the various dishes already stacked up in the sink basin, "Got a little… overenthusiastic. Knocked the bowl onto my foot."

"Ah." Micah nods sagely. "Would you like some help with the cake?"

Catra raises an eyebrow and looks at him, her mouth twisted in bewilderment, "Can you bake?"

Micah chuckles, "I know a thing or two." He holds out his hands, and a rune appears. The mess vanishes from the floor and Catra, and the bowl levitates back up to the counter. He stands up, and Catra follows, looking at herself and the floor appreciatively.

"Can you…"

"Use magic to make the cake taste better?" He finishes, and Catra's eyes light up. "Yes. Yes I can."

Adora

Her friends had arrived fairly close together in time, and now they're all arranged in one of Bright Moon's sitting rooms, arrayed around a projector ready to watch a movie once they finish chatting. Catra is laughing hysterically at Sea Hawk's antics while Mermista's face is buried in her hands. Frosta has challenged Scorpia to an arm wrestling match, which is not going well for her even though Scorpia barely seems to be trying. Castaspella is talking with General Juliet in one corner, while King Micah relaxes in an armchair by the fireplace. Swift Wind and Melog are frolicking in the adjoining balcony.

The party goes on for hours like that, just friends messing around and having fun. At one point Glimmer pulls Scorpia to the side and the two talk seriously and animatedly about the Horde Remnant situation, which bums Adora out. '*Can't Glimmer just give herself a break? She's acting like me with all this work.*'

Entrapta, Hordak, and Kadroh arrive late. After trading a few passive aggressive comments from Mermista, Hordak relegates himself to reading a book in the corner, which he assures Bow he is perfectly content with. ("I do not need to 'socialize' with my former enemies. I have been civil, and will continue to be civil. You may go about your business without worry.")

The cake, brought in by Micah and Catra, is delicious. Three layers of impossibly tasty vanilla cake, topped with smooth icing and delicious flakes of chocolate shavings to contrast.

Catra also brings in one extra cupcake, and hands it to Perfuma. "I wasn't sure if the cake was vegetarian or not, so I made you this just to be sure."

Perfuma smiles delightedly and sets the cupcake down before hugging Catra tightly. "Thank you for your consideration Catra." She says warmly.

Finally, the time comes to open presents. A few other people come in to present their gifts as well.

The first one to be opened is Bow's. Opening the box, she sees what appears to be a gauntlet, similar to old Horde shield gauntlets, lifting it up, she sees the glass screen on one side.

"It's a miniature tracker pad," Bow explains, "So you can keep in touch with everyone without having to carry around the full sized tablet."

Next are Glimmer's presents. One of them is a beautifully detailed globe of Etheria, and the other is a fashionable, slightly asymmetric red cape with gold embroidering around the edge and a gold pauldron on the right side.

"I figured getting you some new fancy apparel would help, and it's a very different look from normal, but it just felt so… you." Glimmer says.

She turns to the next present, and looks up at the massive rectangular wrapped item in front of her. She turns to Scorpia quizzically.

Catra chimes in, "Just open it already. I helped with this one."

Adora shrugs and dives in, tearing through the massive sheets of wrapping paper to discover… "My old locker?" Indeed, it's her old

locker from the Fright Zone barracks.

"Open it." Scorpia says. Adora does, and sees the inside door is covered in little drawings taped there. There are doodles by all her friends, and even a few older ones from Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. "I figured you might be getting just a little homesick up here." Scorpia says. "I know it's a lot, but I haven't given a lot of birthday gifts before, and, I mean, ya only turn 22 once, hehe!"

"You only turn every age once." Mermista snarks.

Adora smiles and closes the door. "Thank you Scorpia."

Sea Hawk brought a fancy tricorn hat made of fine material with a plume of white and red feathers on top that he assures her he definitely didn't steal (despite the name "M. St. Vincent" being written on the inside of the brim). Combined with Glimmer's cape, it makes for a truly spectacular pirate queen ensemble.

Mermista simply says, "I got you this," and hands over a small package, "And also I got you a boat, so you own a boat now. Don't let Sea Hawk burn it down."

"A *boat??*" Adora moves her jaw in wonder as her hands open the package, which has a conch shell beautifully painted with various moments from her life with the Princess Alliance. The Battle of Bright Moon is depicted, as is Adora recharging the Sea Gate, and the destruction of Horde Prime. "Mermista, this is so sweet."

Mermista blushes and waves a hand, "I mean I just like… had that made for you it wasn't me."

"You thought of it though." Adora pokes her friend's cheek. "I think you're secretly a sweetheart."

"Gross! Just open the other presents already."

Adora giggles and moves on. Castaspella made her a red sweater with a white 'A' stitched on the front. "And when you say

‘Greyskull’,” Casta explains, “It changes color!” And indeed, it warps to white with a red and gold ‘S-R’ on it.

Perfuma gives her a bracer made of living wood. She explains that it’s nearly unbreakable, and it should fit perfectly on either arm. She also gives Adora a tiny cactus-like plant in an adorable pot, a succulent, which she says should be easy to take care of for a beginner. (‘*That plant’s gonna die.*’ Adora thinks as she takes it.)

Entrapta built her a little robot, a small disk with three retractable legs and the ability to hover. The little guy immediately shows its affectionate side by bumping up against Adora’s hand when she turns it on. It looks like a tiny little Prime drone. “I’ll let you name him, but he can do all sorts of things! He can transmit visuals, get into tight spots, and he even has a little zapper!” The bot releases a tiny bolt of green lightning.

Adora looks at the little bot standing on her hand. “Bump.” She says firmly, declaring his name for the universe to know and fear.

Micah places his gift on the table in front of her. “I worked with some of Mystacor’s best enchanters on these.” He says. Adora opens the box, and finds a pair of grey boots with little gold wings coming off the heels. “When you click the heels together, you’ll be able to leap great distances for a short time. You can only use them so many times a day before they need to recharge, but they’re perfect for getting out of a tight spot, or giving an edge in a fight.”

Bow’s dads sent gifts as well, although they couldn’t make it to either party. There’s a box set of books, the complete works of a playwright named Duben Schmidt, who Bow says is right up her alley. They also gave her an updated Road Atlas of Etheria, and a wide brimmed sun hat.

A gift is wheeled in by one of the palace servants with a note attached. Reading the note, she sees, “To the hero of Etheria, Adora of Bright Moon, from Chancellor Brannic.” Adora scoffs, she does not like Brannic at all, but she does like the gift: a large oval

mirror, with a poem about a woman's reflection in a lake inscribed around the edge in First Ones script.

Frost gifts her a magical snowglobe with a little moving diorama inside of She Ra and Swift Wind leading the Rebellion into battle.

Swift Wind, her noble steed, bonded to her for life, who knows her true feelings better than anyone except maybe her very closest confidants got her… a bag of oats and a stick.

"Really?" She asks drily.

"What?" The horse responds, "Why wouldn't you want oats? They're *oats*!" Adora facepalms.

"What about the stick?" She asks.

"Okay, that's a regift." He admits.

General Juliet enters, carrying a long leather case. Opening it, Adora sees a felt interior and a small metal rod within, much like her extendable staff hilt, though more ornate and larger. Picking it up, she follows Juliet's instructions and presses a well disguised button towards the top. There's a metallic grinding sound, and a strange blade whips out of the top, segmented and curled, like a whip, before locking together to form a thin, solid sword. She gives a few test swings. It's perfectly weighted. Another button extends the hilt by about a foot and a half, transforming it into something of a polearm.

"She Ra may not always be there when you call on her," Juliet says, "But when she isn't, you can still be ready. It should be quite similar to your old staff, but if you need instructions on its use, I'm happy to provide them." The general bows, and Adora bows back. "On behalf of the soldiers of Bright Moon, I also present you with this:" She holds up a wide, flat box, which Adora takes, and sees a white chain shirt within, along with white leather pauldrons.

"Thank you General." Adora says warmly. "And thank you all for all the wonderful gifts and the wonderful party. You guys are the best

friends I could ever dream of.”

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After a few more hours of socializing, everyone heads off to bed, leaving Catra and Adora alone together, walking towards their room. Adora lets Catra in first, then closes the door before turning to her girlfriend and clasping her hands. “Soooooo…?” She says, bouncing on her heels expectantly.

“What?” Catra asks.

“What did you get me?” Adora says excitedly. “I didn’t get a gift from you earlier so I know you’re holding out.”

“Psh.” Catra scoffs and rolls her eyes. “I didn’t get you anything. Birthdays are dumb.”

Adora crosses her arms, cocks her hip, and raises an eyebrow. “I thought I was supposed to be the bad liar.” She snarks.

Catra grins and tosses a pillow at her, which Adora catches. “Follow me.” She waltzes over to the balcony, and leaps up to the roof. Adora summons her sword, transforms it into a grappling hook, and follows Catra across the spires and roofs of Bright Moon. They cross the castle, Catra taunting Adora to, “Keep up hero,” until they reach the large area of floating rocks. Catra leaps from rock to rock before landing on a particularly large outcropping. Adora climbs up and catches her breath. Looking up, she sees Catra standing sheepishly in front of what looks like a picnic spread.

“I remembered this spot from the Battle.” Catra says bashfully, scratching her upper arm, “And I’ve been waiting for a moment to use it. It’s got a nice view of Bright Moon and the lagoon and the Woods.” Adora turns to look at the admittedly stunning view, too stunned to respond. “And I wanted to share something special and private with you.” Adora turns back, and Catra walks over, gently cupping her cheek and placing a kiss on her lips, her tail wrapping around Adora’s thigh.

“I love you Catra.” Adora whispers, giving her girlfriend another kiss.

“I love you too.” Catra mutters gently. A purr rises deep within her chest as the two hold each other.

Glimmer

Glimmer keeps looking at the door as Brannic talks. *Where is she? She said she’d be here. I don’t care what I see if I have to teleport her out of bed then so help me I will.*

“Furthermore,” Brannic has been droning on, “The Fright Zone’s lands are host to dangerous beasts and roving gangs. We already have defenses against the Crimson Waste, we cannot let our defenses against the Fright Zone fall.”

“There’s no reason to *have* defenses against the Fright Zone anymore.” Glimmer says tiredly, looking at the Chancellor.

“There are *always* reasons to have defenses against the Fright Zone.” He shoots back, “Even if we make the mistake of trusting that Princess Scorpia will maintain an alliance forever, there is also the possibility that it could be conquered by more malicious factions.”

Catra’s voice cuts through the bureaucrat's arguments, “I wouldn’t worry about that if I were you.”

Brannic whips his head around. “And what are you doing here?”

Catra struts across the room, wearing a deep purple and silver top with red gloves, and a neckpiece with the insignia of her new office. “I’m entitled to be. I’m Royal Advisor to Her Majesty.” She strides over and hops into the chair beside Glimmer, lounging sideways as her tail drifts over and wraps around Glimmer’s ankle beneath the table. “And I know a bit more about this subject than you do.”

Brannic scoffs, “I am well aware of your experience, Catra. I had family in Salineas who witnessed it firsthand.” Glimmer feels Catra’s tail tighten around her ankle, and sees her hackles raise slightly.

“Brannic!” Micah shoots a stern glare across the table.

“Then you know what a threat the Horde can be.” Catra says, her voice level, “My campaign proves how effective the Horde can be even when running on low manpower and resources. If you’re going to fear attack, you’d better fear it from the underdogs.”

“Princess Scorpia has more than enough motive to turn on Bright Moon.” The red haired chancellor shoots.

“Hah!” Catra chuckles, “Even if that were true, which it isn’t, Scorpia doesn’t pose much of a threat as a commander, trust me. If she were leading an attack against the other kingdoms, you wouldn’t even need defenses, it would just fall apart on its own. She’s a good friend, and a good person, but noooot the best military leader. But even she could hold the Fright Zone against an invading army, the place is impregnable by any large scale attack. You’ve got no reason to fear her turning on you, or the place getting taken over. So maybe put aside your unfounded paranoia about Scorpia, and worry more about that Remnant base in the Waste, which from what I’ve heard is home to some of the Horde’s most experienced Force Captains and soldiers, who have access to all sorts of mercenaries from the Crimson Waste. I don’t think I need to remind you of how a mercenary from the Crimson Waste managed to cripple the entire Princess Alliance when the Horde attacked Salineas. Removing defenses from any other position would be idiotic. The Fright Zone is the only logical choice. Tell me, do you have defensive outposts guarding against attack from Plumeria?” Brannic does not respond. “I didn’t think so. Perfuma poses a wayyyy bigger threat than Scorpia if you ever made her mad. I think maybe you should focus less on defending against your allies, and more on keeping them.” Catra rolls her gaze over to Glimmer. “Wouldn’t you agree?”

That. Was. Amazing. Glimmer picks her jaw up off the floor and says, "Yes, I do agree Catra. Any further protests Brannic?" The noble shakes his head. "Then this meeting is adjourned." Everyone else files out of the room, and Catra and Glimmer break down into giddy hysterics.

"That was awesome!" Catra says. "Gah I've never even talked to him before but it still felt so good to make him shut up."

"Oh you have no idea." Glimmer giggles, "You'll have to be ready next time because he does not give up, and he's gonna come for you."

"I can handle him." Catra responds smugly. "And, uh…" She adds seriously, suddenly going timid, "Thanks. For… giving me a job and… everything else."

"Of course." Glimmer responds. "That's what friends do."

Fygan

Fygan is bent over his work table, a magnifying glass positioned in front of him as he works with the intricate, tiny mechanical pieces. They rattle against each other, and he attempts to slow his breathing. But his hands are shaking far too much. The pieces clack against each other, but don't fit together. He grits his teeth and sets the tools down, leaning back in his chair and looking at his hands.

"Steady enough for magic. But not for mechanics, eh?" He asks as they tremble in front of him. He clenches his fist and slams it down on the table in frustration.

All I need to do is figure this out, and it'll be over.

He closes his eyes and gets back to work.

No setback is going to stop me.

“Brace yourselves Princesses.” He mutters as he slowly slides the two bothersome pieces together with a satisfying click. “There’s a storm coming for you.”

Chapter End Notes

Happy Thanksgiving! I hope you enjoyed this cute little filler arc, comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Old Wounds, Part 1: A Town Called Mudd

Chapter Summary

> In Which a distress call from a remote town on the edge of the Crimson Waste leads to a reunion with old friends… and a showdown with an old enemy

Chapter Notes

> I'm back! I apologize for the sudden hiatus and lack of communication. I got incredibly busy with theater work and finals, then I got covid, and this just slipped my mind. I intend to keep a better schedule, and hope you all understand

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Deputy Hergus

The Crimson Waste is no place for regular towns. If you want to survive, you have to be tough. The outskirts of the waste, however, are more forgiving. People have carved out lives in small settlements on the edges of the vast desert, mining, farming, and living. The going is tough, but they get by.

The town of Mudd is one such settlement. The people are tough, and life is hard, but it's a close knit community nonetheless, and they take care of their own.

Deputy Hergus takes a few steps forward. One of the outlying farms reported something on the horizon, and she had rushed over. Her stun baton in hand, she creeps up to the nearby wall and peeks over. There's definitely something coming.

Oh no. It's them.

Approaching the farm is a collection of skiffs, both old Horde models and cobbled together. Emblazoned on the sails is the

symbol of their gang: a snake wrapped around itself in a circle.

I need backup. She reaches for her communicator, but finds a hand grabbing her wrist and a knife pressed against her throat.

"I wouldn't do that." A husky voice threatens. Hergus feels the tip of a boot against hers, so she slams her heel on the enemy's toes. "Ow!" They shout, and Hurgus extricates herself from their grasp, spinning around and pointing the baton at the figure. A horned goon with a white tank top and a knife. She grimaces and snarls at Hergus.

"Stand down." Hergus threatens, trying to be intimidating. The sound of the skiffs' engines is growing closer behind her.

"I got a better idea." The horned goon responds, "You don't touch that little communicator, and I don't feed you to my boss."

Hergus gulps. *He eats people?? No. She's bluffing.* She steels herself. "I thought he only let people like him into his gang. Aren't you a bit of an outsider?"

The goon looks hurt for a moment, but shrugs. "Eh. Times change. And speaking of time," The engine sounds are very close now, and the goon smirks evilly.

A new voice picks up behind Hergus, "You're all out." Hergus spins around to see the figure, a massively tall, broad chested figure, with a long serpentine tail and a snake's head. He smiles, and swings his whip forward, snapping the baton out of Hergus's hands. He swings again, wrapping Hergus in the whip and pulling her towards him. "Get the parts boys!" A series of other snake men leap the fence and rush towards the farm equipment. "And you," he leans down to Hergus. "Go ahead and tell your little Marshal that Tung Lashor is in charge around here, and you best stay out of our way." He grabs her and tosses her through the air. She slams against the nearby wall and crumples to the ground, watching helplessly as the bandits make off with the machinery they were after.

Bow

"Remind me again why we're going to the middle of nowhere?"

"Catra, you were at the mission briefing!"

"Uh, yeah! That doesn't mean I was paying attention."

"Why weren't you paying attention?"

"You've known me for how long and you're *still* asking that?"

From his position at the back of the skiff, Bow sighs, and cuts off the lesbians' bickering with, "We got a distress call from a town on the edge of the Crimson Waste. It used an old Horde code, so Adora wanted to check it out."

Catra rolls her eyes, "Yeah, I got that part, but why *us*? Don't we have lackeys we could send to do that?"

There's a pause as Bow and Adora look at each other. "That's… not really how we do things." Bow responds.

Catra scoffs and plops onto her back on the skiff's deck. Adora gives her a head pat before getting up and joining Bow back by the rudder. She spends some time looking around at the golden lights surrounding them; a byproduct of Melog cloaking the skiff, one can never be too careful when travelling around the Crimson Waste.

"Why *are* we doing this ourselves?" Bow asks quietly.

"I just figured it had been a while since we went on a mission like this!" Adora says, "I thought it would be fun. I'd really hoped Glimmer could come too but…" She shrugs, and looks out over the horizon. Bow sighs sadly. With Glimmer's responsibilities as Queen mounting, it's nearly impossible for her to get out on adventures anymore. "Plus," Adora adds, "I just… I have a feeling about this. I can't explain it but I feel like it's important somehow."

Bow puts a hand on her shoulder and smiles. “That’s good enough for me. You should sit down for a bit. We’ve got another two hours before we get there.”

Adora

Something’s wrong. They’ve arrived at the town, a little community up against a mountain on the edge of the Waste, but no one’s around. The buildings are shut and the windows are boarded up. Detritus litters the street. Adora scans around from beneath the brim of her sun hat, but sees no one, only a wooden sign saying “Welcome to Mudd. Population: ” There is no number listing the town’s population, only a discolored spot on the sign. *That’s not ominous at all.*

“Where is everyone?” Bow says quietly.

“Probably hiding,” Catra responds, “most of the skiffs they see are probably bandits or Horde scraps.”

Adora turns to Bow, “Stop the skiff.” Bow obliges, and the four dismount. Catra mutters something to Melog, who slinks away and vanishes.

Once they find out who we are, they’ll show themselves, right? Adora cups her hands around her mouth. “Hello!?” She shouts. It echoes through the dead air of the empty town. Catra ducks against a building and takes cover behind the stairs. “We’re here to help! You sent a distress call, we’re here to answer it!”

There’s the sound of something creaking, and a female voice shouts, “Hold it right there! Who are you?”

Adora opens her mouth to answer, but a new voice comes out, this one male, high, cracky, and quite familiar. “Adora? Is that you?”

“Kyle?” Adora and Catra say in unison.

A new figure steps out from one of the alleyways, tall, broad, green, and distinctly reptilian. He growls in Adora's direction.

"Rogelio?" Adora says, still stunned. Two building doors open, and a pair of figures step out. One is Kyle, still as scrawny and blonde as ever, though a bit more tanned. He and Rogelio are both wearing new outfits, a vague uniform made up of padded pants, a gray shirt, and a leather vest with a silver badge on it.

Adora doesn't recognize the other figure. She's froglike in appearance, short, with large blue eyes and a wide mouth. "Are these… friends of yours?" She asks Kyle.

"Yeah!" Kyle exclaims. Rogelio growls something, and Kyle pauses, "Well… sort of."

The froglike woman turns, and points at Bow. "Wait a minute… I know you. You sent out that message, callin' us all to fight." Bow smiles and nods. The woman looks at Adora, "Who are you?"

"My name is Adora, but… you've probably heard of me as She Ra."

The woman's eyes predictably widen, "You're She Ra?? *The* She Ra?"

Adora chuckles, "As far as I know."

"We gotta bring you to the marshal then, she'll get you up to speed on everything! I'm Hergus, by the way."

Rogelio raises a hand and snarls something. Kyle seems to understand him (*That's new*), and says, "Yeah, why is it just the two of you?"

"It's not!" Bow responds, and Adora turns to look at the now empty space where Catra had been.

Adora rolls her eyes, "You can come out, they're friendly."

Catra's voice rings out from the shadows, "I doubt they'll keep that up if I come out."

Kyle raises an eyebrow, "Is that…"

Catra emerges from the alleyway to his side and leans in to his ear. "Boo."

Kyle shrieks and leaps several feet away, stumbling back. Rogelio jumps in front of Catra and roars in anger.

"Nice to see you too." Catra responds drily. "We didn't leave on the best of terms did we?"

"Why is Catra here?" Kyle questions Adora and Bow.

"She's with us now." Adora responds flatly, on edge at Rogelio's aggressive posture.

"She's one of the good guys," Bow adds, "Like you."

Kyle nods, "In that case, it's good to see you, Catra." He walks over and extends a hand. Catra looks from hand, to Kyle's face, to Rogelio, to Kyle, to hand before shaking it tentatively.

"Yeah," She says slowly, "It's… good to see you too."

"So," Bow pipes up, "Who's the Marshal?"

*****

Lonnie is the Marshal, of course. (*She always had the best leadership instincts*). She's in a small, metal and stone construction in the center of town with a sign that says "Sheriff's Depot" outside. She herself is wearing a Horde Breastplate with a gold star painted over the Horde symbol, and an outfit similar to Kyle and Rogelio. She's currently sitting behind a desk, looking up as the motley group enters. She raises a surprised eyebrow at Adora, and opens her mouth to speak, then snaps it shut when Catra enters.

“Look,” Catra begins, “I know you hate me, and I’m not that big a fan of you either, but I’m here to help.”

Lonnie simply glares at her for a minute before turning to Adora and Bow. “So. We asked for help from the princesses, and I assume that’s you.” Adora nods. “We got a problem.” She says, “A gang of bandits have been raiding the town recently. They’re not attacking in full force, just coming in, stealing some mechanical parts, and leaving.”

“Parts?” Bow inquires, “What kind of parts?”

“I dunno.” Lonnie shrugs, “Lot of random stuff, we haven’t been able to figure out any kind of connection, but the equipment can’t work without them, and without the equipment, we won’t survive for long.”

“Ha, equipment? What do you farm out here?” Catra quips.

“Water.” Lonnie responds, actually looking at Catra this time. “There are big wells of groundwater on the borders of the Crimson Waste. Farmers collect the water and use it for crops, or just trade it to other settlements. It’s like, the only thing in the Crimson Waste that’s worth anything. Didn’t they teach that in force captain orientation?” Catra blanches, and mutters something mutinous about said orientation. Lonnie scoffs and turns back to Adora and Bow, “We don’t have the numbers, or the firepower to drive ‘em off by ourselves. So next time they come, they’ll have quite the surprise on their hands to see you all. You drive them off, we pay you, and then you can go.”

“No way.” Adora responds. “First of all, we won’t accept payment,” Catra tries to protest, but Adora keeps talking, “Second of all, we’re not just going to drive them off. We need a more concrete game plan.”

“This gang,” Catra says, “Who’s the leader?”

“We weren’t sure until a few nights ago.” Lonnie says, “That’s when he showed up in person.”

Deputy Hergus speaks up. “He could have killed me, but he left me alive to send a message. Said that Tung Lashor is in charge here.”

Tung Lashor? What kind of name is that??

Catra coughs, clearly caught off guard. “Wait, that guy’s alive?? More to the point, he’s leading a gang again??”

“You know him?” Kyle says concernedly.

“Last time I was here I beat him up and took over his operation.” Catra says. “I humiliated him pretty bad. It’s honestly impressive he managed to salvage his reputation enough to lead another gang.” *So that’s how she got a gang. Figures.*

Lonnie grimaces at Catra. “Yeah, we’re not really impressed. A few more visits from him and there’ll be nothing left of Mudd. Our *home*.”

Before Catra can respond, the sound of a bell ringing interrupts the conversation.

“They’re here.” Hergus says in a small voice.

Catra

Getting in position took relatively little time. Adora is standing in the middle of the main road, looking towards the rapidly encroaching dust cloud that signals the raider’s approach. Bow took up roost in the bell tower. Kyle and Hergus are set up on some of the second story balconies along the main street, Horde laser batons at the ready. Catra and Rogelio are in opposing alleyways flanking Adora, and Lonnie has set up on the porch of the town’s saloon, sitting in a rocking chair, stun baton in her lap. Melog is beside Catra, their shroud of invisibility covering both of them.

The lead skiff skids to a halt in front of Adora, sending the dust cloud floating into town.

"Turn around and go back the way you came." Adora calls out, her voice calm, but also authoritative and demanding.

Stars, she is just… Catra whistles silently. Melog bops her with a paw and mewls sternly. *Right, focus!*

The declaration is met with laughter from the gathered skiffs. There are five in total, with a difficult to count number of people, but Catra guesses about five or six per skiff. One figure jumps off the lead skiff, a tall, thin serpent woman with a wide hood about her neck and head. Her leather jacket has Tung Lashor's symbol embossed on the breast.

The snake woman walks up to Adora, looming over her a good deal. "Oh we intend to." She murmurs, her voice low and almost sultry, "That's right. We'll take what we need, and then we'll turn around and leave. No one has to get hurt," She raises a slender hand and moves to touch Adora's chin, "Least of all pretty little yo-"

Adora cuts her off by grabbing the offending hand and twisting it down. The snake hisses in pain and falls to one knee, her arm bent at an awkward angle. The other raiders begin to leap off the skiffs and move towards Adora, but Adora's eyes flash as she snaps her head up to look at them. They pause, and Adora raises her free arm.

"For the Honor…" (*I love this*), "Of GREYSKULL!!"

There's a flash of light, and She Ra stands tall above the now silent field. The snake woman blanches, her hand still held in She Ra's now much larger one. In one smooth motion, Adora swings the lizard woman around, sending her skidding behind her, and swings her blade through the air in front of her, creating an arc of energy that blasts out in a cone, knocking the front line of bandits

down and causing the first two skiffs to overload and crumple to the ground, sparking.

Everyone pauses, unsure of what to do. Then, the bandits get to their feet and let out battle cries. *'Wrong answer.'* Catra smirks, and the battlefield springs into action.

The leader pulls out a knife and lunges towards She Ra's back, but Catra conjures her magic whip and wraps it around the serpent woman's wrist, yanking on it and pulling her over, where Catra lays her out with a punch.

She Ra is moving through the enemies like a breeze, each movement knocks another raider down. Their initial "mob with greater numbers" approach fails within seconds, and they quickly back up and start darting in with hit and run attacks. Two of them pull out old Horde energy lassos and toss them towards She Ra. Remembering how effective that strategy was in the Battle of Bright Moon, Catra breathes a sigh of relief when Adora bats them aside.

Kyle and Hergus are firing down long range blasts from their stun batons, keeping the crowd of bandits on their toes. Rogelio lunges in and engages two of them in a grapple.

With the main crowd under control, Catra looks past them to the remaining three skiffs. One of them has unloaded its passengers and backed away, clearly waiting as a getaway vehicle, but the other two are beginning a flanking maneuver. Catra turns into the alley and dashes through, racing from building to building until she emerges, right as the skiff rounds the corner. Tensing, she leaps up onto it, landing on one bandit's chest, heaving her body weight around and launching him off the vehicle. Turning, she sees the remaining four passengers ready weapons. She notices an unusual number of them are wielding somewhat battered Horde weaponry. A beefy man lunges with a mace, but she ducks under his blow, grabbing his ankle and sending him cartwheeling off the front of the skiff. Another swings a stun baton at her while her partner tries to grab Catra with a lasso, but Catra dodges both

strikes, causing the charged up baton to strike the lasso and send a pulse of energy into the wielder, who shouts in shock. Catra swings up, her foot colliding with the face of the first serpent woman, then vaulting over her to bring both fists down on the head of the one wielding the lasso. Somersaulting over that one, she grabs the final combatant by the shoulders and digs her claws in, then curls her body inward to deliver a brutal double kick to his stomach. He groans and doubles over, and she tosses him off the side, then delivers a swift punch to the throat of the skiff's pilot, and grabs onto the rudder without missing a beat.

She accelerates, bringing the skiff back around to the main road. She catches the tail end of the battle there. Many bandits are knocked out or wrapped in Bow's nets, and the remaining ones have piled onto the last two skiffs and are hightailing their way back across the desert.

Adora turns to Lonnie and says, "Alright. Let's make a plan."

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Old Wounds, Part 2: Marshal Lonnie

Chapter Summary

> In which the BFS does some reconnaissance, and Lonnie struggles with her responsibilities.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lonnie

Okay. So She Ra got an upgrade and that Arrow guy is pretty useful. And Catra's with them now. Ugh. That doesn't change everything Catra did! She should be in prison!

… So should I though.

No. That's different. I'm helping people now.

So is she though.

Lonnie groans and brings her head down to her desk. She looks up in time for the door to open and everyone to file in. Adora sits down in the chair on the opposite side of the desk, and Catra leans on her shoulder. Kyle walks over and sits on a stool beside Lonnie, looking anxiously between her and Catra.

"So," Lonnie begins, "It's been a while. Last time I saw you, we were fighting." She says to Adora.

Adora nods, "I know, but the Horde is gone now, and it seems like you're doing the right thing, so we shouldn't have any reason to fight anymore."

"Um, what about you?" Lonnie says indignantly, "You turned on us, left without a word, and then showed up as some eight foot tall princess tearing apart our armies! After everything you went

through, you joined with the *princesses*. Why should we trust you?"

"The princesses are the good guys!" Adora responds incredulously.

Bow adds on from the corner of the room, "I know the Horde told you a lot of awful things about the princesses, but you've gotta know they're not true, right?"

"You left the Horde," Adora says, "I thought you'd have realized they were evil."

"We left," Lonnie says, "Because we realized *she* was evil." She jabs a finger towards Catra, "When are you gonna work that one out?"

Before Adora can pipe up, Catra blurts out, "I'm sorry, okay?!"

Lonnie's eyes widen. She wasn't expecting that one. '*Catra never apologizes. Not for real.*'

Catra breathes in nervously, and Adora reaches up and gently holds her hand. *'Wait, what?'* Catra looks at Lonnie and Kyle, "I know I was… awful to you, and not just you but- everyone in the Horde. I was obsessed with the idea of winning and I forgot what that really meant. I thought that the mission was all that mattered but I was wrong. I'm sorry for the way I treated you." She pauses, and her expression changes. She focuses the next words on Lonnie exclusively, "But come on. It's not like you were ever good to me. I mean you were awful until I got promoted above you. Remember what you told me after Adora left? Because I do. 'Careful Catra, Adora can't protect you anymore.'" Catra imitates Lonnie, who is struck by that. '*Did I really say that?*'

"So what?" She says aloud, "That doesn't excuse anything you did!"

"I know!" Catra shoots back, "But I apologized! And I spend every day living with and trying to fix my mistakes. I grew up! When will you?"

The room is silent for a moment as the two women stare at each other. Eventually, Adora breaks the silence. “This isn’t important right now. What we need to do is come up with a plan. Catra, Melog, Bow, and I are going to track those skiffs. Those bandits had a lot of Horde tech, so we should find their home base and get a more complete layout of what they have. That way, we can plan for a counterattack.”

“Didn’t we scare them off?” Kyle asks tentatively.

“No.” Bow says grimly, “We gave them a challenge.”

Catra nods, “I’ve dealt with Tung Lashor before,” She can’t resist saying his name in a mocking tone, “Guy’s tough, and he doesn’t know how to quit when he’s ahead. He’s gonna try to hit us harder. Prove how strong he is.”

Lonnie says, “Well what are we supposed to do while you’re out scouting? And how do we know that you won’t just up and leave?”

“You know we won’t leave because you’ve fought us enough times to remember that we don’t give up on people who need us.” Bow responds.

“As for what you’ll be doing,” Adora says, “You’ll be getting the town ready for war. I don’t know what kind of weapons the citizens have but we’ll need everyone to be ready. Get anything that could be used as a weapon ready.”

Lonnie nods. “The people don’t really have weapons, but I can think of a few ways they can help.” She thinks for a moment, then adds, “One more thing. If you’re going on a scouting mission, you’re gonna want to take Imp.”

“Imp?” Bow asks, confused.

From the rafters above them, his voice is mimicked, “Imp?” Everyone looks up to see the little gray flying devil baby, its mouth

open and replaying, “Imp? Imp? Imp?” over and over. The little guy hops down onto the desk. Catra narrows her eyes at him.

“Hate that thing.” She murmurs.

“Understandable,” Lonnie says, ignoring the scandalized look she gets from Kyle, “but he is good at picking up information.”

“He is our *baby*.” Kyle says, affronted, hugging Imp tight despite the little spy’s protests.

Adora nods. “Alright. We should get going before their trail gets cold.”

Lonnie raises a hand. “One more thing.” She points to Catra and Adora, “Are you two like, together now?”

Adora and Catra look at each other and blush. “Yes.” Adora says. “Yes we are.”

“Awwwwe!” Kyle says, at the same time Lonnie says, “Frickin finally! Ugh! You guys were insufferable as cadets!”

“Heyyyy,” Adora objects, but Catra simply busts out laughing. *Probably could have avoided all of this if you two had just kissed then.*

Bow rolls his eyes, “They can be insufferable now, too.” He says conspiratorially.

Adora looks at him and whispers, “How could you? I thought we were friends.”

Lonnie chuckles. “Alright. Let’s get going.” Everyone files out of her office except Kyle. Her smile slowly fades.

“So,” He asks, “Are you… okay? With them?”

“No.” She responds flatly, “But I’m not gonna turn away free help. We need it.”

Kyle nods, then leans down and hugs her. His expression is understanding, but sad.

'He wants everything to be nice and happy, just like the "good old days".' Lonnie sighs as he leaves. '*I don't know if I'm ready for that.'*

Catra

Bow's tracker pad is full of some of the most ridiculous yet oddly useful features. They managed to track the skiffs because his pad is able to pick up the remnants of their unique exhaust lingering in the air behind them.

The trail has led them to a large rock formation on the edge of the Crimson Waste. Something about the place is so distantly familiar to Catra, but it's only once they set up on a secluded ridge overlooking the site that she realizes why.

"It's an old Horde outpost…" She mutters. Emphasis on the *old*, the place uses architecture and layouts from Hordak's earliest conquests. There's a large bay where the skiffs are docked, though the roof is missing, and a large barracks that bandits are wandering in and out of.

Bow has a pair of binoculars that he's looking through. "They're moving around too much to get a good count," He says, "But I'd say there's a few dozen bandits at least."

He passes the binoculars to Adora, who focuses on the vehicle bay. "They've got five real Horde skiffs, plus 5 more, uh… homemade skiffs. Looks like they've got some, like… platforms off to the side. I think they might tie those to the back of the skiffs to give more room." Catra almost shudders thinking of how easily a platform like that could capsize or go flying given the fragility and maneuverability of the skiffs. The people who get thrown by that would be the lucky ones. "There's something else… oh no." Adora lowers the binoculars in shock, then quickly raises them and takes a closer look.

“What? What is it?” Catra asks, a little panicked.

“They have a tank.” Adora says quietly. “One of the old ones too.”

Catra feels a nugget of dread settle in her stomach. Old Horde tanks, the ones from Hordak’s earliest conquests, were infamous among the veterans. They were said to be tough to maintain, expensive to make, terribly inefficient to operate… and nigh indestructible, with more firepower than any other machine the Horde made before Entrapta came along.

“And it looks like they’ve got some guys working on a bot too.” Adora hands Catra the binoculars, and points to a shaded spot on the side of the vehicle bay. There, partially obscured by a canvas, Catra can see several engineer types working feverishly on what looks like a heavy assault bot.

“How did these thugs get this kind of firepower?” Catra muses.

“I’m guessing this outpost was abandoned towards the end of the war, and they found it sometime afterwards.” Bow responds.

Catra thinks back, and realizes why this outpost is familiar. She had ordered it be abandoned so its troops and munitions could go towards that final, disastrous campaign. She groans and puts her head in her hands, muttering, “Great. Of course it’s my fault.”

Adora rubs Catra’s back. “It’s not your fault. It’s theirs. They’re the ones who chose to use that tech to attack innocent people.”

“So did I.”

“That’s the past. They’re the bad guys now.” Catra looks at Adora and meets the blonde’s smile. She can’t resist lunging in for a quick kiss. Adora blushes, then slides down the hill a bit. Bow and Catra join. The three are invisible of course, courtesy of Melog, but they still want better cover.

“Okay.” Adora says quietly. “They’d definitely recognize Bow, from his transmission, and a lot of them probably remember Catra, so

I'll go down alone. I won't get too far in, just find a secluded spot, locate their HQ, and send in Imp to figure out what their plan is."

"I don't like you going down there alone." Catra returns, and Melog meows. "Yeah, Melog'll go with you."

Adora nods. "Alright, but don't cloak me." Melog and Catra simultaneously cock their heads in confusion. "If they think I'm one of them, and I get spotted, it'll cause less disruption than if the cloak drops and there's suddenly a stranger in their camp." She leans up and kisses Catra again, "I'll be fine." She then looks to where the winged baby is watching the conversation. "Ready Imp?"

He opens his mouth and replays, "Ready Imp?" He nods, and flutters up to perch on Melog's back.

Catra climbs back up to the top of the ridge and watches their descent down. At a certain point, Melog vanishes, and Adora walks into camp. She's wearing a poncho, so she doesn't stand out too much. Catra sees her briefly converse with another guard and starts to sweat. '*Don't try to blend in, Adora. Don't try to lie.*' Fortunately, the conversation is brief, and Adora moves on, skirting the edge of camp until she comes to the edge of a smaller building that looks like a standard Command Post. She settles down, and Imp appears, climbing into an outside vent.

The waiting begins, and lasts what feels like an hour before Imp re-emerges and quickly vanishes. Adora vanishes as well, and Catra puts down the binoculars and waits for them to return.

Adora

The poncho is hot, and Adora knows her sun hat will make her a target, but if something happens, she needs to be able to see properly, so the wide brimmed straw hat stays on. She's conscious of Melog's presence beside her, and as they approach the camp, she wishes she had just let them cloak her. *It's for the best.*

“Hey!” Comes the scratchy voice of a guard. Adora stops and turns to look at the thin snake person approaching her, their eyes narrowed. “Where have you been.”

Adora’s heart stops. *Come up with a lie, quick!* “Fell off the skiff.” She says, making her voice lower and more raspy “Had to walk here.”

The guard looks at her for a second, then giggles. “Ha. Well don’t rest too much. We’re about to move out again.” They cock their head into camp. “Go get your orders.”

Adora chuckles nervously and walks past. *I just lied! I acted for real! Catra’s rubbing off on me.*

Hey, that’s mean.

I’m sorry. Wait. Why am I apologizing to myself?

Adora shakes her head, and walks over to the edge of camp, an area where crates and tents are bunched together. *‘They’ve got a heck of an operation here.’* She thinks, *‘And that guard was talking like a Horde officer. They’re really well set up.’* She kneels down behind a crate, looking up at an old Horde building, familiar to her as the standard command post. `*Hopefully they know that, so I don’t have to spend any more time here.’* She turns. “Imp?” She whispers.

The little creature appears, fluttering to the ground and looking up expectantly. “Alright.” She says quietly. “There’s a grate up there, see it? I need you to climb into the vents and find out if people are planning in there, if they are, record what you hear, okay? Just like you did for Hordak.” She’s speaking slowly, unsure of Imp’s intelligence. At the name ‘Hordak’, he perks up, and nods enthusiastically, then chitters and flies up to the grate. Adora quickly summons her sword as a lasso, wraps around the grate, and wrenches it off. It comes off without much noise, and she dives in and catches it silently before it can clatter onto the stone. Imp climbs into the vents, and the waiting begins.

After about ten minutes, Imp re-emerges.

“You got it?” She asks quietly and excitedly.

Imp opens its mouth, and plays a recording of a gravelly voice saying, “After the first wave’s done, the tank will move in and take down She Ra.” Adora quickly shushes the creature.

“Alright. Let’s go.” She feels Melog’s invisibility cloak fall over her and Imp, and she makes a beeline out of the camp.

Kyle

“There are only three of them?” “What do you mean we have to learn to fight?” “I thought we called these people to protect us, now you’re saying they’re going to attack our homes?” “How do we know these princesses won’t betray us?”

Kyle looks helplessly over at Lonnie, who is pinching the bridge of her nose in exasperation at the complaints of the crowd. They had called a town meeting to inform everyone of the plan, but the townsfolk are not pleased. They’re getting louder, in fact. Lonnie nods to Rogelio, who stands to his full height and lets out a ferocious roar that brings quiet to the assembly.

“Look,” Lonnie begins, “We don’t like this situation any more than you do, but we’re doing our best. We can’t protect you with what we’ve got. You need to do something to protect yourselves.”

“Yeah,” Kyle adds, turning to the crowd, ignoring Lonnie’s growled “Kylllle…”. He speaks to the people, saying, “We’re not asking you to get out on the front lines. Stay in your houses. You don’t have to learn to fight, but if a bandit passes under your window, drop something heavy on them! Trust me. I know what it’s like to go into a battle you don’t want to be a part of. I was never cut out to be a soldier, but that’s what I had to be if I wanted to help my friends. So if you want to help your friends, and help us save our town, you don’t have to do much. Just… do what you can.” He

looks at the crowd pleadingly, and one by one they begin to mutter their assent.

One older man steps forward. “Thank you for stepping up and helping us.” He says to all three former Horde soldiers.

“You’re welcome.” Kyle responds. He looks up at Lonnie and smiles proudly. She is staring at him, flabbergasted by his speech.

The door opens, and the crowd parts to reveal a grim faced Adora. “We’ve got our intel.” She says.

Catra

Everyone is gathered around a map of the town placed on a large table in the saloon. Adora, Bow, Catra, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, plus Hergus and an older, well muscled and scarred man from the town named Regis. Regis is the former Marshal, and leader of a group of townsfolk who volunteered to fight for real, instead of just hiding and helping when they can.

Imp is sitting on the table, having replayed what he heard of the enemy’s plan. They’re going to send the tank down the main road and blast everything they can, and the main force of bandits are going to follow on foot. Five of their skiffs are going to surround the town and patrol the outskirts to prevent escape, and their assault bot is going to attempt to take the ridge and bombard the town from above.

“We do have advantages.” Adora begins. “They have a lot of vehicles, but their numbers are going to be spread pretty thin. They also don’t have full knowledge of our capabilities. So. Each person is going to have an important mission. Bow will be in the bell tower. It’s the best vantage point of the town and he’ll have line of sight to pretty much everything. Lonnie and Rogelio will destroy that bot before it gets to the ridge. After that, you’ll run interference on the bandit’s skiffs. I’ll take the tank. I’ll draw it down the main street to the back of the town, where I can take it out with less collateral damage. Regis and the rest of the

volunteers will be running hit-and-run attacks, with Melog there to keep them hidden. Stick to the shadows and pick off the bandits on the edges of their ranks, or draw them towards the buildings so the rest of the villagers can help from the safety of their homes."

"What about me?" Kyle asks tentatively.

Catra speaks up, pointing to the main thoroughfare. "You're with me. Once Adora draws the tank away, Tung Lashor is gonna be leading his footsoldiers. I'll get him to face me one on one. We've got some history, and I'll bet he's just itching for a rematch."

"Uh, if it's one on one, what do you need me for?"

Catra cringes a little at the memory. "Last time I… used some underhanded tactics to win. I wouldn't be surprised if he tries to cheat to beat me. That's what I need you for. Bow's gonna be busy, which, unfortunately, means you're the best shot. I need you to keep an eye out for any funny business, any tricks or outside interference, and take it out. I'm kinda putting my life in your hands, so don't screw this up." Kyle gulps in response.

"Once we've taken out their heavy weapons, the bandits will cut and run." Adora says. "And this will finally be over."

Lonnie

"Alright." Lonnie stands on a box to make up for her lack of height compared to everyone else present. "We all know our positions, and we know what we're fighting for. Move out." Everyone nods, and files out of the station. Catra lingers at the door, and looks like she's about to say something, only to leave instead. *'Good. I don't want to talk to her.'*

"You up to this?" The voice startles Lonnie, who nearly falls off the box. She hadn't realized Regis was still in the room.

"What??" She says defensively.

“I asked if you’re sure you’re up to this.” Regis repeats. “You don’t have to go out there. None of you have to risk yourselves for us.”

“They may not,” Lonnie argues, “But Mudd’s my home now too. I’ll do whatever it takes to keep it safe.”

“Even fight side by side with your old enemies?” Regis asks, “I know some of the stories. If it comes down to it, are you gonna choose to save She Ra? Or Bow? Or Catra?”

Lonnie opens her mouth to speak, but can’t find the words. Eventually she settles on, “They’re all more capable than me. And I’ll be on the other side of the battlefield.”

Regis raises his eyebrows and nods thoughtfully. “True enough.” He stands from his chair. “You’re a good woman Marshal Lonnie. It warms my heart to see that the Horde didn’t ruin you.”

He starts to leave, but Lonnie speaks up. “You were the old marshal.” She says, “And you talk like you’re ex-Horde.” Regis turns and nods with a rueful smile. “So,” She pauses, “What’s in this for you? Why volunteer to fight again?”

“Because,” Regis says with a sigh, “If I didn’t do it, who would? Rest of them only volunteered once I did. They look up to me. And one day they’ll look up to you too.” He grabs his hat from the rack by the door and puts it on, then opens the door. “Chances are they’ll look up to you after you save them all today.” He steps out.

”If I didn’t, who would?” The words ring in Lonnie’s head just as the alarm bell sounds, indicating that the fight is about to begin.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, comments and kudos are always appreciated, hope you enjoyed!

Old Wounds, Part 3: The Good, The Bad, and The Kyle

Chapter Summary

> In which the BFS and the citizens of Mudd have a showdown with Tung Lashor's gang

Chapter Notes

> Merry Christmas for those who celebrate it, happy holidays for those who don't, and joyous day for everyone else!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Rogelio

They are coming. The smoke plume on the horizon grows larger. Rogelio checks the scent of the air. It stinks of the snakemen. He growls, low in his chest. Looking to Lonnie, he cocks his head. It is time to get in position. Reluctantly, she follows him to the ridge on the side of town. There is an abandoned farmhouse there that they take up positions in, ready to ambush the horde bot. Rogelio is strangely excited. It has been a long time since he has been in a true battle, even though the odds are against him this time. He worries about Kyle, as he always does, but he takes solace in knowing that they have the She Ra on *their* side this time.

"You alright?" Lonnie asks quietly. Rogelio growls in the affirmative, and returns the question. Lonnie and Kyle don't fully understand his speech, though they've gotten better at reading his tone and body language to estimate his words. "Yeah. I hope we aren't making a mistake." She mutters. Rogelio cocks his head and murmurs a question. "Trusting Catra." Lonnie explains, "She seems better but… I dunno. Not like she's ever exactly been a team player, ya know?"

Rogelio knows that Lonnie must sort through this conflict on her own, so he simply places a hand on her shoulder and nods his support.

"Thanks." She says, and the two settle in and wait for their target to arrive.

Bow

The first wave of skiffs arrive, the five ramshackle ones, towing extra platforms behind them. They unload their troops, whooping war cries and screams. Many of them are brandishing Horde laser batons, sending out blasts of energy almost at random. Bow begins taking his shots. A smoke arrow engulfs one flank of the oncoming force in thick fog, and three bandits fall wrapped in nets. He ducks under the bannister as the mob returns fire, one laser blast singing his hair. He pops back up and fires an explosive arrow at one of the parked skiffs. It hits the exposed fuel tank, and sets off a massive explosion that rips through the adjacent skiff as well.

That's what shoddy craftsmanship gets ya.

She Ra slams into the enemy like a tornado, sending men and women flying with every swing. Her power radiates off her in waves of multicolored light, and even the strongest combatants the bandits have can only slow her down for a few seconds.

The enemies are scattering. Some of them are rushing into buildings, others are running down alleys and causing destruction and chaos. Bow watches a fireball erupt from within one house, the people within rapidly emerge, screaming. The bandits move towards them, but Regis's task force breaks cover to protect them. Bow scans the nearby streets, and behind the bell tower, he sees someone cowering behind a crate.

Is that…? Oh no.

Bow sprints down the spiral staircase of the tower and rushes down the narrow street, skidding around the corner and ducking behind a crate as he shouts, "Kyle!!"

"Ah!" The blond jumps, and points his baton at Bow for a moment before recognizing him. "Oh! Hi Bow, what are you doing here??" He says nervously.

"What are *you* doing here?" Bow says, more quietly now but equally angry. The sounds of battle are all around them, but they seem to be in a safe area. "You're supposed to be out there, giving cover fire and backing up Catra.

"Oh come on," Kyle says, "I'm not a fighter. I ran as soon as they started attacking! Catra's better off without me. Everyone's better off without me! I'm…" He sighs, and raises his knees to his chest. "I've… always been a failure. I can't fight, I can't lead, I can't follow… I just… I mess everything up. It's better if I just stay out of the way." Kyle looks up at Bow, his eyes watery, "I'm a coward."

Bow is silent for a moment, thinking, then he speaks. Not in an urgent tone, but in a low, understanding one. "Me too."

"What??" Kyle almost laughs, "You? You're a Rebellion hero! You fought the Horde without fear for so long! You… you got captured and imprisoned in the Fright Zone. I remember! You weren't scared then! You just wanted to help your friend…" Kyle speaks more slowly at the last part, and retracts into himself again. "I'm not like that. I can't help anyone."

"You're right." Bow says, Kyle looks back up at him confused. "I'm not afraid of fighting. I've always wanted to be a fighter, to be a hero. That's what I was made for. I'm a coward because…" He sighs. "I lied to my family about who I was for years because I was too scared that the truth would hurt them. Heroes can be cowards too."

Kyle doesn't respond, and Bow says, "And if nothing else, think about this: Catra trusts you. She chose you for this. And I've

learned to trust Catra's judgement. If she thinks you're a good enough shot to make it work, I think you're a good enough shot to make it work. You don't have to be the best soldier to be important. You don't have to be a hero to save the day! All you have to do is be good *enough.*" Bow stands up. "Now. I have to get back to my post. You can stay here if you want. I don't think any of us would judge you. Frankly most of us probably want to be back here too. But we're not. And now, you get to choose what you're going to do." Bow turns, then remembers a quote, "Courage isn't the absence of fear. It's acting in spite of it." With that, he rushes back into the bell tower.

Once he's at the top, he gets a full view of the town. Kyle is rushing back to his spot, and Bow smiles proudly.

The first wave of bandits has been beaten back, but the second wave has arrived. Five proper Horde skiffs, in formation surrounding a massive tank, with a four legged bot strutting behind. The skiffs break off, three going to one side of the town, two going to the other. Following the two is the heavy assault bot, a massive platform with laser cannons mounted on top. The bandits seem to have added missiles too. `*Where did these thugs get all this tech??'* Bow fires an electricity arrow that thunks into its armor and stuns it for a moment, but it continues marching. Looking back, he can see the tank, and the second wave of infantry moving behind it.

He ducks another laser blast, and surveys the fighting in the thoroughfare. She Ra is cutting through the enemy ranks, sending wave of bandits flying with each swing, but they're fighting more tactically this time, encircling her with bandits wielding Horde shields and poking at her with long lances, while those on the outside pepper her with stun blasts and attempt to tie her down with lassos. It was the sort of tactic that would have slowed her down in her old form.

But Adora is more powerful now. She shakes off the baton-induced lethargy, revs up her blade, and slams it into the ground, sending out a golden shockwave that wrecks the street and

knocks almost the entire first wave down. There's a moment of stillness, before the tank unloads its first shot. Not at She Ra, but at the nearest building, which detonates in a fireball.

Bow takes a closer look at the tank. It's larger than the tanks he's used to fighting, more heavily armored, with a heavy wedge at the front. There's a smaller turret with an exposed gunner on it that's using some sort of mechanism to fire a steady stream of small metal projectiles towards Adora, who raises her shield and deflects a volley of the spheres with a series of *'Ting'*s. Adora unleashes a pulse of energy from her shield that washes over the tank, then she turns and leaps across town with a single bound, landing at the end of the main street and giving a 'come at me' gesture towards the tank, which seems happy to oblige. The massive piece of machinery chugs down the main street as fast as possible towards its quarry.

Bow looks down and sees the remaining members of the first wave have fallen back to bolster the second mob, which is being led by what he assumes to be Tung Lashor- a massive snake man with a broad chest, huge arms, a sleeveless leather jacket, and red and black scales. On one arm he has a horde buckler and is holding a whip, and on the other arm he has a cannon. It looks like it was taken from a galactic horde bot and retrofitted into an arm mounted weapon, which he raises and fires, raking it across the buildings on the right side of the street.

"Come on out!!!" He bellows, "Now that your princess is occupied, I wanna see what this town has to offer!" He lets out a bellowing laugh. Bow looks down and sees in the alleyway beside the tower, Catra starts to step out.

Lonnie

Lonnie looks out the cracked door. Two Horde skiffs float by, with bandits on them hooting and jeering at the town, firing random blasts and arrows into the nearby buildings. She pumps her fist in pride when she sees a metal plate come spinning out of one of the buildings, beaning a bandit right in the head and sending him

flying off the skiff. His fellows laugh at him and fly away as he grimaces and rushes towards that building.

Lonnie moves to run out and stop him, but the sound of mechanical stomping stills her. She turns towards Rogelio and nods. The bot stalks forward, and past their building, breaking off from the path of the skiffs and moving towards the ridge. Once it passes them, Lonnie and Rogelio dart out from cover. Lonnie ducks behind a low wall, and Rogelio pulls out his quarterstaff.

She fires a quick blast from her baton, striking at the joint of the back leg, at the same time Rogelio slams its foot with his quarterstaff.

The bot staggers, and its armament platform rotates around. Two barrels glow, and Lonnie rolls to the side as lasers pulverise the spot she was just standing. Rogelio darts to another leg and leaps up, jabbing the pointed end of his staff into a gear, which sparks and smokes. The bot flicks that leg up, sending Rogelio sprawling, his staff still stuck in the bot's joint.

Lonnie dives forward, avoiding another blast and sending a few stun blasts of her own up at the thing's eye. They miss, washing over its armor, and it slams its leg down in front of her, narrowly missing and sending her staggering backwards. Another laser blast comes towards her. She raises her shield just in time. The shield shatters on her arm and she falls back.

Rogelio roars back into action, climbing up the bot's leg and jumping onto its top platform. He grabs one of its laser cannons and rips it free, tossing it down. He moves towards the eye, but the bot swings one of its missile tubes like a club to knock him off. He hits the ground hard and skids several feet, slamming his head into the nearby wall.

Lonnie springs to her feet to check on him, but stops when she sees the bot turn towards her. *Draw it away from the wounded.* She rushes towards the farmhouse, but the bot slams down a foot to block her escape. She looks up at it. The two missile tubes

focus on her, and fire. One tube shorts out with a series of sparks, but the other narrowly misses her, the explosion sending her flying forward and up, smacking into the rounded bottom of the bot's chassis. Thinking quickly, Lonnie grabs the lip of the firing platform and hoists herself up. Pulling up her baton, she smashes the bot's eye and unloads several blasts into its insides. It shudders, sparks and electricity flying everywhere. Leaving her baton, she leaps off and rolls to safety as the bot explodes.

"Ha! Take that!" She laughs, "Overgrown training bot!" She turns to look at Rogelio, who is still slumped over. "Rogelio??" She immediately forgets her pride and rushes over to the lizardman.

Rolling him over, he groans, and growls a thanks. He rubs his head and practically mewls in complaint. "You okay?" She asks, and he nods in the affirmative, getting to his feet with her help. "Well good," She says, looking over his shoulder, "Cuz we got company." He turns, and snarls at the approaching skiff.

Catra

"Come on out!!!" Tung Lashor bellows, "Now that your princess is occupied, I wanna see what this town has to offer!" He laughs his stupid evil laugh.

"Really? I'm much more interesting." Catra shouts.

Tung Lashor turns to her and gasps in recognition. "You!!" He swings his arm up, pointing a white arm cannon at her. Catra raises a stun baton in response.

"You willing to bet your life that you shoot first?" She calls out, "Cause I'm willing to bet mine that I can dodge your little pea shooter."

Tung Lashor grimaces. His hand tenses on the firing mechanism. "You and I have unfinished business!" He growls.

“Do you really want to finish it like this?” Catra responds, “Or do you just not think you could take me in a real fight?”

There are scattered “Ooooh”’s among the assembled bandits.

“Shut up!” Tung Lashor bellows, “I’m the strongest in the Crimson Waste! You cheated last time! That’s the only way you won! But you don’t have any quicksand here!”

“No I don’t.” Catra takes a step forward, “So you wanna put that down and fight me for real?”

There’s a tense moment of silence as both combatants stare each other down. The wind howls through an alleyway, sending a cloud of dust up between them. Catra fingers the firing button on her baton. Her eyes narrow. Tung Lashor hesitates, then swings his arm down and fires his laser into the ground and bellows. He tears his vest off and charges forward, unlimbering a massive bullwhip from his belt.

Adora

Adora ducks around the corner of a building as a shell flies from the tank and detonates some distance away. Rolling forward, she wrenches a portion of the wooden fence ahead from the ground and chucks it towards the tank. The fence shatters across the tank’s armor as Adora rushes forward. She raises the sword, and the bandit in the turret fires a shot that strikes her in the hand.

“Ow!” Her sword vanishes as she rolls to the side, flexing her hand in pain. She looks up at the tank, narrows her eyes and shakes her head. “Oh it’s *on*.”

She sprints to the side, the turret’s rapidly firing projectiles following her and kicking up dust. She dives through a nearby shop’s window and races up the stairs. The tank slams into the front of the building, demolishing the front wall with it’s wedge shaped front. Adora dives out the front window, landing on top of the tank. The gunner looks up in shock, “Woah!”

She slams her foot into the turret, snapping off the barrel. "Jeez, lady!" He shouts. She raises a fist towards him, but looks up as the tank's main gun slams into her stomach, picking her up and taking her for a ride as the tank backs away from the building and starts spinning that gun.

"Hey princess!" The gunner says, hefting a grenade, "Catch!" Adora tenses, then flips up on top of the gun and swings her fist forward, punching the grenade back towards the gunner, who is sent flying out of the tank by the blast.

She has no time to savor her victory before the tank fires a shot, the recoil sending her flying off onto the front of the vehicle. She slides down the wedge and staggers to her feet, only to see the massive vehicle surge forward. She catches it with her hands, and skids across the ground as it pushes her. She gasps in pain as it slams her into a wall. The gun slowly spins around towards her and lowers, the barrel glowing as it revs up a shot directly at her face. Adora desperately looks around, bracing for the end.

Lonnie

"HYAH!" Lonnie swings her foot into the skiff pilot's face, sending her flying off the side. She grabs the rudder and steers it forward, accelerating into the back of the skiff in front of her. She tips the nose of her vehicle down until it scrapes against the hull of the other one, then yanks it upwards. The other skiff capsizes, sending the bandits on board sprawling. From a nearby house, villagers swarm out wielding pots and skillets and clubs and start clobbering the prone bandits.

Lonnie swings her skiff around the back of the town, and sees it happen. She Ra, standing on top of the tank's barrel, punching a grenade out of the air. *'Oh come on. Leave some cool for the rest of us Adora. Typical.'* Her brief fond smile vanishes at the tank fires, sending Adora sprawling. The massive vehicle bulldoses into her, smashing her against a wall. She Ra pushes, but the tank pushes harder.

Lonnie looks around, hoping to see Catra or Bow coming to the rescue, but nothing happens. The tank revs up a shot.

"If it comes down to it, are you gonna choose to save She Ra?"

"If I didn't, who would?"

Lonnie grimaces and accelerates the skiff.

Adora

"Adora! Heads up!" Adora's head snaps to the side just in time to see Lonnie leap off her skiff. The vehicle crashes into the back of the tank in a massive fireball. The barrel swings to the side and fires, missing its shot. "Ha!" Adora smiles, and her hands glow with energy. She swings both fists onto the front of the tank. There's a shockwave as the vehicle skids back. She summons her sword and takes a running leap onto it, plunging the blade into its chassis and tearing a massive gash across it, finishing by swooping up and chopping off the cannon barrel. She leaps off, and the tank explodes behind her.

She rushes over and helps the battered looking Lonnie to her feet. "Thanks!" She says brightly.

"Don't mention it." Lonnie replies, lightly tapping Adora's shoulder.

Catra

The whip smashes down right in front of Catra, kicking up a cloud of dust and debris and forcing her to leap backwards. Tung Lashor presses his offensive, swinging the bullwhip with vicious strength, leaving score marks across the street and nearby walls as Catra retreats.

Finally, she counterattacks. As he raises the whip over his head, she rapidly conjures a glyph that sends a blast of magical wind to smack Tung Lashor in the face. He staggers for a moment, and Catra darts forward. He gets his bearings right as she sprints to

one side, running up a wall to gain the high ground, then slamming her fist into the side of his head. She grabs onto his shoulder and swings her knee into his gut, then hoists herself up and somersaults over his back.

As she lands, she swings an open palm to claw his exposed back, but he spins, grabbing her wrist and cackling before spinning around and hurling her into a nearby porch. She crashes through a wooden support beam and smashes a rocking chair. She lies there for a moment, dazed and hurt, but she comes to just in time to scramble out of the way of a whip blow that demolishes the remains of the chair.

Sliding back into the main street, she carves the glyph to summon her magic energy whip. The orange line appears in her hand, and she swings out with a sideways lash. It cuts across Lashor's stomach, leaving a visible wound. He shouts and looks down in shock, giving Catra the opportunity to wrap her whip around his foot and yank as hard as she can.

He doesn't fall, Catra's not strong enough to fully overpower him, but his foot is pulled out, leaving him flailing to maintain balance on one foot. Grinning, Catra pulls out her components and sends another blast of wind at his head that sends him tumbling head over heels down the street.

"Awwwwww…" She calls out, "Big bad Tung Lashor can't stay on his feet." She strides towards him, swinging her whip out and smacking his hand as he tries to get up. "Go on, stay down. Stay in the dirt and slither away like a good little snake."

Tung Lashor struggles to his feet. His goons are closing in, forming a semicircle around the two combatants, who begin to circle each other.

"Gotta say I am kind of impressed that you managed to claw your way back to the top of the food chain here." Catra admits, "I mean, after I humiliated you, I didn't think you'd have any chance

of regaining power, but here you are. Ready to be humiliated again."

Tung Lashor is glaring at her, and Catra sees his eyes flick right over her shoulder for an instant before he bellows, "Not this time!" and charges forward.

Kyle

Kyle has a vantage point. He's seen the whole fight. He was flabbergasted to see Catra doing magic, but he knows that he can't mess this up. His eyes are scanning the crowd as they gather around the two rivals. Catra taunts Tung Lashor in her trademark fashion. Kyle keeps his eye on the bandits, and he sees something. One of them, a snake lady behind Catra, is pulling something from behind her back. Kyle takes aim. It's not perfect. In this situation how could it be? There's a big chance he could hit Catra at this angle. But he takes the best aim he can.

Everything is in slow motion. Catra ducks, ready to pounce. Tung Lashor is barreling forward, fists clenched and whip swinging into motion. The snake lady pulls out her secret weapon and uncorks it, preparing to dump the flask of cold water onto Catra's back. A childish move, but one that Kyle knows could easily startle Catra enough to prove fatal in the situation.

Kyle squeezes the trigger.

Catra

A beam of green energy streaks overhead. Catra and Tung Lashor both pause in their assaults for a fraction of a second as the beam strikes the thug behind Catra, sending her to the ground, dropping the flask that was in her hand, which begins leaking water onto the sand.

Catra leaps into the air and grabs Tung Lashor's head, hefting her body around his to pull him off balance. "Cute try!" She taunts as

she lands on the ground behind him, "But no." She brings her heel down with full force on his tail, eliciting a surprisingly high pitched squeal of pain.

"That's it!" He roars. He spins around, backhanding Catra hard enough to send her sprawling out of the square. She looks up, and yelps in alarm as he fires a blast from his arm cannon. She leaps out of the way, feeling the tip of her tail get singed. The next blast lands in front of her, causing her to spin back.

Tung Lashor is advancing and cackling, firing blast after blast from his arm cannon. Catra turns and spins around, racing from building to building for cover. Her heart is racing, her mind flashing images of another massive tyrant, chasing her through the Fright Zone firing off beams of destructive red energy, each one nearly killing her.

Catra ducks into an alley and claws her way up the side of the building in front of her as an explosion rocks the ground where she just was.

"Awwww, what's wrong, kitty?" Tung Lashor bellows, still guffawing evilly, "Thought you'd bet your life you could dodge this!" Catra gets to the roof of the building and lays flat. "I'm gonna wear your hide like a coat when I'm done!"

His laser rakes up the side of the building. Catra hears screams from inside. '*No, nonono.*' She crawls to the edge of the roof, careful to stay hidden. '*I've gotta end this before anyone gets hurt.*' She tenses her entire body, and springs off the roof.

Tung Lashor gasps and looks up. He swings his cannon up, but not fast enough. Catra slams a fist into his face with all her might. Landing, she springes up on one leg, and brings her heel down on his cannon, shattering it. She spins around and roundhouse kicks him in the stomach before finishing with both fists uppercutting into his jaw.

The warlord is laid low, spinning across the dirt until he comes to rest at the feet of his gang.

"I thought… I told you!" Catra pants, stepping out of the smoldering wreckage of the building's porch and standing tall, her chest puffed out and eyes wild. "*I'm* the strongest… in the Crimson Waste!!"

Half his gang backs up as he stands and glares at her. The other half starts to step away from their peers, chanting, "Catra! Catra! Catra!"

Tung Lashor struggles to his feet. "This isn't over." He growls. He turns to his remaining bandits, "Finish the job!" The bandits surge forward as Tung Lashor pushes his way towards the back of the crowd.

For a moment, fighting breaks out. The two factions of bandits start attacking each other. Items come flying out of windows as the townsfolk finally join the fray. Regis and his volunteers emerge from invisibility in an alleyway and crash into the bandit's flank, with Melog at their side.

It only lasts a few seconds though, before a massive wind blasts through the square, kicking up dust and knocking several people down.

Catra squints down the street to see a nexus of multicolored light moving towards them. At the center of this beacon stands She Ra, powerful and beautiful.

"Leave this town and never come back." She commands, her voice reverberating with power.

After a beat, The bandits turn and run. They pile onto the remaining skiffs and take off. From the lead skiff, Tung Lashor casts a terrified glance back, where She Ra now stands beside Catra. It looks like the snake man can't tell which figure he fears more.

Most of the bandits who turned on him slowly back up to the edge of town, but a few walk over to Regis's volunteers, helping them to their feet. Catra sees the Horned Goon she dubbed "Kyle" grab the old man's arm and help him up.

Adora sighs, and smiles down at Catra. Catra grins up at her, and leaps up. Adora yelps, catching Catra, who wraps herself around She Ra's torso and bombards her with a passionate kiss.

Lonnie

The battle is over. The bandits had fled, thanks to help from the princesses. Main street had been devastated, and they had stolen some more parts, but Lonnie is confident that their power is broken.

"I guess all I can say," She says to Adora, Bow, and Catra as they stand by their skiff, packed and ready to leave. She stands before a large assembly of townsfolk who have gathered to send their heroes off. "Is thank you. I never thought I'd see this day but… The Princess Alliance has a friend in us." She puts a hand on her chest and bows. More quietly, she looks at Catra and says, "And… you were right. I'm sorry for the way I've treated you. I don't know if I forgive you…"

"You don't have to." Catra assures her.

"But it's a good start." Lonnie finishes.

"I hope we see you again!" Kyle says from beside her. Rogelio roars in agreement, stepping forward and grabbing Adora and Catra in a bear hug worthy of Scorpia.

He sets them down, and Adora smiles. "It may not be us, but the Princesses will always be here to help." She steps up onto the skiff, Catra and Melog following suit.

"Goodbye!" Bow calls out to the townsfolk, who all shout their goodbyes and thanks as the skiff takes off into the distance.

Lonnie smiles after it, and Kyle and Rogelio take her hands.

Our home is safe again. She turns and starts to walk into town with Kyle and Rogelio, only to pause. "One sec," She says, extricating herself from her boys and walking over to Regis.

The old man sustained some bad injuries during the fight. One leg is wrapped up and one arm is in a sling. He's sitting in a wheelchair at the moment, and looks up and smiles at Lonnie.

"Thank you." Lonnie says.

"I did what everyone else did." Regis downplays humbly. "Nothin special about me."

"No, you did more than that." Lonnie says, "You saved She Ra."

"Did I?"

"The tank almost had her, but I remembered what you told me, and I decided to help."

"Huh. Heh." He chuckles and raises an eyebrow. "Sounds to me like you saved She Ra. All I did was ask a question. Doesn't give me the credit for your answer." He reaches up and grasps Lonnie's hand. "Now don't you forget today. I'd say you've pretty well earned the respect of the people here."

Lonnie turns, and sees the whole town arrayed before her. A little girl walks up. "Thank you Missus Marshal." She says, and wraps her arms around Lonnie's leg. A chorus of thanks emerge from the crowd, and Lonnie smiles.

'We've done real good here.' She thinks, looking at Kyle and Rogelio. *'And we've got a lot more left to do.'*

Life in the Crimson Waste is hard. The people who live there have to be tough to survive. Most of the population is bandits and brigands and monsters. In the town of Mudd, though, the people

can live fairly normal lives, protected as they are by the Princess Alliance.

And their Marshal.

Tung Lashor

The shack is in sight. Tung Lashor knows that the shapeshifter isn't going to be pleased with what they bring him, but he also doesn't really care. Their agreement hadn't involved fighting She Ra, after all.

Tung Lashor leaps off of the skiff as it arrives and tosses the sack of parts towards his employer. "There's your parts," He growls, "We're done."

Fygan looks down at the sack and narrows his eyes. "I didn't hire you to do half a job." He says coolly.

"You didn't hire us to go up against princesses either!" Tung Lashor bellows, taking a step forward.

Fygan chuckles. "Oh, I'm sorry. It was my impression that you would be competent enough to handle a town full of helpless farmers *without* bringing the princesses down on your heads." Tung Lashor growls, but the shapeshifter simply sneers and continues. "Well I suppose I shouldn't have expected much. You were disgraced after all, and now that it looks like you've been disgraced again, I have no further use for you." Fygan picks up the back and turns around.

"Pay. Up." Tung Lashor growls.

Fygan stops, and turns. "Ha! Or what?"

"Or…" Tung Lashor stalks towards him, "I'll rip you, and your pathetic little shack apart." He looms over the shapeshifter, whose smug smile turns into a much more menacing expression.

"Tsk tsk." He tuts. "Wrong answer."

Fygan moves faster than Tung Lashor. As the snakeman raises a clawed hand, Fygan spins a crescent wrench out of his sleeve, slamming it with all his strength into Tung Lashor's knee. The warlord screams and falls onto his other knee in pain, and looks up to see Fygan summon a small glyph. Tung Lashor sees a green rune circle appear beneath his feet, and suddenly he can't move.

"What?? What is this?" He says, barely able to form the words.

"This," Fygan explains, "Is a simple immobilization spell. It'll last until I drop my concentration, which means you've got to ask yourself a question." The shapeshifter grabs Tung Lashor's chin and leans in until their faces are almost touching. "Ask yourself if you feel lucky. Because you and I are gonna find out together if I fall asleep before the night falls and the beasts come for you." Fygan stands, looking over Tung Lashor at the other bandits. "You all can go. If you still care about him, you can come back tomorrow to pick up what's left."

Fygan picks up the sack and turns around. While in the doorway, he turns back to Tung Lashor, "Best of luck." He winks, and the door slams shut.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Heart of Darkness, Part 1: Return to Beast Island

Chapter Summary

> In which the Best Friends Squad embark on a dangerous trip to Beast Island to prepare for their upcoming trip into the stars. Meanwhile, Fygan begins to set his final plot in motion.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Fygan

Fygan sets the last device into the crate before closing it. He takes one last look around his shack, just in case. *'If this goes wrong…'* He shakes his head and walks over to one of the boards, pulling down a pinned picture. He looks at it for a long while.

"I'm gonna do it." He mutters. "For you. For all of us." He looks at it for another moment before folding the picture and pocketing it. He picks up the crate and steps out of the shack. The door slams shut behind him.

Catra

Flipping through the air, Catra adjusts to hit the ground running. She arcs around the battlefield, bobbing and weaving between the obstacles to disorient her opponent. She leaps on top of a hay bale and turns to her adversary.

She Ra sends a wave of magical energy towards her, which Catra flips over, rolling across the ground to avoid a second blast and sprinting forward. Now in range, she pulls out her segment of rope and conjures a magic whip, swinging her arm out and wrapping the whip around Adora's right forearm. Catra ducks

behind a low wall, braces her feet, and yanks with all her might, hoping to pull Adora off balance.

The whip goes taut. Catra looks over her shoulder and gasps as She Ra smirks, grabbing onto the whip and pulling, bringing Catra tumbling to the ground at her feet. She brings the point of the blade to Catra's neck and smiles. "I win." She says smugly.

"Ugh." Catra smacks the blade aside and springs to her feet, poking the warrior goddess in the chest. "Of course you win like this."

"Well if we're supposed to be training, we should consider that I do most of my fighting as She Ra." Adora counters.

"You just wanna win!" Catra exclaims indignantly. "You're worse than Netossa."

She Ra chuckles and wraps an arm around Catra's waist. "Now you know that's not true."

"Maybe." Catra says. She looks up into those glowing blue eyes and relaxes for a moment, falling into a soft purr as she palms She Ra's cheek and kisses her.

As she pulls away, She Ra fades into Adora with a heavy sigh. Catra opens her eyes and smiles. '*Wait. Something's wrong.*' Catra cocks her head to one side and studies her partner as the blonde walks around the room, collecting their things. '*She's stiff.*' "Hey, Adora?"

"Yeah?" The blonde looks over her shoulder. '*Her voice sounds tired too*.'

"You okay?" Catra walks over and sits down on one of the benches, gently but forcibly pulling Adora with her.

Adora waves a hand and tries to stand back up. "Pft. I'm fine. I'm She Ra." But upon seeing the look in Catra's eyes, she relents. "Okay… I'm pretty exhausted from yesterday."

'*Ohhhh. Right.*' Yesterday a caravan had been attacked by a pack of beasts in the Whispering Woods. No one died, but there were some bad injuries. Adora had gone She Ra in order to heal them, but that much healing took it out of her.

"It's fine though." Adora reassures, "I'm used to it."

"Alright…" Catra says, hugging the blonde, "Just don't break. I'm not ready to return you yet."

Fygan

First stop. Fygan shivers. Even beneath the fur lined cloak of the guard uniform, the Kingdom of Snows is way too cold for his comfort. Fortunately, this should be the easiest task. The Runestone lies beneath the palace in a largely unguarded cavern. With Frosta occupied with a Horde cell at the border, he has a limited window of total access to the Fractal Flake.

No turning back. He breathes, and walks towards the palace.

Glimmer

Glimmer looks around the assembled crowd. The mood is somber as they look at the holographic display on the war table. Micah especially is slumped in his chair, looking at it with a hollow expression, while Adora and Bow are grim-faced.

Entrapta points a long hair tendril towards the center of the display. "My lab is there, in the center of the island. That's where the greatest concentration of power is, because that's where the thullite crystals are."

"Entrapta," Bow says slowly, "Are you sure they're thullite?"

"Yes!" The scientist says excitedly, "Definitely! I mean- probably. I remember them looking almost identical to the crystals we used to refuel Darla in space, only more of them!" She flips out a tablet and begins tapping on it. "And the readings we've gotten from

Beast Island are very similar to the readings I got from that planet. My current hypothesis is that Beast Island is such a hotbed of activity because it was once an ancient First Ones ship, a *big one*. My lab, the temple, must have been built on top of the power source."

"And there's no other way?" Glimmer asks.

"Nnnnope!" Entrapta slashes her hands in an X in front of her, "Thullite doesn't naturally occur on Etheria, and without it we've got no chance of making it very far in space. And this could be a big enough haul to fuel Darla for *years*."

"Then it's settled." Adora says firmly. "We'll go to Beast Island, we'll get the thullite, and we'll leave."

"Great!" Entrapta squeaks.

Glimmer glowers at Adora. "It's not that simple." She says through gritted teeth, "Who's going to go? We can't just rush into a dead zone on a hunch that there's thullite there!"

"There is no other option." Hordak says from across the table. "If Entrapta believes the crystal to be present, then it is present."

"Okay," Glimmer says, "So send a scout drone to find out!"

Bow shakes his head, "We've tried. Beast Island's signal scrambles Prime's robots. We've lost over a dozen drones trying to find out more about that place."

"They're there." Micah says quietly. The whole room turns to look at him. He nods to the smaller hologram, the display of the thullite crystal. "I've seen them." There's a pause, but he doesn't elaborate, clearly being drawn back into a memory. General Juliet reaches down and places her hand on his shoulder, squeezing gently to bring him back to the present. He looks around the table. "I'll go."

"Your Majesty-" Adora begins, but Glimmer speaks first, "Dad, no. You don't have to go back there."

"It's only logical," The king protests, "I have more experience on Beast Island than any living person."

"That's exactly why you shouldn't go." Adora pleads, "Beast Island preys on fear. And all due respect sir, but you're pretty clearly scared of it."

Micah stands up abruptly. "It doesn't matter!" He shouts, "I'm going. I'm not going to let my baby girl anywhere near that place!"

"Dad!" Glimmer says. Micah looks down at her, his face desperate. She forces herself to stay firm, "That's not your decision to make. I *need* to be there. I'm the only one who can get us out if things go wrong." Micah sits down hard, looking like his soul has been crushed. Glimmer closes her eyes and stands. "We're going to the most dangerous place on Etheria." She begins, "Bow, Adora, Catra, Entrapta, Hordak, and I will go." A mewl from Catra's side prompts, "And Melog."

Swift Wind finally speaks up, "Uhm, Adora is not going to that nightmare place without me."

Glimmer is ready to acquiesce, but Adora protests, "Swifty, no! You know you're more susceptible to the signal than us. It's too dangerous."

Swift Wind huffs, "But you need protection! And my above-human senses! And last time you were there She Ra wasn't working right, so you may need me for that too!"

Bow raises a hand. "Swift Wind, how about you come along and stay with the ship. You can be our plan B if things go wrong."

The horse considers this. "Okay…" He looks at Adora and says earnestly, "But promise you'll contact me if you need me."

Adora smiles, “I promise.”

The table looks to Glimmer. “Let’s get ready.” She says.

Micah

Most parents don’t have to go through this. Even a child going off to war would be preferable to this. Micah fights back the urge to lock everyone in place with magic and go on his own as he watches his little girl getting her supplies ready.

They’ll be fine. They’re the most capable group of people on Etheria.

He clenches his fist. *It doesn’t matter on Beast Island. It doesn’t matter how powerful you are. If you’re not smart, you’re dead.*

They’re smart too. They’re going to be fine. They’re going to be fine. She’s going to be fine.

Entrapta and Hordak are running diagnostics on the ship. Swift Wind is fretting over Adora while Catra is reading every report on Beast Island she could find. Melog has a special bag containing cookies made by Catra held in their mouth. A ways away, Bow is video calling his parents, who are likely even more terrified than Micah.

Glimmer walks up to Micah with a confident smile on her face. “Dad. We’ve beaten worse odds than this.”

“I know.” Micah says. They’d rescued Glimmer and Catra from Horde Prime, they could handle Beast Island. “But you didn’t have a choice then. You do now.”

Glimmer takes his hands. “I’ll be okay. We all will.”

Micah puts a hand on Glimmer’s shoulders. “Be careful.”

Entrapta pops her head out. “We’re ready to go!” Everyone slowly stands and moves towards the ship.

Entrapta moves towards Micah on her hair tendrils. "I believe I've configured our communication signal properly to avoid interference from Beast Island. If not, I'll be able to get it working within an hour after arriving. We'll be in touch."

Micah nods, but his attention is over her head. He locks eyes with Glimmer as she looks back and smiles before entering the ship. *This isn't goodbye. They're going to be fine.*

"We'll… be okay, you know." Entrapta says awkwardly, clearly unsure of how to comfort him, "I know Beast Island pretty well too, and if we find EJ, we'll be perfectly fine!" She lifts up on her hair and pats him on the head before spinning around and entering the ship.

Micah looks to the ship. Adora stands in the doorway, locking eyes with the king. She nods silently, saying *"I'll keep them safe."* without words. The doorway closes. The ramp retracts, and the ship lifts off into the air.

Fygan

The repaired Sea Gate looms ahead of them. The ship Fygan is on stops short. A conversation between the captain and the gate guards ensues before the massive glowing wall drops, and Fygan breathes again. He hadn't known that the Sea Gate was repaired, but luck is on his side, and the guards weren't too thorough.

They will be soon enough. If any of them are left.

He disembarks the ship and ducks into an alleyway, quickly changing his clothes and his form into a blue skinned fishman royal guard. He carefully adjusts the outfit as he stands and marches towards the palace. Casting glances around, a ship in the harbor catches his eye, and he almost laughs out loud at his good fortune. There's Princess Mermista in the harbor, on a boat with her little boyfriend, leaving The Pearl unguarded.

And here I was thinking Salineas would be the most difficult.

He walks into the palace, admitted by the guards, who recognize his armor. He steps into the throne room, which is currently empty. The Pearl sits in its spot above the throne. Fygan breathes, and summons a spell circle, running around the edges of the room leaving an invisible wire at every entry point. If something moves within 10 feet of those alarms, he'll know. He wastes no time in leaping onto the throne and scrambling up the wall to The Pearl's mounting spot. He pulls the tools from his boots and sets to work.

Adora

With the notable exception of Entrapta, everyone's mood on the flight to Beast Island is somber. Glimmer is going through her spells, deciding which ones may be useful. Bow is inventorying his arrows, going through net arrows, fire arrows, goop arrows, a sonic arrow, and a grappling arrow. Adora gets up from her chair, tuning out Entrapta's excited ramblings about her time there to Hordak, and walks over to the edge of the bridge. Catra is perched on the windowsill gazing out over the ocean. Adora reaches up and takes her hand.

"You ready for this?" She asks quietly.

Catra scoffs gently, "Pft. No." But she looks down at Adora with a smile, "But if I'm with you…" She trails off and looks back out the window. "We'll be okay. You've… survived Beast Island before. If King Micah was there for 16 years it must not be as bad as the stories say, right?" She turns back to Adora, clear hope sparking in her eyes.

I can't lie to her. She needs to be prepared. "No." Adora says. She lets go of Catra's hand and leans on the sill. It's her turn to gaze contemplatively over the sea. "It's worse. The beasts aren't even the most dangerous part, it's… The island gets in your head. There's this, this signal that comes from the center of the island and drives you into despair. And, Catra," Adora looks up at her girlfriend, "It's going to hit you the hardest."

Catra's eyes widen and she flinches back. "What? What does that mean?"

"You have better hearing than the rest of us. When we came here the first time, Swift Wind was the most vulnerable to the signal because he heard it first and loudest." Adora sighs. "The same thing will probably happen to you. As long as we stay together, we should be alright."

Catra's pupils narrow, and she jumps when Entrapta shouts, "We're arriving at Beast Island!!"

Adora turns and walks over to the captain's chair. Everyone gathers around her, many of them taking seats in the newly added chairs around the cockpit. Bow and Entrapta stand facing the company.

"Okay," Bow begins. "We're going to attempt a landing on the interior of the island, coming in from above and getting as close to the center as possible. Once we land, Swift Wind will stay with the ship while the rest of us make our way towards the center."

"If we're able to find EJ, that'll make it a lot easier!" Entrapta says excitedly.

"EJ?" Glimmer inquires.

"Emily Junior!" The scientist explains, "She's a humongous robot slash transport I built last time I was here. We had to leave her behind to cover our escape but I promised I'd come back for her."

"It will be nice if we find her," Adora says, "But we're not going out of our way to do so, okay?"

Entrapta sighs and her hair droops. "Okay."

Swift Wind raises a wing, "Uh, didn't Darla get all… crashy last time we were here?"

Bow nods, “Hopefully the modifications Entrapta has made will avoid that. If not, then we’ve got a little longer trip ahead.”

Adora looks up past them, out the window, and furrows her brow. “Ummm… Darla?” The ship beeps to life, “Bring up an image of Beast Island.” A pink hologram appears of the scrap heap, a massive, twisting mountain of metal and debris, all sharp angles and jagged peaks. Adora stands from her chair and pulls out a spyglass, peering at what she sees on the horizon. *‘Oh no…’* The island is much more green than last time.

“The magic of Etheria’s release affected Beast Island too.” Adora declares. “We’re going into unknown territory.”

The statement is met with scared silence before Glimmer speaks up. “That’s okay. We stick to the plan.”

Darla rockets towards the island, which looms above them as it gets closer. Catra squeezes Adora’s hand as everyone gets strapped in. They’re closing in on the island, much closer than they were the first time the ship crashed, when Swift Wind starts breathing heavily. “I can hear it!” He panics, “The signal! It’s so much stronger than before!” Catra’s eyes have gone wide, her pupils nothing more than slits. Her ears flatten against her head.

Alarms begin to go off, and the ship begins to nosedive. *So much for Entrapta’s modifications*. “Brace yourselves!” Adora shouts.

Darla stabilizes just before hitting the water and skims across the surface until crashing into an outcropping of land. “Everyone okay?” Adora says, looking around. Everyone looks spooked, but alright.

Entrapta pulls out her communicator and begins turning dials. “Micah? King Micah, come in!” The screen displays static, but eventually, after both she and Bow make some adjustments and switch to one of his communicators, they get a voice signal.

“Yes, yes! We hear you!” Micah’s distorted voice comes through. “Are you at Beast Island?”

“We are.” Adora says, a little louder than is probably necessary, just to make sure.

“Oh no… I mean, good! That’s what we want- for some... reason.” He says. “A few tips. The bugs are the only things that are really safe to eat. If you encounter monsters, fight them. Running away will only increase your fears and allow the island to corrupt you more easily.” He sighs. “Good luck.”

Adora looks at the looming tech infested jungle before them. ‘*We’ll need it.’*

Glimmer

“Well, it’s not that bad so far…” Glimmer says, trying to maintain optimism.

“Sparkles, we’re still on the beach.” Catra snaps.

“We should not be here.” Hordak mutters. He has his arm cannon prepared and is scanning the surroundings.

Micah’s tinny sounding voice comes out of Bow’s tracker pad. “Are you all alright so far?”

“Yes.” The archer responds. “We’ve left the ship and Swift Wind. We’re about to move in.”

Entrapta lets out a squeaky cackle as she climbs up a nearby pillar covered in plants and vines. *‘It’s weirdly beautiful.’* Glimmer admits to herself, *‘Kind of like the Fright Zone.’*

Looking into the jungle is somewhat disorienting. The geometry of Beast Island isn’t normal. There are massive pillars leading up into a canopy of tech, huge platforms seemingly hanging from a ceiling shrouded in darkness, massive trees that bend and twist in strange angles, and much of it is covered in greenery and lush vegetation. Even the metal surfaces of the First Ones’ tech has moss and lichen growing on them.

“Dah!” Catra squeaks and leaps into Adora’s arms as a bug emerges from beneath a rock.

“What was that!?” Micah asks in alarm, “Are you alright??”

“We’re fine dad!” Glimmer says exasperatedly. “It was just a bug.”

“Oh! Eat it. Fuel for your journey.” He says.

“Let’s go.” Adora says, and starts walking into the island.

*****

Almost immediately upon entering the dense jungle they lose sight of the beach. Entrapta leaves various blinking beacons behind them in the hopes of giving them a path back, but even those are quickly swallowed by the darkness.

Catra squeaks in alarm as a tree branch snaps above her and falls onto her head. She skids back onto all fours, her tail ramrod straight into the air. “I hate this place.” She growls, smacking aside Bow’s proffered hand.

“Yeah,” Bow nods, “This is what my nightmares have nightmares about.”

“It’s strange how long we’ve gone without hearing the signal!” Entrapta calls back, typing away on her tablet, “This is one of the longer gaps I’ve experienced.”

Glimmer looks around. Under the foliage, there are lights. The First Ones tech that makes up the island is eternally active, humming and blinking in various moving patterns and flashes that make navigation even more difficult. They’ve seen nothing larger than bugs so far, but the ever present chittering and distant screeches keep them all on edge.

“Do you guys need help!?” A startlingly loud voice comes from Bow’s communicator.

“Swift Wind!” Adora says through gritted teeth. “We’ll contact you if we need help, okay??”

“Sorry, sorry.” The horse says, “I’ll just… be here. Waiting. Alone. *Floatin’ on a ship off the coast of Nightmare Islan-”* Bow cuts off the transmission just as the horse begins to sing.

They sigh and move on. A noise draws Glimmer’s attention, and her hands light up with magic as she snaps around, seeing a dark shape flit out of view.

That’s when the signal comes again. The noise is omnipresent, but quiet. It both invades Glimmer’s head and the air around her. She twitches, but Catra and Melog both look around in alarm.

‘They must hear it a lot louder than everyone else.’ Glimmer thinks. Adora summons her sword and looks around, “That’s a lot farther range than last time.” She says.

From the communicator, they hear sudden raised voices on Micah’s transmission before it cuts out suddenly.

“Dad??” Glimmer rushes over and grabs the communicator, “Dad, are you okay??”

Juliet

King Micah leans over the war table, studying their barebones holographic image of Beast Island. The sounds of the party walking through the jungle echo from the table’s speakers. After a brief interruption by Swift Wind, there is a pause, before a noise begins to ring out of the speaker. It’s like a horn and a siren, layered on top of each other a dozen times, with a steady ringing and electronic modulation, as well as faint voices in the background. Juliet winces as the noise fills the room. The other people in the room all hold their hands to their ears, save King Micah.

He begins to look around wildly, a haunted look in his eyes. “I knew it!” He whispers hoarsely.

“Your Majesty?” Juliet takes a step towards him.

“I’m still there! None of this is real! None of you are real!” The king backs up against the wall, knocking his throne over with a clatter.

“Your majesty, come to your senses!” Chancellor Brannic says, but Micah swings around to the source of the noise and launches a jet of fire towards the chancellor, who is tackled by one of his guards.

“King Micah!” Juliet shouts, only to dodge another gout of flame. She rolls forward and slams her hand on the button to end the communication. The signal fades away, but King Micah is hyperventilating, looking around the room like he’s back on Beast Island.

“It got me. I have to wake up!” He murmurs manically.

Ground him. Bring him back to the present. Juliet dives forward. Micah screams and sinks to his knees. She slides across the floor in front of him until she’s kneeling face to face with him. She places her hands on his cheeks. “Your Majesty!” She says in a quiet but firm voice, not wanting to overwhelm him with loud noises, “You’re in Bright Moon.” She gently presses her forehead against his. “You’re home. You’re safe. The signal isn’t here.”

Micah’s panicked breathing slowly subsides, and tears begin to fall from his eyes. He goes somewhat limp, falling forward against Juliet’s shoulder as he shakes. “It still controls me…” He says quietly, “It’s like my mind wasn’t my own again.”

Juliet shivers, remembering her own time chipped by Horde Prime. She embraces the king. “Your mind is your own.” She says firmly. “You are Micah, King of Bright Moon. You’ve beaten Beast Island before, and you can do it again.”

Micah nods, and slowly stands again. “My apologies.” He says to the gathered people. Brannic slowly rises from behind his chair, one of his cuffs gently smouldering. Micah turns to Juliet. “Thank you, General. I think it’s best if we proceed with minimal audio communication from this point forward. Who knows what the signal could do here once they get further into the island.”

Juliet nods, and plugs a tablet into the war table to begin text communication.

Bow

“Signal goes through communications,” Bow reads the text on his screen as everyone gathers around him with bated breath, “Best to communicate without audio for now. Contact if vitally necessary.”

Everyone breathes a sigh of relief. Bow furrows his brow. ‘*Beast Island’s signal can travel through communicators. It’s like a virus. That makes this a lot more dangerous. I wonder if the open text channel will transmit the signal too…?*’ He shakes his head and sighs. This place has him on edge.

The party moves forward, and begins to make their way upward on a long stone bridge that leads to a ridgeline in the distance. The bridge is thin and warbling, almost like it’s made of volcanic glass. ‘*This place would be so beautiful and fascinating if it weren’t so deadly.*’ Bow thinks, looking around as the twisted sculptures of vaguely Euclidean shapes and spires surrounding them.

Adora holds up a hand for the group to stop. “What’s wrong?” Catra asks. But Bow already knows. He pulls out an arrow and spins around to look behind them. Everything is silent. ‘*Silence is never for a good reason on Beast Island.*’

A sound comes from beneath them, like a slurping, sucking groan, and a massive purple blob oozes up onto the bridge in front of

them, sliding up one of the pillars and coagulating into a large central mass blocking their path.

Hordak grunts and raises his arm cannon, which begins glowing, but Catra smacks his hand. “Are you crazy?” She hisses, “You’ll blow the whole bridge!”

Adora begins to glow as she summons her sword. “For the Honor of Grayskull!!” To Bow’s relief, She Ra works this time, and Adora steps forward to the massive purple ooze. She swings her sword horizontally, not making contact, but sending a wave of energy washing over the beast. The ooze moves back, then unleashes another horrible slurping sound and surges forward.

Glimmer’s up next, bringing up a translucent pink wall of force that the ooze crashes into. She teleports up to the top and conjures a fire spell that tears into the ooze. As the fire burns through it, though, a vibrant pink gas erupts from the wound. Glimmer gets a face full of the stuff and almost immediately staggers back, falling backwards off the rapidly fading wall. Bow dives forward, dropping his bow to catch the unconscious Princess.

Catra lunges in and slashes the ooze, only to immediately shout in pain and fall back, her hand sizzling. Entrapta lets out an “Aaaaahaaa!” and begins pressing buttons on her vambraces, sending a green laser streaking towards the ooze. It strikes, releasing more of the vapor. Everyone backs away from the wounded creature leaking its noxious gas.

“Uhhhh, any ideas!?” Adora says, swinging her blade to keep it at bay.

“I have the shot.” Hordak says, raising his cannon.

“If you miss, the bridge goes!” Catra shouts, “It’s too risky!”

“I won’t miss!” Hordak retorts confidently.

Melog lets out a yowl as a large iron wall appears in front of the ooze. Unfortunately, it doesn't slow it down, as the purple fluid moves through the illusion without missing a beat. *It must be sensing us as life forms somehow*. A pseudopod lashes out towards She Ra, slapping against her arm and leaving a steaming wound.

"Ahhh!" Adora shouts and staggers back from a second pseudopod. "Hordak take the shot!"

Hordak's cannon, the most powerful weapon at their disposal, glows red and revs up to fire.

That's when everything goes wrong.

The signal explodes into everyone's heads. Hordak starts, and his cannon goes off. He hits the ooze, but instead of a clean shot, it rakes across its body in an almost "Z" shape before exploding, sending flabby chunks of ooze and noxious gas flying through the air.

A slab of purple gunk smacks into She Ra's face, sending her staggering back, dangerously close to the edge. Catra leaps upwards, grabbing onto the side of a hanging U-shaped vine.

Bow falls backwards, the barely conscious Glimmer on top of him.

There is a rumble beneath them, and the bridge explodes upwards as a massive green wormlike creature rams into it from below.

Adora goes flying into the air, She Ra falling out of shock. She spins off into darkness below.

Entrapta grabs onto Melog, who leaps forward onto the safe ground on the far side of the bridge.

Hordak doesn't have time to dodge. Bow watches in horror as the creature's head opens like a flower and engulfs him. Entrapta's distraught cry of "HORDAK!!" is lost in the chaos.

Catra’s vine snaps right over her hands, and she plummets, clinging on for dear life and yowling as the momentum carries her far out of sight.

Bow scrambles to his feet and picks up Glimmer before turning and running. The bridge is collapsing behind them. He sprints, losing his footing on the shattering rock several times. They reach the beginning of the bridge, and he dives onto the ground, turning to look at the mostly destroyed formation, the massive dust cloud it kicked up, and the sudden, crushing realization.

They’ve been separated. They’re alone and lost on Beast Island.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed. Comments and kudos are always appreciated!

Heart of Darkness, Part 2: Separated

Chapter Summary

> In which our heroes are scattered across Beast Island, Catra meets a strange creature, and Fygan encounters Perfuma.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra lands on her feet. The branch she landed on does immediately break, sending her tumbling head over heels to an undignified sprawl on the ground, but credit must be given to her initial landing. She gets to her feet and groans. Her whole body is aching, and her hand is numb from scratching that purple jelly monster. Looking around, everything's blurred and wobbly. She looks around and crawls into a hollow underneath a large tree's roots, waiting for the disorientation she assumes to be from the ooze's poison to wear off.

The signal of Beast Island fades into the distance, replaced by the chittering screeches of animals. Catra considers calling out. *Maybe some of them are within earshot.* But she shakes her head. *There are definitely monsters galore within earshot.*

After a few minutes, the poison wears off. She looks down at the bug crawling on her leg. She picks it up by the tail and regards it. "Well, when on Beast Island…" She stabs the bug with her claws, then pops it into her mouth. `*Surprisingly not… terrible. I can see why Micah likes these.'*

She stands up and starts walking in the direction she's fairly certain she came from. She spun around a lot, and hit a few trees, so it's entirely possible she's going the complete wrong way.

To one side of her, a bush rustles. Without hesitation, she pulls out a length of rope and conjures an energy whip, swinging it down with a cry and shattering the bush. Leaping away, a strange four legged beast chitters. It's narrow head ends in a hooklike beak, and its legs end in razor sharp points. Catra cracks her whip again, and the beast turns and darts away. "Maybe this'll be like the Crimson Waste." She mutters to herself hopefully, "I could make my way here."

'No. I have to find Adora and the others.'

A familiar voice creeps into the back of her head, a voice whose low, condescending mockery Catra hasn't imagined in a while. "*Leave them. You'll only slow them down.*"

"Shut up." She growls to the air.

"*Foolish child. You can never be truly alone. I'm a part of you*."

"Yeah I know. You're all my negative thoughts. You aren't real."

"*I am as real as you are.*"

"Why am I even talking to you? Gah!" Catra growls and shakes her head. She's been on her own for five minutes and she's already talking to the voices in her head.

"*Typical. A burden even to yourself.*"

"Shut up." Catra's barely even angry at the voice. Shadow Weaver is long gone. Catra's subconscious just uses her voice to torture her. She's honestly just annoyed and terrified of the island. "I just want to get back, now… buzz off." She swings her whip ahead of her, slashing through a hanging sheet of vines. As she steps through, she hears a creeping sound behind her, and spins around to see the vines have regrown, some of them almost seem to be reaching for her. She shudders and moves away with haste.

A voice rings out. Not in her head this time, but real. It's wavering, almost like the speaker is struggling to articulate each

word, and there's a strange aspect to it, almost a subtle gurgling behind the words and a clicking on certain syllables. "You… aaare lost, are you, not? I can… hhhhelp. You. If… you do not… attack me."

"Show yourself first." Catra says, her hackles raised and her heart rate elevated. No way is she just going to trust the creepy voice in the darkness. She spins as she sees movement.

The figure crawls around a tree and settles on a root looking down at her. Its bottom half is made up of four insectoid legs with grabbing pincers at the end, allowing it to climb and grip. Its upper half, however, is rather humanoid in shape, if not form. It's covered in dark blue armor, and appears to have wires emerging at odd angles, along with other mechanical parts that call to mind a more ramshackle version of Hordak's armor. It has two arms with three-clawed hands clasped in front of it. Draped over its shoulders is a large cloak whose hood obscures much of the entity's head. The face is shadowed, but Catra can see a circular mouth filled with sharp teeth, and a pair of mandibles outside of it. Above, there are two wide sunken hollows with glowing red eyes almost floating in the center. The eyes unsettle Catra the most. Despite the figure's alien nature, those eyes are uncomfortably human aside from the red coloration.

The entity looks her up and down. "You… are… llllost. Looking for your f-friends, eh? Those you c-came with?"

"How do you know that?" Catra says, moving her whip to ready an attack. The eyes shrink back in those sunken sockets and it steps back.

"I hhhhave listened to the island. And I heard of your arrival." It's speech is starting to grow more normal, as if remembering how to talk after years of disuse.

"Listened to the island?" Catra says, still highly suspicious. "Who are you anyway? I didn't know the monsters here could talk."

“Monster? No no, I am not of Beast Island. I was… exiled here. Cast. Out.” The last words bear venom. *There’s a story there.*

“You were sent here. Are you…” Catra hazards a guess, “from the Horde?”

The eyes gleam with recognition, and the creature breathes in a shaky breath. “Ahhhhh. Yesss. Yes! The Horde.” It begins to crawl off the branch, arcing around her. Catra turns to remain facing it. “I gave everything to the Horde, and now… Now I am here. I… ha-have been here for ssso long.”

“Rrright.” Catra says, backing away from the crazy bug-person. “I’m good on my own, thanks.”

The creature raises what passes for an eyebrow and points over her shoulder, warning in a surprisingly dry tone, “You are about to step into a viper heart’s jaws.” Catra helps and spins, looking to the indentation in the ground that resembles an open red flower. It hisses in displeasure as she leaps away. “I know your caution, but- you need a guide. And no one knows Beast Island better than… I do.”

Catra sighs. “Fair point. You go first.” The figure seems to smile as it walks forward. “First,” She says, “Who are you?”

“Ahhhh yessss. My name is…” The entity trails off, “Is… Uhmm hold on.” It scratches its head. “My name… I’ve long since forgotten. For now, just… call me Old One. I will take you to the center of the island.”

“My friends. Take me to my friends.”

“Yes of course.” He snaps, “We must start our search at the center. The center is where the Lost go to be found.” The Old One begins to move forward, and, seeing no other option, Catra follows.

Hordak

The massive serpent creature captures Hordak in its jaws. Hordak collapses against the walls of the mouth, and quickly adjusts. He realizes that what seemed to be a tongue is in fact the creature's true head, hidden inside the protective shell that has him contained. Hordak swings a fist into the side of this crocodilian head, which has its toothy jaws open and snapping at him. It recoils from the strike, which hits one of its many purple eyes.

Hordak can feel the creature lurching and moving. *Moving away from Entrapta… No!*

In desperation, Hordak revs up his arm cannon. The monster swings its head, battering Hordak's stomach against the inner wall of its head shell. Hordak jabs the arm cannon into its mouth as it hisses, and lets loose.

The discharge of energy sends him blasting out of the worm's mouth in a plume of fire and smoke. The beast screams in pain, smoke billowing from its mouth as it writhes around. Hordak skips across the ground before crashing into a small tree, which promptly collapses on top of him. *Fate has elected to make me a play toy.*

Hordak groans and struggles to his feet, taking stock of his surroundings. The ground is uneven, and the groaning beast will soon attract the attention of other creatures. He must find a more advantageous position to begin planning.

He looks at his gauntlet, and presses a button, praying that it's still functional. To his relief, it begins to blink red. *Good. Entrapta's tracker is still functional*. Subconsciously, he almost wishes that Entrapta hadn't removed the shocker from his ankle. The uncomfortable shock of separation from her would have helped him focus.

Flexing his left arm, a blade emerges from the gauntlet above his hand, which he uses to cut his way through the dense underbrush and vines blocking his path. More than once he finds a vine wrapped around the blade, almost as if the plant were attempting

to wrench the weapon out of his grip. He tears through though, eventually coming to a ridgeline overlooking a deep gorge. Movement is visible in the depths, and with his eyes well adjusted to darkness, Hordak grimaces at the realization that it is a nest, full of the serpentine creatures he just escaped from. He snarls and turns, moving away from the outcropping.

His gauntlet flashes dimly. He is far away from Entrapta. It's not a perfect system, so he will just have to move in one direction and hope the flashes get brighter.

"Hordak?" A voice. Entrapta's voice, echoing unnaturally around him.

"Entrapta!?" He calls out. There is no answer. He snarls. *The island is playing tricks on me.*

The signal of Beast Island blares out, screaming into his ears and mind. Hordak shouts in pain and covers his ears, falling to his knees.

This is what I deserve. All the people I sent here… All those I punished for failing me… Now I suffer the same fate I condemned them to. It is fitting. I escaped justice at the hands of the princesses, only to face it here. The consequences of my own mania.

"NO!" Hordak cries, rising to his feet. "I will not fall here!" He shouts defiantly. "I overcame the power of Prime! You shall not defeat me!"

Through the noise of the fading signal, a faint, sinister whisper creeps into Hordak's mind.

"*Did you?*"

Hordak stands, shaking for a moment, then growls and turns, hacking his way through the foliage to get back to his Entrapta.

Fygan

Plumeria. Fygan has spent almost a minute just standing and taking in the beauty of this place. Everyone here is so peaceful and happy. *They were barely a part of the war. I don't need to do this here.*

Yes I do. If things are going to really change, I can't take half measures. He grits his teeth and walks towards the Heart Blossom. He looks up at the tree, with the runestone embedded in its heart. *A metaphor for the princesses if ever there was one. A massive blockage, preventing proper growth. Convincing the surrounding organisms that its making life better somehow, but really… it's a cancer.*

Fygan walks to the backside of the tree, and pulls up a spell circle. He presses his hand against the tree and spins it, creating a perfectly circular cut out of wood. With some difficulty, he pops the plug out of the tree and places the device on the back of the runestone. He chuckles silently as he replaces the plug. *Oh Princesses. So arrogant and secure in your power. With no idea just how easily it could all slip through your fingers.* A quick wave of his hand, and any evidence of his meddling is covered in an illusion.

He walks around the tree and begins to cross the clearing when the worst happens.

"Oh! Hello traveller!" The voice of Princess Perfuma calls out to him, causing him to stop in his tracks. "Is there something I can help you with?"

Fygan spins, and, speaking quickly, begins to talk. He hopes his speech matches his chosen form, because for the life of him, he cannot remember exactly what that form looks like. "Yes, I was actually looking for you, Princess Perfuma. My name is Bai, and I've travelled a long time in search of enlightenment. Forgive me but, might I join you for meditation?"

The princess practically squees at the proposition. "Of course you may!" She waves her hand, and Fygan feels a cushion of plants

sweep him up and spirit him to a meditation clearing before he can say another word.

Adora

"Unnnnnghhhh… huh? GAHHH!" Adora comes to her senses upside down, wrapped in vines, face to face with a Pooka. The cycloptic creature hisses at her and leaps backwards as she flails around. "For the honor of Grayskull!" She says, attempting to raise her hand and invoke the power of She Ra.

Nothing happens. The Pooka chirps and cocks its head curiously. She hears more beeping chirps approaching from the dark. A pack.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" A flash of light this time, but still no She Ra. Her heart begins to beat faster. The Pooka chitters, almost like it's laughing at her. Straining against the vines, she reaches her belt and pulls out the cylinder there. Pressing a button, the segmented blade unfurls and locks into position. With a few slashes, she's free, flipping to the ground below. The Pooka hops backwards and hisses. Two more Pookas crawl out beside it. Adora quickly spins around, taking stock of the pink lights blinking in the darkness. She's surrounded, and She Ra isn't responding. She clicks the other button, and the extended handle springs out of her weapon. Getting a grip on it, she charges towards the three Pookas in front of her. They seem to be the weakest link in the pack.

A sweeping strike sends one of them flying while the other two leap backwards and scatter. Taking advantage of the opening, Adora sprints forward, using her spear to vault over a large root in the way and landing on the other side. After landing, she turns on a dime and starts running a different direction, hoping it might misdirect the Pookas. She swings the blade in front of her, slashing off the tip of a vine reaching for her. *Not doing that this time*. She darts forward and slides underneath a raised rock formation, once again taking the opportunity to turn and change

her direction. She can still hear the Pookas, though it doesn't sound like the whole pack is following her.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" She tries, panting through the phrase while running. Nothing. "GAH! What is wrong with you??" She asks her sword, forgetting for a moment that it's not the Sword of Protection.

"Scaaiiiiii!" A Pooka screeches as it leaps down at her. Swinging her sword like a bat, she strikes the beast and sends it careening. Ducking behind a tree, she pauses and listens. The Pooka's chitters and beeps have faded into the distance. *They must have found some easier prey.* After about a minute, she sinks to the ground and lets her head fall back against the tree. *What's happened to She Ra?*

She looks at her reflection in her new sword. Looking back at her is Adora. Normal Adora. Not special, or powerful, or unique. Nothing more than a blue eyed face and a ragged blonde ponytail.

"Come onnnn." She says, holding up her free hand, "For the Honor of Grayskull!" No response from She Ra. "What's happening? Last time I was here it was blocked because I was afraid… But I'm not afraid now. Where are you…?" She asks She Ra, "I thought I was done with this sort of thing. Is it because Catra's not here? I'm sure… Catra's… she, she's fine on her own. She'll be fine." *Will she though? Catra doesn't exactly have a good track record of being fine on her own*. Adora closes her eyes and sighs. Right now, she needs to trust that all of her friends will be okay until she can save them. *They're all powerful, capable people. Especially Catra*. Adora rises to her feet, holding her sword-spear like a walking staff. *Nothing to do but start walking.*

As an experiment, she walks over to a nearby rock and cracks it in half, creating a fairly smooth flat surface upon which she places a thin strip of metal, attempting to fashion a makeshift compass. To her not-so-great surprise, the metal spins every which way. Figures. No navigation on Beast Island. "No Navigation. No She Ra. No friends. Just me. Just Adora. Hooooo…" Adora starts

walking, only to stop and smack her forehead. “Not just Adora!” She says aloud. She closes her eyes, and calls out with all her spiritual might to Swift Wind.

Entrapta

Click

E: “Beast Island Log, Time Cycle… I don’t remember where I left off so we’ll just start with One! Our group has been separated, which, while unfortunate, has left me in the enviable position to spend some study time with Catra’s alien cat friend! Say hi Cat friend!”

M: “*Meerowl.*”

E: “Since the separation, they have been alternating between pacing around and standing still with their eyes closed. I believe they may be attempting to telepathically reach out to Catra. Is it working?”

M: “*Grrellll…*”

E: “Their mane changes color based on emotion, and also reflects Catra’s emotion. Right now it is swirling yellow, which seems to indicate anxiety based on the other-” *A loud rumbling noise. Entrapta laughs*. “Ahahaha! We’ve been found by a large creature! I haven’t seen this one before though. It hangs from the canopy above with large ape-like arms and has bladed fee- GAHHHHH! IT’S ATTACKING! CAT FRIEND SAVE US!”

Click

*****

Click

E: *Somber*. “Beast Island Log, Time Cycle One. I located Emily Junior. Unfortunately she was barely functional. I was able to get her operational enough to say goodbye… Catra’s friend is

reflecting my emotions right now, their mane has turned to a deep swirling blue.” *Metallic pats*. “You did good, girl. Rest well EJ.”

E: *chipper again* “In other news, my gauntlet is blinking, which means Hordak should find me soon. I intend to stay in the safety of EJ’s mostly intact hull and wait for Hordak to find me, then we’ll be able to come up with a way to find everyone else! Unfortunately I can’t track them myself as my tracker pad was damaged in the fight, so we’re waiting here for the time being!”

M: “*Arroulorrr?*”

E: “Yes.”

Click

*****

Click

The first few minutes are comprised of static, with strange, distorted voices barely audible behind it.

Beat

E: “Ah! The signal faded! I wonder how you picked that up. Melog seemed to be particularly affected, but we managed to avoid actually succumbing to the island’s pull. Something about the signal is different this time, but I can’t put my finger on it…”

Click

Fygan

“Princess Perfuma?”

“Yes Bai?”

What? Oh right! I called myself Bai. "Could I speak to you about something?"

"Of course!"

Fygan opens his eyes and relaxes his posture. Meditation with Perfuma has been a wonderful experience. He's not sure how long he's spent just listening to the world around him, but it's been an hour at least. Much longer than he intended to stay in Plumeria.

"I'm a student of history and philosophy, and the teachings of an ancient Prince of Plumeria keep springing into my mind. Are you familiar with the teachings of Prince Florin?"

Perfuma ponders for a moment. "I know his name but I wasn't aware his ideas were recorded."

Fygan nods. "As I understand it, he was something of a radical. The idea that springs to my mind most often is this: 'people are temporary. But actions are permanent.'" Perfuma takes that in, and Fygan continues. "I always discounted that. It seems contradictory. You can take an action in an instant, and there may not be any physical consequences to you. Meanwhile, how could he say that people are temporary when immortals walk among us? I gave it new thought a few years ago when I heard the news of Queen Angella's passing." Perfuma makes a hand gesture of respect at the mention. "Even she had her time, after living and ruling for… a thousand years? But her actions ring throughout history, as do the actions of everyone. Every action has consequences. Somehow, someway, someone will feel the consequences of your actions, and they will act in turn. Scientists believe that, in physics, every action has an equal, but opposite reaction. I believe the same holds true of people. If you were to act on me, I would react in an equal, but opposite manner. Does that make sense?"

Perfuma nods. She looks very contemplative, and she's studying Fygan's face. *Stars, I hope I didn't just blow my cover.* "I think that is one way to look at it." She says slowly, "But I don't fully

agree. It's breaking people down into actions, and not taking into account motives. During the war with Prime, my… friend, was chipped, and Prime ordered her to kill me. But when she fired her magic, she missed. Her action was just to miss a shot, but her motives were many. At the front of her mind, her motive was to serve Prime. But in the back of her mind, she wanted to save me." Perfuma smiles. "People are so much more than the actions they take."

Fygan nods slowly. *Motive matters more than actions… No. Don't stray down that line of thought. It doesn't matter what they* meant *to do. It's what they do that affects the world. I can't act based on motive. I can't take vengeance for motive. I take vengeance for actions.*

"Thank you, Princess Perfuma. I should be on my way." He stands and bows formally. Perfuma smiles broadly and returns the bow, then waves her hand and summons a flower crown to his head.

"Come again soon!" She says, waving as he exits the clearing.

On his way out, a child runs by, smacking into him in her haste. "Sorry!" She says.

"It's alright." Fygan responds with a smile. "Next time, watch out." She nods, and he takes the crown off his head and places it on hers. *Give this to someone who deserves it*. Fygan turns, and walks away from Plumeria, his expression grim.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated

Heart of Darkness, Part 3: Disparate Pieces

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra learns more about her strange new companion and Beast Island sows the seeds of despair in the BFS.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer

Glimmer comes to on a pile of soft dirt. Blinking, she finds her vision is somewhat fuzzy, and she's rather disoriented. Looking around, she sees she's in a small cave-like hollow beneath the roots of one of Beast Island's massive trees. Groaning, she sits up, clutching her lurching stomach. "Nnnnngh… Bow?" She says, looking up at where the figure stands in the entrance to the cave.

"Glimmer!" Bow turns and rushes towards her, bending down to avoid hitting his head. He kneels down and kisses her softly. "I was so worried." He murmurs, hugging her close, but not too tight.

"Where's everyone else?" Glimmer asks weakly.

Bow sighs, "I don't know." He turns back out to the entrance, redrawing his bow. "We got separated after that Ooze knocked you out. I set up a little camp here until you got better."

"How long was I out?" Glimmer asks. Her vision is coming back to her, and she snaps her fingers experimentally, conjuring a few sparkles of magic.

"A few hours." Bow says. "That gas really did a number on you."

"Yeah. Give me a few minutes and I'll be in better shape."

Bow nods and resumes his post. “Beast Island is… different.” He says. “I can’t tell if it’s less powerful or more powerful than last time we were here.”

Glimmer cocks her head. “What does that mean?” She crawls up to sit next to him and lean against him for solidarity.

Bow sighs. He seems frustrated and confused. “It feels more… alive. The signal is less static, less regular. It comes and goes at random intervals with varying strength. And I’ve fought off a few beasts but way less than I expected. I dunno.”

Glimmer doesn’t know how to respond, so she just hugs the archer tight. After a few minutes, her wooziness has passed, and she stands up. “Well.” She says with a smile, “Let’s go find our friends. Where do we start?”

Bow shrugs, looking unusually despondent. “Nowhere. The bridge collapsed.”

Refusing to let the island get her down, Glimmer grabs him and hauls him to his feet. “Well then we’ll start on the other side.” In an instant, she visualizes the spot on the bridge where they fought the ooze, and she and Bow teleport to the spot if first climbed up.

“WAHHHH!” Glimmer cries as she immediately plummets. She’d gotten them onto an intact portion of the bridge alright. Well, more accurately, she’d gotten *Bow* to an intact portion of the bridge, specifically the very edge of the break. Bow holds her up long enough for her to teleport them both further along the bridge. “Whew. That could have been worse!” She says, determined not to lose her positive attitude.

“I guess.” Bow says, standing up.

“Bow…” She says, her eyebrows knitting in concern. *The only time I’ve seen him this apathetic was when he hated me. Don’t hate me again.* “What’s wrong?” She puts a hand on his cheek and gently pushes his head to look at her.

"I feel like we've already lost." He says quietly. "And I'm so worried about my dads."

Glimmer's smile falters. *That makes sense. They didn't even get to see us off. Didn't even get to say goodbye before…*

She begins to hear a faint droning, pulsing noise in the back of her head. *The signal. It's getting to us.*

"I'm never gonna see them again…" Bow says, his eyes starting to glaze over.

My dad… he's going to outlive his daughter and his wife. He's going to lose me to the place he thought he'd never escape. At that thought. Glimmer shakes her head, snapping out of her stupor. *No! Beast Island is* not *gonna beat us*. She shakes Bow, "Yes you are!" *How can I convince him…* She looks around frantically, and her eyes light up when she sees Bow's tracker pad. Grabbing it from his belt, she holds it up. "Can't you call them?" She suggests.

At that, Bow looks at her, mouth agape. His eyes return to normal and he inhales for a long moment. "How did I not think of that??" He says exasperatedly, snatching the tracker pad and starting to tap on it. "I was alone for like, three hours and I never even thought to call them!"

Glimmer smiles at his renewed exuberance. She looks around her surroundings with a certain smugness. *'I beat you.'* She thinks. '*This time, I beat you.'*

Catra

'I'll give him this, at least. The Old One does know his way around this island.' Catra thinks as she clambers over the husk of a large crustacean monster. Every so often, her guide will talk to her, tell her things about the island. He is so in tune with it that he's been able to warn her when the signal is about to sound. That warning, coupled with her own determination to reunite with her friends,

has allowed her to push through the waves of despair brought on by the signal.

"So…" She says at last, finally letting boredom get the better of her, "What's your story?"

"My… story?" The Old One chuckles, "Mmmmhmhmhmm. There are a great many layers to mmmy story. I was once… a great commander. I was ruthless. *Feared* everywhere I went. I led my armies to great victories."

"Hold on. I thought you were with the Horde."

"Mmhmhmhm, I wasss, yes. But *Hordak* is no leader. He is weak willed, and lacks true vvvision. It was I who led his armies. I who conquered in his name!" *Sounds familiar*. "Until… *she* came." The Old One snarls and brings up an arm. The mechanisms implanted in his flesh whir as a jagged metal blade pops out of his wrist. He slashes through a wall of vines and skitters through.

"She?" Catra says, despite having a sinking feeling she knows who the 'she' in question is.

"The *witch*." He spits, "She arrived after our conquest of the Fffright Zone. She wormed her way into Hordak's inner council. She turned him against me and had me exiled here because I was a threat to herrrr power. She… ruined me."

Catra laughs bitterly. "Trust me. You don't have to tell me about Shadow Weaver ruining people." He hisses at the sound of the name, "I've got *plenty* of first hand experience."

"Mmmmm…" His mandibles chitter contemplatively, "So… what is *your* story, Catra?"

Catra tenses and stops, narrowing her eyes, "How do you know my name??"

"As I told you… I listen to the island. I heard your coming, and your friends talking to you."

So this thing was following us when we arrived. “Right, right. I forgot you’re weird. My story… It’s pretty much the same as yours. I was in the Horde, my best friend left me, Shadow Weaver ruined my life, I pretty much ran the show until Hordak decided to get rid of me. Almost conquered all Etheria. Then I got captured by Horde Prime, rescued by Adora and helped her save the world.”

“Adorrrraaaa… The She Ra, yes?”

Catra narrows her eyes, “Why do you want to know?”

“She has come here before… seeking to save someone… She succeeded, and escaped Beast Island.” He turns partially back, one of those creepy too-human red eyes peering at Catra from within his darkened hood. “Remarkable woman.”

Catra chuckles, “You have no idea.”

“She was your enemy once. Now she is… with you?”

Again, Catra narrows her eyes at how much this Old One knows. “Yeah… It’s… complicated.”

“She… *left*, you? Did she not?”

“Yeah… sort of. She…” Catra sighs. “She found a magical sword in the woods that started calling to her. She went to find it and didn’t let me go with her. She went missing and by the time I found her, she’d abandoned the Horde. Abandoned everything I thought we believed in. She’s turned into a giant, beautiful, strong sword goddess and left me behind. I didn’t want to go with her because…” Catra rubs her arm. “I always felt like I was in Adora’s shadow.” She confides, “Shadow Weaver made sure of that. Some part of me felt like… this was my chance to prove myself. I knew that if I went with her, I’d still just be playing second fiddle to a great hero.”

“You are more than a sssidekick.” The Old One assures her, “You have greatness in you. We share much, Catra. Both of us were spurned, cast out by what we gave our lives to. We’ve had to

adapt. Become… something greater to survive. It is fate that hasss brought you to mmmeee. There is so much I can teach you."

"Pft. About what?"

The Old One turns, its eyes flashing and that circular mouth twisting into a smile. "Everything."

Catra opens her mouth to answer, but suddenly, the Signal screams into her head. "GAHHH!" She collapses to her knees, clutching her ears to her head. "It's so… loud…" It hurts so bad…

Just let go… let yourself be consumed by the island. You're no use to anyone. Beast Island shall comfort you.

Within the signal, voices begin to float into her consciousness. Voices of her friends, her enemies. Voices she barely recognizes.

Adora: "It's too late. I don't need you anymore."

Scorpia: "You drove me away, Wildcat."

Glimmer: "Give up, Catra. It's over."

Shadow Weaver: "You'll only slow Adora down. You are a dead weight to her."

Entrapta: "Let the Island grant you peace."

Horde Prime: "As I once did. Become one with the island child."

She feels her vision fading into dull grays. *Maybe it is for the best. I'm a liability.*

"Catra." She nods her head up, registering that vines are beginning to wrap around her form. The Old One stands on a boulder, looking down at her. "Rise. Accept the signal into yourself, and then overcome it. To defeat Beast Island, as I have, you must first become one with it. Fall. So that you may rise."

Catra stares up at him. “No.” She says quietly. The gray fades into color. “I’m not going to let Beast Island beat me.” She stands up, tearing through the vines with her claws. “The Crimson Waste didn’t beat me. Shadow Weaver didn’t beat me. Horde Prime didn’t beat me!” She lets out a slightly unhinged cackle of arrogance. The signal begins to fade away. Catra looks up at the Old One. “Take me to the center of the island so we can get out of here.”

The Old One gazes at her darkly before turning and slinking away into the darkness. Catra drags her claws across the bark of a nearby tree and follows.

Fygan

The Fright Zone is as much of a dump as it always has been, but fortunately, Fygan’s job here is easy. The Black Garnet was relocated to Horror Hall, where it sits in its own secluded room under constant guard. All Fygan has to do is disguise as a guard, slip into the room, and plant his device. No one approaches the Black Garnet due to lingering superstition caused by Shadow Weaver, so it will go unnoticed.

When he’s in the room, he spends some time looking at the Garnet. He imagines Shadow Weaver, drawing power from this Runestone. He reaches out and presses a finger against it. *One day… I will do what you could not*. He pulls out the device and plants in between one of the crevices of the garnet’s base, covering his work with an illusion.

This one he feels no guilt about. *They’re all Horde anyway. They’ll be getting what they deserve.*

Adora

The sound of wingbeats predicates the arrival of her steed. As does the loud, “Did someone say… SWIFT WIND??”.

The alicorn lands and strikes a pose, only to immediately canter away and whinny in fright as a nearby plant snaps its jaws towards him. He looks up at Adora and smirks, "I'm kidding. I know you said Swift Wind."

Adora smiles and rushes forward, wrapping her arms around Swift Wind's neck. "I'm glad you're here." She says softly. She's been wandering around for some time, she guesses a few hours at least.

"I'm sensing some… tension. What's wrong?" Swift Wind says, "Is it just that you're all alone, separated from your friends on the worst place on earth while you slowly succumb to despair and sink further and further int-"

"NO!" Adora smacks a hand over Swift Wind's mouth before sighing and pulling away. She walks over and sits down on a rock, looking at her warbling reflection in her sword. "I just… I can't transform."

"Again??" Swift Wind walks over and kicks a bug off of his hind leg. "Are you sure it's not Beast Island?"

"No… I transformed earlier but, once we got separated it just dropped. It feels like this new form is a lot easier to drop than when I had the Sword of Protection and I just… I just miss it."

"Duuuhhh, you miss the thing the First Ones made to limit your power and control you in order to make you the trigger for a super weapon??"

Adora does smile at the horse's sarcastic tone. "Well, not that part. But it was a nice security net. Now… every time I can't transform, I feel more unworthy than ever. Plus… I feel like it's connected to Catra. And I love Catra and I don't want to be apart from her," Adora looks up to see Swift Wind exaggeratedly gagging, only to stop when she looks at him. "But I don't want her to have the pressure of She Ra on her too. She Ra is my responsibility." Adora sighs.

Swift Wind chuckles. “Adora, she’s already sharing the responsibility. All your friends are. And I definitely am. You don’t always have to be this big powerful island. I figured it was pretty clear by now that I don’t have a sacred bond to a sword.” He leans his head down and pokes Adora’s forehead with his horn. “I have a sacred bond with you.” He leans back. “You are She Ra. Whether you can transform into an eight foot tall glowing goddess or not. You don’t need your friends, but they’re going to be there for you anyways.”

Adora looks up at Swift Wind and blinks the tears out of her eyes. Resolved, she stands, and raises her free hand, feeling the warmth of her blade appear in it. “For the Honor… of Grayskull!”

Catra

“You know,” Catra begins, “Even though you’re a weird, creepy bug man who’s lived alone on Beast Island for 30 years, I’m starting to warm up to you.”

The Old One holds a branch up while Catra walks under it. “Thhhank you?” He says, showing dry wit. “And has it truly been thirty years?”

Oh yikes. “Uhhh… about.” Catra says, awkwardly rubbing the back of her head.

“Mmmmm. I’d assumed longer.” It says dismissively. “So the Horde lasted thirty years under Shadow Weaver’s stewardship? I… underestimated her.”

Catra scoffs. “Not really. It lasted, sure, but the Princesses weren’t putting up much of a fight for like, half that time until She Ra came around. And after that I took over and started making some real improvements.”

“And yet… you failed, as I did.” Old One observes.

Catra lets her pride fade away. "Yup. I… trusted the wrong people."

"A common mistake made by the tyrannical." *'Hey! Tyrannical?! I mean… actually it's not exactly wrong…'* Catra thinks on that, before Old One turns to her. He looks like he's about to say something, when his pupils dilate, and he suddenly lunges at Catra, the blade emerging from his arm.

"What are you-!" Catra dives to the side as he plunges the blade over her shoulder. There's a scraping sound, and Catra looks up to see the Old One grappling with what appears to be a massive scorpion. His blade is embedded in its stinger, which, based on the positioning, was inches away from her neck. '*I let that sneak up on me.*' Catra realizes with shock.

The beast's pincers snap towards the Old One's legs. One of them grabs onto his front left leg, while the other one gets a sharp kick to the joint for its troubles. Catra rises to her feet to help, but the Old One seems to have the upper hand. She watches as mechanisms in his left leg deploy saw blades that cut the claw holding it, prompting the beast to release him. He yanks the blade out of the scorpion's stinger, partially shattering it. The scorpion chitters and backs away as he delivers a sharp kick to its face. One more slash to its carapace is enough to send it skittering away.

"You saved me." Catra says, looking at her guide.

"Indeed." The Old One nods, retracting its various weapons. "Beast Island has a great many dangers. You must be ready." He continues walking forward.

"Well… uh… thank you." Catra tries awkwardly. The Old One gives a curt nod.

They walk into a tunnel beneath the earth, and The Old One speaks. "Tell me more of the Horde."

“Pft. Where to begin.” Catra muses, “After Shadow Weaver took over, there was a big offensive. The Princesses formed the first Alliance, which got crushed. After that, we didn’t press our advantage. Hordak and Shadow Weaver just sat in the Fright Zone and did nothing until I came along. Once I took charge we almost destroyed Bright Moon, conquered Salineas and had all Etheria in our grasp. Then the Princesses set off some superweapon that brought us into the wider universe. And then the real Horde came.” Catra closes off, clutching her arms and shivering at the memories.

Her hair falling shorn to the ground.

The electric pain of the baptismal font.

The imposing form of Prime standing over her as the chip is implanted.

“PRIME CASTS OUT ALL SHADOWS!” “ALL BEINGS MUST SUFFER TO BECOME PURE!”

“And,” The Old One’s question snaps her out of her memory rabbit hole, “After that?”

“After?”

“The Galactic Horde failed. Prime was destroyed. What has become of the Horde.”

Catra shrugs. “Mostly they’ve rejoined society. There’s some pockets here and there. One big one at Mount Chandrila that doesn’t seem to be any kind of threat. The Horde’s broken.”

The Old One simply hums at that and continues.

As they walk underground, Catra ponders the Old One. *He looks super creepy, and he acts weird, but he hasn’t really done anything wrong. Am I wrong to be so paranoid about him? I mean, Entrapta looks creepy and acts weird, and she’s great.* Ahead of her, the Old One lunges to stab a bug, then eats it off

his blade. *He's kind of endearing in a super weird way.* She shrugs. *What harm could he do anyway? I'm awesome, I can handle a crazy old bug.*

She stops short as the Old One hisses and raises a hand in warning. It's partially turned away from her, and Catra can see his piercing red eyes are wide, and glowing slightly. A pair of slits where a nose should be widen as it sniffs the air.

Catra treads forward silently, her own ears now erect and alert. She flattens herself against a trapezoid of metal jutting out of the soft ground and looks to the Old One. "What is it??" She whispers urgently.

"Wwwwwe are being hunted." He responds in a low tone.

"By what?"

"A being I've not dealt with for a long, llllong time." He pauses, his nostrils flaring again. He looks at Catra and says, "A Doppelganger."

Glimmer

Glimmer and Bow are sheltered under a little pink dome she constructed out of magic, waiting for Bow's dads to get back on the call. They said they had some information on Beast Island that might be able to help.

Not sure how old books are going to help us, but maybe it'll help Bow keep up hope.

A ringing sound on the pad heralds their return. Bow quickly answers, opening with, "Please be quick. It's been a while since the last Signal and I don't want it to get to you guys."

"Right." George says matter-of-factly. He and Lance have a pile of writings in front of them. "We have some information that may

help. The first piece we've found is that we know roughly what the signal is."

"Really?" Bow asks.

Lance picks up. "Yes! According to a document from an ancient Salinean explorer, the First Ones left Etheria when their ships emitted an evacuation signal. Once they were gone, the signals stopped all across Etheria, because the AI were still operational and shut them off. But when the explorer went near Beast Island, he heard the signal again. But this time, it was distorted."

Bow nods, "Because there's no AI to turn it off here. If we take the crystals powering the Temple, maybe we could turn off the signal! Were you able to find anything on the wildlife?"

George grimaces, "A few children's stories about Chibbits and Pookas, but the only major one we've found is a rumor of a dragon sighted flying towards Beast Island."

A dragon??

"Huh…" Bow rubs his chin. "I'm pretty sure we saw a corpse of a dragon last time we were here. That may be it. Thanks dads."

"Be careful Bow!" George says sternly. "We love you!" Lance adds.

"I love you too." Bow responds, turning off the tablet and looking at Glimmer. "Let's go." He says with a nod.

Glimmer waves her hand and dispels the dome, and they begin walking.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! As always, comments and kudos are very much appreciated.

Heart of Darkness, Part 4: The Doppelgänger

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra learns of a particularly dangerous inhabitant of Beast Island

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

"What's a Doppelganger? You mean like, a shapeshifter? Like Double Trouble or Fygan?"

"Mmmmm… I know not who these people arrrrre, but the humanoid shape shif-ting specie of Etheria is but a paltry shadow of the true Doppelganger." The Old One lowers their humanoid upper half to the ground, almost like it's going into a stalking stance.

Catra feels something crawling around her wrist, and yanks her hand away, but sees nothing there. *This place is starting to get to me.* Her eye twitches in annoyance and she looks back to the Old One.

"Okay," she says, "What makes this thing so powerful?" She pokes her head out from behind the metal strut she's hiding behind, but sees nothing besides the inky blackness and glittering technological lights of Beast Island.

"The Doppelganger is an unnnnparalleled hunter. It stalks its prey from afar, using its mmmmagic to scan them."

"Scan them?"

"Yes. It searches your memories, detects your surface thoughts, and from those, it chooses the form it could best use to hunt you."

Catra's eyes widen. "Wait, this thing can turn into anyone? Like…"

The Old One nods. "Indeed. It will likely take the form of one of your friends to lure you into a trap."

Catra feels a chill run down her spine. Then she feels a chill run up her spine. She jumps and spins around, grabbing at her back. But there's nothing on the metal she had been pressed against, and nothing on her back.

The Old One nods and whispers, "The phantom touches? It has begun. It's softening you up for the kill, m-making you jumpy and paranoid. Catra, you must listen carefully. I have survived this creature before. Ignore what you feel, and trust nothing. If you see one of your friends alone… I ammm afraid you cannot trust them. If you let them get too close, the Doppelganger will kill you."

Catra narrows her eyes. "So what? I'm supposed to attack my friends if I see them? Not a chance, bug boy."

The Old One narrows his eyes and hisses in frustration. "Catra, I do not advise attacking your allies, but do not trust them until you are sure."

Catra takes a step forward. "So if I see Adora, I'm supposed to do what? Quiz her?"

The Old One actually shrugs half-heartedly. "An interrogation to determine the true identity would not be amiss. The Doppelganger's mind reading ability has its limits."

"But it knows what I know about them?" Catra's ears perk up, and she darts to the nearest tree, leaping from bough to bough to get a vantage.

The Old One skitters up after her, clinging to the side of the tree. "Yes."

"Any of them?"

“Itssssss knowledge is likely not even limit-ed to those on Beast Island.” The Old One regards her for a moment before asking, quietly, “Have you seen one?”

Catra nods. “Yeah, and one I’m gonna have a particularly hard time with.”

Hordak

Hordak stalks forward, his wrist blade extended. The longer he’s walked alone, following the faint signal of Entrapta on his gauntlet, the more over the island has gotten in its attempts to take him. He’s cut through packs of small predators, avoided dangerous pitfalls that seemed to spontaneously open beneath him, and he’s noticed that the path he walks is swallowed by black vines, making backtracking impossible.

I will not let this island destroy me as it has so many others. Hordak swings his arm downwards, chopping through a brittle shard of glass-like metal blocking his path. The chunk shatters, and he steps through the debris, taking stock of his surroundings.

A ravine yawns wide to his right, while the thicket is much more dense to his left, filled with wickedly curved thorns and twisted vines that sway gently, lying in wait. Hordak watches as a small, crystalline bat-like fairy flutters down and lands on a vine, only to be immediately wrapped in tendrils and wrenched into the heart of the thicket.

Straight ahead of him, a gap between two trees shows him a steep, but walkable path to a plateau. It’s not the exact direction his gauntlet tracker is pointing him, but it seems to be the only walkable path.

He moves forward, cutting through vines on his way up the hill. Clambering up the last, rocky slope, he straightens up and looks around, but his attention is drawn upwards by an echoing, familiar voice.

“Hordak? Is that you?”

Hordak looks around, but cannot see the source of the voice. “Catra? Where are you?” He calls out.

“Why did you abandon Horde Prime?” Catra calls out, her voice still echoing too much to pin down a location.

“What??”

“Answer the question!!”

Hordak growls. *I don’t like your tone, Catra.* “He ordered me to kill Entrapta. I could not.”

“Right… And… Why did you get rid of Shadow Weaver?”

“Why are you interrogating me? Come down here! We must find the others!”

“I’m not coming down until you’ve answered me!” Catra shouts back. There is tension in her voice that Hordak does not quite understand.

Hordak snarls, but plays along. “Shadow Weaver… was no longer useful to me after you took away her power.”

“And she disobeyed you.” Catra adds sharply.

“Ah… yes, yes I remember.”

There’s a pregnant pause before Catra says, “Okay, one more: How did the Horde capture King Micah?”

That one throws Hordak for a loop. “What are you talking about??” He calls to her, looking around at the boughs of the trees. He thinks he sees the flash of the feline’s eyes, but cannot be sure.

“Tell me how you captured King Micah! Because I wouldn’t know!”

"You wouldn't- What??" Hordak takes a step towards where he thinks Catra is hiding, only for her to shout down, "Stay there!"

Hordak closes his eyes and breathes deeply. *The island has driven her mad, clearly.* "We captured King Micah early in the war. The battle was… We…" He trails off, trying to remember, but the memory is so far back, so clouded by white and green. *Not all my memories have returned to me. Prime's mind wipes were strong indeed.* "I… don't remember." He admits, then adds, firmly, "Come down here! We are wasting time, and I must find Entrapta!"

He hears a rumbling hiss from above and behind him, and Catra cries, "I knew it!!" He spins around, eyes wide, and sees her leaping down towards him, claws outstretched.

"Gah!" Hordak wheels backwards, trying to bring up his arm cannon, but Catra is too fast. She lands in a crouch in front of him, spinning around with a sweeping kick to his leg. It doesn't knock him down, but she does not relent, springing up with another kick to his arm, then a two-handed shove to his torso.

Hordak fires an uncharged pulse from his arm cannon into the ground, creating a blast of energy that forces Catra to back away. *There's no talking her down. I'll have to subdue her.* Hordak allows himself a grin. *I've been waiting for this…*

He springs into action, swinging his wrist blade towards her head. Predictably, she ducks, and Hordak brings his knee up into her chest, driving the breath from her. His blade retracts, and he grabs the back of her shirt, lifting her up and spinning her around before hurling her into a tree. The fragile bark splinters under her, and Hordak raises his cannon.

"Stand down, Catra!" He roars.

Catra

But Catra's never given up on a fight in her life, and some Doppelganger isn't going to be the first to make her. She rolls

forward, grabbing onto a fallen branch and hurling it towards the fake Hordak. He ducks out of the way, and she charges forward.

If he's a doppelganger, how can he use the cannon?

The Old One said that it's magical. And if it feeds on memories of fear, that's a pretty potent weapon to copy.

Speaking of the cannon, Hordak fires another uncharged pulse, knocking Catra sprawling. She turns the fall into a combat roll, grabbing a handful of mushy leaf detritus, then throwing it at the doppelganger's face.

The fake Hordak gasps as his vision is obscured, and Catra races forward. She grabs onto his arm and swings around him, using her body weight to spin Hordak, throwing him off balance before she lands, crouches down, and dives into him, hitting his left leg with a full body tackle. This finally knocks the Doppelganger's massive form over, sending him toppling to the ground.

Catra wriggles out from under him, and looks up to see The Old One cautiously looking out from the undergrowth. He catches her eye, and motions urgently for her to come with him. Catra stands up, delivers a swift kick to the back of Fake Hordak's head, then runs.

I got him down for now but I can't beat that thing. She rushes after the Old One, running through underbrush and heading into a lower level of the island. She can hear the echoing sound of Hordak bellowing her name, and, even though he failed her interrogation, can't help but wonder if she was wrong about him being the Doppelganger.

"That's what it wants you to think." The Old One tells her as they finally slow down.

"What?"

"You are second guessing yourself," It explains, "wondering if perhaps that wasn't the Doppelganger, if perhaps you should have

tried more thoroughly to identify it. But the longer you spent talking to it, the more it could have gleaned. The Doppelganger is a patient killer, and your swift attack was the right decision."

Catra nods, then shrugs and adds, "And even if we were wrong, and that was Hordak, it's not like it's the first time I've beat the snot out of him."

The Old One almost chuckles at that, then says, "We are close to the island's center. We should push forward."

Fygan

Fygan takes a seat, breathing heavily. He has been waylaid on his trip to Bright Moon by an ambush of strange little mushroom pixies, who put up a surprisingly good fight.

Fygan reaches to his belt, and grabs his very light waterskin, which, upon lifting it to his lips, he discovers, to his dismay, is all but empty.

"Just my luck." He snarls, hooking the waterskin back on his belt.

Is it even worth it at this point?

Fygan shakes his head, and reaches down to the ground, picking up one of the limp mushroom pixies. Whether it's asleep or dead, he cannot tell. "I'm not giving up now," He tells the little mushroom, "I'm too close now. Too close to the end, and I have too many reasons to keep going. I've taken my revenge on the Horde. My revenge on the Princesses, however, is still incomplete. It doesn't matter what Perfuma said. My path is set."

Fygan tosses the mushroom man to the ground and stands up, ready to continue the final stage of his journey.

Catra

After passing out of a series of caves, the Old One stops and points ahead. “We have arrived.” Following his arm, Catra sees the monolithic crystal structure ahead, like a more overgrown version of The Beacon. The entrance looks to be about a hundred feet up, with a long, damaged rocky bridge leading up to it.

“Great, now we’ve gotta climb that thing.” Catra quips.

“Indeed. An easy task for both of us. You are... Magicat, are you not?”

Catra’s eyes widen and she feels her fur stand on end. “I’m what?”

The Old One turns, fixing her with those baleful red eyes. “Magicat.” He studies her for a moment. “Mmmmm… Yesss, you are, but you do not yet know what that means.” He turns and begins to walk towards the center.

“Wait!” Catra reaches out. *The only person I’ve ever met who seems to have some idea of this. Shadow Weaver always said she didn’t know, didn’t care. I’m not like Grizzlor or any other cat people I’ve seen. I thought I was just… me!* “What are you talking about? What’s a Magicat??”

The Old One gestures for her to follow. “Continue walking the path I tread and all shall be revealed.”

Oh come onnn. Catra rolls her eyes and rushes after the insectoid. Behind her, the vines close the gap she came through, and begin to slither after her.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Heart of Darkness, Part 5: The Signal

Chapter Summary

> In which the BFS reunites, and reaches the heart of Beast Island, but the Island is not done with them yet.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer

"Wait!" Bow holds up a hand, looking over the side of the bridge. Glimmer walks over and follows his eyeline. He's looking at what seems at first to be a large round stone, but upon closer inspection, seems to have large bulbous pink crystals all over it. "Is that…?" Bow draws his bow and anchors a rope arrow into the bridge, tossing the other end off the side.

"What is it?" Glimmer asks, somewhat annoyed at him just starting to act without telling her.

"I think that's Entrapta's mech." Bow says, "EJ."

If Entrapta's anywhere, she'd be there. "Let's go." Glimmer says, rushing down the rope after Bow.

They reach the ground, and Bow walks over to the mech cautiously. "Entrapta?" He hazards.

"PRINCESSES!" Comes the shrill voice from within the mech. From a crenellated mouth, a pink haired, filthy scientist emerges, followed by a warbling alien cat who pounces on and tackles Bow. "Well, Princess." She corrects, pointing at Glimmer. "Is it just you two?" She looks up at the rope expectantly.

"It is." Glimmer says, "We were hoping some others had found their way to you."

“Not yet.” She says. “We’ve been lying low here, hoping someone would get here eventually. And you did! Plan successful!”

Bow gets to his feet. “I think we’re getting close to the center of the island.” He says.

“I believe so!” Entrapta responds, whipping out her own tracker pad, which is functional despite the cracked screen. “The readings suggest the power source is in that direction.” She points out to one side without looking.

Glimmer’s head snaps around as she hears a voice echoing distantly, calling out the name “Entrapta?!”

“Hordak?” Entrapta chirps, her head snapping to attention. “I think that’s Hordak.” Without another word, she starts loping in the direction of the voice on her hair.

Bow sighs and rushes after her, Glimmer and Melog following behind. They manage not to lose sight of Entrapta, who follows her blinking wrist gadget to a clearing, where the bedraggled former warlord emerges on the opposite side.

“HORDAK!!” She squeals, leaping forward and wrapping him in a hug, spinning him around with her momentum. “I was so worried about youuuu!”

“And I you.” Hordak says, gently laying his hands on her back and head, a display of tenderness Glimmer never would have believed possible. Hordak looks up. “The center of the island is close. We should move to regroup within the temple.”

“Did you see anyone else?” Glimmer asks.

Hordak shakes his head. “I did, and I’ve some grave news to repo-”

“*Did someone say*… SWIFT WIND???”

Glimmer facepalms as the alicorn bursts through the trees, She Ra resplendent on his back. He canters to a stop in the middle of the clearing, and Adora leaps off, rushing forward and picking Glimmer and Bow up in a tight embrace. “You’re okay!!” She exclaims, her voice sounding shaky with tears of joy.

“So are you!” Bow responds.

“Where’s Catra?” Glimmer inquires, looking up at Adora, who looks around the clearing.

“She wasn’t with me. Was she not with any of you??” the blonde begins to panic. Everyone shakes their heads in turn.

Hordak steps forward. “I encountered Catra on my search for Entrapta. I… am afraid she has been consumed by the island.”

The silence that follows that statement is complete. Glimmer sees Adora’s face go pale.

“Where is she?” Adora says at last.

“I do not know,” Hordak confesses, “She accosted me with questions, then attacked me. She fled once she realized she could not overpower me.”

Why would she do any of that?

“What do you mean she questioned you?” Bow steps in, putting one hand up on Adora’s shoulder

“She seemed to be trying to probe my memories, but I could not answer the questions she asked.” Hordak recounts.

“Why would she be questioning you though?” Adora says, puzzled.

Glimmer sees the spark of realization in Bow’s eyes, and he looks right at her. “She must not have thought it was him!”

Glimmer cocks her head and can only say, “What?”

Bow excitedly turns to Hordak, “She was trying to prove that you were real, and not something created by Beast Island! She hasn’t fallen to the island, and she’s probably on her way!”

Melog butts their head against Adora’s hand and mewls assertively. Their tail is pointing emphatically.

“I think they can sense her!” Entrapta exclaims, her voice awestruck. “She must not be too far away!”

Adora leaps onto Swift Wind and nods down at Melog. “Lead the way.”

The alien panther nods and darts off into the jungle. Reaching into her pack, she pulls out a little white disk. Pressing the ‘on’ button, legs pop out of it, and a little eye rises from the center. “Hey Bump.” She says with a smile. The bot whirrs in response. “Go after Melog and find Catra.”

“Wheeeeee” The bot beeps as its legs retract and it takes off into the air, hovering after Melog.

Hordak looks after them grimly, then turns to Adora. “If she has fallen, you must be prepared to deal with her.”

Adora gives him a stern look. “I’ve dealt with Catra before. If she’s gone, there’s nothing I won’t do to bring her back.

Catra

Catra vaults over a massive, impossibly deep ravine, landing on an uncomfortably mushy pile of dead foliage.

“The Magicats,” The Old One finally explains, his sudden speech startling her, “were once the greatest kingdom on Etheria. Their empire spanned continents. Then came the First Ones. Most of Etheria’s population was cowed by the Eternian’s technology, but not the Magicats. They waged war on the alien invaders, but they were crushed, and their runestone was destroyed.”

“Wait, I thought the First Ones were supposed to be, like… the first people to live here.”

“Theyyyy… were the first to truly make their mark. Technology was… primitive before they came. History and myth were as one. Mmmagic ran wild and untamed. The leaders who would later become Princesses could barely understand or control their powers. Mind your head.”

Catra ducks under the indicated branch, which has some sort of sleeping, two-headed bird of prey perched on it. “And didn’t the First Ones create the Runestones?”

“Mmhmhmhm… No. They co-opted them for theirrrr wars, but they did not create them.”

“So…” Catra ponders aloud, “You’re saying I’m from an ancient kingdom of princesses? Gross.”

“It is… doubtful you are a direct descendent of their ruling fffamily.” The Old One responds. “We approach the summit now. Within you will find the answers you seek.”

The answers I seek? Catra stops short. “Hold on. This is neat and all but… I don’t really care. I’ve always been curious but it’s not like, a driving part of my identity. We’re going up there to wait for my friends, not to dig for secrets.”

The Old One turns, eyes alight, “Yes of course. And once you are reunited with them, you can scour Beast Island for the answers to every question you want. This place… it issss knowledge. I have scratched the surface and emerged greater for it. But you…” The Old One begins to circle her. As he speaks, a faint hum enters the back of Catra’s mind. “There is greatness in you, beyond your wildest dreams and imaginings. I sense your doubts, your misgivings. You will live a thousand lives before your time is done. You think you were meant to be naught but a player in the story of *She Ra*, but you are wrong. You are everything she is and *more*. You have always wanted to know who you are, what your

place is in this universe. Shadow Weaver scorned you. Hordak cast you aside. Even Adora failed you once. I will not fail you Catra. I am leading you down the path of enlightenment. When you emerge, you will be… incredible."

Catra stands there, stunned for a moment. *'I'm… meant for greatness? More than She Ra? I could become… so much more…'*

'But I'm happy with what I have now.'

'You could be happier. Even now you're in her shadow. Follow the Old One. Step into the light.'

Catra shakes her head and realizes the Old One has continued moving, climbing up the slopes of the Temple structure. She follows him, bounding up until the pair reaches the landing in front of a sheet of vines.

"We are here. Beyond this lies your… destiny." The Old One says, its voice low and resonant.

Catra reaches out for the moss, only to hear a whirring sound. Turning, she sees a small white disk with a little eyestalk on top come careening into her, bumping into her shoulder. "Bump?" She says in surprise. "Hey little guy."

Bump beeps at her, and she looks up to see Melog bounding towards her. She immediately rushes forward and slams into the alien panther, who leaps up and tackles her to the ground, their mane a joyous blue as they lick her face.

"Melog!!" She cries, "Are you with the others??"

Melog mewls in the affirmative. "*They follow.*" They look up over her, and immediately go into a defensive stance, turning red and spiky and growling at the Old One.

"Woah woah!" Catra leaps between them. "He's… a friend."

“Catra,” The Old One says, “Do not now hesitate to do that which you have already done. The key to your true potential lies before you, not behind. Step out, Catra! Prove thaaat you are the hero she could *never be!*”

Catra looks into the vines. She takes a step forward. Melog mewls confusedly and paws at her hand. “The truth…” She mutters, that hum returning to her head.

“Yesss…” The Old One says, “In there you will find the truth. And I will guide you to greatness.”

“Greater than She Ra…” She murmurs, reaching out a hand.

“CATRA!” Adora’s voice calls to her from behind. It snaps her out of her reverie.

“ADORA!?” She shouts back. She hears an enraged growl behind her. Turning, she sees the Old One backing away. “No! Wait!” She holds out a hand as he slinks into the darkness, the eyes being the last to vanish. “NO!” She shouts, staggering forward. The Signal has returned, blaring into her head, sapping her strength. She feels vines begin to wrap around her legs. Melog howls in anguish as they try to free her. She just looks at the spot where the Old One left her. “I’m ready! I need to know! Come back!! Teach me!” She falls to her knees. Her vision grows faint. “Don’t leave me…”

Of course he leaves you. Everyone leaves you. Adora. Shadow Weaver. Scorpia. Double Trouble. “They all leave… That’s my destiny… I’m destined to be alone…”

Catra hangs her head in defeat as the signal overwhelms her.

Bow

“Come on!” Adora shouts, looking at her little remote, “Bump’s found her, she’s up ahead!”

The group charges forward. The sounds of Beast Island are closing in as they near the center. Bow can hear the clicking of Pookas tailing them, and the distant groans and growls of larger monsters below them.

A new sound enters his consciousness. A ringing from his belt. Frantically, he reaches down and open the call. “Dads!” He says, panting, “Not really the time!”

“Bow!” George says excitedly, “We have something for you!”

The Temple is in sight now, and they can see Catra. Before George can elaborate, the signal blares into their minds.

“CATRA!” Adora shouts and leaps off of Swift Wind, rushing forward towards the feline, who has fallen to her knees. Dark vines are wrapping around her, and closing in on the group.

“AHH!” Bow turns to look at Swift Wind, who is swinging his head around wildly. “It’s so loud! So much clearer… I can’t… I shouldn’t have come…” His voice loses its energy. His eyes begin to glaze over. He collapses to the ground as vines begin to wrap around him. “I should have stayed on the ship… I’m just dead weight…”

“Swift Wind!” Glimmer begins launching blasts of magic at the encroaching vines, one of which begins to wrap around her leg. “Oh no! I am not getting taken over by Beast Island. My dad beat you! I can beat you!”

Adora has Catra in her arms now, and looks down at her with a tearful, “No… Catra please don’t give in…”

Catra responds with a vacant. “He left me. I was so stupid.” Her hand drifts up to Adora’s cheek. “It’s too late now… It’s over.”

Adora clutches Catra to her chest as the vines engulf both of them.

Bow is batting aside vines with his bow when he sees one wrap around Glimmer’s arm. He reaches out and calls her name,

“GLIMMER!” In desperation. She looks at him with eyes wide and teleports out of the vines’ grip, blasting them with magic.

“No!” She shouts, “I’m going to see him! I’m not going to get stuck here… like… he… did...” Her voice loses its luster, her magic blasts get weaker as the vines wrap around her and her eyes go grey.

No! Not Glimmer! Bow rushes over and tries to cut her free. “You will!” He tries desperately, “You’ll see him again!”

He looks around. One by one, his friends are succumbing to Beast Island, just like last time. Melog’s mane has gone gray as they wrap around Catra and Adora. Glimmer and Swift Wind have both fallen into despair. On his tracker pad, Lance and George are covering their ears as the signal blares through the connection. Bow looks over desperately at Entrapta and Hordak. Hordak is under assault from all sides by vines, slashing at them desperately. Entrapta is babbling into her recorder, “Our group has been defeated by the signal. It appears that once again, Beast Island is proving to me that it is my home.” Bow hears the monotone in her voice, and sees the grey in her eyes.

“Entrapta!!” Bow and Hordak shout at once. *Not again!* Bow looks over at Hordak, who growls and desperately reaches a hand out. Bow clasps the clone’s wrist. “Come on Hordak!” He says desperately, “Don’t give in!” The clone’s eyes are desperate and wide, “Come on! You broke through the control of Horde Prime, you can break-”

“Prime…” Hordak’s eyes widen, and a chill runs down Bow’s neck. *I said the wrong thingWe never should have come here. I’ve doomed us all*. Darkness closes around him.

He’s not sure how long it is before the voice comes through. Low, powerful, strong. “Bow! Bow!” His eyes drift over to the tablet on the ground, where George’s face fills the screen. *Dad…* “Bow. Don’t give in. You are stronger than Beast Island. You are a hero of the Rebellion! You’re a fighter!”

“Bow!” Come Lance’s voice, “Sound! Enough noise will overwhelm the signal!”

Noise… Bow’s eyes widen, and color returns. *Sound!* “AHH!” He strains against the vines that constrict him, grabbing an arrow from his quiver. Reaching for his bow, the vines begin to attack, cutting off his access to his weapon. The signal blares louder. “No.” Bow declares. “I’m a fighter. I’m a historian. I’m an *inventor*. And I can beat you!” With all his strength, he snaps through the vines and slams the sonic arrow into the ground. It impacts the metal of the bridge and activates, emitting a warbling, resonant screech that drowns out the signal. The vines begin to spasm and retreat. His friends start to come to, gripping their ears against the screech of the arrow.

“OH NO IT’S GOTTEN WORSE!” Swift Wind exclaims, smushing his ears with his wings.

Bow plucks up the arrow and turns it off. Hordak is the first to rise, brushing off the remaining vines and helping Entrapta to her feet. “What… happened?” He says.

“Bow happened!” Lance proclaims excitedly, “Our boy saved you all!”

“Bow, I am so proud of you.” George adds on.

Bow smiles and picks up the tablet. “Thanks dads. I love you too. I’m gonna go before the signal comes again.”

“Yes please,” Lance amends, “I do not want to experience that ever again.”

Bow turns to the group. Adora is holding Catra, who, while back in her senses, is still staring off into the middle distance. “My dads found out that a loud enough noise would block out the signal,” he explains, “My sonic arrow did the trick.”

Glimmer giggles and kisses him on the cheek. “I’m sorry I ever doubted you.”

Bow smiles and looks at the temple, "Now let's get that thullite and get out of here."

Fygan

Fygan steps out of the Whispering Woods, bedraggled and sleep deprived from his little tour of the kingdoms. He looks up at Bright Moon. *It's almost over.*

It's laughably easy to reach the Moonstone in the guise of a Bright Moon guard. *You'd think after the last time I was here they'd tighten security, but nope. Princesses never learn.* He chuckles and shakes his head and sets about planting the devices. Bright Moon is more of a gamble than the other kingdoms. The Moonstone is free floating and plainly visible, and therefore impossible to set his device on directly. So he plants them all around the cradle-like structure of the tower, equidistant from each other and difficult to see.

Satisfied with his work, he sets out across the bridge, only to stop halfway across and narrow his eyes, looking down to where King Micah sits in one of the gardens.

There's no time.

There is for this. Fygan grimaces and walks into Bright Moon castle.

Catra

Catra climbs up from the pit with the last off the thullite they could harvest. Entrapta has been working at the computers as the rest of the party worked, getting as much information as she can transferred into her data drives and tablet.

Maybe she'll find something about Magicats.

Shut up. It doesn't matter. He was just using you for something. Just like Shadow Weaver.

What if he wasn't though? Maybe he left because he was afraid.

Catra hisses quietly and sets her bag down with the rest of them. "This," She declares, "Is way too much to carry."

"I'm aware!" Entrapta calls back, "I believe I should be able to call Darla to us. Theoretically, if her AI system is shut off, Beast Island shouldn't be able to affect her engines."

"Alright." Adora says, "Get her here and let's go."

"Awwww" Entrapta looks over her shoulder, her hands and hair still managing the computer. "Can't I have a *little* more time??"

"Entrapta!" Catra, Glimmer, and Hordak all say at once.

"Agh! Fine!" Entrapta disconnects from the computers and leaves a lingering glance on them before turning around, pulling out her tablet and saying, "I'll call Darla." She presses a button on the screen.

A small red alert flashes on her. Catra's heart sinks into her chest. *No. Nononono…*

Entrapta's mouth twists in confusion. "Well that's not right…" She muses, pressing it again, only to be met with the same red flash.

"Entrapta, what's happening?" Bow asks tentatively.

"I have a connection to Darla but someone's overridden my remote access." Entrapta exposits, shaking her pad in frustration, only to be met with another red flash.

A voice echoes through the cavernous space. "That would be me." Catra's heart falls even further, down to her heels. Everyone looks as the screens in the center of the room go dark, then light up again with a video of Darla's cockpit. On every screen is the Old One. His dark hood is up, his red eyes aglow.

"Apologies for the inconvenience." He says, his voice low and menacing, "I don't mean to cause alarm, but I'm afraid the time has come for me to leave Beast Island, and I can't have you knowing my destination. Rest assured, though. When I arrive I shall send your ship back to you should you survive." He pulls off his hood, and Catra sees his full head. It's gaunt, with a ridge of spines running down the center between two wide hemispheres. His red eyes are set on short stalks in the middle of saucer like cavities on the front of his face. Two flaps unfold on either side of his head, like large fins covered with metal plates, each of which has three crystals set within.

Hordak gasps. "Yes." The Old One chuckles, "It's good to see you again, old frrriend. I'm afraid our flock has lost its way, and the duty falls on me to lead it home." He fixes those creepy red eyes on Catra, "And you, my young apprentice. Do not let your questions go unanswered. I have set you on the righteous path of knowledge. Let nothing stop you from seeing it to its conclusion."

He moves to the captain's chair, and the controls appear in holograms around him.

"You won't get away with this." Adora threatens evenly.

"Hmmmm… Mmhmhmhmmmm… I already have." He replies, "And one last thing, Catra. I've remembered my name. Mmmm… Mantenna." He presses a button, and the screens go black.

No one speaks for a long moment. Catra falls to her knees, her head buzzing.

He tricked me. He lied to me. He used me to escape. I trusted him and he used me. Why do I keep letting people do this to me??

Bow is on his pad, frantically sending out messages to the other Princesses and Bright Moon, as well as his dads. After a moment, he receives a call from Lance and George. Answering it, the silence is broken by, "*YOU'RE TRAPPED ON BEAST ISLAND??!!!*"

Bow winces, “Don’t worry, we’ll find a way out of here.”

“You’re trapped there, with who knows how many evil beasts and other dangers!” Lance says, his voice shrill. Catra can only think, *‘And it’s all my fault.’*

Adora walks over to Bow, her voice calm and confident. “We’ll be alright. We’ll find our way o-” She’s cut off by a massive, rumbling noise. Not the signal, but an overwhelmingly loud roar that shakes the foundations of the island.

“What was that?” Glimmer says tentatively.

“That,” Bow trails off, and George finishes, “Was a Dragon.”

Lance

As soon as the Dragon’s roar is heard, a knock comes at their door. Lancelooks at George. They aren’t expecting one of the boys, and very few others know the location of their library. George looks over to Lance, who walks up to the door. Opening it, he sees a humanoid figure in a cloak.

The figure speaks in a soft voice. “You need my help.” They say.

“What?” Lance says, stepping forward, “Who are you? Why are you here?”

The figure looks up at him. “I’m here because I know that I am needed.” They reach two hands up and pull down their hood, revealing teal skinned, elfin features and a mop of blue and green hair. His eyes are somewhat tired looking. “I’ve foreseen this.” He explains.

Lance gasps as he realizes who the person is. He gives a bow to, “Prince Peekablue.”

Micah

Micah does not know that his daughter is trapped on Beast Island. The communication was too stressful, so he retired early. After spending some time wandering Bright Moon's grounds, he walks to his room. His suspicions are quickly raised as he notices the door is ever so slightly ajar. He summons his staff and traces a rune, ready to fire. He steps forward cautiously and opens the door. Walking in, he sees the room is dark, but there's enough light to identify the figure currently sitting in an armchair, her hands steepled in front of her face.

"General Juliet?" Micah says in surprise, dropping the rune, "What are you-" He takes a step forward, and the figure moves suddenly. Her hand's uncross and runes appear in front of them. Micah conjures a rune of his own and raises it, only to take notice of the spell circle glowing beneath him. A tiny spark ignites from his hand before it fizzles out as he freezes in place.

"Whooo!" General Juliet sighs in relief and stands. Micah watches her skin warp and turn black and green before solidifying into the somewhat familiar form of a male shapeshifter. "That," Fygan says, walking across the room while pointing at Micah, "was close." He walks past and shuts the door. "I mean I knew you were good but you almost beat me to the draw there. And I had the advantage of preparation and surprise. Kudos to you." Fygan walks around in front of Micah and gives a wicked grin. "Now I'd like you to come with me. We've a very special event to attend and I want you to have front row seats beside me." He leans down and grabs Micah's chin. "You and I are going to watch the world burn."

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Trapped, Part 1: Motivation

Chapter Summary

> In which Prince Peekablue guides the BFS through Beast Island, and Fygan explains his motives to King Micah

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Micah

Micah comes to somewhat painfully. As his eyes adjust to the light, he remembers what happened. The shapeshifter Fygan had infiltrated Bright Moon and captured Micah, then knocked him out with a spell. Now, looking around at his surroundings, Micah is surprised. It's a spacious, but rather ramshackle room. The walls are patched together amateurishly, the singular window only has two intact panes, and there are papers scattered everywhere. Boards are covered in multiple layers of pictures, sketches, notes, blueprints, and all sorts of plans, too disjointed to make out any details. There's a heavy smell of metal and oil, and mechanical parts litter the floor and desks.

Micah's captor leans over a workbench, tinkering with some mechanical design. Micah clears his throat loudly, prompting the shapeshifter to pause in his work, turn off his device, and turn around, pulling his goggles up to his forehead.

"Good! You're awake. You know, I am really happy about that because I soooo want to talk to you." Fygan snarks, his voice positively dripping with sarcasm.

Micah doesn't rise to the bait, instead simply looking up at Fygan, who grimaces.

“Oh don’t judge me.” He says bitterly, turning back to his work. “Like your record is spotless.”

That does set Micah off, “You don’t get to talk to me about what I’ve done! I may have made mistakes but you… you’ve committed murder!”

“Several times.” Fygan agrees casually, “But they were all Horde scum anyways. Besides, that was just the opening act. Things get way better from here.”

Micah closes his eyes, and attempts to reach out with magic. Something blocks his attempts though. *Of course. He’s nothing if not careful. Whole place is warded from both sides. Maybe I’ll be able to use that to my advantage…*

Entrapta

Click

E: “Beast Island log, day 1. Catra’s friend betrayed us and stole Darla, meaning we are now stranded on Beast Island. Isn’t that great?!”

*In the background, raised voices can be heard.**

C: “He saved my life! Several times! I didn’t have a choice, it was either trust him, or be lost on Beast Island. I made the right choice!”

H: “You were a fool to trust anyone or anything on Beast Island! Everything here wants you dead.”

C: “Oh, sorry. I forgot that you’re the world’s best judge of character!”

H: “I was not the one who attacked you!”

C: “I thought you weren’t you! And you didn’t answer my questions!”

E: “As you can hear, tensions are running high.”

H: “I should have destroyed you in the Fright Zone, but maybe I’ll just finish the job now!”

M: “*Gurrrrrrowwwrrrrrrr…*”

C: “Bhah! Yeah right. I’m terrified. Give it a rest Hordak.”

G: *The sound of sparkles, followed by,* “Uuughhhhhh!!! I hate thissss!!”

E: “Glimmer’s teleportation ability seems incapable of getting us off Beast Island for some reason, so Bow and his dads are working on a way to guide us off the island. Bow! Any progress yet??”

B: “No. They said that Prince Peekablue was there, then my connection shorted out.”

E: “Why don’t you plug it into the central computer? That should boost your signal enough to reconnect.”

B: “I thought about that… but I don’t like the idea of letting Beast Island get into any of my tech. This place is like a virus.”

E: “Hummmm… Oh! I have an idea!” **Shuffling movement sounds, followed by rapid tapping and beeps** “Adora!”

A: “Yeah? How can I be helpful!?”

E: “Glimmer, can you teleport Adora to EJ? I need her brain!”

G: “Her *wwwhat??*”

E: “Her core processing unit! I designed and built it using tech from here, so it could serve as a rudimentary middle link to protect Bow’s tracker pad from any Beast Island-based malware.”

A: “What does it look like?”

E: “Like a robot brain of course! Bump should be able to recognize it.”

A: **Bump whirrs in agreement** “Alright, let’s go.” **tinkle of teleportation magic**

Click

Bow

Glimmer and Adora arrive back in the room in a sparkle and a sudden light as She Ra appears, covered in oil and sporting a manic grin while holding up a large lump of machinery, with Bump perched contentedly atop it.

“We got it!” She pants, trotting over and plopping it on the ground next to Entrapta.

“Excellent!” The scientist proclaims, and starts plugging things into it, using one tendril of her hair to gesture Bow over to her.

Bow walks over, still a tad bit reluctant. Entrapta’s idea is sound. Plugging into Beast Island’s main network will boost his power enough to re-establish a signal to his dads, and using Emily’s CPU means that any viruses would flow into that instead of his tracker pad. *There are a lot of unknown variables, but I guess it’s the best we can do.*

Bow kneels down and gets ready to plug his pad into the damaged CPU on Entrapta’s mark. The scientist holds up three fingers. Two… One…

He realizes what she was timing when he plugs it in right as the signal blares. Surprisingly, it’s quieter in here, sounding distant and weak as opposed to oppressive and omnipresent. The screens light up with data, and Bow sees his tracker pad similarly surge with information. Fearing the worst, he unplugs it and looks for a connection to his family.

It's back! Bow waits for the signal, and his doubts, to fade away before he calls his family again.

"Bow!" Lance immediately cries, "Are you okay?? What happened?"

"We're okay. We lost the connection but it's fixed now." Bow assures him. He is rather put off by the somewhat awkward scene before him. His dads have their communicator set up on their coffee table, pointing to where they're sitting on the couch. Their body language is somewhat tense, as the robed figure of Prince Peekablue is seated in between them, unaware of the disturbance he's causing.

"Greetings, Bow." Peekablue says. Everyone else begins to gather around Bow to look at the new entity. "Queen Glimmer, Princess Entrapta. It is an honor to meet you all. I am Prince Peekablue. I have left my solitude because I foresaw that you need my help."

Adora speaks up, "Yes, we do. I think. We're trapped on Beast Island. Can you get us out?"

Peekablue nods, and closes his eyes. "I can see the path you must take. Gather yourselves and step out of the Temple."

Everyone gets into motion. Entrapta gives the computer a longing look as Hordak pulls her to the entrance with the group.

"You will walk until you reach the point of first breaking." Peekablue drones, "There you will encounter the first of many trials along your path." Bow looks at Catra, who mouths, 'Why does he talk like that??' He can only shrug in response.

Exiting the temple, the group sticks close to each other as they emerge back out into Beast Island.

"Ehhhh…" Swift Wind complains, "I already regret coming here…"

"Same." Catra agrees.

It's not long before they reach a point where the bridge is heavily damaged. "This looks like the point of first breaking." Adora observes, summoning her sword, "Where's the first trial?"

From its position hovering above them, Bump whirrs in alarm and swoops down to land on Adora. Bow looks up, nocking an arrow. A dark form swoops down from the canopy and flies towards them. It's large, with a somewhat ape-like body and huge bat wings behind its arms. Its head is reptilian, with flaring frills on either side. It lets out a deafening screech and dives towards the group, claws on its feet flared out.

Swift Wind rears upward, stabbing at one of the feet with his horns before it can reach anyone else. The beast shrieks in anger and circles around before landing on the bridge behind them. It slams into the ground and charges at them, its frills shaking and its wings extended for intimidation.

"Look out!" Catra calls, pointing behind them. Bow swings around and fires an arrow at the second creature, a white version of the one charging them, that is swooping in behind them. The arrow bursts into a net, tangling the second beast's wing against its limbs. It shrieks and tumbles down, slamming into the damaged section of the bridge, causing the structure to shake.

Hordak steps forward and unleashes a laser blast at the first beast, who ducks out of the way with a startled cry. It stops short of the group's melee range and opens its mouth. A glob of poison shoots out of its maw. Glimmer teleports out of the way and reappears behind it, zapping it with an energy beam that causes it to stumble forward.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!!" Adora shouts, and turns into She Ra just in time to swing her sword like a bat, sending the first creature spinning off the bridge.

The second creature uses its claws hands to tear through the net, and gallops forward, sending a spray of caustic bile towards them. Bow and Entrapta hit the deck. Catra and Melog dart forward,

leaping over the spray and landing in front of the beast. Catra delivers a roundhouse kick to its chest, while Melog crouches behind it, causing it to stagger backwards and trip over the shapeshifter with a yelp.

The larger one returns, climbing up over the edge of the bridge, only to be met with a barrage from Hordak, Glimmer, and She Ra that sends it flying off into the darkness, trailing smoke behind it.

Bow fires a few arrows into the melee with the white creature, Entrapta is beside him firing her wrist laser. Catra yelps as one of the lasers singes her ear.

"Hey! Watch it!" She shouts, turning towards Entrapta.

"Sorry!" The scientist responds.

"Catra!" Bow warns. The beast flips onto its feet, using one of its long arms to sweep Melog to the side. Catra turns, but doesn't have time to dodge as the beast sprays her with poison.

"WAHHHH!" Catra screams and wheels back, flailing around and falling to the ground.

"Catra!!" Adora rushes forward. Bow fires a volley of arrows, backed up by Glimmer and Entrapta, that sends the second creature into a full retreat. He turns to look at where Catra has fallen.

Adora

"Catra!" Adora rushes towards the limp feline form on the ground. *Nonono… this isn't happening. This can't be happening.* "Catra…" She repeats, lifting her head onto She Ra's lap. Adora closes her eyes and pours her magic into Catra's body. There are a few gasps from the rest of the group as the poison lifts off of Catra's body and floats in the air, the individual globules of liquid converging to form one large bubble of the stuff that falls to the ground with a splash.

Catra inhales slowly and opens her eyes. “Uhhhh….” She looks around. Her pupils are very dilated. She shakes her head rapidly and bolts upright. Looking to the party, her face morphs into a wide grin, and she leaps to her feet, sending Adora sprawling. She raises a hand triumphantly, and declares, “I have discovered… the secret of Beast Island!” before falling flat on her face.

There’s a beat, as everyone looks around at each other.

Glimmer tentatively pokes the face down feline, “Catra..?” She tries, “Are you okay?”

Catra rolls over and looks up at Glimmer from the ground. “Glimmer? When’d you get so tall? And why are you on fire?”

“Say what?” Glimmer deadpans in response.

Catra leaps up again and starts rattling off an advertisement in a very fast voice. “Beast Island! Bad rep, but really a wonderful destination for vacations, getaways, and tourism. We’ve got pookas, we’ve got Chippets, we’ve got dragons! Just take a look at that view!” She falls to the ground and gestures broadly to a nearby tree, where a two headed bird croaks like a frog before fluttering away.

“Oh-kay.” Adora says, “Clearly that poison did a number on your brain.” Kneeling down, Adora lifts her girlfriend into her strong She Ra arms.

“Wooah!” Catra giggles, “Alley-oop.” Immediately, the catgirl wriggles around in Adora’s arms, settling into a fireman’s carry over the shoulder. “Woooooahhh… Hey Adora,” she whispers, “Don’t look now, but Hordak’s walkin’ on the ceiling.”

“Of course he is,” Adora humors her, and looks to Bow and Glimmer, who look just as confused as she is, then over at Entrapta, who is muttering furiously into her recorder, then to Hordak, who is pinching the bridge of his nose and shaking his head scornfully.

“I am not walking on the ceiling.” He mutters.

Melog lets out a warbling noise and transforms into their much creepier humanoid form, then proceeds to drape themself over Swift Wind and gesture forward with one stumpy arm, as if to say “Onward, steed!”

“Oh-kay,” Glimmer says, taking Bow’s tracker pad, “I’m gonna contact my dad and figure out what this is.”

Glimmer

The first call does not go through. *Okay… maybe he’s asleep? It’s hard to tell what time it is*. The second call is answered. General Juliet’s face appears on the screen.

“Your Majesty.” She says stiffly.

“Oh! Good, General. Can you go get my dad?” Glimmer asks.

Juliet closes her eyes and inhales through her nose. “Your Majesty… King Micah has disappeared.”

Glimmer gets a sudden sense of vertigo and nearly drops the tracker pad. “Disappeared?? What do you mean?”

“He isn’t anywhere in Bright Moon. Castaspella is on her way to track him with magic. Don’t worry Your Majesty, he’ll be back soon.” Juliet reaches for the button to end the call.

“No, wait-” Glimmer says, but the screen is already blank. Everyone is silent for a moment. A tear rolls down Glimmer’s cheek. “Dad…”

“Uh-ohhhhhhhh…” Catra says, “That’s not cool, man.”

Juliet

Juliet hangs up the call and sighs heavily. Her moment of quiet is quickly cut short by a pair of guards entering for a report. "General, we've thoroughly searched the castle, and are starting a sweep of the town."

"Very good," Juliet acknowledges, "Get a team to comb the Whispering Woods, and you," She points to the second guard, "Contact Dryl and the Fright Zone to get drones in the air searching for him." Both guards nod, salute, and exit the room. Juliet brings up a holographic map of Etheria. She studies it for a moment, then looks up at the mural on the wall. Queen Angella looks down at her impassively. "We'll find him, Your Majesty." Juliet promises quietly.

Fygan

Fygan is fiddling with the remote when Micah talks again.

"So…" The king in chains begins.

Fygan rolls his eyes. "We don't need to talk."

"Then why kidnap me?"

"I…" Fygan sighs. "I don't know. I wanted someone to be here with me when I do this. I don't… have… anyone else." He trails off.

There's a pause before Micah says, "You go by Fygan now, correct? Am I saying that right?"

You know you are, you pretentious little- "Yes. That's my name."

"Okay. I'll respect that." Micah says, his tone genuine. *More like self-righteous.*

"Wow, *thanks*, means so much." Fygan snarks before getting back to his work. He knows this can work, but something in the remote isn't lining up to send a full strength signal.

“Fygan,” Micah continues to talk for some reason. *Why did I not gag him?* “I know it’s been a long time since I can say that I knew you-”

“A lifetime.” Fygan interrupts coldly.

“Indeed.” Micah agrees morosely, “But this is wrong. You know it is.”

Fygan chuckles, and finally turns to Micah, pulling his goggles up to his forehead as the unhinged laughter escapes his throat. “Oh, do I? Do you? Because I don’t remember the part where I told you what I was even doing. As far as you know, I’m trying to solve world hunger.”

“You said we were going to watch the world burn together.”

“... Oh. Right. Forgot about that.” Fygan shrugs. “Well that may have been a teensy bit- ahh, melodramatic. But can you blame me? I mean the situation was *perfectIt does feel good to have someone to talk to.*

“What *are* you doing?” Micah ventures.

Fygan sighs heavily. *I’ve got no time for this… but if I don’t tell someone I’ll explode. Curse my innate sense of drama!* “For all of its history,” He begins with a flourish, conjuring illusory images to go with his little performance. “Etheria has been unbalanced.” An image of the planet, with the many Runestones orbiting it. “The people have lived and died their ordinary lives, while the Princesses have ruled over them, on the grounds that they’re just so dang *special*.” The Runestones join together to form an exaggerated amorphous being with clawlike hands lording over the planet, which transforms into a crowd of terrified people. “The First Ones came along and they only worsened the divide.” Etheria reappears, covered in First Ones-style tech lines. “They cut the Princesses down to size and lorded over the natural inhabitants of Etheria, but then they vanished,” The planet disappears into several different colored clouds of swirling mist, “And strife

ensued.” The clouds converge in a swirling, angry whirlwind. “And emerging on top of them all, your darling *wife*.” The clouds shift into an image of the late Queen Angella, resplendent and radiant.

“Careful.” Micah growls.

Fygan ignores him. “She consolidated the power of the princesses, using her immortality to become like a god to the people of Etheria. Reminds me of a certain someone, eh?” He twists his hand, and Angella morphs into the broad chested form of Horde Prime. Fygan revels in Micah’s enraged expression at that comparison. “The divide between people and princesses only got worse and worse until the Horde came along.” Prime vanishes, replaced by a scene of tanks and soldiers marching through a wartorn battlefield. “Hordak was able to rally a powerbase because the princesses made it easy for him. The people were already isolated from their magical overlords, and Hordak offered them a way to close the gap. It only got more apparent when he seized the Fright Zone.” He conjures an image of the Fright Zone under the Horde’s rule. “And for years the stalemate held.

“Then came the First Princess Alliance.” Fygan summons an illusion of Princes and Princesses, resplendent in battle gear and bravado, with images of Angella and Micah at the head. “Finally, the people had a reason to look up to their leaders. ‘Here!’ They thought, ‘Here are the heroes of Etheria! Here are people I could follow.’” Fygan closes his hand. The Ice Prince shatters. “They were wrong.” The Princess of Plumeria shatters. “One by one,” The Prince of the Ocean fades into darkness. “Their heroes failed them.” The image of Micah shatters. “And the people’s glorious leader hid away in Bright Moon while the Horde took their land.” Angella’s image moves into an illusory Bright Moon castle. “The princesses did *nothing*! While the Horde destroyed our homes! Our families!” Fygan slashes his hand through the illusion of Bright Moon, dispelling it into mist. He glares at the King of Bright Moon, who looks up at him with sadness in his eyes.

“And then, the Second Princess Alliance came along. A new generation with a spring in their step and a fire in their hearts.”

He conjures an image of the modern princesses. “They fought the Horde. Thirty years too late, they won victory after victory, proving that the princesses could have saved us from the Horde *the whole time*.” He changes his illusion to an image of Etheria. “And then, the Heart of Etheria went off, activated and fueled by *princesses*. Your daughter, if I’m not mistaken. The planet was nearly destroyed, and Horde Prime was led right to our doorstep.” Etheria turns green, as shadowy metallic hands and a four eyed grin appear behind it.

The image fades, leaving Fygan standing there, breathing heavily. “The princesses were a failed experiment. Etheria gave them to us as guardians, but they styled themselves as rulers instead, and have caused nothing but misery since then. So now, I’m going to clean the slate.” He turns back to his work. “I’m going to take away the princess’s innate power. Any rulership they have will be determined by the *people*, as it should have been from the beginning. No more Runestones, no more princesses, no more superweapons.” Fygan turns back to his work, sensing that Micah has nothing more to say.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Trapped, Part 2: The Dragon's Rise

Chapter Summary

In which Catra is still high, and the BFS meet a dragon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

Adora has her sword summoned in one hand, and Catra slung over her shoulder with the other hand. The poison-inebriated feline has been alternating between states of total relaxation, and wall-bouncing hyperactivity for the last two hours as the group has followed Peekablue's directions, moving down to the ground off the safety of the bridge, climbing up a tree and maneuvering through a network of branches to reach a different bridge, and continuing forward.

Several times the prince's foresight has saved them from deadly traps and vicious monsters. *I wonder how we ever got off Beast Island last time without him to guide us.* He has even been able to foresee moments where members of the group were nearly separated, allowing them to avert further disaster.

Frustratingly, he refuses to warn about anything further than the immediate future, claiming that, "Foresight is a dangerous gift. Knowing the path you tread may cause you to unintentionally twist the hands of fate." (Through the communication, George is heard quietly telling Lance, "Okay that one made no sense!" in the background.)

"Is she… okay?" Bow asks quietly, gesturing towards Catra, who has been completely spaced out over Adora's shoulder for several minutes.

“I think she’s asleep.” Adora responds.

“Nnnnnope!” Catra chirps, “I’ve never been more awake in m’life.”

“Oh!” Bow says, “Great.”

As he attempts to walk away, Catra reaches out and grasps his arm and begins to chatter, “Have you ever noticed that you’re made of ants? Like look at those little guys, just roaming all around on ya.”

“WHAT?” Bow squeaks, immediately checking himself all over for ants.

“And Adoraaaaa.” Catra continues, switching targets as she squirms out of Adora’s arms and starts padding along beside her, “You’re glowing.”

Adora looks down at herself and raises an eyebrow, as she hasn’t been She Ra for a while now. “Ummmm, thanks?”

“No problem, I like your new friend too.” Catra points two finger guns at an empty space over Adora’s shoulder, then winks and clicks her tongue.

“Nnnnggh.” Hordak growls, “How long will she stay like this?”

“How long are you gonna stay *invisible*?” Catra shoots back, sticking her tongue out not quite in the direction of Hordak. Melog lets out a loud yowl from their position on the back of Swift Wind, and, as if responding to Catra’s words, turns both themself and the alicorn invisible.

“Dahhhhh-I don’t like this.” Swift Wind complains.

“Swifty, you look great in that dress.” Catra responds with another wink.

Did she just… hit on my horse?? “Okay,” Adora decides, wiping the mental image of Swift Wind in a dress out of her mind. `*Enough is*

enough.' "Peekablue, tell us how to fix her."

"The mind cloud shall pass in due time." The sage assures her.

'Talk normally!' Adora breathes for a moment. In the background, Catra has begun chasing her tail while Melog is batting at a stray lock of Entrapta's hair. Adora continues in a staccato voice, "But how do we get her back to nor-mal?"

Peekablue sounds a little irate, "Rest assured. Her condition will not hinder you."

"But-" Adora's rising annoyance is cut off by a great rumble, followed by a piercing, reverberating shriek that shakes the island.

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" Adora cries. The group closes ranks around Catra and Melog.

Peekablue's voice comes from the tracker pad. "The signal approaches." Bow shuts the communications, and Adora closes her eyes, bracing for the invasion of the island's most dangerous tool.

Bow

The signal hits the group hard this time around.

Hordak screams in pain and fires his cannon into the darkness, sending a swarm of bats flying in terror as flames engulf several trees. He falls to his knees, clutching the sides of his head. "Get. OUT!!" He bellows. Entrapta rushes to his side, only for him to swat her away.

Swift Wind is looking around wildly and hyperventilating, "Oh no… It's following usss!!" He cries, cantering around in terror. Bow fires a flaming arrow behind the horse, where dark vines are creeping up on him, but it only startles Swift Wind more, sending him whinnying and darting around the clearing.

Catra has curled into a fetal position and is whimpering, "Don't hurt me, don't leave me," over and over again. Melog's mane is cycling through colors faster than Bow has ever seen.

Adora seems to be level headed, keeping her blade up and alert. With one arm she grabs Hordak's arm to prevent him from firing anymore.

Bow himself is also less affected, his behavior not changed, instead simply hearing a very loud noise causing a splitting headache. He rushes over to Glimmer, who is staring intently at an empty patch of woods between two trees. "Dad?" She whispers, reaching a hand out, "How are you here?" Bow grabs her arms and spins her around to face him.

"He's not here," He says, "Just focus on me!"

"Dad!" She tries again, struggling in his grasp.

Before anyone can fully succumb to the signal, it is drowned out by a much louder noise. The earth-shaking rumble and shrieking bellow that Bow knows is the roar of a dragon.

Silence falls on Beast Island as the group recovers from the blast of noise. The only noise is the sound of Catra quietly sobbing on the ground in the center of the group.

Adora turns to comfort Catra while Hordak looks at Bow. "Ask your prince," The clone says through gritted teeth, "How much longer we will be here."

Bow nods. *I'm getting tired of the mystery.* Pulling out his tracker pad, he reopens communications with his dads. The image appears, with Peekablue sitting calmly on the sofa in front of him. Before the prince can say anything, Bow says, in his sternest voice, "Okay. Enough vagueness. When are we going to get off of this island? And are we going to encounter that dragon?"

Peekablue nods. "The Ancient One shall be the instrument of your salvation, or your destruction. Which one shall hinge on your

decisions. I cannot see the exact future in this instance, but if all goes well, your predicament shall be mended in due time."

Glimmer grabs the tracker pad, "What do you mean salvation or destruction?"

Peekablue's expression suddenly grows more urgent, and he leans forward. "He approaches. You must ready yourselves! Prove your might to him and he will test you. Do not falter or he will not give you the chance. I can only say good luck now."

Bow immediately draws his bow and begins looking around. "Get to cover!" He hisses to the rest of the group. Hordak and Entrapta rush to a hollow beneath a nearby tree and duck down. Adora grabs Catra and Melog and shelters them beneath a bush, while she stands guard. Glimmer teleports herself and Bow up to a larger tree branch with a view of the clearing. Swift Wind is making a valiant effort to hide behind a rock.

Soon after everyone gets into position, the bushes surrounding the clearing begin to rustle. Bow readies an arrow, and holds as creatures begin to burst into the open. Beasts, ranging from tiny bugs to horse sized carnivores, are running pell mell across the ground, rushing past the group without a care. Through the trees, Bow can see movement. There is a great rumbling in the ground, and a cracking of trees being moved aside by something immense. Cracks form in the rocks below, and even the black vines are retracting from the oncoming form.

There's a pause before the ground erupts. Trees are sent crashing to the ground, rocks scatter every which way. Pillars of stone shatter like falling jenga towers. In the center of this carnage, a massive entity rises from the ground. Two enormous clawed front legs rise out of the pit it's created and slam into the ground with tremendous force, cracking the stone as ten foot long claws tense, pulling the creature's enormous body up.

The dragon's body is long and serpentine, with a muscular torso covered in red scales and a row of spines running along its back.

A long tail stretches out behind it, tearing through the air as the whip-like end sweeps back and forth. Two massive wings unfurl from its back with an audible rattle. Dust dislodges from the sheets of tattered skin as the beast looms over everything in the vicinity. A long neck rises up above the body, and the dragon's head shakes off dirt and dust. Its snout is long, tipped with a pair of horns above the nostrils. Its lips pull back to reveal rows of terrifyingly sharp teeth. Its eyes are orange and yellow, warbling and glowing, and framed by intimidating ridges of sharp scales. The back of its head has a large bony crest flaring out, giving way to a crown of spikes framing the dragon's terrifying visage.

The Dragon of Beast Island radiates power. There's no better way to put it. Bow can feel the thrum of magic in his bones as he looks at this majestic and terrifying entity. This creature is old, far older than anything he's ever encountered, and far stronger than they could ever hope to match.

The dust settles, and no one seems to know what to do. Attacking a creature of this magnitude would be suicide, but Peekablue said that they had to prove themselves.

A low, droning hum fills the clearing, growing more and more powerful. The dragon's chest is emanating an orange glow that is rising up its sinuous neck. It's eyes flash red, and it lets out a roar of challenge, and launches a massive jet of red hot fire straight towards Adora.

The fire rips through the ground, leaving a charred, blackened gash across the clearing. Adora quickly brings up her shield and weathers the storm, but when the stream of flames ends, she falls to her knees, the form of She Ra flickering from exertion.

Bow fires down a hail of trick arrows, but they either bounce harmlessly off his scales or explode in pathetic blasts of smoke or goo. Beside him, Glimmer raises and rotates her hands, conjuring a spell circle that fires out a stream of blue energy. She widens the circle, and spectral chains wrap around the dragon, attempting to hold him in place for the energy beam to hit. A

single baleful eye glances towards them, and the chains melt away. A wavering arcane circle appears above the dragon where Glimmer's spell should have hit it. The dragon's counterspell absorbs the blast, grows larger, and sends it careening back towards Bow and Glimmer. Glimmer quickly brings up a counterspell of her own, but the dragon's skill in magic clearly eclipses even Micah's.

"I don't think this is a fight we can win!" Bow calls as he rains smoke arrows down upon the beast's head, covering its vision in smoke for a moment. A single flap of its massive wings disperses the smoke, and the dragon ducks its head away from the oncoming Swift Wind, who loses balance in the air and tumbles down to earth near the dragon's tail.

Adora is back on her feet, and sends a massive wave of multicolored magic slamming into the dragon's chest. The monumental creature simply wades through the energy, and spins around with surprising speed, slamming its tail into Adora's chest, sending her careening into a nearby tree. She crumples limply to the floor, She Ra fading away.

"It can just take anything we throw at it!" Swift Wind says, taking off and landing over Adora, spreading his wings protectively.

"Let's test that theory." Glimmer says. Before Bow can caution her against doing anything rash, she's teleported into action.

As always, seeing Glimmer in action is a spectacle to behold. Teleporting above the dragon's head, she sends a massive blast of sparkles down to disorient it. She blinks around the beast at lightning speed, sending blasts of magic crashing into its massive form, targeting joints, gaps in the scales, anything that looks like a weak point. The dragon bellows in rage, and its chest and throat glow red as it charges its fire breath, unleashing a massive jet of flame towards the teleporting princess, powerful enough to slice through a nearby tree. Glimmer does not let up, throwing in spells for good measure. Still, the dragon's magical defenses are too strong for her to overcome. Her all out assault, while impressive,

does not seem to harm the titanic creature. It holds for a moment, weathering a torrent of energy as analyzing her pattern. She teleports above it and readies a spell circle, but the dragon lashes out with its wing, smacking her hip and sending her spinning out into the darkness.

"Glimmer!" Bow shouts in terror, firing out a rope arrow to catch her. It falls short, however, and she crashes into a large bush, unmoving. Desperately, he puts his bow away and cups his hands around his mouth. "Dragon!" He calls, his voice breaking, "We don't have to fight!" The beast's eye focuses on him, and he blanches, fixed in place and forgetting what he was going to say. "Uhhh… Wanna talk about anything?"

The dragon turns fully towards Bow and rises. Even as high up in the tree as he is, the beast's head looms over him. Its chest begins to glow, and Bow closes his eyes, bracing for the end.

But it doesn't come. Peeking out one eye, he sees the area light up. He hears a screech, followed by a warbling groan. Opening his eyes, he sees the dragon staggering, the right side of its face smoking. Bow's gaze scans the clearing until he sees the source of the light: Hordak, walking forward with his arm cannon glowing. Another concentrated blast slams into the dragon's neck, tearing down the side and eliciting another roar of pain.

Bow is slack-jawed. *Hordak's cannon is actually powerful enough to faze this monstrosity.* After three more blasts, the dragon turns. Its head snakes down towards Hordak. Another laser crashes directly into its nose, but the massive visage of the dragon emerges from the flames, eyes alight with rage. Hordak stops firing and takes a step back as the dragon bares its massive teeth. But instead of incinerating Hordak, the Dragon simply sits there for a moment.

A low rumble emanates from it, turning into spoken words in a voice like rolling thunder, deep and guttural, with an overwhelming presence to it that sends all other thoughts out of one's head and forces them to pay heed.

"**Well.**" The dragon rumbles. "**You have proven yourselves to be strong. We shall see if you are worthy of my aid.**" The massive creature backs up and settles into a relaxed position, front arms folded over each other and back legs lain out beside its torso like a majestic feline. Its wings furl against its back and it scans the clearing.

Bow rappels down the tree and joins Hordak in the center of the still devastated area. Adora and Swift Wind join them, and Glimmer limps her way over.

Adora steps forward and speaks in an authoritative tone, clearly trying to match the dragon's presence. "I am Adora, She Ra of Etheria. These are my friends. We've been trapped on Beast Island and need a way to leave."

The dragon lets out a terrifying noise that Bow realizes after a moment is not a growl, but a deep, bone-shaking chuckle, "**Well met, She Ra. I am Granamyr the Eternal, King of the Dragons. I am called Starbreaker, Stormbringer, the Beast of Doom, the Harbinger of Fire, the Great Sorcerer, Lord of the Skies and Master of Fate. I have heralded the doom of those who sought destruction, and shepherded those of noble minds to greatness. I am Eldest of all beings, and I shall judge if any one of you is worthy of my aid. I shall look into your hearts, and see if they are true.**"

"Uhhhh… Guys?" Comes a feeble voice from behind them. Turning, Bow sees Catra poking out of the bush. "I thought the poison was wearing off, but I'm pretty sure I'm seeing a dragon."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

The End is Near, Part 1: The Trials of Granamyr (Part 1)

Chapter Summary

> In Which the dragon Granamyr tests the worth of the Best Friend Squad, Micah makes one last desperate attempt to reason with Fygan, and Juliet and Castaspella begin a desperate search for the missing king

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Micah

"Fygan…" Micah says quietly after a very long silence. "I am sorry."

That catches the shapeshifter off guard. "Wh-*what*?" He says, turning.

"I'm sorry." The king repeats, his face genuine and sad. "I don't know what you lost because of our- because of *my* failure, but I can tell that it meant everything to you, and I am so sorry that you went through that."

Fygan visibly gropes around in his head for the right words. "I… Well- It doesn't matter! 'Sorry' doesn't change anything! '*Sorry*' doesn't bring them back!!"

"I know." Micah says, "But you have a chance to set things right. What you're planning will cause untold chaos! You speak of imbalance, but destroying the Runestones will devastate Etheria! They don't just give the princesses their power, they regulate the world we live on."

"I know." Fygan says, "And I've accounted for it. I came up with this by studying Entrapta's work with the Black Garnet. She supercharged one Runestone, and it threw the planet into a destructive storm, leaving the other Runestones weakened. I'm going to do it on a larger scale, simultaneously. When my devices go off, the Runestones will experience a massive surge of energy, drawing power away from each other in a cosmic tug-of-war. Then, they'll detonate. The Runestones will be destroyed, and Etheria will stabilize thanks to the speed at which they are destroyed. The planet will be balanced by the simultaneous destruction, and it will be like nothing ever happened."

He's insane. Micah realizes. "No! That won't work!" He tries desperately. "It will only cause mass destruction! There will be no balance, only chaos!"

Fygan sighs and casts a spell on Micah, who tries to keep talking but finds himself incapable of forming words. "I guess we'll just have to wait and see." He says coldly.

Adora

The presence of a dragon has everyone on edge. Despite the lack of any movements from Granamyr since the end of the fight, everyone can't help but look nervously over their shoulder at the looming form on the opposite end of the clearing. Catra and Melog have mostly gotten over their poison-induced funks, though both of them seem a bit zoned out.

"Okay," Adora begins, "So Granamyr is going to test if we're like… pure hearted heroes or something, and if we pass the test, he'll help us."

"This could prove difficult," Entrapta observes, "If we all have to pass this test." She looks to Hordak and Catra, "That is, assuming Granamyr subscribes to our same system of morality, which is a complete unknown! Oooohhh I hope I get a chance to study him while he's testing everyone!"

“Um,” Bow squeaks nervously, “Maybe don’t run experiments on the live dragon?”

“But imagine the data!!” Entrapta protests, rising onto her hair in excitement.

“Entrapta is right.” Hordak rumbles, “I am not a hero by any metric, nor is Catra.”

“Pft. Better than you.” Catra snarks, her words ever so slightly slurred.

Adora pinches the bridge of her nose in annoyance. *Can you two not just get along??* “Guys,” She says exasperatedly, “I’ll go. If it’s anyone here, it’s me.” Glimmer rolls her eyes and gives a meaningful look to Bow. “What?” Adora says defensively, “I’m She Ra! I’ve saved the world like, half a dozen times. I’ve put my life on the line for others more often than anyone should! I’m like… the most heroic person ever!”

“And humble too.” Glimmer mutters.

Catra steps forward, “Sure, but why?” She asks. ‘*Why?*’ Adora is confused, but Catra continues. “Were you really doing that for other people? Did you really want to be a hero? Or did you just feel like you had to. It’s not really a selfless action if you only do it out of some weird sense of duty.”

That hits Adora in the chest. ‘*Of course it’s still selflessness. I don’t… it’s not like I’m just doing it for myself. I don’t matter at all! As long as everyone else is okay, it’s fine.*’

Catra, reading her expression, sighs. “Adora, that’s the problem. You’re so self sacrificing! A real hero doesn’t try to get themself killed at every opportunity because they know there are other battles to fight.”

Swift Wind raises an eyebrow. “Uhhh, since when is the Horde Soldier an expert on what makes a hero?”

Catra's eyes widen, and she blushes, self-consciously closing off and taking a step back. She quickly mutters, "Since I started reading."

Stars she's cute… and maybe right. "Well I'll at least be the first one to try then." Adora says.

"Fine. Just… be careful." Catra says. She walks up and hugs Adora and attempts to kiss her, but winds up overshooting and smacking her lips into Adora's eye. "Ah! Sorry. Not… fully back to normal yet." The feline says with a bashful grin.

Adora smiles and turns to Bow and Glimmer. "If Granamyr doesn't find me worthy… he might attack. I don't think I could hold him off so…" Adora blinks back tears at the thought. "Just… get everyone back to the Temple and figure out another way." Adora sees the understanding in their eyes before they lunge in and hug her tightly. Memories of the portal and the journey to the Heart of Etheria flash through her mind, but she suppresses them. '*This isn't the same. I'm going to make it out of this.*' Adora takes a deep breath, and turns to face the dragon.

Granamyr's eyes emit faint beams of light that follow Adora across the dim clearing. She considers turning into She Ra, but decides not to. *He doesn't want to judge She Ra. He wants to judge me.*

"Alright." Adora says, "You wanted to test me, and here I am."

Granamyr is a sight to behold. His scales are weathered and cracked with age. Vines and other plant matter cling to his massive form, hanging off of him like tendrils of matted hair. Yellowed teeth extend from its jaw, ranging from the size of her arm to nearly the length of her body. The air around him swirls from his mere breath. His eyes are pools of yellow and orange, like a forest puddle reflecting the bright fall colors above, the light of the sun glinting off of them like a starscape, all contained within those amber orbs. In those eyes Adora can see eternities of torment, triumph, fear, and love, beyond anything she could hope to live through in her mortal life. She finds herself truly awestruck,

unable to move or even breathe for a moment, wondering vaguely if this is what normal people feel like when they see She Ra.

No. She Ra still looks human. This… Granamyr, a real dragon. This is beyond anything I could ever match. Just looking at him, Adora feels humbled.

The dragon's head snakes down and examines her, his eyes boring into her soul and sealing her in place. "**She Ra. Your predecessors were great warriors and heroes. Are you worthy to bear the same mantle? Do you deserve this legacy?**"

Adora's bravado fades. She had walked up intending to be brave, proud, strong. To show this dragon what she's made of and prove to everyone, including herself, that she is worthy. Instead, she sighs and closes her eyes, looking down at the ground. "I… don't know. I've tried to be worthy." She looks up into those fiery eyes. "I've dedicated myself to doing the right thing, even if I'm not always sure I'm doing it right. I gave up everything I thought I knew when I left the Horde because I knew I needed to be better, but I also abandoned my best friend… And I've hurt a lot of people. Bad people, but still people." Adora sighs and rubs her wrist, "I don't know if you'd consider me a hero, but I've done a lot of good for a lot of people and asked nothing in return. If that's not a hero… I'm not sure what is."

Granamyr raises a massive hand in the air, conjuring a grand eldritch spell circle. All around him, tears open in the air, and Adora sees images of herself from her travels. "**The mark of a true heart is humility, and you are full of pride**." Adora sees flashes of dozens of parties in her honor, and sees herself revelling in them. She protests, claiming, "Well, I don't think… I mean- it would have been rude to let their effort go to waste!" Granamyr's eyes narrow, and the dragon continues, "**You never felt appreciated in the Horde, but once you had your recognition, you grew hungry for more; greedy for more. Your self-righteous humility can not hide the simple truth: You feel you are owed praise, She Ra of Etheria.**"

Adora's shoulders slump. Granamyr is already getting under her skin. "Maybe," She concedes, "But can you blame me? Growing up the way I did? I mean no one in the Horde appreciated me except Shadow Weaver, and her appreciation… well. It didn't mean much in the end."

The dragon's head cocks to the side, and its spiked eyebrow ridge raises. "**No one? So sure of that, are you?**" A new image appears.

A younger Adora climbing to a platform on the Fright Zone and talking to a wild-haired Catra.

"I didn't even think you wanted to be Force Captain."

"I don't. Here, take your stupid badge."

"Come on Catra. This is what I've been working for my entire life. I was hoping you could be… I don't know, happy for me?"

The image fades. A tear rolls down Adora's cheek. "**You have always longed for greatness, always believed it was owed to you. You craved power, attention, and let your closest companion fall by the wayside. You were blind to her feelings because you cared only for what would benefit you. Never out of malice, but merely ignorance. But ignorance is far more destructive than malice.**" Quick images of the war flash before Adora's eyes. Catra leaving at Thaymor. The Battle of Bright Moon. Catra corrupting the Sword of Protection and laughing at the ensuing carnage. Bots destroying the Whispering Woods. Catra smirking devilishly while pulling the portal lever. Salineas up in flames.

"Hold on!" Adora says, wiping tears from her face, "I am *not* to blame for Catra's choices."

Granamyr silences her with a snarl, "**Had you not been so oblivious to her feelings, she would not have felt the desperate need to prove herself to be your better. You always wanted more, but all she ever wanted… was you.**"

Adora has no response to that, choosing instead to let the tears fall from her eyes and flow down her chin, dripping onto the ground. She clenches her fists. *I feel so helpless…*

Granamyr's tone softens. "**You are a good person Adora. Your actions speak to that, but you are not worthy.**"

"No." Adora says quietly, tightening her fists. "You're wrong!" She shouts, "Give me another test!"

Granamyr's eyes narrow. Suddenly, it lets out an ear-splitting roar and lunges forward. "**FEAR!!**" He utters. Adora staggers back, tripping over a root and landing hard. Across the clearing, her friends mobilize, raising their weapons, but Granamyr does not press an attack. From deep in his chest, his voice rumbles out scathingly. "**Your pride is born of fear Adora. Not for yourself, but for others. You accept, foolishly, that you must be the one to sacrifice because you are afraid that you will lose those you care for. You fear the very responsibility you crave.**" Rifts appear in the air, showing Adora the Heart of Etheria. The moment Light Hope nearly used her to destroy everything. The moment she shattered the sword. Another rift shows Adora attempting to sacrifice herself at the center of the portal. "**You carry so much fear within you, and that is why you fail.**

"**I have made my judgement. Pray that one among your number possesses a true mind and true heart.**" The dragon settles back into his imperious lounging position, looking down its long snout at Adora, who can do nothing but quietly and impotently seethe before turning back to the group, her arms folded and hands clutching her upper arms.

"Adora?" Catra steps forward, reaching out a tender hand, but after the memories she just watched, seeing the horrible things her partner did… '*because of me…*' Adora pushes away and steps past the group, picking up the pace and rushing away. '*Granamyr is right… I'm not a hero. I'm not worthy… I don't deserve any of*

this.' She rushes to a secluded corner and falls to her knees, tears streaming down her face.

Juliet

Castaspella arrives in true dramatic sorcerer fashion: riding on a cloud. Setting down, she wastes no time in getting to business. "Shadow Weaver's garden," She says, "should have the necessary components to cast a location spell. Take me there."

Juliet does not appreciate the archmage ordering her around in her own home, but she obliges. "Follow me." She says, and begins walking towards the newly-named Garden of Sorceries with haste.

As soon as they arrive, Casta sets to work, rushing into the greenhouse and pulling out fine chalks to draw a spell circle around what was once a birdbath, but is now an arcane focus. The Archmage rambles while she works, and though Juliet doesn't have the first idea what magic is about, she still pays attention.

"If all goes well," The sorceress states, "We'll be able to find him with a simple location spell. My runic circles are designed to strengthen the spell and allow it to break through any protective charms that could block my sight. It would take someone exceptionally powerful or exceptionally well-prepared to overcome them, which is possible. However, if the location spell is a failure," she has completed the runes and is now moving through the various plants and collecting them, "Then we will still have more information on who we're up against, which could help us figure out alternate strategies of finding him."

Juliet nods, somewhat surprised that she followed all of that. Clearly Castaspella is simply good at explaining. The sorceress steps up to the basin and begins dropping ingredients in. The surface of the water turns murky, with various colors and magical energies swirling.

"Come here," Castaspella says, gesturing to the other side of the basin. "The spell requires two people."

“Oh,” Juliet says. She swallows uncomfortably, “I… don’t have magic.”

“Oh nonsense,” Casta says, waving a dismissive hand, “Everyone has magic, just because you can’t cast spells doesn’t mean you don’t have magic. I need you as a focus, a conduit to keep me grounded while the spell reaches out. It’s quite simple.” The sorceress grabs Juliet’s hand and pulls her over to the basin, then raises her own hands above the water and forms a spell circle. Partway through, she grabs both of Juliet’s hands and brings them into contact with the circle, then places her own hands against them, palm to balm. Juliet is unsure why her heart is racing.

The spell circle glows, and turns on its axis before melting into the water. Castaspella brings her hands down to the surface, and dips a single finger into the water, sending perfectly circular ripples across the still surface.

The water’s surface turns cloudy, and Juliet sees flashing images in the depths. Images of Bright Moon, Mystacor, the Whispering Woods, Beast Island, places King Micah has spent much time.

Suddenly, the clouds turn dark and cover the images. A rumble of thunder emanates, and the basin begins to thrum with magic. “Get down!” Juliet says, and lunges forward, tacking Castaspella just as a burst of green lightning detonates, destroying the basin and sending green tendrils of energy and stone shrapnel throughout the greenhouse. Many plants are vaporized or crushed, and glass shatters around them.

Both women sit up, singed and gently smoking. “That,” Castaspella announces, “Was unexpected.”

“Are you alright?” Juliet asks, checking over the sorceress and herself for major wounds. There’s a flare of pain coming from her back and heel, and Casta has a burn on her shoulder.

“I’m fine,” The mage says brusquely, getting to her feet. “More importantly, I know who has Micah.”

“Who??”

“Fygan.” When Castaspella says the name, Juliet’s face sets into one of grim determination. She had foiled the rogue wizard’s plot at the Fright Zone a few months ago, but he had then infiltrated Bright Moon, hiding under her very nose and poisoning one of her own guards. And he’d gotten away scot free. *This could be our chance to bring him to justice, and prevent him from causing any more damage. But then again…*

“Why would Fygan kidnap King Micah?” Juliet asks, “He must know it would only draw attention to himself.”

Casta thinks for a moment, then her eyes widen. “Because he wants an audience. We’ve discounted him for too long, and now he’s entering his endgame. We must hurry.” She rushes out of the greenhouse, Juliet hot on her heels.

“Archmage, if he has his location protected so strongly, how will we find him?”

“We have an item in the vaults of Mystacor,” Casta explains, “The Orrery of Revelean. It highlights powerful centers of magic on Etheria. Two sorcerers as strong as Fygan and Micah together, plus the latent power of those wards, will be more than enough magical energy to light up their location.”

Juliet pulls aside the minotaur guard captain Revina, “Keep the search parties active in the Whispering Woods. We’re looking for a shapechanger, so be on alert. Don’t let anyone have access to the castle unless you’re sure they’re who they seem.”

Revina nods, “Where are you going sir?”

“To Mystacor.”

Juliet rushes after Castaspella, who boards her cloud and helps the General on. “You’re coming? Wonderful! Oh, I wish I had time to give you the grand tour.”

Bow

The mood is morose. The group heard what Granamyr said to Adora, and everyone is unsure what to do. Adora is still in a corner, looking out into the darkness. She's rebuffed any attempts to comfort her, and no one is in a hurry to be next. The fact that the signal has occasionally been sounding in the distance doesn't help to raise anyone's spirits.

Finally, Bow takes a deep breath and stands up, "Alright." He says, "I'll go."

"Be careful." Glimmer says, then forces a smile, "If it's any of us, I'm sure it's you. You're like, the sweetest, nicest person in the world." She gives him a hug and a kiss.

"Bow." Entrapta says, "Try and get a sample while you're there."

"I'll… see what I can do." Bow says. '*I am not going to do that.*'

Bow turns and walks out into the clearing. Granamyr's baleful gaze tracks him across the ground as he approaches.

"Hi, I'm Bow." Bow begins tentatively, "I've done a lot of good things in my life and not that many bad things… I don't really think of myself as a hero, per se, but… I guess that's up to you to decide."

"**Hmmmmm…**" The dragon rumbles and narrows his eyes, peering into Bow's very soul. "**You have a pure heart, and your benevolence is unquestionable.**" Bow shrugs. '*Well that's nice to hear*'

The dragon's nose wrinkles in what seems to be disgust. "**But your tools…**" The air around him splits in many places, and Bow sees images of his arrows appear. Arrows exploding in fire, arrows releasing nets. He sees himself tinkering away on various projects, from his first, simple trick arrow, to the portal in Bright Moon. "**You walk the path of industry.**"

"There's nothing wrong with that!" Bow protests, "If my inventions help people, then that makes them heroic! You can't just argue that all inventors are evil, that's… just really oversimplifying it."

Granamyr snakes his head down with surprising speed and ferocity, sending Bow backpedaling as he snarls, "**Look around you bowman! Those who created this place did not intend harm by their actions. Beast Island was once a haven of safety for the Eternians. But their technology grew beyond their control, and now I alone can overcome its power.**" The signal sounds in the distance, but Bow is aware of it only faintly, so strong is Granamyr's presence. "**You tamper with forces you cannot begin to comprehend, tools used by conquerors. How many worlds did Horde Prime destroy using the portal technology you now seek to co-opt for the sake of convenience?**" Granamyr retracts back into his sitting position and lowers his voice back to a calmer rumble, saying, "**Make no mistake Bow, son of scholars. I do not believe you to be even capable of malice or ill intent. I see your heart, and it is pure and noble. But your actions have the capacity to bring about devastation that you cannot comprehend. You are not worthy.**"

Bow takes a deep breath. "I disagree." He says calmly, "But I respect your judgement." Turning, he speedwalks back to the group, rather disheartened, and more than a little annoyed by the dragon's sentiment.

Technology isn't inherently evil.

Castaspella

Castaspella rushes through the halls of Mystacor with General Juliet hot on her heels. She approaches the Vault, and the guards step aside to let her pass. As soon as she's in, they bring up spectral weapons to block Juliet.

"She's with me!" Casta clarifies, and they reluctantly let the outsider in.

The Vaults of Mystacor are a maze, but Castaspella knows how to get to the Orrery. As she walks, she of course explains the history of the Orrery to General Juliet in an exceedingly dramatic fashion, because that's what she does. "Revelean was a Prince in ancient times, possibly predating the First Ones. Much like our modern day Prince Peekablue, Revelean was gifted with Foresight. He used this ability to craft the Orrery, a powerful magical device that focuses on powerful concentrations of Etherian magic, and projects their locations using an intricately made system of crystals. It's a marvel of both magical prowess and engineering."

"Couldn't he have just… enchanted a map to do that?"

Casta pauses, "Well I suppose so, but then anyone would be able to use it." She stops short in front of one of the Vault's many doors, this one marked with a circular blue crystal inside a diamond. "We're here!" She announces, and presses her badge into the crystal.

The gemstone flashes blue, and she steps back as the door rumbles, and slides into the floor, giving them admittance to the Orrery.

The Orrery of Revelean resides in the center of an unexpectedly grand spherical chamber, with a pathway around the equator that leads around the room to the control panel. The Orrery itself is a large construction, made of many curved bands of metal, with sheets of crystal affixed to large rings at the end of each band. The bands overlap and rotate around a large central apparatus. Castaspella approaches the control console, consisting of a large pentagonal panel with magical runes etched into it, with five spheres floating in rings on the corners.

First, she presses her hands into the pre-carved spell circles on the panel, which light up white. Juliet gasps in awe as the entire upper half of the room transforms into a perfect image of the night's sky, with all of Etheria's moons in position. Castaspella herself gasps. *It's different. It shows the stars now.* She blinks for a moment, taking in the beautiful sight before her. The heavens

are spread out before her, and it's a true wonder to behold. Looking around, she finds herself appreciating Juliet's face of awe just as much as the starscape surrounding them.

Castaspella shakes her head. *I have a mission here. Don't get distracted.* She raises her hands and creates a spell circle above the console, with a pentagon inside it and five hands within circles at each corner. Spectral magic hands appear above every sphere and begin turning them.

The room is filled with the sounds of creaking, grinding metal as her moving the spheres causes a correlatory movement in the five metal bands. She moves them slowly, carefully, aligning them with each of their corresponding moons. As each crystal slots into place, a beam of different colored light pierces through them and shines onto the central apparatus. Once the final ring is in place, the central apparatus glows brightly, then rotates around, rumbles, and projects an image onto the wall directly behind them. Casta reluctantly dispels the starscape so they can see the map.

It is a perfect map of Etheria, outlined in colored magical light. There are several areas that glow brightly. "Each of these different colored points," Casta describes, "Are Runestones. The largest ones are the Prime Runestones."

Juliet points near the pink colored, where a faint yellow point is visible, "What's this second nexus at Bright Moon?"

Casta ponders for a second, then comes to a realization, "That must be the Runestone in the old Sword of Protection. I had no idea it was still functional with the sword broken. That is fascinating…"

Juliet nods, "It is, but what about finding Micah?"

"Oh! Right!" Casta turns to the console and adjusts, "We need to remove the Runestones from the picture. They're such strong sources of energy that the Orrery can't detect anything else."

Looking back to the map, she begins to scan over the now visible images. She marks places known to be hotbeds of magic, as well as Mystacor, which shines just as brightly as the Runestones. Beast Island is a dark spot as always.

“There!” Juliet exclaims, pointing her finger towards a far-flung arm of the Whispering Woods, where a small speck of light is visible in a stretch of land between the Woods and the edge of the Crimson Waste.

“I think you’re right.” Casta says hesitantly, “It’s a no-man’s-land, so a perfect hiding spot, and that is approximately the power we’re looking for.”

“Let’s go.” Juliet says, gripping her sword hilt. Casta nods. While she shuts down the Orrery, she privately worries. That flare is not as strong as Micah should be, but she didn’t see any other spots that could have been him. Either Fygan has found a way to block the Orrery, which would make him more powerful than she ever imagined, or something truly terrible has happened.

My brother is in real danger.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

The End is Near, Part 2: The Trials of Granamyr (Part 2)

Chapter Summary

> In which Granamyrm's trials continue, Casta and Juliet race to find Micah, and Adora has an existential crisis

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer

Okay. This dragon has now caused both my boyfriend and my best friend to have existential crises. I'm done with this.

"I'm going." Glimmer announces.

"Good luck with that Sparkles," Catra snipes, "You've got about as much darkness in you as I do."

Glimmer narrows her eyes, but doesn't rise to the bait. "It doesn't matter." She says, "Someone here has to prove worthy. Maybe it's me." She doesn't let Catra respond, and instead teleports across the clearing to appear in front of Granamyr, who, of course, doesn't appear fazed by it at all.

"Alright, Granamyr," She says firmly, putting her foot down, "I don't know what exactly gives you the right to judge us like this, but I guess we have to go along with it, since you've got us all held hostage. I don't appreciate that you seem to be using this as an opportunity to destroy our self-esteems one by one, but that little game isn't gonna work on me. So go ahead! Lay it on me! Tell me everything that's wrong with me."

The dragon's toothy maw actually cracks into a smile. "**Agghhhhh... I like your spirit. You are the daughter of**

Micah. He is a great man, strong of body, mind, and soul. No one else has kept their sanity on Beast Island like he. There is much of him in you, and much of your mother as well."

Glimmer blinks. "You knew my mother?"

Granamyr nods slowly. "**Queen Angella, wisest and fairest of all beings, whose legacy looms large over you.**" The dragon rises to his feet and stalks in a circle around Glimmer. "**Your desperation to prove your worth to your fallen mother has brought out the worst in you, Glimmer of Bright Moon. Your arrogance, your pride, your stubbornness. You brought ruination down upon this world by activating the Heart of Etheria. You ignored the counsel of those you claimed to care for, and you have learned *nothing* since then!**"

"That's not true!" Glimmer shouts, turning to stare down the wyrm, "I have learned everything, and become a better person, and a better queen because of it. I will never make those mistakes again. Your vision is flawed."

The dragon smirks and continues, his voice lowering to a low rumble, almost purring the words. "**But your flaws are as strong as ever. You may not make the exact same mistakes, but the root causes have not changed. You still believe that you are always correct. But time and again you've been proven wrong, and it drives you mad, doesn't it? Don't you wish you could show them all how strong you are, make them bend to your whims?**" As the dragon speaks, Glimmer hears the signal rise in her head, and Granamyr's voice is echoed by many others. Shadow Weaver, Brannic, Catra, Horde Prime, even faint echoes of Angella, Adora, Micah. "**You could be so much more than you are, yet you allow these fools to hold you back.**" The dragon raises a massive, clawed hand. "**What do you want, Glimmer? Whatever it is, you can have it. All you have to do… is reach out and *take it.***" The hand clenches.

Glimmer is speechless. '*I could make everything perfect… make everyone listen. We could finally have peace across Etheria. Real peace. I wouldn't be held back by bureaucrats or anyone!*' She finds herself unconsciously lifting her hand in a mirror of Granamyr's gesture. The signal grows louder, like a drumbeat playing in her head. She hears the voices of her friends and enemies whispering around her, both encouraging and doubting her. Shadow Weaver pushing her to greatness. Adora undermining her authority. She hears the sounds of marching boots and shouts of terror and joy. '*All I have to do is reach out and take it…*' Her hand falls, and a chill runs down her spine.

"No." She whispers. "I'm not a conqueror or a tyrant."

Granamyr stares through her soul, and she knows he sees how tempted she was at the thought. "**You are not worthy.**" He growls softly, and settles back down.

Glimmer nods, knowing that he's right. 'I'm not a hero. I'm just a person doing the best I can.' She teleports back to her friends. Without a word, she walks over and wraps Bow up in a big hug.

Juliet

Two skiffs tear through the Whispering Woods. A team of Bright Moon's finest, along with a cadre of sorcerers gathered from Mystacor, are racing towards Fygan's location. Juliet starts as her tracker pad rings. She gives it a quizzical look when she sees it's from Bow's father George. *Why would he be contacting me?*

Before she can answer, the skiffs break through the woodland's cover. She cancels the call and gets ready. In the distance, the air is red and hazy, the Crimson Waste, and she can see the silhouette of a single ramshackle structure between them.

The two skiffs race across the empty ground towards their destination, the sun setting as they go. "Slow down!" Casta calls from next to Juliet, "We don't know what sort of traps he could hav-" She is cut off as the other skiff trips some sort of sensor,

and the ground beneath it erupts in a blast of fire, smoke, and debris. The skiff careens to the side and skids to a halt, its rudder damaged and passengers scattered.

"Halt!" Juliet shouts. The driver brings their skiff to a stop. "Dismount and proceed on foot! Rosabeth, Dieren, check on the others." Two of her guards nod and begin carefully moving towards the smoking hulk of the other skiff. Her remaining crew, including two Bright Moon soldiers, two sorcerers, and Castaspella, slowly moves forward towards the distant shack. The sorcerers all conjure up spell circles that seem to sweep the area in front of them for traps. Juliet looks over to the other skiff. Three members of Group Two are injured, and Dieren has them staying with the skiff as she tends to their wounds. The others, including Rosabeth, are being led forward by Captain Revina, arcing around to attempt to flank the shack. Their two sorcerers have the same spells sweeping for traps.

It's tedious going. The flat plain is littered with repurposed Horde traps. A scream from Group Two draws her attention, as she sees one of the sorcerers has stepped onto what appears to be a rune, and been locked in place by green arcs of lightning. Before she can react, one of her soldiers steps on a similar rune, and a blast of concussive force sends Group One flying in different directions. Juliet tucks and rolls to one side, instinctively drawing her sword. While her group is stunned, no one is seriously injured. Both teams regroup, and the sorcerers adjust their spells to check for magical traps.

Her tracker pad rings again, and she cuts it off quickly. *We've got no time for this, and stealth is of the essence.* Still, something nags at the back of her mind. *They wouldn't call if it weren't important…*

One of her soldiers is forced to pull back to the skiff after an undetected trap fires a spike into her leg, and one of Group Two's sorcerers is knocked out by a gas. But the cabin is in range now. Wordlessly, Juliet motions for her remaining two soldiers to take up positions with crossbows, while everyone else circles around to

the shack's door. Juliet and Revina flank the door, while Castaspella and her sorcerers array themselves before the door. Castaspella conjures a large spell glyph, and sends it forward. It phases into the door, which proceeds to glow for a moment, then explodes inward, sending a spray of wood into the interior.

Juliet darts in, sword drawn. Revina barrels in behind her. Castaspella rushes forward, proclaiming, "Stand down Fygan! You can't-" But she cuts herself off when she sees the interior.

The shack is empty. Bits of mechanisms are strewn about the packed dirt floor. Plans and blueprints litter the tables and walls.

"They're not here…" Casta says, her voice trembling, "They were supposed to be here! The- the Orrery does not lie!"

Juliet's comm pad rings once more, and this time she answers it.

"-n't you dare cut me off this time! Oh! General Juliet, thank the Stars!" Lance exclaims.

"What do you need?" She asks, trying not to show the panic that is rising inside her.

George buts in, "No time to explain. Prince Peekablue has an urgent message for you."

Casta leans in. "Prince Peekablue? Ha, no one's seen him for-"

The screen shifts to show the blue and teal skinned visage of the hermit prince.

"Prince Peekablue." Juliet says, awestruck.

The prince speaks gravely. "There is little time. Your quarry can be found where the tyrant's shadow looms. I have no other information. Make haste."

Juliet and Casta look at each other. '*Where the tyrant's shadow looms. Straightforward enough*.' Juliet immediately thinks of the

Fright Zone, but Casta says, "Where's the nearest Horde Spire?"

Catra

Catra's attention is focused on Adora. Her girlfriend hasn't said a word since being judged by Granamyr, and Catra is very worried. '*I'm not sure I've ever seen her this morose*.'

Catra knows she's not a hero. So she's not sure what possesses her to rise to her feet and walk across the clearing towards the massive dragon, this being so ancient that it has vines coming off of its form. She stands before the wyrm as it looks down at her expectantly.

"**Well?**" the dragon rumbles.

"I dunno," Catra shrugs, "I thought you were supposed to be telling me. I mean you're Mister 'I-Judge-You-All-Cuz-I'm-Old-And-All-Knowing', so go ahead and judge away. Trust me. There's nothing you could say that I haven't already thought myself."

The dragon growls deep in its throat. Its gargantuan head looms down and comes face to face with her. The dragon growls with power and what sounds almost like self-satisfied malice, "**You have a pure heart, Catra of the Horde.**"

Catra takes a staggering step back, her head reeling and her eyes widening. "W-what?" She breathes hoarsely.

The dragon's chuckle resonates in Catra's very bones. "**I suppose I can surprise you Little One.**" He lets out a warbling chuckle and settles back. "**You have a long journey ahead of you Catra, and you are far from being a hero, but you are not the failure you think you are. Pride, selfishness, foolishness… All of these are still flaws that you carry with you, but one day you may prove truly worthy of this second chance you've been given.**"

Catra pauses, stumbling over her words, "That… was… unexpected."

"**Make no mistake,**" The dragon adds, sneering, "**You are not worthy. I see potential in you, but you rest on the edge of a knife, ready to fall back into the depths of depravity at a slight provocation.**"

"Well I've made progress," Catra tries for some reason, probably pride, "And I've been tempted plenty of times."

"**And what if your Adora should abandon you again?**"

A chill runs down Catra's spine. "Th-that will never happen."

The wyrm chuckles darkly, "**For Etheria's sake, I hope you are right.**" A tear opens in the air beside his head, and Catra sees flashes of the portal incident, memories she had long since suppressed. She shivers and steps back.

"**Nothing good comes from deception**" Granamyr presses. The visions change to Catra's time leading the Horde. She sees and hears herself lying to Hordak about Entrapta. "Who do you think let the princesses in?" She hears herself say, "Entrapta betrayed us."

"I've changed!" Catra protests, her hackles raising, "I don't lie anymore!"

"**You have lied to *me.***" The dragon cuts her off and the vision changes to show just a few seconds ago. "Th-that will never happen." "**You do not trust her to stay with you, do you? You lie to yourself every day, but your lies will not yield results. Surrender your fears, Catra, and you may one day become a true hero. But until then,**" The dragon's head leans down towards her. It's breath is like the fumes from a forge. An individual fang is half the size of her body. "**You will remain weak**."

Catra gasps inward, realizing that she hasn't breathed since the dragon told her she'd lied. With the breath, the tears soon follow. Sensing her fears, Melog steps in front of Catra, their mane spiked. Granamyr's glowing gaze settles on them. "**Krytian. One of the last bastions of a once great civilization.**"

Melog chirps in surprise and confusion, and Granamyr grins, "**Yes, I know of your people. The dragons once roamed the stars, before the days of Eternia and Prime. Yours was not a kind empire, conquering your planet through fear and trickery, driving your contemporaries into the cold and unforgiving cosmos. Tell me, Melog, did you ever look for others of your kind?**"

Melog's eyes widen, and their mane shrinks. Granamyr continues, "**No. You simply settled into your new life, content to leave the rest of your world to suffer. You had driven off Prime, what more could there be for you? Have you told your companion the purpose of the empathic bond?**"

"What?" Catra says aloud, "Melog, what's he talking about?" Her companion does not respond, and the dragon purrs maliciously, "**It's a tactic they used to drive their enemies insane.**"

Melog begins to meow, "*That is not why I have bonded with you Catra. The dragon may know my history, but he does not know my motives. I was drawn by your strength, and I felt that I could help heal your broken spirit.*"

Catra looks up at Granamyr, who still looks at Melog. "**Neither of you are worthy.**" He growls, almost irritated at this point.

Catra walks back to the group, Melog beside her. '*I'm gonna need to learn more about Melog when this is over.*'

Micah

"Any moment now, *Your Highness*." Fygan sneers as he works. Micah looks around his new accommodations. Fygan had knocked

him out before transportation, but Micah recognizes the architecture well enough to know he's in the control room of a Horde Spire.

"Fygan-" He attempts, but the shapeshifter cuts him off with a harsh, "Quiet! Anything you say, I've already considered." Fygan sighs for a moment. "I may have sunk pretty low, but whatever I've done, you *deserve*."

"It's not too late!" Micah continues desperately. Fygan's plan could prove disastrous if successful, and, restrained as he is by what he's deduced are magic-dampening cuffs, all Micah has to stop him are his words. "I know you're capable of better!"

"Am I?" The illusionist whips around, and Micah sees the bags under his eyes much more clearly in the bright Horde lighting. '*He's worked himself to the bone for this…*' "Hehehehehahahaaa! You don't know the first *thing* about me, King Micah." Fygan spits, his words full of fury and venom. He paces back and forth, gloating aloud, "I've fallen far enough that I've got nowhere left to go, and I've realized that this is where I belong. I'll end anyone who gets in my way if it means I can finally have my sweet, sweet *revenge*."

"Even if your plan works, you'll tear Etheria apart!"

Fygan simply shakes his head, "Ohhhohoho, you'd love it if I believed that, wouldn't you? Sorry Your Highness, but I've accounted for that. Oh there will be consequences. You can't do something as drastic as blowing up a Runestone and not expect ramifications. But when the dust settles, Etheria will finally be free from princesses." He turns back to the console, "At least, the ones that matter. The rest of them will fall like dominoes once the people have control."

"Fygan," Micah tries, attempting a different tactic, "What turned you against Princesses? You fought with us once, it's not too late for you to make amends."

“You forget that I’ve killed quite a few people.” Fygan remarks drily.

“So you may be in prison,” Micah admits, “But that’s a better fate than what will await you after this, success or failure.”

“Oh?”

Micah’s tone drops, “We will hunt you. To the ends of the earth and beyond. You are threatening our home, the people we care about. You forget that Hordak was only spared because he showed signs of change. If you continue to be unrepentant… I cannot promise that you will be shown mercy.” Fygan is silent, but he’s paused. Micah continues, sensing he’s struck a nerve. “It’s not too late! You can make up for your mistakes Gale-”

Wrong move. Micah knows he messed up as soon as the beginnings of the illusionist’s old name cross his lips. “SHUT UP!” Fygan screams, whipping around and sending a disk of hardlight magic spinning towards Micah. The king dodges just in time, but the magic still leaves a nasty gash on his cheek. The shapeshift darts forward and grabs Micah’s face. “That man,” He says furiously, “Is *dead*. You’re not the only one who never left that battlefield!”

Those words hang in the air for a moment as Micah processes them, and Fygan realizes what he just said.

“It was you.” The king breathes.

Fygan stands and runs a hand through his ragged hair, attempting to straighten it. “Of course it was.” He says coldly. He straightens his vest and conjures an illusion, cleaning up his appearance and making himself look positively dapper. “Now if you don’t mind,” He sends a spell into Micah that causes the king’s words to vanish. He turns back to the console, his face having turned into a cocky smirk. “Keep a lid on it. We’re going live in just a few minutes, and then we’ll watch the fireworks.”

Micah can do nothing but glare impotent daggers at the evil sorcerer, and hope that someone is on the way to stop him somehow.

Adora

"It's impossible!" Glimmer rants. Adora can hear her pacing back and forth, occasionally teleporting around with an agitating groan, "He knows everything about us, and his standards are im*possibly* high!"

"Maybe Entrapta could go?" Bow suggests tiredly.

"Ha!" Catra barks, "Yeah, I don't think that'll work out well. Entrapta thinks that morality is just an obstacle to get in the way of," here she imitates the scientist's nasally voice, "*Scientific Progress!*"

"That's true!" Entrapta chirps from her perch, where she is inputting as much visual information about Granamyr into her trackerpad as possible.

Adora is idly poking at Bump with a stick. "Maybe you're worthy buddy." She mutters to the tiny robot with a wry grin. Bump whirrs happily, and rubs against her knee.

Adora sighs and closes her eyes. The signal of Beast Island has started arriving more and more frequently, to the point that it's more of an omnipresent drone.

I've spent so long trying to be a hero… I based my whole identity around it but, he's right. I'm no hero. I don't know what I'm doing, I don't know if it's the right thing. A hero needs to be around to fight every battle, not try to sacrifice herself at any given opportunity.

"*You do not choose. You were chosen.*" The words of Light Hope echo in her head. *But even after I broke the sword I still didn't let myself have a choice. And I thought things would be different but*

now… I'm just going from town to town, being She Ra for people who need her. I'm not changing the world for the better, I'm just providing entertainment to people, and I'm draining myself in the process. The thought causes Adora's body to go sore. She's not had a proper rest in far too long. She feels so empty, physically, magically, and emotionally. She flops onto her back and looks up into the black canopy of trees, to where a single speck of light breaks through and shines down on her.

I restored balance… but now I have no purpose. Adora closes her eyes, and a tear falls down her face.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! I hope you enjoyed. Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

The End is Near, Part 3: The Wrath of Beast Island

Chapter Summary

> In which Granamyr chooses a hero, and Beast Island unleashes its full power to prevent the BFS's escape

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow

Bow startles the group by shouting "AHA! I'm an *idiot!*"

"That's not true!" Glimmer says defensively, at the same time Catra says, "Yeah, so?"

As Glimmer shoots Catra a glare, Bow pulls out his tracker pad and calls his dads. "We can just ask Peekablue who's worthy!"

"That's genius!" Swift Wind exclaims. Catra simply snorts, "Yeah, cuz Peekablue's been soooo helpful."

"He's saved our lives several times." Hordak says flatly.

"Bold of you to assume I want to live." Catra responds.

Lance answers the call, "Bow! Are you alright?"

"Yes, is Peekablue there?"

Peekablue's voice speaks from offscreen. "Yes, has one of you proven your worth?"

"No," Bow says, an edge of frustration creeping into his voice, "Granamyr has pretty much just told us all how much we suck, and not really given us a chance."

“Humans are fallible.” Peekablue says calmly.

“Well duh!” Glimmer butts in, “But that doesn’t help us!”

“You misunderstand,” The prince repeats, “*Humans*, are fallible.”

Entrapta nods, “So we need to build a robot. Robots don’t have moralities, and therefore can’t be immoral.”

“No…” Bow says, his arms slowly lowering as he turns, looking across the clearing.

“Of course…” Glimmer says.

Catra follows their gaze, and goes slack jawed with a mix of surprise, bemusement, and horror. “No… No! It can’t be.”

But it is. It’s always been. The truest hero among us… is currently frozen in place, his mouth open and teeth bared, about to chomp down on a very spiny fruit. His eyes dart around the group trying to figure out why they’ve decided to look at him. Even Adora takes notice and stands up.

“Uhhhh… why are you guys looking at me?” Swift Wind says, still frozen as if caught with his hoof in the cookie jar. The fruit grows legs and skitters away from the horse.

“Because,” Bow starts, and Adora finishes, “You’re the true hero Swifty.”

There’s a pregnant pause before Swift Wind responds with, “Neat.”

Adora (Five Minutes Later)

“**Yes! Yes, you are worthy! If you say the word ‘oats’ *one more time*, I will RETURN THIS ISLAND TO THE SEA!!!**” Granamyr roars. He turns to the group and lets out a heavy sigh, “**In ten thousand years, never have I met such a pure-hearted oaf as this steed.**” He rises to his full height. “**Swift**

Wind has proven worthy. I shall help you all to escape Beast Island."

"Woohoo! Yeah! We're going home! I'm not gonna die here!" Bow, Glimmer, Swift Wind, and Catra all cheer, while Hordak looks on impassively and Entrapta lets out a small, sad, "Awe…"

Adora simply sits. She can't muster up the excitement to leave Beast Island. *'I'll be just as useless out there as I am in here.'*

Some part of her mind fights against this pall of depression that's fallen over her, trying to tell her that she never gives up this easily, that she's letting some overgrown lizard tell her what she is. But she's so very tired, far too tired to listen to that voice in her head.

She smiles and responds to conversations she hears as mere background noise. Granamyr's words echo in her head, as well as her own thoughts and Light Hope's dictations, all fading in and out of the pulsing noise of Beast Island's signal.

"Adora? Adora!" Adora comes to as Catra gives her a playful bap on the cheek. "You alive?"

"Yeah." Adora responds, trying and failing to inject enthusiasm into her voice.

Catra's mouth twists in adorable confusion and she raises an eyebrow. "Adora? Are you still hung up on that dragon?" She narrows her eyes and leans in, grabbing Adora's cheeks, "Did he brain damage you?"

Adora pulls away. "No, I'm just… He said a lot of things that just… hit close to home."

Catra pauses for a moment, looking to the ground contemplatively. She reaches forward and takes Adora's hands. "You don't have to talk about it… I saw some of the things he showed you, and I know some of them were about me… When I was…" Catra inhales through her nose and pauses before

continuing, “But I don’t care if you’re a hero Adora. You’re everything to me, and I want you here.”

Adora smiles, but her thoughts don’t go away. She wraps her arms around Catra and squeezes her tight. “I’m sorry,” She whispers, “I love you.”

At this point, everyone but them, Swift Wind, and Melog has climbed onto Granamyr’s back. Adora looks up, and realizes she can no longer see the sky through the trees. Granamyr notices her expression and nods. “**Beast Island senses my intent. It will try to prevent me from leaving.**”

“How can it do that?” Glimmer asks.

“**Beast Island is powerful little one, and its power has only grown since Etheria’s magic was returned. The Island and I keep each other in check. I prevent its influence from spreading, and it keeps me here. It will send a storm after us, but I will weather it until you are able to escape**.”

Catra gives Adora a reassuring hand squeeze before clambering onto the dragon’s back, leaving Adora alone on the ground. She looks down at her empty hand.

“For the Honor of Grayskull.” She says with quiet determination. Much like when she had been isolated from the group, nothing happens.

Adora sighs, climbs up the dragon’s arm, and settles onto its back. There’s enough room for everyone to sit fairly comfortably on either side of the beast’s ridge of spines.

Granamyr spreads his massive wings. “**Try to restrain your jealousy,**” He says grandly, “**For now you shall see the world as a Dragon does!**”

With that, he takes off, breaking through the canopy and soaring into the sky above Beast Island. The group has varying reactions. Catra squeaks and holds onto Adora for dear life, while Melog

does the same to Catra. Bow is laughing in terror and awe, while Glimmer simply goes, "WHOOOOOOO!!!" Entrapta is attempting to take notes as Hordak holds her down. Swift Wind flies on his own, sticking close to Granamyr's flank.

Adora looks over her shoulder. A massive swirling black funnel is stationary above the peak of Beast Island. As she watches, tendrils of darkness begin to curl off of this storm and seem to approach them.

"Uhhh," She calls out, "We've got, uh… clouds incoming!"

Everyone looks back, where the wisps of darkness are steadily gaining on them. Bow looks around the sky. "Those aren't clouds!" He shouts over the roaring of the wind around them, "They're moving against the wind!"

Entrapta pulls out a pair of binoculars and peers through them. "They appear to be some form of bat-creature!" She proclaims, "Quite unlike anything I encountered during my stay here. And it does appear they are fast approaching!"

Granamyr growls, "**The Deep Ones! Hold on!**" Granamyr banks onto one side, executing a smooth arc in the air to turn and face his adversaries.

Adora's heart speeds up in terror. Clinging onto a flying dragon is not an ideal battle position. "For the Honor of Grayskull!" She tries again, but to no great surprise, nothing happens.

Everyone can hear the droning sound of Beast Island's signal approaching them.

Granamyr's form warms as the telltale hum of his fire breath rises through his body. He opens his mouth and belches out a massive stream of fire, much larger and less concentrated than the jets he employed against them. Smoke billows out of the fire and chokes the air. Adora can hear shrieks of pain as these 'Deep Ones' are engulfed by the flames.

And then the swarm is upon them. Adora desperately reaches to her belt and unfurls her whip sword. With a closer view, she can see the creature's features. About the size of a child, they are a mix of batlike and disturbingly humanoid, with long legs ending in grasping, three-clawed feet. They have small, scrawny arms folded against their chests emerging from the same joint as their flapping wings. Their heads are the most batlike, bearing large ears, upturned noses, and bulging eyes set in even larger saucer-like sockets. Metallic plates run along the cheeks and the top of the head. The armor continues in rigid segments down their backs, reminding Adora of Elementals, though these Deep Ones are much more organic. As they attack, their arms unfurl and Adora sees that they end not in hands, but in wicked six inch serrated blades.

With a cacophony of shrieks and a storm of blades and claws, the Deep Ones begin their assault. They descend on Granamyr in droves, attacking the wyrm from every angle, tearing into him with their bladed arms and grappling onto his scales with their feet, attempting to weigh him down through sheer numbers. The drake spins around, unleashing a firestorm that incinerates the Deep Ones by the dozens, but more keep coming.

They bring the Signal of Beast Island with them, and the battle rages both in the skies and in their minds. Adora keeps one hand wrapped around one of Granamyr's spines, and lashes out with her blade, shearing through a Deep One's wing, sending the creature spinning off below, where its comrades swarm the body and devour it in seconds.

Her friends fight around her. Catra is sending out magical blasts of wind to knock Deep Ones off of Granamyr. Melog darts around Catra, giving her cover from any that swoop to close. Bow fires the few arrows left in his quiver into the storm, knocking out a few clumps of Deep Ones with nets and fireballs. He then resorts to whacking any that get close with his folded up bow as a club. Swift Wind has the advantage of speed, as he darts around Granamyr, knocking Deep Ones off the dragon with kicks and horn thrusts while evading their attempts to pursue.

Entrapta has herself anchored to Granamyr's spines with her hair and is firing into the air with her wrist mounted laser. She also appears to have wrapped an unconscious one in a hair tendril to keep for later. Another hair tendril is wrapped around Hordak's waist. The former conquerer is standing tall on the dragon's back, his arm raised and his other hand steadying the massive cannon as he fires into the storm. Each sweep of his laser destroys almost as many bats as Granamyr's torrents of flame.

'*There must be thousands of these things*.' Adora thinks as she cuts through another pair. She looks at her friends, and her heart stops. "Where's Glimmer!?" She shouts desperately. Her question is soon answered though. Bow is knocked down by a Deep One that immediately pounces on his chest. Another one grabs onto his legs to drag him off Granamyr's back. Before they can lift him, though, a pink form teleports into the space behind them and sends both of them careening off with a ray of magic. Adora pauses for a moment to watch Glimmer's path through the sky as the Princess teleports dozens of times in the span of a few seconds, each time unleashing torrents of Moonstone power and Arcane spells into the crowd. She bamf's in front of one pack and sends a spell circle into them. Immediately, those bats turn on their fellows, creating a dark patch of vicious infighting. Another group is entangled in a spectral net and tumbles into the sea below.

Adora snaps back to the present as one lands a hit across her shoulder, tearing through her jacket and only being deflected by her Bright Moon chain shirt that she had received from Juliet some time ago. She swings her whip-sword through that one, and presses the button to unlock the segments, swinging the weapon around to wrap a Deep One that was about to cleave into Hordak's head. She brings her whip down, slamming the bat creature's head against Granamyr's iron-hard scales and knocking it out. Another swings a blade at her left side, but she brings up Perfuma's wooden gauntlet, which deflects the blow with barely a scuff.

No matter what they do, there are simply too many. The signal is growing overpowering. Adora can see her friends tiring, unable to concentrate on the battle. Bow is disarmed, his precious weapon goes tumbling off the side of the dragon. The bat trapped in Entrapta's hair wakes up, and tackles the scientist, opening its maw to reveal deadly sharp bone plates instead of teeth attempting to tear at her flesh. She brings down her mask just in time to avoid having her face ripped off. Hordak's cannon overheats, and he extends a blade from his wrist and starts slashing through Deep Ones. His blade gets stuck in one's corpse, and they swarm him. He raises his cannon, but a Deep One flies into it full force, colliding with the power crystal using its metal headplate, shattering the powerful weapon.

Granamyr is conjuring a myriad of spell circles with his immense magical power, but he is clearly getting tired. His runes are turning shaky, some of them not even activating at all. His blasts of fire, while still the most powerful offensive move they have, are getting weaker.

The swarm is beginning to anticipate Glimmer's moves, and Adora can see she's taking more damage than she's dealing. The princess teleports back to Granamyr's back and conjures a magical dome to protect herself, Entrapta, Hordak and Bow. Swift Wind gets hit with a powerful wave of the signal, and goes limp. Before he can be consumed by the swarm, Granamyr reaches out a hand and wraps the alicorn in a protective grip.

"Adora!!" Catra shouts, and Adora turns. Her girlfriend is grappling with a Deep One that has her knocked down. Adora rushes forward, letting go of her hold on Granamyr's spine and shoulder-slamming the bat off of Catra. Catra sits up, and Adora turns.

The Deep One flies headfirst into Adora's chest, knocking her backwards into Catra. Both women go careening through the air, tumbling down Granamyr's long body.

Adora reacts fast. One arm flicks out and grabs onto a spine near the end of Granamyr's tail. The other wraps around Catra's hand.

“Hold on!” Adora shouts to Catra, whose eyes are wide with utter terror. Adora thinks back to the only times she’s seen Catra this afraid. When Prime released his control over her to kill her, and when Fygan had them trapped in the Fright Zone. Both moments where she was about to die.

No. I won’t let that happen. “Glimmer!” Adora screams at the top of her lungs, “Help!” The end of the word turns into a yelp as a Deep One strafes her, tearing a bladed claw across her back. “HELP!” She tries again.

Glimmer hears her, and drops her magical shield. She begins to sparkle to teleport, but as soon as she does, the Deep Ones see the lowering of the defenses, and a mass of them descend on the weakened party. Glimmer immediately brings the shield back up, and quivers under the onslaught of bodies slamming against it. She meets Adora’s eyes with a desperate glance.

Granamyr is losing altitude. The sheet number of wounds he’s sustained are beginning to get to him. His spells have ceased, and he’s reduced to flailing about with three of his claws and snapping at them with his jaws. Even weakened, he still holds Swift Wind’s limp form close to his chest protectively. “**You will not conquer me!!**” He bellows, but his labored breath betrays him.

Adora looks down at Catra. “I’ll save us!” She says, her voice cracking, “Just hold on!” The creatures are assailing Catra, and the feline’s grip on Adora’s hand is slipping.

“Adora!” She screams desperately.

“I can do this!” Adora says through gritted teeth. She bends her arm, attempting to pull both of them back towards Granamyr through brute strength, but her muscles scream in anguish and she falls back. Holding the weight of both herself and Catra from a single spine is far too much for her. Adora closes her eyes. “For the Honor of Grayskull.” She whispers. “For the Honor of Grayskull. For the Honor of Grayskull.” Catra’s hand slips further and further down. Adora opens her eyes as their hands are joined

only by tautly curled fingertips. All she can do is look the love of her life in the eyes as it happens. A Deep One swoops down and grabs Catra's arm, tearing her hand free of Adora's.

In slow motion, Adora sees Catra fall into darkness. A strange calm washes over her, and everything goes gray.

She closes her eyes. *I'm no hero… I'm sorry Catra. I'm sorry Angella, I couldn't save them… I'm sorry Mara… Your sacrifice was for nothing… I failed you.*

"No Adora." A voice enters her mind. The chaos of battle and the overwhelming sound of Beast Island is reduced to mere background static. Adora opens her eyes. She can see the battlefield faintly below her, but its blurry and gray, as if seen through thick, murky water. She is She Ra, and, looking up, she sees another figure standing in front of her.

"Mara," Adora breathes, looking at the other woman's form, resplendent in her own She Ra armor.

"You have not failed." Mara says. "You are stronger than you think. You are everything the past She Ras have been and more." As she speaks, Adora sees others appearing behind her. Other women wearing the mantle of She Ra, spreading out into the distance. "Your journey is not over." Mara says strongly, "You are Adora, She Ra of Etheria, and your friends are in danger. Are you going to give up on them? Are you going to let fear consume you? Or are you going to be *brave*?"

Adora blinks. "No." She says, and closes her eyes. "NO!" She opens her eyes, and she's back in the battlefield, looking down as Catra falls. "I… am not… AFRAID!" She lets go of Granamyr's spine and falls towards Catra, going spread eagled as she does.

"For the honor…" She yells. The sword appears in her hands, burning like a white hot brand of righteous fury. The swarm of darkness retreats from the nexus of light that surrounds her. "Of… *GRAYSKULL!!!*"

The mantle of She Ra encompasses her form, and she feels power surge through her. She dives through the air, the Deep Ones making way before her. She reaches out and grabs Catra's spinning form, then clenches her stomach. With great effort, she flips in the air. She carves a circle underneath her with her sword, creating a patch of magical hardlight that she lands on. She tosses Catra onto her shoulder and leaps through the air, landing on Granamyr's back.

Adora raises the Sword of Protection high, and a kaleidoscope of magical energy radiates from her in waves. The Deep Ones shriek in pain and fury, withering before the light and majesty of Etheria's protector. The swarm is broken, and flees towards Beast Island. The oppressive sound of the signal vanishes like a dying scream. The sky's darkness begins to fade. Adora lowers her blade and presses it into the hollow where one of Granamyr's scales was torn off. Magic radiates through the dragon's massive body, and the thousands of wounds he sustained fade away. Even the withering of the years seems to be reversed somewhat, as lustre returns to his ancient form and he stabilizes in the air, swinging around and landing on an outcropping of rock in the sea beneath them.

No one says a word as they all slide down the Dragon's outstretched wing onto the rocky island below. Beast Island is in the distance, defeated for now, and Adora as She Ra stands before Granamyr, the most ancient and powerful being on all of Etheria.

The dragon bows his mighty head before the glowing warrior. "**She Ra.**" He rumbles, "**I have no right any longer to judge your worth. Whether you are a hero is now for you to decide.**"

Adora lets She Ra fade away, and is surprised that she isn't overcome with a massive wave of exhaustion. She looks into those time-bound eyes and thinks. "No." She says simply. "People don't decide whether they're heroes or not. It's their actions that prove their heroics to the generations that follow. Even a

conqueror can be a hero, if she makes the right choice in the end."

Granamyr lets out a low hum, clearly understanding that Adora is talking about both Mara and Catra. "**She was a hero, in the end.**"

Adora shrugs, "She didn't decide to be a hero. She decided to be brave."

Granamyr rises to his full height, towering over Adora and the rest of the party. "**I have no words to acknowledge the strength of spirit I see within you all. You have proven yourselves worthy of more than I saw in you. I return now to my post, keeping the darkness of Beast Island in check. I give you all my blessing, and this warning. I am the last of my kind on Etheria, but there are other Dragons elsewhere in the cosmos. Not all of them are as benevolent as I am.**" He spreads his wings. "**Goodbye, great heroes.**"

And with that, Adora and her friends watch as the Dragon returns to Beast Island.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated. Stay tuned for the finale next arc!

Reckoning, Part 1

Chapter Summary

> In which Juliet and Castaspella are closing in on Fygan and Micah, the Best Friend Squad returns from Beast Island, and Fygan sets his plan in motion.
>
> The finale has begun. The fate of Etheria hangs in the balance as our heroes ready to confront their most dangerous foe yet.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Juliet

The skiff races through the Whispering Woods. Juliet's tracker pad is on the fritz- the Whispering Woods has that effect on tech. She'd managed to get a message through to Bright Moon before her pad had gone out, telling them to send Yanli, the Guard's tech master, along with another squad of soldiers to meet them at the Spire. *'I hope they get there in time… Soon enough to stop whatever Fygan's planning*'. The scattered blueprints had not looked good. Powerful bomb-like devices that seem to mix magic and tech, plus a lot of notes about the Runestones. '*We need to get to him before he can cause more damage.*'

Unfortunately, the Whispering Woods have other plans, as the ground erupts in front of their skiff, and a giant insectoid Elemental comes chittering into action. The pilot swerves to the side, and without missing a beat, Juliet uses the momentum to leap off the skiff towards the Elemental.

Before hitting the ground, she's spun her sword three times, slashing across the bug's face. She hits the ground and immediately somersaults away from the beast's massive stabbing

claw. She slashes her blade across the claw, but is unable to deal more than superficial damage.

"Rope!" She shouts to the skiff. Revina pulls out a rope and starts tying it into a lasso, but Castaspella is quicker on the draw, intuiting the meaning of the command and bringing up a spell glyph that creates a long spectral rope in her hand. The sorceress tosses one end of the rope to Juliet, who catches it and immediately starts running around the bug, avoiding its various legs crashing into the ground and wrapping the rope around it tightly. Its legs thoroughly tangled, the Elemental begins to spin out of control as the skiff circles it. The other end of the rope has been tied off to the mast, and the beast roars in displeasure from the ride.

Juliet sprints over to intercept the skiff, and is hoisted onboard by Revina. "Get us out of here!" She shouts. The pilot jams the rudder forward, and the skiff shoots off through the trees. Castaspella dispels the rope, and the Elemental's momentum carries it spinning into a massive tree, where it settles down until the dizziness fades.

"Punch it." Juliet commands, "We can't have any more detours. King Micah is in danger and as far as we know, we're his only hope."

She looks down at her tracker pad, where the staticky, flashing image shows their skiff getting ever closer to the Spire. '*He has to be there.'*

Micah

Micah is done talking, but Fygan continues to babble on.

"'It's not too late, it's not too late'" The illusionist yammers, "You're like a broken recording, you know that? 'Fygan, it's not too late', 'Fygan, you can still change!' Well what if I don't want to?" The shapeshifter challenges and turns to glare at Micah. "What if I'm perfectly happy right now? I've made peace with this." He

puts his hands on his chest, "I'm the bad guy. And I'm *really good* at it. You should have seen me in the Fright Zone. When I had Catra and Adora dead-to-rights… Ohhhh that was *gooooood*." Fygan is practically devouring the scenery, growling his words with smug satisfaction and pacing back and forth, gesticulating wildly. "I mean you know I've always been good at threats but man, I have gotten *scary*!" He chuckles. "Even you're scared of me."

That causes Micah to snort. The shapeshifter's face falls alarmingly quickly. "What's so funny?"

"I'm sorry." Micah says, "Please, continue."

Fygan sucks his top lip in and holds up a finger. "No, explain the joke, *Your Highness*."

Micah sighs and looks up at his captor. "You're a powerful sorcerer, a merciless killer, and a genius engineer. But you're just a *person*. Fygan, I spent 15 years on *Beast Island,* the place that nightmares are made of. You've always had quite the inflated sense of self-importance but… to think you can do anything to scare me? Come on. That's just delusional." Micah inwardly smiles at the huff of rage the provokes. '*Good. Keep talking*.'

Fygan opens his mouth, then a look of realization crosses his face, and he falls into a smirk. "Ooohohohohoho… Good try. But, ah, very poor choice of words." Fygan creates a large, very ornate spell circle in front of him. "Pity. I had hoped you'd be conscious to watch the grand finale, but you've forced my hand." The circle glows, "I've been working on this for some time. A much more powerful fear spell, that can send even the strongest-willed individuals into a catatonic state. Say hello to your nightmares." The glyph washes over Micah, who resists the encroaching magic for as long as he can.

But eventually, the king's iron will falters, and he finds himself confronted by a menagerie of horrors.

Glimmer

It takes a few jumps to get from the outskirts of Beast Island to the Bright Moon Throne Room. Catra simply collapses, her face extremely pale. Adora, still radiantly glowing as She Ra, kneels down to comfort her.

"Guards!" Glimmer shouts, her voice echoing through the halls. It is immediately followed by the sounds of rushing footsteps.

"Your Majesty!" Three guards rush into the hall and briefly kneel.

Glimmer turns to them, "Where's my father?" She demands.

All three look at each other in trepidation before one of them looks at Glimmer. "General Juliet and Archmage Castaspella left several hours ago. They believe that King Micah was… kidnapped by the outlaw sorcerer Fygan."

Glimmer's eyes immediately widen, and her heart skips a beat. *Fygan??* She looks to Catra and Adora, who have both paled at the name. Adora's face settles into a tranquil fury as she rises to her full height. Catra stays on her knees, but Melog's mane betrays her by shifting to a swirling red and black, an ominous coloration that Glimmer's never seen before.

"Where are they?" Bow asks diplomatically.

"We… aren't sure." Another guard says, "They dropped off coms once they entered the Whispering Woods. Yanli and a squad of guards left to meet up with them about half an hour ago, but we aren't sure exactly where they went."

Glimmer turns to the group, surveying them. Hordak and Swift Wind are still in fairly rough shape, Bow is out of arrows, and Entrapta seems completely tuned out of reality, muttering a complete report of their Beast Island excursion into her recorder. Catra finally stands up and leans against Adora, who seems to be the only one in full fighting shape, but Glimmer knows that after that display of power, she's going to be completely exhausted once She Ra drops.

Glimmer closes her eyes and makes a hard decision. "Bow. Go to your workshop and refill your arrows. Adora, see what you can do to heal Swift Wind. Hordak and Entrapta will stay here. Catra, we're going to Shadow Weaver's garden. I need help to perform a location spell. We'll meet at the garden in five minutes, and we're going to rescue my dad and take Fygan down, once and for all."

*****

It's been a long time since Glimmer has felt this magically drained. She half-considers going to the Moonstone to recharge, but there's no time, and she's not even sure it would do anything. She teleports herself and Catra to Shadow Weaver's garden, and stops dead.

"Sparkles?" Catra says in alarm, nearly bumping into the queen. "What's wro- oh."

The greenhouse is wrecked. Most of the glass is shattered, the plants are damaged, and the basin, the crucial component of the location spell, is shattered. Catra paces around. "What… happened here?"

Glimmer looks around at the plants, her heart sinking. She'd never fully realized how much she valued this place until she sees it so trashed.. *Even though the circumstances were bad… this is where I first learned to do magic. It… hurts to see it so broken*. She closes her eyes and breathes for a second. "I can fix this later." She resolves quietly. She rushes over to a small bookshelf, containing several magical recipe books, and plucks one out. She pulls a shard of glass out of the spine, and flips it open. She hands it to Catra. "Find these plants." She commands, "I'm going to get us a new basin."

A quick series of teleports to the kitchen, and one of Bright Moon's thousands of waterfalls yields the result she intended, and she returns with a large bowl filled with water. A simple act of prestidigitation clears the space for a ritual area in the center, and

Catra returns with the correct ingredients. Some of them are a bit worse for wear, but they should suffice.

"Alright," Glimmer says, snatching the book, "Pay attention. This is a good spell for you to know."

Glimmer walks Catra through the spell, speaking confidently to hide her nerves. *I've never done this spell before… and a lot is riding on this. Don't mess this up Glimmer.*

Prove Granamyr wrong. I am worthy. I can do this to save my dad.

Adora, Bow, and Swift Wind arrive after the first failed attempt. The second attempt fails because Catra is staring off to one side ("Catra!" Glimmer shouts, "stop ogling Adora and pay attention!"). The third time, though, the magic happens. Both Catra and Glimmer work perfectly in tandem, and the surface of the water shimmers and distorts. An image of the Whispering Woods appears, focused on Castaspella. Around her, Glimmer can see a large clearing, and the looming white monolith of a Horde Spire.

"Let's go!" Glimmer says, grabbing everyone and teleporting without hesitation to the site.

Juliet

Her forces are arrayed before her, standing in the shadow of the overgrown Horde Spire. Ten of Bright Moon's finest, led by Captain Revina. Yanli, their satyr techmaster, is currently plugged into a port at the base of the tower, feverishly scrolling through lines of alien code. Castaspella stands next to Juliet, with her three sorcerers slightly separated from the guards.

"Fygan has obviously been planning this move for a long time." Juliet says, "So it's entirely possible that he's rigged this tower against us. When we go in there, be prepared for anything."

Yanli pipes up in their warbly, high pitched voice, warning, "There is a definite power surge throughout the ship. I believe Fygan is charging the bots."

"There are still bots in there??" a sorcerer says, looking shocked.

Juliet grimaces. "It's in the heart of the Whispering Woods. With our attention focused elsewhere we've left this one alone. Clearly that was a mistake to learn from. Yanli, do you have a schematic?"

"Already sent to your pad." The technician responds.

Juliet pulls out her pad, and, thankfully, finds the blueprint. All Horde Spires are identical, so they're not in unknown terrain. "Alright." She says, "Ca- Archmage Castaspella and I will lead a team to the control deck and surrounding levels. Revina, you'll lead everyone else to stop those bots from powering up."

Revina opens her mouth to speak, but suddenly, a large shower of pink sparks fills the space. Juliet falls onto her back foot and draws her sword, but immediately lowers it when she sees, "Queen Glimmer?"

Queen Glimmer has arrived, along with the radiant form of She Ra, and Bow, Catra, Melog, and Swift Wind. Juliet immediately notes their bedraggled nature. They're filthy, they look like they haven't slept in days, and all except She Ra are covered in mostly-healed wounds.

"Glimmer!" Casta exclaims, immediately sweeping her niece into a crushing hug, ignoring Glimmer's winces of pain. She Ra looks to Juliet. "What's the plan General?"

Juliet's somewhat taken aback. She had always been loath to work with Adora during the war. The ex-Horde soldier tended to automatically assume command of every possible situation, including their investigation of Catra's poisoning several months ago, so the implicit acknowledgement of Juliet's authority is a bit of a surprise. She snaps back to the present and lays it out. "With

you all here, we have a much greater advantage. You can join Casta and I in rescuing Micah and confronting Fygan. Revina will lead the rest of our forces, along with our tech master Yanli, to deactivate the bots."

"Bots?" Catra inquires.

"Fygan is activating the bots stored in the spire." Yanli explains, "There are over a thousand bots and drones in there - enough to menace a kingdom - so our best hope is to shut them down."

"I'll go with them." Bow says.

"We're gonna need you Bow." Adora responds, but Bow shakes his head.

"I'm going to be totally honest," The archer says ruefully, "My fingers really hurt from all the shooting recently. I'm going to be of more use helping Yanli."

The satyr's eyes widen. "Bow?? Bright Moon techmaster Bow wants to go with me??"

Bow raises an eyebrow, "If… that's okay?"

Yanli gives a somewhat manic chuckle, "Hahahha, okay? Of, of course! You're my inspiration. It's an honor to work alongside you."

Bow blushes. "Aww." Yanli unplugs and nods to Juliet, still visibly freaking out about getting to work with their hero.

"Alright." Juliet says, turning to the door. "Let's do this."

Everyone begins to move, but they are cut off by a vibrant green light filling the air around them. Everyone jumps into attack positions, but then they realize what it is. A holographic image of Fygan, several stories tall, projecting his message across Etheria just as Prime once did.

All

"People of Etheria!" The message begins with bombast, "Do not be afraid. I do not come to conquer or enslave. Instead, I use these tools of tyranny to spread a message of hope! Of liberty!" People across Etheria huddle in fear, remembering Prime's reign. In New Thaymoor, a mother clutches her newborn close. In Salineas, a guard's weapon drops from his slackened hand, as phantom spasms shoot through him from the scar on the back of his neck.

"For too long," Fygan says, "We have lived as second-class citizens in our own world. We have allowed ourselves to let these… *princesses*, shovel their lies into our minds. We've allowed them to convince us that they are our protectors." At their farmhouse, Netossa and Spinnerella let their gardening tools fall to the ground as they hear the distant echoes from the nearest Spire.

"But no more! I come as a bringer of enlightenment!"

Juliet, Catra, Glimmer, and Castaspella are racing through the halls of the Horde Spire, boarding an elevator to reach the top.

Adora rides Swift Wind to the top, and scours the windows of the Spire for any sign of Fygan.

"If these princesses truly protected you, would they let your oppressors walk free?" In Bright Moon, one of the guards casts a dark look towards Hordak and Entrapta. "They not only shelter these monsters, but they have put them above you! These conquerors have gotten everything they wanted, and you've all accepted it because your princesses told you to!" In Plumeria, Perfuma looks to Scorpia, who is slowly backing away as people begin to look at her with a newfound fury in their eyes. "The Horde wished to rule Etheria, and now, the Princesses let them! We did not win the war, we only changed the enemy! The Princesses and the Horde lord over you side by side, feeling oh-so-safe because of their precious Runestones."

Frosta's eyes widen, and she begins to run towards the chamber of the Fractal Flake. "But now, I'm going to take that power away from them. I urge you all to seize this opportunity! I am giving you the key to your freedom, but it is you that must open the door. Tear off your shackles! Destroy the walls of the old world, that a new one might be born from the ashes. The Princesses have come to silence me now. It is up to you, the people of Etheria, to make sure my struggles are not in vain!! Take back your world! Win this day! For your children! For yourselves! For all those who have fallen!" The message ends.

Across Etheria, people react. Some hide in their homes. Some turn on their neighbors. Some look to the Princesses with hope, others with fear, others with disgust. Mermista, on a romantic boat picnic with Sea Hawk, dodges a bottle thrown at her by an angry reveler. She looks to Sea Hawk, who says, "The Runestone!" Her eyes widen, and she leaps into the water, turning into a mermaid to swim towards the palace.

In Bright Moon, Hordak snarls as guards shove him and Entrapta into a guest room. Brannic orders them to lock the door, and looks to Hordak and Entrapta coldly, drawling out a condescending, "It's for your own protection."

In the Fright Zone, ex-Horde members who have worked day and night tearing apart their old homes as "community service" look to the newly rebuilt Horror Hall, and wonder why Scorpia gets to rule over them when she did just as much wrong.

"Murderer!" An older Plumerian man shouts, pointing at Scorpia. "Murderer!" Another one takes up the call.

"No!" Perfuma says, raising her hands to her people, "No, Scorpia's never killed anyone!"

"Yeah," Cherrick joins, "She's a good person, not like the other Horde people."

"That's not what I-" Perfuma protests.

“Get out of our home!” A younger girl says, picking up a wad of dirt and throwing it at Scorpia, whose eyes are brimming with tears. The crowd is descending into chaos as people choose sides and argue with each other. Perfuma watches in horror as her peaceful people turn to rage so quickly.

Across Etheria, confusion and terror reign supreme as Fygan readies for the finale.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Reckoning, Part 2

Chapter Summary

> In which our heroes confront Fygan, but his devices have already been set. The apocalypse has begun.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow

The door slides open, and Revina and Bow lead the charge, their weapons ready.

"Woah…" Bow says as he looks up. They're in the heart of the Spire, a massive chamber that spans the entire height of the vessel. Racks upon racks of deadly humanoid robots line the walls of the circular chamber, rising up into darkness above. Yanli was right. There must be almost a thousand bots here, more than enough to pose a major threat to any kingdom.

"Yanli!" Revina calls.

The satyr pops their head out from behind a pair of guards and asks, "Is it safe?"

"It's safe." Bow assures them, folding up his bow and walking into the room towards the console that sits at the base of the room's massive central pillar, which holds the spire's equally terrifying supply of drones. Bow and Yanli set to work. There are several devices affixed to the console that are clearly foreign.

"What are these for?" Bow muses.

Yanli looks at one. "They appear to have several different purposes. Some of them are built to provide power to the console, others appear to be for destructive purposes in case the power is

disconnected. This one," They point to a large one attached to a Horde Prime input port, "Appears to be designed to override the bot's directives."

"Give Fygan control." Bow says.

"Hey… techies?" Revina says, "Are they supposed to be blinking?" Bow looks around, and sees that indeed, each of the Bot's chest and eye crystals are flashing in pulses of green light.

Bow meets Yanli's eyes, and both techmasters say, "We need to work fast."

Catra

The elevator doors open, and everyone rushes into the command deck. Catra pulls out her components and summons her whip as soon as she sees Fygan turn around, a demented grin across his face.

"Stand down Fygan!" Castaspella says, two powerful spell glyphs humming in her hands, "Or we'll take you down by force!" Fygan mockingly raises his hands to the sides of his head.

Out of the corner of her eye, Catra sees Juliet scanning the room, and shaking her head. "Where's King Micah?" Catra growls.

"Oh he's safe." The shapeshifter croons, "Ah ah ah!" He adds as Casta's runes glow. "I'd back off if I were you." He cocks his head to one of his hands, which is holding some sort of device. "You make one move on me, and I pop the Runestones like pimples. Don't even think about it, Your Majesty." He snarls at Glimmer, who was readying a teleport. "I've got a heck of a reaction time." Glimmer stands down, but is still ready with a spell glyph over one hand and pink sparkles around the other.

Glimmer doesn't take her eyes off Fygan as she orders Juliet to, "Find my dad!"

The general nods and rushes back into the elevator, hesitating only for a moment when Fygan taunts, “What’s left of him, at least!”

The elevator closes, but the taunt does set off Glimmer, who hurls a ball of magic at Fygan. The shapeshifter darts to one side and holds up a hand, dropping his facade and snarling, “Don’t you dare!” There’s a tense standoff. “Your dad’s alive. Barely.” Fygan says. “The only reason I haven’t set these bombs off is because… okay I admit that last taunt was a low blow. That one’s on me. But let’s start over and be civil, huh? And maybe I won’t have to press this.”

Catra’s barely listening. Instead, she’s studying the device. It’s hard to see with his fingers occluding the surface but there are several buttons on it. It’s clearly a copy of an Entrapta design, and there’s a blinking red light coming from a screen. She narrows her eyes, trying to make out more details.

“You threw civility out the window when you started killing people.” Casta responds.

“Oooh, thrown out the window… that’s a good idea.” Fygan says excitedly.

“I wouldn’t.” Glimmer responds smugly. Fygan realizes the glow streaming in through the window, and looks over his shoulder to see She Ra, astride Swift Wind, staring him down through the glass. “No escape there.” Glimmer taunts.

“What game are you playing??” Catra suddenly cuts in with a snarl, pointing towards the device. “What are those numbers?” Fygan looks to the blinking display on the device, moving his thumb aside so the flashing red numbers are visible.

004

He smiles. “Oh good, you figured it out.”

003

“It’s a countdown”

002

“Pressed it five minutes ago.”

001

“I’ve been stalling.”

000

Perfuma

Perfuma is almost ready to summon magic against her own people, but any potential for violence is cut off as a shockwave rakes through the clearing. Perfuma screams in pain and looks over her shoulder, to where a fireball curls out of the back of the Heart Blossom tree. The ancient trunk is partially blasted open, and the Runestone within is cracked and damaged, sparking with red energy. Beside her, Scorpia collapses to her knees in pain. Perfuma can see the color draining from Scorpia’s skin, and she falls to her knees clutching her lover.

Mermista

Mermista slams into the throne room riding a tidal wave, rushing towards the Pearl. She gets within arm’s length of it when a massive explosion shatters half the throne and sends her flying back.

“Mermista!” Sea Hawk darts in and cradles her in his arms as she begins to groan. The tidal wave sputters. The Pearl has fallen to the ground and is shooting out waves of destructive energy that are laying waste to the hall.

Frosta

Frosta barely gets into the Fractal Flake chamber when the device detonates, sending a shockwave ripping through the cave that knocks her back. The fireball balloons out, then is sucked back into the device and channeled into the Runestone. The multi-pointed crystal glows orange as fire fills the myriad cracks. Frosta raises her hand and encases the Runestone in ice, but the glow is still visible, and the effort of such a concentrated effort of magic nearly knocks her out.

Glimmer

The moment the countdown reaches zero, several things happen at once. Everyone feels a faint rumble in their very souls, like the planet just twisted in a way they weren't prepared for. Glimmer screams out, a sickly pink glow emanating from within her. She falls to her knees in pain. A pain that is somewhat familiar. It reminds her of when she activated the Heart of Etheria, but this pain is somehow opposite of that. She feels the magical energy swirling within her, ebbing and flowing, like it's at war with itself inside her body.

While Catra and Casta are momentarily distracted by worry, Fygan slams his hand onto a pad on the Spire's control console. Green lightning rips through the room, stunning all four of his opponents. Outside the Spire, She Ra's sword glows as Adora prepares to make her entrance, but Fygan is faster. He falls into a crouch and summons a spell glyph. A large, spectral hand appears and grabs Catra, and, before anyone can react, Fygan swings his arm to his side, and the spectral hand mirrors the movement, hurling Catra forward. She curls up just in time as she impacts the window right as a wave of magic from She Ra shatters it.

The cat hurtles through the air, plummeting towards the ground below. Adora and Swift Wind go into a nose dive to catch her.

From his crouched position, Fygan dives across the room, sliding over the smooth floor and spinning around, sweeping a leg into Castaspella's ankles. The archmage hits the floor with a yelp, landing in an inelegant heap, her halo knocked away from her.

Fygan tenses and leaps on top of her, pinning one hand with his foot, and the other with his opposite knee. He conjures a spell circle and forces it onto her face, knocking her out with a powerful sleep spell.

Despite the pain wracking her body, Glimmer glares at the shapeshifter as he turns to her. Finally, he's not able to react fast enough as a beam of pink energy slams into his chest, lifting him off the ground and sending him careening into the opposite wall.

Glimmer sways to her feet, lurching with a stab of pain and staggering to support herself against the wall. She calls on her magic again, but a surge of energy races through her body. Every molecule of her form screams in pain as the red electricity of the Black Garnet once more runs rampant through her body. She falls to her knees, and a bolt of red lightning leaps from her hand and tears across the console. Smoke and flame fill the room as alarms begin to blare.

Fygan looks at her, mouth agape. "That was unexpected." He pants, then places his hand on a panel behind him, opening a hidden door that he slips into.

Glimmer attempts to teleport after him, but she feels a surge of power far beyond what she was expecting. She vanishes from the control room, reappearing miles above the earth, plummeting towards the Whispering Woods below.

"WAUGHHHHH!" She screams, and uses the rest of that wave of energy to teleport back to where she was. She appears about a foot higher, and falls to the hard metal surface with an, "oof." She rolls over onto her back, parallel to her aunt's unconscious form. She can feel magic all around her, both familiar and unfamiliar, like she's taking power from every Runestone at once.

What did he do?

Adora

For the second time today, Adora grasps Catra's arm to save the feline from plummeting to certain death. Catra shouts in pain as her arm is yanked upwards and nearly dislocated. Swift Wind swoops down to the ground and Adora lets Catra go, then lands and dismounts to inspect her girlfriend.

The catgirl is covered in scratches from head to toe from the shattered glass, and is cradling her arm uncomfortably. She looks up at Adora as the radiant form of She Ra kneels before her.

"It's been a heck of a day, huh?" Catra rasps.

"A heck of a day." Adora agrees, wavering between laughter and tears as she cups Catra's cheek and kisses her on the lips. She Ra's magic flows through Catra, healing her wounds. Adora stands up and turns towards Swift Wind. She leaps onto the steed and turns him.

"Let's take him down Swifty." She growls, glaring up towards the Spire, towards Fygan. '*He's nearly killed Catra twice, and he's threatening all of Etheria now. I'm taking him down, for good*.' Swift Wind spreads his wings and readies to take off, but stops when Catra calls, "Adora! Wait!"

Adora turns and sees her girlfriend's attention is focused upwards. Following her gaze, Adora's eyes widen.

The sky is broken. Streaks of vibrant color are streaking across the sky like a terrible aurora. Clouds crash into each other like a roiling sea. Rain is beginning to fall in scattered bursts, but not all of it is falling in the same direction. Adora turns and looks out over the Whispering Woods, where trees are being uprooted by incredibly strong winds, only to fall from the sky as the air suddenly becomes stagnant. Small woodland creatures are visible taking shelter beneath rocks as Elementals go berserk.

Etheria is tearing itself apart. Adora looks down at Catra. "We'll handle Fygan." Catra says, "You need to fix this, you're the only one who can!"

Adora nods. “I love you,” She tells Catra, “This isn’t the end.” She promises, and Swift Wind takes off into the turbulent skies.

Adora looks over her shoulder at the lonely form of Catra for as long as she can until a storm of red lightning bolts around her diverts her attention. “Adora!” Swift Wind shouts over the winds, “Where are we going?”

“Bright Moon!” Adora responds laboriously, “If anyone knows how to stop this, it’s Entrapta!”

Bow

Yanli is working furiously. While they’ve been hacking through many layers of both Fygan and Prime’s firewalls, Bow has been doing the physical labor, disarming the various devices Fygan attached to the console. Out of caution, the Bright Moon guards are tearing down the handful of bots that can be reached from the floor and destroying them, but there are still almost a thousand bots in here, ready for war.

“BrrrreeeeeeEEEEEE!!!” A loud ringing sound echoes through the chamber. The rest of the party has to cover their ears, but Bow has grown quite used to uncomfortable auditory intrusions in the past few days. Looking around, he sees that the bots’ crystals are now glowing entirely green. There’s a whirring of machinery as the racks begin to activate to deploy the bots.

“Everyone get out!” Bow shouts, firing an explosive arrow into one of the racks.

“Wait!” Yanli responds, “I’m so close, I can send out an override code.”

“No time!” Revina says, grabbing the diminutive satyr around the waist and hoisting them over her shoulder. She tosses her spear into a throwing position and chucks it at the first drone to emerge from the hive-like central column.

Three of the guards fill the door with tower shields and spears bristing out. The bots begin to deploy and march into the hallway. The guards have a good chokepoint, and the bots aren't smart enough to try any tactic besides 'Shoot at the obstruction until it's gone', so Bow is able to lead a retreat to the outside of the Spire. "Find cover!" Bow says as he slams his hand onto the control panel, shutting the door in front of the oncoming horde of bots. "This is gonna be a rough fight!"

"What's happening!?" Bow's head snaps towards the sound of Catra's voice, as the catgirl rushes towards him, Melog appearing by her side.

"Catra?? I thought you were taking down Fygan!" He exclaims, his voice cracking slightly.

Catra shrugs nonchalantly, "Got thrown out the window. Did you deactivate the bots?"

As if on cue, a laser blast melts a hole in the metal of the door as the bots begin their attack.

"Nope!" Bow says, grabbing Catra's hand and darting towards the Whispering Woods for some cover.

Scorpia

Perfuma falls to her knees, and magic runs wild. A wave of plants ripples out from her in a circle, growing larger and more dangerous. It sweeps through the crowd, sending people scattering. Yurts and other structures collapse. One of them catches fire from the embers of its fire pit. Rain lashes across Plumeria as flames spread up the height of the Heart Blossom.

Scorpia struggles against a torrential wind and scoops Perfuma into her arms. "Are you alright wildflower??" She shouts.

Perfuma looks dazed, but smiles loosely and rests a hand on Scorpia's cheek. "Everything's okay…" She murmurs, then her eyes

flutter closed and she falls unconscious.

"No!" Scorpia says. She takes the blonde into her arms and stands, only to feel sudden electric pain ravage her body. She screams out and falls to her knees, letting Perfuma tumble onto the ground.

"AHHHHHH!!" Scorpia screams as the pain grows more intense. Reflexively, she spins around and slams her claw into the ground. With her claw as the epicenter, the grass in front of her dies as the water within them joins with the water in the air to create a tidal wave that roars forward into the woods. Scorpia looks at her claws. *'I have water powers now??'* She points her hands towards the Heart Blossom, hoping for another wave to quench the flames, but nothing happens.

Her attention is diverted from the disappointment by a cry of, "Help!!" Spinning around, she sees the source. A woman is desperately trying to lift a tree trunk that was blown over. Trapped underneath is the same old man who had called Scorpia a murderer.

Scorpia runs over without hesitation. "Hang on!" She shouts, "I'll lift, you pull him out!"

The woman nods. Scorpia recognizes her as another member of the crowd that had been disparaging her moments ago, but now lives are on the line, and none of that matters. Scorpia grasps the tree and lifts with all her might.

It rises surprisingly easily, and the woman pulls the old man out from under it. Scorpia looks down at him and nods, but he can only give a flabbergasted stare in response, as if asking, "Why?"

"It doesn't matter!" Scorpia tells him, and turns to look at the prone Perfuma. The moment she does, something happens to her. She has what she could only describe as a premonition, seeing a bolt of red lightning streak down from the sky and annihilate the

helpless plant princess. Knowing somehow the truth of her vision, Scorpia dashes forward, standing over the thin form of Perfuma.

The sky flashes and roars, and lightning tears across it in a web above Plumeria. A single tendril snakes down towards the princesses, and Scorpia braces herself. *Even with my powers, there's not much I could do. But I can take it for her.*

Instinct takes over as the bolt approaches. Scorpia raises a claw to the heavens and catches the lightning stake. Wind whips around her as the electricity pours into her body. Her hair stands on end as she guides the lightning down her arm, through her stomach, and out through the other claw. The bolt emerges and strikes down a dead tree, and Scorpia stands there, stunned and blinking with her arms in an 'L' formation and her hair standing on end.

Juliet

The King is huddled in a corner, his hands tied to a pipe and a haunted look in his eyes as the door opens.

"King Micah!" Juliet says, rushing towards him.

"NO!!" The King barks, stopping her in her tracks. He thrashes against his bonds and glares at her, a terrible and feral expression on his face. "I've won this contest before! You can't break me!"

"Your majesty," Juliet says hesitantly, "It's General Juliet, I'm here to rescue you."

The king simply chuckles manically, "Mmmmahahaaaheheeeh… You can't trick me anymore. I know where I am. I will outlast you, and I will return to my family."

The Spire shakes from some unknown disturbance outside. Juliet leans against the wall. '*He thinks he's back on Beast Island.*'

“Your Majesty,” She begins again, but he cuts her off with a passionate, “No! I’m no King! I was never meant to lead. Glimmer… Glimmer needs me but… I can’t help her.”

“You are a great king.” Juliet says, unsure of how to help. She cautiously approaches him, but hesitates to unbind him, remembering his magical outburst the day before.

Micah finally looks at her, and his eyes widen. “Angella…” He says quietly. “Angella I- I’m sorry… I failed you. I couldn’t save you and now…” His expression changes. “No, wait! Don’t leave! I-...” He pauses as if listening to words Juliet can’t hear. Whatever he hears breaks him, and he simply buries his head in his hands.

Juliet walks up and kneels in front of him. Gently, she takes his cheeks in her hands and lifts his head to look at her. “No.” She says firmly. His eyes are glazed over and unfocused. “You are Micah, King of Bright Moon, leader of the Great Rebellion, greatest sorcerer of all time. You overcame Beast Island and Horde Prime, and you will not let Fygan destroy you.” She presses her forehead against his and hears his breathing regulate.

“Ahhhh… Juliet?” He says hoarsely. She pulls away with relief and stands up, pulling a knife to cut his bonds. “Thank you.” He says simply. She knows he wants to say more, but words are unnecessary right now.

She helps him to his feet, and both of them turn as a hidden door on the far side of the room opens. In steps Fygan, looking bedraggled and singed.

“Alright your Majesty, time to-” His eyes widen as he sees Micah and Juliet side by side, the former conjuring spell glyphs and the latter drawing her sword. He raises his hands in an attempted placating gesture, “Okay,” He says, “Let’s calm down for a second.”

A wave of energy fills the room as Glimmer and Castaspella teleport in. The appearance creates a blast of magic that Juliet

has never seen before, and Glimmer moans faintly and falls to her knees, clutching her head.

Castaspella conjures a large spell circle of her own and turns to Fygan. "Juliet," She says with deadly calm, "Be a darling and get Glimmer somewhere safe. We'll handle Fygan."

Juliet lifts the Queen into her arms, noting the many colors of swirling energy around her. She rushes towards the elevator.

Fygan shrugs his shoulders, "Two on one, and each of my opponents is stronger than me." He cracks his neck and summons a spell glyph in each hand. He breaks into an audacious grin. "I've beat worse odds."

Mermista

Every movement hurts in its own unique way. Her powers are fluctuating too much to consistently protect either herself or her people, so Mermista, despite being battered and burnt from the explosion, is rushing around Salineas trying to save people.

A massive tidal wave tears through a recently rebuilt neighborhood. Her attempt to turn it only creates a maelstrom of wind that blasts the wave apart, but causes damage of its own.

"UGGGGHHH!!" Mermista groans as the wind blows the roof off of her favorite ice cream shop.

"This!" She spins her trident around, "Is!" She slams it into the ground and calls upon her water powers, "The!" She raises a hand to the heavens, "WORRRRRST!!" With a colossal exertion of willpower, she causes the torrential downpour to halt in the air, and turn into an enormous dome that covers all of Salineas.

Mermista's own eyes widen as she sees the scope of her power. '*Dang. I really am that good.*'

Her success doesn't last long however. A wave of pain overcomes her, and she wavers. Screams alert her to the next threat, as a fissure opens in a neighborhood outside the sea gate, and geysers begin to spray boiling water into the air.

"Fine! I guess I'll fix that too!" Mermista yells, and starts to run over there.

Adora

Adora does not pause when Swift Wind comes to a clattering stop in Bright Moon's throne room. She doesn't miss a beat when she leaps off the alicorn's back and begins to stride through the halls. Chancellor Brannic, flanked by two guards, approaches her.

"Where's Entrapta?" Adora demands without stopping.

"The princess of Dryl is currently staying in the guest quarters with Hordak." He drawls. "No visitors are permitted."

That causes Adora to pause. "You're keeping them in prison??"

"For their own protection." The two guards cross their spears to block Adora's access to the hallway. "Besides, shouldn't you be saving the world?" As he says that, an unnaturally cold wind blasts through the halls of Bright Moon. The guard's cloaks and Adora's hair blow dramatically as Adora stares down the bureaucrat.

"I need to talk to Entrapta to find out how to stop this." Adora says, taking a step forward.

"Stop it? How do we know she's not a part of it?" Brannic responds.

Adora narrows her eyes. "She's not. Now move, or I'll move you."

The chancellor scoffs. "Is that a threat, She Ra?"

Adora lunges in and grabs his collar, lifting the large man several feet off the ground with one hand. The guards level their spears at her. "Yes." She snarls, and turns around, chucking the chancellor across the room. He tumbles head-over-heels to rest near Swift Wind's feet. The horse neighs threateningly, and Brannic pales.

Adora turns to the guards, who, after a momentary standoff, raise their spears and let her pass.

Adora lets She Ra drop as she runs through the halls of Bright Moon. Cracks are forming in the walls as the earth rumbles from the chaos happening outside. She would have completely missed Entrapta had the scientist not let out a cackle from the room she's in. Adora slams open the door and sees that Entrapta and Hordak are not, in fact, in the guest room, but instead both furiously working in Bow's lab.

Guess they broke out on their own.

"Entrapta!" Adora pants, "We need you!"

"Adora!" The pigtailed scientist grabs Adora with a tendril of hair and yanks her further into the room. "What is going on?? I have so many theories."

Adora grabs Entrapta's shoulders. "It's Fygan. He's using your research from the Black Garnet… He's done something to all of the Runestones, I think he's trying to destroy them!"

"OOOOHHHAA! That's incredibllllle!!" Entrapta squeals. She grabs a large spherical diorama and drags it over. It's a model of Etheria, with light bulbs representing the various runestones. "When I supercharged the Black Garnet, it sapped strength from the other Runestones." She pressed a few buttons, and one of the bulbs glows much brighter while the others all dim. "That imbalance created a global catastrophe. Fygan's devices are doing the same thing on a much larger scale. They're sapping energy from the Runestones they're attached to, and at the same time funneling

that energy into the Runestones, slowly destroying them." She presses another button, and all of the bulbs begin to flash, going very bright, then very dull. Entrapta pulls out a hammer and smashes one of them. The discharge of energy sets off a chain reaction that shatters all of the bulbs. "Once the Runestones are fully destroyed, there's no telling what's going to happen!!"

"How do we stop it??" Adora says desperately.

"You'll have to heal each Runestone, and you'll have to do it fast!" Entrapta says, a devious twinkle in her eyes. "You'll need your runestone of course." She adds matter-of-factly.

"M-my runestone?"

"The sword!" Entrapta shouts, "Well, what's left of it anyway."

Adora takes that in, and starts to back towards the door. Entrapta turns back to one of the screens. "Ohhh this is incredible. The planet is tearing itself apart! This is so much more destructive than my first test of the Runestones!!" She takes notice of Adora again, "Uh, I mean… hurry up and save the world?"

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Reckoning, Part 3

Chapter Summary

> In which the battle against Fygan rages, as his bots begin to overwhelm our heroes, and he has a showdown with Micah and Casta

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra lets Melog's shroud of invisibility fall over her before she leaps out of cover, weaving through a hail of green lasers to tackle and tear apart one of the bots on the outside of the horde. She then darts back and takes cover again. Rinse and Repeat for the past several minutes, but the waves of bots and drones just keep coming.

Her current retreat is covered by Bow popping up and shooting down two drones with one arrow. The Bright Moon Guards have taken up an offensive position, pushing against the Bots' left flank from behind a shield wall, keeping in close quarters to negate the bots' long range advantage. The three sorcerers of Mystacor are launching spell after spell, primarily to keep their allies covered, but also occasionally shocking a drone with lightning, or opening a tentacled void to swallow a bot whole (that particular move had earned some strange looks from the sorcerer's compatriots).

Catra pulls out her length of frayed rope and conjures her energy whip, lashing it upward and wrapping it around a drone. She spins around in a circle and slams the drone into another one, destroying both flying menaces in a fiery explosion.

"We can't keep this up much longer!" She shouts to Bow.

“I know!” Bow says, holding up his hand. His fingers are starting to bleed from the amount of times he’s fired his bow. He’s out of arrows, but Melog is hard at work using their telekinesis to retrieve intact ones from the battlefield.

Catra winces at that. “We need help!”

“From whom?” Bow shoots back, as he grabs an arrow from Melog’s magical grip and fires it, deploying a net to trap two bots together. Being the dunces that they are, the bots promptly shoot each other in their confusion.

His question is answered from within the Spire, as a massive mushroom cloud of sparkles, red lightning, and black smoke balloons out from the door, sending a dozen bots flying. ‘Did *Glimmer just… do Scorpia’s magic?*’ Through the breach, Glimmer and General Juliet emerge, both hacking and coughing from the thick smoke. Glimmer looks at Bow and grabs onto Juliet. Both women vanish in a cloud of sparkles before reappearing ten feet in the air above Catra and Bow.

“Bahhh!” Both Catra and Glimmer scream in unison. Bow catches Glimmer in his arms (*Because of course he does*) while Catra darts out from under Juliet, who crashes to the ground in an undignified heap.

“Are you okay??” Bow asks, checking over Glimmer’s body for injuries. She looks rather worse for wear.

“I’m alright.” She says, trying and only partially succeeding to keep her voice level and calm, “Whatever Fygan did is messing with my powers. Sometimes they aren’t working, sometimes they’re supercharged, and sometimes I kind of use other princesses’ powers.” Catra looks on the ground around where Bow set Glimmer down, and sees that plants are growing and blooming in a circle around her.

Catra shakes the shock of that off and grimaces as she ducks a laser bolt. “Well that’s great Sparkles, but we could use some

help.”

Juliet takes a look at the bot army. Glimmer had blasted apart the entrance, but more are steadily filtering out. The Bright Moon guards are pushed back by the sheer numbers. One of the sorcerers goes down from a drone blast to the shoulder. “This isn’t a fight we can win.” The general says, before ducking back down and looking to Catra, Bow, and Glimmer, “Any ideas?”

There’s a moment of silence before a high, reedy voice chirps, “I have one!”

Catra spins with a startled yelp, her fur standing on end, as a diminutive satyr in overalls and goggles emerges from a bush.

“What is it, Yanli?” Bow asks.

Yanli looks at the Spire. “If you can get me back into the Spire, I should be able to rig a shutdown signal that will take down all the bots and drones in one fell swoop.”

“It’s a death zone in there!” Catra protests, “And you’re kind of a shrimpy weakling.” Glimmer glares at her, prompting her to add, “No offense,” half-heartedly.

“That is true,” Yanli acknowledges, “I would need protection. And a pretty big distraction.”

“*I will provide the distraction.*” Catra hears Melog rumble from their hiding spot. “You sure?” She responds, and her face cracks into a wide grin as the shapeshifter explains their plan. Catra turns back to the group. “Alright.” She says, “Melog has a plan.”

Perfuma

A sudden sheet of rain lashes into Perfuma’s face, sending the princess stumbling backwards. She looks around desperately, blinking water out of her eyes. Scorpia has gotten most of the citizens of Plumeria loaded onto skiffs.

“Where are we goin’?” An older woman shouts over the sound of thunder and cracking earth.

Scorpia looks to Perfuma for an answer. Perfuma gropes around in her mind, trying to think. ‘*Nowhere on Etheria is safe right now… where* can *they go??’* She has an epiphany and calls, “The old Horde outpost! That should be safer than here!”

There’s a moment of hesitation, and a few people cast dark looks towards Scorpia, but an ear-piercing shriek cuts off any arguments against that. Everyone’s attention turns towards the treeline, where a massive beetle-like entity has crashed through the trees. Its eyes are red, and it’s pulsing with waves of unstable energy.

“GO!” Perfuma cries, waving a hand towards the villagers, “I’ll hold it off!”

There’s a brief moment where Perfuma locks eyes with Scorpia. In but an instant, a whole conversation plays out in their expressions.

“I’m coming to help.” Scorpia pleads, but Perfuma shakes her head, “*They need a leader. Keeping them safe is what matters most*.” Scorpia is pained, but resolves herself and nods.

“Let’s go people!” Scorpia shouts, and spurs her skiff forward. Everyone else follows in a line through the trees.

Perfuma turns towards the beetle Elemental and raises her hands. To her relief, she feels the magic respond to her commands even more than usual. A mass of plant matter rises beneath her like a tidal wave. She looms above the Elemental and shouts, “Please turn around! I don’t want to hurt you!”

The creature simply lets out a garbled shriek and charges forward, swinging scythe-like front appendages into Perfuma’s wall of plants. She responds by wrapping vines around the legs to hold it in place. She lifts it up into the air from its front legs, holding it close to her. She narrows her eyes to appraise it. ‘*Something’s*

clearly wrong with it. The damage to the Runestones must be affecting the Elementals too.' She leans back as she hears a warbling hum emanating from the creature. The cracks in its armor begin to glow and it lets out a chitter of pain.

Perfuma's eyes widen, and she turns around and leaps away as the creature explodes. Her plant mountain is blown apart and she goes sprawling to the ground. The Elemental's self destruct levels several nearby buildings, which begin to smoulder and spark with flames.

Perfuma groans and struggles to her feet. '*Put out the fires,*' is all that runs through her head, not paying attention to the fact that she has no clue how her plant magic would do that. She raises her hands and reaches into herself, calling upon her connection to the Heart Blossom, but there's something blocking her. The flames are growing by the second, turning into a roaring inferno, egged on by the hurricane-force winds and storm of lightning bolts raining down.

Perfuma closes her eyes, trying to force her way through the blockage. She can't, but she does feel a tug in another direction. She pushes down that path, and feels a connection. Magical energy washes over her, and her eyes snap open. She raises her arms up and back, then snaps them forward.

An enormous tsunami springs into existence in front of her. The wall of water surges forward and crashes into the inferno, dousing the flames and conjuring a plume of black smoke. The buildings are miraculously unharmed by the force of the wave.

Perfuma stands there for a moment, aghast at what she just did. '*That was Mermista's magic…*' She thinks in shock.

Perfuma turns towards the scorched husk of the Heart Blossom tree, and the terribly pulsating mass of the Runestone at its core. It hurts her soul to see it in such pain. She begins to rush over, determined to heal her home.

Fygan

Sorcerer duels are both exhilarating and terrifying. A two on one duel, where both enemy sorcerers are a good deal more powerful than you, leans much more towards the latter.

Fygan, surprisingly enough, is holding his own admirably. Though he has not landed a single hit on either of his opponents so far, he has also avoided any major attacks. Micah is actually the easier opponent. The King of Bright Moon may be the most powerful sorcerer alive, but he relies on simple, basic spells to a fault. And simple spells are simple to counter.

Castaspella is another story. Her array of spells is incredibly diverse, and for every spell that Fygan knows how to counter, there's another that he has to physically dodge.

But he does have that edge on his opponents. He is in better physical shape, and his agility is keeping him alive more than his magical prowess, and despite the blistering torrent of energy being slung against him, he's gaining ground.

Casta slams her glyph into the ground, and a rift of purple flame races towards Fygan. He raises a semi-real illusory wall to block it, but is struck in the side by a blast of fire Micah curved around the wall. He turns the roll into a somersault and stands up, springing out of a series of chains emerging from the ground to restrain him. Finally, he begins to counterattack. He conjures an illusory tidal wave that roars across the room towards them. Predictably, Micah and Casta raise protective glyphs. Fygan slams one hand into the ground and twists it. The floor underneath Micah suddenly spins rapidly, sending the king sprawling to the ground, disoriented. Fygan follows up with a lightning bolt against Casta, which shatters the sorceress's hastily drawn protection glyph and sends her hurtling backwards.

She reacts quickly though, casting a flying spell before hitting the ground and arcing around the room, launching several spells against Fygan. He counters a slow spell and dodges away from a

boulder that rises to crush him. He slashes through a net, and reaches to his belt. He smiles. She's right where he wants her.

Micah sends a gust of wind into his side that knocks Fygan off balance. He feels ropes wrap around his legs, and he hops desperately for a moment to regain his balance. An arcane hand appears and punches him in the gut, knocking the wind out of him and sending him airborne, where a section of the metal ceiling warps and tears into a sheet that slaps him in the back, knocking him face-down to the ground.

"Owwww…" He groans, stunned by the vicious combo.

"And so it ends." Comes the sound of Micah's gravelly voice. "This is what it was always going to come down to Fygan. You're not strong enough. You are *alone*."

Fygan is ready to give up, even after all he's sacrificed for this. Micah's right, he can't win this fight. He closes his eyes, and remembers why he's doing this. Who he's fighting for. "You're wrong. I am not alone. Light Spinner taught me cunning. Salene taught me defiance. But my tenacity?" Fygan meet's Micah's eyes, and sees a look of surprise and fear in them that he doesn't fully understand. Fygan grins like the maniac he is. "My tenacity is all me baby. And you don't stand a *chance*."

Fygan rolls to one side as Micah and Casta launch their spells at him. He opens an arcane gateway and dives through, emerging behind them. He fires a magic missile at Micah's back, then conjures three illusory duplicates of himself. All four duplicates scatter, dodging their opponent's counterattacks and launching identical spells. Fygan feels the effort of this spell rapidly draining him, but he can tell it's working. A blue rope wraps around Castaspella's leg and yanks it out from under her. Micah destroys two of the duplicates in a massive firestorm, then turns and brings up a wall of ice to block a spectral arrow.

Fygan wastes no time, refusing to let Micah capitalize on that success. He lets the final duplicate vanish, and opens another

doorway, leaping out above Micah and simply kicking the sorcerer in the back of the neck. Micah staggers forward as Fygan turns himself invisible and launches a ball of light into his face, blinding him.

Castaspella gets to her feet, but Fygan does not let up his blistering offensive, conjuring an illusory beast that leaps at the sorceress with a ferocious roar. She predictably raises a shield, and Fygan sends a counterspell spinning into the center of her ward, causing it to explode and send her flying back from the concussive blast.

Micah readies a fireball, but Fygan closes the distance. With one hand, he grabs Micah's wrist, sending the flame mote into the ceiling. With the other, he simply clocks the King of Bright Moon in the jaw before knocking him back with a kinetic blast.

Fygan falls to his knees as Micah and Casta hit the floor. His vision is blurry and he sees black spots. People aren't supposed to use that much magical energy at once, and he feels like he's lost years off his life.

He smiles in triumph, but even despite going all out, his opponents still have more fight in them. Casta leaps to her feet and summons a magical cuff around Fygan's wrist. He is lifted by the cuff and slammed into the ceiling before being tossed around the room like a ragdoll. The cuff shatters and he hits the floor hard. He desperately brings up a ward against Micah's firebolt, but the spell shatters, leaving him open to Micah's follow-up jet of water.

Steam obscures the room as Fygan is knocked against the back wall.

"It's over Fygan!" Castaspella declares as the two of them walk out of the fog cloud. "Surrender."

"Over?" Fygan chuckles, his voice ragged and hoarse. He struggles to his feet. "Mmhehea… I already told you princesses

once… As long as I’m breathing, it’s not over.” His opponents grimly prepare their spells. Fygan grins and whips his hand out from behind his back, sending a knife spinning towards Castaspella. The blade sinks into her robes and she shrieks in pain.

“Casta!!” Micah hits Fygan with a massive blast of condensed air before rushing to his sister’s side.

Fygan slams into the wall, but gets up quickly and rushes into the elevator, slamming his hand on the control to go down. Once the door is closed, he sinks into the floor, breathing heavily. Everything hurts...

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Reckoning, Part 4

Chapter Summary

> In which Etheria is crumbling, and our heroes are being overwhelmed by Fygan's boy army. General Juliet makes a stand.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Frosta

Frosta's kingdom is crumbling around her. The people have been evacuated from the Fractal Fortress as random spikes of temperature are causing the massive frozen structure to melt and shatter in places.

Frosta is in the main hall, ushering out the final battalion of guards and citizens.

"Hurry!" She shouts. A crack echoes through the hall above, and she reflexively reaches out with her magic and grasps the huge chunk of ice before it can crush the elderly couple beneath it. The pair gasps and shuffles forward. Frosta attempts to gently push the ice chunk away, but instead a surge of strange power courses through her body, and a Glimmer-like pink beam of magic streams out of her hands and shatters the ice chunk, sending a shower of shards into the crowd below, who immediately scream in terror and start trying to scatter.

"I'm sorry!" Frosta shouts. My powers are hurting my people… How can I stop this??

"Your Majesty, look out!!" The guard captain Anska shouts. Frosta's eyes widen as she looks down and sees the floor open up

to swallow her. She attempts to close the gap with her magic, but receives no response.

"WAHH!!" The teenager skids down into the ravine, desperately grabbing onto the edge. "Help!!" She cries. Frosta has never been one to ask for help. From a young age she's always been able and willing to take care of herself.

But now her powers have betrayed her, and she's never felt more scared.

Adora

Adora stands at the gateway of Bright Moon's throne room, the elements buffeting against her. She stares through the storm at the Moonstone tower. The top is alight with fire and magic, swirling like a colossal floral torch. A trio of red lightning flashes illuminates her main obstacle.

The bridge to the tower has been destroyed, smote by lightning or wind, and curled around the base of the massive pillar is an enormous purple and pink worm with a cycloptic blue eye.

The Bright Moon Guardian. Adora faced it before, but that was with Bow and Glimmer at her side, and it was only subdued by Glimmer completing the quest. Something about the devastation being caused by Fygan's actions has awoken it, and now, Adora is going to have to face it alone.

A huff and a stamp of a hoof beside her reminds her that no, she won't be alone. Adora lays a hand on Swift Wind's neck for a moment, then raises it to the sky. The past two days have been the most physically and emotionally draining of her life, but there is power within her yet. Power enough to fight, "For the Honor… of Grayskull!!!"

Bow

The sky splits open, the clouds parting to reveal a shaft of beaming light streaming down from the heavens. The bots turn their heads upward, and the drones assume a defensive semicircle around the breach.

The whinny of a horse echoes through the clearing. Even Bow is enraptured by the display as She Ra and Swift Wind descend towards the bots.

"Yanli, Juliet!" Catra hisses, "*Now!*"

The storm of green lasers changes direction. She Ra raises a massive wall of multicolored light that seems to absorb the bots' barrage. Their window is now.

Juliet leaps out of cover, staying low to the ground. Catra darts out alongside her, an orange energy whip curled in her hand. Yanli scurries behind them, hiding behind a shield borrowed from one of the guards. Bow pops up from cover and fires a series of shots into the side of the bot army. The sorcerers send a volley of spells into the same area. Glimmer pops up to launch a blast of magic, but instead sends a puff of misty water into a drone, which does not seem too perturbed.

Catra and Juliet dive into the breach in their ranks, tearing the bots apart with sword and claw. Slowly, the horde is catching onto the ruse. One by one, bots and drones are turning their attention back to their foes on the ground as She Ra abstains from any attacks.

"Go!" Bow shouts out, "They're onto us!"

Juliet skids between the legs of a bot in front of her, bisecting it with her sword and clearing a small path into the hallway. She grabs Yanli, and the techmaster and general both disappear into the Spire.

Catra tears out a bot's eye crystal, then darts back to cover. Just before she can get to safety, a drone's beam glances across her

back. She shrieks in pain and dives to the ground behind the boulder.

"Catra!" Bow ducks down and looks at the long burnt gash across her shoulder blades. "I think I can help," He says, "Just… hold still." He reaches to his back pouch and pulls out a small vial of golden ichor, his spell component for healing.

"Bow, let me-" Glimmer starts to say, but she stops as a wave of red and green energy tears through her body, leaving her gasping in pain. '*We need to stop this quickly, before it kills her!*'

"Bow!" One of the spellcasters shouts, "We need covering fire!"

Bow doesn't even have time to acknowledge that request before one of the Bright Moon guards takes a laser blast full in the chest and goes sprawling with a groan. The wounded now outnumber those in fighting shape. '*We're not going to win this…*' Bow desperately pours every ounce of his meagre magical talent into Catra's back. '*Come on… come onnn…*' He's never healed a wound even close to this big before, but, to his surprise, he feels a massive surge of magic that nearly bowls him over. The wound closes over and scars in an instant, and Catra twists her head to look at him with confusion.

"How did you-" She begins, but she cuts herself off as Bow suddenly feels a massive rush to his head, and collapses to the ground.

Catra

"Bow!" Catra grabs the archer, who has passed out from the massive exertion of his unexpectedly powerful healing magic. She drags him back and leans him against a tree to recover before dashing back to the rock. The storm of green lasers is tearing their cover apart. '*We've only got seconds before this thing is gone.'*

“Captain!” Catra barks to the red skinned minotaur, “Retreat into the woods!”

Glimmer struggles to her feet. “Sorcerers, move the wounded back!” She commands. The two remaining sorcerers nod. One of them brings up a magical shield just behind the boulder, bracing for it’s fall. The other starts using telekinesis to move the wounded Bright Moon guards and Sorcerers back into the woods.

“Catra, Revina,” Glimmer says, “Let’s cover them.”

As if to punctuate that sentence, the boulder finally explodes from the nonstop rain of plasma.

“Go!” Glimmer shouts, and the three of them dive into action. Glimmer falls back on her spells, which seem more reliable than her princess magic at the moment. A gout of fire quickly gives way to a series of vines that entangle a whole company of bots, before a wave of lightning tears through and incapacitates them. The princess teleports away from a volley of return fire.

Revina simply bullrushes in, easily outpacing even Catra in orden to impale two bots at once on her horns. She then lifts her head up and tosses the bots into a rank of their comrades, taking out a total of six enemies in a single maneuver. She then swings the battleaxe off of her back and starts hacking and slashing through the tin soldiers.

Catra smirks. ‘*Half for them. Half for me.*’ She leaps straight upward as they turn their guns towards her. A blast of wind slams into her back, unexpectedly (but fortuitously) sending her straight into the heart of the bot horde. Still airborne, she lashes her whip around a drone and swings around, kicking a half dozen bots in the face as she goes. She lets go and hits the ground running, grappling onto a bot and swinging it around, using it as a shield against its fellows before kicking it into them. She spins around and roundhouse kicks another bot, sending it backpedaling.

Catra takes a look around the battlefield. For every bot they put down, another one either gets back up or comes out of the spire. Catra in particular is having a hard time dealing enough damage to put them out of commission permanently, and she knows she can't win a war of attrition like this.

'Alright then. Let's mix things up.' Catra reaches to her spell pouch and pulls out her newest component: a scorched twig. She crushes it into ash in one hand, which begins to crackle with electricity. She smacks her fist against her open palm, causing both hands to spark and fizz with arcs of lightning. Catra looks at the bot nearest her and gives it a "come at me" gesture. The bot lunges forward with its spike arm, trying to slash through her, but Catra's already gone, tearing through the bots with her newly electrified strikes.

Adora

Adora leaps over the Guardian's tail strike and rolls to her feet, slashing its side with her sword. The beast bellows and opens its mouth. The eye glows blue as it fires a beam of purple light at her. Her sword flashes into a shield and she tanks the blow, but it sends her skidding backward.

Swift Wind dives down and kicks the Guardian in the head, but the creature has finally caught on. As the alicorn attempts to swoop away, the worm's tail snaps up, striking Swift Wind hard in the side.

"Swifty!!" Adora screams. She feels an echo of the strike through their sacred bond as the horse goes down like a ton of bricks. "No!" Adora charges forward, slicing wildly into the beast's thick hide. A pulse of magical energy radiates from her raging form.

The Bright Moon Guardian roars and turns to her, lunging forward with its toothy maw. Adora rolls out of the way and stands up. The creature raises its tail to strike the prone Swift Wind, forcing Adora to leap across the field and shoulder slam the strike off course.

Adora grasps the hilt of her sword with both hands and stands over her steed, staring down the massive creature before her.

Catra

Catra destroys nearly two dozen bots before she slips up. She leaps on the ground and feels her foot connect with a fallen robot husk. Its chassis collapses, and her foot falls in, the jagged metal tearing the skin of her ankle. She yowls in pain and falls to one knee, desperately trying to extricate herself.

The others also begin to fall. The remaining sorcerers and guards are barely holding against the onslaught from the drones. Bow seems to be back up, but is out of arrows, and is just clubbing any foes that get close to the wounded. Catra feels her empathic bond tug her attention towards Melog, who is desperately trying to tear through the bots to get to her. Catra reaches out a hand, and watches in horror as the shapeshifter takes two shots to the side and skids to a halt, their mane flickering. "MELOG!" Catra screams, tearing her foot out of the bot and limping over to the wounded alien. She slashes down a drone hovering over them and turns, standing protectively over her friend.

Revina lifts a bot over her head, but the move leaves her open to three shots to the torso. She staggers backward, using her remaining strength to hurl the bot into the three that shot her. Two more blasts slam into her side, and she topples to the ground. Catra can't tell if she's alive or dead.

Glimmer is surrounded, blasting the encroaching bots with spell after spell, but they just keep coming. Catra sees Glimmer attempting to teleport away, only for the magic to sputter and fail. The princess finally succeeds, but the effort knocks her out, and she tumbles to the ground at Bow's feet.

Catra tears her eyes away from her friends' plight, and looks ahead of her. The bots are regrouping into a semicircle in front of her, their arms raised like a firing squad.

'Now would be a very good time Yanli.' Catra thinks, but at the same time, a quieter voice in her head says, '*They failed. We failed. This is how it ends*.'

Catra closes her eyes and conjures her energy whip. It crackles with electricity from her still active lightning spell, and she stares down her enemies. Catra digs her heels into the muddy ground and makes her stand there, at the edge of the Whispering Woods, ready to lay down her life to protect Melog.

Juliet

Juliet's heart is pounding. They've gotten into the heart of the Spire, and Yanli is working furiously at the controls, but the bots are still being deployed around them. Juliet has destroyed dozens of them, but they just keep coming. The pair are huddled against the console, turtled up behind a makeshift barrier of destroyed bots and their shields.

Juliet has torn off one of the bot's laser arms and is using it as a rifle to hold their enemies back.

"Gah!" Yanli yelps as a laser blast singes their fingers, "I can't do it! I can't finish this with them firing at me! I need more time!!"

"Hurry up!" Juliet shouts back, popping out and slicing another bot in half at the midsection, then impaling its still-active top half when it tries to grab her. "I don't think the distraction worked!" She notes as bots begin to march in from the corridor leading outside.

"Ahhhh! I'm tryinnnnng…" Yanli says. Another laser blast pierces through their blockade, this one singes a hole in the satyr's left ear. Yanli lets out a terrible cry of pain and collapses to the floor, scooting under the console and whimpering, "I can't… I'm sorry… I'm sorry." Juliet sees tears running down their face and feels a sudden pang of guilt.

'I brought them into this. They're not a soldier and I brought them into a warzone.' Juliet snaps herself out of it and looks out into the encroaching battalion of bots.

"How much time do you need?"

"Wha?"

"I'll do what I can," Juliet says grimly, "Get that signal up and *end this*!"

Yanli watches in horror as Juliet leaps out from cover, firing the arm cannon into the oncoming ranks of bots. She grabs the shield from behind her and advances. Lasers tear through the air around her and slam into the shield. She closes the gap and begins to tear through the bots. She darts forward, not bothering to cover herself from behind. She jams the pointed end of her shield into a bot's chest and lets it go.

The first laser blast hits her in the thigh. She keeps fighting. The bots have turned to face the bigger threat, ignoring Yanli. Juliet swings her sword around, shearing through another bot. A second blast strikes her hand, and she screams in pain as the sword spins away from her.

The general grits her teeth and swings her fist into a bot's faceplate, cracking it. She's pushed out of the spire and is in the yard now. She can see Catra surrounded by bots, and most of her soldiers downed. Queen Glimmer is on the ground, with Bow desperately trying to defend her.

Juliet grabs a bot's disembodied leg from the ground and uses it as a club, swinging against the horde with wild abandon. She can barely see Yanli working furiously inside the Spire. Two laser blasts hit her in the torso. The heat and pain is growing unbearable, but Juliet keeps fighting. The bot leg falls apart in her hands, and one of the automatons steps forward, striking her in the abdomen with a pointed fist. She staggers backward, and a shot slams into her knee. Her vision blurs as she collapses. She

looks through the ranks of bots into the heart of the Spire, where Yanli uses their hard-won time.

An inferno of white-hot fire sears into the back of her neck, and everything goes black.

Catra

Catra watches in horror as General Juliet goes down. Her body goes numb and noise fades into the background. She can hear Bow cry the guard's name. She turns her head to face down the squad of bots pointing their cannons at her and relaxes her posture.

She's been in near-death situations before, quite a few times, even. She's never felt so… calm about it though.

Adora

The Bright Moon Guardian gives a bellow of pain and slumps to the ground, defeated. Adora leaps onto Swift Wind's back and wastes no time in flying up to the Moonstone.

The steed comes to a stop in the air even with the Moonstone's base. Adora can see the series of strange crystalline devices, all pouring energy into the Moonstone and draining it at the same time. She revs up her sword and sends a blast of magic into them. At once, all of the devices shatter, sending out a series of shockwaves. Swift Wind dives in and lands on the platform beneath the Moonstone. Adora leaps off and hops onto the low dais directly under the Runestone.

She reaches to her side and draws the shattered hilt of the Sword of Protection. She readies to raise it, to use it to heal the Runestone and start to end this, but she stops short when she sees her reflection in the blade.

Staring back at her is She Ra. But not *her* She Ra. The hair is loose. The mask is replaced by a tiara. Her armor is simpler.

Staring back at her is the Sword of Protection's She Ra, looking almost disappointed.

Adora stares at it for a moment before her fingers tighten on the hilt. "You don't control me anymore." She says through gritted teeth. She raises the sword above her head, and touches the jagged tip to the Moon Stone.

Glimmer

Glimmer snaps back to consciousness, feeling a surge of power throughout her form unlike anything she's ever felt. She rises to her feet, almost gliding through the air. She summons her magic, and feels it come at her call with no trouble. The army of bots all turn to her, immediately sensing the greater threat.

A pair of spectral, angelic wings flash into being on Glimmer's back, and she rises into the air. A wave of sparkling magic enervates before her, moving through the ground and into each of the bots, causing them all to seize and stop before they can fire on her. At that moment, a wave of noise emanates from the Spire, and every bot and drone on the battlefield begins to spark and fizz with green lightning before folding and crashing to the ground.

Glimmer is almost disappointed by this development. She'd been looking forward to annihilating the entire army by herself. But any feelings on that subject are wiped from her mind when she sees the prone, faintly smoking body slumped outside the Spire's gate.

'General Juliet!' Glimmer feels her wings respond to her command as she swoops through the air, heedless of Bow and Catra's awestruck stares. She lands over the prone form and knees, gently turning the General's body over.

Everyone else rushes to her side. Juliet is covered in scorch marks from the bots' lasers. Her eyes are closed and her body is limp as Glimmer gently lifts it onto her lap.

“Juliet?” She says softly, putting a hand on the general’s cheek. “We did it.”

There’s no response. Catra kneels in front of Glimmer and places a hand on the general’s breast, searching for a heartbeat or signs of breath. The feline meets Glimmer’s tear-filled eyes with a grim, almost lost expression and slowly shakes her head.

Glimmer feels the tears stream down her face. She lifts Juliet to her chest and buries her face in the General’s hair. She feels the surge of energy fade from her. The wings that echoed her mother begin to dissipate into a cloud of sparks that drift away on the breeze.

The two Bright Moon guards still standing slowly remove their helmets and bow their heads.

There’s a long moment of silence that is finally broken by the sound of tentative hoofsteps leaving the Spire. Glimmer looks up, and Catra turns around to see Yanli nervously walking out, clutching their tracker pad to their chest.

“D-did it work?” They ask. Their eyes alight on the tableau in front of them, and their eyes widen. They gasp, and their hands go limp. The tracker pad falls to the ground and shatters.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, hope you enjoyed. Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Reckoning, Part 5: Requiem for a Changeling

Chapter Summary

> In which Catra confronts Fygan and learns why he's done all this, and the story comes to a close.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

The silence is overwhelming. Even though the apocalypse rages around them, Catra, Bow, Glimmer, and the others gathered around Juliet's still form are in their own world right now.

Catra is lost. She's never had to confront this feeling. Shadow Weaver was so much more complex but Juliet… she laid down her life to save them. No hesitation, no ulterior motive, just real heroism. *Why? It doesn't make sense*.

Despite being lost in thought, Catra is the first one to break out of the reverie, because she feels an alert in her head from Melog. She turns to look at the still-wounded Krytian, who has gotten to their feet and seems to have healed somewhat. Melog is staring towards the Whispering Woods. Following their gaze, Catra sees a strange disturbance. Foliage is moving aside against the wind, as if being pushed. A scent carries from that spot towards both felines, and Melog and Catra sense it at once.

A smell that is burned into their memories forever. The man who nearly killed them.

"Fygan."

Bow and Glimmer look at Catra, but she's already bolted towards the Woods after the shapeshifter.

Catra sees Fygan for a moment as his invisibility spell drops. He looks over his shoulder and his eyes widen as he sees Catra racing towards him, Melog hot on her heels. He turns around, and the chase is on.

Fygan moves unexpectedly quickly, weaving between trees and moving through underbrush with ease. *'Must have some sort of magic making him faster*,' Catra thinks.

The effects of the end of the world are no less present in the Whispering Woods. Catra transitions from running to sliding frantically under a falling tree. Melog leaps over the trunk once it crashes to the ground. Fygan vanishes from sight for a moment, but reappears after a moment, flailing his arms around to remove the cloud of insects around him. Catra gains ground, curving around to avoid the ruined hive Fygan had smashed through.

The illusionist conjures a burst of fire to scare the insects away, and peeks over his shoulder to Catra. Her teeth flash in the mottled light as she bears down on him, claws out. Fygan grimaces and turns. He grabs onto a branch and yanks it forward before letting it crack back in an attempt to hit Catra. She cuts through it without losing momentum.

A bolt of red lightning crashes down beside Catra, causing a massive explosion of concussive force that knocks her to the ground. She staggers to her feet and keeps running. The ground is cracking and breaking beneath her as earthquakes ravage Etheria. She tries to ignore the fragment of her mind that strays into memory.

A memory of another time she was in the Whispering Woods with the world crumbling around her.

She vaults over a boulder. “Where is he??” She mutters through clenched teeth. She feels a force in her mind point in the right direction, and catches a glimpse of the tattered red vest and green skin of her quarry. “Thanks Melog.” She picks up the pace.

A blast of light suddenly explodes around her when she rushes between two trees. The light is accompanied by a loud squealing sound that pierces into her ears. She shouts in pain and bumbles forward, face first into a tree. She spins out and tumbles down a small cliff, landing in a bramble patch at the bottom. Yowling in pain, she tears her way free and looks around, unable to blink the light out of her eyes.

"Hurry Catra," Melog says in her mind, their voice urgent. "*He is escaping*."

"I can't see!!" She cries, more than a little frightened by the experience.

"*I will be your eyes. Trust me.*"

For a moment, Catra thinks back to what Granamyr told her. About how the mental link was an evolutionary weapon designed to drive targets insane, to lure them into traps. But that moment is short. "Alright." Catra says, and begins to sprint again, despite only being able to see vague outlines.

"Right." Melog directs. Catra banks right, sticking out her left arm to scrape off of a tree trunk.

"*Jump. Then Left*." Catra leaps, feeling a rush of displaced air beneath her as she sails over a sinkhole. She lands and immediately veers to the left. Her vision is slowly returning, and she sees the large gray blob she avoided.

"Climb five paces, then leap to vine." Melog says. Catra tenses. This direction is more complex. She crouches and moves forward on all fours, clawing her way up a long fallen tree. At the top, she springs forward, arms flailing in front of her. She grabs onto the vine and swings forward, letting go and rolling to the ground. Her vision is mostly clear now, and she sees movement ahead. "*We've caught up.*" Melog confirms. Catra looks over her shoulder and sees the Krytian rushing behind her. Through the empathetic link,

she can feel the pain of the partially healed burns on their side slowing them down, but they still keep pace with her.

"Let's end this." She growls, and sprints forward.

They've covered a lot of ground, though there's no telling where exactly they are due to the Whispering Woods' shifting terrain.

Fygan's voice echoes unnaturally loud, overcoming the sound of snapping twigs and shifting earth. "We're almost there!" He pants, "Getting tired yet?"

"Sounds like you are!" Catra shouts, not breaking her stride.

"I'm just getting warmed up. Got a whole show prepared for you! And the stage is nearly set!"

'Is drama just an inherent trait of shapeshifters??' Catra pushes forward, slashing through a wall of vines and leaping over a haphazardly placed glowing rune trap. She springs over a low, thin sheet of rock sticking out of the ground and darts forward. A wall looms ahead of her and she dives through a square hole in it, somersaulting into a kneeling pose and leaping onto a spherical boulder ahead to scan the surroundings.

Finally, her pace slows as she takes in the area. The thin rocks sticking up at odd, jagged angles aren't just a unique formation. They're ruins. She looks around at the long-destroyed clay buildings. The rock she's on isn't a rock, but an abandoned home. She stands up, forgetting her mission for a moment and looking around at the destroyed village around her. Torn clothing caked with mud lies on the ground. Jagged rocks and stakes of wood stick out of the spongy earth at odd angles. Scorch marks cover the stone, and beneath the years of grime, the symbol of the Horde is unmistakable, branded onto the side of one of the buildings.

"Is this your big show??" She shouts, trying to sound unaffected, "Showing me some random village? What, am I supposed to feel guilty?"

“Ha!” Fygan laughs, his voice hollow and filled with fury. Catra slides down the side of the building and starts stalking through the empty streets, hoping to spot her foe through the rain. “I don’t know why I thought you’d recognize it. Looks just like every other town you destroyed, doesn’t it?”

“Mmmm… Pretty much!” Catra taunts, hoping to draw him out.

No such luck. “Oh but this one’s *special*. Let me jog your memory.”

Catra tenses and whips her head around as the scenery changes around her. The ruins are reconstructed into intact spherical huts. The ground is recolored green as if grass had regrown. Milling about are shadowy humanoid figures; running, playing, dancing. *A party*.

Catra stalks forward carefully. She can still feel the wild winds and rains of the ongoing calamity, but the sky above her looks blue. The party is picking up around her as she paces forward.

Melog sticks close to her. She can sense their panic and confusion. *‘They must not deal with Etherian illusions very well.’*

Catra turns up her nose as Fygan begins narrating, his voice echoing through the haze of the illusion. “This was once a peaceful town, you know. Just like the rest of the towns you destroyed.”

“You sound like a broken record.” Catra shouts, trying not to show how deeply she’s affected by this. She’s walking through the ghost of a town she once destroyed. It’s… not a pleasant experience. A piece of her mind flashes back to Tenfields, to that horrible day; the fleeing soldier, the orange flower, the blood on her hands…

How many more ghosts from my past are waiting for me?

Fygan breaks from his narration to speak directly to Catra. “You know, despite how much I hate you, I can’t help but feel… a connection to you Catra.”

“You and I are *nothing* alike.” Catra hisses, her hackles raise at the mere notion of being compared to this psychopath.

“Oh?” Fygan replies, “We’re both willing to destroy anyone and anything for the sake of getting what we want. That’s what I *admire* about you Catra. You understand that sometimes, in order to build something new… you have to break the old.”

“No.” Catra disagrees, “That was the old me. The new me thinks that no one *has* to break anything.”

Fygan scoffs. “Clearly you’ve never made an omelette. And besides. Didn’t the ‘old you’ have to be broken to make way for the ‘new you’? You’re living proof of my point!”

Catra rounds a corner, ready to summon her whip if she sees Fygan, but she only sees more illusory partiers. “You’re wrong. And I don’t know what an omelette is.” She says coolly, ignoring his actual point. “Anyway, I’m a little pressed for time,” she adds, the tension in her voice belying the attempted casual tone, “So could you skip to the big reveal?”

“Heehhh!” Fygan snarls. *‘Good. At least I can get on his nerves. Might make him slip up.’* Catra ducks against a building and peeks around a corner to see a group of shadowy children watching a puppet show. “Fine.” Fygan says at last, “This was my home. For a time.”

“I thought you were a sorcerer.” Catra calls out, curiosity getting the better of her.

“Yes, but I left Mystacor to join the first Princess Alliance. And when that failed, I retired. Came here and started a new life.” Catra turns to one side to see a small group of individuals who aren’t hazy like the others.

One is tall and slender, with green skin and pale hair tied back in a ponytail behind his head. Despite his reptilian eyes and sharp teeth, there’s a warmth in his smile as he looks down to the child

in front of him. His appearance is slightly changed, but Catra recognizes a somewhat younger, pre-insanity Fygan.

Beside him is a shorter figure, a female satyr in a billowing blue gown that falls off one shoulder and has slits open on the sides of the legs. She's relaxed, leaning against past-Fygan's side, but there's a strange, excitement in her posture, as if any moment she's going to start dancing or burst into song.

The pair is watching the third clear figure in front of them: a child. The small one has a union of the parent's features, though she heavily favors the mother, bearing only a hint of her father's green skin and his long pointed ears. She has a stick clutched in both hands and is play-fighting with another child, this one foggy and indistinct.

'Fygan had a family?'

"What? At a loss for words?" Fygan says aggressively, "Cat got your tongue?" Catra simply stares at the scene in front of her. "I think you know where this is going." Fygan says grimly.

Catra hears an explosion, and feels the earth rumble. Whether it's part of the illusion or simply a well-timed product of the cataclysm going on around them, she cannot tell. The family looks over, and Catra follows their gaze to where a plume of smoke is rising on the edge of town. People are running away, knocking over decorations and stands. Catra sees them rushing into houses and emerging with precious belongings.

Past-Fygan turns to his partner and speaks, the voice warbling and echo-y. "Salene! Take Phaedra and get to the cellar."

The woman reaches up and places her hand on his cheek. "What about you??"

Past-Fygan looks grim. He places his hand on top of hers and pulls it down to kiss her palm. "I'm going to do what I can." A rumble interrupts his partner's protest, and Catra sees one of the houses nearby collapse. A dark shape bulldozes through the rubble,

clearly recognizable as a Horde tank. “Go!” Past-Fygan shouts, turning towards the tank, his hands glowing with arcane energy.

“I love you!” The woman says before scooping up their child and rushing towards the house.

Past-Fygan is readying a spell at the tank, which hasn’t noticed him, when another crash interrupts him. He turns over his shoulder and his eyes widen in horror as he watches another tank smash through the hut his wife and child just ran into.

He lets out a scream, filled with rage and terror and despair. A kind of hollow, desperate, animalistic sound that conveys pain in a way no author could ever replicate. He raises his hands to crush the tank with magic, but a dark shape swoops behind him. A horde skiff passes by, and one of the soldiers hits Fygan with a stun baton, sending the sorcerer to the ground.

Catra stays there for a moment, completely at a loss. Fygan’s voice comes echoing through the air once more. “Are you starting to put the pieces together?”

“They’re gone, aren’t they?” Catra asks quietly.

There’s a long pause before Fygan responds, his voice hollow, “Of course they are. Turn around, or you might miss the main event.”

Catra turns to look at the first tank, the one that had distracted Fygan in the crucial moment before his family went into their home. She pads forward, almost forgetting about what’s going on in the real world, so drawn into this illusion is she. Looking over her shoulder, she sees Past-Fygan starting to come to behind her.

She follows the tank to the smoking ruins of the town square, where the Horde forces are gathered, surrounding what she assumes to be the town’s last fighters. She can’t make out any details through the smoke and illusory haze. She steps into a gap between a chunk of rubble and a tank to get a better view, but before she can make out any further details, a blinding light radiates from one end of the battlefield. She hisses and raises a

hand as the beacon comes closer. She lowers her arm, and when she sees the source, her heart stops.

A towering woman strides through the Horde ranks, glowing like a goddess. Blonde hair and red cape billow majestically behind her, and a massive blue sword is held in one hand. She walks up beside the last fighters - a single archer and a horse, and looks out towards the Horde ranks. She raises her sword, flips her grip, and drives the point into the ground.

The earth shatters, and waves of yellow lightning rip through the Horde's technology. Their forces scatter. Soldiers flee for their lives to avoid the wrath of this vengeful spirit.

Catra walks towards the illusory form of She Ra, and watches as she suddenly grasps her head and staggers, fading in an instant into Adora, who slumps to the ground. Catra stands over the image of her partner, so young and inexperienced here, and turns to follow her gaze, knowing what she will see.

Catra looks through the haze of smoke and sparks to see herself, eyes wide with disbelief at seeing what Adora just did, what she just became. "Catra…" Adora says, the illusory voice vague and hollow. Catra looks at her younger self, and against all logic, mentally pleads, *'Go with her. Don't walk away, just stay with her!'*

But history doesn't bend to her whim. The confused girl before her sets her brow darkly, and backs away into the darkness and smoke.

As her form vanishes, the illusion dissipates. Adora vanishes. The smoke and flames dissipate to reveal the rain and wind of the current devastation. Catra looks to the silhouette of where her younger self vanished, and sees her visage melt, revealing another broken individual standing in the same spot.

Fygan is ragged, his clothing tattered and filthy. His eyes are hollow, and Catra can see tear tracks running through the grime

on his face. He's breathing heavily, his whole torso heaving with each ragged inhale and exhale.

Catra meets his gaze, taking a step to the side to stand where Adora once was. "This was Thaymor. This was… where it all started."

Fygan nods. "So now you understand why you need to *die*."

Catra looks at the person facing her. The man who nearly killed her and Adora, who now threatens the entire planet. She sees the years of torment he's gone through. She sees how broken he is, how his pain runs so very deep - and she understands him. She opens her mouth, and says something she never in her life thought she could say to someone she truly hated as much as she hates Fygan.

She simply says, "I'm sorry."

Fygan growls and narrows his eyes, taking a step forward and conjuring two spell glyphs. "I'm so tired of hearing that. *Sorry.*" He breathes, "Doesn't. Change. Anything."

"I know." Catra responds, "But I'm still sorry. You… were on one side of the war and… we were on the other. I thought I was doing the right thing but I was wrong. You're right to hate me." Fygan hesitates for a moment. "But this?" Catra waves an arm in the air, gesturing to the ongoing apocalypse, "Why this?"

"Mmmhahah!" Fygan chuckles, his head lolling to one side and his face cracking into a demented grin, "Oh I've got so much baggage Catra. You just witnessed but a single vignette out of a lifetime of pain."

Catra lets out a huff through her nostrils and nods knowingly, "You've had a terrible life and now you're destroying the world about it. I've been there."

"SHUT UP!" Fygan screams suddenly, "You and I are *nothing* alike!" Catra raises an eyebrow and smirks, and silently revels in

watching Fygan realize what he just said.

“We’re a lot alike.” Catra says, her voice level, “We’ve both weathered the absolute worst life can throw at us, and been broken by it. We’re both strong because of what we’ve gone through, but we know that nothing we do can change it. So we lash out and change what we can. We don’t have anyone who cares about us, so we make everyone fear us.”

“Enough.” Fygan mutters, magic sparking in his hands, “I know where you’re going with this, and while I appreciate the gesture, my answer is no. I’m not changing anymore. This is where I stand. This is the end of my story, for better or for worse. Nothing you say is going to change that.”

Catra looks into his eyes for a long moment, then sighs. “Adora would keep trying. But I’m not Adora.” She conjures her magical whip and takes a fighting stance. Melog growls beside her. “Okay.” She says, “Let’s do this.”

Fygan cracks his neck and raises a hand, summoning a spell circle around it and pushing his fingers through to make a “come at me” gesture.

Catra darts forward diagonally, swinging her whip in a sideways arc towards Fygan. The sorcerer ducks and leaps back. Catra hops onto the ruined remnants of a building for half a second before Fygan sends a jet of water towards her. She dives out of the way with a screech, rolling to the ground and springing to her feet, barely keeping her footing in the mud.

“Aren’t we supposed to be fighting?” Fygan calls. Catra looks beneath her and sees a rune glowing in the muck. She leaps away as it explodes in a shower of green sparks. She takes cover in another old hut and peeks through a crack towards Fygan. *‘Almost… there!’*

“No!” She shouts back, “I’m just the distraction!” She springs up and, while midair, swings her whip towards her opponent. At the

same time, Melog appears out of thin air behind Fygan, paws out, ready to tackle the shapeshifter.

Both Melog and the whip pass through Fygan's body. Melog yowls and skids to a stop before spinning around and swiping their claws sideways through Fygan's chest. Once more, they pass through harmlessly. Fygan turns towards Catra, dropping his fighting stance. He shrugs.

"Sorry Catra. You're not the only one who was stalling."

Fygan

The jig is up. The moment his illusion is revealed, Fygan is running. He has no idea if Catra will be able to track him, and he doesn't particularly care.

Everything hurts… His entire body is a mixture of sore and numb. The continued strain of sprinting and leaping through the Whispering Woods makes his legs feel like they're on fire, and the amount of magical energy he's expended makes him feel like his insides are a void.

He begins to slow his pace, looking over his shoulder carefully to see if he's been pursued. Catra is nowhere to be seen. Fygan exhales and rests for a moment, looking up at the sky through a gap in the trees.

He cocks his head to one side. *'Something's not right…'* The wind isn't as vicious, and everything is becoming more… normal. The haze in the air has thinned, and lightning is getting less frequent.

"No…" Fygan mutters in disbelief. He looks in front of him and begins to rush forward, looking around desperately for a clearing. He pushes through a sheet of vines and steps forward onto thin air. His arms wheel around desperately as he tumbles and skids down a cliff, coming to a stop at the bottom. He struggles to his feet, though his legs scream in protest.

Getting his bearings, he barely registers the large polygonal crystalline structure in front of him. Instead, he looks into the sky, and towards the woods and earth around him.

'No rumbles… the animals are calming down… Etheria… it's… it's…' "It's healing." Fygan growls. "She Ra found some way to save the day." *'It was all for nothing.'*

"Are you surprised?" Catra calls out, her voice booming from the ridgeline above him.

'Of course she found me.' Fygan's head falls back, and he takes a step backwards. A sigh escapes his lips, that slowly turns into a wry, ragged chuckle. "Not really." He admits. Fygan turns and takes a few steps towards the crystalline structure in the center of the clearing, which he now acknowledges as a First Ones ruin. He grunts slightly as he takes a seat on a large rock. He finally looks up towards the voice, meeting Catra's gaze.

The feline strikes an imposing figure, standing on an outcropping of rock looking down at him, her heterochromatic eyes glowing in the darkness of the storm. A flash of red lightning crackles behind her, further framing her half-grown mane of hair. She's panting, and her claws are extended, but she sheathes them as Fygan sits. She hesitates for a moment before hopping from rock, to root, to rock, to ground and standing up in front of Fygan. Fygan looks up at her, and both of them gaze at each other for a long moment. Fygan reads so many emotions on the cat's face. Hatred, anger, disgust, fear, and fury in spades, but also sadness, sympathy, even pity.

'She sees me for what I am. A hollow shell of a man who just realized that he failed.'

"How do you want this to go down?" Fygan asks. "I'm willing to fight, and though I don't think I'd win, I'd give you some trouble at least."

Catra shakes her head and squats down so that she's now the one looking up at Fygan. "I don't know." She says, a touch of amusement in her voice, "I've been going even longer than you without a break, and my hands are cut up from fighting those bots. You've got a better chance than you may think."

Fygan snorts. "Well I appreciate the vote of confidence." A crack of thunder splits the sky, and behind Catra, a portion of the ridgeline cracks and crumbles, bringing a tree down with it in a rockslide. Fygan could easily use that to his advantage, but he doesn't. He just sits there and watches.

"So…" Catra says, her tone conversational, "A lot's come together now. I get why you hate the Horde, why you tried to kill me and Adora. How'd you do all of this though?"

Fygan grins, "The princesses gave me the tools I needed to destroy them. Entrapta left behind some blueprints in the Fright Zone. Devices designed to destroy Runestones. Something about a feedback loop and exponentially increasing energies cycled through a closed circuit… I don't fully understand it, but I know how to follow directions."

"That explains the power swaps." Catra muses, "Energy is moving between the Runestones…"

"Causing a fluctuation in the Princesses' power." Fygan finishes.

"Why target the Princesses though? They didn't…" She trails off, but he knows the end of the sentence. *'They didn't kill your family.'*

"The Princesses could have wiped out the Horde at any time." Fygan says bitterly, "The system has been broken for generations, and they're the cornerstones. My hatred of the Horde was just… petty revenge. This… This is me ensuring that nothing like that ever happens again. Ensuring that…" He sighs, "That nothing like *me* ever happens again."

“We really do have a lot in common.” Catra says quietly. Fygan cocks his head to the side in reluctant acknowledgment. Catra continues, saying, “You don’t know when to stop though. You can’t just quit while you’re ahead.”

“Of course not.” Fygan responds bitterly, “I want to *win*, and not just by default.”

Catra looks at a spot on the ground, adding, “You want to be the last one standing.”

Fygan nods and chuckles darkly, “I could be the last great sorcerer.”

“You know,” Catra says, “The problem with being the last of anything… eventually there’ll be none left at all.”

“Good. Let magic die. Let Etheria take it back and lock it away. Put everyone on an even playing field.”

Catra is silent for a long time, before finally speaking up unprompted, saying, “I found out yesterday that I’m descended from princesses.” Fygan raises an eyebrow. “Yeah.” Catra says. Her gaze slides up to the ruin in the center of this basin. “Apparently there used to be this big kingdom of Magicats, but they fought against the First Ones and got wiped out. I don’t know if there are any others left, and if there aren’t, how is history going to look on me? The Last Magicat. I hope the first 20 years don’t totally overshadow however long I’ve got left, but it seems likely.”

There’s another long moment of silence, before: “I really am sorry.” Catra says, her expression earnest. She’s looking at him, but avoiding direct eye contact. “And… this is coming from someone who’s still new to apologies so… you know it’s sincere.”

“It doesn’t matter.” Fygan rebuts coldly, turning away and looking up into the sky, where clouds are roiling in a vicious battle for dominance. “You can’t change the past. Neither can I.”

"You're right," Catra agrees, "But we don't have to make the future worse."

Fygan chuckles, "No. We don't have to." He looks back down at her, "But I *want* to. I want to know how much pain everyone is in because of me. I want to revel in the destruction I cause as I pay back this world for all the hurt it's done to me." He stands up, and Catra follows suit, her eyes narrowing and muscles tensing, ready to spring. "I've noticed the storm abating. She Ra's doing something. Healing the Runestones probably. I thought I'd destroyed them but… I guess I didn't a hundred percent know what those devices did." He paces back and forth in front of the dark maw of the First Ones ruin entrance. "But even though I've lost… Ha! I'm not too upset. I came so close to destroying all of you. Me!" He jabs his thumb into his chest for emphasis, "One man, with nothing but his own wit and determination, brought a thousand-year old empire *to its knees*! I walked into their homes and got away scot free! I defeated the two greatest sorcerers of our age in a magic duel! I nearly killed She Ra! I nearly killed you! In a few months I've accomplished more than Hordak did in thirty years! You've got to admit, I'm incredible!! And I feel like I'm just getting started!"

"You're wrong." Catra hisses, "This ends here and now. I didn't want it to come to this but I see now there's no chance to save you." She flexes her hands, and her claws extend. Lightning crackles above them, highlighting her already harsh features with red. "I'm going to take you down Fygan. Once and for all!"

Fygan summons a spell circle in front of him, but his hands shake too badly, and the glyph shatters. He narrows his eyes, and pulls a knife from the back of his belt.

Both combatants leap forward, and the fight begins. Every attack is simple, every dodge perfect. It's like ballet. Soft footwork, dancing around each other. Every knife thrust is countered by a slash. Catra pushes forward, moving her feet to step on Fygan's, keeping him on his back foot. She feints to the left, and he counters. Her hand snaps into his wrist, sending the knife flying.

He swings his arm to one side, catching her cheek with an open-palmed slap. She spins, and the momentum carries her into a leaping kick that he rolls away from. She presses into the space he left, following with a lightning fast flurry of light punches to his torso, only some of which he is able to block. Fygan staggers back, one, two, three steps. Catra angles back, and swings her leg up while flipping backwards. Fygan is knocked back, hitting a sudden updraft of wind that carries him several feet into the air before he falls, landing with a splash in the mud.

Fygan struggles to his feet, dazed and disoriented. He slips and falls again, his shoulder colliding painfully with a rock.

"Don't you get it?" Catra shouts, her voice almost pleading, "It's over!"

"NO!" Fygan roars, staggering once more to his feet, only for his knees to buckle and give out, "I. Don't. Quit." He finally gets to his feet, swaying as he faces down Catra. He can see the multitude of emotions in her eyes once more: pity, confusion, sadness, reluctance. "If you really want this to end, you'll have to end it. But until then…" He flexes his hand ever so slightly, readying the item he'd managed to grab during one of his falls, "I'm going to keep fighting." His hand flicks upward. The knife shoots through the air towards the stunned cat. Victory is within Fygan's grasp…

Out of nowhere, She Ra leaps down from above, her sword in full swing, and parries the thrown weapon. "What?!" Fygan shouts, but his attention is drawn to the left, where Perfuma and Scorpia leap into the clearing, glowing with power, side by side. "No!!" Fygan shouts. He conjures two glyphs, sending a bolt of lightning towards She Ra, and a series of spectral rocks against Perfuma and Scorpia. Before they can land, a wall of water arcs around, freezing almost instantly and blocking every projectile. He spins around, eyes wide, to where Mermista and Frosta have emerged from the underbrush. "Get away from me!!!" Fygan shouts, flinging spell after half-cocked spell against the princesses as they close rank around him. "You've ruined everything!!" He backs up more and more as every spell is reflected. A firebolt against She

Ra is blocked by a suddenly teleporting Glimmer, who fires back with a cloud of sparkles, which Fygan narrowly dodges. He looks up. The Princesses are glowing like a rainbow, their respective powers raised against him.

“How??” He shouts desperately, “How did you find me??”

“I never lost you.” She Ra responds, her voice cold and emotionless, almost hollow.

“What??” Fygan breathes, backing up further. The air around him gets darker as he backs into the mouth of the ruin. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“It means,” Glimmer says in the same monotone, only for Mermista to pick up and say, “You’re gullible.”

Fygan’s eyes widen, “No…” She Ra’s form glows, and a form stalks forward through her.

A massive gray skinned panther, with a nebulous, spiked red mane, and glowing eyes and fangs to match. Melog paces forward, their body nearly doubled in size, claws extended and teeth bared. They growl in absolute rage at Fygan.

Fygan flings an arc of energy out, but somehow, She Ra slices it in half, and Melog continues to advance. “No!” Fygan takes another step backwards. He’s entirely in the ruin now. The next step he takes sends him sprawling back, tripping over a collapsed column. Melog continues to advance, their red eyes and bared fangs being the only source of light in the darkness. “Nononono…” Fygan says, his voice high and terrified. “Don’t kill me…” He pleads. All of his long-standing bravado and bluster is gone, revealing him for the coward he is. “I’ll do anything… I’ll help rebuild? I’ll pay whatever it takes just… DYAH!!” He yelps as light suddenly snaps into being behind him.

A cold, mechanical female voice echoes behind him. Fygan looks over his shoulder to see the holographic image of the ruins’ AI caretaker. “Intruder detected.” She states. “Lockdown initiated.”

“What??” Fygan spins around, looking to the door. Melog backs out, their aggressive disposition slowly fading. “No…” The door begins to close.

“No!” Fygan screams, his voice echoing out of the ruin. Catra pads over, looking in. The light within is an unforgiving red. The shapeshifter looks at her, his eyes full of desperation and fear. “Save me!!” He screams.

The door slides down. Dozens of sets of red eyes blink to life in the darkness surrounding Fygan. “This isn’t over!” Fygan vows as he gets to his feet, backing up, summoning barely-functional spell glyphs to defend himself. “I swear it!!” Catra simply stares at him, wordlessly. “You’ll regret thissss!!” Fygan screams. The metal clicks of the Ruins’ guardians grow closer and louder. “I’LL END YOU CATRA!!! I’LL END AAAALL OF YOU! I’LL WIN IN THE END!!!”

The door slams shut, and Fygan; the illusionist, the technician, the mastermind, the widower, the murderer, the coward; is trapped within.

Catra shivers, her stomach churning, before turning away from the ruin.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading, I hope you enjoyed! Comments and kudos are always appreciated.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

In Which life goes on After the Storm

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

(Four Weeks Later)

There is still much work to be done.

Fygan's attempt to destroy the Runestones, and the resulting apocalypse, has taken on the appellation "The Storm". How appropriate.

The ramifications of the shapeshifter's actions have been enormous. The physical damage done to Etheria is like nothing anyone's ever seen. Reconstruction has barely even begun, and at times, seems an impossibly tall task.

After such brazen attacks on their very hearts, the Princesses have agreed to dissolve the Alliance, in order to better protect their individual homes. Scorpia in particular has spent every instant of time since The Storm in the Fright Zone. She's said that it's simply because her kingdom was hit particularly hard by the event, but it's not impossible that her treatment at the hands of the Plumerians has contributed to her absence from that kingdom.

A surprising ray of hope for the Princesses has come from the kingdom of Lilifungia, which shockingly received little damage from The Storm, and has been sending goodwill ambassadors across the kingdoms. While they have few resources and cannot help with manpower, they have provided a boost to the people's incredibly low morale.

The Storm was not the only highly impactful event of that day. Fygan's message resonated strongly across Etheria. Protests and movements are popping up left and right, demanding the Princesses step down. Horde Remnant cells have seen their numbers swell, particularly at Mount Chandrila, which still refuses to establish contact with the kingdoms.

The Clone settlement at Dryl has been locked down due to a number of incidents wherein disgruntled Etherians harassed or attacked the clones. One incident nearly came to blows, but Kadroh was able to calm the conflict in time.

Despite Fygan being dealt with as a threat, his actions cast a long, dark shadow.

Bow

Bow looks up at the large, partially finished construct in the center of his workshop. Messes of cables and wires are clumped around it. Theoretically it's ready to be activated, but Bow still hesitates. Over and over, Granamyr's words echo in his head.

"***How many worlds did Horde Prime destroy using the portal technology you now seek to co-opt for the sake of convenience***?"

Is this wrong? Teleportation technology could be huge! It could help so many people, it could… bring everyone back together.

Bow sighs. The past four weeks have been lonely without the others around. Of course he has Glimmer, and Catra and Adora whenever they're not with each other, but he still misses the other princesses.

"Sir?" Yanli's reedy voice interrupts his reverie. The satyr is poking out from behind the portal. "Are we… ready?"

Bow sighs again. "Not today Yanli."

The satyr nods, putting down the wires they had been ready to connect. There's visible disappointment on their face. Bow feels a pang of sadness at that. He looks at the portal as the satyr leaves the room and puts his head in his hands with yet another sigh.

Technology isn't inherently evil. What I'm doing is good and worthwhile. It has to be...

Glimmer

"It's perfect!" Glimmer declares as the sheet comes off the statue. The sculptor smiles and thanks her.

Micah approaches her and looks up at the statue with her.

"Do you think it's in poor taste?" Glimmer asks worriedly.

"Of course not."

"Right?? I mean she did so much and helped and she was so brave and- even though she's not… gone…"

Micah puts a steady hand on her shoulder. "It'll be here when she wakes up."

Glimmer smiles up at her father, then looks back to the statue. "When she wakes up." *'Not if. When.'*

The statue of General Juliet really is something to behold. Carved of beautiful rose quartz, depicting the soldier with her head held high, her helm under one arm and her sheathed sword hilt held in the other hand.

"How…" Glimmer starts, then promptly cuts herself off, annoyed for even entertaining the thought. *'How can we be sure she will wake up?'*

The best healers Etheria has to offer have been unable to rouse her. Not even every ounce of She Ra goodness Adora could spare

was able to open the general's eyes. Even if she does awaken, the healers predict she'll be paralyzed from the neck down.

"She'll be alright." Micah says, his voice smooth and comforting. "Casta says they're making progress." Casta had been staying in Bright Moon for the past few weeks. Glimmer's unsure of the specifics, but she'd formed a rather close bond with Juliet during their quest to save Micah, and the sorceress can reliably be found at the general's bedside. "Apparently her eyes are finally moving!" Micah reports excitedly. "Still unconscious, but… She's on the mend."

Glimmer smiles. "Good." She says. "Who knows?" She chirps, her optimism returning, "Maybe she'll be awake in time for the ball!" Only one week from now celebrates the anniversary of Prime's defeat. How much the world has changed in that one year. Glimmer sighs, some of her excitement leaving as soon as it arrived. "I wish it weren't coming so soon after The Storm."

"We all do." Micah acknowledges, "But I think it will help us to persevere. To remember what we've been through, and celebrate our victories." Glimmer lets that sink in. "Pluuuus!" Micah adds after a pause, "It will lift everyone's spirits to attend the Father-Daughter dance!" Micah

"Uhhhgh!" Glimmer groans exaggeratedly, turning towards her dad, "I can't *believe* I let you talk me into that."

"It wasn't that difficult," Micah teases, "I expected much more resistance from you."

Glimmer snorts. "You caught me off guard." Micah smiles, and Glimmer returns it. Both of them look back to the statue and stand in silence, admiring the beauty of the artwork in the light of the setting sun.

Adora

“Catra!!” Adora calls out, her voice carrying down the hallway as she walks towards her room, “Come on Catra I know you’re ready.” Adora arrive and pushes the door open. “Come on, Glimmer’s not gonna start until you’re…” She trails off as she sees Catra. Her girlfriend is sitting on their balcony railing, one leg hanging off the side, the other propped up on the rail. Her tail is swinging slowly back and forth. She’s wearing a white and gold suit with a dark red undershirt. The jacket is hanging loosely in her hand, part of it crumpled on the floor. Her attention is skyward.

“Hey Adora.” She says absently.

Adora crosses the room and stands next to her partner. “Hey.” She says softly. She reaches out and brushes Catra’s hand. The feline, still looking to the stars, lets the rest of the jacket fall to the ground and interlaces her fingers together with Adora’s. Adora joins her in looking up at the sky in silence.

After a moment, Adora looks down at her girlfriend, and starts running her hands through Catra’s shaggy, shoulder length mane. “I like your hair.”

Catra chuckles slightly, “I like it better long,” She muses, “Though I can’t deny the style Prime gave me looked pretty dang good.”

Adora smiles, though images flash through her mind.

Turning around and seeing Catra lift the white hood off her head and speak, saying, “Hello, Adora.” in a voice that just felt… wrong.

Catra’s broken, demented laughter as Prime’s control tightened and the chip was damaged.

Catra falling off the platform into the void, and Adora leaping after her.

Catra coming back to life aboard Darla and clinging to Adora.

“One year…” Catra says, snapping Adora out of her memories. “Doesn’t feel like it.”

“No,” Adora agrees, “It doesn’t.” Catra is silent, and Adora squeezes her hand. “Whatcha thinkin’ about?” She asks, swinging their arms a little.

“A lot.” Catra admits, “Right now thinking about the weird fact that… if it weren’t for Horde Prime, we probably wouldn’t be together.”

Adora feels a little gross hearing that. ‘*I don’t want to give that monster credit for anything good.’* “I don’t think so,” she says moderately, “I think we would have captured you, and eventually you’d have come to your senses.”

“Pft.” Catra scoffs, finally looking at Adora with fond amusement in her eyes, “Ever the optimist darling.”

Adora’s stomach flutters. *‘Darling…’* She leans in and gives Catra a quick kiss that the feline readily returns.

“Also,” Catra says, looking up at the sky, “Thinking about going up there.”

“Ah.” Adora sighs, looking up at the stars. They depart in two months for their epic journey across space, bringing magic to the rest of the universe.

“A few weeks ago,” Catra muses, “I looked up at the sky and it was broken. There was fire on top of the clouds, lightning tearing through everything, wind so strong it warped the air.” Adora shivers, the memory of The Storm all too fresh in her mind. Some of the things that had happened that day still upset her to think about. Catra looks down at Adora, “But you fixed that.” Adora meets Catra’s gaze, a little confused about where the feline is going with this. “Next time it happens, you won’t be here to fix it.” Catra says grimly, “You’ll be up there.” She thrusts her chin up to gesture to the sky with her head.

“Yeah.” Adora says slowly, “That’s all I’ve been able to think about. But… I’m weirdly okay with it?”

Catra raises an eyebrow, “You’re okay with *not* being able to be the hero?” She raises her arm and pinches Adora’s cheek, teasingly asking, “Did the Storm give you brain damage?”

Adora swats her hand away and pouts, “No! I just…” She sighs. “I just… realized how much faith I have that everyone will be okay without me. When I went to each Runestone, the other princesses had pretty much gotten everything under control at their kingdoms. All I needed to do was slap a glowy bandage on and fly away. I think they’ll be fine on their own. Maybe another threat will rise, but they’re going to be able to handle it.”

“I hope they can handle Mantenna.” Catra mutters darkly. Adora is silent, prompting Catra to add, “I can’t *believe* I was dumb enough to trust him.”

“Hey,” Adora says, grabbing Catra’s shoulders, “You did the right thing. He guided you through Beast Island. We probably wouldn’t have escaped without him, because I would have stayed looking for you, and the island would have destroyed us.”

Catra sighs and rolls her eyes, “I know. I’m still gonna regret it because he turned out to suck. Plus he was really creepy the whole way through.”

“Oh come on,” Adora says, her voice getting sarcastic. “I trusted Hordak and Shadow Weaver for 18 years and they were the creepiest people ever.”

“Pfft. Yeah..” Catra giggles, “I guess being a bad judge of character is what brings us together.”

“That’s all?” Adora asks coyly, leaning in and wrapping her arm around the small of Catra’s back, leaning in for a kiss.

Adora quickly recoils as Catra’s tail intercepts her lips. “Yup!” The feline chirps, “That’s the only thing!” Both of them giggle, then

lock eyes and kiss again.

Adora looks up at the stars. "And," She says, going back to the earlier topic, "I think I'm okay with it because I know that I'll be able to fix that kind of problem for so many other people out there."

"It'll be hard." Catra says, a hint of challenge in her voice.

"Good," Adora responds, smiling, "Everything worth doing is hard."

Catra smiles and hops down from the railing, bending over to pick up the jacket and tossing it over her shoulder. "Alright princess," She says, "Let's not keep Sparkles waiting any longer."

"UGH! Finally!!" A voice rings out from across the room. Adora and Catra snap around to see Glimmer standing there, looking incredibly annoyed, "And next time you guys are going to inconvenience me, don't be so cute about it!"

"Bhah!!" Catra barks a laugh, "What?" She drawls, "Queen Softie didn't want to interrupt our moment?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "I'm just glad you were decent this time." She pops over to them and grabs Catra and Adora, teleporting them unceremoniously to the ballroom.

Catra

Catra idly thinks back to a few years ago, when she barely even knew what a "party" was. Her only experience with parties was the Princess Prom, and she hadn't really gotten to enjoy that one on account of having to keep Adora distracted the whole time so Scorpia could plant the bombs.

'I wonder if Adora knows I was scared out of my mind the whole time'. Catra smirks. '*Of course she doesn't.'*

Now, of course, she's attended so many parties that she's beginning to grow tired of them. Not too tired, of course, since

there are still many snacks and games and ways to make Adora or Glimmer uncomfortable.

Plus, this party is special. The first time in weeks all the Princesses will be together. *First time seeing some of them in months*.

Catra breathes in, taking in the myriad of different smells. Parties are always a feast for her heightened senses, more often good than bad. While Bright Moon's parties are not as pleasant smelling as Plumeria's, there's a comfort of familiarity about them. Catra looks around the lofted arches and beautiful mosaics on the walls and smiles. *A few months ago, this place reminded me of Prime. Now… it's my home.*

Home. What a nice feeling.

*****

Catra's not entirely sure what force moves her feet towards the King, but she finds herself settling next to King Micah of Bright Moon in one of the rooms adjoining the ballroom. She stands beside the monarch in awkward silence, looking pensively up at the wall with him.

The wall is covered in a beautiful mosaic depicting Queen Angella and another figure, a tall man with a long gray beard holding a spear and shield. On the shield is a scene of dragons battling in a stormy sky.

"Who is that?" Catra eventually asks.

Micah responds, "One of my predecessors. A King of Bright Moon from centuries ago."

"Oh." Catra says, unsure how to respond to that. She'd known that Queen Angella was ancient, but hadn't really thought about that.

"She rarely spoke of her former spouses." Micah observes, "I believe she wanted to live in the present, rather than the past.

You know, that's what drew me towards her."

"The fact that she'd been married before you?"

"Ha ha! No," Micah chuckles and shakes his head. Catra blushes. *What a stupid thing to say.* "Everyone knew Queen Angella was ancient by reputation, but you never would have guessed it just from knowing her. She never used her age as a trump card, never claimed to be wiser or stronger than anyone else. She was humble."

"Humility is a really important thing in a ruler." Catra says. Micah looks at her, a little surprised, and she blushes again, quickly clarifying, "I… read that in a book."

Micah smiles. "You're right. Even now, I find something new to admire about her almost every day."

Catra looks up at the mural, taking in the features of the Queen. Even though the mural is hundreds of years old, she looks the same as she does in portraits made during the war. Catra feels the familiar rising tide of guilt, and starts to back away, but is stopped when Micah turns and says, "Just as I find something new to admire about you almost every day."

"W-what?" Catra's eyes widen.

Micah smiles, "You're an incredible person Catra. And every day I see you growing into the strong, smart, amazing young woman you have always been meant to be. I hope I'm not overstepping when I say: I'm proud of you Catra."

Catra is at a loss for words, but feels some unidentified emotion welling up inside of her. Her eyes water, and Micah immediately begins to go into panic mode.

"Oh! Ahh, I'm not… I don't know how to handle-" He begins, but Catra cuts him off by hugging him.

She realizes what that emotion is. Love. Actual love for a parental figure, untainted by fear and manipulation and darkness.

*****

Catra is just sitting in a chair, sipping a delightfully fizzy beverage, when Glimmer suddenly appears next to her in an explosion of sparkles. Catra squeaks and falls out of the chair, somehow managing to keep her drink perfectly upright.

"WHYYYY?" She asks the Queen.

Glimmer smiles smugly and shoves Catra's chair away, sitting on the floor with her back to the feline. Catra smiles, recognizing the gesture, and scoots over so she's leaning against Glimmer's back.

A few partiers who are unfamiliar with them give the pair some queer looks, but Catra doesnt care.

"One year." Glimmer says solemnly.

"One year." Catra responds, her tone somewhere between simple agreement and disbelief.

"Do you…" Glimmer says quietly, "Nevermind."

Catra picks up the message though. "Do I still think about being on his ship? Yeah. All the time." She feels Glimmer nod a little, and Catra adds, more light-heartedly, "How long were we even up there? It felt like an eternity."

"Bow told me it was about three weeks." Glimmer responds.

"Wow." Catra replies quietly. "A lot happened in those three weeks, huh?"

"Everything happened so fast back then." Glimmer says, "You switched sides, we hopped from planet to planet, Adora got She Ra back, Prime took over Etheria and almost destroyed everything…"

“And then we won.” Catra says. “Only got some time to breathe afterwards.” Glimmer chuckles a bit, and Catra pauses before saying, “It was you. You realize that, right?”

“Uhhh maybe? Wwwhat do you mean?”

Catra smiles, “Sorry, I mean- you’re the reason I did it. Changed sides. If it had been Adora trapped up there with me… I would have pushed back even harder. I guess I’m just saying… I’m glad we got captured by a genocidal space warlord together, cuz if we hadn’t…” Catra shivers and curls into herself a bit. “I’m not sure where I’d be right now.”

Catra feels Glimmer turn around, and accepts the Queen’s warm embrace. “The feeling’s mutual.” Glimmer says, her voice soft and full of fondness. “I love you, Horde Scum.”

Catra blushes and brings her hands up to squeeze Glimmer’s arm to return the hug. “Love you too Sparkles.”

*****

Catra takes a deep breath in. Scorpia is on her own, taking a break from the party and getting some air. *And I’ve put this off for far too long.*

She steels herself for the worst and walks forward. “Uh-hey, Scorpia. How’s… things?”

“Oh!” The larger woman turns around, a bright smile on her face, “Hey there Catra! Man, it’s been a while since we’ve really talked hasn’t it?”

“Yeah…” Catra says, awkwardly scratching the back of her neck.

Scorpia cocks her head to the side, “Catra? W-what’s wrong?”

Catra closes her eyes, bites her lip, clenches her fists, and breathes in sharply through her nose before saying, louder than she’d intended, “I’m sorry Scorpia!” She opens her eyes to see the

other woman step back, a little confused. “I’m sorry for being a bad friend, and I’m sorry for using you, and manipulating you, and hurting you. I’m sorry for everything I did to you in the Horde. You deserved so much better and I’m so happy you have that now but I still need you to know how much I regret it. I’m so sorry.”

Scorpia looks around and shuffles awkwardly. “Catra… I know that. I don’t think I’ll ever be able to be as close to you as I was back then but… I think that’s best for both of us. I’m happier now than I ever was in the Horde. Plus… honestly, I don’t really think I was a very good friend for you either.” She raises a claw to cut off Catra's protest and continues, “I mean, I was a lot nicer than you were, but I ewas clingy when you needed space. I didn’t respect your boundaries, and I tried to replace Adora. For a little while I thought that you were just bad for me but… It was just… Mutually bad.”

Catra smiles and places a hand on Scorpia’s claw. “Perfuma’s really rubbed off on you.” Scorpia smiles, responding, “Yeah, I guess she has.” Catra, on impulse, takes a step forward and wraps Scorpia up in a hug.

“I’m glad we’re friends.” Catra says quietly.

Scorpia returns the hug. “I’m glad we’re friends too, Wildcat.”

*****

“Ha HA! And then I said: ‘you should have thought about one thing before tangling with me Captain Blue Nose: Gravity!’ And I cut through the yardarm he was balancing on and sent him right down to the depths!!” Sea Hawk finishes his story with wondrous flourish before taking his seat and adding in his less presentory voice: “And then I stole his ship.”

“You mean- what was left of it?” Catra asks wryly.

Sea Hawk chuckles and nods. “Yes yes. So that was the end of my two month feud with the vicious pirate captain Blue Nose.”

Catra smiles and relaxes back onto her makeshift throne of cushions that she's stolen from rooms and furniture throughout the ball. “I wish my stories got to be fun adventures…” she sighs wistfully. “Instead they’re all either depressing or terrifying.”

Sea Hawk smiles understandingly. “Well I certainly embellish my tales a bit,” he admits, “quite frankly they’re always terrifying in the moment. I was balancing on a wooden yardarm during a storm, having a sword fight with a man who had four extra limbs! If it weren’t for my cunning, I don’t think I’d have made it out of there alive.”

Catra raises her drink and says, “To hindsight: making our decisions look dumber and our actions look cooler.” Sea Hawk clinks his beat up metal tankard against her proffered glass. *Where did he even get that?? All the drinks are being served in fancy Bright Moon glasses.*

She drinks deep and sighs. “You know… you are pretty cool Sea Hawk.”

“Ah-“ he splutters a bit, “you really think so?” His voice gets unexpectedly earnest, and his eyes begin to water. “You… don’t know how much that means.”

Catra flushes a bit. “Well I didn’t mean for you to get all weird about it but… it’s true. You’re strong, smart, good at sailing, good at telling stories, and surprisingly insightful. I haven’t forgotten that day in Salineas.”

Sea Hawk smiles fondly, remembering the beginning of the pair’s odd friendship. “That was something wasn’t it…” he leans back in his chair. “Well Catra, here’s to your continued adventures, in the hopes that they be more worthy of stories than the ones you’ve had thus far.”

“Cheers to that.” Catra says, raising her drink a little before taking another sip. “Hey, remember when we tangled with those sea serpents and accidentally crashed Mermista’s shi…p..?”

She looks up at Sea Hawk, and notices a dangerous glint in his eye as he looks over her shoulder. "Oh no…" she says, and turns to follow his gaze.

She sees one of the cakes being carried in, this one dedicated to Salineas. It's shaped like a boat. "Oh *no*!" She turns around, ready to restrain the pyromaniac, only to see a Sea Hawk-shaped puff of smoke where he had been.

"Oh…" she turns back towards the cake, which has been set down between two candelabras, "NOOOO!!"

*****

Catra wasn't expecting to see anyone else here. A dark thought had driven her to slip away from the party and walk through the empty halls of Bright Moon until she arrived here. She wasn't expecting to see Archmage Castaspella clipping plants in the newly-repaired greenhouse of Shadow Weaver's garden.

"Oh!" The Archmage says when she glimpses the feline ascending the floating steps to the greenhouse, "Hello Catra, did the party get to be too much for you?"

"Well this wouldn't be my first choice of hangout spot if it did." Catra drawls, "What are you doing here?"

"Oh just taking some time to gather ingredients." Casta says, pointing up to the sky without looking, "Star-Spun flowers can only be harvested during Dearla's New Moon." Catra looks up, and notes half-heartedly that one of Etheria's moons is indeed dark, and the others aren't very prominent in the sky.

"Huh." She says.

Casta continues speaking, "And what are you doing here dear?"

"Oh," Catra says, shying back, a little bashful. She rubs her arm. "Just… came here to think."

“About?”

Catra pauses, then hangs her head, feeling ashamed of herself for admitting, “Shadow Weaver.”

Casta stops cutting and turns to look at her, “Ah of course. Oh don’t feel ashamed dear, it’s only natural.”

Catra looks at the basin in the middle of the greenhouse and walks towards it slowly. It had been repaired with gold now lining the cracks. “I know…” She says slowly, looking at her reflection in the water, “It’s just… A year since beating Prime means…”

“A year since Shadow Weaver’s death.” Castaspella finishes understandingly.

Catra puts her hands on the rim of the basin, her claws scraping the stone a bit as she tenses. “Why do I still not know how to feel about this?? I’ve gotten over her! I- I’ve moved on! I’ve beaten her over and over and over in my mind and I still…” Catra trails off as a ripple breaks her reflection. She realizes it was caused by a tear falling from her face. She straightens up and wipes away the tear from her other eye. “I still cry over her.” She finishes, her voice harsh.

Casta waves a hand, almost dismissively, “Well of course you do! I can’t even *imagine* how complicated your emotions are about that woman.”

Catra spins, her hackles raised, “I don’t miss her! I’m not sad, I- I’m glad she’s dead!”

Casta nods, “Honestly I’d be surprised if you weren’t. Catra, tears are not reserved for sadness. They just mean that your heart has reached its limit of emotions, and has to get rid of them somehow. So they come out as tears.”

Catra blinks a few times. ‘*That’s cheesy…’* she thinks, but she is also acutely aware of just how deeply those words are already affecting her.

“And,” Casta adds conspiratorially, “If you feel bad about still crying a year later…” She lowers her voice to a stage whisper, “I sometimes cry about how she treated me, even now.”

“Pffft!” Catra can’t help it. She immediately shakes her head, mortified, “No! Nono! I didn’t-“

“Ha! It’s fine!” Casta says, laughing heartily as well, “It’s been thirty years and it still upsets me. You don’t ever ‘get over’ heartbreak. You just learn to live despite it.”

Catra smiles, and turns back to look into the basin. Castaspella walks beside her, putting a hand on her shoulder.

“Yeah…” Catra says, “I like that. When she was alive, I lived despite her. Now… I can do the same thing.”

“Attagirl.” Casta says, gently squeezing Catra’s shoulder.

There’s a pause before Catra asks, “So… did Glimmer really just let Shadow Weaver grow magic plants in Bright Moon??”

*****

Catra stalks forward, her feet barely touching the floor. She makes no noise as she maneuvers deftly through the throngs of people. Her muscles are tense, her eyes narrow, pupils focused on her prey. Her toes flex as she arcs around to a prime attack spot.

Catra silently bends down, and pounces, letting out a ferocious, “BOO!” As she makes contact with her target.

As soon as she hits his shoulders and back, landing and grappling on to perch atop him, Bow shrieks in startlement and befuddlement, dropping his plate of snacks and sending his drink cascading over Chancellor Brannic to his side, who turns red and sputters in fury.

“Catra!!” Bow says as Catra wraps her arms around his neck so she’s sitting on his back in a piggy-back style, “Whyyy?”

“Cuz.” Catra says, playing with a loose curl of his hair, “You looked bored. I am bored. Wanna talk?”

Bow sighs exasperatedly, but Catra can read the fondness in his mind. “Fine,” He says, “Of course, you are aware you chose the cutest possible way to get my attention.” as he grabs Catra’s legs and starts to walk towards a secluded corner of the room where a sitting area has been set up.

“Shut up and go, steed.” Catra shoots back, “I am not cute.”

“At this point even you know that’s not true.” Bow teases back.

Catra growls playfully and leaps off his back to land on a chair, where she promptly sprawls out sideways, her limbs dangling off the furniture at odd angles. Bow sits down on a couch. Catra’s head lolls around to his direction. “So,” She says, “Whatcha been up to the past few weeks? Arrow stuff?”

“No,” Bow says sadly, and sinks into the cushions of the couch, “Working on the teleporter but… not making much progress. Can’t focus on it.”

Catra perks up with worry. “That doesn’t sound like you.” Bow may not be as work focused as Entrapta, but he’s not one to let a project go unfinished for so long. “What’s bugging you?”

“Granamyr.” Bow says, and Catra nods. Everyone has been like this. The dragon’s words stick in their heads like a splinter, driving them to doubt in the worst possible moments. “I mean… I know he was wrong but… it still eats away at me.”

“Hey,” Catra says, swinging her body around to an approximation of a normal sitting position, “Don’t doubt yourself. You’re incredible, and you’re doing the right thing. Frankly, if you wanna focus on what this teleportation tech *was* used for, focus on the fact that it was used to save your girlfriend from Horde Prime. If we had had teleporters during the Storm, we could have fixed it immediately. You’ve made the world a better place already with your tech, and you’re going to continue to do so.” Bow’s eyes are

watering, and Catra is taken aback. “Man,” She says, “I did not think I could give pep talks.”

“You can!” Bow says, his voice breaking, “You give the best pep talks!!”

“Well that’s just blatantly untrue-” Catra begins, but is cut off when Bow jumps up and picks her up in a hug. She is tense at first, but relaxes into the warm embrace, even letting out a little purr, just for him.

*****

“Hey!” Catra turns as Adora nudges her in the side, a mischievous glint in her eyes.

“Hey Adora.” Catra purrs in response, eliciting that oh-so-predictable blush from her dummy. “What are you up to?” She asks, her tail flirting its way around Adora’s waist.

Adora leans down and whispers, “Follow me, our spot.”

Catra’s eyes widen, but before she can question it, Adora is already moving, weaving through the crowd, pulling Catra by the hand. Catra giggles giddily, looking over her shoulder towards the party. “Adoraaa,” She whispers, “We’re close to speech time! Glimmer’s gonna *kill* us if we aren’t there.”

Adora spins with unexpected grace. Catra bumps into her and looks up into those sparkling blue eyes, “That,” Adora says, “is a problem for *future* Catra and Adora.”

Catra’s heart skips a beat as Adora turns and keeps going, slipping out onto an adjoining balcony. *Stars I love you so much*.

Adora and Catra clamber up the walls and roofs of Bright Moon until they get to their spot: A large, floating rock with a little secluded alcove in it that gives them a gorgeous view of the Whispering Woods, the Bright Moon lagoon, and the Moonstone tower.

As soon as Catra hops up onto the stone, Adora pulls her in by the waist and locks lips with her. However, Catra's momentum knocks both of them to the ground, Catra perched atop Adora, continuing the kiss through giggles and snorts from both parties.

"I love you." Catra purrs, unable to contain herself.

"I love you too." Adora says, then cocks her head over to one side. Catra turns, and smiles.

A small campsite has been set up, with bedrolls and chairs and a campfire ready to be lit. A tent is rolled up to one side just in case, but the bedrolls are otherwise open to the sky for a night under the stars.

Catra sits up, and looks at Adora as she does the same. They wrap their arms around each other, and Adora smiles.

"Happy anniversary Catra." Adora says before pulling the love of her life into a deep, wonderful, intoxicating, brilliant kiss.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for reading. It's been a wild ride and I hope you've all enjoyed. I appreciate all of you who have stuck with me from the beginning, and all of you who have joined me on this wonderful journey part way through. Thank you for your patience with my inconsistent uploads throughout. I sincerely hope you've all enjoyed.

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